THE SORCERER'S HOLLOW

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Book Three of The Lattice Chronicles

THE SKILL JUNKY

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First edition.

For mothers who walk the long way home,
and for everyone who waited up.

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We break the ground.
We never take the crown.
We never let a moth in.

— The rule of the Harrow women

PROLOGUE

The Moth at the Window

THERE WAS A COUNTRY at the end of the world where nothing had moved for nine hundred years.

It had no name anymore. It had had one, once. A long and beautiful name, in a language with eleven words for *crown* and none for *enough*. But the people who spoke that language had stopped speaking it a long time ago, and the name had worn away the way names do when nobody says them. Like a coin rubbed smooth in a pocket.

The dust called it the Outer Court. The dust had nothing better to do.

It lay beyond the Sundered Lands, past the last broken road, past the place where the Veil hung across the edge of the world like a curtain of grey silk that nobody could see through and nobody could pass. A country of grey-gold dust and dead gardens. Of fountains that had been dry since before the Lattice was woven. Of palaces made of glass and bone and gold, standing in the dust with their doors open, because there was no one left to keep out and no one left to keep in.

There was no sun there. There was no moon. There was a dim grey-gold light that came from nowhere, the color of a candle seen through a dirty window, and it never changed. Not at morning. Not at night. There was no morning. There was no night.

There was only waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

IN THE TALLEST OF the glass palaces, in a hall with a ceiling like a frozen waterfall, five cocoons hung from the rafters.

They were made of silk. Grey-gold silk, thick as a man's arm, wound round and round and round, each one longer than a coffin and twice as wide. They hung from the high glass beams on ropes of the same silk, swaying very slightly, though there was no wind. There had been no wind in the Outer Court for nine centuries.

Under each cocoon, on the glass floor, lay a crown.

Not on a cushion. Not on a stand. Just lying there in the dust, where it had fallen. A crown of gold leaves. A crown of glass. A crown of black iron, plain and heavy as a manacle. A crown of thorns that had once been a crown of roses.

And under the fifth cocoon, the one at the end, nearest the tall glass windows: a crown of silver wire, so fine it looked like frost. Shaped like wings. Folded.

The dust lay over everything. The crowns. The floor. The cocoons. Thick and soft and grey-gold, like the powder on a moth's wing.

Nothing moved.

Nothing had moved for nine hundred years.

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AND THEN, VERY FAR away, on the other side of the Veil, on the other side of the world, at the bottom of a mountain, in front of a door of black glass—

A man lit a lamp.

A small iron lamp. Squat and round. With one rune on its glass.

He set it down beside two others. And lit it with his own fire. And stood back.

Three lamps. Side by side. In front of a door.

A light left on.

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THE FIFTH COCOON MOVED.

Just a tremor. A shiver, running through the grey-gold silk from top to bottom, the way a sleeper twitches when someone says their name in another room.

The dust on it slid. A little. A soft grey-gold whisper, pouring off the silk onto the glass floor.

Then nothing.

Then the tremor again. Stronger.

Something inside the cocoon was breathing.

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SHE WOKE THE WAY she always had, slowly and then all at once.

First the dark. The close warm silk-dark of the cocoon, pressing on her eyelids, on her mouth. The smell of dust. Old dust. Her own dust.

Then the hunger.

It had been there the whole time she slept. Nine hundred years of it. A dull ache at the center of her, low and steady, like a fire banked down to embers in the bottom of a stove. She had slept through it the way you sleep through a toothache, by going down so deep that the ache was only a rumor.

It wasn't a rumor now.

It was awake when she was. Sharper than she was. It had woken her, in fact. It had smelled something. Far off. And it had shaken her the way a dog shakes its sleeping master when it hears a step on the path.

She lay in the dark and breathed and let the hunger tell her what it smelled.

Light.

Somewhere. Far away. On the other side of the Veil.

Not the dim nothing-light of the Court. Not the grey-gold glow that came from nowhere. A real light. Small and gold and warm and *chosen*. Lit on purpose. By a hand. For someone who wasn't there.

A light left on.

She knew that kind of light. She'd known it all her long life. It was the sweetest light there was. Sweeter than sunlight. Sweeter than fire. Sunlight was only the sun doing what the sun did. Fire was only fire. But a lamp in a window, left burning for someone who hadn't come home—

That was a *promise*. And a promise could be eaten.

She opened her eyes in the dark.

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THE COCOON SPLIT.

Not all at once. One long seam, from top to bottom, opening the way a seed-pod opens, with a soft dry tearing sound like paper. Grey-gold light came in through the seam. Dust poured out. A great deal of dust.

And then a hand.

Long. Pale. Grey-gold, like the dust. The fingers very fine and very long, with too many joints, or with joints in the wrong places. It hooked over the edge of the split silk and held.

Then another.

Then she pulled herself out, and dropped, and landed on the glass floor of the hall in a crouch, among the dust, with her head bowed and her hair falling round her face.

She stayed like that for a while. Breathing.

Then she stood up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS TALL. TALLER than a man. Thin as a candle, and straight, and pale in a way that wasn't the paleness of skin but the paleness of ash, or of the underside of a leaf. Her hair was long and fine and the color of old silver. It fell to her knees.

Her face was beautiful. That was the first thing anyone noticed about her, and it was meant to be. High cheekbones and a long jaw and a wide, soft, sorrowful mouth. A face from a painting. A face from a church window.

Her eyes were the second thing.

They were lit.

Not reflecting light. *Lit*. From inside. Soft and gold and warm, like two windows in a house at the end of a lane on a winter night. The kind of windows you see from a long way off, walking home in the cold, and think: *there. Someone's in. Someone's waiting.*

That was what made people come to her. Nine hundred years ago, and before that. It wasn't her face. It was her eyes. People looked into them and saw a light left on, and walked toward it, the way the lost always do.

And then she was very kind to them, for as long as it took.

On her back, folded close against her spine like a cloak, she had wings.

They were made of silk and dust. Grey-gold. Enormous. Folded, they hung from her shoulders to the floor and trailed behind her a little, like a train. Open, they would have filled the hall. They were patterned, very faintly, in rings and eyes and whorls, darker gold on paler, like the wings of the great night-moths that came to the windows of farmhouses in late summer and beat themselves soft against the glass.

Every time she moved, they shed. A little. A soft gold powder, sifting down onto the glass floor behind her.

She looked down at the crown at her feet. Silver wire. Fine as frost. Shaped like folded wings.

She didn't pick it up.

"*Not yet*," said Maelis of the Crowned, to no one. Her voice was low and soft and a little hoarse, the way a voice is after nine hundred years of not being used. "*Not yet, I think.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED.

Down the hall. Past the other four cocoons, hanging still and silent from the glass beams. She stopped under each one and looked up at it for a while. Not long. Just long enough to be polite.

Gold leaves on the floor. *Oszric*. Her eldest brother. The Gilded King. Who had gone first to the pool, and drunk first, and drunk most. Who had told them all, at the end, when the net came down over the world like a fisherman's cast and the old Ferryman's boat bumped against the shore, that they would be back. *A thousand years at the most. The net will rot. Nets always rot. Then we'll come home and take it back, and everything in it.*

The cocoon didn't stir.

Glass on the floor. *Ysenne*. Who had loved mirrors. Who could not sleep without seeing her own face. Who had wept on the Ferryman's boat because there was no reflection in the grey water.

Black iron. *Caddoc*. Who had never laughed in his life, as far as anyone could tell, and who had sat in the bottom of the boat with his arms crossed and his jaw set and said nothing at all, the whole way out.

Thorns. *Her*. The one whose name none of them said anymore, because she had asked them not to, at the end, when the roses died.

Maelis looked up at the four of them. Hanging in the grey-gold dim. Breathing so slowly you couldn't see it. So slowly you'd think they were dead.

They weren't dead. That was the whole point. That was what they'd drunk for.

"*Sleep*," said Maelis softly. "*I'll go and look. I always was the one who went first to the light.*"

She smiled. It was a lovely smile. Sad and fond and patient.

"*I'll bring you something back*."

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT OUT THROUGH the tall glass doors of the palace into the Outer Court.

The dust lay everywhere. Over the dead gardens. Over the dry fountains. Over the broad white road that ran from the palace doors, straight as a ruler, across the grey-gold plain, toward the edge of the world.

There were shapes in the dust. Along the road. On either side. Hundreds of them.

They looked like heaps. Low mounds of grey-gold, scattered in no order, the way snow drifts against fences. But when she came down the palace steps, they began to move.

One. Then ten. Then all of them.

They sat up out of the dust. Slowly. Shedding it. And unfolded.

People. Or what had been people. Thin and pale and grey-gold, all of them, with long hands and lit eyes, not as bright as hers, nowhere near as bright, just a faint dull glow like the last coal in a grate. And on their backs, small wings. Dust-wings. Furled and ragged and dry.

Her Mothwing.

Her household. Her court. Her servants and soldiers and stewards. The people who had followed her to the pool nine hundred years ago, and drunk a little, a very little, from her own cupped hands, and lived. And kept living. Long after they wanted to. Long after there was anything to live on.

They knelt in the dust as she came down the steps. Row on row of them. With their heads bowed and their small dry wings trembling.

At the front, nearest the steps, an old man. Or the shape of one. Bent and grey and thin as a rake, with a steward's chain of office round his neck, gone black with age. His eyes were barely lit at all. Two dim sparks, like the ends of cigars in a dark room.

"*Majesty*," he said. His voice was a whisper. Dry as a page. "*Majesty. You wake.*"

"*Orrin*." She looked down at him. Fondly. "*You're still here.*"

"*Where else would I go, Majesty*?"

"*Nowhere*," she agreed. "*There's nowhere else. That's rather the point of an exile.*" She tilted her head. Listening. "*Orrin. Can you smell it?*"

The old steward lifted his head. His dim eyes flickered.

"*I can't smell anything anymore, Majesty*," he said. "*Not for three hundred years.*"

"*Light*," said Maelis.

A ripple ran through the kneeling Mothwing. Row on row. A soft dry rustle, like a wind through dead leaves, though there was no wind. Their small wings stirred.

"*Light*," said Maelis again. Softly. Savoring it. "*On the other side. Someone has left a light on.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WALKED TO THE edge of the world.

It took a long time. The broad white road ran across the plain for miles, and there was nothing on it, and nothing changed. The grey-gold light stayed the same. The dust stayed the same. Her Mothwing followed her in a long ragged line, shedding, rustling, their dim eyes fixed on her back.

She didn't hurry. She'd waited nine hundred years. She could wait an afternoon. If there had been afternoons.

At the end of the road, there was a wall.

Not stone. Not glass. Not anything you could touch.

Grey.

A curtain of grey, hanging from nowhere, falling to nowhere, stretching away to the left and right as far as eyes could see. Not quite still. It moved, very slightly, the way silk moves in a draft. You could see light

through it, dimly. Or the memory of light. Colors that might have been fields, or sky, or nothing at all.

The Veil.

The edge of the net. The last knot in the great weaving, where Aurelian Vey had tied off the world and left everything outside it *outside*.

She stopped in front of it.

She'd stood here before. Many times. In the first hundred years. When she still believed Oszric that the net would rot. She'd come to the end of the road and stood in front of the Veil and pressed her long hands flat against it, and pushed. And it had pushed back. Not hard. Not angrily. Just firmly. The way a door pushes back when it's locked.

No, it had said. Not in words. *Not you. Not ever.*

After the first hundred years she'd stopped coming. After the second hundred, she'd gone to sleep.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LIFTED ONE LONG pale hand and laid it flat on the grey.

And it gave.

Not much. Not enough. But it *gave*. The way cloth gives under a finger when the threads have gone loose. The way a knot gives when someone, somewhere, has pulled out the rope that held it tight.

She held very still.

She could feel it. Through her palm. Through the grey silk of the Veil. Something had happened, on the other side. Something enormous. The whole great weaving of the world had been *changed*. Not torn. Not rotted. Changed. Unknotted, ring by ring, and knotted again, differently. Looser. Kinder. With no hand at the center holding all the threads.

No Root, she thought. *There's no Root.*

Someone took the net apart and put it back together, and didn't keep the center for themselves.

Who would do that?

She laughed. Softly. With her hand flat on the Veil.

A fool, she thought. *A good, kind, generous fool.*

I do love a fool.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND UNDER THE CHANGE, underneath it, deep down, so faint she nearly missed it—

Something else.

She went very still. Her lit eyes went wide.

She knew that. She knew that taste. She'd tasted it once, nine hundred years ago, on her knees at the edge of a black pool in a hall of glass, with her brother on one side of her and her sister on the other and her hands cupped full of dark.

The Hollow.

Not the hunger. The hunger was gone. She could feel that it was gone. The great starving emptiness that had followed them to the shore, screaming, as the Ferryman pushed off. The thing that their drinking had left behind.

Gone.

And in its place—

Young.

Something young. Something new. Rising. Slowly. From very far down. Soft and dark and enormous and *full*.

It's grown back.

Maelis of the Crowned stood at the edge of the world with her hand on the Veil and her heart, which had not beaten fast in nine centuries, beating fast.

It's grown back. The Well. The seventh Well. The one we drank. It's healed. It's whole. It's full again. And it's coming up.

Toward the light.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Orrin*," she said. Without turning round.

"*Majesty*."

"*Wake them*." She didn't take her hand off the Veil. "*No. Don't. Let them sleep.*" She smiled. "*I'll go first. I'll go and look. When there's something to bring them, I'll bring it.*"

"*Majesty*." The old steward's dry voice shook. "*Majesty, the Veil. It won't let us. It never has. Not us. Not the Crowned. Not anyone who drank.*"

"*It's loose now*," said Maelis.

"Loose?"

"Someone untied the knot." She pressed her palm against the grey. *"They tied it again. But they tied it with a kinder hand. They left a little give."* She tilted her head, considering. *"Not enough for Oszric. Not enough for a crown. Not yet."* She looked down at herself. Thin and pale and tall. Grey-gold. Shedding dust. *"But enough for a moth. If she's patient. If she goes very slowly. If she folds her wings."*

She folded her wings.

Tight. Close against her spine. Until they were barely a cloak, barely a shadow, a fold of grey-gold silk down her back.

And she leaned against the Veil the way a moth leans against a window. Gently. Patiently. With her whole weight. Toward the light on the other side.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK A LONG time.

It took a long time, and it hurt. The Veil didn't want her. It knew her. Nine hundred years hadn't changed that. The old kind careful knot that Aurelian Vey had tied at the edge of the world still remembered every one of the nine who had knelt at the black pool and drunk, and it pressed against her, *no, not you*, the way it always had.

But it was looser now. And she was very, very patient.

She went through it the way water goes through a cloth. One thread at a time. Leaving dust on every one.

Behind her, her Mothwing pressed against the grey too. A hundred of them. Two hundred. Leaning. Their small wings folded. Following her into the loose place she'd made, the way moths follow each other through a gap in a shutter.

Not all of them made it. The Veil was not as loose for them as for her. Some of them pressed against it and pressed and pressed, and their dry dim bodies came apart into dust against the grey, and the dust fell, and lay on the road with the rest.

She didn't look back.

She never did.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE FAR SIDE of the Veil it was night.

A real night. Cold. Black. With *stars*.

She came out of the grey into the Sundered Lands, on her knees, on hard frozen ground, in a wind that cut like a knife. And knelt there. And lifted her face. And looked up.

Stars.

Thousands of them. Hard and white and glittering, scattered across a black sky. And a moon. Thin. A paring. Low over the broken hills to the east.

She hadn't seen a star in nine hundred years.

She knelt on the frozen ground and looked at them for a long time.

They weren't what she wanted. They were too far. Too cold. Nobody had lit them. Nobody was waiting under them. They were only stars.

But they were *light*.

Her lit eyes brimmed. Gold. And something ran down her pale cheeks, slow and glittering, that might have been tears and might have been dust.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NET FOUND HER almost at once.

She felt it come. A touch. Silver. Light as a spider's thread. Brushing across her the way a blind man's fingers brush across a stranger's face, trying to learn its shape.

A panel opened in the dark in front of her.

She'd never seen one before. She looked at it with great interest.

```
▒▒▒ UNKNOWN ENTITY ▒▒▒
Name: ▒▒▒▒▒▒▒
Class: —
Level: —
Thread: NONE
  NOT OF THIS NET
```

Not of this net.

Maelis of the Crowned looked at it for a long moment. And then laughed. Low and soft and delighted, kneeling on the frozen ground at the edge of the Sundered Lands, under the stars, with her Mothwing crawling out of the Veil behind her one by one.

"*No*," she agreed. "*No, I'm not.*"

She lifted one long pale finger and touched the panel. Very gently. The way you'd touch a soap bubble.

And left a smudge of grey-gold dust on it.

The panel flickered. Went dim.

And went out.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD UP.

She looked east. Across the Sundered Lands. Across the broken hills and the frozen ground and the black ruins of the old Umbral Rift, toward a world she had not seen since before the Lattice was woven.

It was dark. It was enormous. She couldn't see the end of it.

But far, far off, very faint, at the very edge of seeing, she could feel it. The thing that had woken her. Small and gold and warm.

A light left on.

Three, she thought. *Three lamps, in front of a door. At the bottom of a mountain. For someone who isn't home.*

And behind the door, rising, the Well we drank.

And beside the Well, coming home, someone who smells of my sister.

She smiled.

"*Come, Orrin*," said Maelis, the Moth Queen. "*Come, all of you. It's a long way, and I'm hungry, and someone has very kindly left the light on.*"

She opened her wings.

They filled the night. Grey and gold and enormous, patterned with rings and eyes and whorls, shedding dust that glittered in the starlight like frost.

And she flew east.

Toward the light.

PART ONE

A LIGHT IN THE WINDOW

CHAPTER 1

Two Weddings and a Cow

LEX VEY HAD FORGED a Lockward out of the bones of the world, and he could not tie his own collar.

"*Hold still*," said Brannoc.

"*I am holding still*."

"*You're holding still like a horse holds still when there's a wasp in the stable*." The old smith's enormous hands, black-nailed, burn-scarred, steady as an anvil, took the two ends of the cloth from Lex's fingers and did something to them that Lex couldn't follow. Over. Under. Through. Tug. "*There.*"

Lex looked down at it. It was a knot. A good one. Neat and flat and square, at the base of his throat, holding the high collar of the best shirt he had ever owned closed over the burn scars on his collarbone.

"*How did you do that*?"

"*Same way you do a weld*." Brannoc stood back and looked him up and down with his head on one side. "*Don't think about it. Just do it before the iron cools.*"

"*I've never seen you wear a collar in your life*."

"*Wore one once*." Brannoc picked a thread off Lex's shoulder. "*To my own wedding. Thirty-eight years ago. In the chapel at Ashbourne, with Sister Agathe's aunt doing the words, and her aunt's cat asleep on the altar.*" His soot-black beard twitched. "*My Mattie tied it for me. Swore at me the whole time. Said I had a neck like a bull and the sense of a turnip.*"

Lex looked at him.

Brannoc Holt never talked about his wife. Not in the thirteen years Lex had lived in his house. There was a little painted wooden box on the shelf above the forge-loft bed with a lock of brown hair in it, and that was all Lex had ever known.

"*She'd have liked you*," said Brannoc. Gruffly. To the shirt. "*She'd have liked the girl better. But she'd have liked you.*"

"*Everyone likes Wren better*."

"*That's because she's better*," said Brannoc. And then he put both of his enormous hands on Lex's shoulders and held them, hard, the way he'd held them on the night of the fire, when Lex was eleven and couldn't stop shaking. "*You did good, lad*," he said. Very quietly. "*You did good.*"

Lex couldn't say anything.

So he didn't. And Brannoc didn't need him to. He just squeezed Lex's shoulders once, and let go, and turned round, and blew his nose very loudly into a rag that had been used for oiling tongs.

◆ ◆ ◆

[He's right,] said Ember. *[You did.]*

Lex stood in the little stone room off the library of the Lantern Keep, which had been Antho's study, and then Seraphine's study, and then a storeroom for Teo's fish-buckets, and was now, for one morning, the place where the groom was being kept out of everybody's way.

The other groom was being kept in the cold-room. With the fish. Nobody had asked him if he minded.

Ember.

[Yes?]

Are you crying?

[I am a fragment of a sorcerer's mind, pressed into a seal like a maker's mark and currently residing in a metaphorical hearth at the center of your soul,] said Ember. *[I do not have eyes. I cannot cry.]*

You're crying.

[A little,] said Ember. *[Shut up.]*

Lex smiled.

It came out wobbly. Everything about him was wobbly this morning. His hands. His knees. His voice, when he'd said good morning to Pim on

the stairs, which had come out an octave too high and made Pim laugh so hard he'd had to sit down.

He hadn't slept.

None of them had. Not after midnight. Not after their father had knelt down by the fire and woken them and said *she sent a message*, in a voice Lex had never heard him use before. Not after they'd gone down, all of them, and stood in front of the black door and read nothing, because the words were gone, and Antho had put his hand on the glass and listened, and said *there's something with her. And it's a big shape.*

Not alone.

Lex had lain awake on the slope for the rest of the night with Wren asleep against his back and the little silver bell on its cord round his neck, and listened to it. Waiting for it to ring again.

It hadn't.

Ember.

[Still here.]

What do you think she meant?

The coal in his hearth was quiet for a long time.

[I don't know,] said Ember at last. Honestly. The way it always was now, since the Heart, since it had gone down into his hearth and stayed there and started writing. *[I've been thinking about it all night. In between composing a very moving speech I will not be permitted to deliver.]* A pause. *[Whatever it is, it's coming slowly. Antho said far down. Very far. You won't be getting married with it in the room.]*

That's not very comforting.

[It wasn't meant to be comforting,] said Ember. *[It was meant to be true. I've given up being comforting. It never worked. You always saw through it.]*

Lex breathed out.

[Today,] said Ember. More gently. *[Just today. Let it be today. She'd want that. She sent the message so you'd know she was coming, not so you'd spend your wedding staring at a door.]*

You don't know that.

[No,] said Ember. *[But I know her. A little. In the way I know anything. Through him.]* It was quiet. *[She'd want you to have today.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A KNOCK on the door.

It opened before he could answer. Antho came in.

Lex stared at him.

His brother was wearing black. Of course he was. A long coat, plain and fitted, with high collar and silver buttons, over a shirt so white it hurt. His long black hair was tied back at the nape of his neck. His beard was trimmed close. His grey eyes were clear and calm and very, very tired.

He looked like a duke. Or a poet. Or a very well-dressed undertaker.

He was holding a fish.

A large silver fish. By the tail. It was still damp.

"*It got out*," said Antho.

"*What*?"

"*The fish. Teo's fish. The wedding present.*" Antho held it up. It flapped once, weakly, in a disgruntled sort of way. "*It got out of its barrel. I don't know how. It doesn't have legs. I found it in the passage outside the cold-room. Flapping. Towards the door.*"

"*The black door*?"

"*The front door*." Antho looked at it. "*I think it wants to go outside.*"

"*It's a fish*."

"*I'm aware it's a fish*." His brother's mouth did the thing it did. The almost-smile. The one that was exactly like Lex's, which nobody had ever been able to explain. "*I've been holding it for ten minutes. I don't know what to do with it. If I put it back it'll just get out again. If I let it go it'll die. If I give it to Odile she'll name it.*"

"*Give it to Teo*."

"*Teo's doing Seraphine's hair*."

Lex looked at him.

"*He's very good at it*," said Antho. "*It's the Tide. Hair's mostly water, apparently. He made it curl.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY PUT THE FISH in a bucket.

It took both of them. It was a large fish, and slippery, and had opinions. By the time it was in the bucket, in a corner of Seraphine's old study,

glaring at them, Lex's best shirt had a long wet streak down the front and Antho had scales in his beard.

They stood there and looked at each other.

And started laughing.

Lex couldn't stop. He leaned against the wall and laughed until his ribs hurt and his eyes ran, and Antho sat down on a crate of fish-food and put his face in his hands and shook, and neither of them could have said why, except that they hadn't slept and their mother was coming home and they were getting married in an hour in front of a door at the bottom of a mountain, and there was a fish in a bucket, and somehow it was all one thing.

"*Brannoc's going to kill me*," said Lex. When he could. Looking down at the shirt. "*He tied the collar.*"

"*Brannoc's going to cry*," said Antho. Wiping his eyes. "*He's been crying since breakfast. Hedda had to take him for a walk.*"

"*He's not crying*."

"*He's crying*," said Antho. "*He told Pim it was the onions. There weren't any onions. Pim checked.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CHANGED THE SHIRT. He had a second one. Wren had made him bring it, because she knew him.

Brannoc tied the collar again. He didn't say anything about the first one. He just looked at the wet heap of linen on the floor, and at the bucket in the corner, and at the fish in the bucket glaring, and sighed the long weary sigh of a man who has been raising Vey boys for thirteen years and has given up expecting anything.

Then Arion came to fetch them.

He stood in the doorway in a plain grey coat. The same one he'd worn to the masquerade at Sorn's house, a year and a half ago, when he was still forty-five and always would be. It hung a little looser on him now. He was thinner. Greyer. Eleven grey hairs had become twenty since the morning before. Lex could see them. At the temples. Over the ears. And the bold one at the front, curling like a question mark.

His eyes were red. He'd been crying too. Everybody had.

"*It's time*," said Arion.

He looked at his sons. Both of them. Standing in a storeroom full of fish-food, in their wedding clothes.

He didn't say anything else. He didn't need to. He just looked. For a long moment. The way you look at something you didn't think you'd live to see, and are trying to remember properly, so that you'll have it later, when you need it.

Then he cleared his throat.

"*Your mother*," said Arion Vey, "*would have said you both need a haircut.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HOLLOWMAW WAS A mountain with a cave in it, and the cave went down.

A long passage. Sloping. Turning. Down through the living rock of the Greyspine, under the snow and the ice and the wind, into the dark. And all the way down, on both sides of the passage, in niches cut into the stone and on shelves and ledges and iron brackets hammered into the walls, lanterns.

One thousand one hundred and eleven of them.

Antho had lit the first one in the summer after Duskhold, with his own hands, in the cave where he'd lived alone for eight years. Then a second. Then a hundred. Then a thousand. People brought them. From all over Caldor. From the Sunreach. From the twelve villages. Old lanterns and new. Tin and iron and brass and glass. Paper ones, from the Saltreach. A great carved stone one, from the Ironbacks, that had taken four men to carry. Every one of them burning. Every one of them lit for someone who hadn't come home.

The Lantern Keep.

Lex walked down the passage between his brother and his father, past all of them, the way he'd walked down it a dozen times before. But it was different today. Today there were people on both sides of the passage, pressed against the walls between the lanterns. Hundreds of them. Watching. Smiling. Crying. Reaching out to touch his sleeve, or Antho's, as they went by.

Mother Orla, from the Crooked Kettle, with her hand over her mouth. Pell, in his ranger's green, grinning like an idiot. Hollis Penn, the baker, with flour on his good coat. Corin Bell and his sister Mella. Roole and Fenn in their Keepers' grey. Benno, the boy standard-bearer, with the black and grey banner of the Ashen Banners held up straight and his young face set like stone, the way Teodra Hale's had been.

Tilda Crane. With Brannoc's hammer on her back. Who saw Lex looking and went bright red and waved, frantically, with both hands.

Bess Rook. From Fen Hollow. Eighty-one years old. Who had walked three hundred miles with a stick. Who caught Lex's sleeve as he passed and pulled him down, with surprising strength, and kissed him on the cheek, and said, very loudly, so the whole passage heard: "*You're the big smith who made the lights come on.*"

"*Yes*," said Lex, red to the ears.

"*Well, don't muck it up*," said Bess Rook. And let him go.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PASSAGE OPENED OUT at the bottom into a cavern.

Round. High. Shaped like the inside of a bell. With walls of black stone that glittered faintly in the lantern-light, and a floor of black stone worn smooth by ten thousand years of nothing and three years of footsteps.

And at the far end, set into the wall, a door.

Black glass. Tall. Smooth. Sealed. A door to nowhere. A door to the dark under the world. With a narrow niche cut into the stone at its left side, at the height of a woman's hand.

Three lamps in the niche.

A small brown clay one, round and plain, with a chip in its spout and a thumbprint in its base. A squat iron one, with twenty Hush-runes on its glass. And a new one. Small. Iron. Lex's. With a single rune on the glass, which said *ARDENT*.

All three burning. Small and gold and steady. Straight up.

The cavern was full of lanterns too. On every ledge. In every crack. And full of people, standing in a great crowd that filled the floor from wall to wall and pressed up the slope of the passage behind them. The Queen of Caldor, in blue, with a silver circlet. Queen Ishara of the Sunreach, in gold,

with a hawk on her shoulder. Elowen Dunmore, in her armour, with Oathkeeper drawn and point-down on the stone in front of her. Kestrel Varn, with her hair burning quietly gold. Ilse and Ivo Marrow, in matching green, holding hands.

And in front of the door, waiting, with a book in her hands and a lantern hanging from a hook on her staff, Sister Agathe of the Ashbourne chapel.

She was very old now. Small and stooped and wrinkled, in the grey robe of the Lady of Lanterns, with her white hair in a knot. She had baptised Lex. She had buried half of Ashbourne. She had stood in the chapel doorway on the night of the gloamhounds and shouted at them until they went away.

She looked at the two of them coming toward her. Through her thick spectacles. With her mouth set in a thin line.

"*Late*," said Sister Agathe.

"*There was a fish*," said Lex.

"*I don't want to know*," said Sister Agathe.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOOD IN FRONT of the door.

Lex on the left. Antho on the right. Their father a little behind them, between them, with his hands clasped behind his back. Brannoc behind Lex. Hedda Vorne behind Antho, because Antho had asked her to, and Hedda had said *what on earth for* and then gone very quiet and said *all right*.

And Pim.

Pim stood in front of all of them. Right in front of the door. Twelve years old, or thirteen, or fourteen; nobody knew for certain, least of all Pim. Small and thin and solemn, with a mop of black hair that refused to lie flat and the grey-violet eyes that went dark when he was Listening to Shade. He was wearing a coat Seraphine had made him, blue, with brass buttons, of which he was enormously proud.

He was holding a velvet cushion.

On the cushion were two rings. One black iron, plain, made from a hundred-year-old nail. One silver, plain, with a single rune on the inside, which also said *ARDENT*.

Pim had been practicing holding the cushion for six days. He had held it at breakfast. He had held it at lunch. He had held it in his sleep, Odile reported, with his arms out straight, and had woken in a panic at two in the morning shouting that he'd dropped it.

He held it now as if it were made of glass, and the rings were made of glass, and the air was made of glass, and if he breathed it would all shatter.

"*Breathe*, *Pim*," murmured Antho.

Pim breathed. Very carefully. Through his nose.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THE MUSIC STARTED.

It wasn't much. A fiddle. A bone flute. A little Sunreach drum, tapped softly with the fingers. Ilse played the fiddle. Ishara's drummer played the drum. And the bone flute—

Lex turned his head.

It was his father. Arion Vey. Standing behind them with Antho's old bone flute at his lips. The one Antho had played for eight years in a cave to keep the Murmur away. Playing *The Lantern Song*.

Not well. His long fingers were stiff. He'd never been a musician. He missed a note in the second line, and found it again, and went on.

Little light, little light, burning low.

The crowd at the back of the cavern parted.

And Wren came down the passage.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME ON HER mother's arm.

Maren Ashdown was small and thin and had been ill for most of Wren's life. Grey-lung, from the Gloam in the old mines at Coldwater, that the physics of Highcrest couldn't cure. She'd been getting better since Duskhold, five years ago, when the Gloam went out of the world. Slowly. A little each year. She walked with a stick now, instead of being carried. She had color in her cheeks.

She walked down the long passage of the Lantern Keep with her stick in one hand and her daughter on her other arm, and she held her head up like a queen.

And Wren—

Lex had seen Wren Ashdown in a lot of things. Mud. Snow. Blood, her own and other people's. A borrowed green gown in a wrecked ballroom with no shoes on. Nothing at all, once, in a hot spring in the Greyspine, by accident, which had been the most embarrassing day of his life.

He had never seen her in this.

It was green. Of course it was green. Dark green, like pine-needles, like the forests above Thistledown in winter. Plain. Long. With narrow sleeves and a high neck and no lace and no jewels. She'd made it herself. With Seraphine's help, and Ilse's, and a great deal of swearing. She'd had a hood on the cloak, and the hood was down, and her fox-red hair was loose. All of it. Down her back. He'd never seen it loose in public. She always braided it. Practical.

There were small white flowers in it. Snowdrops. From the slope outside. Pim had picked them that morning, in the dark, in the snow.

She had her bow on her back.

Of course she did.

She came down the passage toward him with her mother on her arm and her bow on her back and snowdrops in her hair, and she was looking straight at him, with her green eyes very bright, and she was trying not to laugh.

Lex couldn't breathe.

[Breathe,] said Ember. Very softly.

He didn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND BEHIND HER, THE second bride.

Seraphine Ilvane came on the Queen's arm.

Lysandra had asked. She'd come to the Keep a month ago, on her own, with no guard but Elowen, and sat in the library with Seraphine for an afternoon, and come out with her eyes red. *Her father's dead*, she'd said to

Antho afterward. *Drowned. When she was eleven. And she said there was nobody else. And I said I'd be honored.*

The Queen of Caldor walked down the passage in her blue dress with her silver circlet on her brow and the Royal Archivist of Caldor on her arm.

Seraphine was in grey. Silver-grey, like the inside of a shell, with long sleeves to hide the scars on her wrists from the Pale Wastes, where the Tide had healed her. Her dark hair was up, and curled, and full of tiny silver pins. Teo had done it. Teo stood at the side of the passage, dripping slightly, looking extremely proud.

She was wearing her spectacles.

She'd tried not to. She'd told Lex, in the library, a week ago, very seriously, that brides didn't wear spectacles. That it wasn't done. That there were books about it.

Then how will you see him? Lex had said.

She'd stared at him. And then gone very pink. And worn them.

She was holding a little notebook. A small one, bound in leather, the size of her palm. In her other hand, against her chest. Lex knew what was in it. Antho didn't.

She came down the passage on the Queen's arm and looked at Antho through her spectacles. And Antho, standing beside Lex in his black coat with fish-scales still in his beard, made a small sound. Like a man who has been hit very gently in the chest.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STOOD IN FRONT of the black door. Four of them. In a row.

Sister Agathe looked at them over her book.

"*Well*," she said. "*Here we all are.*"

And she began.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T HEAR MOST of it.

He heard Sister Agathe's thin old voice going on, about the Lady of Lanterns, and the light in the window, and the long road home. He heard Pim breathing very carefully through his nose. He heard the lanterns hiss, a thousand of them, very softly, all round. He heard Brannoc behind him, crying. Not quietly.

But mostly he heard Wren.

Not her voice. She wasn't saying anything. Just—her. Beside him. The small sounds of her. Her breath. The creak of her bow-string against the green cloth. The way she shifted her weight from one foot to the other, the way she always did when she had to stand still for too long. He'd have known those sounds anywhere. In the dark. In his sleep. In the bottom of a Wellworld with fire coming out of his mouth.

He'd heard them every day for five years.

He wanted to hear them every day for fifty more.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*The vows*," said Sister Agathe. "*If there are vows. I'm told there are vows.*" She peered at Lex. "*Short ones, I hope. I'm ninety-one.*"

Lex turned to face Wren.

He'd written it down. Three times. He'd burned all three. Ember had offered to help, and he'd said no, and Ember had said *[good. I'd have made it rhyme.]*

He opened his mouth.

And nothing came out.

Wren looked up at him. Her green eyes very bright. Her mouth twitching.

"*Hammer*," she whispered. "*You've forgotten it.*"

"*I've forgotten it*," he agreed.

The cavern rippled with laughter. Soft. Fond. Brannoc laughed, through his crying. Kestrel laughed so loud Ishara's hawk flapped.

Lex looked down at Wren. At the snowdrops in her hair. At the bow on her back.

[Just say it,] said Ember. *[Whatever it is. Say it the way you'd say it to her at the fire.]*

So he did.

"*I was a Common smith, Level nine, Ceiling twenty-four*," said Lex. "*When I met you. You charged me two silver to walk me up a mountain, and you said I walked like a bear in a china shop.*"

"*You did*," said Wren.

"*I still do.*" He swallowed. "*And then I lost everything. My class. My fire. Everything the Stone said I was. And I was nothing. A man with a hammer and no numbers. And you stayed.*" His voice cracked. "*You chose me with nothing. Before anyone else did. Before I did.*"

The cavern was very quiet.

"*I don't know how to say it better than that*," said Lex. "*I'm not good at words. I'm good at making things. So I made you a ring out of a nail from the first forge I ever worked in. And I put a word on the inside.*" He looked at her. "*That's the vow. That's all of it. It's on the inside. Where you'll see it every time you put it on.*"

He took the black iron ring off Pim's cushion. Pim exhaled, enormously, like a bellows.

He held it out.

Wren looked at it. Then at him.

Then she held out her left hand. And he put it on her finger. And she turned it, once, with her thumb, the way she'd turned it on the roof of the Spire at dawn, and he knew she was feeling the rune on the inside, against her skin.

STAY.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*My turn*," said Wren.

She didn't have anything written down. She'd told him she wouldn't. *If I write it down I'll read it out like a shopping list*, she'd said. *I'll just say it. And if it's terrible, it's terrible.*

She looked up at him.

"*I've been hungry*," said Wren Ashdown. Quietly. "*Properly hungry. When I was little. The winter Mam got sick, and there was nothing in the house, and I went out into the snow with Da's old bow that I couldn't draw, because I thought if I didn't, she'd die.*" She swallowed. "*I hate waste. You know I do. Food. Time. People. I hate it more than anything.*"

"*I know.*"

"*So I'm not going to waste this*," said Wren. Her voice wobbled. She steadied it. "*Whatever it is. However long. I'm not going to waste one day of it. Not one.*" She lifted her chin. "*And if you go off alone again, I'll find you.*

I'm a tracker. It's my job. I'll find you wherever you go. And I'll be very, very angry. And I'll bring you home."

Somebody in the crowd sniffed loudly. It was Elowen Dunmore.

Wren took the silver ring off the cushion—no. Wait. That was Seraphine's. Pim jerked the cushion back so fast both rings bounced. The whole cavern gasped. Lex lunged. Antho lunged.

Pim caught them.

Both of them. One in each hand. Out of the air. With the lightning reflexes of a boy who had grown up on the streets of Kessick and the cliffs of the Greyspine.

There was a long silence.

Pim looked down at the two rings in his two fists. Then up at the four of them. His thin face had gone white.

"*Sorry*," said Pim. In a very small voice.

And then the whole cavern was laughing, the Queen and the knights and the dragons' riders and the bakers and the smiths, and Pim's thin face cracked into a grin, wide and fierce and astonished, and he put the rings back on the cushion very carefully, both of them, and stood up straight.

Wren hadn't got a ring for Lex.

He hadn't wanted one. He'd said so. *I'll lose it. It'll melt. I work in a forge.*

She reached up instead. And took hold of the cord round his neck. The one with Malachi's little silver bell on it. And pulled him down. And kissed him.

In front of everyone. In front of the door. In front of the Queen of Caldor and a ninety-one-year-old Sister of the Lady of Lanterns, who said, very loudly, "*I haven't got to that bit yet.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO'S VOWS WERE NUMBERS.

Lex had known they would be.

His brother turned to Seraphine in front of the black door, with his long hands clasped in front of him so that nobody would see them shaking. And looked at her. Through her spectacles. For a long moment.

"*Eleven*," said Antho Vey.

Seraphine blinked.

"*Eleven times*," said Antho. "*That you've saved my life. I've counted. Fort Caldris, when my Clarity was at six and you sang. The watchtower. The Pale Wastes. The night in the Barrows, which you don't know about, because I never told you how close it was. The Wellworld of Tide. The Highcrest singing. The white mountain. Four more that you'd say don't count, but they do.*" He swallowed. "*Eleven.*"

He looked at the floor.

"*I've saved yours four times*," he said. "*That's not enough. I'm behind. I'll be behind for the rest of my life.*" He looked up again. "*I'd like to spend it catching up.*"

He took the silver ring off the cushion. Pim held it very still.

"*I counted the lanterns this morning*," said Antho. "*Like I always do. One thousand one hundred and thirteen.*" He held the ring out. "*I'd like to count something else now. With you. Every day. Whatever you like. Books. Stars. Days.*" His voice went very quiet. "*I'm not good at much, Seraphine. But I'm very good at counting.*"

Seraphine was crying.

Silently. Behind her spectacles. With the tears running down and dripping off her chin onto her silver-grey dress.

She held out her hand. He put the ring on it. *ARDENT*, on the inside. A lantern's word.

Then she opened the little leather notebook.

"*I made a list*," said Seraphine Ilvane. Her voice was steady, which was a miracle, because her hands weren't. "*Of reasons. I'm a scholar. We make lists.*" She turned a page. "*It's annotated.*"

"*How long is it*?" said Sister Agathe. With deep suspicion.

"*Four hundred and twelve entries*."

"*Child*."

"*I'll only read the first one*," said Seraphine. Hastily. She looked down at the page. Then up at Antho. Then she closed the book.

"*Reason one*," she said. "*He reads to the bats.*"

Antho stared at her.

"*In the cold-room*," said Seraphine. "*At night. When he thinks nobody's listening. Every night. For three years.*" Her voice cracked. "*He reads them*

history. Because he says they've been in the dark so long they don't know what happened."

There was a pause.

"*That's the first one*," said Seraphine. "*The other four hundred and eleven are footnotes.*"

And Antho Vey, Threshold Warden, Tier IV, the man who had stood in the doorway at the bottom of the world and shut out the hunger with his own body, put his face in his hands. In front of everyone. And laughed. And cried. Both. At once.

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS WHEN THE lamps leaned.

Lex saw it first, because he was nearest. Out of the corner of his eye. In the niche beside the black door.

The clay lamp. The little brown one, with the chip in its spout and Seren's thumbprint in the base.

Its flame bent.

Not much. Not like last night. Just a little. A hair. Toward the black glass. The way a candle flame bends toward an open window. Toward a draft. Toward someone breathing very softly on the other side of a door.

And then the iron one. And then the new one, the *ARDENT* one, Lex's. All three of them. Leaning. Gently. Together.

As if someone very far away had stopped walking. And turned. And was listening.

The cavern went quiet.

Not everyone saw it. But enough did. Arion did. Lex heard his father make a sound behind him. Small. Like a man who has been holding his breath for a year and a half.

Antho took his hands away from his face. And looked at the lamps. And then at the door.

"*Mam*," he said. Very softly.

The flames held there. Leaning. For a long moment. Three small gold lights, bent toward the black glass.

And then they straightened. Slowly. One by one. And burned straight up again.

Sister Agathe looked at the lamps over her spectacles. And then at the two brothers. And then at their father. And her thin old face did something it almost never did.

"*Well*," said Sister Agathe. Very gently. "*That's everyone, then.*"

She closed her book.

"*By the light of the Lady of Lanterns*," she said, "*who keeps the door for the ones who go, and the lamp for the ones who come home: you're married. All four of you. Gods help you.*" She sniffed. "*Now you can kiss them. Properly. In the right order.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FEAST WENT ON until the stars came out, and then until the stars went round.

It was held on the slope outside the cave mouth, in the snow, around twenty fires. There were tables made of planks and barrels. There was Mother Orla's bacon, which she had brought from Ashbourne in a cart, wrapped in straw. There was Hollis Penn's bread, a wagon of it, in every shape: loaves and rolls and plaits and a great round one shaped like a lantern, which Hollis Penn carried round himself from fire to fire, so that everyone could see it before they ate it. There were Sunreach dates and figs from Ishara's riders, and smoked fish from the Saltreach, and something purple in a pot that Hedda had made, which nobody could identify and everybody was afraid to ask about.

There was wine. There was a great deal of wine.

There was dancing.

Lex danced with Wren. Badly. He danced like a bear in a china shop. She told him so. He trod on her foot. She trod on his, harder, on purpose. They laughed so much they had to stop.

He danced with Maren Ashdown, very slowly, holding her stick for her. He danced with Bess Rook, who led. He danced with Tilda Crane, who was so nervous she forgot which hand was which and spun the wrong way into Pell. He danced with Queen Ishara of the Sunreach, which was terrifying, because she was taller than him and danced like a sword-fight.

He did not dance with Queen Lysandra of Caldor, because she was dancing with Elowen Dunmore. Both of them. Together. In the snow by the biggest fire. And laughing.

Nobody said anything about it. Nobody needed to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MARROW PLAYERS DID a play.

It was about a wedding. A dragon's wedding, Ilse said. With a lot of illusion. The dragon was made of light, and enormous, and wore a veil, and the groom was a very small, very nervous mouse who kept falling off the dragon's head. Ivo played the mouse. He fell off the cart four times. On the fifth, Ashka, sprawled on the ridge above the fires with her mother, lifted her great blue head and *caught* him, gently, in her jaws, and set him back on the cart.

The crowd went wild. Ivo bowed. Shakily. With dragon-spit in his hair.

Prudence the cow got loose during the curtain call and walked straight through the illusion of the dragon, which flickered and went out. She stopped in front of the cart and looked at Ilse with deep disapproval and mooed. Once. Very loudly.

Then she went and found Correspondence the goat, who was eating Hedda's purple thing out of the pot, and headbutted him into a snowdrift.

Tamsin Varn chased her up the slope shouting her name. Kestrel laughed so hard she set fire to the tablecloth.

◆ ◆ ◆

LATER, MUCH LATER, LEX sat on a rock a little way up the slope with his brother.

The fires were burning low. The music had gone soft. Most of the guests were asleep, or nearly. Rolled in blankets by the fires. Curled in the tents. Brannoc was snoring under a table with his head on a sack of flour and Hedda's shawl over him. Pim was asleep on Arion's lap, by the fire at the cave mouth, with his blue coat buttoned to the chin. Arion wasn't asleep. He was sitting very still, so as not to wake the boy, looking at the fire.

Wren and Seraphine were by the next fire down. Talking. Heads together. Laughing about something. Every so often one of them looked

up the slope at the rock where their husbands were sitting, and said something, and the other one laughed harder.

"*They're talking about us*," said Antho.

"*They're definitely talking about us*."

"*Wren told her about the hot spring*."

Lex choked. "*How do you know about the hot spring*?"

"*Everyone knows about the hot spring*," said Antho. "*Ashka told Vharuun. Vharuun told me. In images. It was very vivid.*"

Lex put his face in his hands.

His brother laughed. Softly. The real laugh. The one that had taken years to come back.

Then it stopped.

Lex looked up.

Antho was rubbing his temple. With two fingers. Slowly. The way he'd done in the old days, in the cave, when the Murmur was rising. His clear grey eyes were narrowed. As if he was listening to something very far off. Or trying not to.

"*Antho*?"

"*Mm*."

"*You all right*?"

His brother took his hand away from his temple. Looked at it. Then at Lex. And smiled.

"*I'm fine*," said Antho. "*Long day. Long night. Too much of Hedda's purple thing.*" He shook his head. "*It's nothing.*"

Lex looked at him.

He knew that smile. He'd known it for five years. It was the smile Antho used when he'd decided something was his to carry. Alone. For now.

He opened his mouth to say something.

And Ember said, very quietly, in his hearth: *[Lex. Not tonight.]*

So he didn't.

He sat on the rock beside his brother on the night of their wedding and looked down at the fires and the sleeping people and the two dragons on the ridge and their father with a boy asleep in his lap. And he let it be tonight. Just tonight.

He'd ask tomorrow.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED HIS STATUS before he slept. He didn't know why. Habit. Five years of it. Like checking the bellows before you bank a fire.

```
LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 90
MIG 118  AGI 86  VIT 131
INT 152  SPI 260  RES 141
Health 1,310  Mana 2,600
ATTUNEMENT
  Flame ........ COMMANDING
  Stone ........ COMMANDING
  Tide ......... ANSWERING
  Gale ......... ANSWERING
  Shade ........ LISTENING
  Radiance ..... LISTENING
Title: [Husband] (new)
  +0 to everything. +1 to everything
  that matters.
```

He read the last line.

Twice.

Ember.

[I didn't write that,] said Ember. Instantly.

You absolutely wrote that.

[The net writes its own titles now,] said Ember. With enormous dignity. *[Since the reforging. Nobody controls it. Nobody at the center. It just—notices things. And says what it notices.]* A pause. *[I may have made a suggestion.]*

Lex lay back on his blanket by the fire, beside his wife, who was already asleep, with snowdrops wilting in her loose red hair and her bow propped against a barrel within arm's reach. And laughed. Silently. Until his ribs ached.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WOKE AN HOUR before dawn.

He didn't know why. The fire was down to embers. The slope was quiet. The stars were very bright, and very cold, and the snow on the Greyspine glittered under them like salt.

Something had woken him. A sound. Or the absence of one.

He lay still and listened.

Nothing. Wind. The fire ticking as it cooled. Wren breathing. Far off, down the slope, Prudence the cow lowing once in her sleep.

He sat up.

The mouth of the Hollowmaw was a gold arch in the dark. The lanterns inside it glowing. One thousand one hundred and thirteen of them, all the way down. The light spilled out onto the snow in a long soft fan.

Antho was standing in it.

His brother. Alone. In his black wedding coat, with his long hair loose now, and the Lantern in one hand with its shutter closed. Standing just inside the cave mouth. Very still. Looking at something on the wall.

Lex got up. Quietly. So as not to wake Wren. He went up the slope through the snow, and stopped beside his brother, and looked where Antho was looking.

At a lantern.

One of the first ones. Just inside the mouth of the cave. Old tin, battered, with a horn pane instead of glass. Lex knew it. It had come from Fenmoor. From the first Gloam-freed village. A woman had brought it, the summer after Duskhold, for her husband, who hadn't come back from the Quiet.

It was dark.

Not out. Not empty. Lex could see the oil in its little tin well, still half full. The wick was trimmed. It hadn't blown out; there was no wind in the cave, there never was.

It was just *dark*. As if the light had been taken out of it. Lifted out, neatly, the way you'd lift a pearl out of an oyster.

And on the horn pane, on the outside, there was dust.

Fine. Soft. Grey-gold. Like the powder off a moth's wing.

"*Antho*," said Lex.

His brother didn't answer. He was looking past the lantern. Into the dark of the passage. Down. Toward the bell-shaped cavern, and the black door, and the three lamps.

Lex looked too.

Something was moving in the dark between the lanterns. Low. Slow. Drifting. Grey-gold, catching the light as it passed each one. The size of a man's hand. Wings. Two pairs. Patterned with rings and whorls. And on each wing, an eye. A dark painted eye, ringed in gold, that seemed to look back at them as it turned.

A moth.

It drifted down the passage, from lantern to lantern. It didn't land. It didn't stop. It just passed close to each one, close enough to brush it with the edge of a wing.

And each one it brushed flickered. Just for a moment. As if something had touched the flame and tasted it.

"*There are no moths*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Not this high. Not in winter. Not in the Greyspine.*"

They watched it go. Down and down. Until it was a speck of grey-gold in the far-off glow at the bottom of the passage. Until it was gone.

Toward the door.

Toward the three lamps.

Lex turned and looked at the dark lantern by the cave mouth. The Fenmoor one. With the dust on its pane.

And his brother, beside him, with the Lantern in his hand and his clear grey eyes very wide, did what he always did.

He counted.

"*One thousand one hundred and twelve*," said Antho Vey.

CHAPTER 2

Growth: Unbounded

"*Good morning*," said Lex to the fire.

It was a small fire. The kitchen hearth of a small house. Four rooms and a loft, of grey Vale stone and new oak beams, with a slate roof that still smelled of the quarry and a door that stuck in wet weather because he'd hung it himself, in a hurry, in the autumn, and hadn't had time to plane it.

The fire was banked down to a few red coals under a heap of ash. He knelt and blew on them, gently, the way you'd wake a sleeping child.

They woke. Flickered. Caught the kindling he fed them. Climbed.

Good morning, said the fire. Not in words. It never used words. Just a warmth, a lift, a small bright sense of being glad to see him. The way a dog is glad. The way it had been every morning for five years, since Malachi's cave in the Wastes, since he'd learned that fire was a thing you could *ask*.

He sat back on his heels and watched it.

[You do that every morning,] said Ember.

I know.

[Every single morning. Without fail. Even the morning after the wedding, when you had a headache like a kicked anvil and Wren threw a boot at you.]

It would be rude not to.

[It's a fire.]

It's a Well, thought Lex. *It's the Flame. It's the oldest thing there is. It's been burning since before there were people to burn for.* He fed it another stick. *The least I can do is say good morning.*

Ember was quiet for a moment.

[Malachi said that,] it said. *[In almost exactly those words. To Aurelian. Nine hundred and forty years ago. I have it in the second volume.]* A pause. *[Aurelian said he was being sentimental.]*

And?

[And look how that turned out,] said Ember.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HOUSE STOOD AT the far end of the Vale, at a place called Harrow.

It wasn't a village. It had never been a village. It was a fold in the hills where the Ashbourne road gave out into a track, and the track gave out into a footpath, and the footpath went up through a birch wood to a clearing with a stream in it. There had been a cottage in the clearing once. Grey stone. One storey. A lantern in the window.

It had burned down thirteen years ago, on the night of Antho's Kindling, with their mother inside it. Or so everyone had thought.

Lex had come back in the autumn, before the wedding, with Brannoc and Tilda and six of the older students from the Forge, and they'd cleared away the black stones. All of them. Down to the footings. And then they'd built it again.

Not the same. He couldn't remember it well enough for the same. He'd been eleven, and most of what he remembered was smoke. But in the same place. With the same stream. And the same birch wood. And a window on the east side, facing the road, deep and wide, with a sill broad enough to sit on.

There was a lantern in it.

He'd made it himself. Iron and glass. With *ARDENT* on the pane, so it would never go out, and *HOME* cut into the base, because Wren said every lantern ought to say what it was for.

It was burning now. In the grey of the morning. Small and gold. Facing the road.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE THE PORRIDGE.

Wren came down the ladder from the loft while it was bubbling, in one of his shirts and a pair of thick wool socks and nothing else, with her red hair in a wild tangle over one shoulder and her eyes half shut. She stood at the bottom of the ladder and swayed.

"*Good morning*," said Lex.

"*Is it*?" said Wren. She sniffed. "*Is that porridge*?"

"*Yes*."

"*With honey*?"

"*Yes*."

She came across the kitchen and leaned her forehead against the middle of his back, between his shoulder blades, and stayed there. Breathing. He stirred the porridge. She didn't move.

"*You're very warm*," she said into his shirt.

"*I'm a Worldforger*."

"*You're a hot-water bottle*," said Wren. "*A large one. With opinions about porridge*."

He smiled. He kept stirring.

They had been married for three weeks.

He still wasn't used to it. Every morning he woke up in the loft, under the slope of the new roof, with the light coming grey through the little window, and she was there. Next to him. Asleep on her stomach with one arm flung over his chest and her hair everywhere. And every morning he lay there for a while and looked at the black iron ring on her finger, and couldn't quite believe it.

[You're doing it again,] said Ember.

Doing what?

[Smiling at the porridge.]

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY ATE AT THE table by the east window, with the lantern between them.

Outside, the birch wood was grey and bare and wet. The snow was going. It had been going for a week. The track down to the Ashbourne road was a river of brown slush, and the stream in the clearing was loud and

high and full of meltwater, and the air coming in round the edges of the window smelled of mud and new green and the first thin edge of spring.

"*You're going to the Forge*," said Wren. It wasn't a question.

"*Kindling-day*."

"*Today*?" She frowned. "*It's early.*"

"*Reeve Dunstan moved it up*." Lex shrugged. "*Twelve of them this spring. From Ashbourne and the farms round. He says they won't wait. Their parents won't wait. Everyone wants it done before planting.*"

"*Because they're unbounded*," said Wren.

"*Because they're unbounded*."

She looked at him over her porridge.

"*You don't like it*," she said.

"*I like it*." He frowned at the lantern. "*I made it. Of course I like it. No more Ceilings. No more children being told what they'll be before anyone asks who they are.*"

"*But*," said Wren.

He didn't answer.

She waited. She was good at waiting. She'd waited for him on a lot of rooftops.

"*It's fast*," said Lex at last. "*That's all. It's going so fast.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED TO ASHBOURNE along the river path.

It was three miles. He could have flown. Ashka would have come if he'd called her, from the Hollowmaw, in an hour. He could have Windstepped, the way Wren did, on the wind, though he was terrible at it and usually landed in a hedge.

He walked. He liked walking. It gave him time to think, and the Vale was beautiful in the thaw, and he wanted to look at it.

He'd lived here all his life. Eleven years at Harrow, thirteen at Ashbourne, with a few years in between of walking up mountains and into Wellworlds and down to the bottom of the world. He knew every field. Every hedge. Every stile. He knew which bridge was rotten and which ford was deep and which farmer would set his dog on you for crossing his barley.

It looked the same.

It wasn't.

He couldn't have said how. He'd been trying to say it for a year and a half. Since the Heart. Since the World Notice. Since every Ceiling in the world had lifted at once, like a lid coming off a pot.

It was in the people. The way they walked. The way they *stood*. Old Tobbin's widow, out in her yard with her geese, straight-backed, with her chin up, who'd stooped as long as Lex had known her. The Dunstan twins, twenty now, Kindled [Laborer] and [Laborer] at sixteen and capped at twenty-four, running past him on the river path in the thaw with packs on their backs and swords at their hips and their faces lit up like lamps.

"*Morning, Master Lex*!" shouted one of them.

"*Where are you going*?"

"*Greyspine*!" shouted the other. Not stopping. "*There's a nest of rock-wyrms up past Thistledown. Wardens never cleared it. Pell says it's worth a level each.*"

"*You're laborers*!"

"*Not anymore*!" They were already past. Already far down the path. One of them turned, running backward, grinning, and shouted back over his shoulder. "*Level thirty-one! Both of us! Since the autumn! We're Wardens now, Master Lex! Proper ones! Well. We're* Brawlers. *But we're going to be Wardens!*"

And they were gone round the bend of the river, running, laughing, two farm lads with swords, toward the mountains and the rock-wyrms and a level each.

Lex stood on the path and watched them go.

[They're happy,] said Ember.

I know.

[Happier than they've ever been. In their lives. You did that.]

I know, thought Lex. *That's what frightens me.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ASHBOURNE FORGE FILLED most of the east end of the village now.

It had started as Brannoc's forge. One anvil. One hearth. One old smith and one boy. Now there was a long hall with twenty hearths and twenty anvils and a great brick chimney at each end. There were two reading rooms and a library and a copying-house. There was a dormitory for the students who came from too far away to go home at night, and a kitchen where Mother Orla's niece cooked for forty, and a yard with a pump and a woodpile and a lean-to where Quill the raven had built a nest of stolen spoons on the chimney-top and lived like a king.

There were more than forty students now. Fifty-three, at the last count. From all over Caldor. From the Sunreach. Three from the Saltreach, who argued with everyone about everything. Two from the twelve villages, who'd come because Ilse Marrow told them to.

All of them unbounded.

He heard them before he saw them. Hammers. Twenty of them. Ringing, overlapping, in the long hall. The rhythm of it came down the street to meet him, and he felt his shoulders go loose the way they always did, the way they had since he was eleven and first heard Brannoc's hammer ringing through the forge wall at night.

Tilda Crane met him at the door.

She was nineteen. Small and fierce and freckled, with a smith's forearms already and a burn-scar on her chin and her mouse-brown hair tied back in a knot so tight it pulled her eyebrows up. She had Brannoc's hammer on her back. She carried it everywhere. She'd carried it to the wedding. Lex suspected she slept with it.

"*Master Lex.*" She was breathless. "*There's a problem.*"

"*There's always a problem.*"

"*No. A real one.*" She grabbed his sleeve. "*It's Dunny Tobbin. They've brought him in.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

DUNNY TOBBIN WAS FOURTEEN.

He'd been Kindled in the autumn. The first Kindling-day after the Heart. The first one in Ashbourne with no Warden at the Stone, no hand on anyone's shoulder, no lid. He'd put his hand on the cracked old Lattice

Stone on the green and it had lit up red and gold and the whole village had gasped.

[Berserker]. Rare. Growth: unbounded.

He'd been Level 1 in the autumn.

He was Level 34 now.

He lay on a cot in the infirmary at the back of the Forge, where Old Mag's apprentice kept her herbs, and he was grey. His left arm was splinted from wrist to shoulder. His right hand was bandaged. His face was bruised down one side, purple and yellow, and there was a cut over his eye with nine stitches in it. His feet, in their wrappings, were black at the toes.

"*Frostbite*," said Hedda Vorne. Grimly. Standing at the foot of the cot with her arms crossed and her cudgel tucked under one elbow. "*He'll lose two. Maybe three. The left foot.*"

Lex looked at the boy.

He knew him. He'd known him since he was born. Farmer Tobbin's grandson. A big slow sweet kid who used to come and watch at the forge door with his thumb in his mouth. Who'd sold Lex a copper penny's worth of conkers once, when he was six, and come back an hour later to give the penny back because he'd decided the conkers weren't very good.

"*Where*?" said Lex.

"*Up past the Teeth*." Hedda's mouth was a thin line. "*Alone. In the snow. For eleven days.*"

"*Doing what*?"

"*Killing things*," said Hedda Vorne.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D GONE UP INTO the Greyspine in midwinter. On his own. With a woodcutter's axe and his da's old coat and a sack of bread.

He'd been killing things ever since.

Gloam-beasts, mostly. The last of them. The ones that had been left behind when Morvane fell and the Quiet were released and the breaches closed. Gloamed bears and gloamed wolves and gloamhounds that had gone feral in the high passes, half-mad, half-starved, with the grey still in them. Nobody had bothered to clear them. They were too high and too scattered and too few. They'd been dying out on their own.

Dunny had found them.

He'd found that they were worth a great deal. A gloamed wolf, at Level 12, was worth a third of a level. A gloamed bear was worth a whole one. And a [Berserker], it turned out, got stronger when he was hurt. *Fury*, the skill was called. The more he bled, the harder he hit.

So he'd let himself bleed.

"*He said he couldn't stop*," said Tilda. Very quietly. Standing beside Lex at the cot. "*When they found him. Pell found him. Coming down the Thistledown track with a dead bear over his shoulders and his arm broken in two places. He said every time he killed one, he went up. And every time he went up, he could feel it. More. Higher. He said it was like being hungry and eating and getting hungrier.*"

She swallowed.

"*He said there wasn't any top*," said Tilda. "*He said he kept waiting for it to stop, and it didn't. He said nobody ever told him when to stop.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

He stood at the foot of the cot and looked down at a fourteen-year-old boy with black toes and a broken arm and nine stitches in his face. Level 34. Rare. Unbounded.

Nobody ever told him when to stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED HIS MOUTH to ask the boy's status.

And stopped. Because he couldn't.

He'd reached for it. Without thinking. The way you reach for a tool on a bench that isn't there anymore. *True Sight*. The gold flicker behind his eyes that had let him see anyone's thread. Their level. Their stats. Their seals and Sanctions and Ceilings.

It wasn't there.

It hadn't been there for a year and a half. He'd given it away at the Heart. With the rest of the Root. *ROOT: RELINQUISHED*. He'd laid it down on a gold anvil at the bottom of the world and walked away and never once regretted it.

But he still reached for it.

A dozen times a day. More. Every time he met someone new. Every time a student came to him with a question. Every time he looked at Wren across the breakfast table and wanted to know, without asking, how she was.

His hand closed on nothing.

[Lex.]

I know.

[You can ask him,] said Ember. Gently. *[People do. That's how everybody else does it.]*

I know.

He crouched down by the cot. Dunny Tobbin's eyes opened. Brown. Bloodshot. Frightened.

"*Hello, Dunny*," said Lex.

"*Master Lex.*" The boy's voice was a croak. "*I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I know I shouldn't have—Gran said—*"

"*How do you feel*?"

Dunny stared at him.

"*Not the arm*," said Lex. "*Not the toes. Inside. How do you feel, now?*"

The boy was quiet for a long time.

"*Hungry*," he whispered.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT AND STOOD in the forge yard for a while.

By the pump. In the thin spring sunshine. With his hands in his pockets.

The yard was full of puddles. And in the middle of it, where there'd never been anything but packed earth and cinders and the stump Brannoc used for splitting kindling, there was a spring.

A real one. Small. Bubbling up out of a crack in the cinders, round and clear, the size of a dinner plate. And warm. Lex could see the steam coming off it in the cold air. It ran across the yard in a little channel it had cut for itself, and under the gate, and away down the street toward the river.

It had appeared six days ago. Overnight. Hedda had come out to the pump in the morning and found it there, steaming, and stood and looked at it for a long time, and then gone and fetched Brannoc, who had stood

and looked at it for even longer, and then said, *well, that'll save on the pump.*

It wasn't the only one.

There'd been others. All winter. All over the Vale. Little things. Strange things. Things people called *the oddities* now, in the Crooked Kettle, with a laugh, the way you laugh at things you don't understand.

A well at Coldbrook, dry for forty years, that filled up in a night. A chimney at the mill that grew a second chimney, smaller, beside it, like a sapling, brick by brick, over a week. A road between Ashbourne and Millbridge that was a mile longer than it used to be, though nobody could say where the extra mile was or when it had been added.

And in Old Mag's garden, at the back of her cottage by the chapel, an apple tree that had been dead for twenty years had bloomed.

In the snow. In midwinter. Every branch. White and pink. Like a bride.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Something's making room*," said Old Mag.

She was ninety-five. Or ninety-six. She'd lost count, she said, and didn't intend to start again. She sat in the chair by her fire with a shawl round her shoulders and a cat on her lap and her one good eye bright and black as a bird's, and the other one milky and blind, and she looked at Lex across her little kitchen as if she'd been expecting him.

She'd been Kindled a [Herbwife], a lifetime ago. Common. Capped at twenty-four. Lex had Unbound her at the Ashbourne Stone, five years ago. She'd become a [Wisewoman]. She'd said it was about time somebody noticed.

"*Room*?" said Lex.

"*That's what it feels like*." Old Mag stroked the cat. "*You know when you're baking bread, and you leave it in the bowl by the fire with a cloth over it, and you come back, and it's risen? Pushed the cloth up. Filled the bowl.*" She nodded at the window. At the apple tree outside, still blooming, in the thaw. "*Like that. Like the ground's rising. Pushing things up. Making room for something underneath.*"

"*For what*?"

"*How should I know*?" said Old Mag. "*I'm a herbwife. I know nettles.*" She looked at him sideways with her bright black eye. "*You're the one with the fire in him. You're the one who went down to the bottom of the world. What's down there?*"

Lex didn't answer.

He was thinking about a door of black glass. And three lamps. And a message on the glass. *Not alone*.

And his brother, on a rock on the night of the wedding, rubbing his temple with two fingers.

Something big, he thought. *Antho said. A big shape.*

Coming up.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KINDLING WAS AT noon.

The whole village came out for it. The way they always did. The way they had for nine hundred years. But it was different now. There was no Warden at the Stone in a grey cloak with a silver badge. There was a Keeper. A young woman from Highcrest named Ada Fell, in the plain grey coat of the Keepers of the Stones, who'd been a Warden-cadet three years ago and had cried, she told Lex once, when Roole made her take off her badge, and then cried again, harder, at her first Kindling as a Keeper, when a farmer's daughter put her hand on the Stone and came up [Healer] and nobody pushed down.

She stood beside the Stone now. With her hands behind her back. Not on anyone's shoulder.

The Stone stood where it had always stood. On the green. Old and grey and leaning and cracked down the middle from top to bottom, the crack Lex had stared at every day of his childhood, the crack he'd always thought looked like a river.

Twelve children stood in a line in front of it.

Sixteen years old. Fifteen. One of them fourteen, because her mother said she was ready and the Keepers didn't argue anymore. They stood in a nervous row in their best clothes, with their parents behind them and the whole of Ashbourne behind their parents, and Reeve Dunstan in front of everyone in his chain of office, which he'd polished for the occasion.

Lex stood at the back. Next to Brannoc. With his arms crossed.

"*You look like a thundercloud*," said Brannoc.

"*I'm fine*."

"*You're thinking about Dunny*." The old smith looked at him sideways. "*Lad, he'd have done it anyway. Ceiling or no Ceiling. He'd have gone up the mountain to kill something because his gran's farm's failing and he thought if he got strong enough he could save it.*" He scratched his beard. "*The Ceiling never stopped anyone being stupid. It just stopped them getting anywhere.*"

"*It stopped them getting hurt*."

"*Did it*?" said Brannoc.

Lex didn't answer.

Brannoc was quiet for a moment.

"*I was capped at twenty-four*," he said. "*For nineteen years. I used to wake up in the night. Every night. Thinking, if I could just get to twenty-five. Just one more. I'd be able to do the big work. The proper work. I'd be able to make something that mattered.*" He shrugged his enormous shoulders. "*Couldn't. Never could. And I'll tell you what that does to a man, lad. It doesn't keep him safe. It just keeps him small.*"

Lex looked at him.

"*Let 'em get hurt*," said Brannoc Holt. Gruffly. "*Then teach 'em how not to. That's what you're for. That's what all of us are for, now. There's no lid. So we'd better be the ones standing round the pot.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST CHILD PUT her hand on the Stone.

It was Nan Hob. The cooper's daughter. Small and dark, with her hair in two plaits. She put her palm flat on the cracked grey stone and shut her eyes.

The Stone lit.

Silver. Faint. Then brighter. Silver and gold, running up through the crack like a river in spate, the way it had since the Heart. The whole green held its breath.

A panel rose over Nan Hob's head. Everyone could see it. They always could, at a Kindling. It was the one time the net showed itself to the world.

```
NAN HOB
Class: COOPER (Common)
Level 1
Growth: unbounded
```

There was a small silence.

Then the cooper, at the back of the crowd, let out a whoop that sent the rooks up out of the chapel elms. And Nan Hob opened her eyes and read it and burst into tears, and her mother swept her up, and everyone was laughing and clapping, and Lex was clapping too.

Common. A cooper. Like her father. Like her grandfather. Three generations of barrels.

Growth: unbounded.

A cooper who could be anything. A cooper who could go as high as she wanted. A Common class that would never, ever stop.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SECOND CHILD WAS Wat Lister's boy. Then the miller's twins. Then a girl from one of the hill farms who came up [Shepherd] and a boy from the same farm who came up [Shepherd] too, and they looked at each other and laughed, because they were cousins and had been fighting over the same flock since they could walk.

Then a girl named Ivy Moss.

She was the fourteen-year-old. The one whose mother said she was ready. She was thin and quiet and had been born with a twisted foot, and walked with a crutch, and had spent her whole life on the edge of things, watching.

She put her hand on the Stone.

And the Stone *hummed*.

Not lit. Not at first. It hummed. Low. Deep. A sound Lex felt in his chest before he heard it with his ears. Like a bell struck very far off. Like a note sung under the ground.

The crowd went quiet.

Ada Fell, the Keeper, took a step back. Her hands came out from behind her back.

The hum went on. Rising. The crack down the middle of the Stone began to glow. Not silver. Not gold. Something else. A dark glow. A deep, soft, purple-black, like the sky an hour after sunset. Like the inside of a closed eye.

[Lex,] said Ember. Sharply.

I feel it.

He did. Under his feet. Through his boots. Through the Stone in him, the Well he'd Commanded at the bottom of the world. The ground under the green was moving. Not shaking. *Rising*. Slowly. Pushing up. Like bread under a cloth.

Making room.

Ivy Moss stood with her hand on the humming Stone, very still, with her eyes wide and her crutch trembling under her other arm. She didn't take her hand away. She didn't scream.

She was listening.

"Ivy," said Lex. Quietly. Coming through the crowd. Slowly. Not running. Not frightening her. *"Ivy, love. Take your hand off the Stone."*

She looked at him.

"It's singing," said Ivy Moss. In a small, wondering voice. *"Master Lex. Can you hear it? It's singing."*

And then the ground beside the Stone opened.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T CRACK. IT didn't split. It didn't fall in.

It *opened*.

The way an eye opens. Smoothly. Silently. All at once. A circle, perfectly round, ten feet across, in the grass of the Ashbourne green beside the Lattice Stone, where an instant ago there had been nothing but turf and a few early daisies.

And inside the circle, dark.

Not a hole. Lex could see that at once. A hole had sides. A hole had dirt and roots and stones, and a bottom, somewhere, even if it was a long way down. This had none of those. It was simply *dark*. Perfectly flat. Perfectly black. Like a pool of ink set into the grass. Like a door left open into a room with no lights.

Air came out of it.

Warm. Soft. Breathing out against Lex's face in a long slow sigh. It smelled of—

He knew that smell. He knew it. Stone and cold and lamp-oil, and under that something older, something he'd only smelled once before, at the bottom of a long passage, in front of a sealed black door.

The Hollowmaw.

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMEBODY SCREAMED.

Then everyone did. The crowd broke backward from the green like a wave going out. Parents grabbing children. The miller's twins tripping over each other. Reeve Dunstan's chain of office swinging as he ran. Ada Fell, the Keeper, standing her ground beside the Stone with her face white and her hands up in front of her, empty, as if she could hold the dark back with them.

Ivy Moss didn't run.

She stood at the edge of the round dark, with one hand still on the humming Stone and her crutch under the other arm. And looked down into it.

Lex reached her. He put his hand on her shoulder. Gently. Not pushing down. Just there.

"*Ivy*."

"*It's all right*, *Master Lex*," said Ivy Moss. She didn't look up. "*It's not angry. It's not anything. It's just—*" She tilted her head. Listening. "*It's just very big. And it doesn't know where to go.*"

She took her hand off the Stone.

The humming stopped. The dark glow in the crack faded. Back to silver. Then to grey. The Stone was a Stone again. Old and leaning and cracked.

A panel rose over Ivy Moss's head.

```
IVY MOSS
Class: ▓▓▓▓▓▓▓
  (unrecognized)
Level 1
Growth: unbounded
Note: Kindled beside an open way.
```

And beside her, over the round dark in the grass, another.

```
▓▓▓ DELVE ▓▓▓
Name: —
Classification: UNCLASSIFIED
Floors: ?
Guardian: ?
Reward: ▓▓▓▓▓▓▓
Warning: This Delve was not spawned
  by the net.
```

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX READ IT.

Not spawned by the net.

Delves were the net's. They always had been. The Lattice spawned them at mana knots, in old places, deep places. The Frostvault, in the Greyspine, where he'd fought his first ice-wight with Wren at his back. The Drowned Archive at Qel'Varran. A thousand others, all over Aldermere. Floors and guardians and rewards. Tidy. Predictable. Ordered. The net made them, and the net labelled them, and the net knew what was in them.

The net didn't know what this was.

[Lex.] Ember's voice was very quiet. *[Lex, I've never seen that before. In nine hundred years of his memory. In all the records. I've never seen the net say it doesn't know.]*

I know.

[What is it?]

I don't know.

He crouched at the edge of the round dark. Close. Closer than he should have. He held his hand out over it, palm down, the way you'd hold your hand over a forge to feel the heat.

Warm. Soft. Breathing.

And very, very faintly, so faint he thought for a moment he was imagining it, from somewhere far down in the dark—

Humming.

A tune. He knew it. He'd known it all his life. He'd heard his mother sing it at the window of a cottage at Harrow. He'd heard his brother play it on a bone flute in a cave. He'd heard his father play it badly at his wedding, three weeks ago, in front of a door.

Little light, little light, burning low.

Flat on the high note.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

Wren was there.

He didn't know how. She'd been three miles away at Harrow, in his shirt and her socks, eating porridge. Now she was on the green beside him, in her leathers, with her bow strung and an arrow on the string and her hair in a hasty braid, breathing hard, with the wind still settling round her ankles.

"*Mistwalker*," she said, before he could ask. "*I heard it. Through the wind. The whole Vale heard it.*" She looked down at the round dark. "*What in the Lady's name is that?*"

"*A Delve.*"

"*That's not a Delve.*" She stared at it. "*Delves have doors. Stairs. Things.*"

"*The net says it's a Delve.*" Lex looked at the panel. "*The net says it didn't make it.*"

Wren was quiet for a moment.

Behind them, the crowd was coming back. Slowly. The way people do when the first fright wears off and the curiosity sets in. Edging forward across the green. Craning. Whispering. Parents holding their children back by the collars.

And the children. The unbounded children. Nan Hob and the miller's twins and the two shepherd cousins, fresh-Kindled, Level 1, with their panels still glowing faintly over their heads. Staring at the round dark beside the Stone with wide bright hungry eyes.

A Delve. Lex could see them thinking it. *A new one. Right here. On the green. Nobody's been in it. Nobody knows what's in it.*

Floors. Guardians. Rewards.

Levels.

Behind them, already, at the edge of the green, Lex saw the Dunstan twins come running back down the river road. Swords out. Faces alight. Two farm lads who were going to be Wardens. Who'd heard the hum from a mile off, and turned round, and come back.

And behind them, more. Pell, in his ranger's green, with his bow. The blacksmith's boys from Millbridge, who'd been at the Forge for the Kindling. Half a dozen of the older students. All of them coming. All of them with that look.

He thought of Dunny Tobbin on his cot, grey, with his black toes.

It was like being hungry and eating and getting hungrier.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TURNED ROUND.

He didn't raise his voice. He'd learned that much, in five years. From Arion, who never raised his. From Antho, who did it with silence. From Queen Lysandra, who could stop a room with an eyebrow.

He just stood between the round dark and the green, with his arms at his sides, and his fire very slightly up, so that the air around him shimmered and the snow-melt on the grass at his feet began, gently, to steam.

And everyone stopped.

"*Nobody goes in*," said Lex Vey.

The green was silent.

"*Nobody*," said Lex. "*Not the twins. Not the students. Not anyone who Kindled today, or yesterday, or last year. I don't care what level you are. I don't care what the net says it's worth.*" He looked at the Dunstan twins. They lowered their swords. Slowly. "*The net doesn't know what this is. Do you understand? For the first time in nine hundred years, the net doesn't know.*"

He let that sink in.

"*Until I know*," said Lex, "*nobody goes in.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WAS STANDING BESIDE him. With her bow.

"*Except us*," she said. Not a question.

He looked at her.

She looked back. Her green eyes very steady. The black iron ring on her finger, on the hand that held the bow.

"*Don't*," said Wren. Very quietly. Just for him. "*Don't you dare say it.*"

He didn't say it.

He'd learned that too. The hard way. On the south road, in the Glass Desert, at the bottom of the world. In a wrecked ballroom with a girl with no shoes on, saying *never again*.

"*Except us*," said Lex.

Wren smiled. Fierce. Bright. And nocked her arrow.

And behind them, Tilda Crane came running across the green with Brannoc's hammer in both hands and her face white and determined, and Pell came with his bow, and stopped, and looked at Lex. Waiting.

Lex looked down into the round dark.

It breathed out against his face. Warm. Soft. Smelling of the Hollowmaw.

And somewhere far, far down, a voice that was not quite a voice, that he had heard before, once, years ago, coming out of his brother's mouth in a cave in the Greyspine, whispered up out of the dark.

Not hungry. Not cruel. Not broken and grinding like it had been then.

Small.

Frightened.

...room...?

...please...make room...

CHAPTER 3

The Delve of Might-Have-Been

THERE WERE NO STAIRS.

Lex had been in a lot of Delves. Eleven, he'd counted once, for Seraphine, who'd wanted it for a footnote. The Frostvault, which had stairs cut into blue ice. The Drowned Archive, which had a spiral ramp going down into black water. A Delve in the Bitter Hills that was nothing but a well-shaft with iron rungs. A Delve in the Sunreach that you went into by walking backward through a mirror.

They all had a way in. A threshold. A first step.

This one had a hole. A round flat perfect dark, like a pool of ink, in the grass beside the Ashbourne Stone. No edge. No lip. No sides.

"*So we jump*," said Wren.

"*We don't know how far down it goes*."

"*So we jump carefully*."

Lex looked at her. She was standing at the edge of the dark with her bow over her shoulder and her knives in her belt and the wind curling round her boots, impatient, the way it always did when she was about to go somewhere it couldn't follow.

"*I'll go first*," said Lex.

"*You'll go first because you're heaviest and you'll hit the bottom first and tell us if there is one*," said Wren. "*Not because you're being noble. Say it.*"

"*I'm going first because I'm heaviest*."

"*Good*." She kissed him. Quick. Hard. "*Don't die. We've only been married three weeks. I haven't finished being annoyed with you about the door.*"

"*I'll fix the door*."

"*You've said that for five months*."

He stepped off the edge.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T FALL.

He went *through*. That was the only way he could describe it afterward, to Seraphine, who wrote it down. Not down. Through. Like walking through a curtain in a dark room. A soft cool pressure all over him at once, and a sense of the world turning over, gently, the way a page turns.

And then he was standing up.

On a floor. Smooth. Black. Glassy. Like the floor of the cavern at the bottom of the Hollowmaw. Faintly warm under his boots.

In a corridor.

It was long. He couldn't see the end of it. It went away in both directions, straight, into a soft grey dimness that wasn't quite dark and wasn't quite light. The walls were the same black glass as the floor. The ceiling was too high to see.

And on both sides of the corridor, as far as he could see in either direction: doors.

Hundreds of them. Wooden doors and iron doors and painted doors and doors of plain planks with rope handles. Tall doors and short ones. A red door with a brass knocker shaped like a fish. A low round green door like the door of a hill-farm. A door that was just a curtain, blue, stirring very slightly as if someone had just walked through.

Every one of them was closed.

And under every one, along the bottom, a line of light.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN ARRIVED BEHIND HIM. Lightly. On her toes. She looked round once and her hand went to her bow.

Then Tilda, who landed badly and sat down hard and said a word Brannoc had certainly taught her.

Then Pell. Who landed perfectly, because he was a Ranger and landing perfectly was apparently a thing Rangers did, and looked round, and said, "*Oh. Oh, I don't like this.*"

"*Nobody likes this*," said Wren.

```
▓▓▓ DELVE — FLOOR 1 ▓▓▓
Name: —
"The doors you didn't open."
Hostiles: ?
```

Lex read it.

The doors you didn't open.

He looked at the nearest one. On his left. An ordinary door. Oak, with an iron latch, worn smooth by hands. The kind of door you saw in every house in the Vale. He knew it. He'd known it all his life.

It was the door of the cottage at Harrow.

The old one. The one that burned.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Don't*," said Wren.

He hadn't moved. He realized he'd been about to. His hand had come up. Toward the latch.

"*Don't touch them*," said Wren. Her voice was very tight. "*Any of them. Look.*"

He looked where she was looking.

Across the corridor. A door. Plain planks. Grey with age. With a horseshoe nailed over it, the wrong way up, the way they did it in Thistledown, so the luck wouldn't run out.

"*That's ours*," said Wren. "*Mam's. The house in Thistledown. Where I grew up.*" She swallowed. "*I can hear her through it. Coughing.*"

Lex could hear it too. Faint. Behind the grey planks. A woman's cough. The deep wet rattling cough that Maren Ashdown had had every winter of Wren's childhood. The one that had eased, slowly, year by year, since Duskhold.

It wasn't stopping now. Behind that door, it was getting worse.

"*It's the one where you didn't come*," said Wren. Very quietly. "*Isn't it. The one where you never came up the road to Thistledown. Where nobody went to Duskhold. Where the Gloam stayed in the mines.*"

She didn't touch it. She stood very still in the middle of the corridor, with her bow in her hands, and listened to her mother cough behind a door that wasn't there.

Then she turned her back on it.

"*Let's go*," said Wren Ashdown.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED.

Down the corridor. In a line. Lex first, then Wren, then Tilda, then Pell at the back with an arrow on his string. Past the doors. Not looking. Trying not to look.

It was hard.

They all had them. Every one of them. Doors they knew. Doors they'd walked past, once, a long time ago, and not gone through. Pell's was a mill door, with flour on the step, and behind it the clack-clack-clack of a mill-wheel and a man's voice, older, Pell's own voice, singing a miller's song. *The life where I took the class the Stone gave me*, Pell said, white-faced. *The life where I stayed a miller.* Tilda's was the door of a farmhouse in the Ironback foothills, which she'd left at fourteen, and behind it a girl's voice, her own, much younger, crying.

They didn't stop.

Lex didn't let them.

[This is cruel,] said Ember. Very quietly. In his hearth. *[Whoever made this, it's cruel.]*

I don't think it means to be.

[How can you tell?]

I don't know, thought Lex. *It doesn't feel cruel. It feels—*

He didn't have the word. He reached for it, the way he'd reach for a tool.

Lost, he thought. *It feels lost. Like a child who's gone into every room of a house looking for someone, and opened every door, and left them all open.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST OF THE Unfinished came out of a door they'd passed.

Tilda saw it first. She turned, because she'd heard something, and screamed. Short. Sharp. And swung Brannoc's hammer up into her hands in one movement, the way Lex had taught her.

It was a wolf.

Or the idea of one. Drawn in lines. Charcoal-black lines on the grey air, like a sketch on a page, the kind of sketch Seraphine did in the margins of her notebooks when she was thinking. A long back. A narrow head. Four legs. A tail. No fur, no flesh, no eyes. Just the lines. Moving.

It came out through the oak door of a house Lex didn't know, as if the door wasn't there, and stood in the corridor, and turned its blank lined head toward them.

And then more. From other doors. Up and down the corridor. Wolves and dogs and something that might have been a horse. A man made of lines, walking stiffly. A bird, flapping, that never quite finished being a bird; one wing kept trying to be a hand.

```
HOSTILE: THE UNFINISHED
Level: ?
"Almost."
```

"*Back to back*," said Lex.

They were already doing it. Five years. Four people who'd fought together in the Greyspine and the Glass Desert and the Wellworlds and the long night under the lid. They turned into a ring in the middle of the corridor without thinking, Lex and Tilda facing one way, Wren and Pell the other.

The lined wolf came at Lex.

He hit it.

He didn't use Anvilsong. He didn't need to. He put his fire into his fist and struck it in the chest the way he'd strike a bar of iron on an anvil, hard and clean, with Flame Commanding behind it, and he felt the fire go out of him into the lines and—

Through.

Straight through. The fire went through the wolf the way a hammer goes through smoke. The charcoal lines wavered. Bent. Came back. And the wolf closed its blank jaws on his wrist.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T BITE. IT had no teeth. It had lines where teeth would be.

It was *cold*.

Not ice-cold. Not the cold of the Greyspine in winter. A different cold. An *empty* cold. Like putting your hand into a room where nobody has lived for a hundred years. It went up his wrist into his arm. And where it went, he felt himself go—

Thin.

He looked down. At his own hand, in the lined wolf's mouth.

The edges of it were blurring. His fingers. His knuckles. The burn-scars on the back of his hand. Going soft at the edges, like a drawing someone has rubbed with their thumb. Going *lined*.

It was taking his shape.

Not eating him. Not hurting him. Just—borrowing. The way a child borrows a coat that's too big for it. Reaching into him for the lines it didn't have.

"*Lex*!"

Wren's arrow went through the wolf's head. Straight through. Like his fire. The lines wavered and came back.

Tilda swung Brannoc's hammer. It went through the wolf's back. The lines bent around it like water.

Nothing worked. Nothing *touched* it. And his hand was getting thinner, and his wrist, and the cold was in his elbow now, and he could feel it reaching further, reaching for the rest of him, patient and lost and *wanting*—

Almost, said the net.

Almost.

◆ ◆ ◆

He thought: *it's not finished*.

He didn't know where the thought came from. It came up out of his hands, the way most of his thoughts did. Out of the part of him that had stood at an anvil every day since he was eleven.

It's not finished. It's a sketch. A pattern. A mould with no metal in it.

You can't break a pattern. There's nothing there to break.

You can only—

He stopped trying to hit it.

He put his other hand on the wolf's lined back. Flat. Gently. The way you'd put your hand on a horse that was frightened. And instead of pushing fire into it, he *listened* to it.

It was very simple. That was the first thing. Very simple and very empty. It wanted to be a wolf. That was all. It had been trying to be a wolf for a long time, and it didn't know how, and nobody had ever shown it, and it had found these lines somewhere, these shapes, the shapes of wolves people had *nearly* seen, and it had put them on like a coat and gone looking for the rest.

All right, thought Lex. *All right. Here.*

And he did what he would have done at the forge. With a bar of iron that didn't know what it wanted to be. He gave it a shape.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT HIS OWN SHAPE. That was what it had been taking. He gave it a wolf's.

He reached into the Stone in him, the Well he Commanded, and drew up iron. Real iron. From the ground under Ashbourne, from the old ore-seams the miners had worked for three hundred years. Not much. A handful. And he poured it into the lines. Into the pattern. Gently. Filling it. The way you pour metal into a mould.

He felt it take.

The lines thickened. Went solid. Went dark. Went grey. The charcoal sketch of a wolf filled up with iron from the nose to the tail, all at once, the way a cup fills when you hold it under a pump.

And then it was a wolf.

An iron wolf. Small. The size of a dog. Rough-cast and grey and plain, with no eyes, standing in the corridor on four iron legs with Lex's hand still in its mouth.

It let go.

It looked at him. With no eyes. Its iron head on one side.

Then it sat down. Very carefully. On the black glass floor. And was still.

Finished.

```
THE UNFINISHED (wolf): COMPLETED
+4,200 XP
New skill effect: WORLDFORGE
  → FINISHING
"A thing that is finished does not
 need to borrow."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT HIS hand.

It was his hand again. Solid. Scarred. Sharp-edged. The cold was going out of his elbow, slowly, like water draining from a sink.

He looked up.

Wren was staring at him. Tilda was staring at him. Pell had an arrow halfway to his ear and was staring at him over it.

The rest of the Unfinished had stopped too. All of them. Up and down the corridor. The lined dogs and the lined horse and the lined man and the bird that kept trying to be a hand. Standing still. Turned toward the iron wolf sitting on the floor. As if they were looking at it. As if they *could* look.

"*It wants to be finished*," said Lex. Hoarsely. "*That's all. They all do. They're not hunting us. They're borrowing. They want shapes.*"

"*So you—*" Tilda's eyes were enormous. "*So you made it into a—*"

"*I finished it.*" He looked at her. "*Tilda. Can you hear the fire?*"

"*Yes. Always.*"

"*Then you can do this*." He nodded at the lined dog nearest her. "*Don't hit it. Put your hand on it. Listen. Find out what it wants to be. Then give it something to be it with.*"

Tilda Crane looked at the lined dog. And at Brannoc's hammer, in her hands. And at Lex.

She set the hammer down.

She put her small scarred hand on the dog's lined back.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE MADE IT OUT of fire.

Not iron. Fire. Lex wouldn't have thought of it. A dog of fire, red and gold and flickering, the size of a sheepdog, curling up at her feet on the black glass floor like a hearth-cat. Warm. Bright. Finished.

Tilda sat down very suddenly next to it.

"*Oh*," she said. "*Oh, Master Lex.*"

```
TILDA CRANE
Level 37 → 39
```

Wren made a bird out of wind. Of course she did. It didn't stay. It went straight up into the high dark of the ceiling, a shape of moving air with a bird's wings, and was gone, and Wren watched it go with her mouth open.

Pell didn't make anything. He couldn't. He was a Ranger, and he didn't Listen to any Well. But he stood guard over the others with his bow, and when the lined man came at him, stiff-legged and blank, he talked to it. Calmly. The way he talked to frightened sheep on the hill. *Steady, now. Steady. Nobody's going to hurt you. Wait your turn.*

And it waited.

Lex finished it. With stone. A small grey stone man, plain and rough, like a cairn-figure on a mountain path. It sat down next to the iron wolf.

The lined horse went to Tilda's fire. The lined bird, the one that kept trying to be a hand, went to Wren, and she held it for a long time, very gently, and listened, and then said, *it wants to be both*, and gave it wind for the wings and her own warm breath for the hand, and it went up after the other one.

The corridor emptied. Slowly. One by one. A floor full of small finished things. Sitting. Still. Patient. Done.

```
▓▓▓ FLOOR 1 — CLEARED ▓▓▓
Hostiles completed: 23
Hostiles destroyed: 0
"Nobody had ever done it that way
 before. It was surprised."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

[It,] said Ember. Slowly. *[The net said* it. *Who's* it*?]*

The Delve, thought Lex.

[Delves aren't it*. Delves are places. The net doesn't call them* it*. In nine hundred years of records, the net has never once said a Delve was surprised.]*

Lex didn't answer.

He was looking at the end of the corridor. Where, a moment ago, there had been nothing but grey dimness going on forever.

There was a door there now.

The last door. At the very end. Plain black. No handle. No latch. No light underneath it.

It stood open.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SECOND FLOOR WAS forges.

Lex knew it the moment he stepped through. He smelled it before he saw it. Coal-smoke and hot iron and quench-water and leather, the smell he'd grown up in, the smell that was more like home than any house.

A long room. Low-roofed. Stone-walled. With a hearth at the far end, and an anvil in front of the hearth, and the coals glowing red.

Brannoc's forge.

The old one. The little one. The one with a single anvil, before the long hall, before the twenty hearths, before any of it. Exactly as it had been when Lex was eleven. The bench under the window with the tongs hung over it. The quench-barrel with the dent in its side. Slag the cat asleep on the woodpile. The little painted wooden box on the shelf over the door.

And at the anvil, working, a man.

Not Brannoc.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOPPED.

The man at the anvil was big. Bigger than Lex. Bald. Soot-bearded. He was working a bar of iron with a hammer Lex knew, swinging it in a rhythm Lex knew, humming a hymn off-key that Lex knew.

But it wasn't Brannoc. It was Brannoc's shape. Brannoc's size. Brannoc's hammer. With nobody in it.

Lines.

Charcoal-black lines on the dim air, drawing a smith at an anvil. Over and over. The hammer rising. Falling. Rising. Falling. Ringing on iron that wasn't there.

And beside the anvil, working the bellows, another figure.

Small. Thin. Eleven years old, or near enough. Dark curly hair, badly cut. Lines.

It was him.

Lex. At eleven. The way he'd been the first night, when Brannoc brought him in from the ashes at Harrow and sat him by the forge and gave him the bellows to work, because he couldn't stop shaking, and Brannoc said the work would help.

The lined boy worked the bellows. The lined smith swung the hammer. Over and over. Ringing.

Lex stood in the doorway and couldn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

[It's not real,] said Ember. *[Lex. It's not real. It's the Delve. It's a door you didn't open.]*

No, thought Lex. *It's a door I did open.*

He couldn't take his eyes off them.

This happened. This is real. This is the night Brannoc took me in. He swallowed. *So why is it here? Why is it a might-have-been?*

And then he understood.

The lined boy at the bellows turned his head. Slowly. Toward the door. Toward Lex.

And his lined face, his eleven-year-old face, went *wrong*.

The lines bent. Shifted. The boy's mouth opened. His eyes, which weren't eyes, which were just two dark loops of charcoal, went wide. And black. All the way black. And his shoulders hunched, and his small hands clenched on the bellows, and from somewhere inside the lines came a sound. A sound Lex hadn't heard in five years.

A whisper. Grinding. Broken.

hungry... so hungry... little brother smells of warm iron...

The Murmur.

Coming out of *his* mouth. His eleven-year-old mouth.

◆ ◆ ◆

The might-have-been where it was me.

He knew it. All at once. Cold and certain, like a nail driven into a board.

The life where Father's seal on me failed instead of Antho's. Where I Kindled first. Where it was me in the cave for eight years. Me on the woodpile. Me with the voice.

And Antho at the forge.

He looked at the lined smith at the anvil. And saw it wasn't Brannoc's shape after all. It was taller. Thinner. With long black hair tied back and a beard grown wild and long, long hands.

Antho. At the anvil. Hammering. Humming a hymn off-key. Brannoc's son. The smith. The one who'd stayed.

And Lex at the bellows with black eyes and the hunger in his mouth.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW HOW long he stood there.

He knew Wren's hand closed on his arm. Hard. He knew she said his name. Three times. He knew Tilda was standing beside him, very white, staring at the lined boy at the bellows with the Murmur coming out of his mouth, and that she knew who it was, because everyone knew who it was. Everyone in Ashbourne had heard the story.

He knew that the lined boy was coming toward him.

Slowly. Leaving the bellows. Walking across the little forge with his black loop-eyes fixed on Lex's face and his hands out. Reaching. The way the lined wolf had reached. For a shape. For lines. For the boy Lex had been, that it didn't have.

...hungry...little brother...

And then, under the grinding whisper, so faint he almost didn't hear it, something else.

Small. Young. Frightened. Not grinding at all.

...sorry...

...didn't mean...

...only learned how to talk from him...it's the only voice it knows...

...sorry...

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT DOWN ON one knee.

On the stone floor of a forge that didn't exist. In front of a boy made of lines who had his face and his brother's madness. And held out his hands.

Open. Palm up. Empty. The way he'd held them out to Brannoc, at eleven, on the night of the fire, when the big man said *give us your hands, lad, let's see if they're any good for anything*.

"*I know*," said Lex. Quietly. "*I know. It's all right.*"

The lined boy stopped.

"*You learned to talk from him*," said Lex. "*From my brother. Didn't you. When you were—when you were hungry. When you were the other thing. You talked through him. It was the only voice you ever had.*"

The lined boy didn't move. His loop-eyes were black and wide.

"*You don't have to use it anymore*," said Lex. "*You can find your own.*"

He didn't give it iron. Or stone. Or fire. He didn't know what to give it. He didn't know what it wanted to be.

So he gave it the only thing he could think of.

Room.

He opened his hands a little wider. And moved back. One step. On his knees on the stone. Away. Leaving a space. In front of him, between them, on the forge floor, where the lined boy could stand. Or not. Where it could be whatever it wanted. Where nobody was pushing.

Make room, it had said.

So he did.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LINED BOY STOOD in the space for a long time.

Then the lines went soft. All of them. The black eyes. The hunched shoulders. The grinding mouth. They went soft and faint and loose, the way charcoal goes when you blow on it. And the boy came apart. Gently. Into the dim air. Like smoke going up a chimney.

And the lined smith at the anvil came apart too. And the forge. The bench and the tongs and the quench-barrel and the cat. Into lines. Into smoke. Into nothing.

And where the little forge had been, there was a floor of black glass. And a room. Round. Small. Bare.

And in the middle of the room, on the floor, a pebble.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS BLACK.

Not shiny. Not dull. Just black. The way the round dark on the green had been black. A smooth flat river-pebble, the size of a hen's egg, lying on the glass floor in the middle of the empty room.

It was the only thing there.

```
▓▓▓ DELVE — GUARDIAN ▓▓▓
"The voice it borrowed."
Status: RELEASED
▓▓▓ DELVE — CORE ▓▓▓
Status: EXPOSED
Options:
  CLAIM (core remains whole)
  SHATTER (core destroyed; reward ×5)
```

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX READ IT. TWICE.

Shatter. Reward times five.

He looked at the pebble.

[Lex,] said Ember. Carefully. *[That's a great deal of experience. At your level. Times five. That's—]*

I know what it is.

He crouched over the pebble. Close. He held his hand out over it, palm down, the way he'd held it over the round dark on the green.

Warm.

Not hot. Warm. Like a stone that's been lying all day in the sun. Like a hand that's just let go of yours.

And humming.

Very faint. So faint he had to hold his breath to hear it. A tune. Flat on the high note.

Little light, little light, burning low.

He didn't shatter it.

He picked it up. In his palm. Very gently. The way he'd picked up the black iron ring when it came out of the quench, still warm, and held it, and thought *that's her ring*.

The pebble sat in his palm. Warm. Humming.

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CORE CLAIMED.
+38,000 XP
Level 90 → 91
"It's all right. It's still here.
 It's just somewhere else now."
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◆ ◆ ◆

THE DELVE CLOSED.

He felt it go. The whole thing. The round room and the forge-that-wasn't and the corridor of doors and all the small finished things sitting patiently on the black glass floor. Folding up. Softly. Behind them and under them and around them. The way a flower closes at dusk.

And then the soft cool pressure all over him at once, and the world turning over, gently, like a page.

And he was standing on the green.

In Ashbourne. In the thin spring afternoon. Beside the Stone. With Wren beside him, and Tilda, and Pell. And the whole village in a great ring round the edge of the green, staring.

The round dark was gone. There was grass where it had been. Ordinary grass. With a few early daisies.

And sitting in the grass, in a ring, quietly, where the hole had been: a small iron wolf. A small stone man. A dog made of fire, flickering, curled up like a hearth-cat.

The whole village stared at them.

The dog made of fire yawned. Stretched. Got up. Trotted across the green, past the staring crowd, straight to Tilda Crane, and sat down at her feet. And looked up at her.

Tilda burst into tears.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. As the village broke over them like a wave, shouting, crying, asking, and Brannoc came across the green at a lumbering run with Hedda behind him. *[Lex. The guardian. The voice it borrowed.]*

I know.

[That was—]

I know what it was.

He was holding the pebble in his fist. Warm. Humming.

[That was the Murmur,] said Ember. *[Antho's Murmur. The voice in the cave. The voice that broke him.]*

Yes.

[But it wasn't—]

No, thought Lex. *It wasn't hungry. Not underneath. Underneath it was something else. Something small. Saying sorry. Saying it only learned to talk from him.*

He looked north. Toward the Greyspine. Toward the white teeth of the mountains, far off, over the roofs of Ashbourne, catching the last of the afternoon sun.

Toward the Hollowmaw.

[Lex?]

I need to see Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T HAVE TO go.

Antho came to him.

That night. Late. When the Forge was quiet and the students were in bed and Lex was sitting by the great hearth in the long hall with Wren asleep on the bench beside him under a blanket and the black pebble on the anvil in front of him, humming.

He heard the wings first. Great slow wings. Beating down out of the night over the roofs of Ashbourne. Then the thud of something very large landing in the forge yard, and the woodpile going over, and Quill the raven shrieking furiously from the chimney-top.

Then the door opened.

His brother stood in it. In his black coat. Wind-blown. White-faced. With the Lantern in one hand and frost in his beard and his clear grey eyes very wide and very dark.

He didn't say hello. He didn't take off his coat.

He looked across the long hall at the anvil. At the black pebble lying on it in the firelight. Humming.

And something went out of his face. Some last held thing. The way the air goes out of a bellows.

"*You heard it*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Didn't you. In there.*"

"*It said make room*."

His brother closed his eyes.

"*It talked to me*," said Lex. "*Antho. In the Delve. With the Murmur's voice. Your voice. It said it was sorry. It said it only learned to talk from you.*" He stood up. "*Antho, what is it?*"

Antho Vey stood in the doorway of the Ashbourne Forge with the Lantern in his hand and the night at his back. And didn't answer for a long time.

Then he opened his eyes.

"*I know*," he said. "*I know it did.*"

He came in. Slowly. And shut the door behind him. And leaned against it.

"*I've been hearing it for a month*," said his brother.

CHAPTER 4

The Voice Comes Back

THE FIRST TIME, ANTHO had thought he was going mad again.

He'd been expecting it, in a way. For five years. Ever since the night in Malachi's valley when his Clarity went up past ninety for the first time and stayed there, and he lay on his back by the eternal fire and looked at the stars and thought, very clearly, in his own voice, *this won't last*.

It had lasted.

Through the war, and the Key, and the long night under the lid. Through the Highcrest singing, when the Murmur finally went out of him for good, like a tooth pulled, and his Clarity touched a hundred and didn't move. Through the Heart. Through the doorway at the bottom of the world, where he'd stood with his back to the hunger and shut it out with his own body and the net had named him *Threshold Warden*.

A year and a half of a hundred. Of quiet. Of his own head, with nobody else in it.

He'd started to believe it.

And then, a week before the wedding, at midnight, standing in front of the black door at the bottom of the Hollowmaw with his father filling the lamps, he'd heard a whisper.

In the old place. In the back of his skull, on the left side, where the Murmur used to live. Where it had grated and ground and muttered for eight years like a millstone turning on nothing.

...lamp...?

That was all. One word. Soft as a moth's wing.

He'd stood very still in front of the door. With his hands at his sides. With his father beside him, saying *good evening* to the clay lamp the way he did every night. And he'd felt the bottom fall out of the world.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I thought it was over*," said Antho.

He was sitting on the bench by the great hearth in the long hall of the Ashbourne Forge. In his black coat, with frost melting out of his beard. His brother sat on the anvil block across from him. Wren was awake now, wrapped in her blanket, cross-legged on the other end of the bench, with her green eyes very sharp.

The black pebble sat on the anvil. Between them. Humming.

"*I checked my status*," said Antho. "*Right there. In front of the door. I thought, that's it, then. It's back. The Clarity's gone. A hundred to nothing in a breath. I thought I'd look down and see a number like six.*" He looked at his hands. "*It said a hundred.*"

"*So it wasn't the Murmur*," said Wren.

"*It was the Murmur's voice*." Antho was quiet. "*I'd know it anywhere. I lived with it for eight years. I know every crack in it. Every place it catches.*" He shook his head. "*But it wasn't* in *me. The Murmur came through a crack. A door in me. Malachi said so. Father's broken seal, and the hunger leaking through.*" He touched his chest. "*There's no door in me now. I shut it. At the Highcrest singing. And I gave the last of it away at the Heart.*"

"*Then where's it coming from*?" said Lex.

Antho looked at him.

"*From the other side*," he said. "*From the door. The real one. The black one.*" He turned the Lantern in his hands. "*I'm the Threshold Warden, Lex. The net made me the thing that stands between. I'm tied to that door the way you're tied to a fire. I feel it. Everything that comes near it. Everything that leans on it from the other side.*"

He looked at the pebble on the anvil.

"*Something's been leaning on it*," said Antho Vey. "*For a month. And talking. In the only voice it knows.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD THEM THE rest.

He hadn't meant to. He'd meant to tell them a little. Enough. And keep the rest, the way he'd always kept the rest, folded up small inside him where it couldn't frighten anyone.

But Lex was looking at him across the anvil with that face. The one he'd had since he was ten. The one that said *I'm not going anywhere*. And Wren was looking at him with the other face. The one that said *and neither are you*.

So he told them.

How it had come back the next night. And the next. Always at the door. Always at midnight. Always one word, or two. Soft. Frightened. *Lamp. Lamp-lady. Where.*

How on the fourth night it had said *brother*.

"*Brother*," said Lex.

"*It means me.*" Antho's mouth twisted. "*I think. I think it thinks—I don't know what it thinks. It lived in me for eight years. It talked through me. Maybe that's what it thinks a brother is. The one whose mouth you used.*"

How on the sixth night, the night before the wedding, before the message came, it had said a name.

"*Mal*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Over and over. Like a child calling for someone in the dark.* Mal? Mal? *It doesn't understand where he's gone.*"

The long hall was very quiet. Only the fire. And the pebble on the anvil, humming.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why didn't you tell me*?" said Lex.

Antho had known it was coming. He'd known it all the way from the Hollowmaw, on Ashka's back, in the dark, with the wind in his face. He'd been rehearsing an answer.

He didn't use it.

"*Because I was frightened*," he said.

His brother didn't say anything.

"*It was the week of the wedding*," said Antho. "*I was frightened. That it was the old thing back. That I was going mad again, Lex. Properly. That I'd stand up in front of that door with Seraphine and open my mouth and the wrong voice would come out.*" He swallowed. "*I was the mad one for eight*

years. The warlock in the cave. The one who killed his mother. I didn't want to be that at my own wedding. Not for one day."

"Antho—"

"I'm not saying it was right," said his brother. *"I'm saying that's why."* He looked up. *"I'm telling you now. I came here tonight because I felt the Delve open. I felt you go into it. I felt it touch you, the voice. And I thought, he's heard it. He knows. And I got on the dragon."*

Lex was quiet for a long time.

"Who else knows?" he said at last.

"Seraphine."

Lex looked at him.

"She asked," said Antho. *"On the wedding night. After the feast. I was standing at the cave mouth looking at the dark lantern, the Fenmoor one, and she came up behind me and said, how long has it been going on."* Something moved at the corner of his mouth. *"Not what's wrong. How long. She'd known for days. She said I'd been rubbing my temple like I used to. She'd counted."*

"And you told her."

"I promised her," said Antho Vey. *"Three weeks ago. In front of a door. With a ninety-one-year-old Sister of the Lady telling me to hurry up."* He looked at his brother. *"I'm trying, Lex. I'm trying very hard to be the kind of man who doesn't carry things alone. I'm not very good at it yet. I told my wife first. I'm telling you second."*

He shrugged. Thin shoulders under the black coat.

"That's better than eight years," he said. *"Isn't it?"*

Lex looked at him.

Then he got up off the anvil block. And came round. And sat down on the bench next to Antho. Shoulder to shoulder. The way they'd sat on the woodpile behind the cottage at Harrow, a long time ago, when Antho was fifteen and hearing things and Lex was ten and didn't know what else to do.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PICKED UP THE pebble.

He held it out. In his big scarred palm. Black and smooth and the size of a hen's egg, humming very faintly in the firelight.

"*Hold it*," said Lex.

Antho looked at it.

He didn't want to. That was the truth. He'd been listening to the voice for a month, at the door, through the glass, from the far side of the world. He didn't want to hold a piece of it in his hand.

He held out his hand anyway.

Lex put the pebble in it.

It was warm. Lighter than it looked. Smooth as skin. And the moment it touched his palm, the humming stopped.

And the voice came.

Not through the door. Not from the far side of the world. Right there. In the old place in the back of his skull. Clear and close and small, like a child whispering in his ear.

...brother?

Antho's hand closed on it.

...brother...it's you...it's you...

...dark...so dark...where's the lamp...where's Mal...

...moths...

...moths coming...

...frightened...

He sat on the bench in the Ashbourne Forge with the pebble in his fist and his eyes shut and his brother's shoulder against his, and listened to the voice that had broken him for eight years. The voice that had told him to burn things. That had told him his mother was dead and he'd killed her. That had whispered *little brother smells of warm iron* in a cave in the dark, while he held a knife to Lex's throat.

The voice said: *...please...*

...please don't be angry...

...I didn't know...I didn't know it hurt...

...I didn't know what I was...

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED HIS EYES.

His face was wet. He hadn't noticed.

Wren was looking at him. Very still. With her blanket round her shoulders and her green eyes enormous.

"*What did it say*?" said Lex. Quietly.

Antho looked down at the pebble in his hand.

"*It said it was sorry*," he said.

He laughed. It came out wrong. Cracked down the middle like the Ashbourne Stone.

"*Nine years*," said Antho Vey. "*Eight in the cave and one before. It told me to kill people. It told me I'd killed our mother. It made me hold a knife to your throat.*" He looked at the pebble. "*And now it's here, in my hand, the size of an egg, saying it's sorry. Saying it didn't know it hurt. Saying* please don't be angry.*"

He closed his hand.

"*I don't know what to do with that*," he said. "*Lex. I don't know what to do.*"

His brother put his arm round his shoulders.

He didn't say *it's all right*. He didn't say *you don't have to forgive it*. He didn't say anything at all.

He just held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FLEW HOME AT dawn.

Lex wanted to come. Antho said no. Then he said yes. Then he said *not yet—let me talk to Father first, and Seraphine. Come in three days. Bring Wren. Bring the twins if you can find them. Bring that Ivy Moss girl. The one who heard it singing.*

He took the pebble with him.

In his coat. In the inside pocket, over his heart. It hummed the whole way. Over the Vale and the foothills and the long white teeth of the Greyspine, with the sun coming up gold on the snow and Ashka's great blue wings beating slow and steady under him. Humming. Flat on the high note.

[...high up...] it said once. Wondering. *[...so high...is this what the sky is?...]*

Antho didn't answer.

But he didn't take it out of his pocket either.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER WAS AT the cave mouth when he came in.

Sitting on Pim's rock. In the cold. In a grey coat with a blanket over his knees, with a cup of something steaming in both hands. Watching the sky. Waiting.

He'd been waiting all night. Antho could see it. In the set of his shoulders. In the frost on the blanket.

He stood up as Ashka came down onto the slope. Slowly. One hand on the rock.

And Antho, sliding down off the dragon's neck into the snow, looked up at his father and felt something go cold in his chest.

He'd only been gone a day.

A day and a night. That was all.

His father's hair was white at the temples.

Not grey. Not threaded. *White*. Two broad wings of it, swept back over his ears, like snow on a dark roof. And the grey had spread through the rest. All of it. Pepper and salt. The bold question-mark curl at the front was silver now.

And the lines. At the corners of his eyes. Around his mouth. Deeper. And new ones. Across his forehead. Down his cheeks. The skin under his jaw had gone soft.

He looked fifty-five.

He'd looked forty-eight at the wedding. Three weeks ago.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Father*," said Antho.

"*I know*." Arion Vey looked at his son's face. And then, with something that was almost a smile, he touched his own temple. Two fingers. Lightly. "*I saw it this morning. In Odile's mirror*." He was quiet. "*It's going faster*."

"*How much faster*?"

His father didn't answer.

Antho came up the slope. Through the snow. He stopped in front of his father.

"*No more secrets*," said Antho. "*You said. At the door. The night of the message. You woke us up and said* no more.*"

"*I did say that*."

"*How much faster*?"

Arion Vey looked at his elder son for a long moment. With his lined face and his white temples and his grey eyes, the same grey as Antho's, very steady.

"*I'm not sure yet*," he said. "*That's the truth. I'm keeping a record. Hairs. Lines. The stiffness in my hands.*" He held one up. The knuckles were swollen. Faintly. "*I'll know more in a week or two. When I've got enough numbers.*"

He smiled. Properly, this time.

"*You'd be proud of me*," said Arion. "*I've been counting*."

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS IN THE library.

She was always in the library. It had been Antho's library first, the summer after Duskhold. A cave off the main passage, dry and high, where he'd carried the Listeners' Codex and the bronze foils and the Founders' records and everything else the Order had tried to burn, and stacked them on rough shelves and started to read. Now it was three caves. Knocked through. With proper shelves, oak, that Lex had made, and lamps on every one, and a long table down the middle covered in paper.

She was at the table when he came in. With her spectacles pushed up on her forehead and ink on her nose and her dark hair coming down out of the knot she'd put it in at dawn. Surrounded by books. Open. Stacked. Bristling with paper markers.

She looked up.

She didn't say *how was it*. She didn't say *what happened*. She looked at his face, the way she always did, as if it were a page in an old hand that she was learning to read.

"*It talked to him*," she said. "*Didn't it. To Lex.*"

"*Yes*."

"*And he's not angry with you*."

"*No*." Antho came and sat down on the bench beside her. Heavily. "*He's not angry. He sat next to me. And put his arm round me. And didn't say anything.*"

Seraphine looked at him.

"*That's worse*," she said.

"*That's much worse*," Antho agreed.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK THE PEBBLE out of his coat and put it on the table.

Between a stack of Founders' records and a cup of cold tea. In the lamplight.

Seraphine looked at it for a long time.

Then she pulled her spectacles down off her forehead. And leaned close. Very close. Her nose almost touching it. The way she looked at a page of Wellscript she couldn't read yet.

"*It's humming*," she said.

"*Yes*."

"*The Lantern Song*." She tilted her head. "*Flat. On the high note.*"

"*Yes*."

She didn't touch it. She looked at it. And Antho watched her look at it, and watched the line come between her eyebrows, the one that came when something in a book didn't add up.

"*Antho*," she said slowly. "*What's it humming with?*"

"*What*?"

"*Sound needs something to move*." She didn't look up. "*Air. Water. A string. A bell. Something has to shake.*" She leaned closer. "*It's a stone. It's not shaking. I'd see it. I can see the grain in it, it's perfectly still.*" Her voice went very quiet. "*So what's making the sound?*"

He looked at the pebble.

He didn't know.

Seraphine sat back. And took off her spectacles. And rubbed her eyes with ink-stained fingers.

"*I can't hear it*," she said. "*Not properly. Not the way you can. I hear the tune. Faintly. The way you'd hear someone singing in another room.*" She put her spectacles back on. "*But I can hear something else.*"

"*What*?"

Seraphine Ilvane, who had never heard a Well in her life, who had sat by Malachi's eternal fire in the Pale Wastes for nineteen days and copied down every word he said and never once heard the fire answer, looked at the black pebble on the table.

"*The gap*," she said. "*Around it. The—space. Where the sound isn't.*" She shook her head. "*I don't know how to say it. It's like reading. When you read, you don't see the letters. You see the words. And the words are made of the spaces between the letters as much as the letters.*" She frowned. "*That's what I can hear. Not the song. The space the song is sitting in.*"

Antho stared at her.

"*It's probably nothing*," said Seraphine. Hastily. Going pink. "*I haven't slept. I've been reading about Wells all night. It's probably—*"

"*It's not nothing*," said Antho.

He didn't know how he knew. He just did. The way you know, sometimes, in the dark, that there's someone else in the room.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS CAME THAT night.

He'd been half-expecting them. Since the wedding. Since the first one drifted down the passage brushing the lanterns with its wings. They'd come back twice since. Single ones. Late. Drifting in out of the dark at the cave mouth, grey-gold, the size of a hand, with painted eyes on their wings. Brushing a lantern. Two. Then gone.

Each time, a lantern went dark.

Not out. *Dark*. The way the Fenmoor one had been. The oil still in it. The wick still trimmed. The light simply lifted out of it, neatly, like a pearl from an oyster. And a fine soft dust on the glass, grey-gold, that wouldn't wipe off. It smeared. It stuck. Odile had scrubbed one pane for an hour with soap and sand and it had still been there, faint, like a fingerprint.

The Fenmoor lantern had taken three days to relight. Antho had sat with it. Every evening. Trying. Striking flint over the wick. Holding a taper to it. The wick wouldn't catch. It would smoke, and sputter, and go out, as if the lamp had forgotten how to burn.

On the third evening, Pim had sat down beside him. And watched. And then, very quietly, without asking, he'd reached out and cupped his small thin hands round the lantern. Not touching it. Just round it. Making a space.

And the wick had caught.

Antho hadn't said anything. Neither had Pim. But he'd thought about it every night since.

◆ ◆ ◆

THIS TIME THERE WERE more than two.

Odile saw them first. She was on watch at the cave mouth, as she was every third night, wrapped in a blanket on the rock with a lamp beside her and a book of Founders' poems she pretended not to like. She was nineteen now. Tall and dark and solemn, with a scholar's stoop and a Shade-Listener's stillness. The first of Antho's students. The first one who'd climbed the mountain to the mad warlock's cave and knocked.

She came down the passage at a run. Not shouting. Odile never shouted. She came to the door of the library and stood in it, white, with her book still in her hand.

"*Master Antho*," she said. "*The sky.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT UP.

He stood at the mouth of the Hollowmaw, in the snow, under the stars, with Seraphine beside him and Odile behind, and looked out over the slope and the valley and the long white ridges of the Greyspine going away to the west.

There was a cloud.

Low. Coming over the western ridge. Not a storm-cloud. Not snow. It moved wrong. Too slow and too soft and too low, drifting down the far slope toward the valley like smoke from a chimney when the wind drops.

And it glittered.

Faintly. Grey-gold. In the starlight. Like frost on a window. Like dust in a sunbeam.

"*Moths*," said Seraphine. Very quietly.

Hundreds of them. Thousands. Coming down out of the west. Drifting. Not hurrying. Spreading as they came, like ink in water. Down the far slope. Across the valley. Up the near slope. Toward the cave mouth.

Toward the light.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...moths...] said the pebble in his pocket. In the back of his skull. Small and high and terrified. *[...moths moths moths...they're coming...they're HUNGRY...brother brother brother...]*

"*Odile*," said Antho. "*Wake the students. All of them. Every one who can hold a Shade.*" He didn't look round. "*Seraphine. Find Father. Then go down to the door and stay there.*"

"*I'm not going to—*"

"*The lamps*," said Antho. "*Mam's lamp. The three in the niche. If they get to the door—*"

Seraphine went.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED THE LANTERN.

The shutter slid back. And the Keeper's Lantern, Lex's lantern, Well-forged, Legendary, with twelve Hush-runes round its glass and the word *SHELTER* across its base, blazed up in his hand.

Not bright. Not like fire. A deep, soft, steady gold that spread out from him across the snow like the light from an open door on a winter night. And with it, the hush. The quiet that lived in the Lantern. The silence it made, the silence that kept voices out.

The first of the moths reached the edge of the light.

And *stopped*.

Hung there. In the air. At the very edge of the gold. Wings beating. A grey-gold moth the size of his hand, with a painted eye on each wing, hanging in the night two yards from the Lantern as if it had hit glass.

Then another. Then ten. Then a hundred. A wall of them. Building up along the edge of the Lantern's light like snow against a door. Beating. Fluttering. Glittering. Wanting in.

And where their wings touched the edge of the gold, the gold *thinned*.

Antho felt it. Through the Lantern. Through his hand. A pull. Soft and steady and terrible, like a child sucking the juice out of an orange. They weren't attacking the light. They were *drinking* it. Every wing that brushed the edge of the Lantern's glow came away brighter. And the glow came away dimmer.

"*Master Antho*!"

The students. Coming up the passage. Nine of them. Odile at the front. The Millbridge twins. A boy from the Saltreach named Cass. The others. All of them with their eyes going dark, the way a Shade-Listener's eyes go when they reach into the dark and ask it for help.

And Pim. At the back. Small. In his blue coat with the brass buttons. With his thin face set.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A STRANGE fight.

Antho had been in a lot of fights. He'd fought ice-trolls and hollow-knights and Umbral Wardens. He'd fought his own brother in a cave. He'd fought the hunger at the bottom of the world.

He'd never fought anything that didn't fight back.

The moths didn't attack. They didn't bite. They didn't swarm. They just *came*. Endlessly. Drifting in out of the dark. Toward the light. Toward the Lantern, and the lanterns in the passage behind him, and the lamps on the students' belts. Brushing. Drinking. Moving on.

Shade didn't hurt them. The students wrapped them in darkness and they went still in it, folded, the way a moth goes still in a closed hand. And when the darkness opened, they flew out again, unhurt, glittering, and went straight back to the light.

Gale didn't help. Antho called a wind off the snow, a hard cold west wind that would have knocked a man flat, and the moths rode it. Effortlessly. Up and over and down again, like leaves.

And they kept coming.

Behind him, in the passage, one by one, the lanterns began to go dark.

He felt it. Every one. A thousand small lights. Lit for the lost. Going out. Not out. *Dark*. Emptied. Smeared with dust.

One thousand one hundred and ten, he counted. Without meaning to. *One thousand one hundred and nine. One thousand one hundred and—*

◆ ◆ ◆

ODILE SCREAMED.

She never screamed. Antho turned.

She was on her knees in the snow at the cave mouth. Holding her right hand in her left. Staring at it.

There was dust on it. Grey-gold. All over the back of her hand and her fingers, where a moth had settled. Just for a moment. And flown off again. And left its mark.

"*Odile—*"

"*It's cold*," said Odile Marsh. Her voice was strange. Flat. Faraway. "*Master Antho. It's—it went in. It went* in.*" She looked up at him. And her dark eyes were—

Dim.

Not dark. Odile's eyes went dark when she Listened. Deep and black and full of stars. This was different. This was *dim*. Like a window when someone inside has turned down the lamp. Like the light had gone out of them, and left only the glass.

"*It took something*," said Odile. Quietly. Wonderingly. "*I don't know what. I don't—it's gone. I can't remember what it felt like. It was warm. It was mine.*" She looked down at her dusty hand. "*It doesn't matter. Does it. It doesn't seem to matter. Nothing seems to—*"

She stopped talking.

She sat back on her heels in the snow, very slowly, with her hands in her lap. And looked out at the moths. Drifting. Glittering. And her dim eyes followed them. Followed the light on their wings. The way a cat's eyes follow a string.

And she started to get up.

To go *toward* them.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO CAUGHT HER ARM.

She didn't fight him. She didn't pull. She just kept leaning. Toward the moths. Toward the glitter. Gently. Like a plant leaning toward a window.

"*Odile*!"

She didn't hear him.

He didn't know what to do. He'd never seen anything like it. He held her arm and felt the cold in her, the empty quiet cold, like the Unfinished in Lex's Delve, and the moths were thick now all round the cave mouth, a blizzard of grey-gold, and the Lantern was flickering in his other hand, thinning, and behind him in the passage the lanterns were going dark and dark and dark—

And Pim walked past him.

Out of the light. Into the moths. Small. Thin. In his blue coat.

And stopped. And stood there.

And was *silent*.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HAD NEVER BEEN able to explain Pim's silence.

He'd tried. To Seraphine. To Lex. To himself, late at night, in the cold-room, with the bats. It wasn't just not talking. Lots of people didn't talk. It wasn't Shade, though Pim Listened to Shade, and was good at it, better than anyone Antho had ever taught. It was something else. Underneath. Something Pim had carried up the mountain with him at nine years old, from Kessick and the man who'd tried to beat the voices out of him. A place in him where nothing was. Where nothing had been allowed to be. Where he'd gone, for years, to hide.

It was the silence that had hidden Antho's thread from the Key, on the night of the Blade. It was the silence that had made the Cantor go out at the Highcrest singing, like a candle in a draft.

Pim stood in the middle of the moths. And let it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOTHING HAPPENED. THAT WAS what it looked like. A small boy standing in the snow.

But the moths *moved*.

All of them. All at once. A great soft lurch through the whole glittering cloud, the way a flock of starlings turns in the sky. Away. Away from Pim. Out. A space opened round him. A ring. Ten feet across. Empty. Moths on every side of it, beating, glittering, and none of them coming in.

As if he were a hole in the light. A place with nothing to drink.

Pim walked forward.

Slowly. Step by step. Through the snow. And the empty ring went with him. And the moths drew back in front of him like water in front of a ship's bow.

He walked to Odile. Who was still leaning toward the glitter, in Antho's grip, with her dim eyes. And he stood in front of her. And the ring of nothing closed round her too.

And Pim reached out. And cupped his small thin hands round her dusty one. Not touching it. Just round it.

Making a space.

Odile blinked.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS WENT AT dawn.

Not driven off. Not beaten. They just went. When the sky in the east went grey over the Greyspine, and the first thin light came up over the snow, the whole cloud of them lifted off the slope at once, like smoke when a door opens, and drifted away west. Over the ridge. Glittering. Gone.

Antho stood in the cave mouth with the Lantern in his hand, flickering, and watched them go.

Behind him, in the passage, he counted the dark lanterns.

Two hundred and six.

◆ ◆ ◆

ODILE WAS BY THE fire in the kitchen, wrapped in three blankets, with a cup of tea she wasn't drinking. Pim sat beside her. Not touching her. Just there.

Her eyes were better. Not right. But better. There was light in them again. Faint. Like a lamp turned very low.

"*It's coming back*," she told Antho. When he crouched down in front of her. "*Slowly. It's like—it's like when your hand goes to sleep. And the feeling comes back. And it hurts.*" She looked at the tea. "*I remember what it was now. What it took.*"

"*What*?"

Odile was quiet for a long time.

"*The first time I came up the mountain*," she said. "*When I was fifteen. And I knocked on the door of the cave. And you opened it.*" She looked at him with her half-lit eyes. "*And you looked so frightened. More frightened than me. And you said, oh. Are you here to learn? And I said yes. And you said—*" She stopped. "*You said, thank goodness. I've no idea what I'm doing.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

"*That*," said Odile Marsh. "*That's what it took. How that felt. When you said that.*" She swallowed. "*It's the warmest thing I have. And it took it. And for a while I didn't care.*"

She looked at Pim. Sitting beside her. Small and solemn.

"*He gave it back*," she said. "*I don't know how. He just—made room for it. To come back.*"

Pim looked at his knees.

Antho put his hand on the boy's thin shoulder. And held it there.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT DOWN TO the door at midnight.

Alone. He didn't wake his father. Arion had sat up all night by the passage with a tinderbox, relighting what he could, which was nothing. He was asleep now. In the chair in the library. With his white head on his chest.

Antho went down the long passage past two hundred and six dark lanterns. Past nine hundred and seven lit ones. Into the bell-shaped cavern. To the black door.

The three lamps were burning in the niche.

All three. The clay one and the iron one and the *ARDENT* one. Straight up. Small and gold and steady. Untouched.

Seraphine had stood in front of them all night. With her back to the niche and her arms spread and a lamp of her own in each hand, held out, so that if anything came down the passage it would go to hers first. She hadn't needed to. Nothing had come this far. But she'd stood there. All night. In her nightgown and her spectacles.

He loved her so much it frightened him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT HIS HAND on the black glass.

Cold. Smooth. Sealed. On the other side, the deep. The soft endless dark under the world. Shade's dark, again. Not the hunger. Never the hunger again.

He listened.

He was the Threshold Warden. He was the thing that stood between. He could feel everything that leaned on this door from the far side, the way you feel someone sit down on the other end of a bench.

Something was leaning on it now.

Enormous. Soft. Far down. Pressed close against the glass from the other side, the way a frightened child presses against a door, with its whole body. Trembling.

[...brother...]

The pebble in his coat. And the thing behind the door. The same voice. The same small frightened whisper. One close and one far. Like an echo.

[...brother...moths...the moths came...]

I know, thought Antho. *I know they did.*

[...were they...did they hurt...]

They took some light, thought Antho. *Two hundred and six lanterns. And something of Odile's. It's all right. We're all right.*

[...they're HUNGRY...] said the voice. And something came with it, through the door, through his palm, through the old place in the back of his skull. Not words. A feeling. A memory. Old. Very old. A great black pool in a hall of glass. And kneeling round it, cupping their hands, drinking, drinking, drinking, faces. Beautiful faces. Lit eyes.

[...they drank me...] said the voice. *[...before...a long time before...they drank and drank and drank until I was...]*

It stopped.

[...until I was the other thing...]

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STOOD VERY STILL.

He didn't understand it. Not yet. But something in him went cold and sharp and clear, the way it did when he was reading an old text and a word he'd been staring at for hours suddenly turned over and showed him its other side.

They drank me.

Until I was the other thing.

He opened his mouth.

And a different voice came through the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THE SMALL ONE. Not the frightened one.

A woman's voice. Low. Warm. A little rough, the way a voice is when it hasn't been used for a while, or has been used too much, singing in the dark to someone who couldn't sleep.

Close.

Closer than she'd ever been. Closer than the night of the Blade, when she spoke to Elric through the door. Closer than the Heart. As if she were standing on the other side of the glass, right there, with her hand flat against it, where his was.

"*Antho*," said his mother. "*Love.*"

He couldn't breathe.

"*Don't be afraid of it*," said Seren Vey. Gently. Through the door. Through the dark. Through the long long road home. "*It's only little. It's only very young.*"

The glass under his hand was warm.

"*It's frightened of the moths*," said his mother. "*It's been frightened of them for nine hundred years.*"

A pause. And then, very quietly, in a voice that had gone hard and cold and certain in a way he had never once heard it, not in all the memories of his childhood, not in the Threshold or the Heart—

"*And so should you be, my darling*," said Seren Harrow. "*Don't let them in. Whatever they say. Whoever comes. Don't ever let a moth in.*"

CHAPTER 5

The Seventh Circle

IVY MOSS HAD NEVER seen a dragon.

She'd never seen a lot of things. She'd told Lex so, in a small fierce voice, on the morning they left Ashbourne, standing on the green beside her mother with her crutch under one arm and a bundle in the other. She'd never been further than Millbridge. She'd never seen the sea. She'd never seen a mountain up close, only the Greyspine, far off, white on the edge of the sky. She'd never slept anywhere but her own bed.

"*I've never done anything*," said Ivy Moss. "*I've just watched.*"

Her mother had looked at Lex over the girl's head. A thin tired woman named Bet, a weaver, widowed young, who'd carried her daughter on her back for the first six years of her life because the twisted foot wouldn't bear weight.

She heard it singing, Bet Moss had said to him the night before. Quietly. In the doorway of their cottage. *Under the Stone. She's always heard things. In the ground. In the walls. She used to sit by the well for hours and say it was talking.* She'd twisted her hands in her apron. *The Wardens said it was a fever. The old Sister said it was the Lady. I didn't know what to say.*

It wasn't a fever, Lex had said.

I know. Bet Moss had looked at him with her tired eyes. *Take her. Take her up the mountain to your brother. He's the one who listens, isn't he? Everyone says.* Her voice had cracked. *She's never been anywhere. Take her somewhere.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SO IVY MOSS RODE up the Greyspine on the back of a storm-drake the size of a house.

Ashka had come down for them at dawn, onto the Ashbourne green, scattering geese. She'd landed beside the Stone in a great rush of wind and blue wings, and folded them, and lowered her long neck, and looked at Ivy Moss with one enormous golden eye.

Ivy Moss had looked back.

She hadn't screamed. She hadn't run. She'd stood on the green with her crutch and her bundle and looked up into the dragon's eye, with her small pale face very still. Listening.

[...little...] Ashka had said. In images, the way she did. Lex felt it through the Bloodbond, faint, the way he always did when the dragon spoke near him. A picture. A small thin bird with a crooked wing, sitting on a branch in the rain. *[...little broken-wing...]*

"*She's like me*," said Ivy Moss.

She'd said it out loud. To no one. Looking at the faded silver scar on Ashka's left wing, where Warden hunters had torn it, ten years ago, when she was cat-sized and Antho found her bleeding in the snow.

Ashka had lowered her great head further. All the way down. Until her chin was on the grass and her golden eye was level with the girl's face.

And Ivy Moss had put out her hand. And laid it on the dragon's nose.

Lex had never seen Ashka do that. Not for anyone. Not for him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She's going to want to stay*," said Wren. Behind him, on the dragon's back, with her arms round his waist and her chin on his shoulder. Shouting over the wind. "*You know that. She's going to get to the top of this mountain and see the lanterns and the bats and the library and she's never going to want to go home.*"

"*Her mother knows*."

"*Does Antho know*?"

Lex thought about it.

"*He will*," he said.

Wren laughed into his ear. Then stopped. And went quiet. And he felt her arms tighten round him, and her forehead press against his back.

"*Wren*?"

"*Fine*." Her voice was muffled. "*Just the height. Just the wind. I'm fine.*"

He frowned.

Wren Ashdown had stepped off the roof of the Spire into the wind at eight hundred feet. She'd ridden the eye of a storm above the Teeth. She'd flown on her own breath through a Wellworld of Gale with lightning going off around her like fireworks.

She'd never once, in five years, said *just the height*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LANTERN KEEP WAS dark.

Not all of it. Most of it. But Lex felt it the moment he walked in through the cave mouth. Like walking into a room where someone has blown out half the candles.

He'd counted on the way down, without meaning to. A habit he'd caught from his brother. The lanterns in their niches and on their brackets, one after another, down the long passage. Gold. Gold. Gold.

Dark.

Dark. Dark. Gold. Dark.

Two hundred and six of them. Antho had told him the number in the letter, the one Quill brought to Ashbourne the morning after the moths. He hadn't understood it. Not properly. Not until he saw it.

Every dark one had dust on its glass. Grey-gold. Fine as flour. Smeared, where someone had tried to wipe it. Faint fingerprints of it, on the brass and the tin and the iron. As if something had come down the passage in the night and touched every one. Lightly. Lovingly. The way you'd touch the face of someone sleeping.

And taken the light away.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It won't come off*," said Odile.

She was standing beside him at one of the dark ones. A tall brass lantern from the Saltreach, with green glass. She had a cloth in her hand. She'd been scrubbing.

She looked better than Antho's letter had said. Thinner. Tired. But her eyes were dark and clear when she turned them on him. Mostly clear. There was something behind them still. A dimness. Like a window that's been cleaned but still has a smear in one corner.

"*We've tried soap*," said Odile. "*Sand. Vinegar. Teo's sea-water; he left a barrel. Hedda's purple thing, from the wedding. Master Arion said it might be acidic.*" She looked at the cloth. "*It wasn't.*"

"*What was it*?"

"*Nobody knows*." Odile scrubbed. "*Pim ate some. On a dare. Cass dared him. He said it tasted of plums.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER WAS IN the library.

He was sitting at the long table with Seraphine. Surrounded by books. Lex stopped in the doorway and looked at him, and felt something in his chest go tight and cold and quiet.

Three days.

He'd seen his father three days ago, at the wedding. In his grey coat. Playing the bone flute badly. With twenty grey hairs.

Arion Vey looked up from the table. And smiled. And his face was the face of a man of fifty-eight. White at the temples. Grey everywhere else. Lines across his forehead like the grain in old oak. And his hands, on the table, holding a page, had gone thin. Brown spots on the backs of them. Knuckles swollen.

"*Lex*," said his father. "*Wren.*" He started to get up. Slowly. One hand on the table.

"*Don't*," said Lex. "*Don't get up.*"

"*I can get up*," said Arion. Mildly. And got up. And came round the table. And took his son by both shoulders, the way Brannoc did, and looked at him.

"*It's all right*," said Arion Vey. Quietly. "*I promise you. It's all right.*"

"*You keep saying that*."

"*Because it keeps being true*." His father's grey eyes were very steady. "*I've lived two hundred and thirty-three years, Lex. I've had a long time to think about what I'd do if I ever got the chance to get old. I've had a long time to*

want it." He let go of Lex's shoulders. And touched his own white temple. Two fingers. "*I'll tell you all about it. I'll tell you everything. When I've got the numbers. I promise.*"

He looked past Lex. At the doorway. At Ivy Moss, standing in it with her crutch, staring at the shelves of books that went up into the dark of the cave roof like the walls of a canyon.

And his lined face changed. Softened.

"*Hello*," said Arion Vey. "*You must be the one who heard it singing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE HAD A BOOK open on the table.

Not a book. A box. Wooden. Old. Plain. The kind of box you'd keep tea in, or letters. With a goat-hair rope round it and a smell of woodsmoke and salt that went straight into Lex like a knife, because it was the smell of a hut by a still pool in the Pale Wastes. The smell of an eternal fire.

"*Malachi's*," said Seraphine.

She didn't need to say it.

"*Correspondence brought it*," she said. "*Last spring. After the burial. You remember. We left everything in the hut. His bowl and his blanket and his straw hat. We didn't think it was ours to take.*" She touched the goat-hair rope. "*And then three weeks later Correspondence turned up at the cave mouth with this box tied to his back. On his own. He'd walked from the Wastes. Nine hundred miles.*"

"*He'd eaten half the rope*," said Antho. From the other end of the table. Where he sat with his long legs stretched out and his hands folded on his stomach and his eyes half shut. "*And a corner of the lid. And, we think, a letter.*"

"*I put it on a shelf*," said Seraphine. "*I didn't open it. I couldn't. It was his. And he was—*" She stopped. "*I wasn't ready.*"

She looked down at the box.

"*I opened it last night*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WASN'T MUCH INSIDE.

A wooden spoon. Carved. Worn smooth. A child's spoon. A twist of dried herbs, gone to dust. A clay whistle in the shape of a bird, with a crack down its back. A smooth white stone with a hole through it, on a string.

And papers.

A thin bundle. Tied with grass. Old. Not paper. Vellum. Bark. Something that might have been a dried leaf, pressed flat. Covered in writing. Wellscript, mostly. The Founders' glyphs. Faded. Crabbed. In an old man's hand, and then, further down the bundle, in a younger one.

"*His*," said Seraphine. "*All of them. Notes. Letters he never sent. Things he wrote down to remember.*" She touched them. Very lightly. "*Some of them are nine hundred years old. Some are from last year.*"

She drew one out of the bundle. Carefully. With the tips of her ink-stained fingers.

It was a circle.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD SEEN IT before.

Everyone had. It was on the first page of the Listeners' Codex. The grey book from Qel'Varran, that Seraphine had copied by firelight in the Wastes. That three scribes at the Ashbourne Forge copied every day now, over and over, to send to every new forge and every new school in Caldor.

Six circles. Arranged in a ring. Each with a glyph inside it. *Flame. Stone. Tide. Gale. Radiance. Shade.*

And in the center of the ring, a seventh circle.

Empty.

Lex had asked about it once. Five years ago. In the Wastes. Sitting by the eternal fire with Malachi, with his hands blistered from talking to flame. *What's the one in the middle*? he'd said. *The empty one.*

And Malachi had looked at him with his shifting eyes. For a long moment. And then laughed. And said *that's where you sit, smith. In the middle. Listening.*

Lex had thought it was a joke.

He'd thought everything Malachi said was a joke. Most of it was.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CIRCLE ON THE vellum was the same. Six in a ring. One in the center.

But the one in the center wasn't empty.

It was black.

Filled in. Solid. With ink so old it had gone brown at the edges, laid on thick and heavy, as if whoever drew it had pressed the pen down hard and gone round and round and round. And inside the black, scratched into it with the point of something sharp, so that the pale vellum showed through, a glyph.

Lex couldn't read Wellscript. Not anymore. He'd read it with the Root, once, when the gold text bled through the silver and every Founders' glyph made sense to him like his own name. He'd given that away at the Heart.

He didn't need to read it.

He knew the shape.

He'd seen it on the black door. He'd seen it on a gold anvil at the bottom of the world. He'd seen it carved into the floor of a forge on top of a white mountain, under a little hammer, in the place where a starving thing had been held for nine hundred years.

"*Hollow*," said Seraphine.

◆ ◆ ◆

UNDER THE CIRCLE, IN the corner of the vellum, there was a line of writing.

Not Wellscript. The common tongue. The old form, with the long *s* and the looped *th*. In a small cramped hand. A young hand. Malachi's, Seraphine said. From before. From before the Weaving. When he was the youngest of seven, and Aurelian was the eldest, and the world hadn't been sundered yet.

She read it out loud.

"*Hollow*," read Seraphine Ilvane. "*The seventh. The one in the middle. The one they drank. The one we caged.*"

She stopped.

"*There's more*," she said. "*Further down. Different ink. Later. Shakier.*"

She read it.

"*Forgive us.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

Lex sat at the long table in the library of the Lantern Keep with his hands flat on the wood and looked at the black circle on the vellum. Six around one. Flame and Stone and Tide and Gale and Radiance and Shade. And in the middle, where Malachi had told him he'd sit, listening, a dark thing. Filled in. Scratched.

The one they drank.

The one we caged.

Forgive us.

"*It's a Well*," said Lex. Slowly. "*Isn't it. The hunger. The Unmaker. The thing at the bottom of the world.*" He looked up. "*It was a Well.*"

"*I think so.*" Seraphine's voice was very quiet. "*I've been up all night. Reading everything. Every Founders' record. Every bronze foil from Qel'Varran. Every page of the Codex. Every scrap Malachi ever wrote.*" She took off her spectacles. Her eyes were red. "*It's never said. Not anywhere. Not in plain words. But it's all through it. Like a watermark. Once you know to look for it.*"

She put her spectacles back on. And pulled a stack of her own notes toward her. Covered in her neat cramped hand.

"*There used to be seven*," said Seraphine. "*Seven Wells. Seven Listeners, at the first. Seven children of the House of Vey, in Aurelian's generation, and Malachi the seventh child.*" She turned a page. "*Six of them are the ones we know. Things. Forces. Fire and stone and water and wind and light and dark.*"

"*And the seventh*?" said Wren.

"*The seventh isn't a thing*," said Seraphine. "*It's the space for a thing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TRIED TO EXPLAIN it.

She was very good at explaining things. She'd explained the Tithe to a room full of kings and dukes in a way that made them understand it in their stomachs. She'd explained Wellscript to Lex in a cave by firelight. She'd explained to the Queen of Caldor the difference between justice and cruelty, and the Queen had remembered it.

She was having trouble with this.

"*Every Well is a—a kind of moving*," said Seraphine. "*Fire burns. Stone holds. Water flows. Wind moves. Light shows. Dark rests.*" She made a shape in the air with her hands. A ring. "*And all of them need somewhere to do it. Fire needs something to burn. Water needs a bed to run in. Wind needs room to move.*"

She put her hands together. Cupped. Empty.

"*The Hollow is the room*," said Seraphine. "*The—the empty place. The space before. The quiet at the start of a song. The mould before the metal.*" She looked at Lex. "*You'd know that one better than me.*"

Lex did.

He was thinking of a sand-mould. In the casting-pit at the back of the Ashbourne Forge. Packed tight round a wooden pattern, and the pattern lifted out, carefully, carefully, and the shape it left behind in the sand. The empty shape. Perfect. Waiting.

You can't pour metal into nothing, Brannoc had said. When he was twelve. *You have to make the nothing first. That's the hard part. Anybody can melt iron. Making the right kind of empty—that's the craft.*

"*Every new thing*," said Lex slowly, "*needs a hollow to be made in.*"

Seraphine looked at him.

"*Yes*," she said. Very softly. "*That's it. That's exactly it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*A spring*," said Wren. Suddenly.

They all looked at her.

"*In the forge yard*." Wren was frowning. "*The warm one. That came up out of the cinders overnight.*" She looked at Lex. "*And the well at Coldbrook. And the chimney at the mill that grew another chimney. And Old Mag's apple tree. And the extra mile on the Millbridge road.*" She was sitting up very straight. "*The oddities. Everyone's been laughing about them all winter.*"

"*New things*," said Seraphine. Slowly.

"*New things*," said Wren. "*Coming up. Out of nowhere. Like—like there's room for them now. Like something's made room.*"

"*Old Mag said that*," said Lex. "*She said it feels like the ground's rising. Making room for something underneath.*"

There was a silence.

And then Ivy Moss, who was sitting at the very end of the long table with her crutch across her knees, very small, saying nothing, the way she'd said nothing since she arrived, looked up.

"*It's coming up*," said Ivy Moss.

◆ ◆ ◆

EVERYONE TURNED TO LOOK at her.

She went red. All the way up to her pale hair. She looked down at the table. But she didn't stop.

"*I can hear it*," she said. In a small, stubborn voice. "*Under the ground. I've always been able to. Ever since I was little.*" She swallowed. "*It used to be far away. Very far. Like someone singing at the other end of the Vale, and you can only just hear it on the wind. Mam said I was making it up. The Sister said it was the Lady.*"

She looked at Antho. At the end of the table. With his eyes open now, very grey and very still, fixed on her.

"*It's not far now*," said Ivy Moss. "*It's getting closer. All the time. Every day. It's coming* up." She hesitated. "*And it's big. Bigger than anything. Bigger than the mountain.*"

"*Is it hungry*?" said Antho. Very quietly.

Ivy Moss thought about it. Seriously. The way children think about questions grown-ups ask them as if the answer matters.

"*No*," she said. "*It's—*" She frowned. "*It's like when you're little. And you've been sick. A long time. And you get better. And you get up for the first time and you walk to the window and you look out, and everything's so bright and big.*" She looked at her hands. "*It's like that. It's frightened. And it's never seen anything. And it wants to see everything.*"

She was quiet.

"*And it doesn't know where to go*," said Ivy Moss.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO GOT UP.

He came down the long table. Slowly. And sat down on the bench beside the girl. Not close. A little way off. The way he'd sat beside Pim, at the cave mouth, in the evenings, when Pim didn't talk.

He took the black pebble out of his coat. And put it on the table in front of her.

"*Do you hear this*?" said Antho.

Ivy Moss looked at the pebble.

Then she leaned forward. And put her ear right down on the table. Next to it. With her pale hair spilling over the wood.

She lay there for a long time. With her eyes shut.

"*It's singing*," she said. "*The lantern one. The one Mam sings when she's carding.*" A pause. "*It's flat.*"

"*Yes*," said Antho. "*It learned it from my mother. She sings it flat.*"

Ivy Moss opened her eyes. Still with her ear on the table.

"*It's saying something*," she said. "*Under the singing. Over and over.*" She frowned. "*It's saying* room.*"*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY ARGUED.

Of course they did. They'd been arguing at that table for five years. About Wellscript and Wardens and wars and the best way to boil an egg. It was what they did. It was how they thought.

"*It ate worlds*," said Wren. "*I'm sorry. I know. I know it's sorry. I know it's little and frightened and Ivy can hear it singing.*" She was standing up. Pacing. The way she did when the wind was restless in her. "*But it ate* worlds. *The Forbidden Lands. The drowned city. Everything at the bottom of the deep. Whole worlds full of people, gone. And it ate a quarter of everyone at the Heart, a year and a half ago, and pulled more than half of them through the Tithe, and nearly ate Lex's whole* life.*"* She stopped. "*I was there. I held his hand while it ate his memories. One by one. I watched them go out of his face.*"

The library was quiet.

"*I'm not saying kill it*," said Wren. "*I don't know how you'd kill a Well. I'm saying—*" She looked at Lex. "*I'm saying be careful. That's all. Be*

careful what you open the door to. Just because something's sorry doesn't mean it can't hurt you."

"*It was starving*," said Antho.

"*I know*."

"*For nine hundred years*." His brother's voice was very quiet. "*Somebody drank it dry. Somebody knelt down at a pool and drank and drank until there was nothing left, and what was left was a hole. A hole that wanted to be filled. That's all the hunger ever was.*" He looked at the pebble. "*It didn't choose to be the Unmaker. Someone made it into that.*"

"*That doesn't make it not dangerous*."

"*No*," Antho agreed. "*It doesn't. Neither does Lex. Neither do I. Neither do you, Wren, with the wind in you. Neither does any Well.*" He looked up at her. "*Fire burned the Sunreach once. The Sunwell burned its own people to kill a hungry thing. We still say good morning to it.*"

Wren didn't answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Malachi sat with it*," said Lex.

Everyone looked at him.

He hadn't meant to say it. It had come up out of him. Out of the place where he kept the things that hurt.

"*At the Heart*," said Lex. "*When it unfolded. When Aurelian let go and I struck the seam and it came apart into a—a small lonely dark. That's what it was. That's what it looked like. A small dark thing. Cold. Shaking.*" He swallowed. "*And Malachi cupped it in his hands. And said, I'm not going to cage you. I'm just going to sit with you.*"

He looked at the vellum. At the black circle. At the line in the corner. *Forgive us*.

"*And he went down with it*," said Lex. "*Into the deep. Singing. And he never came up.*"

The library was very quiet.

"*He didn't die to cage it*," said Lex. "*He died to keep it company. So it wouldn't be alone. So it could—*" He stopped. He didn't know the word.

"*Heal*," said Seraphine. Very softly.

"*Heal*." Lex looked round the table. At his brother. At his wife. At his father. At Seraphine and Odile and Ivy Moss. "*He was the seventh child. He sat in the middle and listened. That's what he told me. Five years ago. That's where you sit, smith. In the middle. Listening.*"

He put his hand on the black pebble. It was warm.

"*I'm not going to undo that*," said Lex Vey. "*Whatever it is. Whatever it did. I'm not going to kill the thing he died to keep company. And I'm not going to put it back in a cage.*"

He looked at Wren.

"*But I'll be careful*," he said. "*I promise. I'll be careful.*"

Wren looked at him for a long time.

Then she sat down. Heavily. On the bench. And put her face in her hands. And said, through her fingers, "*Idiot.*"

But she reached out, without looking, and found his hand on the table. And held it.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER HADN'T SAID anything.

He'd sat through the whole argument with his hands folded on the table and his white head bowed. Listening. The way he listened to the Queen's council, Lysandra said. Saying nothing until everyone else had said everything, and then saying the one thing nobody had thought of.

He lifted his head.

"*They*," said Arion Vey.

Everyone looked at him.

"*The one they drank*," said Arion. He reached out and touched the corner of the vellum. With one thin brown-spotted finger. Very gently. "*Not we. They. And then: the one* we *caged.*" He looked up. "*Two different groups of people. The ones who drank. And the ones who caged.*"

Seraphine had gone very still.

"*Malachi was a Listener*," said Arion. "*He was one of the ones who caged. The House of Vey. The Founders. Aurelian and his brothers and sisters, who wove the net.*" He looked at the black circle. "*So who drank?*"

Nobody answered.

"*There's a story*," said Arion. Slowly. "*In the Spire. An old one. Not a record. A story. The kind of thing junior Wardens tell each other at night in the dormitory, to frighten the new ones.*" He was quiet for a moment. Remembering. "*I heard it when I was nineteen. My first year. Nearly two hundred years before you were born.*"

"*What story*?" said Antho.

"*The Nine at the Pool*," said his father.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD IT.

It wasn't much. He said so. He didn't remember it well. He'd been nineteen and frightened and trying very hard not to look frightened in front of the older cadets. It was the kind of story that changed every time someone told it.

Before the net, said Arion. *Before the Sundering. When the sorcerer-kings ruled. Nine of them. Nine crowns. Nine kingdoms. Each one stronger than the last. And they found a pool.*

A black pool. In a hall of glass. And whoever drank from it would never die.

So they drank.

And they drank. And drank. Until the pool was empty. And they lived forever. And the world broke.

And the Founders came, and wove the net, and threw the Nine out of the world. Past the edge. Into the grey. And locked the door behind them.

And they're still there.

"*And then the older cadets would blow out the candle*," said Arion. "*And whisper—*" He stopped.

"*What*?" said Wren.

His father was looking at the window. The narrow slit window high in the library wall, cut through the rock of the mountain, that looked out over the valley. It was dusk. The sky was going grey-blue. The first star was out.

"*They'd whisper*," said Arion Vey, "*if you leave a light on, they'll see it. Past the edge. Through the grey. And they'll come for it. Because that's all they want. That's all they've ever wanted.*"

He was quiet.

"*Never leave a light on*," said his father. "*That was the end of the story. That was how the cadets frightened each other. In a city where every window has a lantern in it for the Lady.*" He shook his head. "*Never leave a light on. Or the Nine will come.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIBRARY WAS VERY quiet.

Lex looked at the window. At the first star. At the dark coming down over the Greyspine.

He thought about a door of black glass. And three lamps in a niche beside it. Burning. Every night. For a year and a half. For someone who hadn't come home.

He thought about two hundred and six lanterns in the passage outside, with dust on their glass.

He thought about a moth. Drifting down the passage on the night of his wedding. From lantern to lantern. Brushing each one with its wing.

Never leave a light on.

Don't ever let a moth in.

"*Mam said that*," said Antho. Very quietly. He was looking at the window too. "*Through the door. Three nights ago. Don't let them in. Whatever they say. Whoever comes.*" He swallowed. "*She sounded—I've never heard her sound like that. Not ever. Not even when she was angry. She sounded like she knew.*"

"*Knew what*?" said Lex.

His brother didn't answer.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RAVEN CAME AN hour later.

Not Quill. A Keeper's raven. Grey-black, with a brass ring on its leg and the Keepers' sigil, a Stone with a hand on it, stamped into the ring. It came in out of the dark through the cave mouth and down the long passage, past the lit lanterns and the dark ones, and landed on the long table in the library in a scatter of feathers and frost, and held out its leg.

It was from Roole.

Antho opened it. Read it. Read it again. And handed it to Lex without a word.

It was short. Roole's letters were always short. He wrote like he talked. Like a man reading out a list of charges.

Sundered Lands outposts. Four of five gone dark. Last report from Greyfall, three nights ago. Lanterns failing. All of them. Dust on the glass.

Survivors from Greyfall came in this morning. Six. Of forty.

They say the moths came out of the west at dusk. Out of the Veil. Thousands.

They say there's a woman walking with them.

Tall. Grey. Beautiful. They say her eyes are lit. Like windows.

They say she smiled at them. And asked, very politely, the way to Highcrest.

Sending Fenn and forty to the Veil's edge. Asking Dame Elowen to go with them.

Asking Wren Ashdown to track.

Come if you can.

— Roole

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX READ IT TWICE.

Then he put it down on the table. On top of Malachi's vellum. On top of the black circle with the glyph scratched into it.

And looked at his wife.

Wren was already standing up.

She had her bow in her hand. He hadn't seen her pick it up. Her face was white. And set. And her green eyes were very bright and very hard, the way they'd been on the roof of the Spire, waiting for him, a month of dawns, not knowing if he was alive.

"*Don't*," said Wren Ashdown. Very quietly. "*Don't you dare.*"

He didn't.

He looked at her for a long moment. At the bow in her hand. At the black iron ring on her finger. At the faint grey under her eyes that hadn't been there a week ago, that he'd noticed on the dragon, and hadn't said anything about.

Just the height, she'd said. *Just the wind.*

"*Be careful*," said Lex.

"*I'm always careful*."

"*You stepped off the Spire*."

"*Carefully*," said Wren. And came round the table. And kissed him. Quick. Hard. The way she had at the edge of the round dark on the Ashbourne green. "*I'll be back. A week. Two. I'll track her and I'll watch her and I'll come back and tell you what she is.*"

She stopped in the doorway.

"*And Hammer*," she said. Without turning round. "*Fix the door.*"

And she was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT AT THE long table for a long time after.

With the raven's letter under his hand. And Malachi's vellum under that. And the black pebble beside it, humming.

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. In his hearth.

Mm.

[I remember the story.] A pause. *[The Nine at the Pool. He told it to me. Arion. When I was him. When he was nineteen and frightened in the dormitory.]* Another pause. Longer. *[I didn't remember it until he said it. It was in a partition. Locked. Since the seal.]*

What else is in it?

[I don't know yet.] The coal in his hearth was very quiet. *[But there's something. Under the story. Something he heard later. Much later. Two hundred years later. From someone who wasn't frightened at all.]*

Who?

Ember didn't answer for a long time.

[Your mother,] it said at last. *[On the steps of the Spire. In the rain. The first night they met.]*

Lex went very still.

[He told her the story,] said Ember. *[As a joke. Because she'd laughed at the lanterns. All the lanterns in all the windows of Highcrest. And he said, never leave a light on, or the Nine will come.]*

And what did she say?

The coal glowed. Very faintly. In the dark of his hearth.

[She didn't laugh,] said Ember. *[That's all I've got. She stopped laughing. And looked at him. And said—*]

It stopped.

[It's locked,] said Ember. *[The rest of it. I can feel it. Like a word on the tip of a tongue.]* A long pause. *[But I think, Lex. I think she said something about moths.]*

CHAPTER 6

The Lady of Moths

WREN ASHDOWN HAD BEEN sick in a ditch three times since Highcrest, and she was beginning to take it personally.

The first time was the morning they rode out. Forty Keepers in grey and Dame Elowen Dunmore in her armor and Keeper-Lieutenant Fenn on a bay mare, going out through the West Gate in the thin spring dawn with a crowd on the walls to see them off. Wren had made it as far as the first milestone. Then the smell of forty horses and the creak of leather and somebody's breakfast sausage had all come together in her stomach at once, and she'd leaned out of the saddle and been sick into the ditch beside the road.

Elowen had looked at her.

"*Bad fish*," Wren had said. "*At the inn.*"

"*We didn't eat at an inn*."

"*Bad fish somewhere*," said Wren.

The second time was on the fourth day, crossing the downs west of the Blightmarch, in a wind. The third was this morning. At the edge of the Sundered Lands. For no reason at all. She'd woken up in her blanket in the frost and sat up and the world had tipped sideways, and she'd crawled out of the tent on her hands and knees and been sick into a patch of dead heather while a crow watched her from a rock with deep interest.

She'd wiped her mouth. And sat back on her heels. And glared at the crow.

"*Don't*," said Wren. "*Don't you start.*"

The crow said nothing. It didn't need to.

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THE SUNDERED LANDS BEGAN where the grass stopped.

There was no sign. No marker. No wall. The downs just *ended*. A long ridge of grey-green turf, running north and south as far as you could see, and on the near side of it, grass. Sheep-cropped. Dotted with gorse. Ordinary.

And on the far side, nothing grew.

Not dead. Not burned. Not Gloam-grey, the way the Blightmarch had been before the brothers closed the breach. Just—*bare*. Hard grey ground, cracked like the bottom of a dried pond, going away west in low broken ridges and long shallow valleys, all the way to the edge of the sky. A few rocks. A few black stumps of things that might once have been trees. A wind that never stopped, cold and thin and smelling of nothing.

And at the edge of the sky, very far off, the Veil.

Wren had seen it once before. Two years ago. On the way to the Umbral Rift, with Lex and Antho and Dorran Vask, on the long cold march to the end of the world. She'd never forgotten it.

A wall of grey. Hanging from nowhere. Falling to nowhere. Stretching north and south along the whole western edge of the world, as far as eyes could follow. Not quite still. Moving, very slightly, the way a curtain moves when there's a window open somewhere behind it.

You couldn't see through it. You couldn't see past it. When you looked at it too long your eyes started to water and slide away, the way they slid off something very bright, though it wasn't bright at all.

It was the end of the world. That was all. The place where the net stopped.

And something had come through it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Greyfall's over that ridge*," said Fenn.

He was a narrow, quiet man with sandy hair going thin on top, in the plain grey coat of the Keepers of the Stones. He'd been a Warden for twelve years and a Keeper for one and a half. He'd stood beside Roole at the Hollowmaw on the night of the Blade, and at the Highcrest singing, and

he'd been the one, Roole said, who'd straightened every leaning Stone in the west with his own hands.

He didn't talk much. When he did, he said exactly what he meant.

"*Six survivors*," he said. "*Of forty. They came in on foot. Walking east. In a line. Not talking.*" He was looking at the ridge. "*They didn't stop walking until somebody stood in front of them. Roole said it was like stopping sleepwalkers.*"

"*What did they say*?" said Elowen.

"*Nothing, at first*." Fenn's mouth was a thin line. "*Then one of them, a girl, a cadet, eighteen, started crying. And couldn't stop. And said the light went out. Over and over. The light went out.*" He was quiet. "*She didn't mean the lanterns.*"

Wren looked at the ridge.

Grey. Bare. Cracked. With the wind coming over it, thin and cold, smelling of nothing at all.

"*I'll go first*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT ON THE wind.

Not high. Low. Skimming. A Mistwalker's step, the way she'd learned it at the Gale Wellworld, in the eye of a storm above the Teeth, with lightning going off around her. Not flying. Walking. On air. Each step a little gust that caught her foot and held it and let it go. Silent. Quick. Close to the ground.

She'd been the best tracker in Thistledown at fourteen. A [Tracker], Common, Level 19, capped at 24, who could follow a hare across bare rock by the way the lichen was bent. She'd been a [Pathfinder] at twenty. Unbound by a smith with gold in his eyes, in a green valley in the Pale Wastes, while he was still learning how.

She was a Mistwalker now. Epic. Level 66.

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WREN ASHDOWN
Class: MISTWALKER (Epic)
Level 66
Gale ............ COMMANDING
Skills: WINDSTEP (Master 4)
  TEMPEST (Expert 9)
  MISTWALK (Expert 6)
  TRACKER'S EYE (Grandmaster 2)
Title: [Wife of a Fool] (new)
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She'd seen the title the morning after the wedding. She'd laughed so hard she'd fallen out of the loft.

She hadn't told Lex. He'd think Ember did it.

Ember probably did it.

◆ ◆ ◆

GREYFALL WAS A FORT.

A small one. A square of grey stone walls with a tower at one corner, built on a low rise at the edge of the bare ground, looking west. The Order had built it two hundred years ago to watch the Veil, back when the Order still thought there was something past the Veil worth watching. The Keepers had taken it over. Forty of them. A garrison. To keep an eye on the old Umbral Rift, ten miles south, where the Lock still sat with the Key of Shadows barred in it.

The gates were open.

Wren stopped on the rise outside and looked at them for a long time.

Then she looked at the ground.

There were tracks. Of course there were tracks. Forty Keepers had lived here for a year and a half. The ground in front of the gate was beaten flat by boots and hooves and cart wheels. She could see the six who'd walked out, three nights ago. Walking east. In a line. Their steps very even and very slow, like people walking in their sleep.

And there were other tracks.

She crouched. Looked closer.

Not tracks. Not footprints. Not anything she'd ever seen.

Dust.

Fine. Soft. Grey-gold. Lying on the hard ground in front of the gate in long drifts and streaks and patches, like the pattern frost makes on a window. Like something had come across the bare ground in the night, not walking, not running, but *drifting*, low, just above the earth, shedding as it came.

Hundreds of somethings.

And in the middle of the drifts, coming straight across the bare ground from the west, from the Veil, to the open gate of Greyfall, one line of it. Narrower than the rest. Neater. Straighter.

The trail of something that didn't drift.

That *walked*.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT IN.

Elowen came behind her, with Oathkeeper drawn and her shield up. Then Fenn. Then the Keepers, in pairs, the way Roole drilled them. Spreading out across the little courtyard. Checking doors.

It was quiet.

Not empty. That was the worst part. Wren had walked into a lot of places after something terrible had happened in them. Villages after the Gloam. Fenmoor, with the Quiet standing in rows. The Highcrest square after the Cantor's singing, with a thousand people standing with their mouths open and nothing coming out.

Greyfall wasn't empty.

There were Keepers in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE SITTING.

In the courtyard. On the walls. In the doorway of the tower. On the steps of the little stone barracks. Thirty-four of them. In their grey coats. Some with their swords still in their hands. Some with lanterns. Sitting very still, where they'd stopped, with their faces turned west.

Toward the Veil.

Watching it.

Their eyes were open. Wren could see them from across the courtyard. Open, and *dim*. Not dark. Not empty. Dim. Like windows in a house

where someone has turned the lamps down very low. There was something behind them. You could see it. Faint. Far back. Like a person standing a long way back from the glass in a dark room. But it wasn't coming forward.

And on every one of them, somewhere, dust.

On a hand. On a cheek. On the back of a neck. Grey-gold. A smudge of it. The size of a moth's wing.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lady's light*," said Elowen Dunmore. Very quietly.

She went to the nearest one. A young man. Sitting on the steps of the barracks with a lantern in his lap. Dark. Dust on its glass. Dust on the back of his hand, where he held it.

Elowen knelt in front of him. In her armor. With Oathkeeper laid across her knees.

"*Keeper*," she said. "*Keeper. Can you hear me?*"

He didn't move. He was looking past her. West. At the grey.

She put her hand on his shoulder. Shook him. Gently. Then not gently.

He swayed. Like a reed. And came back to where he'd been. Still looking west.

"*They're alive*," said Fenn. From the tower doorway. Where he was kneeling by an older woman, a sergeant, with grey hair cropped short. He had two fingers on her throat. "*Pulse is slow. Very slow. But they're alive.*" He looked up. "*Three nights. Sitting here. No food. No water.*"

"*How*?" said Wren.

Fenn didn't answer.

He didn't know.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FOUND THE DEAD ones in the stables.

Six. Lying in the straw. Not hurt. Not marked. Just lying there, very peaceful, with their eyes shut and dust on their faces. As if they'd lain down to sleep and simply not bothered to wake up.

Six of forty walked out, thought Wren. *Thirty-four sitting in the yard. Six here.*

That's forty-six.

She counted again. Then she went back out to the courtyard and counted the sitters.

Twenty-eight.

Not thirty-four. Twenty-eight. Sitting on the walls and steps and in the doorways. Twenty-eight. Plus six walked out. Plus six dead in the stables.

Forty.

She stood in the middle of the courtyard and counted them again. Twenty-eight.

She'd counted thirty-four when she came in. She was sure of it. She was a tracker. She counted things for a living.

She turned round slowly.

And saw them.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE ON THE walls.

Six of them. Standing up. Where six Keepers had been sitting, a moment ago, with dim eyes and dust on their hands.

Only they weren't Keepers.

Not anymore.

They were standing very straight. Very still. In grey coats that hung on them as if they'd been made for bigger people. Their skin was pale. Not pale like a sick man is pale. Pale like ash. Like the underside of a leaf. Their eyes were lit. Faintly. Two dull gold sparks in each face, like the last coals in a grate.

And on their backs, under the grey coats, pushing the cloth up in two ragged humps, something was moving.

Unfolding.

The coats tore. Quietly. Down the back seams. And out of the torn cloth came wings.

Small. Ragged. Grey-gold. Dusty. Like the wings of the moths that had come over the ridge at the Lantern Keep, the night Odile went dim. But bigger. Man-sized. Furled and creased and dry, like leaves in autumn.

The six on the wall turned their faces toward the courtyard.

Toward the Keepers' lanterns. Toward Elowen's torch. Toward the little fire Fenn's men had just lit by the gate.

Toward the light.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Elowen*!"

Wren had an arrow on the string before she knew she'd reached for one. She drew. Aimed. At the nearest. A woman, or what had been a woman, with cropped grey hair and a sergeant's stripes on the torn sleeve of her coat.

The sergeant Fenn had been kneeling beside. A moment ago. With his fingers on her throat.

Wren loosed.

The arrow went through the woman's chest. Clean. Through the heart. The way Wren had put arrows through the hearts of gloamhounds and hollow-knights and ice-trolls a hundred times.

The woman looked down at it.

Then she came apart.

Not fell. Not bled. *Came apart*. Into dust. All at once. Grey-gold. Like a sandcastle when the wave comes in. Her coat fell empty onto the wall. The arrow fell through the dust and clattered on the stone. And the dust hung in the air for a moment, glittering. A cloud of it. The shape of a woman.

And then drifted down. Slowly. And settled on the wall.

And began, very slowly, to pile up again.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE OTHER FIVE CAME off the wall.

Not jumping. *Gliding*. Their ragged wings caught the thin cold wind and held them, the way a sycamore seed is held, and they came down into the courtyard slowly, spinning a little, light as leaves.

Toward the light.

Toward Fenn's little fire by the gate. Toward the lanterns in the Keepers' hands. Toward Elowen's torch.

They didn't attack the Keepers. They went *past* them. Straight past. Brushing them with their wings. To the lanterns. To the fire. And bent over them. Close. Closer. With their lit eyes and their pale faces. The way you'd bend over a cup of hot soup on a cold night.

And the lanterns went dim.

And the eyes of the Mothwing went bright.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEEPERS BROKE.

Not all of them. Not at once. Roole had drilled them well. They held for a moment. Stood in their pairs. Swords up. Shields up.

But they'd come to the end of the world. Into a fort full of their friends sitting with dim eyes, looking west. And the friends had stood up and grown wings and come down off the walls to drink the light out of their hands.

A boy dropped his lantern and ran. Then another. Then four. Scattering across the courtyard. Toward the gate. Away.

And the Mothwing turned their heads, and watched them go, the way a cat watches a moth. Not interested. The lanterns were what they wanted. The running boys had no light.

Except the one at the back. Who'd kept his torch.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHWING CAME FOR him.

Wren saw it. A pale grey shape with ragged wings, gliding across the courtyard toward a running boy with a torch in his fist. Low. Fast. Faster than they'd moved before. Its lit eyes fixed on the flame.

It reached out. A long pale hand. Too many joints in the fingers.

And caught the boy's wrist.

Not his torch. His *wrist*. Where his skin was. And the boy screamed, high and short, like a hare. And the hand left dust on him. Grey-gold. A smudge of it, the size of a moth's wing, on the back of his hand.

And the boy stopped screaming.

And stopped running.

And stood very still in the middle of the courtyard, with the torch going out in his fist, and turned his face slowly toward the west. Toward the Veil.

And his eyes went dim.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CALLED THE WIND.

She didn't think about it. She didn't decide. It came up out of her the way it always did now, since the Wellworld of Gale, since she'd carried the First Breath in her lungs for three days. A *Tempest*. Hard. Cold. Straight down out of a clear sky into the courtyard of Greyfall like a fist.

It hit the Mothwing.

And they *tumbled*.

All of them. All five. Their ragged dust-wings caught the gust like sails in a gale, and they went over. Head over heels. Spinning. Tumbling across the courtyard like leaves in an autumn storm. Smashing into walls. Into each other. Into the ground. Their wings creasing and tearing, shedding dust in great glittering clouds.

They couldn't fly in it.

They were too light. Too dry. Too *dusty*. They'd come through the Veil on a whisper of air and drifted across the bare lands on the thinnest of breezes and glided down off the walls like seeds. They had no weight. No strength. No grip on the air.

And Wren Ashdown had the whole sky in her.

"*Down*!" she shouted. "*Keep them down! Elowen!*"

Elowen Dunmore was already moving.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T REALLY A fight after that.

It was a storm. And a knight.

Wren held the wind. Down, into the courtyard. Hard and cold and endless, pinning the Mothwing to the stones like leaves pinned to a fence. Every time one of them tried to rise, tried to spread its wings, she slammed it down again. She could feel them through the wind. Light. Brittle. Dry as paper. Struggling. Not angry. Not afraid. Just—*hungry*. Straining toward the lanterns that the Keepers had dropped. Straining toward the light.

And Elowen went through them with Oathkeeper.

She didn't use the edge. She'd seen the arrow. She'd seen the sergeant come apart into dust and start, slowly, to pile up again. She used the *flat*. Hard. Like a woman beating a rug. One blow each. On the back. Between the ragged wings.

And each one she hit came apart. Into dust.

And the dust tried to settle. To pile up. To gather.

And Wren's wind took it.

Picked it up. Off the stones. Out of the courtyard. Up. Over the walls. Away. Scattered it. East and west and north and south. Across the bare grey ground. A little here. A little there. Thin as smoke. Spread over a mile of the Sundered Lands.

It didn't gather again.

◆ ◆ ◆

WHEN IT WAS OVER, Wren sat down on the steps of the barracks with her head between her knees.

She was going to be sick. She knew it. She'd been fighting it the whole time, the whole storm, her stomach rolling like a boat in a gale. She sat very still and breathed through her nose and willed it to go down.

It went down.

Mostly.

Elowen sat down beside her. Heavily. In her armor. With Oathkeeper across her knees, dusted grey-gold from tip to hilt. She was breathing hard.

"*That's not bad fish*," said Elowen Dunmore.

"*It's bad fish*."

"*It's not bad fish*," said Elowen. And looked at her sideways. With her hard grey eyes, her father's eyes, Garrick's eyes. "*I grew up in a house with four aunts, Wren. And eleven cousins. Every one of them born in that house.*" She looked back at the courtyard. "*I know what bad fish looks like. That's not it.*"

Wren lifted her head.

And stared at her.

Elowen didn't say anything else. She just raised one eyebrow. Very slightly. And went back to cleaning dust off Oathkeeper with the corner of her cloak.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING either.

She sat on the barracks steps in the thin cold wind at the end of the world and looked at the courtyard. At the Keepers going round from sitter

to sitter. At Fenn, crouched by the boy with the dust on his wrist, who was standing in the middle of the yard looking west. At the arrow lying on the wall where the sergeant had been.

She was counting.

Not Keepers. Not Mothwing. Days. Weeks.

The wedding. Three weeks and four days. And before that—

Oh, she thought.

Oh, no. Oh—

And then: *oh*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SUN WENT DOWN.

They'd decided to stay. Fenn decided. They couldn't move twenty-eight dim Keepers across the bare lands in the dark. They couldn't leave them. And the Mothwing, if there were more of them, would come back. To the light. Better to be ready. Better to be inside walls.

So they shut the gates. And lit the lanterns, every one they'd brought, and put them on the walls. And sat the dim Keepers in the barracks, in rows, wrapped in blankets, and tried to make them drink water, and some of them did, a little. And the Keepers who weren't dim stood on the walls in pairs with their swords and their lanterns and looked west.

Wren stood on the tower.

With her bow. And the wind. And a hand over her stomach, under her coat, where nobody could see.

The sky went red, and then purple, and then grey. And the Veil, at the edge of the world, went from grey to darker grey to nothing. A place where the stars stopped.

And on the bare ground below the fort, at the bottom of the rise, in the last of the light, someone was standing.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T SEE HER come.

That was the first thing. That was the thing she'd remember, afterward. She'd been watching. She'd been watching the whole time. Every ridge. Every hollow. Every shadow on the bare grey ground between the fort and

the Veil. She was a tracker. She was the best tracker in Caldor. Nothing moved on open ground without her seeing it.

She didn't see her come.

She was just there. At the bottom of the rise. Fifty yards from the gate. Standing on the cracked grey earth with her hands folded in front of her and her face turned up toward the walls.

A woman.

Tall. Taller than any man in the fort. Thin. Straight as a candle. In a long grey-gold gown that went down to the ground and moved in the wind like smoke. With silver hair, very long, very fine, loose down her back to her knees.

And something folded on her back. Close against her spine. Like a cloak. Like a train. Grey-gold. Patterned, faintly, with rings and eyes.

Her face was turned up toward the walls. Toward the lanterns.

And her eyes were lit.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE THE MOST beautiful thing Wren had ever seen.

She'd think that afterward, and be ashamed of it, and think it anyway. Two lights. Soft and gold and warm. Not like the dull coal-sparks of the Mothwing. Not like anything. Like windows. Like two windows in a house at the end of a long lane, on a winter night, when you've been walking a long time in the cold and the dark and you're tired and lost and your feet hurt and you see them, far off, and think—

There. Someone's home.

Someone's waiting.

Wren's foot moved.

Forward. Toward the edge of the tower. Toward the lights.

She stopped it.

She stood very still on the tower of Greyfall with her bow in her hands and her heart going like a hammer and made her foot stop. And her other foot. And her eyes. She made herself look away. At the ground. At the dust on the cracked earth round the woman's feet.

No tracks, she thought. *She's not making tracks.*

She's standing on the ground and she's not leaving a mark on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Good evening*," said the woman.

Her voice came up the rise to the walls. Low. Soft. A little hoarse. Kind. It carried on the wind the way a voice carries across water at night. Every Keeper on the walls heard it. Wren saw them turn. Saw their faces.

"*I'm so sorry*," said the woman. "*About your friends. About your lanterns.*" She looked at the walls. At the dark ones, with dust on their glass. "*They were starving. My people. You must understand. It's been so very long since anyone left a light on for us.*"

Nobody answered.

Elowen was on the wall above the gate. With Oathkeeper drawn. Wren could see her. Very straight. Very still. Not looking at the woman's eyes. Looking at her hands.

"*Who are you*?" said Fenn. From the gate. His voice was steady. Mostly.

The woman smiled.

It was a lovely smile. Sad. Fond. Patient. The kind of smile a grandmother gives a child who has asked a question with a very long answer.

"*My name is Maelis*," she said. "*It's a very old name. You won't have heard it. Nobody's said it in a long time.*" She spread her long pale hands. Empty. "*I've come a very long way. From the other side of your Veil. From a country that was taken away from us, a long time ago, by a man who thought he knew best.*" She looked up at the walls. "*I've come to ask for sanctuary.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WALL WAS VERY quiet.

"*Sanctuary*," said Fenn.

"*Sanctuary*," said Maelis. "*For myself. And my household. The ones who are left.*" Something moved in her face. Grief. Or something that looked very like it. "*There were thousands of us once. There are hundreds now. The rest came apart against the Veil. Coming through. It's very old, your Veil. Very cruel. It doesn't like us.*" She looked at the wall where the sergeant had been. At the arrow lying in the dust. "*And now six more.*"

"*They attacked us*," said Fenn.

"*They were hungry*," said Maelis. Gently. "*They've been hungry for nine hundred years. They saw your lights and they couldn't help themselves.*" She shook her head. "*I'm sorry. I'm truly sorry. I called them back as soon as I could. But I'm only one woman, and they're very old, and very tired, and very hungry.*"

She looked up at the tower.

At Wren.

"*I'd like to speak to your Queen*," said Maelis. "*If she'll see me. I'll come as a prisoner, if you like. In chains. Unarmed.*" Her lit eyes didn't leave Wren's face. "*I have things to tell her. About your net. About the man who wove it. About what was here before.*"

A pause.

"*About what's coming up under your feet*," said Maelis softly. "*Even now. As we speak. Rising toward your lights. The thing your Founders couldn't kill.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN'S HAND HAD GONE to her stomach again.

She didn't notice. Not until the woman's eyes moved. Down. From her face to her hand. To the place under her coat where her hand was resting. Flat. Without meaning to.

And stayed there.

The lit eyes widened. Very slightly.

And Maelis of the Crowned, standing on the bare grey earth at the bottom of the rise with the Veil behind her and the stars coming out, and leaving no tracks at all, looked up at Wren Ashdown on the tower of Greyfall.

And smiled.

Differently, this time. Not sad. Not fond. Not patient.

Hungry.

"*Oh*," said Maelis. Very softly. So softly that only the wind carried it, and only to Wren. "*Oh, look at you.*"

Wren went cold all over.

"*You're carrying a light*," said the Moth Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I don't have a lantern*," said Wren.

It came out of her before she could stop it. Stupid. Hoarse. Her voice didn't sound like her own.

Maelis looked at her for a long moment. With her lit eyes. Her beautiful face. Her long pale hands folded in front of her.

"*No*," she said. Gently. "*No, you don't.*"

And then she turned away. As if it didn't matter. As if she'd said nothing at all. And looked up at the gate, at Fenn, with her sad and patient smile.

"*Well*?" said Maelis. "*Will you take me to your Queen?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T HEAR WHAT Fenn said.

She heard the blood in her ears. She heard her own heart. She heard the wind, coming in off the bare lands, thin and cold and smelling of nothing.

And under it, very faint, so faint she thought she was imagining it—

Something else. A sound she'd never heard before. Low. Small. Quick. Like a bird's heart, beating. Like a little drum, very far off.

Not outside her.

Inside.

She stood on the tower of Greyfall with her hand flat on her stomach and her bow forgotten in her other hand, and listened to it. And didn't breathe.

And at the bottom of the rise, in the dusk, the Moth Queen looked up at her one last time.

And her lit eyes, warm and gold and beautiful, like windows at the end of a long lane on a winter night, were fixed on Wren's hand.

On what was under it.

The way a moth looks at a lamp.

CHAPTER 7

SANCTUARY

HIGHCREST PUT ITS LANTERNS out for her.

Not because anyone told it to. Not at first. Queen Lysandra's order came later, at noon, carried through the streets by heralds on horseback. *By command of the Crown, all lanterns in the city are to be shuttered or extinguished from dusk until the Queen's further word.* By then it was too late. By then the city had already done it on its own.

Lex watched it happen from the West Gate.

He'd been standing there since dawn. On the wall. In the cold spring wind. Watching the road. The long white road that ran west from Highcrest across the green downs toward the Blightmarch and the bare lands and the edge of the world. He'd been standing there for two days, on and off. Since the raven came from Fenn, saying *returning with the woman. Ten days. Wren safe.*

Wren safe. That was all. Two words. He'd read them two hundred times.

And now, at last, at the far end of the road, a column. Grey coats. Horses. Carts. Coming slowly. And above them, high, small, a figure on the wind. Coming fast. Ahead of the rest. A speck of green and red against the grey sky.

He was down off the wall before he knew it. Through the gate. Running.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME DOWN OUT of the wind onto the road in front of him so hard she staggered. And he caught her. And held on.

He didn't say anything. Neither did she. They stood in the middle of the West Road with the city walls behind them and the wind settling round them, and held on.

She smelled of dust. Grey-gold. Faintly. Of plums.

"*You're all right*," said Lex. Into her hair.

"*I'm all right*."

"*Fenn said safe. He didn't say all right.*"

"*I'm safe and I'm all right*." She pulled back. Just enough to look at him. Her face was thinner. Her green eyes were very bright and very strange. Not frightened. Something else. Something he couldn't read. "*Lex. Listen. Before they get here. Before she gets here.*"

"*What*?"

Wren opened her mouth.

Then closed it.

He watched her do it. Watched something come up in her face and go down again. Like a fish in deep water.

"*Later*," said Wren. "*Tonight. Not here. Not with—*" She glanced back down the road. At the column. Closer now. "*Just—later. I'll tell you later. It's not bad. It's not—I don't think it's bad.*" She swallowed. "*But not here.*"

"*Wren—*"

"*Don't look at her eyes*," said Wren.

It came out fast and low and hard. She had his coat in both fists.

"*Whatever you do*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Whatever she says. However kind she sounds. Don't look at her eyes, Lex. Look at her hands. Look at her feet. Look at the ground round her feet.*" Her own eyes were fierce. "*She doesn't leave tracks.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COLUMN CAME IN through the West Gate at noon.

Forty Keepers in grey. Fenn on his bay mare at the front. Dame Elowen Dunmore beside him on a big grey warhorse, in her armor, with Oathkeeper across her saddle-bow and her face like a shut door.

And behind them, carts.

Six of them. Farm-carts, borrowed from the last village before the downs. With straw in the beds and blankets over the straw. And sitting in the straw, in rows, wrapped in blankets, with their faces turned west, twenty-eight Keepers.

Dim.

The crowd that had gathered at the gate went quiet when the carts came through. Lex heard it go. Like a wave going out. People who'd come to see the strange woman from beyond the Veil, laughing and shoving and holding children up on their shoulders, went silent. One by one. As the carts went by.

Twenty-eight faces. Pale. Still. Eyes open. Looking west. Past the gate, past the walls, past the crowd. Looking back down the road the way they'd come. As if they'd left something there. As if they were waiting for it to follow.

And between the fourth cart and the fifth, walking, with an iron chain on her wrists, the woman.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T LOOK AT her eyes.

He wanted to. That was the worst part. He'd think about that afterward, for a long time. How much he wanted to.

He looked at her hands.

Long. Pale. Grey-gold, like the dust on the lanterns. The fingers very fine and very long, too long, with joints in them that shouldn't have been there. Folded in front of her. With a chain between the wrists. Ordinary iron. Keepers' issue. The kind Roole's people used for drunks and thieves.

She wore it like jewelry. Like a bracelet. Her hands held it as if it were a string of pearls.

He looked at her feet.

He couldn't see them. Her gown went down to the ground. Long and grey-gold, moving in the wind like smoke. And under the hem, on the cobbles of the West Gate, where she'd walked—

Nothing.

Not a mark. Not a scuff. Not a print in the dust of the road that had come in on the cart-wheels and the horses' hooves and forty Keepers' boots.

The cobbles behind her were clean.

As if she'd never been there at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE LANTERNS LEANED.

He saw it. Everyone saw it. It was noon, broad day, and the lanterns of Highcrest weren't lit, they were never lit at noon. But they hung in every window and from every eave and every bracket along the West Way, the way they had for a year and a half, since the Heart. Dark. Unlit. Waiting for dusk.

And as she walked past them, every one of them *swung*.

Toward her.

Not much. Just a little. The way a lantern swings in a breeze. Except there wasn't a breeze. Except they all swung the same way. Toward her. As she passed. Like heads turning. Like flowers turning toward the sun.

And then swinging back. Slowly. When she'd gone by.

The crowd saw it.

Lex watched them see it. Watched the faces change. Watched the people at the front of the crowd take a step back. And then, slowly, watched some of them take a step *forward*. Toward her. Toward the tall grey-gold woman with the chain on her wrists, walking up the West Way between the carts. Looking at her face.

Looking at her eyes.

A child broke away from its mother. A little girl. Five. Six. In a blue smock. And ran out into the road. Toward the woman. With her arms up.

And Maelis stopped walking.

And looked down at the child.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS MOVING. HE didn't know when he'd started. Pushing through the crowd at the side of the road. Fire coming up in him, without his asking, the way it did when someone he cared for was in danger. He didn't know the child. He didn't care. He was moving.

And Maelis knelt down.

In the road. In her long grey-gold gown. With the chain on her wrists. On the cobbles of the West Way. So that her face was level with the little girl's.

She didn't touch her. She didn't reach out. She just knelt there. And looked at the child. And smiled.

"*Hello*," said the Moth Queen. Softly. "*Aren't you a bright one.*"

The little girl stared at her. With her arms still up.

"*Go back to your mother*," said Maelis. Gently. "*She's frightened. Can you see? She's frightened for you.*" She tilted her head. "*Never make your mother frightened. It's the worst thing in the world. Go on.*"

And the little girl turned. And ran back. Into the crowd. Into her mother's arms.

And Maelis stood up. Unhurried. And brushed off her gown. Though there was nothing on it. And walked on up the West Way. Between the carts. Toward the castle.

And Lex, standing at the edge of the crowd with fire in his hands and nowhere to put it, looked down at the cobbles where she'd knelt.

Where the hem of her gown had brushed.

There was dust on them.

Grey-gold. A little. A smudge. The shape of a moth's wing.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[Lex. Put the fire out.]*

He put it out.

[That was—]

I know what it was.

[She could have—]

I know, thought Lex. *She could have. She didn't. She wanted everyone to see her not do it.*

He looked up the West Way. At the tall grey-gold figure walking between the carts. With the lanterns swinging toward her as she passed.

She's very good at this, he thought.

She's been doing it for a very long time.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE QUEEN RECEIVED HER in the Hall of Lanterns.

It had been the throne room. It had been called the Hall of the Crown for three hundred years. Lysandra had changed the name, the summer after the Heart, and taken the throne out, and put in a long table instead. Oak. Plain. With chairs down both sides and one at the head that was no bigger than the others. And above the table, hanging from the high stone ceiling on iron chains, a hundred lanterns. Brass and tin and glass. From every corner of Caldor.

They were dark today. Shuttered. Every one.

Lysandra had done that herself. Lex had watched her. Climbing up a ladder in her plain blue dress at dawn, with Elowen holding the bottom of it, swearing, closing the shutters on her lanterns one by one.

If she wants light, the Queen had said, coming down the ladder, *she can bring her own.*

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS CAME IN ON Fenn's arm.

Not because she needed it. Because she'd asked. *I'm a little tired*, she'd said, at the door of the Hall, in her low soft hoarse voice. *It's been a long walk. Would you mind?* And Fenn, who had straightened every leaning Stone in the west with his own hands and stood beside Roole at the Hollowmaw on the night of the Blade and didn't talk much, had looked at her for a long moment.

And given her his arm.

Lex saw his face as they came in. Fenn's narrow sandy face. Pale. Set. Confused. Like a man who's done something without deciding to, and doesn't know why.

The Hall was full.

Not the whole court. Lysandra hadn't wanted the whole court. Just the council. The ones who mattered. The Queen at the head of the long table, in blue, with her silver circlet. Arion at her right hand, where he always sat. Commander Roole on her left, in Keepers' grey. Seraphine further down, with a notebook open in front of her and her pen already moving. Elowen standing behind the Queen's chair, with Oathkeeper drawn and point-down on the stone. A dozen lords and ladies of the council. Duke

Harlowe, old and white-bearded. Lady Cressa Moore, who'd taken Sorn's seat. Others Lex knew by face but not by name.

And Antho.

His brother was at the far end of the table. Alone. Sitting very still. In his black coat. With the Lantern on the table in front of him, its shutter closed, and his long hands folded round it. He'd come down from the Hollowmaw that morning on Ashka. He hadn't said anything when he arrived. He'd just looked at Lex, and nodded, and gone and sat at the end of the table and folded his hands round the Lantern.

He was looking at the door. At the woman coming through it on Fenn's arm.

His face was white.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT DOWN BESIDE Wren. Halfway down the table. She took his hand under the table and held it so hard his fingers went numb.

He didn't look at the woman's eyes.

He looked at the Queen.

Lysandra was looking at Maelis. Steadily. With her sharp dark face very calm, the way it went before a fight. She'd been crowned at twenty-four, in a city that had just lost its king and its High Warden and half its army. She'd faced down a coup in a ballroom with no shoes on. She'd named her people one by one in a square full of singing to open a path for Lex's brother. She was not, Lex thought, a woman who was easily charmed.

"*You asked for sanctuary*," said the Queen of Caldor.

"*I did, Majesty*."

"*Sit down*."

Maelis looked at the chair at the foot of the table. The one that had been set for her. Plain oak. Like the others.

She didn't sit in it.

She sat on the floor.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DID IT SLOWLY. Gracefully. Folding herself down onto the stone flags of the Hall of Lanterns at the foot of the long table, in her long grey-gold gown, with her chain in her lap. Like a child sitting down to hear

a story. Like a petitioner kneeling before a throne. Her silver hair pooled round her on the floor.

She looked up at the Queen.

"*Forgive me*," said Maelis. "*I've sat on a throne. A long time ago. It wasn't comfortable. I've never liked chairs since.*" Her smile was small and wry. "*And I think it's better, don't you? If I'm lower than you. While we talk. So nobody forgets who's asking.*"

There was a ripple round the table. Lex felt it. Like a breeze through grass. Something in the room relaxing. A lord at the far end chuckled.

Lysandra didn't.

"*Who are you*?" said the Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS TOLD THEM.

She told it well. Lex would give her that, afterward, when he went over it again and again in his head, trying to find the place where it went wrong. She was a wonderful storyteller. Better than Ilse. Better than Ember. Her low hoarse voice filled the Hall of Lanterns without ever rising. She never hurried. She never paused too long. She looked at each of them in turn as she spoke, the way a good teacher does, so that each of them felt she was speaking only to them.

Lex looked at her hands. The whole time.

He heard every word.

◆ ◆ ◆

Before your net, said Maelis, *there were no Ceilings.*

You know that. You've read it in your books. But you don't know what it meant. You can't. You've only had a year and a half without one.

It meant that anyone could rise. Anyone. A shepherd's daughter. A fisherman's son. As high as they could go. As far as they could reach. Nobody stood beside you at a Stone and put a hand on your shoulder and pushed down. There were no Stones. There was only the world. And the Wells. And whatever you could make of them.

Some of us rose very high.

She looked down at her hands. At the chain in her lap.

Nine of us. Nine who rose higher than anyone. We built kingdoms. Great ones. Beautiful ones. Cities of glass and gold. Gardens that bloomed in winter. Roads that ran straight across the world from sea to sea. We made peace where there had been war. We fed people who had been hungry.

They called us the Crowned.

And then we found the spring.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL WAS VERY quiet.

A pool, said Maelis. *In a hall of glass, in the heart of the eldest kingdom. Black. Still. Deep. My brother found it. Oszric. The eldest of us. He found it under the floor of his palace, when they were digging new cellars.*

And whoever drank from it lived.

Not forever. I won't lie to you. Not forever. But long. Very long. Hundreds of years. Without growing old. Without growing sick.

We drank.

She looked up. At the table. At each of them. Her face was very sad.

Wouldn't you? she said. Softly. *If you found a spring, and the water in it would let you live five hundred years, and see your grandchildren's grandchildren grow up, and never watch anyone you loved grow old and die—wouldn't you drink?*

Nobody answered.

Lex felt it go round the table. A stillness. Every person at it thinking the same thing. Thinking of someone. A mother. A father. A child. Someone they'd watched grow old.

He felt Arion go very still. At the Queen's right hand. With his white temples and his brown-spotted hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

And then, said Maelis, *a man came.*

Her voice changed. Not much. Just a little. A coolness.

A Listener. A clever one. The cleverest of his generation. The eldest of seven. You know his name. You've spent the last two years learning it.

Aurelian Vey.

Lex's hand closed on Wren's under the table.

He came to us, said Maelis. *To the Nine. To our courts. He said the spring was dangerous. He said it was a Well, not a spring, and we were draining it. He said if we drank any more, it would go dry, and what was left would be a hunger that would eat the world.*

We didn't believe him.

She spread her long pale hands. The chain clinked.

Why would we? she said. *He was a Listener. A hedge-mage. A man who talked to fire. He'd never ruled anything. He'd never fed anyone. He came to us in his plain robe with his little hammer and told us we were wrong, and we laughed at him. Not cruelly. We were never cruel. We just—laughed.*

And he went away.

And he wove his net.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL OF LANTERNS was silent.

You know the rest, said Maelis softly. *You know it better than I do. You've lived it. Nine hundred years of it.*

He wove the world into a net. Every person in it. Every thread. And he set himself at the center, as its Root, and he put a lid on the spring and called it the Hollow, and he put a Ceiling on everyone so that no one would ever rise high enough to challenge him again.

And he took a Tithe. From all of you. Every one. A tenth of everything you had. To feed the thing under the lid.

And us— She looked down. *Us, he threw out. Past the edge. Into the grey. And tied the knot behind us, so we could never come home.*

Nine hundred years, said Maelis of the Crowned. *Nine hundred years in a country with no sun. Watching our people come apart into dust. One by one. Because there was nothing to live on. Because he'd taken the spring and put a lid on it and kept it for himself.*

She looked up.

At Lex. At Antho. At Arion.

And then you broke his net, she said. *His own blood. His great-great-grandsons, forty times over. You went down to the bottom of the world and found him there, rotting, merged with the thing he'd made, and*

you broke his net and threw away his Root and lifted his Ceiling off every head in the world.

Her lit eyes were wet.

You set everyone free, said Maelis softly. *Everyone. Even us.*

Thank you.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SPOKE FOR A long time.

Lex didn't look at her eyes. He looked at her hands. Folded in her lap. Long and pale and grey-gold. With dust in the creases of the knuckles.

He felt the room.

He could feel it the way he could feel a forge. The heat of it. The pressure. Every person at that table had been listening. Every one of them had been *moved*. He could feel it in the silence. In the way Duke Harlowe was looking at his own hands. In the way Lady Cressa Moore had her fingers pressed to her lips.

It was all true.

That was the trouble. That was what made the back of his neck go cold. Every word of it was true. Aurelian *had* woven the net. He *had* set himself at the center. He *had* taken a Tithe from everyone and fed it to the thing under the lid. He *had* put a Ceiling on the world. Lex had stood at the Heart and seen it. He'd seen the old man at the gold anvil, merged with the hunger, nine hundred years rotten.

It was all true.

And it was all wrong.

He couldn't have said how. Not then. He sat at the table with Wren's hand crushing his and the fire very low in him and knew, the way he knew when a weld was bad before he struck it, that something in the story was cracked. Something at the center. Something she'd left out. Or put in the wrong place.

[She's very good,] said Ember. Very quietly.

Yes.

[She hasn't told a single lie. Not one. I've been checking. Against everything he knew. Against everything in the Book of What Was.] A pause.

[She's just—arranged it. Like a jeweler arranges a setting. So the light hits it the way she wants.]

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why are you here*?" said the Queen.

Lysandra hadn't moved. She was sitting at the head of the long table exactly as she had been when Maelis came in. Back straight. Hands folded. Face calm.

Lex loved her for it.

"*Because the knot came loose*," said Maelis. "*When your smith reforged the net. He tied it again with a kinder hand. He left a little give.*" She smiled at Lex. He looked at her hands. "*Just enough for a moth.*"

"*That's how. I asked why*."

Maelis looked at the Queen for a long moment.

"*Because of what's coming up*," she said.

The Hall went still.

"*You've felt it*," said Maelis. "*Haven't you. All of you. Your springs. Your wells. Your strange new roads. Your Delves that open in village greens.*" She looked at Lex. "*Your Delves that your net doesn't recognize.*"

She leaned forward. Slightly. On the floor. Her chain clinked.

"*The Well we drank*," said Maelis. "*The spring under Oszric's palace. The one Aurelian put a lid on and called the Hollow. It went dry when we drank it. And what was left was a hunger. A terrible hunger. That's what he caged. That's what he fed your Tithe to. For nine hundred years.*" Her voice dropped. "*You called it the Unmaker.*"

"*We know*," said Lex.

He hadn't meant to speak. It came out of him.

Maelis turned her face toward him. He didn't look up.

"*Do you*?" she said. Softly. "*Then you know what it did. You know what it ate. Worlds. Whole worlds. Before Aurelian caught it. After. Under his lid. You saw them yourself, at the bottom of the deep. Drifting. Eaten.*"

"*It was starving*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

EVERYONE TURNED.

His brother hadn't moved. He was still sitting at the far end of the table, alone, with his long hands folded round the Lantern. His face was white. His grey eyes were fixed on the woman on the floor.

He was the only one at the table looking straight at her eyes.

Lex felt his stomach drop.

"*It was starving*," said Antho Vey again. Quietly. "*Because you drank it. You and your brother and the rest of you. You knelt at the pool and drank until there was nothing left.*" He didn't blink. "*Aurelian didn't make the hunger. You did. He just caught it.*"

Maelis looked at him.

For a long time.

And Lex, watching her hands, saw them do something. For the first time since she'd come into the Hall. A tiny movement. The long pale fingers curling. Very slightly. In her lap. Round the chain.

"*Yes*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TABLE WENT VERY quiet.

"*Yes*," said Maelis. Simply. Looking at Antho. "*We drank. I told you we drank. We didn't know what it would do. We were told, by a hedge-mage with a hammer, and we didn't believe him.*" She tilted her head. "*Have you never done something terrible, Threshold Warden, because you didn't believe someone who told you not to?*"

Antho didn't answer.

"*I think you have*," said Maelis. Gently. "*I think everyone at this table has. That's what it is to be a person.*" She looked round at them. "*We were wrong. We were young, and greedy, and frightened of dying, and we were wrong. And we've paid for it for nine hundred years.*" Her voice was very soft. "*Haven't we paid enough?*"

She looked back at Antho.

"*And now it's coming back*," she said. "*The thing we made. The hunger. It's healed, you think. Grown back. Full again. Your old Listener sat with it, and sang to it, and you think it's good now.*" Something in her face, then. Something almost like pity. "*Wells don't heal, Threshold Warden. Not that*

one. It remembers. It remembers being drunk dry. It remembers being caged. It remembers nine hundred years of the Tithe."

She leaned forward.

"*It's coming up*," said Maelis. "*Under your feet. Toward your lights. Toward the woman who's leading it.*" A pause. "*And when it comes, it will be hungry again. It can't help it. That's what it is now. That's what we made it.*"

She looked at the Queen.

"*I know how to bind it*," said Maelis of the Crowned. "*I'm the only one alive who does. That's why I've come. That's what I'm offering.*" She lifted her chained hands. "*Give me sanctuary. And when it comes, I'll help you put it back in the dark where it belongs. Before it eats your world the way it ate ours.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE COUNCIL ERUPTED.

Not loudly. They weren't that kind of council. But all at once. Duke Harlowe and Lady Cressa and three lords Lex didn't know, all speaking at the same time. *Majesty, we must—Majesty, consider—if what she says is true—the springs, the Delves, the dust on the lanterns—*

Lysandra held up one hand.

They stopped.

The Queen of Caldor looked down the long table at the woman sitting on the floor at the foot of it. For a long, long time.

Then she looked at her advisor.

"*Arion*," she said.

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HIS FATHER HADN'T SAID anything. The whole time. He'd sat at the Queen's right hand with his white head bowed and his thin brown-spotted hands folded on the table. Listening. The way he always listened.

He lifted his head.

And looked at Maelis.

Not at her hands. At her face. At her eyes. Lex saw him do it. Saw his father look straight into the lit gold eyes of the Moth Queen, steady and grey and two hundred and thirty-three years old.

And not move.

"*Hello*," said Arion Vey.

Maelis looked back at him. And for the first time since she'd come into the Hall of Lanterns, something in her face was not arranged. Something was *surprised*.

"*Warden-Architect*," she said slowly. "*You've grown old.*"

"*I have*."

"*How lovely*," said Maelis. And she sounded as if she meant it. As if it was the loveliest thing she'd ever seen. And the most delicious. "*How very lovely. I've never seen a Vey grow old. Not one. Not in all my life.*"

"*Neither had I*," said Arion. Mildly. "*Until last month. I'm finding it very educational.*"

He looked at her for a moment longer.

"*There's a story they tell in the Spire*," he said. "*To frighten new cadets. About Nine at a Pool. And how they were thrown out past the edge of the world. And how they're still there.*" He tilted his head. "*It ends with a warning. Never leave a light on. Or the Nine will come for it.*"

Maelis smiled.

"*Children's stories*," she said.

"*Yes*," said Arion. "*I thought so too. For two hundred years.*" He looked at the dark lanterns hanging over the table. Shuttered. Every one. "*I've lived in this city a very long time, my lady. Through nine kings and one Queen. And I've never once seen the lanterns of Highcrest swing toward anyone the way they swung toward you this morning.*"

The Hall was very quiet.

"*Majesty*," said Arion Vey. Without looking away from Maelis. "*My advice is this. Give her sanctuary.*"

Lex stared at him.

"*Give her a house*," said his father. "*In the Upper City. Where we can see her. With Keepers on the doors and no lanterns within a hundred yards. Keep her people outside the walls. Out at Greyfall, where they came from. Let*

her talk to anyone who wants to talk to her. Let her tell her story. Let her offer whatever she likes."

He folded his hands.

"*And if one more lantern in your kingdom goes dark*," said Arion, "*put her back on the road. And walk her to the edge of the world. And watch her go.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LYSANDRA LOOKED AT HIM for a long moment.

Then she looked at Maelis.

"*You heard him*," said the Queen of Caldor.

"*I did, Majesty*."

"*Those are my terms. A house. Keepers. No lanterns. Your people stay at Greyfall.*" Lysandra's voice was very even. "*One lantern. One. And you're gone.*"

Maelis bowed her head. On the floor. Her silver hair falling forward over her face.

"*You're very generous*," she said. "*More generous than I deserve. Thank you.*"

She got up. Slowly. Gracefully. The chain clinking. And turned toward the door, where Fenn was waiting, very pale, to take her arm.

And stopped.

Beside Lex's chair.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T LOOK UP.

He looked at her hands. Hanging at her sides now, with the chain between them. Close. Very close. He could have touched them. He could see the dust in the creases of the knuckles. He could smell her. Plums. Old silk. Something underneath, like a room that's been shut up for a very long time.

He felt Wren's hand go rigid in his.

"*You have her hands*," said Maelis.

Her voice was very soft. Just for him. And for Wren. And maybe for Antho, at the end of the table, who had stood up.

"*My sister's*," said Maelis. "*Square. Strong. Never still. Too big for the rest of her, our mother used to say. Good for making things.*" She was quiet. "*I'd know those hands anywhere. I held them once. When they were very small.*"

A pause.

"*Does your mother have them too*?" said Maelis. "*Seren. Seren Harrow.*"

Lex looked up.

He didn't mean to. It happened before he could stop it. His head came up and his eyes came up and he was looking into her face, her beautiful sad face, and her eyes.

Lit. Gold. Warm. Like two windows at the end of a long lane on a winter night.

There, said something in him. *There. Someone's home.*

He couldn't look away.

"*How do you know her name*?" said Lex. His voice sounded very far off.

"*Your father says it every night*," said Maelis. Gently. "*To a little clay lamp. At the bottom of a mountain. Good evening, Seren.*" She smiled. "*My moths are very good listeners.*"

He couldn't breathe.

"*Oh, child*," she said. "*Didn't anyone ever tell you?*"

She leaned down. Close. Her silver hair brushing his shoulder. Her lit eyes very near.

"*Harrow isn't a hedge-witch's name*," said the Moth Queen softly. "*It never was. It was my sister's.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN SHE STRAIGHTENED. And turned. And took Fenn's arm.

And walked out of the Hall of Lanterns, slowly, gracefully, in her long grey-gold gown, leaving no tracks on the stone floor at all.

Above the table, a hundred shuttered lanterns swung on their chains as she passed under them.

Toward her.

And Lex sat very still in his chair with his wife's hand crushing his and his brother standing white-faced at the end of the table and his father's grey eyes on him from the Queen's right hand, and couldn't move.

On his shoulder, where her hair had brushed it, there was dust.
Grey-gold. Fine as flour.
It smelled of plums.

CHAPTER 8

What the Harrow Women Knew

WREN TOLD HIM AT midnight, on the roof of the Spire.

He hadn't wanted to go up. It was cold, and it was dark, and it was eight hundred feet, and he hadn't stopped shaking since the Hall of Lanterns. Not on the outside. On the inside. Somewhere under his ribs. Like a bell that had been struck and wouldn't stop humming.

Harrow was my sister's.

He'd washed his shoulder three times. With soap. In the basin in his father's rooms in the Spire. The dust wouldn't come off. It smeared. It stuck. It smelled of plums.

Wren had watched him do it from the doorway. Then she'd taken the cloth out of his hand. And taken his hand. And said, *come up on the roof*.

So he went up on the roof.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SAT ON THE parapet. The way she always did. With her back to the drop and her boots dangling over the roof and the whole of Highcrest spread out behind her, dark.

That was the strangest thing. The dark. He'd never seen Highcrest dark. Not since the Heart. Every night for a year and a half the golden city had been lit from end to end. Every window. Every eave. A lantern for the lost in every house. Even the bakery in the Lower Town with its great loaf-shaped lantern in the window.

Tonight there was nothing. A city of black roofs under black sky. A few candles, here and there, behind thick curtains. The watch-fires on the walls. The stars.

Lysandra's order. *All lanterns in the city to be shuttered or extinguished from dusk*.

And somewhere down there, in a tall grey house on the Crown Terrace with Keepers on the doors and no lights within a hundred yards, a woman with lit eyes, sitting in the dark. Waiting.

"*Sit down*," said Wren. "*You're looming.*"

He sat down. On the cold stone of the roof. At her feet. With his back against the parapet.

She didn't say anything for a while.

Then she reached down and took his hand. And pulled it up. And put it flat on her stomach. Under her coat. Through her shirt. Warm.

And held it there.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T UNDERSTAND.

For a moment. A long moment. He sat on the roof of the Spire with his hand on his wife's stomach and didn't understand. He thought, *she's cold*. He thought, *she's sick, she's been sick, the bad fish*. He thought—

He looked up at her.

She was looking down at him. In the starlight. With her fox-red braid over one shoulder and her green eyes very bright. And her mouth doing a thing he'd never seen it do before. Wobbling.

"*Wren*," he said.

"*I counted*," said Wren. "*At Greyfall. On the barracks steps. After the fight.*" Her voice was very steady. Her mouth wasn't. "*Elowen said it wasn't bad fish. She grew up with four aunts. She said she knows what bad fish looks like.*" She swallowed. "*So I counted.*"

He couldn't speak.

"*It's early*," said Wren. "*Very early. Six weeks. Maybe seven. I think it was—*" She went red. Very red. Even in the starlight. "*I think it was the night after the wedding. In the tent. When the cow got in.*"

Lex made a sound.

He didn't know what kind of sound it was. It came up out of him from somewhere under his ribs, where the bell had been humming since the Hall of Lanterns, and it wasn't a laugh and it wasn't a sob and it wasn't a word. It was all three. At once.

Wren slid down off the parapet. Onto the roof. Into his lap. And put her arms round his neck. And held on.

"*Hammer*," she said into his shoulder. The clean one. "*Say something. Please. You're frightening me.*"

He held her.

He held her so tight she squeaked. And then he loosened his arms, terrified, as if she'd break. And then held her again. And put his face in her hair. And breathed.

"*A baby*," said Lex Vey.

"*Yes*."

"*Ours*."

"*Well, I certainly hope so*," said Wren. "*I've been very careful about that.*"

He laughed.

It cracked in the middle. He didn't care.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STAYED UP THERE a long time.

He kept his hand on her stomach. He couldn't stop. He didn't feel anything; there was nothing to feel, she said, not yet, not for months. It was the size of a bean. A pea. A grain of barley. He didn't care. He kept his hand there anyway. As if he could hold it. As if he could keep it warm.

"*I heard it*," said Wren. Very quietly. After a long time. "*At Greyfall. On the tower.*"

"*Heard what*?"

"*Its heart*." She was quiet. "*I think. I don't know. It was very faint. Like a bird's heart. Like a drum a long way off.*" She looked at her hand on his. "*Seraphine says that's impossible. Too early. Nobody can hear a heart at six weeks.*"

"*You're a Mistwalker*."

"*I'm a Mistwalker*," Wren agreed. "*I hear things in the wind. I heard the whole Vale when your Delve opened. Three miles off.*" She smiled. A small

strange smile. "*Maybe I can hear things in me, too. Maybe that's how it works now. Maybe the wind knows.*"

He didn't say anything.

He was thinking about the tower at Greyfall. And a tall grey-gold woman at the bottom of the rise in the dusk, looking up. With her lit eyes on Wren's hand.

On what was under it.

You're carrying a light.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN FELT HIM GO cold. She always did.

"*I know*," she said. Very low. "*I know. I thought it too.*"

"*She knew*."

"*Before I did*." Wren's arms tightened round his neck. "*She looked at my hand and she knew. Before I'd finished counting. Before I'd heard the heart.*" Her voice went very hard. "*And she looked at it like—*"

She stopped.

"*Like what*?"

"*Like you look at the fire*," said Wren. "*In the morning. When you say good morning to it.*" She shivered. "*Like it was the most beautiful thing she'd ever seen. And she wanted to put her hands round it.*"

Lex held her.

He looked out over the dark city. At the black roofs. At the Crown Terrace, high on the north side, where a tall grey house stood with Keepers on its doors and no light anywhere near it.

If one more lantern in your kingdom goes dark, his father had said. *Put her back on the road.*

He wanted to go down there. Now. Tonight. With fire in his hands. And kick in her door. And walk her to the edge of the world himself. And watch her go.

He didn't.

He sat on the roof of the Spire with his wife in his lap and his hand on her stomach and the fire very low in him, banked, the way you bank a forge at night so it'll still be there in the morning.

And made a promise. Silently. To a grain of barley.

Nobody puts their hands round you, thought Lex Vey. *Nobody. Not ever.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FLEW TO HARROW in the morning.

Antho came. Lex hadn't asked him. He'd just been there, at dawn, in the courtyard of the Spire, with Ashka saddled and his face white and set and the Lantern on his hip. He'd looked at Lex. Then at Wren. Then at Wren again, harder. And his clear grey eyes had widened. Very slightly.

"*Oh*," said Antho Vey.

"*How*?" said Wren. "*How do you* do *that? Both of you? It's the size of a bean!*"

"*You're standing differently*," said Antho. And then he did something Lex had never seen him do. He came across the courtyard. And put his arms round Wren. Carefully. Very carefully. The way you'd hold a bird. And held her for a long moment. And let go.

"*I'm going to be an uncle*," he said. To no one. Wonderingly. "*I'm going to be an* uncle."

"*You're going to be a terrible uncle*," said Wren. Her eyes were wet. "*You're going to teach it to talk to bats.*"

"*Yes*," said Antho. "*Yes, I am.*"

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THEY WENT TO HARROW because there was nowhere else to go.

Harrow was my sister's. That was all Maelis had said. She'd walked out of the Hall of Lanterns and up to her tall grey house on the Crown Terrace and shut the door, and when Seraphine went to see her in the evening, with Fenn and two Keepers and a notebook, she'd said she was very tired. That it had been a very long walk. That she'd be glad to talk tomorrow. Or the day after. There was plenty of time. She'd been waiting nine hundred years; she could wait a few days more.

She's making us come to her, Seraphine said. Furious. Over a cold supper in Arion's rooms. *She dropped it on you in front of the whole council and walked out. She wants you to wonder. She wants you to come and ask.*

Then we won't ask, said Antho. *Not her.*

Who, then?

His brother had looked at Lex across the table. And Lex had known what he was going to say before he said it.

Mam, said Antho. *We ask Mam.*

She's in the Hollow.

Not all of her. Antho's face was very still. *Some of her's at Harrow. Some of her's in the Vale. Some of her's in every person who ever knew her.* He looked at his hands. *Someone knew her before Father did. Someone knew her mother. Someone in that Vale knows what a Harrow is.*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD BUILT THE new cottage on the old footings.

He'd told himself it was because the footings were good. Deep. Well-laid. Dressed stone, set without mortar, the way the old builders did it in the Vale. Better than anything he could have dug himself in an autumn.

It was true. It wasn't why.

The fire had taken everything above the ground. The walls and the roof and the loft and the furniture and the iron pots, which had melted. Thirteen years ago. On the night of Antho's Kindling. When the Stone screamed and flashed black and the seal on his brother broke and the dark came in.

But it hadn't taken what was under the ground.

There was a cellar. Lex remembered it. Barely. A small square stone room under the kitchen floor, cool and damp, where his mother kept apples and potatoes and the crock of butter in summer. A trapdoor with an iron ring. A ladder. He'd been afraid of it when he was little. Antho used to shut him in it. For about ten seconds. And then open the trapdoor again, laughing, before he could cry.

When they cleared the black stones in the autumn, the trapdoor was gone. Burned. The ladder was gone. But the cellar was there. Under the ash. Under the fallen roof. Full of rubble and charcoal and the melted lumps of the iron pots, which had fallen through when the floor burned.

They'd cleared it out. Carted the rubble away. Swept it. Lex had put in a new trapdoor and a new ladder. Wren had put apples in it.

He'd never looked at the walls.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's here*," said Antho.

He was standing at the bottom of the new ladder. In the cellar. With the Lantern in his hand, shutter open, its soft gold light filling the little stone room. It was smaller than Lex remembered. Everything was. Eight feet square. Low. Lex had to stoop. The walls were dressed grey stone, the same as the footings, fitted tight. The floor was packed earth. There was a smell of apples and damp and, very faintly, under everything, thirteen years later, smoke.

"*What's here*?" said Lex.

His brother didn't answer. He was standing in the middle of the cellar with his eyes half shut. Listening. The way he listened to the black door.

"*Something*," said Antho. "*Something quiet. Something that's been quiet a very long time.*" He turned. Slowly. In a circle. With the Lantern held up. "*It's hiding. Like Pim hides. Like a thread in Shade.*"

He stopped.

Facing the north wall. The one under the old hearth. Where the great chimney of the cottage had stood, before it fell.

"*There*," said Antho Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A STONE.

An ordinary one. Grey. Dressed. Fitted into the wall like all the others. A foot and a half wide and a foot high. Lex had looked at it a dozen times in the autumn, sweeping. He'd never seen anything.

He looked at it now. And still saw nothing.

"*Put your hand on it*," said Antho.

Lex put his hand on it.

Stone. Cold. Damp. Ordinary.

And then, under his palm, through the Well he Commanded, the deep slow certain sense of stone that had been in him since he was nineteen—

Hollow.

The stone was hollow.

Not hollow like a jug. Hollow like a held breath. Like a pocket. Like a space inside it that wasn't empty, exactly, but *waiting*. Folded. Hidden.

Wrapped in something so quiet he'd never have felt it if his brother hadn't stood in the middle of the cellar with his eyes shut and pointed.

"*It's warded*," said Lex slowly. "*Isn't it.*"

"*Hushed*." Antho came and stood beside him. "*Like the Lantern. Like Pim. Something made it quiet. So no one would look.*" He put his own hand on the stone. Beside Lex's. "*Someone who knew how to hide things from Wardens. From Root. From True Sight.*" His voice was very quiet. "*Father lived in this house for eight years. With all his Authority. And he never knew it was here.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX ASKED THE STONE to move.

That was all it took. He didn't break it. He didn't burn it. He asked. The way the Hearth had taught him, in the Wellworld of Flame. The way the Heartiron had taught him, in the Wellworld of Stone. *You're not making it do anything, lad. You're asking it nicely to be something else for a while.*

The stone slid out of the wall. Smoothly. Into his hands. As if it had been waiting thirteen years for someone to ask.

Behind it, in a hollow in the thickness of the wall, there was a box.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS SMALL.

Smaller than Malachi's. Oak, gone almost black with age. Bound with iron at the corners. No lock. A plain iron hasp with a twist of old blue cloth through it instead of a pin.

Blue cloth.

Lex knew that cloth. He'd seen it a thousand times, when he was small. In his mother's hair. *She was small and fierce and freckled, her hair tied back with a strip of blue cloth.*

He couldn't move.

Antho reached past him. And lifted the box out of the wall. Carefully. With both hands. And held it for a moment. Against his chest.

Then he gave it to Lex.

"*You open it*," said his brother. "*I can't.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WAS SITTING AT the top of the ladder. With her legs dangling down into the cellar. She'd been told to stay up there. She'd ignored it as far as the top rung, which was, she said, a compromise.

She watched him untie the blue cloth.

It was rotten. It came apart in his fingers. He held the pieces for a moment. Then put them very carefully in his coat pocket.

He opened the lid.

◆ ◆ ◆

INSIDE, THERE WERE THREE things.

A book. Small. Thick. Bound in soft brown leather gone dark and supple with handling. The kind of book a hedge-witch keeps. Recipes. Remedies. Charms.

A letter. Folded. Sealed with a blob of plain brown wax with a thumbprint in it.

And the box itself.

That was the third thing. Lex didn't see it at first. He saw the book and the letter and thought that was all. And then Antho, crouching beside him with the Lantern, made a small sound. And reached out. And touched the inside of the lid.

There was a carving there.

Small. Neat. Cut into the dark oak with the point of a knife, by someone who'd been patient, and careful, and very sure of what they were doing.

A moth.

Wings spread. Four of them. The two upper ones with a ring on each, like an eye. The body long and narrow. Every line very fine. Very exact. As if whoever carved it had seen one very close, for a long time, and never forgotten.

And through the moth, from corner to corner, deep and hard and angry, one long straight cut.

Crossing it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN THE BOTTOM of the box, under the book and the letter, a shape.

Not a thing. A *shape*. A hollow. Pressed into the wood of the box's floor, the way a ring presses a mark into the velvet of its case if you leave it there long enough. A circle. A little bigger than a man's hand could span. With points on it. Seven of them. Small and sharp, rising from the rim at even spaces, like the teeth of a comb. Or the tines of a fork.

Or the points of a crown.

Lex stared at it.

Whatever had made that shape had lain in this box a very, very long time. Long enough to press itself into the oak. Long enough to leave its mark.

And it wasn't there anymore.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LETTER WAS FROM Seren's mother.

Lex knew it before he opened it. He didn't know how. The thumbprint in the wax was small, and old, and not his mother's. He knew his mother's. He'd seen it a thousand times, in flour, in butter, in the soft clay of a little brown lamp.

He broke the seal.

The paper was thin and brown and spotted. The ink was faded. The hand was small and slanting and quick. A hand that wrote the way a person walks when they're used to leaving places in a hurry.

Seren, it said.

My bright girl. My last one.

If you're reading this, I'm gone, and you've stayed. You've stayed for the Warden-man with the grey eyes. Don't look like that. I know. I've known since the first night you came home from Highcrest with rain in your hair and your face lit up like a Lantern-Night window.

I'm not angry. I want you to know that. I was, at first. I'm not now.

Every Harrow woman for nine hundred years has kept moving. Every one. Thirty houses in thirty years, my mother had. Twenty-two, I had. We don't stay. We don't Kindle. We don't put our hands on their Stones and let

their net read us. We sing to the dark and we keep the door and we never, ever stay long enough for anyone to look at us too closely.

And you've stayed.

Maybe that's right. Maybe it's time. Maybe nine hundred years is long enough to run. The knot is old and tight and nobody has felt a moth this side of the grey since your great-great-grandmother's time. Maybe they've given up. Maybe they've gone to sleep.

But if they haven't—

The ink was blotted there. As if the pen had stopped. And rested on the page. And waited.

If they haven't, my girl, you remember. You remember everything I taught you. You remember the song, all of it, all the verses, not just the one for babies. You remember the rule.

We break the ground. We never take the crown. We never let a moth in.

I've taken the crown where it belongs. Where it was always meant to go. It's not in the box anymore. Don't look for it. Don't tell anyone it was ever there. Not even your Warden-man. Not even if you love him.

Especially not if you love him.

If they come, they'll come for the blood. They'll come for you, and for anything of yours. They'll be kind. They'll be so kind. They'll have the loveliest eyes you ever saw, and they'll tell you the truest story you ever heard, and every word of it will be true, and it will all be a lie.

Don't let them in.

I love you. I've loved you every day of your life. I'm sorry I made you move so much.

Light the lamp for me.

— Your mam

Wenna Harrow

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

The Lantern hissed softly in Antho's hand. The apples sat in their barrel in the corner. Upstairs, through the open trapdoor, Lex could hear the fire in the kitchen hearth, ticking, and the stream outside, loud with meltwater, and a blackbird in the birch wood.

He read the letter again.

We break the ground. We never take the crown. We never let a moth in. They'll come for the blood.

He put his hand on the hollow in the bottom of the box. The circle. The seven points.

I've taken the crown where it belongs.

"*Lex*," said Wren. From the top of the ladder. Very quietly.

He looked up.

She was sitting very still. With her hand flat on her stomach. Under her coat.

They'll come for you, and for anything of yours.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT TO SEE Old Mag in the afternoon.

She was in her chair by the fire, with her shawl and her cat and her one bright black eye. The apple tree outside her window was still in bloom. More than before. Every branch. White and pink and heavy with it, so that the boughs bent down to brush the grass.

She looked at the three of them coming in at her door. Lex and Antho and Wren. With the box.

She didn't say anything for a long moment.

Then she looked at Wren.

At Wren's face. At the way she was standing. At her hand.

And her old wrinkled face cracked open into a smile so wide and so sudden that the cat jumped off her lap.

"*Well*," said Old Mag. "*Well, well, well. Look at you, girl.*"

Wren went red.

"*You're carrying a light*," said Old Mag.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WENT WHITE.

All of it. All at once. The red drained out of her face as if someone had pulled a plug. She stood in Old Mag's doorway with her hand on her stomach and stared at the old woman. And Lex saw her knees go.

He caught her.

"*Lass*?" Old Mag was struggling up out of her chair. "*Lass, what is it? What did I say?*"

"*That*," said Wren. Hoarsely. In Lex's arms. "*That. What you said. Carrying a light.*" She swallowed. "*Where did you—who says that?*"

Old Mag stared at her.

"*Everyone*," she said. "*In the Vale. When a girl's expecting.*" She looked at Lex. Then back at Wren. "*It's just a saying, lass. An old one. Carrying a light. Like a lamp in a window. Because there's someone coming home.*" She frowned. "*My gran said it. And hers. Everyone says it.*"

"*Since when*?" said Antho. Very quietly.

Old Mag looked at him.

"*Since always*," she said. "*Since—*" She stopped. And her one bright eye narrowed. And went far away. The way old people's eyes go when they reach back past a great many years for something they've half forgotten.

"*Since the Harrow women*," said Old Mag slowly. "*That's right. That's where it's from. My gran told me. The Harrow women brought it. Back when they first came into the Vale. Before my gran's gran was born.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD THEM.

Sitting in her chair by the fire, with the cat back in her lap and the box on the table beside her and Wren on the settle with a cup of something hot and herbal and foul that Old Mag swore by. Lex and Antho on stools at her feet. Like children.

It came out slowly. In pieces. The way old stories do. Some of it was her gran's. Some of it was her gran's gran's. Some of it was hers.

There were always Harrow women, said Old Mag. *That's what my gran said. Always. Every few generations. A mother and a daughter. Never a son. Never a husband, or not one anybody ever saw. They'd come into the Vale from somewhere else. North, or east, or over the Greyspine. With a cart, or on foot, with a bundle on their backs. And they'd stay a while. A year. Two. Five. In a cottage somewhere out of the way.*

They were hedge-witches. Herb-women. Good ones. Better than me. Better than anyone. They knew things nobody else knew. They could stop a fever. Turn a breech baby. Talk a frightened horse down.

And they never Kindled.

Never. Not one. Not the mother and not the daughter. When the girl turned sixteen, they'd be gone. Off. Moved on. Before the Warden came round. Before anyone could put her hand on a Stone.

People talked. Course they did. Said they were wildcasters. Said they were wanted. Said all sorts.

But nobody ever told on them. Not once. Because every one of them, every Harrow woman, had saved someone's baby. Or someone's mam. Or someone's cow. And you don't tell on the woman who saved your cow.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And the moths*?" said Antho.

Old Mag looked at him.

"*How'd you know about the moths*?" she said.

"*Tell me*."

The old woman was quiet for a long moment. Stroking the cat.

My gran said, said Old Mag slowly, *there were three things about the Harrow women. Three things everyone knew. Three things you didn't ask about.*

One. They never Kindled.

Two. When their daughters were expecting, they didn't say expecting. They said carrying a light. And everyone thought it was pretty and started saying it too.

Three.

She stopped.

Three, said Old Mag. *They hated moths.*

Hated them. More than anything. More than Wardens. They'd sit up all night, my gran said, when it was moth season, at the end of summer, with the shutters closed and a lamp inside and a broom. And if a moth got in, if one single moth got into a Harrow house, they'd kill it. And burn it. And sweep the ashes out the door and throw salt after them.

And then they'd pack.

That same night. The cart. The bundle. And be gone by morning.

My gran's gran saw it once. A Harrow woman, with a little girl, the year the summer was so hot. A moth got into her cottage. Just one. And my gran's

gran was there, helping with a calving, and she saw the Harrow woman's face. When she saw it on the wall.

She said it was the face of a woman who'd seen a wolf at her child's cradle.

Old Mag looked down at the cat.

And they were gone by morning, she said. *And nobody saw a Harrow woman in the Vale for sixty years. Not till your mam's mam came. Wenna. Wenna Harrow. With her little girl.*

She looked up. At Lex. At Antho.

Your mam, said Old Mag. *Seren. She was nine.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED BACK TO the cottage at dusk.

Through the birch wood. Along the stream. Antho in front, with the Lantern. Wren in the middle. Lex behind, with the box under his arm.

Nobody talked.

The light was going. Grey and gold and then grey. The birches were white in it, pale as bone, with their new leaves just showing, a mist of green. The stream ran loud and cold beside the path.

And in the window of the cottage, ahead of them through the trees, a lantern.

Lex's. Iron and glass. *ARDENT* on the pane. *HOME* on the base. Burning. The way it burned every night. Small and gold and steady. Facing the road.

He stopped on the path and looked at it.

Never leave a light on, the cadets whispered in the Spire. *Or the Nine will come for it*.

We never let a moth in.

He'd made that lantern so it would never go out. So there'd always be a light in the window at Harrow. For his mother. For whoever was coming home.

He stood on the path and looked at it and felt, for the first time in his life, afraid of a lamp.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SLEPT IN THE loft.

Antho slept in the kitchen, by the fire, rolled in his coat, with the Lantern beside him. He'd said he wasn't going back to the Keep tonight. He'd said Seraphine could manage the bats for one night, and Arion was in Highcrest, and Odile had the door, and Pim had the moths. He'd said he wanted to sleep in his mother's house.

Lex didn't sleep.

He sat in the deep window on the east side of the cottage. On the broad sill. With his back against one side of the window frame and his boots against the other, and the lantern between his feet. And the box on his knees. And the letter in his hand.

He'd read it eleven times.

They'll be kind. They'll be so kind. They'll have the loveliest eyes you ever saw, and they'll tell you the truest story you ever heard, and every word of it will be true, and it will all be a lie.

Outside the window, the birch wood was dark. The stream was loud. The stars were out.

And something was on the glass.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SEE IT land.

He looked up from the letter, and it was there. On the outside of the window. On the pane. Right in front of the lantern.

A moth.

Large. Larger than the ones at the Keep. The size of his spread hand. Grey-gold. Its wings open, flat against the glass. Four of them. Patterned. And on each of the upper two, a ring. Like an eye. Dark. Gold-rimmed. Looking in at him.

It didn't move.

It sat on the outside of the glass with its wings spread and its eyes on him and the lantern-light shining through it, so that he could see the veins in its wings, fine as the lines on a leaf. And dust. Grey-gold. Glittering on the glass where its wings touched.

Lex didn't move either.

He sat in the window with the letter in his hand and looked at it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Good evening*," said the moth.

Not the moth. The voice came *through* the moth. The way a voice comes through a door. Low. Soft. A little hoarse. Kind.

Hers.

"*What a pretty lamp*," said Maelis. "*Did you make it? I think you did. It has your hands all over it.*"

Lex said nothing.

"*Ardent*," said the voice. Reading the rune on the pane. From the outside. Backward. "*Home.*" A soft sound. Almost a laugh. "*Oh, that's lovely. That's the loveliest thing. A lamp that will never go out. In a window. For someone who isn't home yet.*"

The moth's wings stirred. Very slightly. On the glass.

"*It's cold out here*," said Maelis. "*It's been cold for nine hundred years.*"

A pause.

"*May I come in*?"

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LEX LOOKED AT THE moth for a long time.

At its wings. At its eyes, that weren't eyes. At the dust it was leaving on his window. On the glass he'd cut himself, in the autumn, in the Forge, for this window, so his mother would have a light when she came home.

He thought about a crown-shaped hollow in the bottom of a box.

He thought about a grain of barley.

He thought about his mother's mother, sitting up all night with the shutters closed and a lamp inside and a broom.

"*No*," said Lex.

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THE MOTH WAS VERY still.

Then, through it, soft and low and delighted, the Moth Queen laughed.

"*Good*," said Maelis. "*Oh, good. That's the right answer. That's exactly the right answer.*"

Her voice was warm. Fond. Almost proud.

"*Your mother would be so proud of you*," she said. "*All your mothers would. Every one of them, all the way back. They always said no to me too.*"

The moth lifted off the glass.

Slowly. Its great grey-gold wings opening. It hung there for a moment, in the dark outside the window, in the light of the lantern, glittering.

And then it was gone. Up. Into the dark. Over the birch wood. West.

On the glass where it had been, there was dust. The shape of its wings. Four of them. With two rings, like eyes. Printed on the outside of the pane in grey-gold, perfectly, the way a hand leaves a print on a frosted window.

And the lantern in the window, *ARDENT*, *HOME*, the lamp Lex had made so it would never go out—

Flickered.

Just once.

And burned on.

CHAPTER 9

The Uncapped

BY THE END OF spring there were forty-one of them.

Seraphine kept the count. She had a map of Caldor pinned to the wall of the library at the Lantern Keep, a big one, hand-drawn, from the Saltreach to the Blightmarch and the Greyspine to the Scald. Every time a raven came in, she put a pin in it. Black pins. Forty-one.

DELVE — UNCLASSIFIED.

On village greens. In farmyards. At the bottom of a dry well in Millbridge. In the cellar of a tavern in the Saltreach, which the landlord had boarded over and was now charging a copper a look. In the middle of the Old Founders' Road, between the Lithic Oracle and the Thornwood, where a merchant's cart had driven straight into one at dusk and come out the next morning, horse and all, a mile away, with the driver white-haired and unable to say where he'd been.

Round. Flat. Black. Perfect. Breathing warm air that smelled of the Hollowmaw.

And humming.

"*They're not random*," said Seraphine. Standing in front of the map with her arms crossed and a pin in her teeth. "*Look.*"

Lex looked.

At first it was just pins. Black pins, scattered across Caldor like seeds thrown on a field. Then she took a piece of string and pinned one end of it to the Greyspine. To the Hollowmaw. And swung it in a slow circle round the map.

And the pins were on the circle. Most of them. Or near it. Or on another circle, further out. Or another, further still. Rings. Spreading out from the Hollowmaw across the whole of Caldor like the rings on a pond when a stone drops into it.

"*It's coming up under the Keep*," said Seraphine. "*Under the door. And the closer it gets, the more it—*" She stopped. Looked for the word.

"*Sheds*," said Lex.

She looked at him.

"*Like a snake*," said Lex. "*Or a dog in spring. When it's getting bigger. Bits come off.*" He looked at the pins. "*It's growing. And it's coming up. And bits of it are coming up ahead of it. Like—*"

"*Like the first drops*," said Seraphine softly. "*Before rain.*"

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THE NET HAD STARTED paying for them.

That was the trouble. Lex understood that quite quickly. That was the whole trouble, in one.

He'd claimed the Ashbourne core. He'd held a warm black pebble in his palm and felt it hum and the net had given him thirty-eight thousand experience and a level and said *it's all right, it's still here, it's just somewhere else now*.

And it had offered him five times that. If he broke it.

He hadn't. He hadn't even thought about it, really. It would have been like breaking a bird's egg.

But other people had.

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THE FIRST WAS A company out of the Saltreach. Six of them. Sailors, mostly. Kindled [Deckhand] and [Netmender] and [Rigger], all capped at twenty-four, all Unbound at the great Stone on the Saltreach quay the summer after the Heart. They'd heard about the Delve in the tavern cellar. They'd paid the landlord a silver each. They'd gone down.

They'd come up three days later with a black pebble. And put it on the bar. And one of them, a big woman named Hesk with a rigger's arms and a scar through her eyebrow, had looked at the panel that came up over it, and laughed, and brought a belaying pin down on it as hard as she could.

It shattered.

Lex had heard about it from three different people, and they'd all told it the same way. It shattered like glass, they said. Like a black glass bottle. Into a thousand pieces. And the pieces went up in smoke. Black smoke. Very fine. That hung in the air of the tavern for a moment and then went down. Through the floor. Into the ground. Like water draining away.

And the six of them went up three levels each.

Three. In a breath. Standing at a bar in the Saltreach.

The story was all over Caldor in a week.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CALLED THEMSELVES THE Uncapped.

Not a guild. Not a company. Nothing so organized. Just a word that had started in the taverns and caught, the way words do. *Uncapped*. Everyone who'd been Unbound and wanted to see how high they could go. Everyone who'd lain awake for years at twenty-four, the way Brannoc had, thinking *just one more*.

There were thousands of them.

Lex saw them on the roads. Bands of five and six and ten, with swords and bows and packs and the bright hard look Dunny Tobbin had had, coming down off the Greyspine. Heading for the nearest black pin on Seraphine's map. Fighting each other for them, sometimes. Racing. Selling the locations in tavern back rooms. *A Delve in Fenmoor, nobody's been in it, three floors, I'll tell you where for a crown.*

And shattering the cores.

Every one they could reach.

◆ ◆ ◆

[It's not their fault,] said Ember.

Lex was in the forge yard at Ashbourne. At dawn. Standing beside the warm spring that had come up out of the cinders. It was bigger now. The size of a cart-wheel. Steaming. With a little channel running away from it down the street that Brannoc had lined with stones.

I know it's not their fault.

[They don't know what it is. Nobody's told them. The net certainly isn't telling them. The net's offering them five times the reward.]

I know.

[Because the net doesn't know either,] said Ember. Quietly. *[Since you reforged it. It's nobody's. It just—notices. And pays for what it notices. It noticed a Delve with a core in it. It noticed someone could break the core. It priced it the way it prices every Delve core. It doesn't know the core's alive.]*

So I tell it.

[You can't. You gave away the Root. Nobody can tell it anything now.] A pause. *[That was the point. That was the whole point of the reforging. Nobody at the center.]*

Lex looked at the spring. Steaming in the cold. New. Clean. Bubbling up out of nothing, out of the cinders of the forge yard where he'd learned his trade, because something under the ground was rising and making room.

Then I tell them, he thought. *The Uncapped. Every one. I go and stand at the Delves and tell them.*

[There are thousands of them.]

I've got time.

[Lex.]

What?

[You've got a wife who's carrying a light,] said Ember. *[And a mother walking up out of the deep with something the size of a mountain. And a woman with lit eyes sitting in a house on the Crown Terrace telling the whole council of Caldor that the something is the Unmaker reborn and offering to put it back in a cage.]* A pause. *[I don't think you've got time.]*

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WREN CAME WITH HIM to Thistledown.

He'd known she would. He'd lain awake half the night in the loft at Harrow working out how to ask her not to, and the other half working out how to say it so she wouldn't throw a boot at him. He'd had eleven versions by dawn.

He didn't use any of them.

He came down the ladder and she was at the table, in her leathers, with her bow strung and her quiver full and two bowls of porridge in front of

her, one of which she was eating and one of which she pushed across the table at him without looking up.

"*I'm coming*," she said.

"*I know*."

"*I'm not staying home*."

"*I know*."

"*I'm staying at the top*," said Wren. "*That's different.*" She looked up. "*I'm not going down. Not into a Delve. Not with—*" She glanced down. At herself. Quickly. As if it embarrassed her. "*Not now. Old Mag says no. Seraphine says no. My own stomach says absolutely not.*" She stabbed her porridge. "*But I'm coming to Thistledown. And I'm standing at the top of the hole with my bow and my wind, and if anything comes up out of it that isn't you, I'm going to put an arrow in it.*"

Lex looked at her.

"*Say it*," said Wren. "*Go on. Say it's dangerous.*"

"*It's dangerous*."

"*Everything's dangerous*." She took a mouthful of porridge. "*Being married to you is dangerous. You set the bed on fire in your sleep last week.*"

"*That was once*."

"*It was a very nice bed*," said Wren. And then, quieter, not looking at him: "*I'll stay at the top, Lex. I promise. I'm not stupid. I'm not going to do anything that—*" She stopped. "*But I'm not staying home. I'm not going to sit at Harrow with my hands in my lap waiting for you to come back. I did that. On the roof of the Spire. For a month.*"

She looked up at him. And her green eyes were very bright.

"*Never again*," she said. "*Remember?*"

He remembered.

He sat down and ate his porridge.

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THISTLEDOWN WAS A TRADING post on the lower slopes of the Greyspine. Twenty houses and an inn and a market cross, at the place where the mountain road came down out of the high passes and met the road from the Vale. Wren had grown up there. In a grey-plank house with a

horseshoe over the door, the wrong way up, so the luck wouldn't run out. Before her mother got sick and they moved to Highcrest for the physic.

Lex had met her there. Five years ago. At the inn. She'd been sitting on the edge of a water-trough in the yard, whittling, and he'd asked her for a guide up the mountain, and she'd looked him up and down and said *you walk like a bear in a china shop* and charged him two silver.

The Delve had opened in the inn yard.

Right where the water-trough had been.

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IT WAS BIGGER THAN the Ashbourne one.

Twice as big. Twenty feet across. Round and flat and black and perfect. The water-trough was gone. The cobbles round it were cracked, pushed up, as if something underneath had *bulged*. Warm air breathed out of it in a long slow sigh that Lex could feel on his face from across the yard.

And it was humming. Louder than the one in Ashbourne. Low and deep. He could feel it in the soles of his feet.

Little light, little light.

There were people round it.

Of course there were. A ring of them. Thirty. Forty. Standing at the edge of the black in the inn yard, with weapons, in groups. Uncapped. He could tell them by the look. The bright hard hungry look. And by the way they stood. Apart. In their bands. Eyeing each other.

And at the very edge of the dark, standing with one boot actually *on* the lip of it, where the cracked cobbles met the black, a man.

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HE WAS BIG.

Not as big as Brannoc. Bigger than Lex. Broad and heavy-shouldered and deep in the chest, in a coat of oiled leather patched with steel plates, scratched and dented and scorched. He had a pick over his shoulder. Not a war-pick. A miner's pick. Iron-headed, ash-hafted, the haft worn black and shiny with years of hands. His hair was cropped close. Grey-brown. His face was square and heavy and weathered. Lined round the eyes from squinting in the dark.

And he coughed.

That was the first thing Lex noticed about him. Before anything else. He coughed. A deep wet rattling cough that bent him over. That went on for a long time. That Lex had heard before. In a narrow stone house on Fennel Street in Highcrest, five years ago. Every winter of Wren's childhood.

Grey-lung.

The man straightened up. Wiped his mouth on the back of his hand. Spat, carefully, to one side, away from the hole.

And saw Lex.

And grinned.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Well*," he said. His voice was deep and rough, with a burr in it Lex didn't know. East. Far east. "*Well, well. Look who's come up the mountain.*"

The yard went quiet.

Lex felt it. Every head in the ring turning. Toward him. Toward the big man with the pick. Back and forth. The way a crowd turns at a fair when two bulls see each other across a field.

"*You know me*," said Lex.

"*Everyone knows you*." The man's grin widened. "*You're the smith. The Worldforger. The big lad with the gold in his eyes who went down to the bottom of the world and took the lid off.*" He spread his arms. The pick swung. "*Course I know you. There's a song about you. Three songs. One of them's filthy.*"

Somebody in the ring laughed. Then stopped.

"*I meant*," said Lex, "*you know me. Not the songs. Me.*"

The big man looked at him for a long moment. And the grin went somewhere else. Not gone. Just quieter.

"*Coldwater*," he said. "*Two summers back. The Stone in the square. You came through on a dragon with your brother and the scholar woman and stood at our Stone in the rain and put your hand on it.*" He was quiet. "*And four thousand of us went up. All at once. Like a mine-damp going off.*"

Lex remembered.

Not him. Not the man. He'd Unbound two hundred and sixty Stones by then. More. He couldn't remember the faces. But he remembered

Coldwater. A grey town in a grey valley in the far east of Vhessa, at the edge of the old Blightmarch, built round the mouths of mines. The rain. The black slag-heaps. The cough. Everyone in the square coughing.

Grey-lung. From the Gloam in the mines. From the breach in Vhessa.

His father's breach.

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"*Silas Hask*," said the big man. And held out his hand.

Lex took it.

It was like taking hold of a lump of granite. Hard. Rough. Callused in places Lex had never seen calluses. Scarred across the knuckles. A miner's hand. A hand that had swung a pick in the dark every day of its life.

"*I was a [Hewer]*," said Silas Hask. Still holding on. "*Common. Capped at twenty-four. Twenty-six years down the pits at Coldwater. My da before me. His da before him.*" His grip tightened. Not hard. Just enough. "*You know what a hewer does, smith?*"

"*He cuts the coal*."

"*He cuts the coal*." Hask nodded. "*At the face. In the dark. On his side, mostly, in a seam two foot high, with the roof creaking over him. Twelve hours a day. Till his back goes. Or his lungs. Or the roof.*" He let go of Lex's hand. "*My da's lungs went. My mam's. My little sister's. All three. In one winter. The year the grey came up out of the deep seams.*"

He coughed. Short. Into his fist.

"*Mine are going*," said Silas Hask. Matter-of-fact. "*Slower. I'm big. I've got more to go.*" He shrugged his heavy shoulders. "*Physic in Highcrest says three years. Maybe five.*"

He looked at Lex.

"*And then you came*," he said, "*and put your hand on the Stone.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED HIS STATUS.

Right there. In the inn yard. In front of everyone. The way people did now, sometimes, with no Wardens watching. The way a man might pull up his shirt in a tavern to show you the scar.

```
SILAS HASK
Class: DELVEBREAKER (Epic)
  (from HEWER, Common — Unbound)
Level 71
Growth: unbounded
Skills: FAULT-FINDER (Master 1)
  BREAK (Master 6)
  DEEP-SENSE (Expert 8)
  ENDURE (Grandmaster 3)
Title: [The Uncapped] (first)
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The ring of people murmured.

Lex read it. *Level 71*. Two summers. From twenty-four to seventy-one. He'd gone up nearly fifty levels in two years. More than Lex had in five.

Fault-Finder. He looked at that one twice.

"*You find the weak place*," said Lex slowly. "*In stone. In anything.*"

"*Every seam's got a fault*," said Hask. "*Every wall. Every roof. Every man.*" He tapped the pick on his shoulder. "*Find the fault, put the point in it, and the whole thing comes down. Twenty-six years in the dark, smith. You learn to feel where things are going to break.*"

He grinned.

"*Bit like what you do*," he said. "*With your little hammer. I heard. At the bottom of the world. You found the flaw in the old man's folding. And struck it. And the whole thing came apart.*"

He nodded at the black hole in the inn yard.

"*Same thing*," said Silas Hask. "*Just bigger.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Don't break the core*," said Lex.

The yard went silent.

Hask looked at him. His grin didn't move. But his eyes did. Something went still in them. Watchful. The way a miner's eyes go still when he hears the roof creak.

"*Say that again*," he said.

"*Don't break it.*" Lex didn't raise his voice. He turned. Slowly. So that he was speaking to all of them. The whole ring. Thirty, forty Uncapped, with their weapons and their bright hungry faces. "*The cores. In the Delves. The black stones at the bottom. Don't shatter them. Claim them. Take them*

whole. The net gives you less, I know. It's still a lot. It's still a level, maybe more."

"*And why*," said Hask, "*would we do that?*"

Lex looked at him.

"*Because they're alive*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMEONE LAUGHED.

A young man at the back of the ring. Thin. Sharp-faced. With a sword on his hip and a Saltreach accent. He laughed out loud and then looked round to see if anyone else was laughing.

Nobody was.

"*They're pieces of something*," said Lex. "*Something big. Something that's coming up under all of us. A Well. Like Flame, or Stone. The seventh one. The one that was starved.*" He looked round at their faces. "*The Delves are bits of it. Coming up ahead of it. Like—like bits of bark off a tree that's growing. And the cores are—*"

He didn't know how to say it.

The voice it borrowed. It's all right. It's still here. It's just somewhere else now.

"*When you break them*," said Lex, "*it hurts. The thing they came from. It feels it. My brother feels it.*" He looked at Hask. "*It's frightened. It's very young. It doesn't understand what's happening to it.*"

Silas Hask looked at him for a long, long time.

Then he looked down at the black hole at his feet.

"*Alive*," he said.

"*Yes.*"

"*A Well.*"

"*Yes.*"

Hask nodded slowly. Thoughtfully. He scratched his cropped grey-brown head.

"*So's coal*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX BLINKED.

"*Coal's alive*," said Silas Hask. "*Or it was. Trees. Ferns. Great big swamps full of them, a million years ago. My grandda used to say you could see the leaves in it, if you split it right. Little ferns. Pressed flat. In the black.*" He tapped the pick-handle against his palm. "*I've broken a lot of coal, smith. Twenty-six years. Every day. Never once asked it how it felt.*"

"*That's not the same—*"

"*Isn't it*?" Hask's voice didn't change. Calm. Rough. Reasonable. "*You stood in the Hall of Lanterns and told the Queen's council that the thing coming up is a starved Well and it's sorry and it needs a home.*" He smiled. "*Oh, yes. I heard. Everyone heard. It's all over Highcrest.*" His smile went thin. "*And there's a lady in a house on the Crown Terrace who says it's the Unmaker. Who says it ate worlds. Who says it'll eat ours.*"

The ring was very quiet.

"*I don't know who's right*," said Silas Hask. "*I'm a hewer. I don't know about Wells. I know about the dark. I know about seams. And I know that every time I go down one of these holes and come up with a black stone and put my pick through it, I go up three levels.*" He looked at Lex. "*And the cough gets a bit better.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He looked at the big man. At his heavy weathered face. At his scarred miner's hands. At the faint grey tinge round his lips that Lex had seen on Wren's mother, every winter.

"*Better*," he said.

"*Every level*." Hask coughed again. Short. Into his fist. And looked at it. "*VIT goes up. Health goes up. Every level, a bit more.*" He wiped his hand on his coat. "*Physic said three years. Maybe five.*" He looked at the black hole. "*I've been going down these since the first one opened. Six of them. Six cores. Eighteen levels.*" He shrugged. "*He says ten, now. Maybe more. If I keep going.*"

The inn yard was very quiet.

"*You took off my Ceiling, smith*," said Silas Hask. Quietly. Not angry. Not cruel. Just certain. The way a man is certain about the weight of a pick he's carried for twenty-six years. "*You stood at our Stone in the rain and gave*

four thousand people their lives back. My life back. You did that. I'll never forget it." He looked Lex in the eye. *"Don't you dare put a new one on."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT IN TOGETHER.

Lex hadn't wanted that. Neither had Hask. But there was one Delve and forty Uncapped standing round it, and nobody was going to let anybody else go first, and in the end it was Wren who settled it. Standing at the edge of the inn yard with her bow strung and her wind curling round her boots, saying *oh, for the Lady's sake, just all go in together and stop posturing, you look like a lot of cockerels*.

So they went in together.

Lex. And Hask, with his pick. And Hask's crew, five of them, hewers from Coldwater, every one Unbound at the same Stone in the same rain. A woman named Brigid with a hammer. Two brothers named Tull. An old man named Absalom, nearly sixty, with one eye and a lamp on his helmet. A boy named Kit who couldn't have been more than seventeen.

And Wren stayed at the top.

She stood at the edge of the black in the inn yard where the water-trough used to be. In her leathers. With her bow. And watched him step off the edge.

"Don't die," she said.

"I won't."

"And don't let him break it," said Wren. Very low. Just for him.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS A MIGHT-HAVE-BEEN again. The first floor.

Lex had half expected it. A long corridor. Black glass floor. Doors.

But not the same doors. These were mine-doors. Heavy timber, iron-banded, set into rock, with chalk marks on them. And behind each one, the sound of picks. Ringing. In the dark. And men coughing.

The Coldwater crew went very quiet.

"That's the Number Four," said the boy, Kit. Staring at a door. Very white. *"That's my da's seam. That's—I can hear him. That's his cough."*

"Don't touch it," said Lex.

"*He's dead*." Kit's voice cracked. "*He's been dead three years. And I can hear him.*"

"*It's a might-have-been*," said Lex. "*A door you didn't open. A life that didn't happen.*" He looked at the boy. "*The one where the grey never came up. Where he's still down there, cutting coal.*"

Kit stared at the door. With his hand half raised.

And Silas Hask put his big scarred hand on the boy's shoulder. And turned him round. Gently. Away from the door.

"*He'd still be coughing, lad*," said Hask. "*Grey or no grey. Coal-damp gets everyone in the end. You know that.*" He pushed him, gently, down the corridor. "*Walk on.*"

Kit walked on.

Lex looked at Hask.

Hask didn't look back.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE UNFINISHED CAME ON the second floor.

Lines. Charcoal-black lines on grey air. Lex had told them. All of them. On the way in. *Don't hit them. It goes through. Put your hand on them. Listen. Give them something to be.*

Hask had listened politely. And nodded. And said *right you are*.

And then the first one came out of the wall at him, a long sketch of something with too many legs, like a centipede drawn by a child, and he looked at it for exactly one breath with his miner's eyes narrowed—

And put the point of his pick into it. Precisely. At one spot. Behind the third pair of legs, where two lines crossed and didn't quite meet.

And it came apart.

Not into iron. Not into stone. Not into anything. Into *nothing*. The lines just—unravelled. Like a knitted sock when you pull the right thread. Fell apart into loose black squiggles on the grey air. And faded. And were gone.

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THE UNFINISHED (crawler): UNMADE
+2,100 XP
```

"*Fault*," said Silas Hask. Mildly. "*Every pattern's got one. Even the ones that aren't finished.*" He looked at Lex. "*Specially the ones that aren't finished. They're all fault, near enough.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DID IT HIS way, mostly.

Lex couldn't stop them. He tried. He went ahead and caught the Unfinished before Hask's crew could reach them, and put his hand on them, and listened, and finished them. A small stone dog. An iron hare. A thing that wanted to be a bird made of wind, which he couldn't do without Wren, and had to let go. They sat down on the black glass floor behind him. Done. Patient.

But there were too many. And the Coldwater crew were fast. And Hask was faster.

Fault. Point. Pull. Gone.

Fault. Point. Pull. Gone.

He was very good. Lex had to admit it. He'd seen a lot of fighters. Garrick. Elowen. Teodra Hale. Kestrel, who fought like a bonfire. Antho, who fought like a held breath.

He'd never seen anyone fight like Silas Hask. Patiently. Without anger. Without hurry. Like a man at a coal-face, twelve hours into a shift, working a seam he'd worked a thousand times. Finding the place. Putting the point in. Moving on.

[He's not cruel,] said Ember. Quietly. Watching. *[Lex. He's not cruel. He doesn't enjoy it.]*

I know.

[He's just—working.]

I know, thought Lex. *That's what frightens me.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GUARDIAN WAS AT the bottom of the third floor.

A mine.

A real one. Or the shape of one. A long low gallery cut into black rock, with pit-props of grey timber holding up the roof, and a narrow-gauge rail running down the middle into the dark. And at the end of it, at the

coal-face, a man. Made of lines. Kneeling. Swinging a pick. Over and over. Into black that wasn't there.

And coughing.

The Coldwater crew stopped dead.

And Silas Hask, at the front, with his pick on his shoulder, stood very still in the mouth of the gallery and looked at the lined man kneeling at the face.

He knew who it was. Lex could see it. Everyone could see it.

"*Da*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T HIS FATHER. Lex knew that. It was a pattern. A sketch. A might-have-been, with the shape of Hask's father on it, because the Delve had reached into Hask's head and found the deepest door there and opened it.

The voice it borrowed.

The lined man at the coal-face stopped swinging. And put down his pick. And turned round. Slowly. On his knees. In the low gallery. And looked at his son.

And from inside the lines came a cough. Deep and wet and rattling. And under it, small and frightened and young, so faint Lex barely heard it—

...sorry...

...didn't know...

...only borrowed...it's the only shape I found...

Silas Hask stood in the mouth of the gallery. And didn't move.

And then he did.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED DOWN THE gallery. Between the pit-props. Along the rail. Not fast. Not slow. The way a man walks down a seam at the start of a shift. His boots crunching on the black floor.

He stopped in front of the lined man.

And looked down at him. For a long time.

"*You're not him*," said Silas Hask.

The lined man looked up at him. With its loop-eyes. Coughing.

"*He's dead*," said Hask. "*He died in my arms. In the front room. In the winter. With the grey coming up out of his mouth like smoke.*" His voice didn't change. Calm. Rough. "*You're not him. You're a picture of him. Something drew him on the dark to get at me.*"

He lifted the pick.

"*Hask*," said Lex. "*Don't—*"

"*I know what you're going to say, smith*," said Silas Hask. Without turning round. "*Put my hand on it. Listen to it. Give it something to be.*" He looked at the lined man. "*I don't want to give it anything. I want it to stop wearing my da.*"

He found the fault.

Lex saw him find it. Saw the miner's eyes narrow and go still, the way they did, reading the lines. One place. Over the heart. Where two lines crossed and didn't meet.

He put the point in.

The lined man came apart. Gently. Like smoke. Like charcoal blown off a page. And the cough went with it.

And the gallery, and the pit-props, and the rail, and the coal-face.

And there was a round room. Small. Bare. Black glass.

And on the floor, in the middle, a pebble.

◆ ◆ ◆

CLAIM (core remains whole).

SHATTER (core destroyed; reward ×5).

Lex was moving before the panel finished. Across the room. Toward the pebble. He could hear it. Humming. Faint. Frightened. *Little light, little light*.

He was fast. He was a Worldforger, Tier IV, Level 91, with AGI eighty-six.

Silas Hask had been standing two feet from it.

He didn't hurry. He didn't need to. He looked down at the pebble at his feet. Black. Smooth. The size of a hen's egg.

"*Hask*!"

"*Sorry, smith*," said Silas Hask.

And brought the pick down.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT SHATTERED.

Like glass. Like a black glass bottle. Into a thousand pieces. That went up in smoke. Fine. Black. Hanging in the air.

And then down. Through the floor. Into the ground.

And Lex, standing three feet away with his hand out, felt it go.

Not the core. Not the smoke. Something else. Something on the other end of the smoke. A long way down. Something enormous and soft and young, rising slowly through the dark.

He felt it *flinch*.

The whole of it. All at once. The way a hand flinches off a hot stove. A great soft shudder, running through the dark under the world, from Thistledown to the Hollowmaw to the bottom of the deep. And a sound. Not a sound. A *feeling*. Coming up through the floor of the Delve, through the soles of his boots, through the Stone in him, through his chest—

A scream.

Small. High. Young. Like a child who's put its hand on something hot for the first time and doesn't understand why the world has turned on it.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN, THROUGH THE Bloodbond, the other thing.

Fifty miles away. North. At the top of a mountain. In a library full of books.

His brother. Falling.

Lex felt it like a blow to the chest. Felt Antho's knees go. Felt him hit the floor. Felt his hands come up to his head, both of them, clutching, the way they'd clutched in the cave, in the old days, when the Murmur was screaming. Felt his Clarity *drop*. Not far. Not to six. Not to nothing. But down. Hard. Like a stone down a well.

And felt, through his brother, through the Bloodbond, through the old place in the back of Antho's skull where the voice had lived for eight years—

The scream.

The same scream. Coming out of Antho's mouth.

◆ ◆ ◆

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CORE SHATTERED.
+190,000 XP
SILAS HASK — Level 71 → 74
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HASK LOOKED AT THE panel.

Then he looked at Lex.

Lex was on one knee on the black glass floor. With one hand flat on it. And the other pressed to his chest. Breathing hard. With his eyes wide and his face white and his fire up, all the way up, without his asking, so that the air round him shook and the black glass under his palm was starting, very slowly, to glow.

"*Smith*," said Silas Hask. "*What—*"

"*My brother*," said Lex.

He couldn't say anything else.

He could still hear it. Through the Bloodbond. Fifty miles off. Antho on the floor of the library. Seraphine's voice. Calling his name. And under it, coming out of his brother's mouth, small and high and young and terrible—

...why...

...why...why...I didn't...I didn't do anything...

...it HURTS...

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DELVE FOLDED UP round them. Softly. Like a flower at dusk.

And then they were in the inn yard at Thistledown. In the thin spring afternoon. With the cracked cobbles and the ring of Uncapped staring and Wren at the edge of where the hole had been, with an arrow on her string and her face white.

Lex was still on one knee.

He got up. Slowly. And turned round.

Silas Hask was standing behind him. With his pick on his shoulder. And a new panel fading over his head. *Level 74*.

He wasn't smiling.

He was looking at Lex's face. At whatever was in it. And his own heavy weathered face was very still. Watchful. The way a miner's face goes when he hears the roof creak, and doesn't know yet which way it's going to fall.

"*You felt that*," said Lex.

Hask didn't answer.

"*You felt it*," said Lex. "*When you broke it. I saw your face. You felt it.*"

Silas Hask was quiet for a long moment.

"*I felt something*," he said at last. Slowly. "*I always do. Every one.*" He looked down at the cracked cobbles where the hole had been. "*Like a seam settling. After you take the coal out. A sort of—groan. In the rock.*" He shrugged. "*Rock groans, smith. When you take something out of it. That's all.*"

"*That wasn't rock*."

Hask looked up.

"*No*," he said. Quietly. "*Maybe not.*"

He coughed. Into his fist. And looked at his hand. Lex looked too.

There was less grey on it. Not much less. A little.

Silas Hask closed his hand.

"*I'm sorry about your brother*," he said. And he sounded as if he meant it. "*I am. Truly.*" He settled the pick on his shoulder. "*But I've got ten years now, smith. Maybe more. Instead of three.*" He looked at Lex. "*Ask me to give that back. Go on. Ask me.*"

Lex didn't ask.

He couldn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK TURNED. AND WHISTLED. Two notes. And the Coldwater crew came to him. Brigid and the Tulls and old Absalom with his helmet-lamp and Kit, the boy, white-faced, who wouldn't look at Lex.

They walked out of the inn yard. Down the mountain road. Toward the next pin on someone's map.

Lex watched them go.

And just before they turned the corner by the market cross, he saw it. Small. Grey-gold. Settling on Silas Hask's broad patched shoulder, on the steel plate over his collarbone, the way a leaf settles on a stream.

A moth.

It sat there. Wings spread. Glittering in the thin spring sun.

And Silas Hask didn't brush it off.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WAS BESIDE HIM. With her hand on his arm.

"*Antho*," said Lex. Hoarsely. "*Wren. It's Antho. He's—*"

"*I know*." Her face was white. "*I heard it. In the wind. Something screamed. The whole mountain heard it.*" She was already pulling at him. Toward the stable. Toward the road. "*Come on. Come on. Ashka's at the Keep. We'll take horses to the—*"

She stopped.

Because the sky over Thistledown had gone dark. And there was wind. And thunder. And something vast and blue and furious coming down out of the north over the shoulder of the Greyspine, with lightning crackling round its horns.

Not Ashka.

Vharuun. The storm-mother. Ashka's mother. Vast as a storm-cloud. Coming down onto the slope above Thistledown in a rush of wind that flattened every roof-thatch in the village. And lowering her great head. And looking at Lex with one enormous golden eye.

And in it, through the Bloodbond, through the dragon, through the long cold miles from the Hollowmaw, an image. One. Very clear.

A library. Books. Lamplight. And on the floor, among scattered pages, a man in a black coat, curled up on his side, with his hands over his ears. And a woman with spectacles kneeling over him, holding his head in her lap.

And from his mouth, over and over, in a voice that wasn't his—

...it HURTS...

...brother, it HURTS...

...make them STOP...

CHAPTER 10

The Ferryman's Keeping

IT HAD FELT LIKE the first night.

That was what Antho told his brother, afterward, lying on the cot in the library with a cold cloth on his forehead and Seraphine's hand in his and Lex sitting on the floor beside him, still in his Thistledown dust, with dragon-wind in his hair. It had felt like the first night. The night of his Kindling. Sixteen years old. With his hand on the Ashbourne Stone and the Stone *screaming* and flashing black, and something coming in through the crack in him like water through a broken dam.

Not the same. Not that bad. Nothing would ever be that bad again.

But the same *shape*.

He'd been at the long table. Reading. A Founders' record about the old Wells, in a hand so crabbed he'd had to hold it up to the lamp. Seraphine had been at the other end, with her map and her pins. Pim had been under the table, with a cat. It had been very quiet. A spring evening. The best kind of quiet.

And then something fifty miles south had *broken*.

He'd felt it go. Not heard. Felt. Like a bone snapping somewhere in his own body. And then the thing under the world, the vast soft young thing that had been pressing against his door for two months, had *flinched*. All of it. At once. And the flinch had come up through the door and through the floor and through the Threshold and through the old place in the back of his skull where the Murmur used to live—

And it had screamed.

And he'd screamed with it. He hadn't been able to help it. It had come out of his mouth the way it used to. In the old days. In the cave. In a voice that wasn't his.

It HURTS.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Your Clarity dropped to seventy-one*," said Seraphine.

She said it the way she said everything. Precisely. Holding his hand very tight.

"*I counted*," she said. "*I watched your panel. It went down like a stone. Ninety-eight. Ninety. Eighty-two. Seventy-one.*" Her voice shook. Just a little. "*And then it stopped. And then it started to come back.*"

"*It's back to ninety-four*," said Antho. "*I can feel it.*"

"*I know. I'm still watching.*"

He looked at her. At her spectacles, crooked. At the ink on her nose. At the line between her eyebrows, which was very deep.

"*It wasn't the Murmur*," he said. "*Seraphine. It wasn't—it wasn't trying to get in. It wasn't trying to use me. It was just—*" He didn't know how to say it. "*It was just screaming. And I was the nearest thing with a mouth.*"

"*I know*," said Seraphine. "*I know, love. I know.*"

She didn't let go of his hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TOLD HIM ABOUT Silas Hask.

All of it. Sitting on the library floor with his back against the cot and his big scarred hands hanging between his knees. The inn yard. The grey-lung. Coldwater. Four thousand people going up like mine-damp. The pick. The fault. *You took off my Ceiling, smith. Don't you dare put a new one on.*

The moth on his shoulder.

Antho listened with his eyes shut.

"*He's not wrong*," he said, when Lex had finished.

"*I know he's not wrong.*"

"*That's the trouble*," said Antho. "*Isn't it. He's not wrong. He's dying and it makes him live. He's poor and it makes him strong. He's been capped his whole life and now he isn't.*" He opened his eyes. "*And every time he goes up, it screams.*"

They were quiet for a while.

"*I need to know what it is*," said Antho. "*Properly. Not what Seraphine's books say. Not what Malachi's notes say. Not what she says.*" He didn't need to say who *she* was. "*I need to know from someone who was there.*"

"*Who was there*?" said Lex. "*Nine hundred years ago? Everyone's dead. Malachi's dead. Aurelian's dead. The only person who was there is—*"

He stopped.

Antho looked at him.

"*No*," said Lex. "*Not her.*"

"*Not her*," Antho agreed. He sat up. Slowly. The cold cloth fell off his forehead into his lap. "*Someone else. Someone who was there before her. Before the pool. Before the Wells. Before the world.*"

He looked at the window. The narrow slit window high in the library wall. West.

"*Someone who's been here since before the world was made*," said Antho Vey. "*And will be here when it's gone.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T GO ALONE.

He'd thought about it. Lying on the cot that night, after Lex had gone to sleep on the library floor and Seraphine had gone to sleep in the chair with her head on his chest. He'd thought, *I could go now. On Ashka. Before anyone wakes up. Be there and back in four days.*

He'd thought it the way you think about an old road you used to walk every day. Without meaning to. Your feet just start going that way.

He made them stop.

I'm trying, he'd told his brother. *I'm trying very hard to be the kind of man who doesn't carry things alone.*

So in the morning, at breakfast, in the kitchen of the Lantern Keep, with porridge and Odile's terrible tea and Lex half asleep over a bowl and Seraphine reading a letter from Highcrest, he put down his spoon and said, out loud, to everyone: "*I'm going to see the Ferryman.*"

The kitchen went quiet.

"*Today*," said Antho. "*On Ashka. West past the Teeth. Four days. Maybe five.*" He looked at his brother. "*I'm telling you before I go. Not after. Not from the road. Before.*"

Lex looked at him for a long moment.

Then he nodded. Once.

"*Who's going with you*?" he said.

Antho opened his mouth.

And Pim, at the end of the table, with porridge on his chin, put down his spoon. And got up. And went and stood beside Antho's chair. In his blue coat with the brass buttons.

And didn't say anything at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FLEW WEST IN the morning.

Over the Teeth. The great jagged white peaks at the western end of the Greyspine, where the mountains rose highest and sharpest, like the jaw of something buried under the world. Ashka climbed and climbed, beating hard in the thin cold air, until the snowfields were blinding below them and the wind cut like glass and Pim, wrapped in two coats and a blanket in front of Antho in the saddle, had his face buried in the dragon's neck.

And then down. The other side. West.

Into the thinned.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS DIFFERENT.

Antho had come this way twice before. Two years ago, alone, walking, with Ashka limping beside him, looking for a grey river and a man who took payment in memories. And a year and a half ago, at the very end, coming back from the Heart with everyone, on dragons, too tired to look.

Two years ago it had been grey.

All of it. The land west of the Teeth. Grey grass. Grey trees. Grey sky. A grey that wasn't a color, that was the *absence* of color, the way the world looks just before you faint. The further west you went, the thinner it got. Things lost their edges. Their weight. You could put your hand through a tree, almost, if you pushed. The ground under your feet felt like wet paper. The world, Malachi had said, was worn through there. Like the elbow of

an old coat. Like a place where the Tithe had been drawing off the world for so long that there was hardly any world left.

It wasn't grey now.

Not all of it. Not as much. As Ashka came down out of the mountains into the long low hills west of the Teeth, Antho saw green. Faint. Patchy. Like the first green on a field in early spring, when you can't tell if it's grass or wishful thinking. But green. On the hills. In the hollows. Along the streams.

And the streams had *sound*.

He hadn't noticed, two years ago. That the water here didn't make a noise. That it slid over its stones without a murmur, like a thing too tired to talk. He noticed now. Because it was talking. Small. Faint. A chuckle over a shallow. A gurgle round a root.

"*It's coming back*," said Antho. Out loud. To no one.

Pim lifted his head out of Ashka's neck. And looked down at the faint green hills. With his grey-violet eyes very wide.

"*Since the Tithe stopped*," said Antho. "*The world's been worn through here for nine hundred years. And now it's—*" He didn't have the word.

"*Healing*," said Pim.

Antho looked down at him.

Pim didn't look round. He was staring at the hills.

"*Like a scab*," said Pim. "*Under. Where the new skin comes.*" He touched his own elbow. Where there was an old white scar. From Kessick. From the man who'd tried to beat the voices out of him. "*It itches.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RIVER WAS SILVER.

Antho saw it from a long way off. From the top of the last hill. A line across the bottom of the long valley, running north to south, wide and flat and slow. Two years ago it had been grey. The grey of slate. The grey of a dead man's face. *The Tithe runs through it*, the Ferryman had said. *Every thread cut, every mana taken. It runs through my water. It makes it heavy.*

It was silver now.

Clear. Bright. Catching the light. With the sky in it.

And on the near bank, on the grey shingle at the water's edge, a long flat boat. Grey. Low. Like an eel-fisher's punt.

And beside it, leaning on a long pole, a tall thin figure in grey robes.

On top of the pole, a lantern.

Lit.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN TURNED HIS head as they came down the shingle.

He had no eyes. Antho had known that. He'd stood in front of this face twice before. It still made his stomach turn over, every time. Not because it was frightening. It wasn't, exactly. It was a long thin face, grey, smooth, old as river-stones. With a mouth, and a nose, and where the eyes should be, nothing. Not holes. Not scars. Just smooth grey skin. As if no one had ever thought to put eyes there. As if he'd never needed them.

"*Anthoren Vey*," said the Ferryman.

"*Ferryman*."

"*You skipped it again*." The eyeless face turned toward him. Slowly. "*The stone. On the lake past the Teeth. Last summer. Five times.*" A pause. "*I felt it. In the water. All lakes are my water, a little.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

He'd been fifteen. With a small boy beside him, on a riverbank, on a summer evening. *Low, low, like you're trying to make it fly under a door*. The stone had skipped five times. He'd told his brother it was four. And years later, under the stars, he'd told him the truth.

He'd paid that memory to this river. Two years ago. To cross. It was gone. A warm empty hollow where it used to be. He'd only seen it once more. From the river's side. Through the water. On the way to the Heart.

And then last summer, at the lake past the Teeth, he'd picked up a flat grey stone and thrown it. Low. Like he was trying to make it fly under a door.

And it had skipped five times. And he'd counted.

"*I'm glad*," said the Ferryman. "*It was a good memory. I've kept it very carefully.*" His long grey hand moved on his pole. "*It is still here. In the river. If you ever want to look again.*"

"*I know*," said Antho. "*Thank you.*"

The eyeless face turned. Away from him. Down. To the small figure beside him in a blue coat with brass buttons.

"*And who*," said the Ferryman, "*is this?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM DIDN'T HIDE.

Antho had thought he might. Pim hid from everything new. Strangers. Dragons. Loud noises. The first time Lex came to the Keep, Pim had spent three days in the cold-room with the bats.

He didn't hide from the Ferryman.

He stood on the grey shingle at the edge of the silver river in his blue coat and looked up into the tall grey eyeless face. Steadily. With his grey-violet eyes.

And was silent.

Not the way he was usually silent. The *other* way. The deep way. The way he'd been silent in the middle of the moths at the Keep. A place in him where nothing was. Where nothing had been allowed to be.

The Ferryman went very still.

For a long time. Longer than Antho had ever seen him be still, and he was the stillest thing Antho had ever seen.

"*Oh*," said the Ferryman at last. Very softly. "*Oh, little one. They hurt you very badly, didn't they.*"

Pim didn't answer.

"*And you made a room*," said the Ferryman. "*Inside. Where it couldn't reach. And you went into it. And you've been sitting in it ever since.*" The eyeless face bent lower. "*And it's grown. Your room. Hasn't it. Bigger than you. Bigger than the hurt.*"

Pim's mouth trembled.

"*That's the seventh*," said the Ferryman. "*That's what you've got. Did you know? A little piece of it. Of the room in the middle. You made it yourself. Out of nothing. Out of being hurt.*" His long grey hand came up. And stopped. In the air. An inch from Pim's face. Not touching. "*No wonder the moths won't go near you. There's nothing in you for them to drink. You've made yourself into a room with the lamp out.*"

Pim stood very still.

And then, very slowly, he reached up. And took hold of the Ferryman's long grey fingers. In his small thin hand.

And held them.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You came to ask me something*," said the Ferryman.

He was sitting in his boat. On the bench at the stern. With his pole across his knees and his lantern at his feet, burning. Antho sat on the shingle in front of him. Pim sat in the boat. In the bow. With his knees pulled up and his chin on them, looking at the river.

The Ferryman hadn't said anything about Pim getting into the boat. He'd just moved his pole so the boy had room.

"*Yes*," said Antho.

"*Ask, then*."

Antho looked at the river. Silver. Slow. Wide. The far bank was there now. He could see it. Two years ago there'd been nothing on the far side. Just grey. Just mist. The far shore of the dead.

There were hills on the far side now. Low. Faint. Green, a little.

"*What's coming up*?" said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN WAS QUIET for a long time.

"*The seventh*," he said at last. "*The one in the middle.*"

"*The Hollow*."

"*That's what your Founders called it*." The eyeless face turned toward the river. "*It had other names. Before. Older ones. The Room. The Cup. The First Quiet. The place before a thing.*" A pause. "*It was very small, when I first knew it. Smaller than the others. Flame was a great wild roaring thing even then. Stone was older than anything. Tide and Gale were everywhere. Radiance and Shade went on forever.*" His long hand moved on his pole. "*The seventh was only a little pool. In a valley. In the middle of everything. Very still. Very dark. Very deep.*"

"*What did it do*?"

"*It made room*."

The Ferryman was quiet again.

"*When a new thing came into the world*," he said, "*a new spring, a new kind of bird, a new child, it came through the seventh. Through the room in the middle. That's what it was for. It was the door new things came in by.*" He tilted his head. "*Without it, nothing new. Only the old things, going round and round. Fire burning. Water running. Stone sitting. The same, forever.*"

He looked toward Antho with his eyeless face.

"*They built a palace over it*," said the Ferryman. "*The sorcerer-kings. They found the pool, and they built a hall of glass round it, and they knelt at the edge of it, and they drank.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How many*?" said Antho.

"*Nine*."

"*She said nine*."

"*She told the truth*." The Ferryman's voice didn't change. "*She always does. That is her art. She has never needed to lie. She only needs to choose where to stand.*"

Antho went very still.

"*Nine*," said the Ferryman. "*Nine crowns. The eldest found it. The Gilded King. Oszric. He drank first. And then he brought his brothers and his sisters, and they drank. And then they brought their households. A little each. From their own cupped hands.*"

"*And it went dry*."

"*It went dry*." The Ferryman looked at the river. "*It was only a little pool. It was never meant to be drunk. It was meant to be a door. They drank the door.*" He was quiet. "*And what was left, when the water was gone, was the shape of the water. The hollow where it had been. Empty. And an empty room wants to be filled. That is what a room is for.*"

"*The hunger*," said Antho.

"*The hunger*." The Ferryman nodded slowly. "*It began to pull. At everything. To fill itself. Fire and stone and water and wind. People. Worlds.*" He looked toward the far bank. "*There were other worlds then. Near this one. Like boats moored side by side. It pulled them in. One by one.*

It couldn't help it. It was the shape of a room with nothing in it, and it was trying to stop being empty."

Antho thought of the Forbidden Lands. At the bottom of the deep. Eaten worlds, drifting. Grey. Endless.

"*And the Founders caught it*."

"*Aurelian caught it. And his brothers and sisters.*" The Ferryman's voice was very quiet. "*They wove the net over the world, and they put a lid on the hunger, and they fed it the Tithe to keep it quiet. And Aurelian sat on the lid. For nine hundred years. Holding it.*" A pause. "*You know the rest. You were there at the end of it.*"

"*And the Nine*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN DIDN'T ANSWER for a long time.

The river ran past. Silver. Slow. The lantern on the end of his pole swung gently in the wind off the water.

"*I carried them*," he said.

Antho stared at him.

"*Out*," said the Ferryman. "*Past the edge. Past the place where the net was tied off. Into the grey country beyond.*" His long hands lay still on his pole. "*Aurelian came to my shore. With the Nine. In chains. Not iron chains. Net. Woven. Threads of the net he'd made, round their wrists and ankles.*" He was quiet. "*He asked me to take them across. Out of the world. Where they couldn't drink anything ever again.*"

"*And you did*."

"*He paid*." The eyeless face turned toward Antho. "*Everyone pays. That is the river's law.*"

"*What did he pay*?"

The Ferryman was silent for a very long time.

"*His sleep*," he said at last.

Antho didn't understand.

"*He never slept again*," said the Ferryman. "*From that night. Nine hundred years. He sat on the lid and held the hunger and never once closed his eyes.*" A pause. "*I think that is why it ate him, in the end. A man who*

never sleeps has no door to go back through. No room to rest in. He was all holding and no letting go."

Antho thought of an old man at a gold anvil at the bottom of the world. Curled up. Holding a little hammer. *I'm the flaw.*

He couldn't say anything.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Four of them came apart*," said the Ferryman. "*Against the edge. When I pushed them through. The net was very tight, then. New. It didn't like them.*" He looked at the river. "*Four came apart into dust. Five went through.*"

"*Five*."

"*The Gilded King. The Glass Queen. The Iron Crown. The one with thorns, whose name they don't say.*" The Ferryman paused. "*And the Moth.*"

"*Maelis*."

"*Maelis*." The eyeless face was turned toward the water. "*She sat in the bow of my boat. Where your boy is sitting now. The whole way out. With her lit eyes. Looking back.*" He was quiet. "*Not at the world. At the lights in the world. Every lamp. Every window. Every fire. She looked back at them the whole way across, the way a starving child looks back at a bakery window.*"

He turned his face toward Antho.

"*She came to my shore three nights ago*."

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WAS ON HIS feet.

He didn't remember standing. He was standing on the grey shingle with the Lantern in his hand and his heart going like a drum, staring at the tall grey figure in the boat.

"*Here*?"

"*Here*." The Ferryman didn't move. "*At midnight. Walking. Leaving no tracks.*" He tilted his head. "*She asked me very politely to take her down. To the deep. To the bottom of the river, where it runs into the dark under the world.*" A pause. "*She said she wanted to meet the little one. Before it reached the light. She said she had something to say to it.*"

"*And*?"

"*I said no*."

The Ferryman's voice was very quiet. And very cold. Colder than Antho had ever heard it. Cold as the river had been, two years ago, when it ran grey with the Tithe.

"*I don't carry the Crowned*," said the Ferryman. "*Not down. Not ever again. I carried them out once. I was paid for it. I have kept that payment nine hundred years.*" His long hands tightened on his pole. "*I will not carry her to the thing she drank. Not for any price.*"

Antho breathed out.

"*She laughed*," said the Ferryman. "*She has a lovely laugh. She thanked me. She said she quite understood. She said there were other ways down.*"

He turned his eyeless face toward Antho.

"*Every time a Delve opens*," said the Ferryman, "*there is a way down. From the world to the deep. A hole. A thread of the little one, reaching up toward the light.*" A pause. "*When the core is claimed, the hole closes. Softly. The thread draws back. Like a hand drawn back from a flame.*"

Antho felt his stomach go cold.

"*And when the core is broken*," said the Ferryman, "*the thread snaps. And the hole stays open. A wound. A shaft. Straight down. All the way to the little one.*" He was quiet. "*Twenty-three, so far. I can feel them. Like splinters in the river.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

Twenty-three.

Antho thought of Seraphine's map. Forty-one black pins. And the Uncapped. Thousands of them. With picks and belaying pins and bright hungry faces. Breaking cores in tavern cellars and inn yards. Going up three levels in a breath.

And a moth. Grey-gold. Settling on Silas Hask's broad patched shoulder. And Silas Hask not brushing it off.

"*She's using them*," said Antho. "*The Uncapped. She's—she doesn't need to break the cores herself. She just needs someone else to. And then she walks down the hole.*"

"*Yes*," said the Ferryman.

"*Does Hask know*?"

"*I don't know who that is.*" The eyeless face turned toward him. "*But I know her. She doesn't need anyone to know. She only needs them to want.*" A pause. "*That is what a moth is, Anthoren Vey. It doesn't break the window. It waits for someone to open it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE ASKED THE LAST thing at dusk.

He hadn't meant to. He'd meant to go. He'd got what he came for. More. He should be on Ashka already, beating east over the Teeth, to tell Lex. To tell Seraphine. To tell the Queen.

But the sun was going down over the far bank, red and gold on the silver river, and the lantern on the Ferryman's pole was glowing brighter as the light went, and Pim was asleep in the bow of the boat with his head on his arms. And Antho sat on the grey shingle and looked at the tall eyeless figure in the stern, and the question came up out of him before he could stop it.

"*My mother paid you*," he said.

The Ferryman didn't move.

"*Thirteen years ago*," said Antho. "*The first winter. To cross back. To come home. She paid you the memory she'd least wish to lose.*" He swallowed. "*She paid you my father.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*All of him.*"

"*All of him.*" The Ferryman's voice was very quiet. "*Every day. Every word. The steps of the Spire in the rain. The first time he laughed. The night your brother was born. Everything.*" He was silent for a moment. "*I told you once she paid more than anyone has ever paid me. I meant it. Most people pay one memory. She paid a man.*"

"*And then she didn't cross.*"

"*She crossed.*" The eyeless face turned toward him. "*She stood on this shore. On the world's side. With the way home in front of her.*" A pause. "*And she heard you. Far off. Over the mountains. At the Hollowmaw. Sixteen years old, in the cold, with the dark coming through the crack you'd torn. Screaming.*" The Ferryman was quiet. "*And she turned round. And*

walked back down my shingle. Into the dark. To hold it shut from the other side."

Antho couldn't breathe.

"*She paid*," said the Ferryman. "*She didn't get what she paid for. I don't give refunds. The river takes what it's owed.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Can she have it back*?"

It came out of Antho in a rush. Hoarse. Too loud. Pim stirred in the bow and didn't wake.

"*My father*," said Antho. "*Her memories of him. Can she have them back? If someone pays? If—*"

"*An equal price*," said the Ferryman.

"*What's equal*?"

The Ferryman was quiet for a long time.

"*A love for a love*," he said at last. "*That is the only thing that weighs the same.*" He turned his face toward the east. Toward the Teeth. Toward the world. "*Someone would have to pay me all their memories of someone they loved as much as she loved him. Every day. Every word. The whole person.*" A pause. "*And then I would give her back hers.*"

Antho stared at him.

"*Your father has thought of it*," said the Ferryman. Quietly. "*I know he has. He'll come to my shore. Before long.*" The eyeless face didn't change. "*Old men always do.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FLEW EAST THROUGH the night.

He didn't stop. He didn't sleep. He sat in the saddle with Pim asleep against his chest and the Lantern hanging from the pommel and the wind in his face, and Ashka beat up and over the Teeth in the dark and down the other side, and the stars went round.

He'll come to my shore. Before long. Old men always do.

A love for a love.

Someone would have to pay me all their memories of someone they loved as much as she loved him.

Your father has thought of it.

He thought about his father. In the library. At the long table. With his white temples and his brown-spotted hands. Saying *I've been counting*.

He thought about his father saying *good evening* to a little clay lamp. Every night. For a year and a half. For a woman who didn't know who he was.

He thought: *he would*.

He'd do it. He'd go down to that shore and give the Ferryman every memory he has of her. Every one. The steps of the Spire and the rain and the night Lex was born. So she could have hers back. So she'd come home and know him.

And he'd stand in front of her and not know who she was.

Antho put his face down against Pim's hair and held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN ONTO the slope of the Hollowmaw at dawn.

The Keep was quiet. Too quiet. The cave mouth was a dark arch in the grey morning. No one on Pim's rock. No smoke from the kitchen chimney.

And then Odile came running out of it.

She was white. In her nightgown. Barefoot. In the snow. She'd never run in her life, not that Antho had seen. Odile walked. Carefully. Like a scholar. Like a Shade-Listener.

She came down the slope at a run and grabbed Ashka's bridle before the dragon had folded her wings and looked up at Antho with her dark eyes enormous.

"*Master Antho*," she said. "*It's your father.*"

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HE WAS AT THE door.

At the bottom of the long passage. In the bell-shaped cavern. On the black floor in front of the black glass door. Where he'd gone, at midnight, the way he always went, with his copper oil-flask, to fill the lamps.

He was lying on his side. With the flask spilled beside him. And his hand stretched out toward the niche. Toward the three lamps.

Seraphine was kneeling beside him. With his head in her lap. And Lex was there, on his other side, with Wren, and Lex's face was grey.

Antho stopped in the mouth of the cavern.

He couldn't go any further.

His father opened his eyes.

Grey. Steady. The same grey as Antho's. In a face that was—

Old.

Not fifty-eight. Not sixty. Old. The face of a man of seventy. More. The lines had gone deep, deep as plough-furrows, across his forehead and down his cheeks and round his mouth. His hair was white. All of it. Not white at the temples. White. Thin. Fine as thistledown. His hands, on the black floor, were all knuckle and bone and brown spots, and they shook.

He'd been sixty, four days ago. When Antho left for the Ferryman.

"*Antho*," said Arion Vey. His voice was thin. Cracked. An old man's voice. But it was his. "*You're back.*"

Antho came across the floor. And knelt. And took his father's shaking hand.

"*What happened*?"

"*I came down to fill the lamps*." His father smiled. A little. "*And I bent down. To the niche. And I couldn't get up again.*" He looked at his own hand, in Antho's. "*I think I've got the numbers now. I think I can tell you.*"

"*Tell me*."

"*Ten years*," said Arion Vey. "*Last night. In one night.*" He looked up at his son. "*It's not slowing down, Antho. It's speeding up.*"

He was quiet for a moment.

"*Two hundred years*," he said. "*The Root held them back for two hundred years. Like a dam. And I took the dam away.*" His thin old fingers tightened on Antho's. "*And now the water's coming. All of it. All at once.*"

Beside him, in the niche, the three lamps burned. Small and gold and steady.

And the clay one leaned. Very slightly. Toward the door.

As if someone a long way off, walking up out of the deep, had stopped. And turned. And was listening.

CHAPTER 11

Borrowed Years

ARION VEY HAD KEPT records all his life.

It was the Warden in him. Or the scholar. Or simply the man. Two hundred and thirty-three years of ledgers. Of lists. Of small neat columns of figures in small neat handwriting, in books bound in grey cloth that filled three shelves of the secret room in the Spire, behind the portraits. Weather. Harvests. The price of bread in Highcrest in every year of nine kings. The number of children Kindled at every Stone in Caldor, and their classes, and their Ceilings. The day each of his sons was born, and the hour, and how long Seren had laboured, and what she'd said, which was not repeatable.

He'd kept a record of himself, too. Not much of one. There'd never been much to record. Two hundred years of the same face in the same mirror. *No change*, he'd written, once a year, on his birthday, at midwinter. *No change. No change. No change.* Two hundred lines of it. Like a man writing the same word over and over until it stops meaning anything.

He'd started a new book the morning after the wedding.

Grey cloth. Like the others. And on the first page, in his small neat hand: *Hairs, white: 20. Lines, eyes: 4 each side. Lines, mouth: 2. Grip (right): firm. Grip (left): firm. Stairs to the cave mouth: 211 steps, no rest.*

He had filled forty pages since.

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"*Ten years*," said Arion. "*In one night. I think.*"

He was sitting in the big chair at the head of the long table in the library of the Lantern Keep. Wrapped in a blanket. With his grey book open in front of him and his spectacles on his nose. He hadn't needed spectacles a week ago. He did now. Seraphine had given him a spare pair, and he'd put them on, and the world had come back into focus, and he'd laughed out loud. *So this is what it's like*, he'd said. *Everyone else has been doing this for nine hundred years.*

His sons were sitting on either side of the table. Lex on his left. Antho on his right. With their wives beside them. And Odile at the end, and Pim under the table with the cat, and Ivy Moss perched on a stool by the shelves with her crutch across her knees, very quiet, listening.

Nobody had said anything since he started.

"*I can't be certain*," said Arion. "*Not about the night. I was asleep for most of it, and then I was on the floor.*" He turned a page. "*But the record's quite clear. On the evening before last I was sixty-one, or near enough. Grey hair. Lines here and here. Grip firm. Stairs, two hundred and eleven, one rest.*" He looked at the next page. "*Yesterday morning I was seventy. Seventy-one, perhaps. White hair. Grip weak. Stairs—*" He smiled. Slightly. "*I didn't try the stairs. Lex carried me.*"

"*Father—*"

"*Let me finish*." Arion held up one thin hand. It shook. He looked at it with interest. "*Please. I've been waiting two hundred years to give this report. I'd like to give it properly.*"

Lex shut his mouth.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LAID IT OUT for them.

The way he'd lay out a report for the Queen's council. Calmly. In order. Without hurrying and without leaving anything out. He'd learned that, in two hundred years. That the worst news was easiest to hear when it was given plainly. When the person giving it wasn't afraid of it.

He wasn't afraid of it. That was the strange thing. He kept checking. The way you check a tooth with your tongue to see if it still hurts. He wasn't afraid.

The Root held me, he told them. *From the day I took it. Thirty-one years old, at the Great Stone, in my first year as a Warden-Architect. It held me the way a dam holds a river. It needed me. A Root has to have a holder, and Aurelian had already chosen his vessel, and it wasn't me, and so the net held on to me instead. As long as it needed me.*

Two hundred and two years.

And then my son reforged the net. And gave the Root away. And there was nothing to hold me anymore.

He looked at the grey book.

For the first year and a half, he said, *it came slowly. A grey hair. A line. A little stiffness in the morning. I was very happy. I thought, I'll have twenty years. Thirty. I'll grow old like an ordinary man.*

And then, after the wedding, it began to come faster.

He turned the pages. Showing them. Columns of numbers. Small and neat. Going down the pages like water down a slope.

A year a month, he said. *Then a year a fortnight. Then a year a week. And now—*

He put his finger on the last page.

Ten years in a night.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's a curve*," said Seraphine.

She was leaning forward. Over the book. With her own spectacles pushed up on her head and her eyes moving down the columns the way they moved down a page of Wellscript. Fast. Hungry. Her face had gone very pale.

"*It's not a line*," she said. "*It's a curve. It's getting steeper.*"

"*Yes*," said Arion.

"*Like water*," said Seraphine. "*When a dam breaks. It doesn't come out all at once. It comes out a little, at first. Through the crack. And the crack gets wider. And more comes through. And the crack gets wider still, and—*"

She stopped.

"*And then it all comes*," said Arion gently. "*Yes. That's what I think too.*"

"*How long*?" said Antho.

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THE LIBRARY WAS VERY quiet.

Arion looked at his elder son. Sitting on his right. With his long black hair tied back and his clear grey eyes, the same grey as Arion's own, fixed on him. Steady. Not looking away.

He always looks, thought Arion. *Even when it hurts. He's always looked. Since he was nine and sat on the kitchen table asking me why the stars didn't fall.*

"*I don't know exactly*," he said. "*I'm not good enough at mathematics. Seraphine is better.*"

"*Arion—*" said Seraphine.

"*I'd rather you said it*," said Arion. "*If you can. I'd rather hear it from you than work it out alone in the night.*"

Seraphine looked at him. For a long moment. Behind her spectacles her eyes were bright and wet.

Then she looked down at the book. And pulled it toward her. And took the pencil from behind her ear. And began, very quietly, to write.

Nobody said anything while she did it. Nobody moved. Even Pim, under the table, was still.

It took her four minutes.

She put the pencil down.

"*If it goes on like this*," said Seraphine Ilvane. Very steadily. Not looking up. "*If the curve doesn't change. If nothing changes.*" She swallowed. "*A season. Perhaps two. Into the autumn.*"

She looked up.

"*Not past Lantern Night*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD UP.

His chair went over behind him. He didn't notice. He stood at the long table with his big scarred hands flat on the wood and his face gone white and then red and then white again, and the air around him began to shake, and the lamps on the table flared, and the pages of the grey book stirred.

"*No*," said Lex.

"*Lex.*"

"*No. There's something—*" His hands were pressing into the table. Hard. The oak under them was beginning to smoke. "*There's something we can do. There has to be. There's always something. We went to the bottom of the world. We reforged the net. We—*"

"*We gave away the Root*," said Arion.

His son stopped.

"*You gave it away*," said Arion. Gently. "*At the Heart. I was there. I watched you. And Antho gave his. And I gave mine.*" He looked up at Lex. "*It was the right thing to do. It was the best thing anyone has done in nine hundred years. I'd do it again. I'd do it a thousand times.*"

"*If I hadn't—*"

"*If you hadn't*," said his father, "*I'd be forty-five forever. In a tower. Holding a net that held me. Watching everyone I love grow old and die.*" He held out his hand. Thin. Shaking. Brown-spotted. "*Lex. Look at me. Look at my hand.*"

Lex looked.

"*I'm old*," said Arion Vey. "*I've wanted this for two hundred years. I used to stand in front of the mirror in the Spire every morning and pray for a grey hair. One. Just one. So I'd know I was a man and not a—a fixture. A piece of furniture in the net.*" He smiled. "*I've got hundreds now. I've got so many I've stopped counting. Do you know what that's like? For me? To stop counting something?*"

His son's face crumpled.

He came round the table. And knelt. On the floor of the library. Beside his father's chair. And put his head down on his father's knees, on the blanket, the way he hadn't done since he was four. The night before the seal. With a horseshoe nail in his fist.

Arion put his thin old hand on his son's dark hair.

And held it there.

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HE WENT BACK TO Highcrest three days later.

They argued, of course. All of them. Even Pim, who came out from under the table and stood in front of the door of the library with his arms spread, small and fierce and silent, until Arion bent down, slowly, and

talked to him for a long time in a low voice, and Pim went away and sat on the stairs and cried.

You can barely walk, said Lex.

I can walk. I can't do stairs. Highcrest is flat.

Highcrest is built on a hill.

The castle has a lift. Lysandra put it in for her grandfather.

The Queen—

The Queen, said Arion, *has a woman in a house on the Crown Terrace telling her council that the thing my wife is bringing home is the Unmaker. And half her council is listening. And the woman knows things about my wife's family that my wife never told me. And she asked my son how he knew his mother's name.* He looked at Lex. *I'm the Queen's advisor. That's my work. It's the only work I have left that I'm any good at. I'm going to do it.*

He looked round at them.

I'm old, he said. *I'm not finished.*

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN CARRIED HIM.

The storm-mother came down onto the slope of the Hollowmaw at dawn, vast and blue and gentle, and lowered her head to the ground, and Lex lifted his father into a chair that Brannoc had made, the night before, with leather straps and a back and a little roof of oiled canvas against the rain, and strapped it to the dragon's neck between two great ridges of blue scale.

It's a throne, said Antho, looking at it.

It's a cart-seat, said Brannoc. Who had come up the mountain on purpose. Grumbling. *With straps.*

It's lovely, said Arion. And meant it.

Brannoc looked at him. The old smith. Sixty-three. Bald and soot-bearded and enormous. Who had punched him in the face, five years ago, *for Seren*, and then sat up all night drinking with him and given him her letter.

He was older than Arion now. Looked it. Just about.

Not for long.

"*Look after yourself*," said Brannoc Holt. Gruffly.

"*You too.*"

"*I'm going to outlive you*," said Brannoc. "*Did you think of that? Two hundred and thirty-three years, and I'm going to outlive you. A smith from Ashbourne.*" His beard twitched. "*Seren'd laugh.*"

"*Seren would laugh*," Arion agreed.

Brannoc looked at him for a moment longer. Then he reached up, with his enormous scarred hand, and took Arion's thin one. And held it. Hard. The way he'd held it at the bottom of a bottle in the back room of the Crooked Kettle.

"*Don't you dare*," said Brannoc. Very low. "*Don't you dare go before she gets home. You hear me? Not after all this. You hold on.*"

Arion didn't say anything.

He couldn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIGHCREST WAS DARK.

He'd known it would be. He'd been in the Hall of Lanterns when Lysandra gave the order. But knowing a thing and seeing it were different.

He came in at dusk. On Vharuun's neck, in Brannoc's chair, over the walls, with the city spread out below him going grey and then blue and then black. The city he'd lived in for two hundred years. Through nine kings and one Queen.

He'd never once seen it dark.

Not even in the long night under the lid, when the Key was turned and the world went black. Even then, Highcrest had lit candles. Thousands of them. In every window. *Against* the dark.

Now there was nothing. Black roofs. Black windows. The watch-fires on the walls. A few candles, here and there, behind thick curtains, the way people used to keep lights in the old days, in the plague years, so no one would see.

And on the north side, high up, on the Crown Terrace, a tall grey house. With Keepers on its doors.

And in one of its upper windows, very faint, a light.

Not a lamp. Not a candle.

Two lights. Small. Gold. Close together.

Looking out.

◆ ◆ ◆

LYSANDRA CAME TO SEE him that night.

In his rooms in the Spire. The ones he'd lived in for two hundred years. On the top floor, under the roof, with the long windows looking north over the city, and the shelves of grey books, and the narrow bed, and the tall bookcase that swung open, if you pulled the right book down, onto the little round room where all the portraits were.

She came alone. Without Elowen. In a plain cloak with the hood up. She came in without knocking, the way she had since she was nine and her grandfather had sent her to him for lessons in history and she'd sat on his floor and argued with him about the Treaty of Scald.

She stopped in the doorway.

And looked at him.

He was in the chair by the window. With a blanket on his knees and his grey book in his lap and his spectacles on. He'd been writing. *Stairs, Spire, ninety-four steps, lift to the sixth floor, four rests. Hands, cold. Eyes, tired.*

He looked up.

"*Majesty*," said Arion.

The Queen of Caldor stood in the doorway of his room with her hood up and her hand on the frame and looked at her old teacher. For a long time.

Then she came across the room. And knelt down in front of his chair. In her cloak. On the floor. The way she'd sat on his floor when she was nine.

"*Oh, Arion*," said Lysandra. Very softly.

"*I know*."

"*Oh, my dear*."

"*It's all right*," said Arion. "*I promise you. It's all right.*"

The Queen put her face in her hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD HIM ABOUT the council.

Later. When she'd stopped crying, and he'd made her tea, slowly, with his shaking hands, and she'd sat in the other chair by the window with her feet tucked under her and the cup in both hands, the way she'd sat at nine.

"*Harlowe's been to see her*," said Lysandra. "*Three times. And Cressa Moore. And half the old families on the north side. The ones who lost their Sanctions.*" She stared into her tea. "*She has a salon. In the dark. Every evening. They go and sit in her drawing room with the shutters closed and no candles, and she talks to them.*"

"*About what*?"

"*About what happens*," said the Queen, "*when people rise without limits.*"

Arion was quiet.

"*She's very good*," said Lysandra. "*She doesn't argue. She doesn't push. She just tells them stories. About the old kingdoms. Before the net. About what it was like when anyone could rise as high as they wanted.*" She turned the cup. "*About sorcerer-kings who were shepherds' sons. About wars between them that burned whole countries. About the Sundering.*" She looked up. "*About how the strong always rise. And how they always end up on top of the weak. And how nobody ever stops them.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then she says, of course, it's different now. You're wiser than we were. You'll manage it better.*" The Queen's mouth twisted. "*And everyone goes home and lies awake.*"

She set the cup down.

"*There's a man called Silas Hask*," she said. "*From Coldwater. A miner. Level seventy-four. In two years.*"

"*I know. Lex met him.*"

"*He's not the only one. There are eleven Uncapped over level sixty now. Fifty over fifty. Hundreds over forty.*" Lysandra looked out of the dark window. At the dark city. "*Arion, there are farm-boys in the Vale who are stronger than my knights. There are fishwives in the Saltreach who could take Elowen. There's a girl in the Sunreach, Ishara wrote, who Kindled last autumn as a [Sand-Dancer] and is level forty-one and has already killed two men in duels.*" She swallowed. "*And it's been a year and a half.*"

"*What do the people say*?"

"*The people*," said the Queen of Caldor, "*are delighted. The people are rising. The people have never been happier in their lives.*" She looked at him. "*It's the rest of us who are lying awake.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She wants me to accept her offer*," said Lysandra. "*The council does. Half of it. They want me to let her help us bind the thing that's coming up.*"

"*And you*?"

"*I want to know what you think*." She looked at him. "*I always want to know what you think. I've wanted to know what you think since I was nine years old and you told me the Treaty of Scald was a crime and I asked you why nobody had ever said so and you said* because nobody ever asked.*"*

Arion smiled.

"*I think she's lying*," he said.

"*About what*?"

"*I don't know yet*." He looked at the grey book in his lap. "*That's the trouble. Everything she's said is true. I've checked. Seraphine's checked. Ember's checked; Lex says it has the whole of my memory up to the seal, and it went through all of it, and couldn't find a single false word.*" He shook his head. "*She hasn't lied. Not once. But she's lying.*"

"*How can you tell*?"

He thought about it.

"*Because she sat on the floor*," said Arion Vey.

The Queen stared at him.

"*She sat on the floor*," said Arion. "*In the Hall of Lanterns. In front of the whole council. Lower than everyone. So nobody would forget who was asking.*" He looked at the dark window. "*I've been at court for two hundred years, Lysandra. Through nine kings. I've watched a great many people ask for things.*" He was quiet. "*The ones who sit on the floor are always the ones who want the throne.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT TO SEE her the next evening.

Alone. Lysandra didn't like it. Elowen liked it even less. Lex, when he heard, sent a raven from Ashbourne so furious that Quill had refused to carry it and a Keeper's bird had to be found.

He went anyway.

He was the Queen's advisor. He was two hundred and thirty-three years old. He'd spoken to every king and lord and High Warden in Caldor for two centuries, and to a hollow thing wearing his ancestor's face at the bottom of the world, and to a man who'd betrayed him at Fort Caldris and then died to save him at the Rift.

He wanted to look at her.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TALL GREY HOUSE on the Crown Terrace had been Varric Sorn's.

Arion had been inside it once before. A year and a half ago. On the night of the masks. When the Ceiling Party tried to take the throne and Isaura Kell tore Lampshades off people with her Inspection and a man in ash-grey put a Severance chain round Arion's own throat.

The ballroom was shut up now. The masks were gone. The Keepers at the door, four of them, in grey, looked at him with something close to horror as he came up the steps on a stick, slowly, one at a time, and one of them, a young woman, tried to take his arm.

"*Thank you*," said Arion. "*No.*"

He went in.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS IN THE drawing room.

It was dark. Of course it was. The shutters were closed. There were no candles. No lamps. No fire in the grate. Only the faint grey of the evening coming in round the edges of the shutters, and the dark furniture, and the dark pictures on the walls.

And two lights.

Small. Gold. Close together. In a high-backed chair by the cold fireplace.

"*Warden-Architect*," said Maelis. "*How lovely. Do sit down.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT DOWN.

There was a chair opposite hers. He found it in the dark with his stick, and lowered himself into it, slowly, an inch at a time, the way his knees let him. It took a long time. She didn't help. She didn't look away. She watched him do it with her lit eyes, the way you'd watch something precious being unwrapped.

"*You're older*," she said. When he was settled. "*Than in the Hall. A great deal older.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*How much*?"

"*Ten years. In one night.*"

She was quiet for a moment.

"*Oh*," said Maelis. Softly. "*Oh, I'm sorry. I truly am.*" And she sounded it. She sounded so sorry that something in his chest went warm and loose for a moment before he caught it and made it stop. "*The dam's broken. Hasn't it. The Root's gone, and the dam's broken, and it's all coming at once.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*How long*?"

"*A season. Perhaps two.*"

She didn't say anything for a while.

He couldn't see her face. Only the eyes. Two soft gold lights in the dark. Like windows. Like lamps. Like the light in the window of a cottage at the end of a long lane in the Vale, on a winter night, coming home.

He didn't look away from them.

He'd decided that on the steps. He was too old to look at her hands. Too old and too tired and too curious. He'd been looking at people's faces for two hundred years. He wanted to look at hers.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You know who I am*," said Maelis.

"*I know what you said in the Hall.*"

"*That's who I am.*" The lights tilted. "*I didn't lie.*"

"*I know*," said Arion. "*That's what's so interesting about you.*"

She laughed.

It was a lovely laugh. Low and warm and surprised. It filled the dark room. And something about it, some note in it, made the hair stand up on the back of his old neck.

"*Oh, I like you*," said Maelis. "*I thought I might. I've been listening to you for months, you know. Through my moths. Every night. At the bottom of the mountain.*" Her voice went soft. "*Good evening, Seren. Good evening. Good evening.*"

He didn't move.

"*She doesn't remember you*," said Maelis. Gently. "*Does she.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D KNOWN SHE'D SAY it. He'd known on the steps. He'd known in the Hall, when she leaned down to Lex and said *your father says it every night*. He'd prepared for it. He'd lain awake in his narrow bed in the Spire last night and thought about exactly what he'd say.

He didn't say any of it.

He sat in the dark and looked at the two gold lights and didn't say anything at all.

"*She paid you away*," said Maelis. "*To the old man in the boat. To cross his river. Every memory. Every day. The steps of your Spire, in the rain.*" Her voice was very kind. "*And then she didn't even cross. She turned round. For your son. And went back into the dark. And now she's coming home.*"

A pause.

"*To a stranger*," said Maelis. "*An old man. With white hair and a stick and a voice she half-remembers from somewhere, and doesn't know why.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*What do you want?*" said Arion.

His voice came out steady. He was proud of that, afterward. Steady and dry and quiet. A Warden-Architect's voice. A voice for council chambers.

"*To help*," said Maelis.

"*Help.*"

"*You're running out of time.*" The gold lights didn't waver. "*A season. Perhaps two. She's still in the deep. She's walking, Warden-Architect. With something the size of a mountain following her. She won't be home before*

midsummer." A pause. *"You'll be eighty by then. Ninety. You won't be able to walk down the passage to the door to meet her."*

He didn't answer.

"I can give you time," said Maelis.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM WAS VERY quiet.

"A little light," said Maelis. Softly. *"From my own hands. The way I gave it to my household, nine hundred years ago. A sip."* The gold lights moved. Closer. She was leaning forward in the dark. *"Not enough to make you one of them. Not enough to make you mine. Just enough to hold the water back. To mend the dam a little."*

"How much?"

"Ten years. Twenty. As much as you like." A pause. *"Enough to be young when she comes home."*

He couldn't breathe.

"She doesn't remember an old man," said Maelis. Very gently. *"She remembers a voice. Through the Root, in the dark. Three years of nights. A young man's voice. That's what she fell in love with, the second time. Not this."* The lights didn't move. *"Let her come home to that. Let her walk up out of the dark and through the door and see a young man standing there. With dark hair. And grey eyes. And a voice she knows."*

A long pause.

"Let her fall in love with you a third time," said the Moth Queen. *"Properly. With her eyes open."*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT IN THE dark for a long time.

He thought about a woman on the steps of the Spire. In the rain. Small and fierce and freckled. With her hair tied back with a strip of blue cloth and flour on her cheek, because she'd come up to Highcrest to sell bread at the market and been caught in the downpour, and she'd stood on the steps of the Spire under the arch to keep dry and laughed at the lanterns. All the lanterns, in all the windows of Highcrest, glowing gold in the rain. She'd laughed and said, *are you all afraid of the dark up here?*

And he'd told her the story of the Nine. As a joke.

And she'd stopped laughing.

He couldn't remember what she'd said next. He'd tried. For years. He'd sat in the secret room behind the portraits and closed his eyes and tried to hear it. It was the one thing he couldn't remember, of that whole night. Her face. Her hair. The rain. The lanterns. Every word of the story he told her.

And then a blank. Like a page torn out.

And then she was laughing again, and saying *buy me a cup of something hot, Warden, I'm soaked*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why*?" said Arion.

The gold lights tilted.

"*Why would you do that*?" said Arion. "*For me. What do you want for it?*"

"*Nothing*."

"*Everyone pays. That's the river's law. That's every law.*"

Maelis was quiet.

"*I'd like to be your friend*," she said at last. Softly. "*That's all. I've been very lonely, Warden-Architect. For a very long time. In a grey country with no sun. With my brothers and sisters asleep and my people coming apart into dust one by one.*" Her voice was very low. "*And now I've come home. And I find a man who's lived two hundred years and is dying of it. A man who's been young too long and old too short. Who knows what it is to watch everyone you love grow old while you stay the same.*"

The lights moved closer.

"*I know what that is*," said Maelis. "*I've known it for nine hundred years.*"

"*And when she comes home*," said Arion. "*My wife. With the thing that's following her.*"

"*Then you'll be young*," said Maelis. "*And strong. And you'll be able to stand beside her. And help her.*" A pause. "*And when she understands what she's bringing home, you'll be able to help her let it go.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T ANSWER FOR a long time.

He sat in the dark drawing room of Varric Sorn's house, with his stick across his knees and his old heart beating slow and hard and uneven, the way it did now, and looked into the two gold lights.

Let her fall in love with you a third time.

With her eyes open.

He thought about his grey book. Forty pages. Columns of figures going down like water down a slope.

He thought about the clay lamp. Leaning.

He thought about Brannoc, on the slope of the Hollowmaw, holding his hand. *Don't you dare go before she gets home*.

He thought about the face in the mirror. White hair. Lines like plough-furrows. An old man. *His* old man. The one he'd waited two hundred years to see.

"*I'll think about it*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT HOME SLOWLY.

Down the steps. On his stick. One at a time. Past the four Keepers, who watched him with white faces. Along the Crown Terrace in the dark. Down the long slope to the Spire. Into the lift. Up. Along the corridor. Into his rooms.

He sat down in the chair by the window.

He didn't light a candle.

He sat in the dark for a long time with his grey book in his lap and his hands folded on it and his stick against the arm of the chair. Looking out at the dark city.

On the outside of his window, on the glass, in the dark, there was something.

He didn't need a light to see it. He knew what it was. Large. Grey-gold. Wings spread. With two rings on them, like eyes. Looking in.

It didn't say anything.

It didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT SOME POINT, VERY late, he opened the grey book.

And found the pencil. And by the light of the moth's faint glow on the glass, which was the only light there was, he wrote one more line. Under the columns. Under the numbers going down like water down a slope.

Small. Neat. Shaking only a little.

Offered: twenty years. Price: not stated.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then, underneath, smaller:

I would give anything to see her face when she sees mine.

And then, under that, so small it was almost nothing, almost a scratch on the page:

Anything?

He closed the book.

And sat in the dark with it in his lap. And didn't sleep. And the moth stayed on his window until dawn.

CHAPTER 12

HUSH

THE DELVE OPENED IN the cold-room.

Of course it did. Antho would think about that afterward, often, with a kind of tired fondness. Of all the places in Caldor. Of all the village greens and inn yards and tavern cellars and dry wells. It opened at the bottom of the Lantern Keep, in the cold-room, among the bats.

He was there when it happened. That was the other thing.

It was the night after his father went back to Highcrest. He couldn't sleep. He'd lain in bed beside Seraphine for three hours looking at the ceiling, and then got up, and put on his coat, and taken a book down to the cold-room the way he did on bad nights. To read to the bats.

The cold-room was a cave off the lower passage. Long and low and dark, with water dripping somewhere at the back and a smell of stone and bat and Teo's old fish-buckets, which nobody had ever quite managed to get rid of. There were about four hundred bats. Small brown ones, mostly. Hanging from the roof in great soft clusters, like bunches of dried fruit.

Antho sat on his usual crate, by the lantern he kept there, and opened the book.

The History of the Reign of King Aldric the Second, by a Warden-Historian of the Spire, in eleven volumes. He was on volume four. It was the dullest book ever written. The bats loved it.

"*In the third year of his reign*," read Antho Vey, "*the King turned his attention to the vexed matter of the river tolls at Saltreach—*"

And the floor of the cold-room opened.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT MADE NO SOUND.

That was what he'd tell Lex. No crack. No rumble. No breaking stone. The floor of the cold-room was there, rough grey rock, wet, with a puddle where the drip landed. And then, between one word and the next, ten feet from his crate, it wasn't.

A circle. Round. Flat. Black. Perfect.

Breathing.

The bats went mad.

Four hundred of them. All at once. Dropping off the roof in a great brown roaring cloud, wheeling, shrieking, a storm of wings that put out his lantern and knocked the book out of his hands and filled the cold-room with a sound like tearing silk. They poured past him. Out. Up the passage. Toward the cave mouth. Gone.

And then silence.

And darkness. Except for the round black on the floor, which wasn't light, which was the opposite of light, but somehow you could see it anyway. The way you can see a hole in the dark.

And humming.

Little light, little light.

Antho sat on his crate in the dark with his empty hands in his lap.

"*Well*," he said. To no one. "*That's the end of volume four.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[...brother...]

He went still.

It was loud. Louder than it had ever been. Not through the door. Not through a pebble. *Here*. In the room. Coming up out of the round dark on the floor of the cold-room like breath out of a mouth.

[...brother...brother you're here...]

Yes, thought Antho. *I'm here.*

[...it hurts...the holes...they keep breaking...]

He knew. He'd felt every one. Since Thistledown. Twelve more. Twelve more times something had snapped, somewhere in Caldor, and the thing under the world had flinched, and screamed. He'd learned to feel

them coming. A kind of tightening, in the back of his skull. And then the snap. And then the scream. And he'd learned to hold on through it. To grip the edge of the table, or the bed, or Seraphine's hand. To not let it come out of his mouth.

He hadn't always managed.

[...why...why do they break them...]

"*Because they don't know*," said Antho. Out loud. In the dark. "*They don't know you're there. They think you're stones.*"

[...I'm not stones...]

"*I know.*"

[...I just wanted to see...I just wanted to come UP...]

"*I know*," said Antho Vey.

He got up off the crate. In the dark. And walked across the cold-room floor. Slowly. Until he was standing at the very edge of the round black. With his boots an inch from it.

And knelt down.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T GO IN.

He'd thought about it. Kneeling there. With the warm breath of it on his face and the humming in his bones. He'd thought, *I could go down. Like Lex did, at Ashbourne. Find the core. Claim it. Close it softly.*

He didn't.

He'd made a promise. To himself. To Seraphine. To his brother on a bench in the Ashbourne Forge. *I'm trying very hard to be the kind of man who doesn't carry things alone.*

So he knelt at the edge of the hole in his cold-room floor, in the dark, and put his hand flat on the stone beside it. And waited.

And after a while, he heard footsteps.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE CAME FIRST. IN her nightgown. With her spectacles on and a lamp in her hand and her hair in a long dark plait down her back. She came down the passage at a run, the way she always ran, awkwardly, like someone who'd learned to run late in life from a book.

She stopped in the doorway. And looked at the hole. And at him.

"*The bats came through the library*," she said. "*All of them. They knocked over the ink.*"

"*Sorry*."

"*It's on the map*." She came in. Slowly. Holding the lamp up. "*Right on Malachi's map. There's a bat-shaped splash over the whole of the Saltreach.*" She looked at the round black on the floor. "*Oh.*"

"*Yes*."

"*In the cold-room*."

"*Yes*."

She was quiet for a moment.

"*Teo will be so annoyed he missed this*," said Seraphine.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN ODILE. THEN IVY Moss, on her crutch, very fast, with her pale hair everywhere and her eyes enormous. Then the Millbridge twins and Cass and the rest, crowding in the doorway in their nightclothes.

And Pim.

Pim didn't crowd. He came past the others. Small. Barefoot. In a nightshirt too big for him. And walked straight across the cold-room to where Antho was kneeling. And knelt down beside him. At the edge of the hole.

And looked into it.

"*It's frightened*," said Ivy Moss. From the doorway. In a small high voice. "*It's very frightened. It doesn't want to be broken.*"

"*Nobody's going to break it*," said Antho.

"*It doesn't know that*."

"*No*," said Antho. "*It doesn't.*" He looked down at the black. "*Nobody's ever told it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WORKED THROUGH THE night.

It was Seraphine's idea, mostly. Or rather, it was everyone's idea, in pieces, and Seraphine put the pieces together. That was what she did. That was what she'd always done. She sat on Antho's crate with her lamp and her notebook on her knees and listened to everyone talking at once and

wrote it all down. And then read it back. And then said, *wait*, and crossed things out, and drew arrows, and said *wait* again.

"*The claim closes it*," she said. "*We know that. Lex claimed the Ashbourne core and the Delve folded up.*"

"*Lex had to go all the way down to do it*," said Odile. "*Three floors. Through the Unfinished. And the guardian.*"

"*And so would we*," said Seraphine. "*Every time. Forty-one Delves. More every week. And the Uncapped get to most of them first.*" She tapped her pencil on the notebook. "*We can't go down every hole in Caldor. There aren't enough of us. There isn't enough time.*"

"*So what*?" said one of the twins.

Seraphine looked at the hole.

"*So we don't go down*," she said slowly. "*We make it go down. From up here. Before anyone goes in.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How*?" said Antho.

"*I don't know yet*." She was writing. Fast. "*But think. What's a Delve? What is it, really?*"

"*A hole*," said Cass.

"*A hole*." Seraphine nodded. "*A way. A thread of the little one, reaching up toward the light. Like a—like a root growing toward water. Or a plant growing toward the sun.*" She looked up. "*It's reaching. That's all a Delve is. It's the little one putting its hand up out of the ground.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*And when the core's claimed*," said Seraphine, "*the hand draws back. Softly. Like a hand drawn back from a flame.*" She was quoting the Ferryman. Antho had told her. Every word. "*And when the core's broken, the hand gets cut off. And the wound stays open.*"

She looked down at her notebook. At the arrows.

"*So what if we just—*" She stopped. Bit her pencil. "*What if we just made it feel safe? Enough to draw its hand back on its own? Before anyone cuts it?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY TRIED EVERYTHING.

Antho opened the Lantern. Full. All twelve Hush-runes blazing gold. The quiet that kept voices out. He held it over the round black and let the hush pour down into it.

It went still. For a moment. The humming stopped.

And then started again. Louder. Frightened. *[...brother...brother it's DARK...why did you make it dark...]*

He closed the Lantern.

Odile and the twins tried Shade. Wrapping the hole in darkness, gently, the way you'd wrap a frightened bird in a cloth.

It didn't like that either. *[...dark...it's always dark...I don't want dark I want to SEE...]*

Ivy Moss tried singing to it. *The Lantern Song*. In her thin small voice. Sitting at the edge of the hole on the cold-room floor with her crutch beside her.

It liked that. It hummed along. Flat. On the high note.

But it didn't draw back. It reached further. Toward her voice. The round black on the floor grew. A foot. Two. Until its edge was touching Ivy's knee, and she scrambled back with a squeak, and it stopped.

"*It wants to come up more*," said Ivy Moss. Breathlessly. "*When I sing. It wants to come up and see who's singing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS NEARLY DAWN when Pim did it.

They'd stopped. All of them. Tired. Sitting round the edge of the cold-room in their nightclothes with blankets that Odile had fetched, and cold tea that nobody was drinking, and the round black humming in the middle of the floor.

Antho was sitting with his back against the wall and Seraphine's head on his shoulder. She'd fallen asleep in the middle of a sentence. Her notebook was open on her knees. The last thing she'd written, in a trailing line that went off the edge of the page, was *what does a frightened thing want, if not dark and not light and not—*

Pim got up.

He'd been sitting at the edge of the hole all night. Not saying anything. Watching it. The way he watched everything. The way he'd watched the moths. The way he'd watched the Ferryman.

He got up. And walked round the edge of the hole. Slowly. All the way round. Once. Looking down at it.

And then he knelt down. On the far side. Facing Antho.

And held out his hands.

Over the black. Not touching it. Cupped. The way he'd cupped them round the Fenmoor lantern, when the wick wouldn't catch. The way he'd cupped them round Odile's dusty hand in the snow.

Round it.

Making a space.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FELT IT BEFORE he saw it.

The silence. Pim's silence. The deep kind. The room in him where nothing was. He'd felt it at the moths, and on the night of the Blade, and at the Highcrest singing. He felt it now. Coming out of the boy's small thin hands. Not into the hole. *Around* it. Like the walls of a cup.

And the hole—

Listened.

The humming stopped. Not the way it had stopped under the Lantern. Not frightened. *Curious*. The way a child stops crying when someone does something unexpected.

[...oh...]

Antho sat up very straight. Seraphine woke. Slid off his shoulder. Blinked.

[...oh...this is...]

[...this is like ME...]

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM DIDN'T MOVE.

He knelt on the cold-room floor with his hands cupped round the round black, an inch above it, and was silent. And the silence went round the hole the way a hand goes round a candle-flame in a draft. Not touching. Not pressing. Not putting it out.

Just there. Round it. A room around a room.

[...it's quiet...] said the voice. Wondering. *[...it's quiet but it's not dark...it's not cold...it's...]*

It didn't have the word.

[...it's like being held without being held...]

And the round black on the floor of the cold-room, very slowly, very softly, began to get smaller.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY BREATHED.

Ten feet across. Nine. Eight. The edge drawing in. Smoothly. Not like a wound closing. Like a flower closing at dusk. Like an eye shutting, slowly, in a warm room, when you're very tired and someone has put a blanket over you.

Six feet. Four. Pim's hands drew in with it. Staying round it. Cupped. An inch above.

Two feet. A foot.

The size of a dinner plate. A saucer. A coin.

And then nothing. Rough grey stone. Wet. The puddle where the drip landed.

And on the stone, where the hole had been, lying in the puddle, a pebble.

Black. Smooth. The size of a hen's egg. Humming. Very softly. Flat on the high note.

Not claimed. Nobody had gone down. Nobody had touched it.

It had just—*come up*. On its own. Like a child coming out from under a bed when it's sure the shouting has stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM PICKED IT UP.

He held it in his cupped hands for a moment. Close to his face. Looking at it. With his grey-violet eyes.

Then he turned round on his knees. And held it out to Antho.

Antho took it.

Warm. Smooth. Humming.

[...brother...] said the voice. In the old place in the back of his skull. Very small. Very sleepy. *[...brother that was nice...can he do that again...]*

Antho looked at Pim.

Pim looked back. And for the first time Antho could remember, in three years at the Keep, the boy's thin solemn face did something it never did.

It smiled. Small. Shy. Proud.

"*Room*," said Pim. "*It wanted room. Not dark. Not light.*" He looked down at his own empty hands. "*Just room.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

```
▓▓▓ DELVE — FOLDED ▓▓▓
"It went home on its own. Nobody made
 it. Somebody made room for it to."
New technique discovered: HUSH-FOLD
(Recorded by the net. First instance.)
```

```
ANTHOREN VEY
Level 79 → 80
```

```
PIM (no surname given)
Level 22 → 29
"Seven levels for an act no one had
 thought of. The net was impressed.
 It does not often say so."
```

PIM STARED AT HIS panel. At the last line.

Then he turned very red. And got up. And went out of the cold-room at a run. And they heard him all the way up the passage, his bare feet slapping on the stone, and then a door bang somewhere, and then nothing.

"*He's gone to tell Ashka*," said Odile. Smiling. "*He always tells Ashka first.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[...brother...]

The pebble was warm in Antho's hand. Humming. Sleepy.

[...brother...can I show you something...]

He went still.

Seraphine felt it. She was beside him again, on the floor, with her notebook. She looked at his face. And put her hand on his arm.

Show me what? thought Antho.

[...before...] said the voice. *[...a long time before...the first time...when they came...]*

[...I want you to know...I want SOMEONE to know...]

[...nobody ever asked...]

Antho looked down at the pebble in his hand.

"*Antho*?" said Seraphine.

"*It wants to show me something*," he said. Very quietly. "*Something old.*"

Her hand tightened on his arm.

"*I'm here*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*I'm not going anywhere. Go on.*"

He closed his eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

A HALL.

Glass. All of it. Walls and roof and floor. Tall. Vaulted. Like the inside of a great frozen waterfall, or a cathedral made of ice. Light came in through the walls from everywhere at once, gold and soft, the light of a late summer evening. It made the whole hall glow.

And in the middle of the floor, a pool.

Small. Round. No bigger than the round black on the cold-room floor. Ten feet across. Its edge was a ring of plain grey stone, worn smooth, much older than the glass hall built over it. And inside the ring, water.

No. Not water.

Dark. Still. Deep. So deep that looking into it was like looking up at the night sky. Not empty. *Full*. Full the way a held breath is full. Full the way the moment before a word is full, when everything that might be said hasn't been said yet.

Antho had never seen anything so beautiful in his life.

That's me, said the voice. Very small. Very far off. *That was me. Before.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME IN THROUGH the great doors at the end of the hall.

Nine of them.

Tall. Beautiful. In robes of silk and cloth-of-gold, with crowns on their heads. A crown of gold leaves on a tall broad man with a golden beard, who walked first. A crown of glass on a woman with a face like a statue. A crown of black iron on a dark heavy man who didn't smile. A crown of roses on a woman Antho couldn't quite see; she kept turning her face away.

And a crown of silver wire, fine as frost, shaped like folded wings, on a tall pale woman with silver hair to her knees and eyes the color of candlelight.

Not lit. Not yet. Just a color. Warm brown-gold. Like honey. Like the eyes of anyone.

Maelis.

Antho knew her at once. Even without the lit eyes. Even without the wings. Something in the way she walked. In the way she held her head. Slightly tilted. Toward the light coming in through the glass walls. Toward the glow.

Four others. He didn't know them. Crowns of bronze and bone and copper and something that might have been coral. They walked behind.

And they knelt. All nine. Round the edge of the pool. On the old grey stone.

And cupped their hands.

And drank.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT.

Through the voice. Through the pebble. Through the old place in his skull where the hunger used to live. He felt the pool feel it.

The first sip.

It didn't hurt. That was the terrible thing. It didn't hurt at all. It felt like being *tasted*. Like a hand on your face. Like someone leaning close to look at you. Like being seen. The pool had never been seen before. It was a room. A door. A place things came *through*. Nobody had ever stopped at it. Nobody had ever knelt down and looked.

They knelt. They looked. They cupped their hands and lifted it up to their mouths.

And the pool was *glad*.

I didn't know, said the voice. Very small. *I didn't know what they were doing. I thought—*

I thought they liked me.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME BACK THE next day. And the next. And the next.

Every evening. In the gold light. The nine of them. Kneeling round the pool. Drinking. And then their households. Lines of them. Courtiers and servants and soldiers. Kneeling at the edges while the Crowned held out their own cupped hands, full of dark, and let them sip.

And the pool went down.

Antho felt it go. Days. Weeks. Seasons. Like water going down in a well in a dry summer. Like breath going out of a body. The dark in the stone ring getting lower. And lower. Until you could see the stone sides of it, going down. Grey. Dry.

And the Crowned *changed*.

He saw it. Through the pool's eyes. Watching them come back, every evening, in the gold light. Their faces didn't age. Their hands didn't shake. Their eyes—

Their eyes began to *glow*.

Maelis first. Of course Maelis first. She drank more than any of them except the Gilded King. She drank slowly. Savoring. With her eyes closed. And when she opened them, one evening in the late autumn, they were lit. Soft. Gold. Warm. Like two windows at the end of a long lane.

And she looked down at the pool. With her lit eyes.

And smiled.

And the pool, which by then was very low, and very cold, and very frightened, and didn't understand why, looked up at her.

She looked at me like I was a lamp, said the voice. *Like I was a lamp she wanted to put her hands round*.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE TENTH.

Antho almost missed her. She was standing in the doorway. At the end of the hall. Behind everyone. In the shadow of the great glass doors. Not kneeling. Not drinking.

Watching.

She was young. Younger than the others. Seventeen. Eighteen. Small. Thin. With brown hair tied back and a plain grey dress, not silk, not cloth-of-gold. No crown.

No. There was a crown. In her hands. She was holding it. Not wearing it. Holding it in front of her, the way you'd hold a bowl. A small crown. Plain silver. With seven points.

And her hands—

Square. Strong. Never still. Too big for the rest of her.

Antho's breath stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME FORWARD.

On the last evening. When the pool was nearly gone. When the dark in the stone ring was no deeper than a puddle after rain, and the stone sides were dry and cracked, and the whole glass hall had gone cold, and the Crowned were kneeling round the edge of it, scraping, with their lit eyes and their cupped hands.

She came forward through them. Small. In her grey dress. With the crown in her hands.

The Gilded King looked up. And said something. Antho couldn't hear it. Something sharp. A command.

The girl didn't stop.

She came to the edge of the pool. And looked down into it. At the little puddle of dark at the bottom of the dry stone ring.

And she knelt down.

Not to drink.

She set the crown down beside her on the stone. Carefully. As if it didn't matter. As if it were a cup she'd finished with.

And she cupped her hands.

And she *poured*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS NOTHING IN her hands.

Antho could see that. They were empty. Cupped. Square and strong and empty.

But she poured. She tipped them. Over the dry stone ring. Over the little puddle of dark at the bottom. Slowly. Carefully. The way you'd pour water into a dry well, a cup at a time, knowing it won't be enough, doing it anyway.

And something went out of her. Into the pool.

Not much. Not water. Something smaller. Something warmer. Antho didn't know what it was. He'd never know. But the pool knew. The pool felt it go in, a cupful of something, a drop in a dry well, and for one moment, in the cold glass hall, at the very end, it was *less empty*.

A cupful less.

She gave me back, said the voice. Very small. Very far off. Wondering. *Everyone took. She gave me back. Just a little. Just what she had.*

Nobody else ever did.

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS TURNED HER HEAD.

She was kneeling beside the girl. Her sister. Antho could see it now. The same long jaw. The same high cheekbones. Not the same eyes. The girl's eyes were brown. Ordinary. Unlit.

Maelis looked at her sister with her lit gold eyes.

And her face changed.

Not anger. Not surprise.

Hunger.

She looked at the girl's empty cupped hands. At the place where something had gone out of them into the pool. And her lit eyes widened. And she leaned closer. Toward the girl. Toward her hands. The way a moth leans toward a lamp.

And the girl looked back at her.

And said something.

Antho heard it. Clearly. Across nine hundred years. In a young voice, steady, low, not frightened at all.

"*No*," said Hesper Harrow. "*Not me. Not ever.*"

And she got up. And left the crown lying on the stone. And walked out of the hall of glass. And didn't look back.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO OPENED HIS EYES.

He was on the cold-room floor. On his back. He didn't remember lying down. Seraphine was bending over him, with her spectacles crooked and her face white. Odile was holding his hand. Ivy Moss was sitting at his feet with her crutch across her knees and tears running down her face.

The pebble was on his chest. Over his heart. Humming.

"*Antho*," said Seraphine. "*Antho. You stopped breathing. For a moment. You stopped—*"

"*I saw her*," said Antho.

His voice was a croak.

"*Who*?"

"*The tenth*." He looked up at his wife. "*At the pool. The one who didn't drink. She had a crown in her hands. She put it down. She gave something back. She said no.*" He swallowed. "*She had our hands, Seraphine. Lex's. Mam's. Square. Too big for the rest of her.*"

Seraphine stared at him.

"*Harrow*," she said. Very softly.

"*Hesper*," said Antho. "*Her name was Hesper.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T SLEEP.

They sat in the kitchen as the sun came up, with porridge nobody ate and Odile's terrible tea, and Antho told them. All of it. The glass hall. The pool. The nine. The gold light. The lit eyes. The tenth girl in the doorway, with the crown.

Seraphine wrote it all down.

Every word. In her small neat hand. Filling page after page. Not looking up. Her pencil moving and moving.

When he got to the end, she put the pencil down.

And sat very still. With her hands flat on the notebook.

"*Seraphine*?"

She didn't answer.

She was staring at the pebble. On the kitchen table. Between the porridge and the teapot. Black. Smooth. The size of a hen's egg.

"*Antho*," she said.

Her voice was very strange. Very quiet. Very far away.

"*Antho. Say something.*"

"*What*?"

"*Anything. Say anything. Say a word.*"

He looked at her. Confused. "*Pebble*," he said.

Seraphine shut her eyes.

"*There*," she said. "*There. There.*" She put her hand flat on the table. Next to the pebble. Not touching it. "*The space. Before you said it. And after. The—*" She shook her head. "*It's like reading. I told you. It's like the space between letters.*"

She opened her eyes.

And they were wet.

"*It's not the song*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*I've been trying to hear the song. That's why I couldn't. I've been trying to hear the—the* thing." She looked at the pebble. "*It's not a thing. It's the room the thing goes in. It's the quiet before the word.*"

She was shaking.

"*Antho*," said his wife. "*I can hear it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D BEEN WITH HER at the eternal fire in the Pale Wastes. For nineteen days. Watching her sit with Malachi's Codex on her knees, copying, every word, every lesson, while the rest of them learned to Listen. While Lex heard the fire and Wren heard the wind and Antho heard the dark. While the old man laughed and the goats wandered and every single one of them, one by one, heard *something*.

She'd heard nothing. Nineteen days. Not a whisper. Not a flicker.

Some people don't, Malachi had said. Gently. *It's not a failing. Someone has to write it down.*

She'd written it down. All of it. For five years. Every word anyone had ever said about the Wells. Every lesson. Every story. She'd copied the Codex nine times. She'd taught it. She'd translated it. She'd explained it to the Queen.

She'd never heard a single one of them.

He watched her face now. Across the kitchen table. In the dawn light. With the pebble between them.

And watched a panel come up over her head. Silver and gold. Faint. And something else. Something that wasn't silver or gold or violet or any color he'd ever seen on a panel. A kind of *clear*. Like the color of a window. Like the color of the air in an empty room.

```
SERAPHINE ILVANE
Class: LATTICE SCRIBE (Rare)
Level 44
ATTUNEMENT
  ▓▓▓ (unrecognized) ... LISTENING
"There was a space at the center of
 the ring. She heard it."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE READ IT.

She read it twice.

Then she took off her spectacles. And put them on the table. Next to the pebble. Very carefully. And put her face in her hands.

And laughed.

And cried.

Both. At once.

The way he did. The way his brother did. The way they all did, now, the whole family, when something was too big to be only one thing.

Antho came round the table. And knelt on the kitchen floor beside her chair. And put his arms round her.

"*I've always been good at gaps*," said Seraphine. Into her hands. Shaking. "*Always. The spaces between letters. The words people don't say. The things that are missing from a record. The pages someone's torn out.*" She took her hands away from her face. "*That's all I've ever been good at. Noticing what isn't there.*"

"*I know*," said Antho.

"*I thought it was nothing*," said Seraphine. "*I thought it was just—being a scholar. Being careful.*" She looked at the pebble. "*I didn't know it was a Well.*"

Antho held her.

And on the kitchen table, between the porridge and the teapot, the black pebble hummed. Softly. Sleepily.

And in the back of his skull, very small, very far off, so faint he almost didn't hear it—

[...oh...]

[...she can hear me...]

[...the one with the glass eyes...she can HEAR me...]

[...nobody ever...]

[...nobody but you and the lamp-lady and the old man who sang...]

[...brother...]

[...brother, I'm not alone...]

CHAPTER 13

The Drowned Archive

LEX MADE THE FIRST Hush-cup out of a horseshoe.

It was the only iron to hand. He was at the Lantern Keep, in the kitchen, at dawn, with his brother's letter still in his fist. Quill had brought it to Ashbourne in the night. Three lines. *Pim folded one. From the top. Without going in. Come.* He'd come on Vharuun before the sun was up, with Wren behind him, and found them all in the kitchen, Antho and Seraphine and Pim and the students, with a black pebble on the table and porridge nobody had eaten and Seraphine's notebook open to forty pages of arrows.

Seraphine had explained it to him. Twice. With diagrams.

It doesn't want dark, she'd said. *It doesn't want light. It wants room. A space round it. Not touching it. Not pressing it. Just—held, without being held.*

Like Pim's hands, Lex had said.

Like Pim's hands. Seraphine had looked at him over her spectacles. *But there's only one Pim. And forty-one Delves. And more every week.*

So Lex had gone out to the stable, where Ashka slept, and found a cast horseshoe in the straw, and brought it back, and sat down at the kitchen table, and started to think.

◆ ◆ ◆

[You're going to make a hand,] said Ember.

I'm going to make a cup.

[A cup shaped like a pair of hands.]

A cup shaped like the space inside a pair of hands, thought Lex. *That's different.*

He held the horseshoe in his palm. Old iron. Worn thin at the toe where it had struck stone. A good shoe. It had carried a horse a long way.

He didn't put it in a fire. There was no need. He was a Worldforger. He asked it.

And the horseshoe softened in his hand. Like wax. Like warm bread. And he shaped it with his thumbs. Slowly. Not into a cup. Into the space a cup would hold. A curve. A bowl. Shallow. Open at the top. Like two hands cupped together, if the hands were made of iron and there was nothing inside them but air.

Then he turned to Seraphine.

"*The glyph*," he said. "*From Malachi's vellum. The one scratched into the black circle.*"

She was already drawing it. On a scrap of paper. The Wellscript glyph for the seventh. *Hollow*. A circle with a break in it. Like a ring that doesn't quite close.

He couldn't read it. He'd lost that with the Root. But he didn't need to read it. He only needed to cut it.

He cut it into the inside of the iron cup. On the curve. Where the palms would be.

And then, round the rim, very small, very fine, the way he'd cut them into the Keeper's Lantern five years ago in Malachi's valley: Hush-runes. Seven of them. Not twelve. Seven.

He held it up.

It was small. Rough. The size of his two hands cupped. Grey iron, with a broken circle on the inside and seven runes round the edge.

"*Pim*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOY CAME ROUND the table.

Lex held the cup out. Pim looked at it. Then at Lex. Then he put out his small thin hands. And cupped them round it. Not touching. An inch away. The way he'd cupped them round the hole in the cold-room.

And was silent.

Lex felt it go in.

Not much. A little. The way warmth goes into iron when you hold it. Pim's silence. The room in him. Going into the curve of the cup. Settling there. Like water settling into a bowl.

And the cup went *quiet*.

That was the only word for it. It didn't glow. It didn't hum. It didn't do anything a person could see. It just—went quiet. The way a room goes quiet when someone you love walks into it.

```
ITEM CREATED: HUSH-CUP
Grade: SUPERIOR (blue)
"A room that can be carried."
Effect: When set at the mouth of an
  unclassified Delve, the Delve folds
  home of its own will. Core returns
  whole. No reward is given.
Charges: 1 (refill: Pim)
```

No reward is given.

Lex looked at that line for a long time.

[That's going to be a problem,] said Ember. Quietly.

I know.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY MADE FORTY MORE in three days.

Not Lex alone. Everyone. Brannoc came up the mountain with Tilda and a cart full of iron and twenty students from the Forge, grumbling about his knees the whole way, and set up three anvils in the Keep's cave mouth. Hedda came with a box of Hush-rune templates she'd been keeping since the Hollowmaw lanterns. Seraphine cut the broken circle into every cup with a steel stylus, sitting at the kitchen table, tongue between her teeth.

And Pim filled them.

One at a time. In the evenings. Sitting on his rock at the cave mouth with a cup in his lap and his hands round it, silent, for an hour each, while the sun went down over the Greyspine. He didn't complain. He didn't say anything. He just sat. And filled them. And when each one was done he

put it in a basket at his feet, carefully, the way a hen puts down an egg, and picked up the next.

By the third evening he was grey with tiredness.

"*He can't keep doing this*," said Antho. Watching him from the cave mouth. Very low.

"*I know*."

"*He's thirteen. Or twelve. Or fourteen. He's a child.*"

"*I know*," said Lex. "*I'm working on it.*"

He was. He'd been working on it for three days. Every cup he made, he made a little differently. Trying to find a way to make the room in it without Pim. To make the quiet *himself*. He'd tried Shade, and the Stone in him, and his own breath, and the space between hammer-strokes.

None of it worked.

[You can't make a room by putting things in,] said Ember. *[That's what Seraphine says. The Hollow's the space. Not the thing. You keep trying to put something in the cup.]*

Then how do I make the space?

[I don't know,] said Ember. *[I'm a coal in a hearth. I'm not very good at nothing either.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RAVEN CAME ON the fourth morning.

Not Roole's. Not Quill. A bird from the Saltreach, bedraggled, with sea-salt on its feathers and a slip of paper on its leg in a scrawled, ink-blotted hand.

Qel'Varran. The Drowned Archive. It's opened. In the dome. The middle. Under the water.

The Coldwater crew passed through Saltmere village yesterday. Six of them. With a big man with a pick.

There were moths with them. A lot of moths.

— Arno Vell, Captain, Saltreach garrison

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Qel'Varran*," said Seraphine.

She'd gone very white.

Lex knew why. Five years ago, in the Saltmere Fens, in the half-sunk dome of the Drowned Archive, she'd been carried in on a litter with a gold-lightning burn down her side, half-dead, and watched him burn Inkwraiths with ordinary fire. She'd found the Listeners' Codex there. The book that changed everything. The book she'd copied nine times.

It was the most important library in the world. It was where she'd found out who she was.

And now it was a Delve.

"*I'm coming*," said Seraphine.

Antho opened his mouth.

"*I'm coming*," said his wife. "*I know that dome better than anyone alive. I know every shelf. Every gallery. Every broken window.*" She looked at him. "*And I can hear it now. I can hear the room. I can tell you where the core is before anyone goes down.*"

Antho closed his mouth.

"*And Pim*," said Seraphine. "*Pim has to come. And you know it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT SEVEN.

Lex. Seraphine. Pim, with the basket of Hush-cups on his back, forty of them, wrapped in straw. Tilda, with Brannoc's hammer. And the twins.

Ilse and Ivo Marrow had turned up at the Keep on the third evening. In their cart. With a great deal of noise. They'd been touring the Bitter Hills with *The Knights of the Ford* and heard about the Delves, and the Uncapped, and a big man with a pick, and the moths. And had turned the cart round.

"*You need a distraction*," said Ilse. Standing in the cave mouth with her hands on her hips. "*Everyone always needs a distraction. That's what we're for.*"

"*We're very distracting*," said Ivo.

"*He fell off the stage in Hollin's Rest*," said Ilse. "*Into a pig-trough. The whole village came out to see.*"

"*That was on purpose.*"

"*It was not on purpose.*"

Lex looked at them. Twenty-six now. Mouse-brown hair. Patched green coats. Holding hands without seeming to notice they were doing it. Two years ago Ivo had made his own wrist look like nothing so his sister would let go, and been dragged down to the bottom of the world by a knight made of two knights. And come back.

"*Yes*," said Lex. "*Come.*"

And Antho.

Antho came. Lex had expected him to stay. To hold the door. To watch for moths at the Keep.

He didn't.

"*Odile has the door*," he said. "*And Father's lamp. And Ivy can hear it coming from three valleys off.*" He looked at Lex. "*And when you set one of those cups at the mouth of that Delve, and it folds, I want to be there. I want to feel it go home. I want to feel it not scream.*"

Lex looked at him.

"*I've felt it scream twenty-three times*," said his brother. Very quietly. "*I'd like to feel it do something else.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CAME AS FAR as the fen.

She'd said she would. She'd said it at breakfast at Harrow, standing at the stove with her back to him, in a voice that dared him to argue. *As far as the fen. To the edge. Where the reeds start. I'll stand on dry ground with my bow and my wind and I'll watch the dome, and if anything comes out of it that isn't you, I'll shoot it.*

He didn't argue.

She was nine weeks gone. She'd been sick every morning for a month. Old Mag said it would stop soon. Old Mag said a great many things, most of them about ginger.

She stood at the edge of the Saltmere Fens in the grey morning, in her leathers, with her bow strung and her red braid over one shoulder and her hand resting, without her seeming to notice, on her stomach.

"*Come back*," said Wren.

"*I'll come back*."

"And don't—" She stopped. Looked at the dome, far off across the reeds, rising out of the black water like the top of a buried skull. *"Don't let them break it, Lex. Please."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SALTMERE FENS HADN'T changed.

Reeds. Black water. Mist. Miles of it. Flat and grey and silent, stretching away to the edge of the sky, with here and there a stunted alder or a hump of drier ground. The smell of rot and salt and old water. The cry of a bittern somewhere, hollow, like someone blowing across the top of a jug.

And in the middle of it, rising out of the black water, the dome.

Qel'Varran. The Drowned Archive. Grey stone. Huge. Half-sunk. Its great curved roof broken in places, its round windows staring out over the fen like empty eye-sockets. It had been built nine hundred years ago, before the net. By the Listeners. To keep their books safe. And then the sea had come in, and the land had gone down, and the fen had swallowed it up to its shoulders.

They went in the way they'd gone in five years ago. Through a broken window, just above the waterline. Onto the gallery.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

The dome was *lit*.

Five years ago it had been dark. Pitch dark. A great hollow of black, with the shelves spiralling down into it, and at the very bottom, far below, the faint gleam of still water.

It wasn't dark now.

There was light at the bottom. Faint. Grey-gold. Shifting. Like light through dust. Like the light in a room where the curtains are drawn and the sun is shining outside.

And it was moving.

Lex stood on the gallery and looked down. Down the long spiral of the shelves. Down past the rotted books and the stone galleries and the broken stairs. To the bottom. To the black water. Where, five years ago, there had been nothing.

There was a hole in the water now.

Round. Flat. Perfect. Black. *In* the water. Not under it. *In* it. As if someone had cut a circle out of the surface of the pool at the bottom of the dome and lifted it away. The water stood up round the edge of it like the walls of a well. Twenty feet across.

And around it, over it, above it, filling the bottom of the dome like smoke fills a chimney—

Moths.

◆ ◆ ◆

THOUSANDS.

Lex had seen the cloud at the Keep. Antho had told him. He hadn't understood. Not properly. Not until now.

They hung in the air at the bottom of the dome in a great slow turning column. Grey-gold. Glittering. Drifting. Round and round. Like water going down a drain. Like leaves in a whirlpool. Their wings caught the faint light and threw it back, so the whole bottom of the dome shimmered. It was beautiful. It was the most beautiful thing Lex had ever seen.

It made him want to be sick.

And among them, standing on the narrow stone ledge that ran round the edge of the water at the very bottom of the dome, people.

Not people. Mothwing. Twenty. Thirty. Pale. Thin. Ragged dust-wings folded on their backs. Standing very still. Facing the hole. Waiting.

And beside them, on the ledge, six figures in patched leather and steel plate. With picks.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*They're already down*," said Antho. Very low.

Lex looked.

He was right. The six on the ledge weren't moving. They were standing at the edge of the hole. Looking down into it. Coldwater crew. Lex knew them. Brigid with her hammer. The Tull brothers. Old Absalom with his helmet-lamp. Kit.

Five.

Not six.

Hask's gone in, thought Lex. *Hask's already in it.*

"*How long*?" he said.

Seraphine had her eyes shut. Standing on the gallery with one hand on the stone shelf beside her and her head tilted. Listening. To the room.

"*Not long*," she said. "*An hour. Less. He's—*" She frowned. "*He's on the second floor. I think. I can hear the space change. Where he's walking. Like—like a mouse in a wall.*" She opened her eyes. "*He's fast, Lex. He's very fast.*"

"*Can we fold it*?" said Antho. "*From up here? Now?*"

"*With him inside*?"

"*Yes*."

Seraphine looked at him.

"*I don't know*," she said. "*Pim folded the cold-room with no one in it. I don't know what happens if there's someone inside.*" She swallowed. "*At Ashbourne, when Lex claimed the core, it folded up round him and put him out on the green. Gently. But that was the core going home. I don't know what a fold does to a person who's still on the second floor.*"

Lex looked down at the hole. At the moths. At the five figures on the ledge.

"*Then we go down*," he said. "*And get him out. And then we fold it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS NOTICED THEM on the third turn of the stair.

He'd known they would. He'd brought fire. He *was* fire. Every one of them was carrying a light of some kind. Antho had the Lantern. Seraphine had a lamp. Tilda had a lamp. Even Pim had a little tin lantern on his belt, that Odile had given him.

The cloud at the bottom of the dome shifted. All at once. Like a flock of starlings. And began to rise.

Up the spiral of the shelves. Slowly. Glittering. Toward the gallery. Toward the lamps.

And the Mothwing on the ledge turned their pale faces up.

"*Lights out*," said Lex. "*All of them. Now.*"

They put them out. Seraphine's lamp. Tilda's. Pim's little tin one. Antho shuttered the Lantern.

The cloud kept coming.

"*It's you*," said Antho. "*Lex. It's you. You're the light.*"

Lex looked down at himself.

He hadn't noticed. He never noticed anymore. He'd carried the fire in him so long it was like his own heartbeat. But in the dark of the dome, with every lamp out, he could see it. A faint gold. Coming off his skin. Off his hands. Off his hair. The glow of a forge banked down for the night. The glow of a Worldforger.

He couldn't put it out. It was him.

"*Ilse*," he said. "*Ivo.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TWINS HAD BEEN waiting for this.

Lex saw it in their faces. In the way they grinned at each other in the dark. The quick fierce thieves' grin from the Wickhollow, before Dorran died, before the Rift, before everything.

"*Lights*," said Ilse.

"*Lots of lights*," said Ivo.

And they lit the dome.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT REAL LIGHTS. ILLUSIONS. They were the best illusionists in Caldor. They'd made fifty Queens dance in a ballroom. They'd made a dragon of light the size of a house wear a veil at a wedding.

They made lanterns.

Hundreds of them. All at once. Hanging in the air of the dome. Up and down the spiral of the shelves. On the galleries. Over the black water. Gold and red and white and blue. Paper lanterns and iron ones and great brass temple-lamps. Swinging gently on chains that weren't there, from hooks that weren't there. Burning with a light that wasn't there.

It was beautiful.

The moths went mad.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE CLOUD BROKE APART. Into a thousand streams. Each one making for a lantern. Any lantern. The nearest. The brightest. They

poured over the illusions like water over rocks. Brushing them. Settling on them. Beating against them.

Drinking.

And getting *nothing*.

Lex watched it. Watched a moth land on the glass of an illusory brass lamp and press its grey-gold wings against it and *drink*, and find nothing, and drink harder, and find nothing, and flutter off, confused, and go to the next one. And the next. And the next.

The Mothwing on the ledge were moving now. Rising. On their ragged wings. Gliding up into the dome toward the nearest lanterns. Reaching for them with their long pale hands.

Their hands went through.

Like the Unfinished, thought Lex. *Like my fire through the lined wolf. There's nothing there to hold.*

"*That won't hold them long*," said Ivo. Sweating. His hands were moving. Shaping. Holding the illusions in the air. "*They'll work it out. They're not stupid. They're just hungry.*"

"*How long*?"

"*Ten minutes*," said Ilse. "*Maybe less.*" She grinned. Fierce. "*Go.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN.

Fast. Down the spiral stair, past the rotted shelves, past the moths swarming the lanterns that weren't there. Lex first. Antho behind him, with the shuttered Lantern. Seraphine. Tilda with the hammer. Pim with the basket of cups on his back.

The five on the ledge saw them coming.

Brigid turned. With her hammer. A big rawboned woman with a face like a hatchet. She saw Lex coming down the last turn of the stair with gold coming off his skin and fire in his hands, and her face went white. And then set.

"*Smith*," she said.

"*Where is he*?"

"*Down*." She didn't lift the hammer. Not yet. "*Second floor. Third, by now. He'll be at the core soon.*" Her eyes went to the basket on Pim's back. "*What's that?*"

"*A way to close it*," said Lex. "*Without breaking it.*"

Brigid looked at him.

"*He told us you'd say that*," she said.

"*And*?"

"*And he said you'd mean it*." The hammer came up. Slowly. "*He also said it's not your call.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS KIT WHO stopped it.

The boy. Seventeen. White-faced. Standing at the back of the five on the ledge with a short pick in his hands that he didn't seem to know what to do with.

"*Brigid*," he said.

"*Not now, Kit*."

"*Brigid*. *Look at them.*"

He wasn't looking at Lex. He was looking up. At the moths. At the Mothwing. At the pale ragged figures gliding through the illusory lanterns with their long hands reaching and going through.

"*Look at them*," said Kit. His voice was shaking. "*That's what he's turning into. Isn't it? That's what she's making him.*"

The ledge went very quiet.

Brigid didn't look round. But her hammer stopped rising.

"*His eyes*," said Kit. "*You've seen. Since Thistledown. Since he went to see her in Highcrest. They've gone gold. Like hers. Like* theirs." He pointed up. At the Mothwing. "*And the cough's gone. Gone completely. Not better. Gone. In a week.*"

"*Kit*," said one of the Tull brothers. Low. Warning.

"*And there's something on his back*," said Kit. "*Under his coat. I've seen it. When he takes it off at night. Something—*"

He stopped.

He was crying.

"*Two humps*," said Kit. "*Like something folded. Under the skin.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The moths whirled overhead. The illusory lanterns swung. Ivo's voice came down from somewhere far above, strained, *five minutes, Lex, maybe four*.

Brigid looked at Lex.

For a long moment. Her hatchet face very still.

"*Get him out*," she said. Very low. "*Smith. If you can. Get him out of there before he breaks it.*" Her voice cracked. "*He's going to break it and go up and she's going to give him another sip and the wings are going to come through and he won't be Silas anymore.*"

She stepped aside.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HOLE IN THE water was twenty feet across. Black. Breathing.

Lex stood at the edge of it.

"*Seraphine*."

"*Third floor*." She had her eyes shut. Her hand on Antho's arm. "*Near the bottom. He's—he's near the core. He's walking toward it. Slowly.*" She opened her eyes. "*He's not fighting anything. There's nothing left to fight. He's just walking.*"

"*Can we fold it with him in it*?"

"*I don't know*."

"*Guess*."

Seraphine looked at the hole.

"*I think*," she said slowly, "*I think the room doesn't want to hurt anyone. I think if it goes home with him in it, it'll put him out. Like it put you out at Ashbourne.*" She swallowed. "*I think. I can't hear well enough to be sure. I've only been listening for four days.*"

Lex looked at Pim.

The boy had the basket off his back. He'd unwrapped one of the cups. He was holding it in his two hands, cupped round it, the way he held everything. Looking up at Lex.

Waiting.

"*Set it*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN, FROM THE hole, a voice.

Not the small one. Not the frightened one. Not *brother*. Not *Mal*.

A woman's.

Coming up out of the black. Out of the round dark in the water at the bottom of the Drowned Archive. Faint. Far. Echoing. As if it had come up a very long way. Up a shaft. Up a hole that went straight down to the bottom of the world.

"*Lex*."

He couldn't move.

"*Lex, love*."

His mother's voice.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THROUGH THE DOOR. Not through the black glass at the Hollowmaw, where Antho heard her. Not through the clay lamp. Here. In a drowned library in the middle of a fen. Coming up out of a hole in the water.

Up a shaft, thought Lex. *The broken ones. The shattered cores. The wounds that stay open.*

Straight down.

She's at the bottom of one.

"*Mam*," he said. Out loud. Hoarse. To the hole.

"*Listen to me*," said Seren Vey. Her voice was fading in and out. Like a voice on the wind. Like someone calling from the bottom of a well. "*Listen. I don't have long. It hurts to talk through these. They're wounds. It's like—like shouting through a cut.*"

"*Mam, we're coming—*"

"*No. Listen.*" Her voice came stronger. Hard. Cold. The voice Antho had heard through the door. The Harrow voice. "*They're coming down the holes. The moths. All of them. Down every broken one. There's twenty-six now. They're pouring down like smoke down a chimney.*"

A pause. The voice fading. Coming back.

"*And she's coming down*," said his mother. "*Herself. I can feel her. On the way. In the dark. She's coming down to us, Lex. To the little one.*"

A long pause.

"*To me*."

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN, FROM BELOW, from the third floor of the Delve, from somewhere very close to the core—

A sound.

Not a scream. Not yet. A *tightening*. Lex felt it through the Stone in him. Through the floor of the dome. Through the black water. A drawing-in. Like a breath before a blow. Like the moment before a hammer falls.

Antho went white.

"*He's at the core*," said Seraphine. "*He's standing over it. He's—*"

"*Pim*!"

Pim set the cup.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNELT AT THE edge of the hole. On the narrow stone ledge. In the faint grey-gold light, with the moths whirling overhead and the illusory lanterns swinging and the Mothwing reaching and reaching through nothing. He knelt and set the iron cup down on the black water at the edge of the hole. Gently. As if he were putting a candle on a windowsill.

And cupped his hands round it.

And was silent.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HOLE FOLDED.

Not slowly. Not like the cold-room. Fast. Like a door closing. Like an eye shutting. Like a hand drawn back from a flame.

Twenty feet. Ten. Five. Gone.

And as it went, it *put out* what was inside it.

Lex felt it happen. Felt the world turn over, gently, like a page. Felt something come up out of the folding dark and land on the ledge beside him, hard, rolling, in a clatter of steel plate and a grunt and the ring of a pick on stone.

Silas Hask.

On his back. On the wet stone ledge at the bottom of the Drowned Archive. With his pick still in his hand. Raised. Over his head. Ready to fall.

On nothing.

The water at the bottom of the dome was just water again. Black. Still. Faintly gleaming. With a small iron cup floating on it, rocking gently, quiet.

And under the cup, on the bottom of the pool, under a foot of black water, Lex could see it. A pebble. Black. Smooth. The size of a hen's egg.

Whole.

◆ ◆ ◆

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▒▒▒ DELVE — FOLDED ▒▒▒
Method: HUSH-CUP
"It went home. It wasn't hurt. It
 put everyone out on the doorstep,
 gently, and shut the door."
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```
LEX VEY
Level 91 → 92
"For making the first room that could
 be carried."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

SILAS HASK GOT UP.

Slowly. On one knee. Then the other. With his pick in one hand and the other flat on the wet stone. Breathing hard. He'd lost his helmet in the fall. His cropped grey-brown hair was wet.

He looked up at Lex.

And Lex saw his eyes.

Gold.

Not like Maelis's. Not lit. Not windows. Fainter. Duller. Like the Mothwing at Greyfall. Two dull gold sparks, deep in his weathered face, like the last coals in a grate.

And he wasn't coughing.

Not at all. His breath came deep and clean and easy, in and out, in the cold wet air of the dome. No rattle. No catch. Nothing.

"*Smith*," said Silas Hask.

His voice was the same. Rough. Calm. Reasonable.

"*You closed it*," he said. "*With me in it.*"

"*It let you out*."

"*I was standing over the core*." Hask looked down at the pick in his hand. At the point. "*I had it. It was right there. At my feet. I had the pick up.*" He looked at Lex. "*Do you know what that was worth? At my level? Five times? Do you know how far that would have taken me?*"

"*Yes*," said Lex.

Hask looked at him.

"*And you closed it anyway*."

"*Yes*."

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS HAD STOPPED.

Lex noticed it all at once. The illusory lanterns were gone. Ivo had let them go. The dome was dark again, except for the faint glow off Lex's own skin and the grey-gold glitter of the cloud overhead.

And the cloud wasn't moving.

It hung in the air of the dome. Still. Every moth. Thousands of them. With their wings spread. Their painted eyes. All turned the same way.

Toward Silas Hask.

And the Mothwing, on the galleries and the ledges and in the air, had stopped too. Their pale faces turned. Their dull gold eyes.

Toward him.

The way you'd turn toward someone who's just walked into the room. Someone important. Someone you've been told to watch.

Hask felt it. Lex saw him feel it. Saw the big man's shoulders go tight under his patched coat. Saw something move under the leather, between his shoulder blades. Two humps. Folded. Shifting.

Hask didn't look up at them.

He looked at Lex.

"I'm not hers," said Silas Hask. Very quietly. *"Whatever the boy told you. I'm not."*

"Your eyes—"

"She gave me a sip." Hask's voice didn't change. *"In Highcrest. In her drawing room. In the dark. Out of her own hands."* He touched his chest. *"And I breathed. For the first time in twenty-six years. All the way down. No grey."* He looked at Lex with his dull gold eyes. *"Do you know what that's like, smith? To breathe?"*

Lex didn't answer.

"I'm not hers," said Hask again. *"I'm mine. I'm finally mine. Nobody's Ceiling. Nobody's hewer. Nobody's."* He picked up his helmet off the stone. Put it on. *"She just helped."*

He turned. And whistled. Two notes.

And the Coldwater crew came to him. Slowly. Brigid. The Tulls. Absalom.

Not Kit.

Kit stood at the edge of the ledge. White. Shaking. And didn't move.

Hask looked at him. For a long moment.

"Kit," he said.

"I'm staying," said the boy. His voice cracked in half. *"I'm sorry. I'm sorry, Silas. I'm staying."*

Silas Hask looked at him a moment longer.

Then he nodded. Once. Like a man who's heard the roof creak and decided which way it's going to fall.

And turned. And walked up the spiral stair of the Drowned Archive. With his crew behind him.

And the moths went with him.

All of them. The whole glittering cloud. Rising off the bottom of the dome in a great slow spiral, following him up the stair. Like a cloak. Like a train. Like a shadow made of light.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD ON THE ledge for a long time after.

With his brother beside him. And Seraphine. And Pim, kneeling at the edge of the water, with his hands still cupped round nothing, and tears

running down his face, very quietly, because he was tired, and because it was over, and because it hadn't screamed.

It hadn't screamed. Lex had felt it go. Felt the thread draw back. Softly. Into the dark. Home.

Like a hand drawn back from a flame.

But he couldn't stop hearing the other thing.

She's coming down. Herself. To the little one.

To me.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO PUT THE LANTERN on the stone. And knelt beside Pim. And put his arm round the boy's shoulders.

"*It didn't scream*," said his brother. Very low. "*Lex. It didn't scream. I felt it go home. It was—*" He didn't have the word.

"*I know.*"

"*It was like the first one. The cold-room. It was glad.*"

"*I know.*" Lex was looking at the water. At the small iron cup, rocking gently on the black. "*Antho.*"

His brother looked up.

"*Twenty-six holes*," said Lex. "*She said. Twenty-six broken. Wide open. Straight down.*" He swallowed. "*And Maelis is going down one of them.*"

"*I know.*"

"*To Mam.*"

"*I know.*"

"*We can't fold those*," said Lex. "*Can we. The broken ones. There's no core to go home. There's just the wound.*" He looked at Seraphine. "*Can we?*"

Seraphine shook her head. Slowly.

"*I don't know*," she said. "*I don't think so. Not with a cup. A cup's a room. You can't put a wound in a room.*" She looked at the water. "*You'd have to—mend it. Stitch it. Somehow.*" Her voice was very small. "*I don't know how.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

He stood on the ledge at the bottom of the Drowned Archive and looked down at the black water. At the pebble lying whole on the bottom of the pool, under a foot of dark, humming.

And thought about a woman with lit eyes, folding her wings, leaning into a hole the way a moth leans into a gap in a shutter. Going down. Down. Down. Patient. Hungry. Toward the bottom of the world.

Toward a woman with a clay lamp, singing flat on the high note.

Toward something enormous and soft and young and frightened, that had been drunk dry once already, a long time ago, by a woman with lit eyes kneeling at the edge of a pool.

She looked at me like I was a lamp, it had told his brother. *Like I was a lamp she wanted to put her hands round.*

"*We have to go down*," said Lex.

Nobody answered.

They didn't have to.

CHAPTER 14

The Long Walk Up

SEREN VEY HAD BEEN walking for a year and a half, and her feet hurt.

That was the thing nobody ever told you about the bottom of the world. That your feet would hurt. All the old stories, the ones her mother told by the fire in twenty-two different cottages in twenty-two different valleys, the stories about heroes going down into the dark under the world, Listeners and kings and girls with lamps, none of them ever said *and her feet were killing her*.

They should have. It was the truest thing about it.

She stopped. And sat down. On nothing. On the dark. It held her up; it always did, down here. Like sitting on a cushion of air. And she took off her left shoe, which had been her right shoe once, a long time ago, until the left one wore through and she swapped, and rubbed her foot.

"*Again*?" said Isaura Kell.

"*Again*."

"*You stopped an hour ago*."

"*There aren't any hours down here*," said Seren. "*You keep saying that like there are hours. There aren't. There's walking and there's stopping. And I'm stopping*."

Kell looked at her.

She was standing a little way off. On the dark. Straight-backed. In robes that had been white once, Warden-white, the white of the High Warden of the Order of the Lattice, and were now the color of old candle-wax, torn at the hem and stained at the knees. She was tall and gaunt and grey, with her

hair cut short, very short, the way she'd cut it herself with a knife in the first month. Her face was all bones. Her eyes were very pale and very steady.

She'd been the most powerful woman in Caldor once. Tier IV. Level eighty-one. She'd had kings bow to her. She'd sent Wardens to burn hedge-witches.

She'd sent Wardens to burn women exactly like Seren.

"*Fine*," said Isaura Kell. And sat down too. On the dark. A little way off. Very straight. With her hands on her knees.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY'D WALKED A LONG way.

Seren didn't know how far. There was no way to know. There were no roads in the Hollow. No landmarks. No sun, no moon, no stars—

No. That wasn't true anymore. There were stars now.

That had been the first thing. After the Heart. After her boys reforged the net and the eaten worlds went up in gold and the river ran clean and the deep went from hunger to quiet. She'd looked up, at the bottom of the world, and there had been stars.

Not real stars. She didn't think. Little lights. Very far up. Scattered across the dark like seeds. Soft and silver and faint.

Shade, Antho had said. When she'd told him. Through the door, a hundred times since, in the long nights. *That's Shade, Mam. That's what Shade's dark looks like, when it's not being eaten. It's not empty. It's never been empty. It's just dark. Like the sky's dark.*

Her clever boy. Her clever dark boy, who listened.

So they walked under Shade's stars. Up. Always up. Not up like a hill. Up like a dream of rising. She'd tried to explain it to Kell once and given up. You just *knew* which way was up, down here. The way a plant knows. The way a child in the womb knows which way is out.

Toward the light.

Toward the lamp.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HAD THE LAMP in her lap now. She always had it. In her lap when she sat, in her hand when she walked. A small brown clay lamp. Round. Plain. With a chip in its spout and a thumbprint in its base. Her own

thumbprint. She'd made it at the kitchen table at Harrow, the summer Lex was born, out of clay from the stream.

It wasn't really the lamp. She knew that. The lamp was on the other side of the door. In a niche, in a cavern at the bottom of a mountain, with an iron one beside it and a new one beside that. Her boys had put it there. And a man she didn't remember filled it every night, and said good evening.

This was the *flame*. The other half of it. The light that came through. One flame on both sides of the door. That was how her mother had taught her to make it, a long time ago, in a cottage in the Ironbacks, by the fire. *A Harrow lamp*, Wenna had said. *For the ones who go. So there's always a light on both sides.*

She'd carried it into the dark thirteen years ago. With her hands shaking and her eldest son screaming on the stairs.

She'd never once let it go out.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's quiet*," said Kell.

Seren looked up.

The Warden was looking past her. Behind her. Down. The way they'd come.

At the little one.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D NEVER BE ABLE to describe it. She'd tried. To Kell, who didn't need it described, who could see it as well as she could. To herself. To her boys, through the door.

The best she'd managed was: *it's like the sky.*

Not the sky with stars. The sky *between* the stars. The soft deep dark that's not empty, that's full of something you can't see. If you took that, all of it, the whole night sky over the Vale on a clear winter night, and folded it up, and folded it again, and made it soft, and made it *warm*, and made it *young*—

And then put it behind you. On the long road up out of the dark. Following. Close. The way a child follows its mother through a crowd. With its hand in the back of her skirt.

That was the little one.

It went back and down from where they sat for miles. She couldn't see the end of it. A great soft slope of dark, darker than the dark, rising behind them like a hill. Like a sleeping animal. Like a wave that hasn't broken yet. You could only see it because it blotted out Shade's stars. Where it was, there were no stars. Just soft deep black, going up and back and away.

And it was quiet.

That was what Kell meant. It was *quiet*. It was usually humming. Singing. Talking. Asking. It talked all the time. In its small young voice, in Seren's head and in the dark all round them. *Lamp-lady. Lamp-lady, where are we going. Lamp-lady, what's up there. Lamp-lady, is Mal up there. Lamp-lady, will they like me.*

It wasn't talking now.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Little one*," said Seren. Out loud. Softly. "*Little lamb. What's wrong?*"

Nothing.

Then, very small, from everywhere at once:

[...it's going to happen again...]

Seren went still.

[...I can feel it...far up...someone standing over one of my hands...]

[...with something heavy...]

She was on her feet. She didn't remember standing. The lamp was in her hand and she was turning toward the great soft slope of dark behind her with her free hand out, open, the way you'd hold out your hand to a frightened horse.

"*I'm here*," she said. "*Lamb. I'm here. Hold on to me.*"

[...lamp-lady...]

And then the snap.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D FELT IT TWENTY-SIX times now. She'd never get used to it.

It came from far up. From the world. From one of the holes. The little hands it put up through the ground, the threads it reached toward the light. Somewhere up there, very far, in a place she couldn't see, someone brought something heavy down on the end of one of them.

And it *broke*.

She felt it go. Like a bone snapping. Like a twig. A small sharp crack, far off, that came down the thread like a shock down a rope.

And the little one *flinched*.

All of it. All at once. The whole vast soft slope of it behind them, miles of it, folded night-sky, shuddering. Like a dog shudders when it's struck. Like a child flinches from a raised hand. The dark round them went cold for an instant. The stars overhead flickered.

And it screamed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T LOUD. THAT was the worst thing. It was never loud. It was small. High. Thin. A sound you felt more than heard. In your chest. In your teeth. A child's cry in the night, in another room, when you're too far away to get there in time.

[...WHY...]

[...why why why I didn't DO anything...]

[...it HURTS...]

Seren was holding it.

She didn't know how. She never knew how. She just did. She stood on the dark with the lamp held up in one hand and her other hand flat on the nearest edge of it, on the soft cool dark that was its skin, if it had skin, and *held*. With her whole self. With the Listener in her, the old untaught hedge-witch part of her that had been talking to things nobody else could hear since she was three. She held on. And sang.

Little light, little light, burning low.

Flat. On the high note. She always was. She'd never been able to hit it. Her mother used to laugh at her.

Keep the door for the ones who go.

And the shudder went on. And on. And slowly, slowly, under her hand, under her voice, it began to ease.

[...lamp-lady...]

If the dark comes calling, don't you mind—

[...lamp-lady it hurts...]

"I know," said Seren. Singing it. Into the dark. *"I know, my lamb. I know. I've got you."*

A lantern's lit for the ones behind.

◆ ◆ ◆

WHEN IT WAS OVER, she sat down again.

Not on purpose. Her legs went. She sat down on the dark with the lamp in her lap and her hands shaking and her face wet.

Kell was there. Crouched beside her. With one hand on her shoulder. Not holding. Just there. Kell was never very good at holding.

"Twenty-seven," said Isaura Kell. Quietly.

"I know."

"It's getting faster."

"I know."

The Warden was silent for a moment.

"They don't know what they're doing," said Kell. *"Up there. They don't know it's alive."*

"I know that too."

"I did," said Kell.

Seren looked at her.

The gaunt grey face was very still. The pale eyes were looking at the dark. At the great soft slope of it, behind them, settling. Trembling a little still. The way a horse trembles after a fright.

"For forty years," said Isaura Kell. *"I put children's hands on Stones and pushed down. I sent Wardens to hunt women who talked to fire. I signed warrants for unlatticed sorcery. Forty-one of them. I remember every name."* She was quiet. *"I didn't think they were alive either. Not really. Not the way I was. They were threads. Numbers. Risks."*

She looked at her own hands. Long. Thin. Bony.

"I knew," she said. *"Somewhere. I always knew. And I did it anyway. Because it was the law, and the law kept things safe, and safe was the only thing I knew how to want."*

She looked at Seren.

"Those people up there don't know," said Kell. *"That's not the same as me. They're better than me. They just don't know."*

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

She'd had a year and a half of this. Walking up out of the dark with the woman who'd been High Warden of the Order of the Lattice. Who'd hunted her mother, though she didn't know it. Who'd hunted women exactly like her. Who'd been unwritten by the Key, eaten by the hunger, dragged down to the bottom of the world with her name torn off, and had stood at the Heart with no face and no name and been given both back by a smith reading out of a ledger.

Dorran Vask carried you. That was what had done it. That was what Lex had said. And something had come back into Isaura Kell's empty face, like a lamp being lit in a window.

And then she'd gone and sealed the Hollowmaw threshold from the inside. *Warden by gift*. Seren had watched her do it. Stand in front of the great black door at the bottom of the world, from the dark side, and put her bony hands on it, and *hold*.

And then she'd turned round. And looked at Seren. And said, *I'm not going back. Not yet. You'll want company.*

Seren had laughed. She couldn't help it. *You*? she'd said. *Company? You sent Wardens to burn people like me.*

Yes, Kell had said. *I know. That's why.*

They'd been walking ever since.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're not that woman anymore*," said Seren.

"*I am*," said Kell. "*I'm exactly that woman. I just know what she did now.*" She stood up. Straight-backed. Brushing off her ruined robes, which didn't need brushing, which nothing could clean. "*That's not redemption. That's arithmetic.*"

Seren looked up at her.

"*You know*," she said, "*for a woman who keeps saying she's not good company, you're very good company.*"

Isaura Kell looked down at her.

Something moved at the corner of her thin mouth. Very slightly. It might have been a smile. It was hard to tell. Kell didn't smile often, and

when she did it came out sideways, like a door that hadn't been opened in years and had forgotten how to swing.

"*Put your shoe on*," said Isaura Kell. "*We should keep walking.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY KEPT WALKING.

Up. Under Shade's stars. With the little one behind them, following, its great soft dark rising and falling like breath.

Seren talked to it. She always talked to it, when they walked. It liked that. It liked her voice. It had liked it, it told her, since the very beginning. Since a woman with a lamp came into the dark thirteen years ago and sat with her back against a door and sang to a boy on the other side, flat on the high note, every night, for eight years.

[...I heard you...] it said. *[...all that time...I didn't know what you were...I was the other thing then...]*

I know, lamb.

[...I was so hungry...I wanted to eat you...and then I wanted to listen...]

I know.

[...you sang flat...]

"*Everyone says that*," said Seren. Out loud. Indignant. "*Everyone. My mother. My boys. Kell.*"

"*You do sing flat*," said Kell.

"*It's not flat. It's a choice.*"

[...it's flat...] said the little one. And something came with it. Something she'd never felt from it before, in all the months of walking. A ripple. Through the whole great soft dark of it. Small and bright and quick. Like a breeze across a still pond. Like a cat's tail flicking.

Seren stopped walking.

"*Did you just—*" She turned round. Looked up at the great soft slope of dark behind her. "*Did you just* laugh *at me?*"

[...]

[...maybe...]

Seren Vey stood on the dark at the bottom of the world and laughed. Out loud. Until her sides ached. Until Kell, beside her, made a small dry sound that might, if you were being generous, have been a laugh too.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT ASKED ABOUT MAL again that night.

It asked every night. When they stopped. When Seren lay down on the dark with the lamp beside her and her shoe off and her head on her arm. When it was quiet, and the stars were very far, and the little one curled round them in the dark like a cat round a hearth.

[...lamp-lady...]

"*Mm*."

[...where's Mal...]

She'd told it. A hundred times. She told it again.

"*He's gone, lamb*," she said. Softly. "*He went down. Into the deep. Into the very middle of you. With his brother. The one who held you. The old one, with the hammer.*" She was quiet. "*They went down together. Singing. And they stayed.*"

[...but where...]

"*In you*," said Seren. "*In the middle. Where it's warmest. That's where they are.*"

The little one was quiet for a long time.

[...I can feel them...] it said at last. Very small. *[...in the middle...two little lights...very still...]*

[...they don't talk...]

"*No*," said Seren. "*They don't talk anymore. They're resting.*"

[...why...]

She didn't know how to answer that. She'd never known. Her mother had died in a cottage in the Vale when Seren was nineteen, and she'd sat by the bed and held her hand, and at the end Wenna Harrow had opened her eyes and said *light the lamp for me*, and closed them. And Seren had sat there all night with the lamp lit and asked *why*. And nobody had ever answered.

"*Because they were very old*," she said at last. "*And very tired. And they'd done what they came to do.*" She swallowed. "*Mal sat with you. So you wouldn't be alone. That's what he came to do. And when you weren't alone anymore, when you had me, and Kell, and my boys through the door, he could rest.*"

The little one was quiet.

[...he sang...] it said. *[...the whole time...he sang the same song you do...]*

"*Did he*?"

[...he sang it in tune...]

Seren laughed. Into her arm. Her eyes stinging.

"*Well*," she said. "*He would. Clever old goat.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DREAMED OF THE man again.

She always did. She'd dreamed of him for thirteen years. Since the first winter. Since she'd stood on the shingle at the edge of a grey river and the Ferryman had said *the memory you would least wish to lose* and she'd paid.

Not of him. Of the hole where he'd been.

That was the dream. Always. Her life. The whole of it. Every day she remembered. And in every one of them, a gap. A shape. Where someone should have been standing.

She dreamed of the night Antho was born. In the cottage at Harrow. With her mother dead a year and the midwife from Ashbourne and the snow coming down outside. And someone holding her hand. All night. She could feel it. A hand in hers. Long fingers. Cool. Steady. She could feel the hand.

She couldn't see who it belonged to.

She dreamed of Lex at two. Sick with a fever. Screaming. And someone walking him up and down the kitchen at three in the morning, up and down, up and down, singing something low that wasn't the Lantern Song, that was something else, something old, in a voice—

She couldn't hear the voice.

She dreamed of a coat on a hook by the door. Grey. Long. A man's coat. She'd seen it every day for eight years. She'd brushed it. She'd mended its elbows. She could feel the wool under her fingers.

She didn't know whose it was.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WOKE WITH HER face wet.

Kell was sitting up. A little way off. Straight-backed. Watching the dark. She always watched, when Seren slept. She said she didn't need to sleep much. Seren didn't believe her.

"*The coat again*?" said Kell.

"*The coat*."

"*You were talking*."

"*What did I say*?"

"*You said, why are your hands so cold*." Kell didn't look round. "*And then you said, don't, I'll do it, you'll burn the porridge.*"

Seren laughed. Wetly.

"*I don't know him*," she said. "*Kell. I don't know him at all. I'm going home to a man I've been married to for thirty years and I don't know what he looks like. I don't know what he sounds like when he laughs. I don't know if he snores. I don't know if he takes salt in his porridge.*"

"*You know his voice*."

"*I know a voice*." Seren sat up. "*Through the Root. In the dark. Three years of nights, before the Heart. A voice that talked to me. And I talked back.*" She looked at the lamp. "*I fell in love with it. Isn't that stupid? I fell in love with a voice in the dark. Not knowing who it was. And then the boys told me, at the Heart. That's him. That's Father. That's your husband.*"

She was quiet.

"*And now the Root's gone*," she said. "*My boy gave it away. And the voice is gone with it. And I'm walking home to a man who was that voice. And I don't know if I'll know him.*"

Kell didn't say anything for a long time.

"*He fills the lamp*," she said at last. "*Every night. You said.*"

"*Every night*."

"*And says good evening*."

"*Every night*."

"*For a year and a half*," said Isaura Kell. "*To a woman who doesn't know who he is.*" She looked at Seren with her pale steady eyes. "*I knew him for forty years. Arion Vey. Warden-Architect. The most infuriating man in the Spire. Always right. Never once raised his voice. Never once told anyone anything.*" Something moved at the corner of her mouth. "*I hated him. Very much. For a long time.*"

"*And*?"

"*And I don't think he's ever said good evening to anything in his life*," said Kell. "*Not before you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS CAME ON the next walk.

Seren felt them first. Before Kell. Before the little one. Before anything.

A prickle. On the back of her neck. On her arms. Like the feeling in the air before a storm.

Like the feeling her mother used to get, at the end of summer, in the evenings, in twenty-two different cottages. When she'd stop in the middle of whatever she was doing, and go still, and lift her head, and sniff the air like a dog. And then go and close the shutters. All of them. And light the lamp inside. And get the broom.

"*Kell*," said Seren.

"*I feel it*."

They stopped walking.

Above them. Far up. In the dark between Shade's stars. Something was coming down.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE COULDN'T SEE THEM at first. Only the stars. Going out. One by one. Far up. As something passed in front of them.

And then the glitter.

Faint. Grey-gold. Coming down out of the dark from very high up. Not falling. *Drifting*. The way snow drifts when there's no wind. The way dust drifts in a sunbeam. Thousands of tiny points of glitter, coming down in long slow spirals.

From the holes.

She knew it at once. She'd felt them open. Every one. Twenty-seven of them. Twenty-seven wounds in the little one, twenty-seven threads snapped off, twenty-seven open shafts running from the world down into the deep. Like chimneys. Like wells. Like holes in a roof.

And down them, now, like smoke down a chimney when the wind turns, the moths.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LITTLE ONE SAW them.

Seren felt it see them. The whole vast soft slope of it, behind them, going rigid. Every inch of it. Like a hare when the hawk's shadow crosses the field.

[...no...]

[...no no no no...]

[...THEM...]

"Lamb—"

[...THEM...it's THEM...they're coming...they're coming BACK...]

And it moved.

Not toward them. Away. Down. Back. The great soft dark of it pulling in on itself. Folding. Drawing back down the long slope the way they'd come. Away from the glitter. Away from the moths.

Away from her.

"No!" Seren was running. Back. Down. After it. With the lamp held up. *"No, lamb, don't—don't go back down, you've come so far—"*

[...they DRANK me...]

[...they knelt down and they DRANK me...]

[...she looked at me like a LAMP...]

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST MOTHS REACHED them.

Seren didn't stop running. She heard Kell shout something behind her. She didn't turn. She ran down the dark after the little one with her lamp held high and the moths came down round her like snow.

They went for the lamp.

Of course they did. It was the only light down here. The only real light, in all the soft deep dark at the bottom of the world. A Harrow lamp. A light left on.

They came down on it in a cloud. Grey-gold. Glittering. Wings beating. Drinking—

And couldn't.

Seren felt it. Felt them press against the flame, the little flame in its clay cup, and *pull*, and get—nothing. Not nothing. Something. But not what

they wanted. They pressed and pressed and the flame stayed the same. Small. Gold. Steady.

And they fell back. Confused. Fluttering.

Of course, she thought. Running. *Of course. Mam's lamp. A Harrow lamp.*

It's not kept. It's given. It's a light for someone else.

They can't drink what's already been given away.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHWING CAME AFTER the moths.

She saw them in the glitter. Pale shapes. Gliding down out of the dark on ragged wings. Long hands reaching. Lit eyes, dull gold, like coals. Five. Ten. Twenty.

They didn't go for the lamp.

They'd seen it. They'd seen the moths fail. They were older than moths, and cleverer, and hungrier. They glided down past the lamp. Past Seren. Down the long dark slope.

Toward the little one.

◆ ◆ ◆

KELL MET THEM.

Seren would never know how she got there. One moment she was behind, shouting. The next she was in front. Between the Mothwing and the great soft retreating dark. Standing on nothing. Straight-backed. In her ruined white robes.

With a staff.

Seren had never seen her with a staff. She didn't know where it came from. A long plain stick of dark wood, like a shepherd's crook without the crook. Maybe Kell had carried it all along. Maybe she'd made it out of the dark. Maybe it was just the shape of what she'd been, for forty years, a Warden of the Order, standing in front of things with a staff in her hands.

The first Mothwing reached her.

And Isaura Kell, sixty-something, gaunt, grey, with no class and no level and no thread in the net at all, swung the staff.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WASN'T TRYING TO kill them. Seren saw that. She *couldn't* kill them, probably. They came apart into dust when you struck them, the way they did, and then the dust drifted and began to gather again.

She was trying to *stop* them.

She stood in front of the little one and swung the staff and every Mothwing that came at her, she knocked aside. Not hard. Precisely. A Warden's training. Forty years of it. The way they taught cadets in the Spire to hold a door. Not with strength. With position. With knowing exactly where to stand.

They broke round her like water round a stone.

And behind her, the little one stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN FELT IT STOP. Felt it turn. The whole vast soft dark of it. Pausing in its flight. Looking back. At the gaunt grey woman in white, standing in the dark between it and the things that had drunk it, with a stick.

[...the Warden...]

[...the Warden is standing in front of me...]

"*Yes*," said Seren. Breathless. Running up beside Kell with her lamp. "*Yes, lamb. She is.*"

[...why...]

Kell didn't look round. She swung the staff. A Mothwing came apart into dust. She shifted her feet. Waited. Swung again.

"*Because you're mine*," said Isaura Kell. Through her teeth. "*Gods help me. I walked you all the way up here. A year and a half. I'm not letting them have you now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE GLITTER stopped.

All at once. The moths. The Mothwing. Every one. Hanging in the dark. Not moving. Wings still. Lit eyes turned. Up.

Toward something coming down.

Seren looked up.

She saw a star go out. Far up. Directly overhead. And then another. And another. A line of them. Going out one by one. Coming down. Toward her.

Something large.

Something folded. Close. Wings tight against its back. Leaning into the dark the way a moth leans into a gap in a shutter. Patient. Slow. Coming down the longest, deepest shaft in the world.

And at the front of it, two lights.

Gold. Warm. Soft.

Like windows.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME DOWN ONTO the dark in front of them.

Lightly. On her toes. Like a dancer. Her long grey-gold gown settling round her. Her silver hair falling to her knees. Her wings unfolding, slowly, enormously, behind her, filling the dark, patterned with rings and whorls and eyes.

She didn't look at Kell.

She didn't look at Seren. Not at first.

She looked past them both. Up. At the great soft slope of dark behind them. Rising. Folded night. Miles of it. Young and soft and full and *frightened*.

And her face—

Seren had seen a lot of faces. She'd been a hedge-witch for thirty years. She'd sat by sickbeds. She'd delivered babies. She'd watched a man see his wife come back from the dead, once, in a cottage in the Ironbacks, when the fever broke.

She'd never seen a face like this.

It was *longing*. Pure. Total. The way a person looks at the sea after thirty years inland. The way a starving man looks at bread. The way a lover looks at someone they lost a long time ago and never thought they'd see again.

Maelis of the Crowned stood at the bottom of the world and looked at the Well she'd drunk dry nine hundred years before.

And her lit eyes filled with tears.

"*Oh*," she whispered. "*Oh, look at you. Look at you. You've grown back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND SEREN, THE LITTLE one made a sound.

Not a word. Not a scream. A sound like nothing she'd ever heard. Low. Long. Shaking. The sound a thing makes when the worst thing it has ever known walks back into the room.

And it went *still*.

Not frozen. Not fleeing. *Still*. The way a rabbit goes still when it knows the fox has seen it. When there's nowhere left to run, and running would only make it worse.

Seren felt it. Felt the whole vast soft dark of it go still behind her. Felt it make itself small. As small as something the size of a mountain can make itself. Pressing down. Pressing in. Trying not to be seen.

She lifted the lamp.

She didn't decide to. Her hand did it on its own. The way her mother's hand had done it, in twenty-two cottages, at the end of every summer. Lifted the lamp. Up. High. Between the thing behind her and the thing in front of her.

A light. Given. Not kept.

The Moth Queen's eyes moved.

Down. From the little one. To the lamp. To the small clay lamp in Seren's square strong hand. And then, slowly, to Seren's face.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT SEREN for a long time.

At her face. Small and freckled and fierce. At her hair, brown, going grey, tied back with nothing, because the blue cloth had worn through years ago. At her hands. At her hand on the lamp.

And something moved in the Moth Queen's beautiful face. Something that wasn't longing. Something older. Something that had been waiting nine hundred years in a grey country with no sun.

Recognition.

"*Oh*," said Maelis. Very softly. "*Oh, there you are.*"

Seren didn't move.

"*I'd know those hands anywhere*," said the Moth Queen. "*Square. Strong. Too big for the rest of you.*" She tilted her head. "*Holding up a lamp. Of course. Of course you are. She always did that too.*"

She took a step forward.

Kell's staff came up. Between them. Straight. Steady.

Maelis didn't look at it. She didn't look at Kell. She looked at Seren. Over the staff. With her lit eyes warm and soft and gold and very, very hungry.

"*Sister's girl*," said Maelis of the Crowned.

She smiled.

"*You have something of mine*."

CHAPTER 15

The Door Opens Down

KESTREL VARN WALKED INTO the Lantern Keep on a Tuesday, with her hair on fire.

Not badly. Just at the ends. She'd been walking for three weeks, she said, from the Sunreach, north across the Scald and up through the Vale and over the foothills, and somewhere around Thistledown she'd stopped bothering to keep it down. It burned gold. Quietly. All the time. Like a lamp left on in a window. It had singed her collar black.

She stood in the cave mouth in the late afternoon sun with a pack on her back and a new scar on her chin and a Sunreach blade at her hip, curved, in a red leather sheath. Brown from the southern sun. Thinner. Harder. With something in her amber eyes that hadn't been there a year ago.

She looked at Antho. Then past him. Down the long passage. At the lanterns. At the two hundred and six dark ones, still dark, with dust on their glass.

"*I got your raven*," said Kestrel.

"*Which one*?"

"*All four*." She shrugged off her pack. "*The first one said moths. The second one said a woman with lit eyes. The third one said she's my great-great-something aunt. The fourth one said we're going down.*" She looked at him. "*I stopped reading after that and started walking.*"

"*It's dangerous*," said Antho.

Kestrel looked at him with her amber eyes for a long moment.

Then she laughed. The old laugh. The one from the Temple of Ysmir, two years ago, on the White Shore, when she was a fire-witch with no thread who'd do anything to get her brother's name back.

"Antho," said Kestrel Varn. *"Love. It's always dangerous. That's why you write to me."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY HELD THE COUNCIL in the library.

All of them. Around the long table, with Malachi's box at one end and Seraphine's map on the wall, black pins everywhere, forty-one, fifty-three now, and a new cluster of red ones. Twenty-seven red pins. The broken ones. The shafts.

Lex. Wren. Seraphine. Kestrel. Odile. Pim, under the table, as always. Ivy Moss on her stool. The twins, who'd come back from Qel'Varran with them and hadn't left. Tilda, with Brannoc's hammer across her knees. Kit, the Coldwater boy, who'd walked out of the Drowned Archive behind them and kept walking, all the way to the Keep, and sat now at the very end of the table, very white, not speaking, with his hands clenched in his lap.

And at the head of the table, in the big chair, wrapped in a blanket, with his grey book open in front of him and his stick against the arm of the chair—

Their father.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D COME BACK FROM Highcrest that morning.

On Vharuun's neck. In Brannoc's chair. He'd heard about Qel'Varran from a Keeper's raven. *Seren's voice. Up a shaft. She's coming down*. And he'd got up out of his chair by the window in the Spire, and called for the dragon, and come.

Lex had carried him up the stairs from the cave mouth.

All two hundred and eleven. Without stopping. With his father's arms round his neck and his father's head on his shoulder. He weighed nothing. Nothing at all. Like carrying a bundle of sticks. Like carrying a bird.

Antho had watched them come up. And counted the steps. And had to turn away.

He was seventy-five now. Or near it. The grey book said so. His hair was white and thin as thistledown. His hands shook all the time. He had to hold his cup with both of them. His eyes, behind Seraphine's spare spectacles, were still the same grey. Still clear. Still steady.

Still listening.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*We have to go down*," said Lex.

He said it to the whole table. He'd said it at Qel'Varran, standing on the ledge at the bottom of the Drowned Archive. He'd said it on the flight back. He'd said it at dinner, and at breakfast, and to Wren in the dark in the guest room, over and over, until she'd put her hand over his mouth and said *I know, Hammer. I know. I heard you the first nine times.*

Nobody argued.

That was the strange thing. Antho had expected an argument. There was always an argument. That was how they thought, round this table. Somebody said a thing, and somebody else said *but*, and they went round and round until the thing was worn smooth and true.

Nobody said *but*.

"*She's going down to Mam*," said Lex. "*Mam said so. Up the shaft. She's coming down to us. To the little one. To me.*" He looked round the table. "*She's going down there to finish what she started nine hundred years ago. And Mam's standing between them with a lamp.*"

"*And Kell*," said Seraphine. Quietly.

"*And Kell*." Lex nodded. "*Two women. One with a lamp and one with no thread. Against her.*" He put his hands flat on the table. "*We have to go down.*"

"*How*?" said Kestrel.

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS THE ARGUMENT.

Not *whether*. *How*.

"*The shafts*," said Tilda. "*The broken ones. That's how she's going. Straight down.*"

"*They're wounds*," said Seraphine. "*Open ones. You'd be climbing down the inside of a cut. It would hurt it. Every step.*" She shook her head. "*And*

they go straight to the little one. Into it. Not to your mother. We don't know where she is."

"*The Ferryman*," said Ilse. "*He took you all the way to the Heart last time.*"

"*He won't*," said Antho.

Everyone looked at him.

"*He won't take anyone down*," said Antho. "*Not now. He said so. He said he wouldn't carry the Crowned. And he's angry. I could feel it. Angry about the shafts. About his river. About what she's doing.*" He looked at his hands. "*He's not going to row anyone into the deep while she's down there. Not for any price.*"

"*Then how*?" said Kestrel again.

Antho didn't answer.

He didn't need to. He felt his brother look at him. Felt his father look at him. Felt every eye at the table turn, slowly, to him.

And then, one by one, past him.

To the floor. To the stone. Down. Through two hundred feet of mountain. To the bottom of the long passage. To a bell-shaped cavern, and a niche, and three lamps.

And a door.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's Kell's*," said Antho.

He hadn't meant to say anything. He'd been sitting very still, the whole council, with his hands folded round the Lantern. He'd been thinking about it since Qel'Varran. Since the moment Lex said *we have to go down*. He'd known it then.

"*The door*," he said. "*At the Heart. Lex gave it to her. You said it was yours now. And she took it. And sealed it from the inside.*" He looked up. "*She's the Warden of it. By gift. It's hers. Not mine.*"

"*You're the Threshold Warden*," said Seraphine.

"*I'm the one who stands between*." Antho looked down at the Lantern. "*That's what the net said. Not the one who opens. Not the one who closes. The one who stands in the doorway and decides.*" He was quiet. "*I don't know if I can open someone else's door.*"

"*Have you tried*?" said Kestrel.

Antho looked at her.

"*No*," he said.

"*Well*," said Kestrel Varn. "*There's your problem.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING during the council.

Antho noticed. He noticed everything about Wren now. He couldn't help it. He was going to be an uncle. He'd been going to be an uncle for three weeks and it had changed something in him he didn't have a name for. He watched her the way he'd watched Pim, the first winter. The way he watched the bats.

She sat beside Lex. Very straight. With her bow on the table in front of her and her hand on the bow. Not on her stomach. On the bow. As if she'd decided to put it there.

She didn't argue. She didn't say *I'm coming*. She didn't say *I'm not staying*.

She'd known since Qel'Varran. Antho could see it. She'd known standing at the edge of the fen on dry ground, with her bow and her wind, watching the dome. That this time she couldn't come.

He saw Lex look at her. Over and over. Through the whole council. And look away.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FOUND THEM ON the slope that night.

He hadn't meant to. He'd gone out to check on Ashka, who'd been restless since the moths, and found her curled in the snow at the bottom of the slope with her great blue head on her forepaws. And beyond her, sitting on the rock where Pim always sat, two figures.

He stopped. In the shadow of the dragon's wing. And didn't go any closer.

"*I hate this*," said Wren.

Her voice carried. The night was very still.

"*I know*."

"*I hate it. I hate it more than anything. More than the Spire. More than the month on the roof.*" She was quiet for a moment. "*At least on the roof I*

chose it. I could have come after you. I didn't, because Arion needed guarding and I promised. But I could have."

"I know."

"This isn't a choice." Her voice cracked. *"This is just—a fact. Like weather. Like a Ceiling. Somebody else decided it and I have to live with it."* She laughed. It didn't sound like a laugh. *"It's the size of a pea, Lex. A pea. And it's put a Ceiling on me."*

Lex didn't say anything.

Antho saw him reach out. In the dark. And take her hand. The left one. With the black iron ring on it.

"It's not a Ceiling," said Lex. *"Wren. It's not."*

"Then what is it?"

"It's a door," said his brother. *"You're standing in it. For someone else. So they can come through."* He was quiet. *"That's what Antho does. That's what Kell does. That's what Mam did for thirteen years."*

Wren didn't say anything.

"You're holding the top," said Lex. *"That's not staying home. That's the hardest job there is. Someone has to be here when we come up. Someone has to hold the door open from this side. Someone has to watch for moths."* His voice dropped. *"Someone has to be the light we're coming home to."*

There was a long silence.

"That's a terrible speech," said Wren. Her voice was wet. *"That's the worst speech I've ever heard. Did Ember write that?"*

"No."

"It's terrible." She was crying. Antho could hear it. *"I hate it. I hate you. Come here."*

Antho went back up the slope very quietly. And didn't look back.

◆ ◆ ◆

IN THE MORNING, AT the cave mouth, she gave Lex a bottle.

Antho was there. Everyone was. Kestrel with her Sunreach blade and her hair burning. Seraphine with her notebook and a pack of food and three lamps. Odile and Pim and the students, crowded in the cave mouth to see them off. Ivy Moss. Kit.

Wren held it out.

It was small. Glass. Clear. The size of a thumb. With a cork in it, sealed with wax.

It was empty.

Lex looked at it. Then at her.

"*It's not empty*," said Wren. "*It's a breath.*"

He stared at her.

"*From the Wellworld of Gale*," she said. "*From the eye of the storm. The First Breath. I carried it in my lungs for three days, to the Hollowmaw, to forge the Lockward. Remember?*" She looked at the bottle. "*I kept a little. At the end. Just a little. I breathed it into this. I don't know why. I thought—*" She stopped. "*I thought someday someone might need air. Somewhere there isn't any.*"

She put it in his hand. And closed his fingers round it.

"*There's no wind in the deep*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Seren told Antho. Nothing moves. Nothing breathes.*" She looked up at him. "*If you need air down there, Hammer. If you need wind. If you need* me."

She let go of his hand.

"*Open it*," she said. "*And breathe.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEIR FATHER CAME DOWN to the door.

Lex carried him. Down the long passage. Past the lanterns, lit and dark. Past nine hundred and seven gold ones and two hundred and six with dust on their glass. Into the bell-shaped cavern at the bottom of the mountain.

He set him down in a chair Odile had brought. By the niche. By the three lamps.

The clay one. The iron one. The *ARDENT* one. Burning. Small and gold and steady.

Arion looked at them for a long time.

Then he reached into his coat. Slowly. With his shaking hand. And took out a letter.

Folded. Thick. Many pages. Sealed with plain grey wax and a thumbprint.

"*For your mother*," he said.

Lex looked at it.

"*If she wants it*," said Arion. "*Only if. Don't give it to her if she doesn't want it. Don't give it to her if she's frightened, or hurt, or—*" He stopped. "*Ask her first. Ask her if she wants a letter from a man she doesn't remember. And if she says no—*" His voice went very quiet. "*Burn it. Please. Don't bring it back. I don't want to know.*"

"*What's in it*?" said Antho.

His father looked at him.

"*Everything*," said Arion Vey. "*The steps. The rain. The lanterns. What she said about the story. What I said back.*" He swallowed. "*I've been writing it for a year and a half. Since the Heart. Every night after I filled the lamps.*" He looked at the clay one. "*In case I don't get to tell her myself.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STOOD IN FRONT of the door.

Black glass. Tall. Smooth. Sealed. A door to nowhere. A door to the dark under the world. He'd stood in front of it a thousand times. He'd stood behind it, once, with his back to the hunger. He'd put his hand on it every night for three years and said *evening, Mam* to a lamp.

He'd never opened it.

He'd never tried.

He put his hand on it now.

Cold. Smooth. On the other side, the deep. Shade's dark. Starlit. Quiet. And very far down, so far he could barely feel it, something vast and soft and young, gone very still. Like a hare in a field. Like a child hiding under a bed.

[...brother...]

So faint. A whisper from the bottom of a well.

[...brother she's here...the moth...she's HERE...]

I know, thought Antho. *I'm coming.*

He pushed.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOTHING HAPPENED.

The glass was cold and smooth and sealed and didn't move. He pushed harder. With his hand. With the Lantern. With Shade, Commanding, reaching into the dark of the door and asking it to open.

Nothing.

He reached for the thing the net had given him. *Threshold Warden*. The one who stands between. He reached for it the way you reach for a word you know you know. And found it. A sense. A weight. A place in him that was a doorway, that he could stand in, that he could decide from.

He stood in it. And decided.

Open.

The door didn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's not yours*," said Seraphine. Quietly. Behind him. "*Antho. It's hers. You said.*"

"*I know*."

"*You can't decide for a door that isn't yours*."

"*I know*." He was breathing hard. His hand was flat on the glass. His forehead was nearly touching it. "*I know. I know.*"

"*Then don't*," said Kestrel.

He turned his head. She was standing beside Lex. With her arms crossed and her hair burning and her amber eyes on him.

"*Don't decide*," said Kestrel Varn. "*Ask.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT HER for a long moment.

Ask.

He thought about the Undertow, in the Wellworld of Tide, which hated stillness and had to be asked nicely. He thought about Lex, in the cellar at Harrow, asking a stone in the wall to move. He thought about the Hearth. *You're not making it do anything, lad. You're asking it nicely to be something else for a while.*

He thought about every door he'd ever stood in. Every one. Not one of them had been his. The cave in the Greyspine had been the mountain's. The Hollowmaw had been the world's. The doorway at the bottom of the Heart had been the hunger's, and Lex's, and he'd stood in it and decided because there was nobody else to.

He'd never once knocked.

He lifted his hand off the glass.

And knocked.

◆ ◆ ◆

THREE TIMES. WITH HIS knuckles. On the black glass. Softly. The way you knock on a door at night in a house where someone might be sleeping.

The sound went into the door. And through it. And down.

Into the deep. Into the dark. Into Shade's starlit nothing. Down and down and down. Antho felt it go. Like a stone dropped down a well. Like a voice calling into a cave.

Kell, he thought. Into the knock. Into the door. *Isaura Kell. Warden of this door. It's Anthoren Vey. Seren's son.*

May we come in?

◆ ◆ ◆

FOR A LONG TIME, nothing.

The door was cold. The cavern was silent. Behind him, he could hear his brother breathing. Seraphine. Kestrel. His father, in the chair by the niche, very still.

And then, very far off—

He felt it.

A hand. On the other side of the door. Not near. Very far down. Very faint. A long thin bony hand, laid flat on the black glass from the dark side, the way he'd laid his own on it a thousand times.

Weak. Shaking.

Hurt.

And a voice. Dry. Thin. Precise. A voice that had given orders for twenty years. Coming up through the door from the bottom of the world, so faint he had to hold his breath to hear it.

[...Vey...]

[...about time...]

[...come in, then...]

[...hurry...]

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DOOR OPENED.

Not like a door. Not swinging. Not sliding. The black glass simply—*stopped being there*. From the middle outward. Like ice melting. Like breath clearing off a window. A circle of not-glass, opening in the center of the door, and widening, and widening, until there was an arch. Tall. Round-topped. The shape of the door. Full of dark.

Not black. Not the round flat black of a Delve.

Dark. Deep. Soft. Endless. Going down. With faint silver points scattered through it, very far off, like stars.

And cold air coming out of it. Cold and still and smelling of nothing at all.

Behind Antho, someone made a sound. Small. Like a breath let out after a long time held.

His father.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION WAS ON HIS feet.

Antho didn't know how. He couldn't stand without his stick. He couldn't do stairs. Lex had carried him down two hundred and eleven of them that morning like a bundle of sticks.

He was standing. By the niche. With one hand on the stone and the other reaching out. Toward the open door. Toward the dark. His thin old face white. His grey eyes enormous behind Seraphine's spectacles.

"*Seren*," said Arion Vey.

The dark didn't answer.

He took a step. Toward it. And another. Shaking. Slowly. An old man walking toward a door.

Lex caught him.

Gently. Both arms round him. From behind. And held him. And didn't let him go.

"*Father*," said Lex. "*No.*"

"*She's there—*"

"*I know.*" Lex's voice was rough. "*I know she is. I'll bring her. I promise. I'll bring her home.*" He held on. "*You can't come. You'd never make it back up. You know you wouldn't.*"

Arion stood in his son's arms. Shaking. With his hand out. Reaching for the dark.

And then, slowly, very slowly, the hand came down.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT HIM BACK in the chair.

And knelt in front of him. And took his father's shaking hands in his own big scarred ones. And held them.

"*Fill the lamps*," said Lex. "*Tonight. Like always. And say good evening.*"

His father looked at him.

"*She'll hear it*," said Lex. "*Wherever she is. She'll hear you. That's how she's been finding her way all this time. That's the light she's walking toward.*" He swallowed. "*Don't stop. Not for one night. Whatever happens.*"

Arion Vey looked down at his son for a long, long time.

"*Every night*," he said. "*I promise.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STEPPED THROUGH.

Antho first. Because it was a door, and he was the Threshold Warden, and someone had to stand in it. Then Seraphine, with her notebook in her coat and three lamps on her belt, unlit. Then Kestrel, with her hair burning.

Then Lex.

He stopped in the arch. With one foot on the black floor of the cavern and one in the dark. And turned round.

Wren was standing at the mouth of the cavern. Where the long passage came down. With her bow on her back and her hand on the stone wall and Pim beside her, holding her other hand, very tight.

She didn't say anything.

Neither did Lex.

He looked at her. For a long moment. Across the bell-shaped cavern. Past the three lamps and his father in the chair and Odile and the students and the twins and Tilda and Kit. Just at her.

And then he put his hand flat on his chest. Over his heart. Where the little glass bottle was. In his inside pocket. With a breath in it.

Wren put her hand flat on her stomach.

And held it there.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TURNED.

And stepped into the dark.

And behind him, the arch began to close. From the edges inward. Like ice forming. Like breath fogging a window. The black glass coming back. Slowly. Until there was only a circle in the middle. Then a hole. Then a crack.

Antho, standing in the dark on the other side, put his hand on it.

Not all the way, he thought. To the door. To Kell, far below. *Leave it on the latch. We're coming back.*

The crack stayed.

A thin line of gold. Lantern-light. Lamp-light. Coming through from the world. From the cavern. From three small flames in a niche, and a thousand lanterns on the walls of a long passage, and an old man in a chair.

It was the only light in the dark.

They turned their backs on it. And looked down.

◆ ◆ ◆

DOWN.

Into Shade's dark. Starlit. Soft. Endless. Going down forever. Antho had been here before. At the bottom of the world. On the way to the Heart. He knew this dark. He knew it the way he knew his own breath.

He'd never seen it look like this.

It *glittered*.

Far below. Very far. Like a field of frost seen from a hilltop. Like the surface of a lake at night under a full moon. A faint grey-gold shimmer. Spread out. Across the whole of the dark beneath them. As far as eyes could see.

Moving.

Slowly. Like smoke. Like a tide. Turning. Drifting. Settling. Rising.

"*Oh*," said Seraphine. Very quietly. "*Oh, no.*"

"*How many*?" said Kestrel.

Nobody answered.

Nobody could count that many.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN, FROM SOMEWHERE in the glitter, so far below that it might have been the bottom of the world, a sound.

Not a moth. Not a voice.

A *crack*. Sharp. Bright. Like wood splitting. Like a staff breaking.

And after it, a cry. Thin. Dry. Human.

And then nothing.

Lex was already moving.

Antho caught his arm. "*Lex*—"

"*That was Kell*."

"*I know*."

"*That was Kell's staff*." His brother's face was white in the faint gold light from the crack in the door behind them. His fire was coming up. All the way up. Gold. Bright. Lighting the dark round them like a torch. "*Antho, that was*—"

And below them, far below, in the great slow glitter of the deep, every single moth turned.

Toward the light.

Toward *him*.

And began, slowly, enormously, like a tide coming in, to rise.

CHAPTER 16

THE DEEP

THEY CAME UP OUT of the dark like a tide.

Lex had seen the sea come in once. On the Saltreach coast, the summer after Duskhold, with Wren. A spring tide, at night, under a full moon. They'd stood on the sand and watched it come. Not a wave. Not a rush. Just the water, rising. Spreading. Silver. Silent. Filling the flats and the channels and the hollows, coming closer and closer without ever seeming to move, until suddenly it was round your ankles and you hadn't seen it come.

The moths came like that.

From below. From everywhere. Rising out of the deep in a great slow sheet of grey-gold glitter, spreading as it came, filling the dark between Shade's stars. Not hurrying. Not swarming. Just *coming*. Up. Toward the light.

Toward him.

"*Lex*," said Antho. Very calmly. "*You need to put it out.*"

"*I can't*."

"*You need to*."

"*I can't*." He looked down at his hands. Gold. Glowing. Bright as a forge-mouth in the dark. It was coming off him in waves. Off his skin. His hair. His breath. He'd let it come up when he heard Kell's staff break, and now it was up, all the way, the way it went when he was afraid, and he couldn't make it go back down. "*It's not a lamp, Antho. I can't shutter it. It's me.*"

The glitter was closer. A hundred yards. Less. He could see them now. Single moths. Wings beating. Painted eyes. Thousands upon thousands, a field of them, a sky of them, rising.

"*Then make it something else*," said Kestrel.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED HIS HEAD.

She was standing beside him. On the dark. With her hair burning gold and her Sunreach blade drawn and her amber eyes fixed on the rising glitter. Calm. Utterly calm. The way she'd been calm in the Glass Desert, on the fire-bridge, with the Sunwell roaring under her.

"*Make it what*?" said Lex.

"*I don't know*." Kestrel didn't look at him. "*You're the smith. What's fire that isn't light?*"

He stared at her.

What's fire that isn't light?

And something came up out of his hands. The way most of his thoughts did. Out of the part of him that had stood at an anvil every day since he was eleven.

Black heat.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC HAD TAUGHT HIM. The first winter. When he was eleven and couldn't stop shaking and the old smith had given him the bellows to work because he said the work would help.

Look at it, lad, Brannoc had said. Holding a bar of iron in the tongs. Fresh out of the fire. *What color is it?*

Black, Lex had said.

It's not black. Brannoc had held it closer. Not close enough to burn. Close enough to feel. *Put your hand near it. Go on. Not on. Near.*

Lex had put his hand near it.

And snatched it back. With a yelp. Because it was *hot*. Hotter than anything. Hot enough to blister at a foot away. And it was black. Dull grey-black. Not glowing at all. Not red. Not orange. Not anything.

Black heat, Brannoc had said. *Iron gets hot long before it glows. Hotter than your oven at home. Hot enough to take your skin off. And it doesn't look*

like anything at all. He'd put the bar back in the fire. *That's the one that gets apprentices. Not the red. Not the white. The black. You see red, you know to be careful. You see black, you think it's cool. You pick it up.*

He'd looked at Lex with his soot-black beard and his kind fierce eyes.

Most dangerous heat there is, Brannoc Holt had said. *The kind with no light in it.*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Black heat*," said Lex.

Kestrel looked at him.

"*Fire that's hot*," said Lex. "*Without glowing. Iron does it. Before it goes red.*" He looked down at his hands. Gold. Bright. "*The moths drink light. Not heat. They can't drink heat.*"

"*Can you do it*?"

"*I don't know*."

The glitter was fifty yards away. Forty. He could hear it now. A sound like rain on a roof. Like sand blowing over stone. Thousands of wings.

He looked at the fire in his hands. And asked it.

Not brighter, he thought. *Hotter. Hotter and darker. The way iron goes. Before it shows.*

Hide.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T WANT TO.

He felt it not want to. The fire in him. The Flame he Commanded. It was a bright thing. A loud thing. It liked to be seen. It had been burning since before there were people to burn for, and it had always, always shown itself. That was what fire *was*.

I know, thought Lex. *I know. Just for a while. Just down here. Please.*

It's dark down here. There's things in the dark that eat light.

Hide with me.

And slowly, grudgingly, the way a dog lies down when you ask it to and it doesn't want to—

The gold went out of his hands.

Not out. *Down*. Into them. Under the skin. The glow faded off his arms, his chest, his hair, his breath. Dimmer. Dimmer. Until he was

standing in the dark at the bottom of the world in the faint gold light from the crack in the door behind them, and he wasn't glowing at all.

He was *hot*.

He felt it. Pouring off him. Invisible. Like the heat off a stone wall at the end of a summer day. Like the air above a forge chimney, shimmering. The dark round him rippled with it. Antho, beside him, took a step back.

"*Gods*," said his brother. "*Lex. What—*"

"*Black heat*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS REACHED THEM.

And didn't stop.

They'd been coming for the light. The light was gone. But they were close now, and the tide doesn't stop when the moon goes behind a cloud. They came on. In a great slow glittering sheet. Over and round and past.

And the ones that came near Lex—

Burned.

He didn't see it, at first. There was nothing to see. No flame. No flash. A moth would drift close to him, a foot away, two feet, wings beating, painted eyes turning, looking for the light that had been there a moment ago—

And it would go *still*. In the air. For a breath.

And then crumple. Like a leaf held too near a stove. Curl. Blacken at the edges. And fall.

And another. And another.

They didn't know what was killing them. They couldn't see it. They came on, looking for light, and found heat instead. Black heat. Invisible. The most dangerous kind there is.

The kind with no light in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh, that's clever*," said Kestrel. Softly. "*That's very clever.*"

She was watching him. With her amber eyes narrowed. The way she watched the Ashari fire-women in the Sunreach, Lex thought. The way she watched anything she wanted to learn.

And then she did it too.

He saw her do it. Saw the gold go out of her hair. All at once. Not out. Down. Into her. The fire that had burned at the ends of her hair for three weeks, that had singed her collar black, that had been burning quietly ever since the Heart like a lamp left on in a window—

Gone dark.

And the air round her began to ripple.

"*Huh*," said Kestrel Varn. Looking at her own hands. "*That's harder than it looks.*"

"*You did it in one try*."

"*I've been watching fire-women for a year*." She flexed her fingers. A moth drifted near them, and curled, and fell. "*They do something like it. With the sand. Make it hot without making it bright. So you don't see the trap till you step in it.*" She grinned. Fierce. In the dark. "*I never could get the trick of it. I kept making it too pretty.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN.

Through the moths. Through the great slow glittering tide of them. Lex at the front, dark and hot, and Kestrel beside him, dark and hot. A wedge. A plough. The moths parting in front of them and curling and falling, and closing again behind.

Antho came after. With the Lantern shuttered. With Shade wrapped round him so close he was hardly there at all, a darker shape in the dark, the way he'd learned to walk in the Greyspine in the old days when the Wardens were hunting him.

And Seraphine.

She had no fire. No Shade. No wind. She walked between the brothers with her three lamps on her belt, unlit, and her notebook in her coat, and her eyes shut.

Listening.

"*Down*," she said. "*And left. A little. There's a—the room changes. Over there. It's thicker.*"

"*Thicker*?"

"*Like a fold in a blanket.*" She didn't open her eyes. "*Like when you shake out a sheet and there's a crease where it was folded. It's—it's folded over there. Something's folded.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS THINNED.

Not all at once. Slowly. The tide going out. Lex felt it before he saw it. Fewer wings. Fewer painted eyes. More dark between them. More of Shade's stars, faint and silver, showing through.

And then they were through. Below it. In clear dark. With the glitter overhead now, a great slow-turning ceiling of grey-gold, like a sky full of snow that hasn't started falling.

And below them, *something*.

◆ ◆ ◆

STREETS.

Lex knew them. He'd seen them before. Two years ago. On the way to the Heart. From the Ferryman's boat. A city. Drowned. Grey. Enormous. Stretching away under the dark in every direction. Towers and domes and bridges and long straight streets. Pre-Lattice. Older than anything in Caldor. Older than the Founders.

The Drowned Country.

Two years ago it had been full.

Full of the dead. Grey. Drifting. Thousands of them. Hundreds of thousands. Walking the streets with their faces slack and their hands empty. Everyone the hunger had ever pulled down. Everyone who'd ever drowned in it.

It was empty now.

The streets were empty. The squares. The bridges. The great flights of steps. Not a soul. Not a grey shape. Not a drifting hand.

They'd gone up. At the Heart. When the net was reforged and the Tithe ended and the eaten worlds rose in gold. Lex had seen it. Every grey dead thing in the deep, rising. Going up. Gold. Into the light.

Gone home.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WALKED DOWN A street.

It was strange. Lex had never walked here. He'd only looked down at it from the boat. It was wide. Paved with grey stone. With tall grey houses on either side, their doors open, their windows dark. There were things in the street. A cart, overturned. A child's shoe. A basket. Grey. Everything grey. Like a drawing in charcoal. Like the Unfinished.

And at the end of the street, in a little square, by a fountain that had no water in it, six lanterns.

On the ground. In a circle. Iron. Small. Each with a single rune on its glass.

ARDENT.

They were burning.

Small. Gold. Steady. In the empty grey square at the bottom of the world. The only light in the whole drowned city.

Antho stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD IN THE mouth of the square and looked at them. For a long time.

Lex knew. He'd been there. On the way to the Heart. When the Ferryman took them down the river, and they passed the Drowned Country, and Antho had asked the old man to stop. Just for a moment. And got out of the boat. And walked up a grey street to a grey square, with six lanterns in his arms.

I made a promise, he'd said. *Two years ago. To a little girl. I said I'd come back with a light.*

A little grey girl. Drowned. Drifting in a grey street. Who had held his sleeve.

He'd set the six lanterns down in a circle in the square where he'd found her, and lit them, and she'd come. Out of the grey. And stood in the middle of them. And held his sleeve again.

And at the Heart, when the eaten worlds rose, she'd gone up. Gold. Holding his sleeve.

He'd never come back to see if the lanterns were still burning.

They were.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WALKED INTO THE square.

He didn't say anything. He walked to the circle of lanterns and knelt down in the middle of it, on the grey stone, among the six small gold flames.

And put his hand flat on the stone. Where she'd stood.

Lex didn't follow him. Neither did Kestrel. Neither did Seraphine. They stood at the edge of the square and waited. The way you wait at the edge of a grave.

After a while Antho got up. And came back.

His face was wet. He didn't wipe it.

"*They stayed lit*," he said. Very quietly. "*Two years. Nobody filled them. Nobody's been here.*"

"*They're Ardent*," said Lex. "*They don't go out.*"

"*I know*." Antho looked back at the circle. "*I know. I just—*" He stopped. "*I thought maybe nobody would ever see them. Down here. In the dark. I thought they'd just burn and burn and nobody would ever know.*"

He looked at Lex.

"*Moths didn't take them*," he said.

Lex looked at the lanterns. Six small gold flames. Untouched. In the middle of the drowned city. With the great glittering ceiling of moths overhead, turning, so close, so many.

"*No*," he said slowly. "*They didn't.*"

"*Why*?"

Seraphine answered.

"*Because they weren't for anyone*," she said. Quietly. "*Not anymore. She went up. They're not waiting for someone to come home.*" She looked at the circle. "*They're just—light. Left on. For no one. For the dark itself.*"

She was quiet.

"*You can't drink a promise that's already kept*," said Seraphine Ilvane.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FOUND KELL IN the next street.

Seraphine heard her first. Not her voice. Her *quiet*. A place in the room where something was missing. "*There*," she said. "*There. In the doorway. Someone's—someone's gone thin there.*"

She was sitting in a doorway. The doorway of a tall grey house, three steps up from the street, with its door hanging open on one hinge. Sitting on the top step. With her back against the door-frame. And her long legs stretched out in front of her. And her hands in her lap.

There was a stick across her knees. Long. Plain. Dark wood.

Broken. In two. Snapped clean through in the middle, as if someone had brought it down across their knee.

Her white robes were grey with dust. Grey-gold. All down the front. All over her hands. Her face.

And she was looking up.

Past them. Past the grey roofs. Up. At the glittering ceiling of moths overhead. With her pale eyes.

Dim.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Kell*," said Lex.

She didn't look at him.

He went up the three steps. And crouched in front of her. Close. With his black heat pulled in tight, as tight as he could make it, so it wouldn't burn her.

Her eyes were the eyes of the Keepers at Greyfall. The eyes of Odile, on the night of the moths. Open. Dim. Like a window in a house where someone has turned the lamp down very low. Something behind them. Far back. Not coming forward.

She was leaning. Very slightly. Up. Toward the glitter.

"*Isaura*," said Lex.

Nothing.

Antho was beside him. With the Lantern. He opened the shutter. Just a crack. And the gold light fell across Kell's grey dusty face.

She flinched. A little. As if the light hurt.

And her lips moved.

"*...took it...*" said Isaura Kell. In a voice like dry paper. Like a page turning. "*...she took it...*"

"*Took what*?"

"*...the warm thing...the only one...*" The pale dim eyes didn't move off the glitter. "*...I only had the one...*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HER.

At the broken staff across her knees. At the dust on her face. At her thin bony hands, lying in her lap, palm up, empty. The way Pim's hands had lain on the floor of the cold-room after he folded the Delve. The way a pair of hands lies when it's let go of something and there's nothing left to hold.

The only warm thing.

He knew what it was.

He'd been there. At the Heart. Standing in the white forge on the white mountain at the bottom of the world, with the Ledger of What Was open in his hands. A book that kept the names of the Unnamed. And a faceless woman in front of him. A woman with no name and no face, who'd been High Warden of the Order of the Lattice once, and had been unwritten, and eaten, and made into the hunger's Warden.

He'd read her name out of the Ledger. *Isaura Kell*. And nothing had happened.

And then Ilse had spoken. Ilse, whom Kell had saved, at the bottom of the Rift, by letting herself be taken below in Ilse's place.

And then Lex had said the only other thing he knew about her. The last thing. The thing that had happened at the Rift, when Dorran Vask was dying, holding up a wall of the world.

Dorran Vask carried you.

And her face had come back. Like a lamp being lit in a window.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She took Dorran*," said Lex. Very quietly.

Antho looked at him.

"*The memory*," said Lex. "*At the Rift. When she was forty-one percent unwritten. When she couldn't walk. When Dorran picked her up and carried her across the bottom of the Umbral Rift on his back.*" He swallowed.

"She told Seraphine about it once. At the Heart. After. She said it was the only time in her life anyone ever carried her."

Seraphine had her hand over her mouth.

"She said," said Lex, *"nobody had touched her kindly since she was nine. Not once. Not in fifty years. And then a man she'd branded with a Kindling-Warden's mark picked her up in the dark and carried her and said, I've got you, High Warden. I've got you."*

He looked at the dim pale eyes. Leaning. Up. Toward the glitter.

"That's what Maelis took," he said. *"That's the warm thing. The only one she had."*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK THE LEDGER out of his coat.

He'd carried it everywhere since the Heart. The *Ledger of What Was*. Legendary. Bound in grey leather, gone soft. Ysmir's book. The book that kept the names of the Unnamed, so that someone would remember them when no one else could. There were only two names left in it that hadn't been restored. Two. Out of thousands.

Isaura Kell.

Elric Thorne.

No. One. Kell's had been restored at the Heart. Her face had come back. Her name. He'd watched it happen.

He opened the book anyway. To her page.

It was still there. In Ysmir's clear old hand. Faded now. Pale. The way a name fades in the Ledger when the person comes back to themselves, and the book doesn't need to hold it anymore.

Isaura Kell. Of Highcrest. High Warden of the Order of the Lattice. Sixty-one. She signed forty-one warrants for unlatticed sorcery and remembered every name.

And under it, in a different hand. Lex's own. Big and clumsy and careful. Written in at the Heart, in charcoal, kneeling on a white floor.

Dorran Vask carried her.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE READ IT OUT loud.

All of it. Ysmir's line, and his own. Slowly. Clearly. Kneeling on the top step of a grey house in a drowned city at the bottom of the world, with a dim-eyed woman in front of him and a sky of moths overhead.

"*Isaura Kell*," read Lex Vey. "*Of Highcrest. High Warden of the Order of the Lattice. She signed forty-one warrants for unlatticed sorcery and remembered every name.*"

The pale eyes didn't move.

"*Dorran Vask carried her*," said Lex.

Nothing.

He looked at the page.

And then, without deciding to, without knowing he was going to, he said the rest. The bit that wasn't written down. The bit he'd heard from Seraphine, in the white forge, after. The bit that Kell had told her, sitting on the floor, shaking, with her face just back.

"*Through the dark*," said Lex. "*At the bottom of the Rift. On his back. Like a sack of grain. And she was so light he hardly felt her. And he said, I've got you, High Warden.*" His voice cracked. "*I've got you. Don't you worry. I've carried heavier.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ISAURA KELL BLINKED.

Slowly. Once. Like someone waking from a long sleep. Like a lamp being turned up, a very little, in a dark window.

Her eyes moved. Off the glitter. Down. To Lex's face.

Still dim. But not *as* dim. Something behind them. Coming forward. A little. A very little. The way a person comes forward in a dark room when they hear their name.

"*...heavier*," she whispered.

"*He'd carried heavier.*" Lex didn't look away from her. "*That's what he said.*"

Her thin mouth moved. Very slightly. Sideways. Like a door that hadn't been opened in years.

"*Liar*," said Isaura Kell. Faintly. "*He said that. But he was lying. I was very heavy.*" Her eyes were wet. "*I was the heaviest thing he ever carried. I could feel it. In his back. He was shaking.*"

"*He carried you anyway.*"

"*He carried me anyway.*"

And something came back into her face. Not all of it. Not the way it had at the Heart, all at once, like a lamp. Just a little. Like a single coal catching in a cold grate.

Enough.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY GAVE HER WATER. And bread, from Seraphine's pack. And sat with her on the steps of the grey house while she ate. Slowly. Mechanically. Like someone who'd forgotten how.

"*She came*," said Kell. When she could. Her voice was thin. Dry. Still faint. But hers. "*Down the longest shaft. Like a moth down a chimney. Folded.*" She looked at her broken staff. "*Seren held up the lamp. I held up this.*"

"*And*?"

"*And she laughed*." Kell's thin mouth twisted. "*She has a lovely laugh. She looked at me over my stick and said, oh, Isaura. Isaura Kell. High Warden. I've heard of you. You burned women like my sister's girl.*" She was quiet. "*And then she took my stick. In one hand. And broke it. Over her knee. Like kindling.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*And then she touched me*," said Kell. Very quietly. "*Here.*" She touched her own cheek. Where the dust was thickest. "*Very gently. Like a mother. And I felt it go.*"

"*And Mam*?" said Antho. "*Where's Mam?*"

Kell looked at him. With her half-dim eyes.

"*Gone*," she said.

Antho went white.

"*Not like that*." Kell shook her head. Slowly. "*Not taken. Gone. Inside.*" She looked up. Past them. Past the grey roofs. At the dark. "*The little one took her. When the moth turned toward her. It moved. Faster than I've ever seen it move. It folded round her. Like a hand closing. Like a—*" She stopped. Looked for the word.

"*Like a room*," said Seraphine.

Kell looked at her.

"*Like a room*," she agreed. "*It made a room. In itself. And put her in it. And shut the door.*" Her voice was very quiet. "*And then it went away. Down. Into itself. And the moth's been hunting for the door ever since.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Where*?" said Lex.

"*I don't know*." Kell closed her eyes. "*Everywhere. Nowhere. It's big, Vey. It's so big. It's the size of a country. It's the size of the dark. And it's folded itself up like a—like a letter. Like a map. And she's somewhere in one of the folds.*" She opened her eyes. "*The moth can't find her. That's the only reason she's still—*"

She stopped.

Because Seraphine had stood up.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS STANDING IN the middle of the grey street. With her eyes shut. And her hands out. Palms up. Like someone feeling for rain.

"*Seraphine*?" said Antho.

"*Shh*."

She stood there for a long time. In the dark. In the drowned city. Under the glittering ceiling of moths. Very still.

"*Oh*," she said.

Her voice was very small.

"*Oh. Oh, it's—Antho. Lex. It's—*"

She opened her eyes.

And looked round. At the grey street. The grey houses. The empty squares and the bridges and the great flights of steps, going away in every direction. The whole of the drowned city, lying silent at the bottom of the world.

At the dark *over* it. Under it. Around it. Between Shade's faint silver stars.

"*It's here*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*It's not somewhere else. It's not far away. It's* here."

She turned in a slow circle. With her hands out.

"*We've been walking in it*," she said. "*The whole time. Since we came through the door. The dark. All of it. That's not Shade.*" Her eyes were enormous behind her spectacles. "*I mean—it is Shade. But it's not* only *Shade. The room. The space. The thing that makes the dark have room in it.*"

She stopped turning.

"*We're inside it*," said Seraphine. "*We've been inside it all along. It's all round us. It's folded round the whole of the deep like a—like a hand round a lamp.*"

She looked at Lex.

"*And it's listening*," she said. "*Right now. It's been listening to us since we came through the door. Since Antho knocked.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STREET WAS VERY quiet.

Lex looked up. At the dark. At Shade's stars, faint and silver. At the great slow glittering ceiling of the moths, turning overhead, so close, so many, looking for a light that wasn't there.

At the space *between*.

He couldn't feel it. He wasn't a Listener of the Hollow. He was a smith. He felt fire, and stone, and a little of water and wind. He couldn't feel rooms.

But Antho could.

His brother had gone very still. Standing in the middle of the grey street with the Lantern in his hand and his clear grey eyes wide. Listening. To the dark. To the old place in the back of his skull.

"*Little one*," said Antho Vey. Out loud. Very softly. Into the dark. "*Little one. Is that you?*"

Nothing.

"*It's me*," said Antho. "*It's your brother. I came down. I knocked. The Warden let me in.*" His voice shook. "*I've brought my brother. Lex. The one who claimed your first stone. The one who made the cups.*"

Nothing.

"*Where's the lamp-lady*?" said Antho. "*Where did you put her? I want to see her. She's my mother.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DARK DIDN'T ANSWER.

But something changed.

Lex felt it. Not with his skin. Not with his fire. Not with the Stone in him. With something else. Something older. Something that had sat on a woodpile at Harrow at ten years old, beside a brother who heard voices, and not asked, and not pushed. Just been there.

The dark *leaned*.

Toward them. All of it. Gently. The whole great soft fold of it, round the drowned city, round the street, round the four of them standing in it and the gaunt woman on the steps. Leaning in. The way a child leans toward you when you crouch down to its height. The way a horse leans its head against your shoulder.

And in the dark, in the street, ten feet in front of them, a light.

Small. Gold. Low down. At the height of a woman's hand.

A lamp.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HUNG THERE. IN the dark. On nothing. A small brown clay lamp, round and plain, with a chip in its spout. Burning. Small and gold and steady. Not attached to anything. Not held by anything.

And then, slowly, the dark round it *opened*.

Not like a door. Like a hand. Like fingers uncurling. Like a fold in a blanket being smoothed out. The dark drew back from round the lamp in a long soft curve, and there was a space there. A room. Small. Round. Warm. Lit gold by the little flame.

And in the room, sitting on nothing, with her shoes off and her knees pulled up and the lamp held in both hands in her lap, a woman.

Small. Fierce. Freckled. With brown hair going grey, tied back with nothing. In a dress that had been blue once, a long time ago.

She looked up.

At the four of them, standing in the grey street of the drowned city. At Kell, on the steps. At Seraphine with her hands out. At Kestrel with her dark hot fire. At her two sons.

Her face did something Lex had never seen a face do. All of it at once. Every part. Crumpling and opening and lighting up, like a window when someone throws back the shutters on a winter morning.

"*Oh*," said Seren Vey. "*Oh, my boys. You came down.*"

And behind her, around her, above her, so close Lex could feel it in his teeth, the dark said one word. Small. Frightened. Young. In his brother's old voice.

[...brother...]

And far above them, in the great glittering ceiling of the moths, every single moth went still.

And turned.

Toward the lamp.

CHAPTER 17

MOTHER

THE ROOM CLOSED BEHIND them.

Lex didn't see it happen. He was running. Across the grey street of the drowned city, toward the small gold light and the woman sitting in it with her shoes off. Antho beside him. Running. The way they'd run as boys, down the track to the stream at Harrow, racing, elbowing, to see who'd get to the water first.

And then they were in the light.

And the dark folded shut round them. Soft. Silent. Like a hand closing. Like a blanket drawn up. The grey street was gone, and the drowned city, and the glittering ceiling of moths. There was only the room. Small. Round. Warm. Lit gold by a clay lamp.

And their mother.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T GET UP.

She couldn't. Her legs had gone. She told them that afterward, laughing, wiping her eyes. *I'd been sitting so long I'd forgotten how to stand. I tried. Nothing happened. My feet just lay there like a pair of old fish.*

She held out her arms instead.

And they went into them. Both of them. At once. On their knees. Lex on one side and Antho on the other, with the clay lamp between them, and their mother's arms round their necks, pulling their heads down onto her shoulders. Small. She was so small. Lex had forgotten. At the Heart he'd

been so tired, and she'd been so faint, half there and half not, light coming through her like light through a curtain. He hadn't *felt* her.

He felt her now.

Thin. Bony. Warm. Smelling of nothing, of the deep, of dust and old wool and lamp-oil. Her hair against his cheek, coarse and grey-brown. Her heart going fast under his ear.

Her hands. In his hair. Square and strong and never still.

"*Oh, my boys*," said Seren Vey. Into the top of his head. "*Oh, look at you. Look at you both. You've got so* big."

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T KNOW HOW long they stayed like that.

Long enough that his knees hurt. Long enough that Antho started shaking, the way he did when something was too big to hold, and their mother let go of Lex's hair and put both arms round her elder son and held him while he shook. Long enough that Lex heard someone behind him blow their nose. Kestrel. Very loudly. And then say *sorry* in a cracked voice.

When he finally sat back, his face was wet.

So was his mother's. She didn't wipe it. She looked at him. At his face. The way Brannoc had looked at him the morning of the wedding. The way you look at something you didn't think you'd live to see, and are trying to remember properly.

"*You've got your father's height*," she said. "*Poor love. He was always banging his head on the beams.*"

Lex went very still.

His mother saw it. He saw her see it. Saw her face change. A small thing. A flicker. Like a cloud going over the sun.

"*I know that*," said Seren slowly. "*Don't I. That he banged his head. I know that.*" She looked at the lamp. "*I don't know how I know it. I don't remember him doing it. I just know.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*It's like that*," said their mother. Very quietly. "*All the time. Little things. Like stones in a field after the snow's gone. I trip over them.*" She looked up. "*I know he takes salt in his porridge. I know he hums when he's reading. I don't know what he looks like.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mam*," said Antho.

She looked at him.

"*This is Seraphine*," said Antho. He reached back without looking and found her hand. Seraphine had been standing at the edge of the gold light. Very still. Not coming closer. The way she always stood at the edge of things, until someone asked her in. "*My wife.*"

Seren looked past him.

At Seraphine. Standing in the gold light of the clay lamp with her spectacles crooked and her hair coming down and her hand in Antho's. Very pale. Very straight. Looking back at her husband's mother at the bottom of the world.

"*Wife*," said Seren.

"*Three months*," said Antho. "*In front of your door. You leaned the lamps.*"

His mother stared at him.

Then she looked back at Seraphine. Slowly. Up and down. At the ink on her fingers. At the scars on her wrists, where her sleeves had ridden up. At the notebook sticking out of her coat pocket.

"*You're the one with the glass eyes*," said Seren Vey.

Seraphine blinked. "*I'm—sorry*?"

"*The little one calls you that*." Seren tilted her head. Listening. To the dark. "*The one with the glass eyes. The one who can hear it.*" Her face changed. Opened. "*It's been talking about you for days. It's so excited. It's never had anyone hear it before. Not from up there. Not on purpose.*"

She held out her hand.

Seraphine looked at it. A small square freckled hand. Held out. In the gold light.

She came forward. And knelt. And took it.

And Seren pulled her down, with surprising strength, and kissed her on the forehead. Hard. The way she'd kiss a child.

"*Thank you*," said Seren. Very low. "*For listening to it. Nobody ever does. Not properly.*" She looked at Antho. "*And for him. Thank you for him. I've been worried about him since he was fifteen.*"

Seraphine burst into tears.

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL DIDN'T COME INTO the light.

She stood at the edge of it. In the dark. With her black heat pulled in tight and her arms crossed and her amber eyes very bright. Lex looked round and saw her standing there. Alone. Watching.

He knew that look. He'd seen it on the White Shore, two years ago. On a fire-witch with no thread who'd watched him give back a farmer's name to a faded man by the fire. Who'd watched him say *Tam the Ram* and seen the faded man come back.

Her brother. Tamsin. Whom she'd sold Lex's blood to get back.

Kestrel had had a mother too. Once. She'd never said what happened to her.

Seren saw her.

Over Antho's shoulder. Over Seraphine's head. She looked at the tall red-haired woman standing at the edge of the light with her arms crossed, and something in her face went very soft.

"*And who's this*?" said Seren.

"*Kestrel*," said Lex. "*Kestrel Varn. She's*—" He didn't know how to say it. "*She's family. Sort of. She stole my blood once.*"

"*I gave it back*," said Kestrel.

"*She gave it back*." Lex looked at her. "*She came from the Sunreach. Three weeks, on foot. Because Antho wrote.*"

Seren looked at Kestrel for a long moment.

"*Come here, love*," she said. "*Come into the light. It's cold out there.*"

Kestrel didn't move.

"*I'm fine*," she said. Her voice was very tight.

"*I know you are*," said Seren Vey. Gently. "*I'm not asking because you're not fine. I'm asking because there's room.*"

Kestrel Varn stood at the edge of the gold light for a long time.

Then she came in. And sat down. On the warm dark. A little way off. With her knees pulled up.

And Seren reached out without looking and put her hand on Kestrel's red hair. And left it there. And went on talking to her sons.

And Kestrel, who had walked three weeks from the Sunreach on foot with her hair burning, put her face down on her knees and didn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TOLD HER ABOUT Wren.

He hadn't meant to. Not yet. Not here. He'd thought about it on the way down. He'd thought, *I'll tell her when we're home. When we're safe. When there's a window and a kettle and no moths.*

But she asked.

"*And you*?" said Seren. Looking at him. "*My Lex. Who used to hide under the table when it thundered. There's a ring on your hand.*"

He looked down. He didn't wear a ring. He worked in a forge.

But there was a mark. On the third finger of his left hand. A thin pale band of skin, very faint. Where Wren had put a ring on it in the loft at Harrow one night, just to see, a plain iron one she'd found in Brannoc's scrap box, and laughed, and taken it off again, and he'd worn it for three days anyway before it got caught in a vise and he had to take it off.

His mother had seen it. In the gold light. At the bottom of the world.

"*Wren*," said Lex. "*Her name's Wren. Wren Ashdown. She's a tracker. From Thistledown.*" He swallowed. "*She charged me two silver to walk me up a mountain. She said I walked like a bear in a china shop.*"

His mother laughed. Delighted. "*You do*."

"*Everyone says that*."

"*Because it's true*." Seren's eyes were very bright. "*I know her. I think. Don't I? The one with the wind. I heard her. Through the door, at the Heart. And before. At the Hollowmaw. On the night of the Blade. She was the one who wouldn't let go of your hand.*"

"*Yes*," said Lex.

"*Is she here*?"

"*No*." He hesitated.

His mother looked at him. And the hedge-witch came up into her face. The one who had turned breech babies and stopped fevers in twenty-two cottages in twenty-two valleys. Sharp. Knowing.

"*Lex*," said Seren Vey. "*Why isn't she here?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD HER.

He watched her face while he did it. Watched it go still. And then go soft. And then, very slowly, go lit. From inside. Like a window when someone throws back the shutters.

"*Oh*," said his mother. Softly. "*Oh, Lex. She's carrying a light.*"

He nodded.

He couldn't speak.

She reached out and took his face in both her hands. And held it. And looked at him. For a long, long time.

And then, slowly, he watched the light in her face go out.

Not all of it. Not gone. Covered. Like a hand cupped over a candle-flame. And under it, something else. Something hard and cold and very old. The Harrow thing. The thing that had sat up all night at the end of summer in twenty-two cottages with the shutters closed and a broom.

"*Does she know*?" said Seren. Very quietly.

"*Who*?"

"*Lex*." His mother's hands were still on his face. "*Does the Moth know? Has she seen Wren?*"

He didn't answer.

He didn't need to. His mother saw it in his face. The way she'd always seen everything in his face, since he was four, since he hid under the table when it thundered.

Her hands tightened.

"*Then you go home*," said Seren Vey. "*As soon as you can. As soon as this is done. You go home and you stand in front of her and you don't let anything with lit eyes within a mile of her. Not one. Not a moth. Not a woman. Not anything.*" Her voice was like iron. "*Do you hear me? Do you understand?*"

"*Mam—*"

"*We never let a moth in*," said his mother. "*Never. Not for nine hundred years. Not once.*" Her eyes were fierce. "*And above all, we never let a moth near a light that's carrying.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex.]

He went very still.

Ember. In his hearth. Very quiet. Very strange. A voice he'd never heard it use. Not the dry voice. Not the precise one. Not the one that made terrible jokes about metallurgy.

Small. Shaking.

[Lex. That's her.]

I know.

[No.] The coal in his hearth was glowing. Brighter than he'd ever felt it. [*You don't understand. That's* her. *I remember her. I remember* her.*]*

Lex didn't move.

[I'm a piece of him,] said Ember. *[From before the seal. Twenty years ago. Everything he was, up to that night. Everything he knew. Everything he—]* It stopped. *[Lex, I remember the steps. The rain. I remember her laughing at the lanterns. I remember the flour on her cheek. I remember the night Antho was born, holding her hand, all night. I remember walking you up and down the kitchen at three in the morning when you had the fever.]*

Ember—

[She paid him to the Ferryman,] said Ember. *[All of him. Every memory. But not mine. The Ferryman took her memories. Not his. Not mine.]* The coal flared. *[I've got them. All of them. Up to the seal. I've had them all along.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WAS LOOKING at him.

Not at his face. At his chest. Where his hearth was. Where Ember was. Her head on one side. Listening. The way she listened to the dark. The way she'd listened to the little one for a year and a half.

"*Lex*," she said slowly. "*Who's that?*"

He stared at her.

"*In there*." She lifted one hand. And laid it flat on his chest. Over his heart. Over the place where the little glass bottle was, with Wren's breath in it. And under that, deeper, in the hearth at the center of him— "*There's someone in there. Talking. I can hear it.*"

She was a Listener. An untaught one. A hedge-witch. She heard things nobody else could hear. She'd heard Antho through a door for eight years.

She'd heard the hunger turn into a little one. She'd heard the dark under the world.

Of course she could hear Ember.

"*It's*—" Lex didn't know how to say it. "*Mam. It's Ember.*"

"*Ember*."

"*It's a*—" He swallowed. "*It's a piece of Father. A little piece. From when he sealed us. He put it in the seal, like a maker's mark. To look after me.*" He looked down at her hand on his chest. "*It's been with me since I was nineteen. It talks. It's very rude.*"

His mother didn't move.

"*Say something*," she said.

"*What*?"

"*Not you*." Her hand pressed flat on his chest. "*Him. The piece. Tell him to say something. I want to hear his voice.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[I can't,] said Ember.

She can hear you.

[I can't.] *The coal was trembling.* [*Lex. I can't. What if—what if it's wrong. What if it's not the voice. What if she doesn't*—]

She can hear you, thought Lex. *Say something.*

The coal was quiet for a long time.

And then, in his hearth, so softly he almost didn't hear it, in a voice he'd heard every day for five years and never, until this moment, really listened to—

Dry. Quiet. A little old-fashioned. With a habit of tapping, two fingers, on any surface. The voice of a man who'd stood on the steps of the Spire in the rain two hundred years into his long life and seen a woman laughing at the lanterns.

[Hello, Seren.]

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER'S HAND WENT rigid on his chest.

Her face—

He'd never forget it. He'd see it for the rest of his life. In the forge, at night, with the coals banked down. In the loft at Harrow, waking at dawn. In every window with a lamp in it.

It went white. Then red. Then white again. Her eyes went wide. Her mouth opened. Her breath stopped.

And then she *knew*.

Not remembered. She couldn't remember. The Ferryman had all of that. But she knew. The way you know your own name. The way you know which way is up, at the bottom of the world.

"*That's the voice*," whispered Seren Vey.

[Yes.]

"*From the Root*." Her hand was shaking on his chest. "*In the dark. Three years. Every night. Before the Heart.*" She swallowed. "*That's the voice I—*"

She stopped.

[Yes,] said Ember. Very softly. *[That was him. That's me. A little bit of him. A piece. From long ago. From before.]* The coal was glowing so bright Lex could feel it in his ribs. *[I'm sorry. I'm only a small piece. I don't know what he's like now. I don't know about the last twenty years. I only know what he was.]*

"*What was he*?" said his mother. In a voice like a child's.

[In love with you,] said Ember. *[Every day. From the steps. From the first night. Every single day until the night he sealed your boys and walked out the door with the lantern still lit in the window behind him.]*

A pause.

[And I suspect,] said Ember, very gently, *[every day since.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER TOOK HER hand off his chest.

Slowly. As if it hurt. And sat back. On the warm dark. With the clay lamp in her lap. And looked at it. For a long time.

Nobody said anything.

Antho had his hand over his mouth. Seraphine was holding his other hand so tight her knuckles were white. Kestrel had lifted her face off her knees and was staring at Lex's chest with her amber eyes enormous.

"*He wrote you a letter*," said Lex.

His mother looked up.

"*Father*," said Lex. "*The real one. Not—not Ember. Him.*" He reached into his coat. Past the glass bottle. And took it out. Thick. Many pages. Sealed with plain grey wax and a thumbprint. "*He's been writing it for a year and a half. Every night after he fills the lamps.*" He held it out. "*He said to ask you first. If you want it. He said if you don't, I'm to burn it, and not bring it back, and not tell him.*"

His mother looked at the letter.

She didn't take it.

"*Is he old*?" she said.

Lex didn't answer.

"*Antho told me*," said Seren. "*Through the door. A month ago. He said, Mam, Father's getting old. He's going grey. He's so happy about it.*" She was looking at the letter. "*And then a week ago, he said—*" She stopped. "*He said it's going faster. He said, Mam, hurry.*"

She looked up at her sons.

"*How old*?" she said.

"*Seventy-five*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Maybe more. By now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOOK THE LETTER.

She held it in both hands. In her lap. Beside the lamp. She turned it over. Looked at the seal. At the thumbprint in the wax. Long. Narrow. A long-fingered hand.

She touched the thumbprint. Very lightly. With one finger.

She didn't open it.

"*Not here*," she said. "*Not now. Not with moths up there and the little one so frightened.*" She put the letter inside her dress. Against her chest. Over her heart. "*When I'm home. I want to read it by a window. In the daylight. With the kettle on.*"

She looked at Lex.

"*Tell him I took it*," she said. "*Tell him I didn't burn it. Tell him—*" She stopped. "*No. Don't tell him anything. I'll tell him myself.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[...lamp-lady...]

They all heard it. Even Kestrel. Even Seraphine, who heard the room, not the voice. It was so close now. So close. In the walls of the gold room. In the warm dark round them.

[...lamp-lady...the moths...the moths are looking...]

"*I know, lamb*," said Seren. Not looking up. "*I know. Stay folded. Stay very small. She can't find us if you stay small.*"

[...I'm trying...]

[...I'm so big...it's so hard to be small...]

[...brother...]

Antho lifted his head.

[...brother...you came down...you came all the way down...]

"*I came*," said Antho.

He said it out loud. Into the room. Into the dark. His voice was steady. Mostly.

[...nobody ever came down for me...]

[...except Mal...and the lamp-lady...and the Warden...]

[...and now YOU...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS BROTHER WAS QUIET for a long moment.

Lex watched him. Sitting on the warm dark at the bottom of the world, in a room made of the thing that had lived in his head for eight years. The thing that had told him to burn. That had told him he'd killed his mother. That had whispered *little brother smells of warm iron* in a cave, with a knife at Lex's throat.

The thing that had said *please don't be angry*.

"*I'm not angry*," said Antho.

The room was very still.

"*I've been trying to work out what I am*," said his brother. Slowly. "*For three months. Since you came back. Since you started talking to me again. I've been lying awake trying to work out if I'm angry. If I should be. If I'm allowed not to be.*" He looked at his hands. "*I'm not. I thought I would be. I'm not.*"

[...why...]

"*I don't know*." Antho's mouth twisted. "*Seraphine says it's because I'm tired. Lex says it's because I've already used up all my anger on Father. Odile says it's because I'm getting old.*" He was quiet. "*I think it's because you said sorry. Nobody else ever did. Not the Order. Not the Wardens who hunted me. Not the people in Ashbourne who said I killed my mother.*" He looked at the dark. "*You were the worst thing that ever happened to me. And you're the only one who ever said sorry.*"

The room didn't answer.

"*I don't forgive you*," said Antho Vey. "*Not yet. I don't know how. I don't know if I ever will.*" He swallowed. "*But I came down. And I'm not angry. And I'm not going to let her drink you.*"

He put his hand flat on the warm dark beside him.

"*That'll have to do*," he said. "*For now.*"

And the room *leaned*. Toward him. All of it. Soft and warm and enormous. The way a child leans against you when it's too tired to say anything else.

[...for now...] said the little one. Very small. *[...for now is good...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Show them*," said Seren.

Lex looked at her.

"*The middle*," said his mother. To the dark. "*Lamb. Show them where Mal is. They should see.*"

[...it's in the middle...it's far...]

"*Not far*," said Seren. "*Not for you. You're everywhere. Fold the room. Bring the middle here.*"

The little one was quiet.

And then the room moved.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T HAVE DESCRIBED it. Not then. Not afterward, to Wren, in the loft at Harrow. He tried. He said *it was like a page turning*. He said *it was like the world folding over*. He said *it was like when you're falling asleep and the bed drops out from under you and you jerk awake*.

It was none of those.

The gold room stayed where it was. The lamp. His mother. His brother. Seraphine. Kestrel. All of them. On the warm dark.

And the dark *came to them*. From very far off. From the middle of everything. From the warmest, deepest, quietest place there was. It folded. And folded. And folded again. Like a map. Like a letter. Like a sheet being folded by two people walking toward each other from opposite ends, until the corners meet.

And the corners met.

And in the dark, just beyond the edge of the gold light, there were two more lights.

◆ ◆ ◆

SMALL. PALE. SILVER-GOLD. LIKE the light of very old candles. Very still. Very quiet. Lying together, side by side, curled up, the way two people sleep when they've slept side by side for a long time.

Lex knew them.

One was small. Bent. Brown, once. With a straw hat, he thought. Or the shape of one. And bare feet. Lying on its side, with one arm flung out, the hand open, as if it had been holding something and let go.

And the other was tall. Thin. Old. Very old. Curled round something in its hands. Something small. Something that might have been a hammer.

They didn't move. They didn't speak. They lay there in the deepest middle of the dark, two little lights, very still, very peaceful, the way you'd lie by a fire on a winter night when the work's all done and there's nothing left to do but rest.

And from them, very faint, so faint Lex had to hold his breath, a sound.

Singing.

Little light, little light, burning low.

In tune.

◆ ◆ ◆

ROUND HIS NECK, UNDER his shirt, against his chest, the little silver bell with the crooked clapper moved.

He felt it. A tremble. A shiver. Like something waking.

And it rang.

Once. Very softly.

Not flat. Not the way it had rung on the eve of the wedding, in the dark, flat on the high note, his mother's note.

True.

A clear small silver *ting*, perfectly in tune. Like a struck glass. Like a bird. Like an old man laughing.

It rings when he's sad, Teo had said. Two years ago. Coming back from the Undertow with it in his hands. *It's never stopped. Not in nine hundred years.*

It stopped, Antho had said, at the Heart. *Because he's not sad anymore.*

It rang now. Once. In tune.

And Lex knew, the way he knew iron, the way he knew fire, the way he knew the weight of a hammer in his hand, what it meant.

I'm here, said the bell. *I'm all right. I'm resting. I'm with my brother.*

I'm not sad.

Ting.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WAS CRYING.

So was Antho. So was Seraphine, and Kestrel, and Lex. All of them. Sitting in a small gold room at the bottom of the world, round a clay lamp, with two little sleeping lights at the edge of it, crying. And laughing. Both. At once.

"*Clever old goat*," said Seren Vey. Wiping her eyes. "*Clever old goat. He always did sing it better than me.*"

[...that's Mal...] said the little one. Very softly. Very proudly. *[...that's Mal and his brother...they're in the middle...they're warm...]*

[...I grew round them...]

[...like a shell grows round a pearl...]

Lex put his hand over the bell. Under his shirt. Against his chest.

Thank you, he thought. To the little light with the straw hat. *For sitting with it. For staying. For singing.*

The little light didn't answer.

But the bell, under his hand, was warm.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE ROOM *shook*.

All of it. All at once. Hard. Like a house when a door slams. Like a horse when it's struck. The gold light of the clay lamp swung wildly. The two little lights at the edge of the room flickered. The warm dark *flinched*.

[...NO...]

[...no no no she's FOUND it...she's found the FOLD...]

[...when I brought the middle here...when I opened it...she SAW...]

Seren was on her feet. Lex didn't know how. Her legs that had gone like old fish. She was standing in the middle of the gold room with the lamp held up high in her square strong hand and her face gone white and hard and cold.

"*Lamb*," she said. "*Fold it back. Now. Send the middle back. Fold it all—*"

[...I CAN'T...she's got her hand in it...she's got her HAND in the fold...]

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WALL OF THE room tore.

Not like cloth. Not like paper. Like *skin*. A long slow rip, from top to bottom, in the warm dark beside them. And through it, cold air. And grey-gold glitter. And light.

Not lamplight. Not firelight.

Two lights. Gold. Warm. Soft. Like windows at the end of a long lane on a winter night.

And a long pale hand. With too many joints. Reaching in through the tear. Slowly. Gently. The way you'd reach into a nest to take an egg.

Reaching for the middle. For the two little lights, curled side by side, singing in tune.

And past them. Through them. Toward the place behind them where the dark was deepest and softest and warmest and *fullest*.

The heart of it.

"*Oh*," said a voice. Through the tear. Low and soft and hoarse and full of longing. "*Oh, there you are. There you are. I've been looking everywhere.*"

The little one *screamed*.

And Lex felt Antho's hand close on his arm like a vise. And felt his brother's whole body go rigid. And heard him make a sound, low and

terrible, the sound of a man who has heard that scream through his own mouth twenty-seven times and is not going to hear it again.

And Antho Vey stood up.

And walked into the tear.

CHAPTER 18

The Moth Queen Drinks

THE TEAR WAS A doorway.

Antho knew it the moment he stepped into it. Before his foot touched the edge. Before the cold air from the other side hit his face. He knew it the way he knew the black glass at the bottom of the Hollowmaw. The way he'd known the doorway at the bottom of the Heart, two years ago, with the hunger at his back.

A gap. Between one place and another. Between the warm gold room with his mother in it, and the cold glittering dark outside. Between the middle of the little one, the softest deepest warmest place in all the deep, and a long pale hand reaching in.

A threshold.

And he was the Threshold Warden.

He stood in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ANTHOREN VEY
THRESHOLD WARDEN
Skill: STAND BETWEEN (Master 8)
"Nothing passes a doorway he stands in
 without his leave."
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◆ ◆ ◆

THE HAND STOPPED.

An inch from his chest. Long. Pale. Grey-gold. Fingers spread. Too many joints in them. Reaching past him. Through him. Toward the two little sleeping lights behind him, and the soft deep dark behind *them*.

It stopped as if it had hit glass.

And on the other side of the tear, in the cold, in the glitter, the two gold lights that were her eyes went very wide.

"*Oh*," said Maelis.

She didn't pull her hand back. She left it there. An inch from his chest. Pressed flat against nothing. The way a moth presses against a window.

"*Oh, look at that*," she said softly. "*A little Warden. In a little door.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULD SEE HER now.

All of her. Through the tear. Standing on the dark outside, on nothing, in the cold, with the moths swirling round her in a great slow glittering column, like smoke round a chimney. Tall. Taller than he remembered from the Hall of Lanterns. Her silver hair loose. Her long grey-gold gown moving in a wind that wasn't there. And her wings—

Open.

He'd only seen them folded. In the Hall. On the West Way. A cloak. A train. A fold of silk down her back.

They weren't folded now.

They filled the dark behind her. Enormous. Grey and gold. Patterned with rings and whorls and eyes. Dozens of eyes. Painted eyes, dark, gold-rimmed, on every part of every wing, all of them turned toward him. Toward the tear. Toward the light behind him.

And they were *shedding*. With every slow beat. A fine glittering dust, falling off them like snow off a branch. Drifting down into the dark.

And behind her, on the dark, her Mothwing. Thirty. Forty. Pale and ragged and dull-eyed. Standing very still. Waiting.

"*Let me in*," said Maelis.

"*No*."

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SMILED.

It was the loveliest smile he'd ever seen. Sad and fond and patient. The smile she'd given the little girl on the West Way. The smile she'd given the whole council of Caldor from the floor of the Hall of Lanterns.

"*You sound just like her*," she said. "*Did you know? Your mother. She said no to me too. Just now. With her lamp.*" Her lit eyes moved past him. Into the room. To where Seren was standing, with the lamp held high. "*And her mother before her. And hers. All the way back.*" She sighed. "*Nine hundred years of Harrow women saying no to me through windows.*"

"*Then you should be used to it*."

She laughed.

"*Oh, I like you*," said Maelis. "*I like you very much, little Warden. You're so* angry." Her head tilted. "*You've been angry your whole life, haven't you? At your father. At the Order. At the thing in your head.*" Her eyes moved. Over his shoulder. To the soft deep dark behind him. "*At* that."

He didn't answer.

"*It's in you*," said Maelis softly. "*Still. I can smell it. Eight years of it. The voice. The hunger. It's in the walls of you, the way smoke gets into the walls of a house and never comes out.*" Her hand, pressed against nothing an inch from his chest, spread its long fingers. "*And you're standing in front of it. Protecting it. The thing that broke you.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Why*?"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT ABOUT IT.

He actually thought about it. Standing in the tear. With the cold on his face and the warm at his back. With her hand an inch from his heart and her lit eyes on him and thirty Mothwing waiting in the dark.

He'd been asked that before. By himself. Every night for three months. Lying awake. *Why*? *Why am I doing this? Why do I care? It broke me. It took eight years of my life. It made me hold a knife to Lex's throat.*

He'd never had an answer.

He had one now.

"*Because it said sorry*," said Antho Vey.

Maelis looked at him.

"*And you never did*," said Antho.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SMILE WENT OUT of her face.

Not all at once. Slowly. Like a lamp being turned down. The lovely sad fond patient smile, going. And under it, something else. Something he'd seen once before, through the little one's eyes, in a hall of glass nine hundred years ago, on the face of a woman kneeling at the edge of a nearly empty pool.

Hunger.

"*Sorry*," said Maelis. Very quietly. "*Sorry.*" She tilted her head. "*What would I be sorry for, little Warden? For being thirsty? For drinking? For wanting to live?*"

She leaned closer. Her face an inch from the edge of the tear. From the edge of his doorway.

"*Would you be sorry*?" she whispered. "*If you were dying? If you'd watched everyone you loved grow old and wither and go into the ground, one by one, and you found a spring in the cellar that would stop it? Would you kneel down at the edge of it and say no thank you? Would you* not drink?"

"*My grandmother's sister didn't*," said Antho.

Maelis went very still.

"*Hesper*," said Antho. "*She stood in the doorway. And watched. And when it was nearly empty, she came forward. And knelt down. And poured something back.*" He looked into her lit eyes. "*I saw it. It showed me. She put her crown down on the stone and cupped her empty hands and poured. And you looked at her the way you're looking at me now.*"

Maelis said nothing.

"*And she said no*," said Antho. "*Not me. Not ever.*"

He held the doorway.

"*Neither will I*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOOK HER HAND away.

Slowly. Drawing it back from the inch of nothing in front of his chest. Folding the long pale fingers in. Letting it fall to her side.

She looked at him for a long time.

"*All right*," said Maelis. Softly. Reasonably. "*All right, little Warden. You hold your door.*"

She smiled again. A different smile. Small. Thin. Not lovely at all.

"*I'll just go round*," said the Moth Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T UNDERSTAND.

Not for a moment. Not for the space of a breath. He stood in the tear with his feet set and his hands at his sides and the Lantern hanging from his belt, holding the doorway, and didn't understand.

Then she turned.

Away from him. Away from the tear. Away from the gold room and the two little lights and his mother with her lamp.

And spread her enormous wings.

And knelt.

On the dark. On the nothing. On the soft cold deep under her feet. The dark that wasn't just dark. The dark that was the room. The space. The Well. All of it. Everywhere. Folded round the whole of the deep like a hand round a lamp.

We're inside it, Seraphine had said. *We've been inside it all along.*

Maelis knelt on it. And cupped her long pale hands.

And put them down into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*NO*!"

He didn't know who shouted. Him. Lex. His mother. Seraphine. All of them.

It didn't matter.

The Moth Queen's hands went into the dark like hands going into water. Up to the wrists. Up to the elbows. Into the soft deep folded night-sky that was the little one's body, its skin, if it had skin.

And she lifted them out.

Full.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D NEVER FORGET WHAT was in them.

Dark. But not dark. *Full* dark. The dark of the pool in the glass hall. The dark of the moment before a word. Soft and deep and alive and *glowing*, faintly, from inside, the way the night sky glows when you're far from any town. Pouring between her long fingers like water. Like light. Like the first breath of something being born.

And she lifted it to her mouth.

And drank.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LITTLE ONE SCREAMED.

Not the way it screamed when the cores broke. Not small. Not high. Not a child's cry in another room.

It screamed the way a *world* screams.

Antho felt it. Everyone felt it. It came up through the dark and through the room and through the tear he was standing in and through his feet and his legs and his chest and the old place in the back of his skull, and it was so big, so *enormous*, that for a moment there was nothing else. No deep. No moths. No mother. No brother. Just the scream. Filling everything. Filling him.

[...AGAIN...]

[...she's doing it AGAIN...like BEFORE...like the HALL...]

[...brother brother brother she's DRINKING me...]

His knees went.

He didn't fall. He wouldn't let himself fall. He went down on one knee in the doorway with both hands clamped to his head and his eyes shut and his teeth gritted and the scream going through him like a river through a broken dam, and he *held the doorway*. He held it. Nothing came past him. Nothing.

But she wasn't trying to come past him.

She was drinking from the other side.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Clarity: 100 → 84 → 71 → 58]

He saw it. Flickering. In the corner of his eye. The old number. The one he hadn't looked at in two years.

[52 → 47]

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Antho*!"

Lex. Somewhere. Behind him. Close. And then not behind him. Past him. Through the tear. Out. Into the cold. Into the glitter.

Not glowing. Dark. Black heat pouring off him like the air off a forge chimney. Antho felt it go by. Felt the moths round the tear curl and crumple and fall as his brother passed.

And Kestrel. Behind him. Dark and hot. Her Sunreach blade out.

They went at the Mothwing.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO COULDN'T SEE MUCH of it.

He was on his knee in the doorway with the scream going through him. He saw it in pieces. In flashes. The way you see a fight in the dark by lightning.

Lex, going through the Mothwing like a plough through stubble. Not striking them. Not burning them. Just *walking*. Through them. With the black heat round him. And every one he came near going still in the air and crumpling, curling, falling. Into dust. That didn't gather. That couldn't gather. Because the heat was still there, pouring off him, and every speck of dust that drifted near him blackened and was gone.

Kestrel. Beside him. Laughing. Fierce. With her Sunreach blade, which didn't need an edge, which was hot enough to cut through anything that came near it.

And behind them both, the moths. The great slow glittering column. Turning. Coming down. On top of them. Smothering. Thousands. Tens of thousands. Not burning fast enough. Too many. A blizzard of grey-gold dust, filling the dark round his brother and Kestrel so thick he couldn't see them anymore.

And through it, kneeling on the dark with her hands cupped and her wings spread and her head bent, *drinking*—

Maelis.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...Clarity: 41...]

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I can't breathe*!"

Seraphine. Close. Behind him. In the room. Choking. He turned his head. Through the scream. Through the haze.

The dust was coming in. Through the tear. Past him. He was holding the doorway against things, against hands and Mothwing and the Moth Queen herself. Not against *dust*. Dust wasn't anything. Dust was just air with something in it. It came through the tear like smoke through a crack under a door. Grey-gold. Glittering. Filling the gold room. Thick. Thicker.

Seraphine was on her knees. With her hands over her mouth. Coughing. His mother beside her, holding the lamp up, high, and the dust swirling round the lamp, trying to get at it, failing, and swirling round her instead. Round her face. Her hands. Getting on her.

And the two little lights. At the edge of the room. Curled together. Very still.

The dust was settling on them.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T MOVE.

That was the thing. That was the worst thing. He couldn't move. If he moved, the doorway was empty. If the doorway was empty, she could come in. She could stop drinking from the outside and walk in through the tear and put her hands round the middle. Round the two little lights. Round the heart.

He had to hold the door.

And the dust was coming in past him. And his wife was choking. And his mother was going grey with it. And the little one was screaming. And his Clarity was going down and down and down like a stone in a well, and somewhere in the back of his skull, in the old place, something was waking up that he'd thought was dead.

Not the little one.

Him. The old him. The thing that had sat in a cave for eight years with the Murmur in its head. Black-eyed. Hungry. Angry.

Let it go, said the old thing. *Let the door go. Go out there. Kill her. Kill all of them. You know how. You remember. You remember what the dark can do when you stop asking it nicely.*

◆ ◆ ◆

[Clarity: 33]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HELD THE DOOR.

He held it with his knee on the dark and his hands on his head and his teeth so tight his jaw ached. He held it against the old thing in his skull and the scream in his body and the dust in his wife's lungs.

He didn't know how much longer he could.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HIS BROTHER came back.

Out of the dust. Out of the blizzard. Staggering. Dark. With moth-wings stuck to his coat, blackened, crumpled. With his black heat failing. Flickering. Gold coming through it in patches, the way it did when he was too tired to hold it down, so the moths saw him and came at him again, thicker, heavier.

He fell to his knees beside Antho. In the tear. Gasping.

"*Too many*," said Lex. "*Antho, there's too many. I can't—*"

He put his hand on his chest. Over his heart. Inside his coat.

And Antho saw what was in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

A BOTTLE. GLASS. SMALL. The size of a thumb. Clear. With a cork, sealed with wax.

Empty.

Not empty.

If you need air down there, Hammer. If you need wind. If you need me.

Lex looked at it. In his big scarred palm. In the dust and the dark and the scream.

Then he put his thumb on the wax. And broke it. And pulled the cork.

And breathed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT CAME OUT OF the bottle like a bird out of a cage.

Antho felt it. Before he heard it. Before he saw it. A *coolness*. A freshness. A smell. Not of the deep. Not of dust. Of *sky*. Of high cold places. Of snow on mountains and rain on grass and the eye of a storm above the Teeth, where a girl with a fox-red braid had stood and let go of a smith's hand and trusted the wind to catch him.

The First Breath.

The first wind there ever was. Before the world. Before anything. The breath the Gale Well breathed when it woke.

Just a little. Just what one girl had kept in her lungs for three days and breathed into a bottle at the end because she thought someday someone might need air somewhere there wasn't any.

It came out of the bottle.

And it *grew*.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT THROUGH THE gold room first. Round. Through. A clean cold rush. Like a window flung open in a sickroom.

The dust went with it.

All of it. Lifted off Seraphine's face. Off his mother's hands. Off the two little sleeping lights at the edge of the room. Lifted, and swept, and carried. Out. Through the tear. Past him. Into the cold dark.

And then it hit the moths.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HAD SEEN WREN use her wind on the Mothwing. Lex had told him. At Greyfall. *They tumbled*, Lex had said. *They're too light. They're made of dust. They can't fly in a real wind.*

This was a real wind.

It was the realest wind there was.

The great slow glittering column of moths round Maelis *broke*. All at once. Like a stack of leaves when you open a door in autumn. They went up and over and round, tumbling, whirling, a hurricane of grey-gold, smashing into each other, tearing, shedding. Their wings creasing. Folding. Coming apart. And the dust they shed went with the wind, and the wind

took it away, up, out, into the dark, into the far deep, scattered so thin it could never gather.

The Mothwing went with them. Thirty. Forty. Pale shapes tumbling head over heels through the dark like scarecrows in a gale. Gone.

And Maelis—

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIND HIT HER where she knelt.

Kneeling on the dark with her hands cupped and her mouth bent to them and her enormous wings spread behind her like sails.

Like *sails*.

It caught them. Both wings. All of them. Every painted eye. And it *pulled*.

She went over.

Backward. Off her knees. Her hands flying up. And what was in them, the full dark, the glowing night-sky, the stolen piece of the little one, spilled. Out of her fingers. In a long glittering arc. Back down. Into the dark. Into the deep. Into the little one, where it came from.

Not all of it. Most of it. She'd drunk. She'd drunk a great deal. But what was still in her hands—

It went home.

And the little one's scream *broke*. Stopped. Mid-cry. Like a child's crying stops when you pick it up.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Clarity: 33 → 41]

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS CAME UP OUT of the wind.

On her feet. Slowly. Staggering. Her wings torn. Not badly. A rent in one, the left, near the top, where the wind had caught it hardest. Her silver hair wild. Her gown torn at the hem.

And she was *bright*.

Antho looked at her. Through the clearing dark. Through the last of the tumbling moths.

She'd been bright before. Her eyes. Two lights. Windows. Lamps.

She wasn't just her eyes now.

She was lit all through. From inside. Her skin. Her hair. Her hands. The whole tall thin grey-gold shape of her glowing, faintly, softly, the way the dark had glowed in her cupped hands. The way the night sky glows far from any town.

She'd drunk it. The piece of the little one. It was in her.

And over her head, in the dark, the net found her.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
▓▓▓ ENTITY RECLASSIFIED ▓▓▓
Name: MAELIS (of the Crowned)
Class: ▓▓▓▓▓▓▓ — NOT OF THIS NET
Measure: TIER V
  "SOVEREIGN"
Warning: This entity carries a share
  of an unrecognized Well.
```

◆ ◆ ◆

TIER V.

Sovereign.

Antho had read about it. In every Founders' record. In the Codex. In Seraphine's notes. Tier V. Level one hundred. The top of everything. The last rung of the net. *Only Aurelian is known to have reached it.*

Aurelian. And now her.

She looked at the panel over her head. With her lit eyes. For a long moment.

And laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T A LOVELY laugh. Not this time. It was something else. Low. Deep. Shaking. The laugh of someone who has been starving for nine hundred years and has just eaten.

"*Oh*," said Maelis of the Crowned. "*Oh, I'd forgotten. I'd forgotten what it tastes like.*"

She looked down at her own hands. Glowing.

"*Nine hundred years*," she said softly. "*In the grey. With nothing. Watching my people come apart.*" She closed her hands. "*I'd forgotten.*"

She looked up.

At the tear. At the doorway. At Antho, on his knee in it, with his hands still on his head. At Lex beside him, with an empty glass bottle in his fist. At the gold room behind them. At Seren with her lamp.

"*Thank you*," said Maelis. To all of them. To the little one. To the dark. "*Thank you. That was only a sip. But it was enough to remember.*"

She smiled.

"*Now I know I can*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX MOVED.

Antho didn't see him take it out. He just had it. In his hand. Small. Plain. Old. Worn smooth. A little hand-hammer. The one from Malachi's cave. The one from the Heart. The one an old man had held, curled up at the bottom of the world, saying *I'm the flaw*.

Aurelian's hammer.

His brother went out through the tear. Not running. Walking. Across the dark. Toward the glowing woman. With the little hammer held low at his side.

She watched him come.

She didn't move. She didn't spread her wings. She stood there, glowing, Sovereign, with her lit eyes on him, and watched him come, the way you'd watch a child walk toward you with a stick.

"*Smith*," she said. Fondly. "*What are you going to do with that?*"

"*Find the flaw*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

Unmaking.

Antho had seen him do it. Twice. Once to a Severance chain, at Sorn's masquerade. Once to the hunger, at the Heart. The seam. The place where a made thing was weakest. Where it had been folded wrong, or welded badly, or held together too long by something that wasn't meant to hold.

Every made thing has a flaw, Lex had said. *You just have to listen for it. Tink.*

He stopped in front of her. Close. Closer than anyone should have stood to that much light. With the black heat round him flickering, failing, gold coming through.

And lifted the little hammer.

And tapped her.

Not hard. Lightly. The way you'd tap a bell to hear if it's cracked. Once. On the breastbone. Over the heart.

Tink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SOUND WENT THROUGH her.

Antho heard it. Everyone heard it. A small clear ringing note. Like a struck glass. Like a bell. Going into the glowing grey-gold body of the Moth Queen and through it and—

And *out the other side*.

That was what was wrong. Antho heard it. Lex heard it. He saw his brother's face change. A sound that goes into a solid thing comes back. Rings. Hums. Fills it.

This didn't come back.

It went in. And kept going. Through. As if there was nothing there to stop it. As if the middle of her was—

Hollow.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Oh*," said Lex.

Very quietly. Standing in front of her with the little hammer in his hand.

"*Oh. There's nothing there.*"

Maelis didn't move.

"*You're hollow*," said Lex. Slowly. Wonderingly. "*In the middle. Where it should be. You drank and drank and drank, and it never—*" He stopped. "*It never filled you. Did it. It went in. And through. And out. Like water through a sieve.*"

The Moth Queen looked at him.

And for the first time since Antho had seen her, on the floor of the Hall of Lanterns, at the bottom of the world, something in her face was not arranged. Not chosen. Not shown on purpose.

Afraid.

"*That's why you're always hungry*," said Lex. "*Isn't it. Nine hundred years. It's not the grey. It's not the exile. You were hungry before. At the pool. That's why you drank more than anyone.*" He looked at her glowing hands. "*You drank a Well dry. And you're still empty.*"

"*Be quiet*," said Maelis.

"*It's going out of you*," said Lex. "*Right now. I can hear it. Through the flaw. What you just drank. It's leaking.*"

"*Be quiet*."

"*You'll have to keep drinking*," said his brother. Very softly. "*Forever. Won't you. Because it never stays.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STRUCK HIM.

Antho saw it. A long pale glowing hand, fast as a snake, faster than anything. Across the face. Open-palmed. The way you'd slap a child.

Lex went backward. Off his feet. Across the dark. Ten yards. Twenty. And landed hard. And rolled. And didn't get up.

"*LEX*!"

Antho was up. Off his knee. Out of the doorway—

No.

He stopped. On the edge. With one foot over.

If I go, the door's empty. If the door's empty, she walks in. Past me. To the middle.

He stood on the edge of the tear with one foot over and every part of him screaming to go, to run to his brother, to put the dark round that tall glowing shape and *squeeze*—

And held the door.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T COME FOR it.

She stood in the dark where she'd struck Lex. Breathing hard. Glowing. With her lit eyes wide and her hand still raised. Looking at it. At her own hand.

It was flickering.

The glow. In her fingers. In her wrist. Going dim. Coming back. Going dim again. Like a lamp running out of oil. Like a candle in a draft.

Leaking.

She looked at it for a long moment. And her face did something Antho would think about for the rest of his life.

It looked *old*.

Not her skin. Not her hair. Her face stayed beautiful. But something behind it. Something in the eyes. Nine hundred years. Every one of them. Showing. All at once. Like the face of a woman who has just been told something she's always known and spent her whole life arranging not to hear.

Then it was gone.

She closed her hand. Tight. Round the flickering glow. Holding it in. And folded her torn wings. Close. Tight. Against her back.

And looked at Antho. In his doorway.

"*Keep your door, little Warden*," said Maelis of the Crowned. Very softly. "*Keep it as long as you like. It doesn't matter now.*"

She smiled. Thin. Cold.

"*I know where it's going*," she said. "*Up. Toward the light. It can't help it. That's what it is.*" Her lit eyes moved past him. To the gold room. To Seren. "*And when it comes up, I'll be waiting. Under the sky. With all my people. With every moth there is.*"

She leaned toward the dark above her. Toward the longest shaft. The way a moth leans toward a gap in a shutter.

"*And it won't be a sip next time*," said the Moth Queen.

And she was gone.

Up. Into the dark. Folded. Fast. A grey-gold streak, glowing, going up the longest, deepest shaft in the world. Like a spark up a chimney. Like a moth through a crack.

Gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO GOT TO HIS brother first.

He didn't remember leaving the doorway. Afterward, he'd ask Seraphine, and she'd say *you held it until she was gone. Until the very last of her was gone. And then you ran.*

Lex was on his back on the dark. With his eyes open. With a mark across his face, from his left temple to his jaw. Not a cut. Not a bruise. A *print*. Grey-gold. Glittering. The shape of a long-fingered hand.

"*Lex—*"

"*I'm all right*." His brother's voice was thick. "*I'm all right. I think. I think she broke my nose.*" He blinked. "*Antho. Did you hear it?*"

"*Hear what*?"

"*The tink*." Lex lifted his hand. The little hammer was still in it. "*It went straight through her. There's nothing in the middle. She's hollow. She's been hollow the whole time.*" He was staring up at the dark. At the shaft. "*She can't keep it. Anything she drinks. It goes straight through.*"

Antho knelt beside him. And put his hand on his brother's chest. Over his heart. Where the empty bottle was. And the little silver bell.

And felt his heart beating. Hard. Fast. Alive.

"*You're an idiot*," said Antho Vey. His voice cracked in half. "*You walked up to a Sovereign with a hammer the size of a spoon.*"

"*It worked*."

"*She hit you across the world*."

"*It worked*," said Lex. And started to laugh. And then stopped, because it hurt. "*Ow.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

```
LEX VEY
Level 92 → 93
Skill: UNMAKING (Expert 4)
  → New effect: FLAW-SENSE
"He heard the place where she was
 empty."
```

```
ANTHOREN VEY
Level 80 → 82
Clarity: 41 → 63 (recovering)
"He held the door. He did not go out.
 It was the hardest thing he has ever
 not done."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

KESTREL FOUND KELL.

Out in the dark. Where the drowned city began. Sitting against the wall of a grey house. With half a broken staff in her lap and blood on her ruined white robes. Down her side. From under her ribs.

"*One of the Mothwing*," said Kell. Very calmly. When they got to her. "*It had a knife. I didn't know they carried knives.*" She looked at the blood. "*I came to help. I'm not very good at helping without a staff.*"

Seraphine knelt beside her. Pressed her hands to the wound. Her face went white.

"*It's deep*," she said.

"*I know.*" Kell looked at her. With her pale eyes. Half-dim still. "*I know what deep is, scholar. I've been at the bottom of the world for two years.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT IN THE gold room after.

All of them. Round the clay lamp. In the warm. With the little one folded close round them, closer than before. Trembling. Like a horse after a fright. Like a child that won't let go of your skirt.

There was a wound in it.

Antho could feel it. Everyone could. Out there. In the dark. Where she'd knelt and cupped her hands and drunk. A place where the dark was thin. Where it was *less*. Like a bite out of an apple. Like a bruise. Aching. Leaking, a little, the way she was leaking.

[...she drank me...] said the little one. Very small. Over and over. *[...she drank me...she drank me...like before...like the hall...]*

"*I know, lamb*," said Seren. Holding the lamp. Holding the warm dark. Holding it with her whole self, the way she'd held it for a year and a half. "*I know. I know. I've got you.*"

[...she said she'll be waiting...]
[...when I come up...under the sky...]
[...with every moth there is...]
Nobody said anything.
[...lamp-lady...]
"*Yes, lamb.*"
[...I don't want to come up anymore...]

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO LOOKED AT HIS mother.

She was sitting very straight. With the lamp in her lap and her hand on the dark beside her. Her face was grey with tiredness and dust. Her eyes were very bright.

He'd seen that face before. In memory. Thirteen years ago. On the stairs at Harrow. In the kitchen, with the hole opening behind the hearth and the dark coming in. Her face, turning toward him, with the lamp in her hand.

Making a decision.

"*You have to*," said Seren Vey. Very gently. To the dark. "*Lamb. You have to come up. You can't stay down here forever. Down here there's nothing. No sun. No rain. No new things.*" She swallowed. "*You're the door new things come in by. You can't be a door at the bottom of the world. A door has to open onto somewhere.*"

[...but SHE'LL be there...]
"*I know.*"
[...she'll DRINK me...]
"*No*," said Seren.

She looked up. At her sons. At Lex, with the handprint on his face and the little hammer in his lap. At Antho, with his Clarity creeping back up and his hands still shaking.

"*No*," said their mother. "*She won't. Because when you come up, lamb, you're not going to come up alone. And you're not going to come up into her sky.*"

She looked at Lex.

"*You're going to come up somewhere that's been made ready for you*," said Seren Vey. "*Somewhere with room.*"

Lex looked back at her.

And Antho watched his brother understand. Watched it come up into his face the way it always did. Out of his hands. Out of the part of him that had stood at an anvil every day since he was eleven.

Every new thing needs a hollow to be made in.

"*A mould*," said Lex. Very slowly. "*You want me to make it a mould.*"

His mother didn't answer.

She didn't need to.

Out in the dark, beyond the gold room, the little one went very still.

Listening.

CHAPTER 19

Room

THE HANDPRINT WOULDN'T COME off.

Seraphine tried. With water from her flask, and a cloth, and then with her own sleeve, kneeling beside Lex in the gold room with her spectacles pushed up and her tongue between her teeth. Scrubbing at his face.

It smeared. It stuck. It glittered.

Grey-gold. Fine as flour. From his left temple, across his cheekbone, down to the hinge of his jaw. Four long fingers and a thumb. The shape of a hand that had struck him open-palmed across the dark at the bottom of the world.

"*It's in the skin*," said Seraphine at last. Sitting back. "*Lex. It's not on your face. It's* in *it. Like a tattoo. Like a burn.*"

"*Does it hurt*?" said his mother.

"*No*." He touched it. It didn't feel like anything. Smooth. Slightly cool. Like the inside of a shell. "*My nose hurts.*"

"*Your nose is broken*," said Kestrel. Without sympathy. She'd set it herself, ten minutes ago, with a quick hard twist of her fingers that had made him see stars. "*That's what noses do when Sovereigns slap them.*"

His mother was looking at the handprint.

She didn't say anything. She reached out, very slowly, and touched it. With one square freckled fingertip. Lightly. The way she'd touched the thumbprint in the wax of his father's letter.

"*She marked you*," said Seren Vey.

"*She hit me*."

"*She marked you*." Her finger stayed on his cheek. "*That's what they do, Lex. My mother said. When they touch you, they leave a mark. So they can find you again.*" Her hand dropped. "*Like a moth leaves dust on a window. So the next one knows there was a light there.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SLEPT.

There wasn't really any sleeping, down here. There wasn't any night or day. There was the gold room, and the clay lamp, and the warm dark round them, folded close. And outside it, the cold, and Shade's stars, and the place in the dark where the little one had been bitten.

Lex could feel it.

He wasn't a Listener of the Hollow. He couldn't hear rooms. But he could feel *that*. The way you can feel a cold draft from a broken window two rooms away. A thinness. A place where something had been taken out.

It ached. Even to him.

And the little one wouldn't stop trembling.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It can't come through the door*," said Seraphine.

She'd been working it out. For an hour. With her notebook on her knees and her pencil going and the clay lamp beside her for light. She'd covered six pages. Lex had watched her cover them. Lines. Circles. Numbers. A drawing that might have been the Hollowmaw. A drawing that was certainly the little one, a great soft shape like a hill, with a tiny door drawn at its feet for scale.

The door was the size of a grain of rice.

"*It's too big*," said Seraphine. "*Not by a little. By—*" She looked at her numbers. "*I don't know how to say how much. It's the size of the deep, Lex. It's folded round the whole of the bottom of the world. When it unfolds, when it comes up properly, it'll be—*" She stopped.

"*How big*?"

"*A country*," said Seraphine. "*A small one. At least.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*If it comes up through the Hollowmaw*," said Seraphine, very carefully, "*through the door, it'll have to fold itself into a shape the size of the door. And*

then squeeze through. And then unfold on the other side. In the cavern. Under the mountain." She looked at Antho. *"There isn't room under the mountain."*

"So it can't come through the door," said Kestrel.

"It can't come through any door," said Seraphine. *"Not the Hollowmaw. Not the shafts. The shafts are worse; they're narrower, and they're wounds."* She looked at the six pages. *"Not anywhere. There isn't a door in the world big enough."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"Then we make one," said Lex.

They all looked at him.

He didn't know where it came from. It came up out of his hands. It usually did. He was sitting on the warm dark with the little hammer in his lap and his broken nose throbbing and the handprint on his face, and he said it before he'd thought it.

"Not a door," he said. *"A door's for walking through. It's not going to walk through. It's going to* come up.*"* He looked at Seraphine's drawing. The great soft hill. The grain of rice. *"Like water coming up in a spring. Like iron coming up a mould."*

"A mould," said his mother. Softly.

"You said." He looked at her. *"Somewhere that's been made ready. Somewhere with room."* He turned the little hammer over in his fingers. *"That's a mould. That's exactly a mould. You make the shape first. The empty shape. In the sand. And then you pour."*

"The size of a country?" said Kestrel.

"I don't know." He looked at the hammer. *"I've never made a mould bigger than a cartwheel. Brannoc made one once for a church bell. It took him three months and he nearly killed himself."*

"So how—"

"I don't know," said Lex Vey. *"I don't know how. I don't know where. I don't know what it's made of or how deep it goes or who's going to help me dig it."* He looked up. At the dark. At the warm soft trembling folded dark round the little gold room. *"But I know that's what it needs. That's what*

new things need. A hollow to come up into. A space someone made for them, on purpose. Before they got there."

He put his hand flat on the warm dark beside him.

"Little one," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT VERY STILL.

He felt it go still. All of it. Round them. Listening. The way Antho said it listened. The way a child goes still when someone it doesn't know very well speaks to it directly for the first time.

[...the smith...]

He heard it.

Not like Antho heard it. Not in the back of his skull. Not in an old place where something used to live. He heard it the way you hear someone speak in the next room. Faintly. Through the wall. Through the warm dark under his palm.

[...the smith is talking to me...]

"I'm the smith," said Lex. *"I claimed your first stone. On the green at Ashbourne. Do you remember?"*

[...you picked it up...you didn't break it...you held it...]

"I held it."

[...it was warm in your hand...]

"So was it," said Lex.

The little one was quiet.

[...you made the cups...]

"Me and Pim."

[...the little quiet one...the one with the room inside...]

"Yes."

[...the cups were nice...] A pause. *[...the cups were like being carried...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

"Listen," said Lex.

He didn't know how to talk to it. He'd never talked to anything this big. He'd talked to fire. To stone. To the Undertow, once, in the Wellworld of Tide, and nearly drowned. To the Hearth, in the Wellworld

of Flame, which had asked him what he burned for, and he'd said *I don't know, I keep asking*.

He talked to it the way he'd talk to Dunny Tobbin. To Ivy Moss. To any frightened child who'd come to the forge door and stood there with their thumb in their mouth.

"*You can't come up through the door*," said Lex. "*You're too big. That's not your fault. You're the right size. The door's the wrong size.*"

[...]

"*So I'm going to make you a new one*," said Lex. "*Not a door. A room. Up there. Under the sky. Big enough for all of you. Somewhere the moths can't get into. Somewhere you can come up slowly, and unfold, and see everything, and not be frightened.*"

[...a room...]

"*A room*," said Lex. "*Made ready. For you. Before you get there.*"

[...nobody ever made a room for ME...]

[...I'm the room...I'm the one that makes room...for everything else...]

[...nobody ever...]

"*I know*," said Lex. His voice was rough. "*I know. That's why. Somebody should.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WARM DARK ROUND them trembled.

Not with fear. Lex felt the difference. He couldn't have said how. A different trembling. The way a dog trembles when you've come home after a long time away, and it doesn't know what to do with itself, and it just *shakes*.

[...how long...]

He didn't know.

He looked at Seraphine. She was looking at her six pages. At her numbers. At the great soft hill and the grain of rice.

"*It's still rising*," she said slowly. "*It's been rising since the Heart. A year and a half. Faster now. Faster every week.*" She bit her pencil. "*It'll come up whether we're ready or not. It can't help it. It's what it is. It goes toward the light.*"

"*How long*?" said Lex.

Seraphine looked at the dark. Listening. With her hands out, palms up.

"*Autumn*," she said at last. Very quietly. "*Late autumn. When the nights get long and the lights come on.*" She swallowed. "*The end of the year.*"

Lex looked at his mother.

His mother looked back.

They both knew what came at the end of the year. When the nights got long and every window in Caldor had a lantern in it.

Lantern Night.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'll stay with it*," said Kell.

Everyone turned.

She was sitting against the wall of the gold room. Where Seraphine had propped her. With her back to the warm dark and her long legs stretched out and her ruined white robes stiff and dark down one side where the blood had dried. Seraphine had bound the wound. Tight. With strips of her own petticoat. It had stopped bleeding. Mostly.

Kell's face was grey. Greyer than it had been. Her eyes were still half-dim. Faint. Like a lamp turned down low.

But she was sitting very straight.

"*Isaura*," said Seren. "*No.*"

"*Someone has to*." Kell didn't look at her. She was looking at the dark. At the place, out beyond the gold room, where the little one had been bitten. "*Someone has to stay. She knows where it is now. She's tasted it. She'll send more down the shafts. Moths. Her people. She'll keep coming back. Sipping.*" Her thin mouth twisted. "*Someone has to stand in front of it with a stick.*"

"*You don't have a stick*," said Kestrel.

"*I'll find another stick*."

"*You're hurt*," said Seraphine.

"*I've been hurt before*." Kell looked at her. "*I was unwritten, scholar. I was made into a Warden for the thing it used to be. I stood at the Hollowmaw door from the inside for months with no face and no name.*" She looked back at the dark. "*This is just a knife.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Then I'll stay too*," said Seren.

Lex turned round so fast his broken nose screamed.

"*Mam—*"

"*She can't stay alone*." His mother's face was set. "*Not hurt. Not with half her light gone. Not with that thing sending moths down the holes.*" She held the clay lamp tighter. "*And it needs me. Listen to it. It's shaking. It's been shaking since she bit it. I'm the one it listens to. I'm the one who sings. If I go up—*"

"*If you stay*," said Isaura Kell, "*you'll die down here.*"

Seren stopped.

"*Not of the moths*," said Kell. Very calmly. "*Not of her. Of the waiting. Of the walking. Of a year and a half in the dark with your feet hurting and a coat on a hook you can't remember.*" She looked at Seren with her pale half-dim eyes. "*You've been down here thirteen years, Seren Vey. Holding doors. Walking things home. Singing to children who aren't yours.*" Her voice didn't change. "*Your husband is up there. Dying. He's got a season. Maybe less. He fills your lamp every night and says good evening to it.*"

The gold room was very quiet.

"*Go home*," said Isaura Kell. "*Go home to him. Before he's gone. Read his letter by a window. Find out if he takes salt in his porridge.*" Something moved at the corner of her mouth. "*I'll sit with your little one. I'm not good at much. I'm good at standing in front of things.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER DIDN'T SAY anything for a long time.

Lex watched her. She was sitting on the warm dark with the clay lamp in her lap, and her hand on the lamp, and her face very still. Looking at Kell. And then at the dark. And then at her sons. And then at the lamp.

He knew that face. He'd seen it on the stairs at Harrow, thirteen years ago. He'd seen it on the night she walked into the dark.

A woman deciding which of the things she loved she was going to have to put down.

"*You hate it*," said Seren. To Kell. Very quietly. "*Don't you. Underneath. It ate you. It ate your name.*"

Kell was quiet.

"*Yes*," she said. "*Underneath. Some days.*" She looked at the dark. "*Some days I wake up and I remember being nothing. Being a shape. Being its Warden. Standing at a door with no face, pushing, for months, because it told me to.*" Her bony hands clenched in her lap. "*And I want to burn it. All of it. I want to take a torch and set fire to the whole of the deep and watch it go.*"

Nobody moved.

"*And then it says—*" Kell stopped. Her mouth worked. "*It says,* Warden, are you awake? Warden, can I tell you something? *In that voice. That little voice.*" She swallowed. "*And it tells me something. Some little thing. That it saw a star. That it heard you singing. That it's frightened of the dark, which is ridiculous, because it* is *the dark.*"

She looked at Seren.

"*And I can't*," said Isaura Kell. "*I can't burn it. I've tried. In my head. I can't.*" Her voice cracked. Just a little. The first time Lex had ever heard it crack. "*Gods help me. I walked it all the way up here. I'm not going to stop now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Someone sat with it before*," said Lex.

Kell looked at him.

"*When it was the other thing*," said Lex. "*At the Heart. When it unfolded. When it was just a small cold shaking dark.*" He looked toward the edge of the gold room. Where the two little lights had been, before the dark folded the middle back. "*Malachi sat with it. Cupped it in his hands and said, I'm not going to cage you. I'm just going to sit with you.*"

Kell said nothing.

"*He sat with it till it got better*," said Lex. "*Till it wasn't hungry anymore. Till it was this.*" He looked at her. "*And now somebody's going to sit with it till it gets home.*"

Isaura Kell, who had been High Warden of the Order of the Lattice, who had signed forty-one warrants for unlatticed sorcery and remembered every name, who had been carried across the bottom of the world on the back of a man she'd branded, looked at Lex Vey for a long time.

"*Yes*," she said at last. Very quietly. "*Someone is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[...Warden...]

They all heard it. Even Kestrel.

[...Warden...are you staying...]

Kell didn't look up. She was looking at her own hands.

"*I'm staying*," she said. "*Till you're home. Till the smith makes your room. Till you come up.*"

[...why...]

Kell was quiet for a moment.

"*Because somebody carried me once*," said Isaura Kell. "*When I couldn't walk. When I was half gone. Across the bottom of the world. In the dark.*" Her voice was very steady. "*He didn't have to. I'd hurt him. I'd branded him. I'd made him cap four thousand children.*" She looked at the dark. "*He carried me anyway.*"

She put her bony hand flat on the warm dark beside her.

"*So I'm carrying you*," she said. "*That's all. I'm just passing it on.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE DARK—

Lex felt it. They all felt it. The whole warm soft trembling fold of it, round the gold room. It *settled*. Round Kell. Close. Closer. The way a cat settles into a lap. The way a child settles into sleep.

And where it touched her side, where the wound was, under Seraphine's petticoat bandage, something happened.

Lex couldn't see it. None of them could. But Seraphine could hear it. She went very still. With her hands out.

"*It's making room*," she whispered. "*Round the wound. In the wound. It's—*" She shook her head. "*It's not healing it. It can't heal. That's not what it does.*" She swallowed. "*It's making room for it to heal. It's holding the space. So the wound has somewhere to close into.*"

Kell put her hand on her side.

And breathed. Deep. All the way down. For the first time since they'd found her on the steps of the grey house.

"*Oh*," said Isaura Kell. Very softly. "*Oh. That's—*"

She didn't finish.

She didn't have to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT UP THE next day.

There wasn't a next day. But it felt like one. They'd sat in the gold room, and eaten Seraphine's bread, and Kestrel had slept for an hour with her head on her pack, and Antho had sat with his back against the warm dark with his hand flat on it and his eyes shut, and his mother had sung. Flat on the high note. Over and over. Until the little one stopped trembling.

And then Seren had stood up.

On her own. Her legs worked now. She stood up in the gold room with the clay lamp in her hand and looked at Kell.

"*I'll come back*," she said.

"*I know*."

"*Before Lantern Night*."

"*I know*."

"*Don't let it go to sleep while I'm gone*," said Seren. "*It sleeps too much when it's frightened. Wake it up. Talk to it. Tell it things. It likes stories.*" Her voice cracked. "*It likes the one about the girl who married the bear. And the one about the miller's cat. It doesn't like the one about the wolf. Don't tell it the wolf.*"

"*I won't tell it the wolf*," said Kell.

Seren looked at her for a long moment.

Then she bent down. And put her arms round the gaunt grey woman in the ruined white robes. And held her. Hard. The way she'd held her sons.

Kell didn't move. For a long time. Her arms stayed at her sides. Rigid. The arms of a woman who hadn't been held since she was nine, except once, on the back of a man in the dark.

And then, slowly, awkwardly, the way a door swings that hasn't been opened in years—

She held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LITTLE ONE TOOK them up.

It wasn't like walking. It wasn't like the long slow climb Seren had told them about, a year and a half of it, up and up through Shade's dark with her feet hurting. It was like being *carried*. The warm dark folded round them, soft, close, and then folded again, and again, and every fold brought them higher. Like a map being folded. Like a letter. Like a sheet being folded by two people walking toward each other from opposite ends.

Lex felt the moths go by. Overhead. And then beside them. And then below. A great slow glittering field of them, turning, drifting, in the dark between the stars. Hunting. They didn't see. The little one held them folded so close and so small that there was nothing to see.

[...this is how I carry the lamp-lady...] it said. Shyly. To him. Through the warm dark. *[...when the moths come...I fold her up small...like a letter...]*

"*It's very good*," said Lex.

[...is it...]

"*It's the best carrying I've ever had*," said Lex. "*And I've been carried by dragons.*"

The warm dark rippled. Like a cat's tail flicking.

[...dragons...] said the little one. Wonderingly. *[...the lamp-lady says there are dragons...up there...is that true...]*

"*Two*," said Lex. "*A big one and a little one. The little one's the size of a house.*"

[...]

[...I want to see the dragons...]

◆ ◆ ◆

EMBER TALKED TO HIS mother on the way up.

Lex didn't hear most of it. He didn't try. It wasn't his.

He felt it, though. The coal in his hearth, glowing. Talking. Very quietly. And his mother, walking beside him in the folded dark, with her hand on his arm and her head bent toward his chest. Listening. Her face very still.

Once, she laughed. Softly. Surprised.

Once, she put her hand over her mouth.

Once, near the top, she stopped walking. And stood very still. With her eyes shut. And Lex felt Ember go quiet in his hearth, and his mother's hand

tighten on his arm, and something pass between them that he wasn't part of.

When she opened her eyes, they were wet.

"*He told me about the steps*," she said. Very low. Not to Lex. To herself. "*The rain. What I said about the lanterns.*" She swallowed. "*What he said back.*"

[Only that one,] said Ember. In his hearth. Very softly. *[I told her only that one. She asked for the rest. I said no.]*

Why?

[Because they're his,] said Ember. *[Not mine. I'm only a copy. He should be the one to tell her. While he still can.]* A pause. *[I'll keep them. All of them. Until she wants them. Or until he can't tell her himself.]*

Lex didn't say anything.

He put his hand over his mother's, on his arm. And held it there. All the rest of the way up.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE DOOR.

He saw it before anything else. A line. Thin. Gold. In the dark ahead of them. The crack Antho had left. *On the latch. We're coming back.*

Light. Lamp-light. Lantern-light. Coming through from the world. From a bell-shaped cavern at the bottom of a mountain. From a niche with three lamps in it.

From an old man in a chair.

The little one stopped.

It set them down. Gently. On the dark. In front of the crack. And unfolded from round them, slowly, the way a hand opens.

[...I can't go any further...] it said. Very small. *[...the door's too little...]*

"*I know*," said Lex.

[...you'll make the room...]

"*I'll make the room*."

[...promise...]

Lex put his hand flat on the warm dark. The last of it. Where it touched the edge of the door.

"*I promise*," said Lex Vey. "*I'll make you room. Up there. Under the sky. Before Lantern Night. Big enough for all of you. And I'll stand in it. With my brother, and my mother, and every lantern in Caldor.*" He swallowed. "*And when you come up, you won't come up into her sky. You'll come up into ours.*"

The little one didn't say anything.

But the dark, under his palm, was warm. And it leaned. Once. Against his hand. The way a horse leans its head against your shoulder.

And then it drew back. Down. Into the deep. Into Shade's starlit dark. Going home. To the gold room. To a gaunt grey woman with no stick, sitting very straight, waiting to tell it the one about the miller's cat.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER WAS STANDING in front of the door.

In front of the crack. The thin gold line of light. With the clay lamp in her hand. And her other hand at her chest. Inside her dress. Where the letter was.

She wasn't moving.

Antho came and stood beside her. On one side. Lex on the other. Seraphine and Kestrel behind.

"*Mam*," said Antho. Very gently.

She didn't look at him.

She was looking through the crack. Lex looked too. Through the thin gold line, into the world.

He could see the cavern. A little of it. The black floor. The black wall. The niche. Three small gold flames. And beside the niche, a chair. And in the chair, a shape.

An old man. Small. Wrapped in a blanket. With his white head fallen forward on his chest. Asleep. With one thin hand hanging down over the arm of the chair. And on the floor beneath it, where it had slipped from his fingers, a little copper oil-flask.

Fill the lamps, Lex had told him. *Every night. Don't stop.*

Every night, his father had said. *I promise*.

His mother made a sound.

Small. Low. Like a breath let out after a very long time held.

"*What if he doesn't know me*?" said Seren Vey. In a voice like a child's. "*What if I walk through and he looks up and—*"

She stopped.

"*What if I don't know him*," she whispered.

Nobody answered.

Nobody could.

And on the other side of the door, in the chair by the niche, the old man stirred. In his sleep. And lifted his white head a little. As if he'd heard something. Very far off. A voice he knew. A step on a long road.

And the clay lamp in the niche beside him—

Leaned.

All the way over. Toward the door. Toward the crack. Toward the woman standing on the other side of it, with its other half in her hand.

The way it had leaned every night for thirteen years.

Only this time, she was close enough to see.

CHAPTER 20

Leave a Light On

ANTHO OPENED THE DOOR the way you'd open a door on a sickroom.

Slowly. Quietly. With his hand flat on the black glass and his breath held. Not pushing. Asking. The way Kestrel had told him. The way he'd knocked, days ago, or weeks, or however long it had been down there in the dark.

Kell, he thought. *It's me again. We're home. May we come out?*

Far below, so far he could barely feel it, a bony hand on the other side of the glass. Faint. Steady. Sitting very straight beside something enormous and soft.

[...go on, then...]

[...don't let the cold in...]

The crack widened.

From the middle out. Like ice melting. Like breath clearing off a window. The thin gold line becoming a sliver, becoming a gap, becoming an arch. Tall. Round-topped. Full of gold light. Lamp-light. Lantern-light. The light of a thousand small flames on the walls of a long passage, and three in a niche, and the warm still air of a cavern at the bottom of a mountain, that smelled of stone and oil and home.

His mother stood in it.

She didn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HAD IMAGINED THIS.

Every night. For thirteen years. From the first night in the cave in the Greyspine, with the Murmur grinding in his skull and Ashka a cat-sized bundle of hurt in his lap. He'd imagined it the way you imagine things you know will never happen. In detail. Carefully. Like a man building a house in his head, room by room, so he'll have somewhere to go when the real house is too cold.

He'd imagined her coming through a door. Any door. The cottage door at Harrow, with the lantern in the window. The door of the cave. The black door at the bottom of the Hollowmaw, after he'd built the Keep round it and lit the first lantern and started saying *evening, Mam* to the dark.

He'd imagined her face.

He'd imagined his father's.

He'd never once imagined her standing in the doorway, not moving, with the clay lamp in her hand and the letter against her chest and her face gone white, looking at an old man asleep in a chair.

Afraid.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Mam*," he said. Very softly.

She didn't look at him.

"*I can't*," said Seren Vey. In a whisper. "*Antho. I can't. Look at him. He's so old.*"

"*I know.*"

"*He was young.*" She didn't take her eyes off the chair. "*In the dark. In my head. The voice was young. I thought—I don't know what I thought. I thought he'd be—*" She stopped. "*I don't know him. I don't know his face. I'm going to walk in there and he's going to wake up and look at me and I'm going to look at him and I won't know him.*"

"*You'll know him.*"

"*How do you know?*"

Antho looked at her. At his mother. Small and fierce and freckled, standing in a doorway at the bottom of the world with her lamp. The way she'd stood on the stairs at Harrow, thirteen years ago, with the dark coming in behind the hearth and her son screaming.

She'd walked into the dark then. Without stopping. Without looking back.

She'd been less afraid of the dark than she was of this.

"*Because Lex is right*," said Antho. "*You always know. You always have.*"

"*I don't remember—*"

"*You didn't remember Ember*," said Antho. "*And you knew him.*"

His mother turned her head. Slowly. And looked at him.

"*You knew his voice*," said Antho. "*In Lex's chest. Through a hearth. A piece of him from twenty years ago. You put your hand on Lex and said, that's the voice. You didn't remember it. You knew it.*" He swallowed. "*Go and listen, Mam. That's all. You're a Listener. Go and listen to him.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT.

One step. Out of the dark. Onto the black floor of the cavern. Into the gold light.

The clay lamp in the niche leaned so far over its flame nearly touched the stone. Toward her. Toward the lamp in her hand. Its other half. Two small gold flames, bending toward each other across the cavern, like hands reaching.

Another step.

The iron lamp leaned. The *ARDENT* one. All three. Leaning. Toward her.

The old man in the chair stirred.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WOKE THE WAY old people wake. Slowly. In pieces. His white head lifting off his chest. His thin hand moving on the arm of the chair, feeling for something. For the oil-flask that had fallen. His eyes, behind Seraphine's spare spectacles, opening. Blinking. Grey. Clouded with sleep.

He looked at the lamps first.

Antho saw him do it. Saw the old habit. A year and a half of it. Waking in the chair by the niche, and looking at the lamps, to see if they were still burning.

He saw them leaning.

And went very still.

And then, slowly, very slowly, the way you turn your head toward a sound you've been listening for so long you've stopped believing you'll ever hear it—

He turned.

And saw her.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY MOVED.

Not Antho, in the arch of the door. Not Lex, behind him. Not Seraphine, or Kestrel. Not Wren, who was at the mouth of the cavern, where the passage came down, with her hand on the wall and Pim beside her, who must have been there all along, who must have been sitting at the bottom of the passage for days, waiting. Not Odile. Not the students crowded in the passage behind them. Not the twins, or Tilda, or Kit, or Ivy Moss.

Nobody breathed.

His father sat in the chair and looked at his mother.

His mother stood on the black floor and looked at his father.

He was eighty. Antho could see it. Eighty, or more. White. Thin. A face like a walnut, all furrows. Hands like a bundle of twigs, brown-spotted, shaking on the arms of the chair. A blanket over his knees. Spectacles on his nose.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't try to get up. Antho saw him think about it. Saw his hands tighten on the arms of the chair. And stop. And let go.

He'd known. Antho thought. He'd known he wouldn't be able to stand. He'd known for weeks. He'd sat in the chair by the lamps every night and filled them and said good evening, and known that if she came, when she came, he'd be sitting down.

He took off his spectacles.

Slowly. With both shaking hands. And folded them. And put them in his lap.

And looked at her. With his own eyes. Grey. Clear. Steady. The same grey as Antho's.

And said the only thing he'd said to her every night for a year and a half.

"*Good evening*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER MADE A sound.

Antho would never be able to describe it. Not to Seraphine, who asked. Not to Lex, who'd heard it too and didn't need it described. Not to anyone. Not ever.

It wasn't a word. It wasn't a sob. It wasn't a laugh.

It was the sound of a lamp being lit.

She was across the cavern. Antho didn't see her go. One moment she was standing on the black floor three yards from the door, and the next she was on her knees in front of the chair, with the clay lamp set down on the stone beside her, and her square strong freckled hands on the old man's face.

On his face. His cheeks. His jaw. His forehead. His white hair. Touching. Not holding. Touching. The way a blind woman touches a face to learn it. Fast. Light. Everywhere. Her fingers running over the furrows and the hollows and the lines, over his eyebrows, his nose, his mouth.

He didn't move.

He sat in the chair with her hands on his face and his eyes on hers and didn't move at all. Antho saw his hands, on the arms of the chair. Gripping. White-knuckled. Shaking so hard the chair shook. Holding on.

Not touching her.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Say it again*," said his mother.

Her voice was a whisper. Her hands had stopped. On his face. One on each side. Cupping it.

"*Good evening*," said his father.

His voice was thin. Cracked. Old. An old man's voice, reedy, with a wobble in it at the end. Not the voice Antho remembered from the cottage at Harrow, deep and quiet and dry. Not the voice from the Spire, or the council, or the crystal at Avaloria.

But underneath—

Underneath, the same. The same shape. The same quiet. The same way of saying a thing as if it mattered very much and he didn't want anyone to know it mattered at all.

His mother shut her eyes.

And listened.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STAYED LIKE THAT for a long time.

Kneeling. Eyes shut. Hands on his face. Listening. To his breathing. To the small sounds of him. The creak of the chair. The tremor in his hands. Whatever it was a Listener heard, when she listened to a person.

Antho didn't know. He'd never know. He listened to the dark. To doors. To the little one. He'd never once listened to a person like that.

He thought, standing there: *I should. I should learn. Seraphine. Lex. Pim. I should listen to them like that.*

His mother opened her eyes.

They were wet. Her whole face was wet. She didn't seem to notice.

"*You have a nice voice*," said Seren Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER LAUGHED.

It came out of him like something breaking. Cracked. Wet. Startled. An old man's laugh, wheezing, that turned into a cough, that turned back into a laugh. He laughed with her hands on his face and his own hands gripping the arms of the chair and tears running down into the furrows of his cheeks, and he couldn't stop.

"*I'm told*," said Arion Vey. When he could. Gasping. "*I'm told it used to be nicer.*"

"*Who told you that*?"

"*You did*." He was still laughing. Crying. Both. "*The first night. On the steps of the Spire. In the rain. You said I had a voice like a librarian telling off a choir.*"

His mother stared at him.

"*I did not*."

"*You did*." He was shaking. "*I've written it down. It's in the letter. Page four.*"

"*That's a terrible thing to say to someone*."

"*It was*," Arion agreed. "*I fell in love with you on the spot.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE KISSED HIM.

Antho looked away. Everyone did. Kestrel turned round and studied the wall of the cavern with enormous interest. Seraphine put her face in Antho's shoulder. Lex made a sound like a man who has been hit very hard in the chest and found it didn't hurt.

At the mouth of the cavern, Wren Ashdown said, very quietly, "*Oh, for the Lady's sake,*" and burst into tears.

And Pim—

Pim, standing beside her, holding her hand, small and solemn in his blue coat, looked at the two old people by the niche. At the old man in the chair and the small woman kneeling in front of him, with her hands on his face.

And smiled.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T STAY IN the cavern long.

His father couldn't. He was cold. He was always cold now. And he was shaking so hard Seraphine was worried about his heart.

Lex carried him up. Two hundred and eleven steps. Up the long passage. Past the lanterns.

And his mother walked beside them. With her hand on the old man's arm. And the clay lamp in her other hand. Not the one from the niche. The one she'd carried. The flame. Its other half.

And as she passed them, the dark lanterns *lit*.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAW IT FIRST. Because he was behind. Because he was counting. Because he always counted.

The first was a lantern from Fenmoor. Old tin, battered, with a horn pane. Just inside the cavern, where the passage began. It had been dark since the first night of the moths, with dust on its pane that wouldn't come off.

His mother walked past it.

And it lit.

Not suddenly. Not all at once. Slowly. A glow. Behind the horn pane. Faint. Then less faint. Then gold. The dust on the pane didn't go. It was still there. Grey-gold. Smeared. But the light came through it anyway. Soft. Steady. Like a lamp lit behind a dirty window.

The next one. Brass, from the Saltreach, with green glass. Dark. Dusty.

She walked past it.

It lit.

And the next. And the next. All the way up the passage. Every dark one. Every one the moths had touched. Two hundred and six of them. As she passed. Each one. Lighting. Slowly. From inside. As if the light had been there all along, folded up very small, hiding, the way the little one had folded his mother up small in the dark when the moths came. Waiting for someone to walk past who knew how to unfold it.

She didn't seem to notice.

She was looking at the old man in Lex's arms. Talking to him. Low. Too low to hear. Her hand on his arm.

Antho walked behind them. And counted.

He didn't say the numbers out loud. He didn't need to. They went through him like a song. Like the Lantern Song. Like a bell.

Nine hundred and eight. Nine hundred and nine. Nine hundred and ten.

All the way up. All the way to the cave mouth. All the way to the last one. The very first one. The one he'd lit himself, the summer after Duskhold, with his own hands, in the cave where he'd lived alone for eight years.

One thousand one hundred and thirteen.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*How did she do that*?" said Seraphine.

At the cave mouth. In the dusk. With the sun going down red over the Greyspine and the slope below full of people. The students. The twins. Tilda, Kit, Ivy Moss. Odile with Pim on her hip, too big to be carried,

being carried anyway. Wren. Kestrel. Ashka on the ridge, with her great blue head up, watching.

Antho looked down the long passage. At the lanterns. Gold. All of them. Every one. Burning. With dust on half their panes, and the light coming through it anyway.

"*I don't know*," he said.

"*It was the lamp*," said Ivy Moss. From her stool by the door, where someone had put her. Very small. With her crutch across her knees. Looking down the passage with enormous eyes. "*Her lamp. The one she carried.*"

Everyone looked at her.

"*It's not kept*," said Ivy Moss. She went red. But she didn't stop. "*It's given. I could hear it. When she walked past. It's a light for someone else. That's all it is. That's all it's ever been.*" She looked at the lanterns. "*And the moths took the lights out of the lanterns. But they couldn't take them* away." She frowned. Looking for the words. "*They just—folded them up. Small. Hid them. Like the little one hid her.*"

She looked at Seren. At the end of the passage. Standing by the old man, who Lex had set down in a chair by the kitchen fire.

"*And when a light that's given walks past a light that's hiding*," said Ivy Moss, "*the hiding one remembers what it's for. And comes out.*"

Nobody said anything for a long time.

"*How do you know that*?" said Antho. Very gently.

Ivy Moss looked at her knees.

"*I don't know*," she said. "*It just—it sounds like that. Under. In the room. It sounds like that's what it is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WAS AT THE kitchen door.

With Wren.

Antho saw them. Over the heads of the students. Standing in the doorway, close. Not touching. Wren's hand was up. On his face. On his left cheek. Where the handprint was.

Grey-gold. Glittering. From his temple to his jaw.

She wasn't crying anymore.

She was looking at it. Her face very white. Very still. Her green eyes very hard.

"*She did this*," said Wren.

"*Yes*."

"*She touched you*."

"*She hit me*." Lex tried to smile. His broken nose made it lopsided. "*Across the world. I flew. Kestrel set my nose. It's fine.*"

Wren's thumb moved. Very lightly. Over the print. Over the long fingers of it.

"*It's not fine*," she said. Very quietly. "*It's a mark. She left a mark on you. On your face. Where I'll see it every day.*" Her hand dropped. To her own stomach. Flat. Over it. "*So she can find you again.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*Your mother told me*," said Wren. "*Just now. On the stairs. She came up to me and put her hand on me, here, without asking, the way old women do in the market, and she looked at me with those eyes of hers, and she said, you're carrying a light. Has the moth seen you?*" Her voice was very steady. "*And I said yes. At Greyfall. And she went white. Whiter than your father.*"

"*Wren—*"

"*She said the Harrow women never let a moth near a light that's carrying*," said Wren Ashdown. "*She said never. Not once. Not in nine hundred years.*" She looked up at him. "*She said that's the one thing they want more than anything. More than the Well. More than the blood.*"

The kitchen doorway was very quiet.

"*A new light*," said Wren. "*One that hasn't been given to anyone yet. That's never been anyone's but its own.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN READ THE LETTER by the window.

That night. In the kitchen of the Lantern Keep, which had one small high window cut through the rock of the mountain, looking east, over the valley, toward the Vale and Ashbourne and Harrow.

It wasn't daylight. It wasn't the window she'd wanted. There wasn't a kettle; Odile's terrible tea had to do.

She read it anyway.

Sitting on the bench under the window, with a lamp beside her, the clay one, and the old man asleep in the chair by the fire, wrapped in three blankets, with his white head on his chest. She'd said she wanted to read it with him there. She'd said she didn't care if he was asleep. She'd said she wanted to be able to look up from it and see him.

Antho sat at the long table, at the other end of the kitchen. Not watching. Not listening. Just there. The way you sit in a room with someone who's reading something important. So they won't be alone.

She read for a long time.

Sometimes she laughed. Softly. Into her hand.

Sometimes she stopped. And looked up. At the old man in the chair. For a long while. And then looked down again.

Once, she put the letter down in her lap. And put both her hands over her face. And sat like that, very still, for so long that Antho half got up.

Then she took her hands away. And picked up the letter. And kept reading.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME TO THE end at midnight.

He knew it was midnight because the old man in the chair woke up. All on his own. The way he'd woken every night for a year and a half. At midnight. To go down to the door and fill the lamps.

He woke. And lifted his head. And reached for the oil-flask that wasn't there.

And then remembered.

And looked up.

His wife was sitting on the bench under the window. With the letter in her lap. Forty pages. In his small neat hand. Looking at him.

"*Did you read it*?" said Arion. Very quietly.

"*Yes*."

"*All of it*?"

"*All of it*." She folded it. Carefully. Along the creases. "*Page four's my favorite. The librarian.*"

He looked at her. With his grey eyes. For a long time.

"*Do you—*" He stopped. Tried again. "*Is any of it—*"

"*No*," said Seren. Very gently. "*I don't remember any of it. Not one word. Not the steps. Not the rain. Not the librarian.*" She looked at the folded letter in her lap. "*It's like reading a story about two other people. Two people I'd have liked very much.*"

He nodded. Slowly. As if he'd expected it. As if he'd known.

"*But*," said Seren.

He looked up.

"*But I read the bit about the lanterns*," said his wife. "*Page nine. Where you told me the story of the Nine. As a joke. And I stopped laughing. And you wrote that you couldn't remember what I said next. That it was the one thing from that night you'd never been able to remember. That it was like a page torn out.*"

He'd gone very still.

"*I know what I said*," said Seren Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KITCHEN WAS VERY quiet.

"*I didn't remember it*," said Seren. "*Not until I read your letter. Not until I read that you couldn't.*" She looked down at the clay lamp beside her. "*And then I did. All at once. Like a stone turning over in a field.*" She looked up at him. "*Because it wasn't about you. That's why. It wasn't yours. It was mine. It was Mam's. The Ferryman only took you.*"

"*What did you say*?"

His mother looked at his father across the kitchen of the Lantern Keep, at midnight, with the letter in her lap and the lamp beside her and a thousand lanterns burning in the passage behind her.

"*I said, they're not stories*," said Seren Vey. "*I said, my mother's mother's mother saw one. A moth. In a window. At the end of a hot summer. And she packed her cart that same night and ran.*" She swallowed. "*And then I said: don't ever leave a light on for me, Warden. Not ever. If you love me. I'd rather walk home in the dark.*"

Arion Vey stared at her.

"*And then*," said his wife, "*you said—*"

"*I said, too late*," whispered his father. "*I've already lit one.*"

She smiled. Wet. Wide.

"*Page nine*," said Seren. "*You wrote that bit down. You just didn't know it was the answer.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THAT WAS WHEN THE World Notice came.

Antho felt it before he saw it. Everyone did. Everyone in the world. A *pressure*. Behind the eyes. The way a storm presses on your ears before it breaks. The net, reaching out. Through every thread. To every person in it. All at once.

He'd felt it four times before. *A Ceiling has been broken. A Key has been turned. The lid has lifted. The Ceiling is lifted, the Tithe is ended, the Root is relinquished, the net is reforged.*

It came now.

Not silver. Not gold. Not violet.

Grey-gold. Glittering. Like dust in a sunbeam.

◆ ◆ ◆

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▓▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓▓
A SOVEREIGN HAS RISEN.
Name: MAELIS (of the Crowned)
Tier: V
Location: HIGHCREST, CALDOR
"Not of this net. The net has
 measured her anyway. It did not
 enjoy it."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

The kitchen was silent. Antho heard the fire crackle. He heard his father breathing, quick and shallow, in the chair. He heard, very far off, down the passage, through the rock, through the door left on the latch, something enormous and soft and frightened, at the bottom of the world, go very still.

[...brother...]

[...brother, she's up there...]

[...she's up there with my light in her...]

His mother was on her feet. With the letter clutched to her chest. And her face white and set and hard. The Harrow face.

"*Highcrest*," said Seren Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT OUT TO the cave mouth.

All of them. Everyone in the Keep. Students in their nightclothes. Lex and Wren. Kestrel with her hair burning. Seraphine with her notebook. Antho with the Lantern. Lex carrying their father again, wrapped in blankets, with his white head on his son's shoulder. Seren beside them. With her lamp.

They stood in the snow at the mouth of the Hollowmaw, under the stars, and looked east.

Toward the Vale. Toward Ashbourne. Toward the long road south and east to Highcrest, a hundred miles off, far beyond the edge of seeing.

The moon was up. Nearly full. Low over the eastern ridges. Silver. Bright.

And as they watched, it went out.

◆ ◆ ◆

Not out. *Covered*.

Something passed in front of it. From the west. From behind them. From over the Greyspine, from the bare lands and the edge of the world. A cloud. Low. Vast. Moving east.

Not a cloud.

It glittered.

Grey-gold. In the moonlight. Like frost. Like dust in a sunbeam. Like the surface of a lake at night. Stretching from one edge of the sky to the other. North to south. As far as the eye could see. Drifting east. Slowly. Endlessly. Over the mountains. Over the Keep. Over their heads.

So high they couldn't hear it. So many there was no counting.

The moon went out behind them. And the stars. One by one. Swallowed. Until the whole sky over the Greyspine was a glittering grey-gold dark, turning, drifting, going east.

Toward Highcrest.

Toward the light.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STOOD IN THE snow and looked up.

He felt Seraphine's hand find his. He felt his brother beside him, with their father in his arms. He felt Wren on Lex's other side, with her hand on her stomach. He felt his mother.

He felt the little one. Far below. At the bottom of the world. With a gaunt grey woman sitting beside it, very straight, telling it the one about the miller's cat. Trembling.

And he did what he always did. What he'd done every night for thirteen years. In a cave, in a keep, at a door, on a mountain.

He counted.

But there was nothing to count. Not the moths. Not the stars. There were too many of one and none of the other.

So he counted the only thing he could.

The people beside him. In the snow. Under the glittering dark.

Mam. Father. Lex. Wren. Seraphine. Kestrel. Pim. Odile. Ivy. Tilda. Kit. Ilse. Ivo. Cass. The twins.

And one more. Very small. The size of a pea. Carrying a light.

Seventeen, thought Antho Vey.

And behind them, down the long passage, one thousand one hundred and thirteen lanterns burned. Every one. With dust on half their panes. And the light coming through it anyway.

INTERLUDE

The Sister Who Would Not Drink

NINE HUNDRED YEARS BEFORE a smith's son was born in a cottage at Harrow, a girl of seventeen sat on the edge of a fountain in a garden of glass and listened to a pool cry.

Nobody else could hear it.

She'd known that since she was small. Since she was four, and had sat on the cold grey stone at the edge of the pool in the cellars of her father's palace, before there was a hall of glass built over it, before anyone but the masons knew it was there. She'd sat there for hours. Listening. To the quiet. To the *full*. To the soft deep dark in the stone ring that sounded, if you listened long enough, like the moment before somebody says your name.

Her nurse had found her and smacked her and carried her upstairs. *Strange child*, the nurse had said. *Sitting in the dark talking to a puddle.*

She'd never told anyone else.

She'd never needed to. She was the tenth child. The youngest. The one nobody noticed. Her brothers and sisters were kings and queens. She was a girl in a grey dress who liked gardens.

Nobody asked what she could hear.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HAD BEEN GLAD, at first.

That was the worst of it. She'd think about that for the rest of her life, in twenty-two cottages in twenty-two valleys, by twenty-two fires. That it had been *glad*.

When Oszric found it. When he came down into the cellars with his masons and his torches and his great gold beard, and knelt at the edge of the stone ring, and looked down into the dark, and laughed. When he cupped his hands and drank, the first time, and stood up with his eyes wide and his face flushed and said *brothers, sisters, come and see what I've found.*

The pool had been glad.

She'd heard it. Standing at the back, behind the others, in her grey dress. A ripple. A brightness. Like a cat that has been sitting by a door for a hundred years and hears, at last, a hand on the latch.

Someone's looking at me, it had said. Not in words. It didn't have words. In the way it went warm. *Someone's kneeling down. Someone's come to see.*

Nobody ever stops.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY BUILT THE HALL over it in a year.

Glass. All of it. Walls and roof and floor. Ysenne's idea. Ysenne, who loved mirrors, who couldn't sleep without seeing her own face, wanted to see the pool from every side. From above. From below. So the masons dug out the cellars and the glassmakers came from every kingdom of the Nine, and they built a cathedral of ice over a puddle in the dark.

And every evening, in the gold light, the Nine came down and knelt.

All of them. Every brother and sister but her. Oszric first, always. Then Maelis. Then Ysenne and Caddoc and Rhosyn, whose crown was roses then. Then the four who weren't hers by blood but by marriage, kings of the eastern kingdoms, cousins, with crowns of bronze and bone and copper and coral.

Nine.

They knelt round the stone ring. And cupped their hands. And drank.

And she stood in the doorway in her grey dress and listened to the pool get smaller.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You should drink*," said Maelis.

She'd come and found her. In the garden. On the edge of the dry fountain. In the dusk.

Maelis was twenty-nine. The second-eldest. The most beautiful of all of them, everyone said, and the cleverest, and the kindest. She was the one who'd brushed Hesper's hair when she was small, when the nurses were too busy. The one who'd sat with her when she had the fever at six and told her stories all night about a girl who married a bear.

She sat down on the edge of the fountain beside her. Close. With her silver hair loose and her long hands in her lap. Her eyes were warm brown. Like honey. Like anyone's.

Not lit. Not yet.

"*You should drink*," she said again. Gently. "*Hes. Little sister. Everyone else has.*"

"*I don't want to*."

"*Why not*?"

Hesper didn't answer.

"*It's not wrong*," said Maelis. "*Oszric's asked the scholars. The old texts. There's nothing about it anywhere. No law. No curse. It's just a spring. A very old one. A very good one.*" She put her arm round Hesper's shoulders. "*Have you seen Father? Since he drank? He's walking again. Without the stick. His hands don't shake.*"

"*I've seen him*."

"*Then why—*"

"*Because it's crying*," said Hesper.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER SISTER WENT VERY still.

Hesper had never said it out loud. Not to anyone. Not in seventeen years. She'd said it now without meaning to, sitting on a dry fountain in the dusk, with her sister's arm round her and the pool under the palace getting smaller every evening.

"*Crying*," said Maelis.

"*The pool*." Hesper didn't look at her. "*I can hear it. I always could. Since I was little. It's—it's not a spring, Mae. It's not water. It's a—*" She didn't have the word. Nobody had the word. Not yet. Not for nine hundred

years. "*It's a room. A space. It's the place new things come through. And it was glad when you came. And now it's frightened. And it's getting smaller. And you're all getting—*"

She stopped.

"*Getting what*?" said Maelis. Very softly.

Hesper looked at her.

At her face. Beautiful. Kind. Twenty-nine and never going to be thirty. At her hands. Long. Pale. Steady.

At her eyes.

There was something in them. Far back. A flicker. A glint. Like the first spark when you strike flint. Not lit. Not yet. But *beginning*.

"*Hungry*," said Hesper.

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS LAUGHED.

It was a lovely laugh. Low and warm and fond. She kissed Hesper on the forehead. The way she'd kissed her when she was six, with the fever.

"*Oh, Hes*," she said. "*You always were the strange one.*"

And she got up. And brushed off her gown. And went back inside. To the hall of glass. To the gold light. To kneel.

And Hesper sat on the edge of the dry fountain in the dusk and heard, far down, under her feet, under the palace, the pool cry.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOY CAME IN the autumn.

She found him in the kitchen garden. Among the cabbages. Sitting on an upturned bucket with his feet bare and his knees up and his hands round them, waiting. Small. Brown. Thin as a rake. Seventeen, maybe, the same as her. With a face that looked as if it laughed a great deal, when it wasn't waiting outside a palace being ignored.

"*They won't let me in*," he said. Before she could ask. "*I've been here three days. I've asked every guard. They say the King doesn't receive Listeners.*" He looked up at her. "*I've been eating your cabbages. I'm sorry. They're very good.*"

"*Who are you*?"

"*Malachi*." He stood up. Bowed. Badly. He'd clearly never bowed to anyone in his life. "*Of the House of Vey. The youngest. My brother sent me.*"

"*Your brother*."

"*Aurelian*." He said it with an odd mixture of pride and weariness. The way a boy says the name of an older brother who is very clever and very serious and has never once let him win at anything. "*He'd have come himself. But they threw him out last time. And the time before. So he sent me. He said they'd be less likely to throw out a child.*"

"*You're not a child*."

"*I'm the seventh child*," said Malachi. "*That's close enough, in my family.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE BROUGHT HIM BREAD. And cheese. And a cup of milk from the kitchen. And sat with him on the edge of the cabbage bed while he ate, very fast, the way boys eat who've been sleeping in a garden for three days.

"*What's the message*?" she said.

He looked at her over the cup.

"*I'm not supposed to tell anyone but the King*."

"*The King's never going to see you*." She pulled her knees up. "*He's in the hall. Every evening. Drinking. He won't see anyone who isn't bringing him something.*"

Malachi was quiet for a moment.

"*The message is*," he said, "*stop.*"

Hesper looked at him.

"*That's all*," said Malachi. "*Just stop. My brother says it's a Well. Not a spring. One of the seven. The one in the middle. The one that makes room.*" He put the cup down. "*He says if they keep drinking it'll go dry. And a Well that goes dry doesn't just stop. It turns. It becomes the opposite of what it was. A room with nothing in it.*" He looked at his hands. "*And an empty room wants to be filled.*"

"*How does he know*?"

"*He listens*," said Malachi simply. "*We all do. All seven of us. That's what we are. Listeners. We sit by the fires and the rivers and the mountains and we listen until they tell us their names.*" He looked at her. "*He's been*

listening to it from three hundred miles away for a year. He says he can hear it crying."

◆ ◆ ◆

HESPER DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

She sat on the edge of the cabbage bed with her knees up and looked at the boy. At his bare brown feet. At his laughing face that wasn't laughing.

"*So can I*," she said.

Malachi went very still.

"*I always could*," said Hesper. "*Since I was four. I used to sit by it in the cellar. Before the hall. Before any of it.*" She swallowed. "*I thought I was mad. Everyone said I was strange. My nurse said I talked to puddles.*"

The boy looked at her. For a long time. With his eyes, which were brown, and very steady, and didn't laugh at all.

"*You're not mad*," said Malachi of the House of Vey. "*You're a Listener. That's all. Same as me.*"

He held out his hand. Small. Brown. Callused from goats.

"*And you're the only one in this whole palace who can hear it*," he said. "*Which means you're the only one who can help.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TRIED.

She tried for a month. She went to Oszric, in his great gold rooms, and stood in front of him in her grey dress and told him the pool was crying. He laughed at her. Kindly. And gave her a bracelet. And sent her away.

She went to Ysenne, who was looking in a mirror, and didn't look round.

She went to Caddoc, who didn't laugh, who never laughed, who listened to her with his heavy dark face very still and then said, *if it's dying, all the more reason to drink it while we can*.

She went to Rhosyn, who was in the garden with her roses, and who listened. Who actually listened. Who looked at Hesper with her green eyes going wide and frightened, and said *oh*. And said *are you sure*. And said *oh, Hes*.

And went down to the hall that evening and drank anyway.

She went to Maelis last.

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS WAS IN THE hall.

Alone. After the others had gone. Kneeling at the edge of the stone ring in the last of the gold light, with her silver hair pooled round her on the glass floor. Not drinking. Just looking. Down. Into the pool.

It was so low now. Hesper could see the stone sides of it. Grey. Dry. Going down. And at the bottom, a dark that wasn't full anymore. That was thin. Shallow. Like a puddle after rain.

And it was afraid.

She could hear it. So clearly, now. Not words. Never words. A shrinking. A pulling-in. Like an animal backing into a corner. *Please*, it was saying. *Please, please. Not again. Not again. I don't understand. I don't understand what you're doing.*

"*Mae*," said Hesper.

Her sister didn't look round.

"*It's so beautiful*," said Maelis. Softly. Looking down at the shallow dark. "*Isn't it. Even now. I come down here every evening after the others have gone. Just to look at it.*"

"*It's dying*."

"*I know*." Maelis didn't move. "*I know. The Vey boy told me. In the garden. I found him there with you yesterday.*" She was quiet. "*He's very sweet. He said stop. As if it were that easy.*"

"*It is that easy*."

Maelis turned her head.

And her eyes were lit.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT MUCH. NOT YET. Not the windows they'd be, nine hundred years later, at the edge of the world. Just a glow. Faint. Gold. Behind the honey-brown. Like a candle behind a curtain.

But lit.

She looked at Hesper with them. With her lovely kind face and her lit eyes. And smiled.

"*Nothing's that easy, Hes*," she said. "*Nothing. You'll learn that when you're older.*" She looked back at the pool. "*Do you know what it feels like?*

When you drink? It feels like—like someone's left a light on for you. In a window. At the end of a long road. Like you've been walking in the cold your whole life and you didn't know it, and suddenly there's a house, and it's warm, and someone's waiting."

Her voice was very soft.

"*I've never felt that before*," said Maelis. "*Not once. Not in twenty-nine years. Not with Father. Not with any of the men they wanted me to marry. Not with any of you.*" She looked down at her own long pale hands. "*I've always been cold, Hes. Always. Inside. Right in the middle. And I never knew why.*"

She cupped her hands.

"*And then I drank*," said Maelis. "*And I wasn't.*"

She bent down. And dipped her cupped hands into the shallow dark. And lifted them. And drank.

And Hesper heard the pool scream.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE VEY BOY TOOK her out of the palace that night.

Over the garden wall. Through the cabbages. Down the long dark road toward the hills, with a lantern, with nothing but the clothes she stood in and a pair of boots she'd stolen from the kitchen.

"*Where are we going*?" she said.

"*To my brother*," said Malachi. "*He's going to do something. Something big. He won't tell me what. He just said, bring her. If she can hear it, bring her.*" He looked at her sideways. In the lantern-light. "*He said you'll need to be somewhere safe. When it happens.*"

"*When what happens*?"

Malachi didn't answer.

She found out three months later. In the winter. On the night the world was woven.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D NEVER FORGET IT.

She stood on a hilltop in the cold, with Malachi beside her and four of his brothers and sisters round them in a ring, and his eldest brother in the

middle. Aurelian. Tall and serious and grey-eyed, in a plain robe, with a little hammer in his hand. And she watched him strike it.

Once. On nothing. On the air. On the world.

Tink.

And the net came down.

Silver. Gold. Fine as cobweb. Out of the sky. Out of the ground. Out of everything. Falling over the whole of the world like a fisherman's cast. Over every hill and every river and every person. Over her. She felt it settle. Light. Cool. Like a veil. Like a hand on her hair.

And she felt it go down. Into the ground. Down and down and down. To a palace of glass three hundred miles away. To a cellar. To a stone ring. To a dark that wasn't dark anymore, that was *empty*, that was a hollow with nothing in it, screaming.

And settle over it.

Like a lid.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE HEARD THE SCREAM stop.

Not end. *Stop*. Muffled. Covered. The way a scream stops when you put your hand over someone's mouth.

And beside her, Malachi made a sound.

She looked at him. At the boy with the laughing face. Standing on the hilltop in the cold with tears running down his cheeks, staring at his eldest brother in the middle of the ring with the hammer in his hand.

"*He's gone into it*," whispered Malachi. "*Hes. He's gone* into *it. He's put himself in the middle. He's going to hold it.*"

She didn't understand. Not then.

She understood later.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN'S SHORE WAS grey.

All of it. The shingle. The water. The sky. A long grey river running north and south across a long grey valley at the edge of the world. And a long grey boat drawn up on the shingle. And a tall grey figure leaning on a pole, with no eyes.

And nine people, in chains.

Not iron. *Net*. Silver and gold. Fine as cobweb and strong as steel. Round their wrists and their ankles. Woven out of the same threads that had come down over the world.

They stood on the shingle in their silks and their crowns. Oszric with his gold leaves, white-faced, furious. Ysenne with her glass, weeping because there was no reflection in the grey water. Caddoc with his iron, silent, arms crossed. Rhosyn with her roses, which were already dying, the petals falling one by one onto the grey stones.

The four cousins. Bronze and bone and copper and coral. Grey. Shaking.

And Maelis.

Silver wire. Fine as frost. Shaped like folded wings.

With her eyes lit.

◆ ◆ ◆

HESPER CAME DOWN THE shingle.

Alone. Malachi had wanted to come. She'd said no. She'd said *this is mine. They're mine*. He'd stood at the top of the shingle in the grey light with his hands clenched and let her go.

She stopped in front of them.

Her brothers. Her sisters. Her cousins. In chains. At the edge of the world.

Oszric looked at her and didn't speak. He'd never speak to her again. Not in nine hundred years. She'd hear, much later, through the grey, through the Veil, through the dreams the Harrow women had at the end of summer, that he still said her name sometimes. In his sleep. In his cocoon. As a curse.

Caddoc looked at her and nodded. Once. As if she'd won a game he hadn't known they were playing.

Rhosyn was crying. She held out her chained hands. And Hesper took them. And held them. And Rhosyn said, *I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I heard you. I should have listened. I'm sorry*, over and over, until the Ferryman said *it is time*, and she had to let go.

And Maelis—

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

She stood on the grey shingle in her chains and her silver-wire crown and looked at her little sister. With her lit eyes. For a long time.

And Hesper looked back.

She'd brushed her hair. When she was small. When the nurses were too busy. She'd sat with her all night with the fever, telling stories about a girl who married a bear.

She'd always been cold. Right in the middle. And never known why.

"*You could come with us*," said Maelis.

Hesper didn't answer.

"*Wherever we're going*," said her sister. "*You could come. He'd let you. The old man.*" She nodded at the Ferryman. "*You're family. You belong with us.*"

"*I didn't drink*."

"*You could*." Maelis's lit eyes were very soft. "*It's not too late. There's a little left. In me. In all of us. I could give you some. From my own hands. Like I gave my household.*" She held out her chained hands. Cupped. "*Then you'd never be cold. Then you'd never be alone.*"

Hesper looked at the cupped hands.

At the long pale fingers. At the glow in them. Faint. Gold. Leaking, a little, between the fingers, like water through a sieve.

"*No*," she said.

Her sister's face didn't change.

"*Not me*," said Hesper. "*Not ever.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN PUT THEM in the boat.

One by one. Oszric first. Then the others. Then Maelis, last, in the bow. Facing back. Toward the shore. Toward the world.

And Hesper stood on the grey shingle and watched.

"*Hes*," said Maelis.

From the boat. As the Ferryman pushed off. As the grey water opened between them. Not loud. Soft. The way she'd said it when Hesper was six, with the fever, in the dark.

"*Leave a light on for me*," said Maelis.

Hesper stood on the shore.

"*Please*," said her sister. "*Somewhere. In a window. So I'll know where you are. So I'll have something to look at, out there, in the grey. So I'll know someone's waiting.*"

The boat was drifting. Out. Into the grey. Into the river. Toward the far shore, where there was nothing. No hills. No sky. Just grey.

"*No*," said Hesper Harrow.

It was the first time she'd ever used the name. She didn't know where it came from. It came up out of her the way the pool's voice used to. *Harrow. To break the ground. Before sowing.*

"*No light*," she said. "*Not for you. Not ever. Not in any window I ever live behind.*" Her voice was shaking. She didn't let it stop her. "*If I leave a light on, you'll come for it. I know you will. You'll come for it the way you came for the pool. And you'll kneel down and cup your hands and you'll drink it dry and you'll still be cold.*"

Maelis's lit eyes looked at her across the widening grey.

"*Then I'll find yours*," said the Moth Queen. Very softly. "*Someday. Somehow. Whatever window you hide behind. Whatever light you light.*"

She smiled.

"*I'm very patient, little sister*," said Maelis. "*You'll see.*"

And the grey took her.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN WOULDN'T TAKE Hesper.

She asked him. When the boat came back. Empty. When he stepped out onto the shingle and leaned on his long grey pole and turned his eyeless face toward her.

"*Take me across*," she said. "*After them. Please. I'll pay.*"

"*No*," said the Ferryman.

"*I'll pay whatever you want.*"

"*It is not the price.*" The eyeless face didn't move. "*You did not drink. You poured back. I felt it, in my water. A cupful. Of the room you were born with.*" He was quiet. "*The grey country is for those who drank. It will not hold you. It will push you back. You would come apart against the edge, the way four of them did, coming through.*"

"*Four—*"

"*Four.*" The Ferryman's voice was very quiet. "*Bronze and bone and copper and coral. They came apart into dust against the edge of the world. Your cousins. Your sisters' husbands.*" He turned his face toward the grey. "*Five went through.*"

Hesper sat down on the shingle.

She didn't remember sitting down. She just was. On the cold grey stones. With her knees up and her arms round them. Like a girl on the edge of a cabbage bed.

"*What do I do*?" she said.

The Ferryman was quiet for a long time.

"*Live*," he said at last. "*In the world. Under the net. Without it reading you. Without it knowing your name.*" His long grey hand moved on his pole. "*And never, ever leave a light on.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

MALACHI FOUND HER ON the shingle at dusk.

He sat down beside her. On the cold grey stones. Not touching her. Just there. The way you sit beside someone at a grave.

He had something in his hand. He held it out.

A crown.

Small. Plain. Silver. With seven points. Rising from the rim at even spaces, like the tines of a fork.

Hers. The one she'd set down on the stone at the edge of the pool, on the last evening, when she cupped her empty hands and poured.

"*I went back for it*," said Malachi. "*To the hall. Before it fell.*"

"*I don't want it*."

"*I know*." He didn't take it back. "*But someone has to keep it. My brother says. The other nine are gone. Out there. In the grey. But this one never drank. This one's the only crown of the Ten that never touched the pool.*" He looked at it. In his brown hands. "*He says that matters. He says it's the only one that can say no.*"

"*Say no to what*?"

"*He didn't tell me*." Malachi's mouth twisted. "*He never tells me anything. He just goes and does things.*" He put the crown down on the shingle between them. "*Keep it. Hide it. Don't wear it. Pass it on.*"

Hesper looked at the crown for a long time.

Then she picked it up. And held it in her lap. Like a bowl.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT ON THE shingle until it was dark.

Neither of them said anything. There was nothing to say. Her brothers and sisters were gone into the grey, and his brother was gone into the net, into the middle of it, holding a starving thing in the dark under a lid. And the world had been woven. And they were seventeen.

When it was fully dark, Malachi reached into his robe and took out something else.

Small. Silver. A bell. The kind you'd hang round a goat's neck. With a clapper inside it that was bent, a little, crooked, so that when it rang it rang very slightly off.

"*It's yours*," he said.

She stared at it.

"*It is*," said Malachi. "*You dropped it. In the garden. The day I came. Off your belt. You didn't notice. I picked it up and I was going to give it back and then—*" He went red. Even in the dark. "*I didn't.*"

She looked at the bell. She remembered it. A little silver bell from her room in the palace. She'd hung it from her belt since she was nine so the nurses would know where she was. She'd dropped it on the stone floor of the kitchen once and bent the clapper.

"*Keep it*," said Hesper.

"*It's yours*."

"*Keep it*." She closed his fingers round it. "*Then I'll know. Wherever I am. If you're sad.*"

He looked at her.

"*How*?" he said.

"*I don't know*," said Hesper Harrow. "*I'm a Listener. You said. Same as you.*" She held his hand closed round the bell. "*I'll listen for it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LEFT THE NEXT morning.

East. Into the world. With a crown in a bundle on her back and the boots she'd stolen from the kitchen and no light.

He watched her go. From the top of the shingle. With a little silver bell in his hand.

She didn't look back. Harrow women never did.

But at the bend in the grey valley, where the river turned and the shingle ended and the world began, she stopped. And stood for a moment. With her back to him.

And somewhere behind her, very faint, very far, carried on the wind off the grey water—

Ting.

Slightly off. A little crooked. Like a bell with a bent clapper.

It would ring for nine hundred years.

She'd hear it, sometimes. All her life. In the evenings. In the cottages. Faint. Far. At the edge of hearing. And she'd stop whatever she was doing. And listen. And know that somewhere, by some fire, in some valley, a man who'd been a boy with bare feet in her cabbage bed was sad.

She never went back.

She never once left a light on.

And she taught her daughter the rule. And her daughter taught hers. All the way down. Twenty-two cottages. Thirty houses. Twenty generations. A crown in a box. A moth carved in a lid and crossed out.

We break the ground. We never take the crown. We never let a moth in.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ON THE FAR side of the world, beyond the grey, in a country with no sun, in a hall of glass and bone and gold, five cocoons hung from the rafters.

Asleep.

And under the fifth, on the floor, a crown of silver wire, shaped like folded wings.

And in the cocoon above it, a woman with lit eyes, dreaming.

Of a window. A light. A long road.

And at the end of it, someone waiting.

PART TWO

THE MOTH AND THE FLAME

CHAPTER 21

The Dimming

HIGHCREST WENT DARK IN a single night.

Lex heard about it from a raven at dawn. Roole's. Grey-black, with the Keepers' ring on its leg. It came down out of a grey sky onto the slope of the Hollowmaw and stood in the snow with its feathers fluffed and its beak open, panting, as if it had flown the whole hundred miles without stopping.

The note on its leg was four words.

Highcrest is lost. Come.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT ON VHARUUN. With Antho, and Kestrel, and the dragon's great blue wings beating so hard the air sang. Ashka stayed at the Keep. Wren stayed with her. And their mother, and their father, and the students, and Pim with a basket of Hush-cups, filling them.

Wren didn't argue.

She'd stood in the cave mouth at dawn with the raven's note in her hand and read it, and gone white, and then gone very still. And looked at him.

"*Mam's in Highcrest*," she said. "*And Tam. And Robbie.*"

"*I know.*"

"*Fennel Street. The narrow house with the green door. Third from the end.*" Her voice was very steady. "*If you see them. If you can. If they're—*" She stopped.

"*I'll find them*," said Lex.

"*Don't promise*."

"*I'm not promising*." He took her face in his hands. "*I'm telling you. I'll find them.*"

She looked at him for a long moment. At the handprint on his cheek. At his crooked nose.

"*Go*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Go on. Before I change my mind and come with you and Old Mag kills me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAW IT FROM forty miles off.

Lex had seen Highcrest from the air a hundred times. On dragons. In all weathers. At dawn, when the golden stone of the walls caught the first light and the whole city glowed like a lamp. At night, when every window had a lantern in it and the city on its hill looked like a heap of embers in a grate.

He'd never seen it like this.

It was noon. Clear. Summer. A blue sky. A high bright sun.

And over Highcrest, a cloud.

Not a rain-cloud. Not smoke. It sat on the city like a lid. Low. Grey-gold. Glittering. Turning slowly, the way a whirlpool turns, round and round, over the walls and the towers and the roofs, so thick the sun couldn't get through it. Under it, the city was in shadow. Grey. Dim. A golden city with the gold drained out of it.

And in the middle of the cloud, at the top of the hill, rising out of the glitter like a finger pointing at the sky—

The Spire.

Lit.

Not with lanterns. Not with fire. Gold. Soft. Warm. Glowing. From every window. From the top floor to the bottom. Like a lamp. Like a beacon. Like two eyes at the end of a long lane on a winter night, multiplied by a thousand.

The only light in Highcrest.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She's in the Spire*," said Antho. Behind him. In the wind. Very quiet.

"*I know*."

"*Father's rooms*." His brother's voice was very flat. "*The top floor. Where the light's brightest.*"

Lex didn't answer.

He was looking down. At the downs west of the city. At the long white road that ran out of the West Gate toward the Blightmarch.

There were people on it.

Hundreds. Thousands. A long dark stream of them. Coming out of the West Gate. Spreading across the downs. Walking. Running. Carts. Horses. Children carried on shoulders. Old people carried on backs.

Running away.

And behind them, coming out of the gate after them, slowly, drifting, low over the road like smoke over water—

The glitter.

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN CAME DOWN ON the road like a thunderbolt.

Lex didn't ask her to. She just did. Out of the sky. Folding her wings. Dropping. A hundred feet in a breath. And landing, in a crash of blue scale and a gust of wind that knocked half the people on the road flat and blew the leading edge of the glitter back fifty yards, between the running crowd and the moths.

And spread her wings.

Across the road. From hedge to hedge. A wall of blue. Crackling with lightning at the edges.

And roared.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GLITTER STOPPED.

Not because of the roar. Not because of the wings. Lex saw it stop. Saw it hang there, over the road, fifty yards off. A great slow turning curtain of grey-gold, from the ground to the sky.

And saw why.

Vharuun was glowing.

Faintly. Blue-white. All along the edges of her wings, where the lightning crackled. Light. Bright. Living. The light of a storm. The light of the sky.

The moths had seen it.

And they were *coming*.

"*Kestrel*!"

She was already off the dragon's neck. Already on the road. With her hair gone dark and the air round her rippling. Black heat. Lex was beside her. Dark. Hot.

And Antho behind them, with the Lantern shuttered and the dark wrapped round him and his face like stone.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS NOT LIKE the deep.

In the deep there had been nothing to protect. Just the three of them, and Seraphine, and the dark. Here there were people. Thousands. Behind them on the road. Screaming. Falling. Crawling. Children. Old women. A man pushing a handcart with a grandmother in it.

And the moths came for the light. And the people *had* light.

Lanterns. Candles. Fire in a pot. A girl with a little tin lamp clutched against her chest. Every one of them carrying something. Because it was Highcrest. Because every house in Highcrest had a lantern in the window. Because when you run from your house in the dark, you take the light with you.

The moths came over Vharuun's wings like water over a weir.

And went for the lamps.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX BURNED THEM.

He walked into them with black heat pouring off him, and they curled and crumpled and fell, the way they had in the deep. Hundreds. Thousands. Kestrel beside him, doing the same, with her Sunreach blade out and her teeth bared. A wedge. A plough.

It wasn't enough.

There were too many. And they weren't coming at him. They were going *past*. Round. Over. To the lamps. To the people. And every time one of them settled on a lantern, the lantern dimmed. And every time one of them settled on a person—

He saw it happen.

A woman. Thirty, maybe. In an apron. Running with a baby in her arms. A moth came down out of the glitter and landed on her cheek. Just for a moment. Lightly. Like a kiss.

And flew off.

And the woman stopped running.

Stood still. In the middle of the road. With the baby in her arms. And turned. Slowly. And looked back. Toward the city. Toward the Spire. Toward the gold light at the top of the hill.

Her eyes were dim.

And she started to walk. Back. Toward it. With the baby still in her arms.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO CAUGHT HER.

He came out of the dark beside her like a shadow coming off a wall, and put his arm round her, and turned her. Gently. Back toward the downs. She didn't fight. She didn't pull. She just kept leaning. Toward the city. The way Odile had leaned in the snow.

"*Lex*!" said his brother. "*I can't hold them all! They're turning back! All of them!*"

Lex looked.

All down the road. Up and down the long stream of people coming out of the West Gate. Here and there. One. Then another. Then ten. Stopping. Standing still. Turning round.

And walking back. Slowly. Into the glitter. Toward the gold light at the top of the hill.

Not running. Not screaming. Not afraid.

Peaceful.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Shut your lamps*!" Lex was shouting. He didn't remember starting. "*Shut your lamps! Put them out! All of them! Now!*"

Some of them heard him. Some of them did it. Blew out their candles. Dropped their lanterns in the ditch. Covered their faces.

Not enough.

He saw the girl with the little tin lamp. Eight. Nine. Clutching it against her chest. In the middle of the road. Frozen. Staring at the glitter coming down on her. Her lamp held tight. As if it was the only thing she had.

It probably was.

He ran.

He got there first. Just. He put himself between the girl and the moths, dark and hot, and they hit the air round him and curled and fell like burnt paper. And he crouched down in front of her. In the road. With the moths dying round them both in a ring.

"*Give me the lamp*," said Lex.

She stared at him.

"*Give it to me. I'll keep it safe. I promise.*"

"*It's for my da*," said the girl. In a whisper. "*He's on the wall. He's a soldier. He didn't come home last night. I lit it for him.*"

Lex looked at the little tin lamp.

At the little flame in it. Small and gold and steady.

A light left on. For someone who hadn't come home.

"*I know*," he said. Very gently. "*I know you did. That's why they want it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK HER AND the lamp both. Picked her up, with the lamp held in her arms against her chest, and wrapped them both in black heat, as close as he could without burning her, and ran.

Back down the road. Away from the gate. Toward Vharuun. Toward the wall of blue scale and lightning.

And over his shoulder, high up, coming out of the glitter over the West Gate—

A shape.

Big. Heavy. Broad-shouldered. With something on its back. Spread. Grey-gold. Ragged. *Wings*.

Not the small dry furled wings of the Mothwing. Big ones. Strong ones. Beating. Carrying a man the size of a bear through the air over the road as easily as a hawk carries a mouse.

A miner's pick in one hand.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILAS HASK CAME DOWN on the road in front of Vharuun.

Lightly. On his toes. Like a moth on a window. His great grey-gold wings folding behind him. His patched leather coat torn open down the back to let them through.

He looked at the dragon.

Then at Lex. With the girl in his arms.

His eyes were gold.

Not dull now. Not the dim coal-spark gold of the Mothwing. Brighter. Warmer. Lit. Like two candles behind a curtain.

"*Smith*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

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SILAS HASK
Class: DELVEBREAKER (Epic)
  → MOTHBORN CHAMPION (?)
Level 86
"Not wholly of this net any longer.
 The net is not sure what he is. It
 suspects he isn't either."
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◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT THE GIRL down.

Behind him. Behind Vharuun's foreleg. With her lamp. And said *stay there*, and *don't move*, and *close your eyes*, and turned round.

Hask hadn't moved.

He was standing in the road. With his pick on his shoulder. And his wings folded. And the glitter coming down round him like snow. Settling on his shoulders. On his hair. Not touching him. Moving round him. The way the moths had moved round Maelis in the deep. Like a cloak. Like a court.

He wasn't coughing.

He was breathing. Deep and slow and easy. All the way down.

"*She made you her Champion*," said Lex.

"*She asked*." Hask's voice was the same. Rough. Calm. Reasonable. "*Last night. When she came back. Lit up like a lighthouse.*" He looked down

at his own hands. Big. Scarred. Faintly glowing at the knuckles. *"She said she needed someone who could stand in front of her. Someone strong. Someone who'd been capped his whole life and knew what it was worth to be free."*

"And you said yes."

"I said what's the pay." Hask's mouth twitched. *"She gave me a sip. Another one. Bigger. Out of what she brought up from the deep."* He breathed in. Out. *"And I said yes."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"That was the little one," said Lex.

Hask looked at him.

"What she brought up," said Lex. *"What she gave you. That's a piece of it. She knelt down in the deep and put her hands in it and drank. And it screamed. My brother heard it. Everyone at the bottom of the world heard it."* He didn't look away from Hask's gold eyes. *"You're breathing with it. That's what's in your lungs. That's what's holding up your wings."*

Hask didn't say anything.

"You felt it," said Lex. *"At Thistledown. When you broke the core. You said it was like a seam settling. A groan in the rock."* He took a step forward. *"You know what it is. You've known since the first one."*

"I know," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROAD WAS VERY quiet.

Behind Lex, people were still running. Still falling. Still turning back. Kestrel was burning moths. Antho was holding a woman with a baby who kept trying to walk toward the city. Vharuun was standing with her wings spread and her lightning crackling and her great golden eye fixed on the winged man in the road.

And Hask stood with his pick on his shoulder and looked at Lex.

"I know what it is," he said again. Quietly. *"I'm not stupid, smith. I'm a hewer. I know what's alive and what's rock. I've known since Thistledown."* He looked down at his glowing hands. *"It's alive. It hurts it. Every time."*

"Then why—"

"Because I can breathe."

He said it simply. Without anger. Without pleading. The way a man says the weight of a pick he's carried for twenty-six years.

"*Because my da died coughing grey in my arms*," said Silas Hask. "*And my mam. And my sister. And I was going to be next. And now I'm not.*" He looked up. "*Because I was a Common hewer capped at twenty-four for twenty-six years, and now I'm level eighty-six and I can fly.*"

He shifted the pick on his shoulder.

"*Because you gave me that*," he said. "*You. At the Stone in Coldwater. In the rain. You took off my Ceiling and you said, go. As high as you can.*" His gold eyes didn't waver. "*So I'm going.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Not like this*," said Lex.

"*How, then*?" Hask's voice didn't rise. "*Tell me how, smith. Tell me how a coughing hewer from Coldwater gets to eighty-six without breaking anything. Without hurting anything.*" He spread his free hand. "*You went down to the bottom of the world and reforged the net and broke a Ceiling for every soul in Aldermere. Who'd you hurt doing that?*"

Lex didn't answer.

"*The nobles*," said Hask. "*The Order. The ones who sold Sanctions. Every one of them lost everything the day you did that. Their land. Their seats. Their sons' futures.*" He shrugged. "*You hurt them. You didn't care. Because it was right.*"

"*That's not the same—*"

"*It's always the same*," said Silas Hask. "*Somebody's always getting hurt so somebody else can rise. That's what rising* is.*"*

He looked past Lex. At the road. At the people. At the woman with the baby in Antho's arms, still leaning toward the city.

"*She's not killing them*," he said. "*You know that? She's not. She could. She's not.*" He looked back at Lex. "*She's taking the light. That's all. The warm bit. And they don't mind. They walk back to her and stand outside her house and they're* happy.*"* He paused. "*Happier than they've been in years, some of them. No fear. No grief. No worrying about the rent. Just—quiet.*"

"*That's not happy*."

"*No*," Hask agreed. "*It's not. But it's not hurting either.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"Silas."

The voice came from behind Hask. From the gate. Soft. Low. A little hoarse.

Lex looked up.

And didn't look away fast enough.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS STANDING ON the West Gate.

On top of it. On the battlements. In the shadow of the glitter. Tall. Grey-gold. With her silver hair loose to her knees and her wings folded down her back like a cloak. Glowing. All through. Not just her eyes. Her skin. Her hair. Her hands. The way she'd glowed in the deep, after she drank.

She was smiling.

Lex had looked into her eyes once. In the Hall of Lanterns. When she leaned down and said *Harrow was my sister's*. He'd felt it then. The pull. The *there, someone's home*.

He felt it now. A hundred times worse.

It was like standing at the bottom of a hill on a winter night, in the cold, in the dark, with nothing in your belly and nowhere to go, and looking up, and seeing at the top of the hill a house. With every window lit. And the door open. And someone standing in it. Waiting.

For you.

His foot moved.

◆ ◆ ◆

[LEX.]

Ember. Loud. Louder than he'd ever heard it. A clang in his hearth like a hammer on an anvil.

[LEX. LOOK AT HER HANDS.]

He looked at her hands.

Long. Pale. Glowing. Hanging at her sides. And at the ends of the fingers, very faint, so faint he'd never have seen it if he hadn't been looking

for it, if he hadn't stood in front of her in the deep with Aurelian's little hammer and heard the *tink* go straight through—

Flickering.

The glow. At the fingertips. Going dim. Coming back. Going dim.

Leaking.

He breathed out. And his foot stopped. And he looked at her hands, at the leak, at the flaw, and not at her eyes, and the warm lit house at the top of the hill went away.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*," said Maelis. From the gate. Fondly. "*You found your way home. And look. You brought your mother.*"

"*She's not here*."

"*No. But she's home.*" The Moth Queen tilted her head. "*I felt her come through the door. The Warden's door. I felt the little one let her go.*" She smiled. "*I felt your father say good evening.*"

Lex said nothing.

"*Wasn't that lovely*," said Maelis softly. "*After all those years. She came through the door, and he said good evening, and she said you have a nice voice.*" Her lit eyes were very warm. "*My moths told me. They were there. In the passage. Under the lanterns. They're always there.*"

Lex's hands were burning. Black heat. Pouring off him.

"*I've taken the city*," said Maelis. Conversationally. "*Did you notice? It wasn't hard. Everyone in it had a light in the window. For someone. For the Lady. For the lost.*" She shook her head. "*Every single window. Do you know how* easy *that is?*"

"*Give them back*."

"*I will*." The Moth Queen smiled. "*Of course I will. I don't want them. Not really. They're very small lights. They don't last.*" She looked at her own flickering fingers. "*Nothing lasts.*"

She looked back at him.

"*Bring me the blood*," said Maelis of the Crowned. "*All of it. Every drop of Harrow in the world. Your mother. Your brother. You.*" A pause. "*And anything of yours.*"

Lex went cold.

"*And when the little one comes up*," said Maelis, "*under the sky, at the end of the year, when every window in your country has a lantern in it for Lantern Night—*" She smiled. "*Bring me that too.*"

"*And then*?"

"*And then I'll give them all back*," said the Moth Queen. "*Every light in Highcrest. Every Keeper at Greyfall. Every shepherd in the Greyspine. Every one.*" Her lit eyes were very soft. "*And I'll go. Back through the Veil. With my brothers and sisters. And you'll never see me again.*"

"*Liar*," said Lex.

She laughed.

"*I've never lied to you*," said Maelis. "*Not once. Ask your little coal. It's been checking.*"

[She hasn't,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[That's the worst part. She hasn't.]*

"*I'll go back through the Veil*," said Maelis. "*Exactly as I said. With my brothers and sisters.*" Her smile widened. "*All four of them. Awake. Through a door your mother's blood will open. Into the grey country. Where we'll drink what we've brought, and be full, and never come back.*"

She tilted her head.

"*Not this year*," she said. "*Not next year.*" A pause. "*Perhaps not for a hundred years. Perhaps not for nine hundred.*"

She spread her long glowing hands.

"*You'll be long dead, smith*," said Maelis. Gently. "*What do you care?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN SHE WAS gone.

Not flying. Not walking. Gone. Like a light going out. One moment on the gate, glowing, smiling, with her wings folded. The next, nothing. Just the battlements, grey, in the shadow of the glitter.

And Hask.

He'd turned. Away from Lex. Toward the gate. Toward where she'd been. With his wings half open. His gold eyes on the empty battlements.

Then he looked back at Lex.

For a long moment.

"*She doesn't lie*," said Silas Hask. Quietly. "*I'll give her that. She's the only one who never has.*"

He spread his wings.

"*Think about it, smith*," he said. "*A hundred years. Two hundred. Nine hundred. You'll be dead. Your brother. Your wife. Your kid.*" He looked at Lex. "*What do you care?*"

And he went up. Into the glitter. Into the shadow over Highcrest. Toward the gold light at the top of the hill.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY GOT THE QUEEN out at dusk.

Not through the West Gate. Through the old sally port on the north side, under the castle, a tunnel that Lysandra's great-great-grandfather had cut through the rock in the wars with the Saltreach and that nobody had used for a hundred years. Elowen knew about it. Elowen knew about everything.

They came out of it into a ditch at the bottom of the north wall. Thirty of them. The Queen in a plain cloak with the hood up and her silver circlet in her pocket. Elowen with Oathkeeper drawn and her armor black with dust. Roole, grey-faced, with his arm in a sling. Fenn, carrying a girl of six who wouldn't stop crying. Duke Harlowe's daughter, the young one, who'd refused to leave her father until Elowen picked her up and carried her. A dozen Keepers. A dozen guards.

Lex was waiting in the ditch with Vharuun.

Lysandra came up out of the tunnel and stood in the ditch in the dusk with her hood up and looked at him.

She didn't say anything.

She didn't need to.

He'd seen faces like that. At Fort Caldris, after Elric. At Duskhold. At the Rift. The face of someone who's lost a thing they'd sworn to keep. Who is standing in a ditch, alive, because someone else stood in front of something for them.

"*How many*?" said Lex.

The Queen of Caldor looked at him with her sharp dark eyes. Red-rimmed. Dry.

"*Most of them*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD HIM ON Vharuun's neck. In the dark. Flying north. With the glitter over Highcrest falling behind them and the stars coming out.

The moths had come at dusk. The night before. The night of the World Notice. Out of the west. Over the walls. So many they put out the sunset.

They came for the lanterns, said Lysandra. *That's all, at first. Every window in the city. They went from lantern to lantern and the lanterns went dim and we thought, well. Lanterns. We can live without lanterns.*

And then she came out of the house on the Crown Terrace.

She didn't break the door. She didn't fight the Keepers on it. She walked out. Glowing. And the four Keepers on the door looked at her. And she touched them. On the cheek. One by one. Like a mother.

And they turned round and followed her.

She walked through the city, said the Queen. Slowly. All night. Down the Crown Terrace. Through the Upper Town. Through the market. Through the Lower Town. Touching people. Everyone she passed. A hand on a cheek. A hand on a shoulder.

And they followed her.

By midnight there were a thousand behind her. By dawn, ten thousand.

She walked them all up to the Spire. And went in. And they stood outside. In the square. In the streets. On the steps. Looking up at it. Swaying a little. Like grass.

And she lit it.

"*Lit it*?"

"*From inside*." Lysandra's voice was very quiet. "*Every window. Gold. Like her eyes.*" She was quiet for a moment. "*She's in Arion's rooms. At the top. I saw the light come on. In his window. Where I used to sit on the floor when I was nine.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hollis Penn*," said Elowen.

She was sitting behind the Queen. With Oathkeeper across her knees and her face like stone.

"*The baker*," she said. "*From the Lower Town. The one with the loaf-shaped lantern. The one who made the bread for the wedding.*"

Lex remembered. Hollis Penn. Unwritten by Elric's Key, two years ago, in the square at Highcrest. Hollow-born. Restored at the Highcrest singing. Woken holding a loaf. *Nobody's getting married at the Lantern Keep without a proper loaf.*

"*I saw him*," said Elowen. "*On the steps of the Spire. At dawn. When we went for the sally port.*" She looked down at her sword. "*He was standing in the front row. With his apron on. And flour on his hands. Swaying.*"

She was quiet.

"*He was holding his lantern*," said Elowen Dunmore. "*The loaf-shaped one. From his window. Dark. With dust all over it.*" Her voice cracked. "*He was holding it up. Toward her window. Like he was offering it to her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN AT the Ashbourne Forge at midnight.

Brannoc was waiting in the forge yard. With Hedda. And Tilda. And forty students with torches. They'd seen the dragon coming from ten miles off.

The Queen of Caldor slid down off Vharuun's neck into the forge yard at Ashbourne. In her plain cloak. With her hood up. With dust on her face and her circlet in her pocket and thirty people behind her who were all that was left of her court.

And Brannoc Holt, sixty-three, bald, soot-bearded, enormous, who had capped himself at twenty-four for nineteen years and hummed hymns off-key and cried at weddings, looked at her.

And went down on one knee. In the cinders. In front of the warm spring that had come up out of the forge yard at the end of winter.

"*Majesty*," he said. "*You're welcome here. Long as you like.*"

Lysandra looked down at him.

And then she did something Lex had never seen a queen do. She knelt too. In the cinders. In front of him. And took his enormous scarred hands in hers.

"*Thank you*," said the Queen of Caldor. "*Thank you, Master Holt.*"

And put her head down on his hands. And cried.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOOD IN THE forge yard and looked south.

Toward Highcrest. A hundred miles off. Beyond the edge of seeing.

He couldn't see it. He knew he couldn't. It was too far. There were hills in the way. The Vale. The downs.

But he looked anyway.

And thought he saw it. Very faint. Very far. At the very edge of the dark, where the sky met the hills.

A light.

Small. Gold. Warm.

Not a lantern. Not a fire. Not a star.

A window. At the top of a tower. In a dark city full of people standing in the streets, swaying like grass, holding up their dark lanterns toward it. In a room on the top floor of the Spire, with long windows looking north, and shelves of grey books, and a narrow bed, and a tall bookcase that swung open onto a little round room full of portraits.

His father's room.

Leave a light on, the Harrow women never said. *Never. Not once. Not in nine hundred years.*

And someone, in his father's room, at the top of the tallest tower in Caldor, had left one on.

For him.

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[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly.

I see it.

[She's reading them.] *The coal in his hearth was very still.* [*His books. The grey ones. On the shelves. Two hundred years of them.*]

I know.

[Everything he ever wrote down.] *A long pause.* [*Every Kindling. Every Ceiling. Every name.*] *Another pause.* [*The day each of you was born. The hour. Where.*]

Lex didn't say anything.

[She's learning us,] said Ember. *[Lex. She's sitting in his chair by his window reading his books, and she's learning everything about us he ever knew.]*

Lex stood in the forge yard at Ashbourne with the Queen of Caldor weeping on Brannoc's hands behind him, and the warm spring steaming in the cinders at his feet, and looked south at a light he couldn't see.

And for the first time since he was eleven years old, standing in the ashes of a cottage at Harrow with his mother gone and his brother gone and the whole world on fire—

He was afraid of the dark.

Not the dark.

The light *in* it.

CHAPTER 22

A Stranger with a Nice Voice

THE FIRST THING SEREN Vey did, when she woke up in the world, was cry at a window.

Not a sad cry. She'd had thirteen years of sad cries. She knew the difference. This one came up out of her before she was properly awake, while she was still lying in the narrow bed in the little stone room off the library that Antho had given her, with the blanket up to her chin and her feet, for the first time in thirteen years, not hurting.

There was a window. High in the wall. Small. Cut through the rock of the mountain. And through it, the sky.

Blue.

Not Shade's dark. Not stars. Not the soft deep black of the little one, folded round her like a hand. *Blue*. Pale. Early. With one long thin cloud across it, pink at the edges, like a scarf someone had dropped.

She lay in the bed and looked at it and cried until the pillow was wet. And then got up, and put on a dress that Seraphine had found for her, too long in the hem, and went to find out what the world smelled like.

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IT SMELLED LIKE PORRIDGE.

And smoke. And stone. And bat. And a goat, somewhere, very close, which turned out to be in the kitchen, eating a dishcloth.

"*That's Correspondence*," said a small voice.

She looked down.

A boy was sitting on the kitchen step. Thin. Solemn. In a blue coat with brass buttons, buttoned wrong. With a mop of black hair that refused to lie flat and grey-violet eyes that looked at her steadily, the way very few people ever looked at anything.

She knew him. She'd heard him. Through the door. For three years. The quiet one. The one with the room inside.

"*Pim*," she said.

He nodded.

"*Is it always in the kitchen*?"

"*Yes*," said Pim. "*It's Master Malachi's. It walked here from the Wastes with a box on its back.*" He considered the goat. "*It eats everything. It ate one of Master Antho's books. Volume six. He said it was an improvement.*"

Seren laughed. Out loud. In a kitchen. In the morning.

She hadn't done that in thirteen years either.

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SHE MADE THE PORRIDGE.

They let her. Odile had been going to. Odile had come in, tall and dark and solemn, a Shade-Listener, nineteen, and seen Seren standing at the stove with the pot, and stopped in the doorway with her mouth open. And then closed it. And gone out again. And Seren heard her in the passage, saying to someone in a very low voice, *she's making the porridge. Lady's light. Master Antho's mother is making the porridge.*

It was the first thing she'd cooked in thirteen years.

She burned it.

Not badly. Just at the bottom. She'd forgotten how. Forgotten that you had to stir it. Forgotten that porridge didn't just sit there, the way things sat in the deep, patient, unchanging. She stood at the stove with the wooden spoon in her hand and the smell of burnt oats coming up and laughed until she had to hold on to the shelf.

And Arion said, from the doorway, "*You always burned the porridge.*"

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SHE TURNED ROUND.

He was in the doorway. Sitting. In a chair with wheels on it, that someone, Brannoc probably, had made out of a kitchen chair and two cart

wheels. Wrapped in a blanket. With his white head and his walnut face and his grey eyes behind his spectacles.

Looking at her.

She didn't know what to do.

She'd been home three days. She'd seen him every day. Sat with him. Read his letter. Kissed him, once, in a cavern at the bottom of a mountain, in front of everyone, without meaning to, because she'd heard his voice and it was the voice, it was *the voice*, and her body had done it before her head could stop it.

She didn't know him.

That was the truth. That was what she lay awake with. She knew his voice. She knew his letter. Forty pages of it. She knew he took salt in his porridge, because Ember had told her.

She didn't know *him*. What he did with his hands when he was nervous. What he looked like when he was angry. Whether he snored. Whether he'd laugh if she burned the porridge, or frown, or pretend not to notice.

"*Did I*?" she said.

"*Every morning*," said Arion. "*For eight years. At the cottage. You'd put it on and then you'd see something out of the window, a bird or a cloud or the boys doing something they shouldn't, and you'd go and look at it, and come back, and it'd be black at the bottom.*"

"*And what did you do*?"

He smiled. Slowly. The lines round his eyes going deep.

"*I ate it*," said Arion Vey. "*Every morning. Burnt bits and all. I told you it was how I liked it.*"

"*Was it*?"

"*No*," he said. "*It was terrible.*"

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SHE BROUGHT HIM A bowl.

Burnt bits and all. She put salt on it without asking. He looked at the salt. Then at her.

"*Ember told me*," she said.

"*Ah*."

"*He tells me things.*" She sat down on the bench beside his wheeled chair. With her own bowl. "*When Lex lets him. Little things. That you take salt. That you hum when you're reading. That you tap two fingers on the table when you're thinking.*" She looked at his hand on the arm of the chair. Thin. Brown-spotted. Two fingers. Tapping. Very lightly. "*Like that.*"

He looked down at his hand. It stopped.

"*I didn't know I did that*," he said.

"*Ember knew*."

"*Ember's a piece of me from twenty years ago*." His mouth twisted. "*He knows things about me I've forgotten. It's very strange. Like having a younger brother who's read your diary.*"

Seren laughed.

He looked at her. When she laughed. She saw him do it. Saw his face change. Go very still. The way a man's face goes when he hears a song he hasn't heard in a long time.

"*What*?" she said.

"*Nothing*." He looked down at his porridge. "*You laugh the same. That's all. Exactly the same.*" He picked up his spoon. With both shaking hands. "*I'd forgotten. Isn't that strange. I remembered everything else. I'd forgotten how you laugh.*"

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THEY ATE THE PORRIDGE.

It was terrible. He ate all of it. Burnt bits and all.

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THE DAYS WENT LIKE that.

Small. Slow. Strange. She'd been in the dark so long she'd forgotten what days were. That they had shapes. Mornings and middles and evenings. That things happened in them. Not big things. Small ones. A goat ate a dishcloth. A boy buttoned his coat wrong. An old man ate burnt porridge and said it was terrible.

She sat with him.

Every day. In the mornings, in the kitchen. In the afternoons, at the cave mouth, in the sun, him in his wheeled chair and her on Pim's rock,

with the whole of the Greyspine spread out below them, green now, summer, and the sky going on forever.

And he told her about them.

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NOT ALL AT ONCE. He didn't push. He'd learned that, he said, from Antho. Who had told Lex about the five-skip stone every day for a year, a little at a time, after the Ferryman took it. *You don't pour it all in at once*, Antho had said. *It just runs out the other side. You give them a bit. And let them hold it. And come back tomorrow.*

So he gave her a bit.

The steps of the Spire. The rain. The lanterns. What she'd said. What he'd said back. That was the first day.

The second day, the cup of something hot she'd made him buy her, at a stall in the market, which had turned out to be mulled cider, which he'd never drunk before in two hundred years, which had made him so dizzy he'd walked into a pillar.

The third day, the walk. Down out of Highcrest, three weeks later, on foot, with her, to the Vale. To meet her mother. Who had stood in the door of a cottage at the far end of the Vale, at a place that wasn't a village, that was a fold in the hills where the road gave out, and looked at him. A Warden. A Warden-Architect of the Spire. In his grey coat.

Who's this? Wenna Harrow had said.

This is Arion, Seren had said. *He's going to stay for supper.*

And Wenna had looked at him for a very long time. With her hedge-witch eyes. And then stood aside. And let him in.

She never said a word to me, said Arion. *Not that night. Not for a month. She just watched me. Every time I came. She'd sit by the fire with her mending and watch me.* He smiled. *And then one night, in the winter, I came up the path and there was a lantern in the window.*

Seren went very still.

She'd never had one, said Arion. *Not once. In all the time I'd been coming. You'd told me. Harrow women don't leave lights on.* He looked at the mountains. *And then one night there was one. In the window. Small. Clay. For me.*

She'd made it, said Arion Vey. *Herself. Out of clay from the stream. With her thumbprint in the bottom.*

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SEREN DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

She was sitting on Pim's rock with her knees pulled up. Looking at the mountains. She'd brought the lamp out with her. She always did. It was in her lap. Small. Brown. Clay. With a chip in the spout.

She turned it over.

The thumbprint in the base.

She'd always thought it was hers. She'd thought she'd made the lamp. At the kitchen table at Harrow, the summer Lex was born. She remembered it. Clay from the stream. Her hands. The wheel.

She held her thumb up to the print.

It was smaller. Narrower. An older hand.

"*She made it*," said Seren. Very quietly. "*Mam. Not me. I made a copy. Later. When she was gone. I made a copy and I broke it, the first time I fired it, and I cried, and I never made another.*" She stared at the lamp. "*I forgot. I forgot that I forgot.*"

Arion didn't say anything.

"*She left a light on*," said Seren. "*For you. She broke the rule. Nine hundred years. And she broke it for you.*"

She looked at him.

"*Why*?"

The old man in the wheeled chair looked back at her. With his grey eyes. Very steady.

"*She said*," said Arion slowly, "*the first night. When I came up the path and saw it. I stopped. On the step. And looked at it. And she was standing in the door behind it. And she said—*"

He stopped.

"*She said, I've been running from the dark for forty years, Warden. Waiting for something to come for us. And it hasn't. And now something's come for my girl instead, and it's you, and you're not the dark.*" He swallowed. "*And then she said, don't make me sorry.*"

Seren put her face in her hands.

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BRANNOC CAME ON THE fourth day.

She heard him before she saw him. Everyone did. He came up the mountain on a cart, with Hedda Vorne beside him on the seat, and the cart was full of iron and the horse was full of opinions, and Brannoc was singing.

A hymn. *Lantern-bearer, light the way*. Off-key. Very loud.

She knew that voice.

She'd known it twenty years ago. In the Ashbourne forge. When she brought the boys in to watch the sparks. When Lex was two, and sat on the woodpile with his thumb in his mouth, and Antho was seven, and kept asking questions about the bellows. A big bald man with a soot-black beard, singing hymns off-key at the anvil, who'd given Lex a horseshoe nail to hold and said *there you go, lad, that's your first bit of iron*.

The man who'd taken her son in.

When the cottage burned. When she was gone into the dark and Antho was gone into the mountains and Lex was eleven, standing in the ashes. The man who'd come and found him. And taken him home. And given him the bellows to work, because the work would help.

She'd heard about it through the door. For eight years. Antho had told her. And then for three more years Lex had. Every story. Brannoc's hammer. Brannoc's eggs, cooked on the anvil. Brannoc's knees. Brannoc teaching him to draw a nail. Brannoc at the Hollowmaw with Hedda's barricade. Brannoc crying at weddings.

She'd never seen him since.

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HE STOPPED THE CART at the bottom of the slope.

And stopped singing.

And sat on the cart seat with the reins in his enormous hands and looked up the slope at the small woman standing at the mouth of the cave. For a long time.

He was old. That was the first thing. Not old like Arion. Not *that*. But old. Sixty-three. Bald and brown-spotted and stooped at the shoulders. His

soot-black beard gone grey. His knees, when he climbed down off the cart, creaking so loud she could hear them from the top of the slope.

He came up the slope.

Slowly. One step at a time. With Hedda behind him.

He stopped in front of her.

Seren looked up at him. He was so *big*. She'd forgotten. He'd been big at forty. He was bigger now. Or she was smaller. A great grey stooped bear of a man with a smith's forearms and burn-scarred hands and his eyes very wet.

"*Seren*," said Brannoc Holt.

"*Brannoc*."

"*I kept him*," said Brannoc. His voice was very rough. "*Your boy. Lex. I kept him. Like you'd have wanted. I didn't—I never knew what you'd have wanted. I just did what I could.*" He swallowed. "*I taught him to draw a nail. I taught him the forge. I taught him—*"

"*I know*," said Seren.

He stopped.

"*I heard*," she said. "*Through the door. Every story. For eleven years.*" Her voice cracked. "*The eggs on the anvil. The hymns. The night he couldn't stop shaking and you gave him the bellows.*"

The big man's face crumpled.

"*Thank you*," said Seren Vey. "*Brannoc. Thank you for keeping my boy.*"

And Brannoc Holt, sixty-three, the smith of Ashbourne, who had sat at Level 24 for nineteen years and never once complained, put his enormous arms round her and lifted her clean off the ground. And held her. And cried into her hair. Very loudly. While Hedda stood behind him with her arms crossed, saying *oh, for pity's sake*, and wiping her own eyes on her sleeve.

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HE PUT HER DOWN eventually.

And looked at her. Up and down. With his wet eyes.

"*You look old*," said Brannoc.

"*I look old*?" Seren stared at him. "*Brannoc. Look at you. You're a hundred.*"

"*I'm sixty-three*."

"*You look a hundred*."

"*Have you seen your husband*?" said Brannoc Holt.

There was a pause.

And then Seren laughed. Out loud. Helplessly. On the slope of the Hollowmaw, in the summer sun, with tears running down her face. And Brannoc laughed too. Great booming gusts of it, that echoed off the rocks. And Arion, in his wheeled chair at the mouth of the cave, where Pim had pushed him to watch, laughed so hard he started coughing and Odile had to come and thump him on the back.

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LEX CAME HOME THAT night.

From Highcrest. On Vharuun. With the Queen of Caldor and thirty people behind him and a face like the end of the world.

He told them in the kitchen.

All of it. The glitter over the city. The people turning back. The girl with the little tin lamp. Silas Hask with wings. The Moth Queen on the gate. *Bring me the blood. All of it. Every drop of Harrow. And anything of yours.*

The Spire. Lit. From every window. And Arion's room at the top, brightest of all.

Seren listened.

She sat at the long table with her hands round a cup of tea and didn't say anything until he'd finished. She watched her son tell it. Her big son, with his father's height and her face and a moth's handprint glittering on his cheek. Telling it badly. With his hands. The way he told everything.

When he'd finished, nobody said anything.

Then Arion, in his wheeled chair at the end of the table, said very quietly: "*She's reading my books.*"

Everyone looked at him.

"*The grey ones*," said Arion. "*On the shelves. And the ones in the little room behind the bookcase. Two hundred years of them.*" He looked at his hands. "*Every Kindling. Every Ceiling. Every name.*" A pause. "*Every child born to a Vey since I took the Root. When. Where. Who the mother was.*"

"*Why does that matter*?" said Wren.

"*Because she's hunting the blood*," said Seren.

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SHE HADN'T MEANT TO say it.

It came out of her. The way the pool's voice used to come out of Hesper, nine hundred years ago, in a dry garden. The way the rule came out of her mother, at the end of every summer, in twenty-two cottages.

Everyone was looking at her now.

She put down her tea.

"*I should tell you*," said Seren Vey. "*All of it. What I know. What Mam told me. What her mam told her.*" She looked round the table. At her sons. At their wives. At Kestrel and Seraphine and Brannoc and Hedda and the Queen of Caldor, who was sitting very straight at the far end with her hood down and her eyes red. "*I should have told you before. At the Heart. Through the door. I didn't think—I didn't think it mattered anymore. I thought they were asleep. I thought they'd gone.*"

She looked at Arion.

"*I never told you*," she said. "*Did I. Not once. Not in eight years.*"

"*No*," said her husband. Very gently. "*You never told me anything about your family. Not once. I asked. You'd change the subject. You'd go and look at a bird out of the window and burn the porridge.*"

"*Mam said not to*." She looked at her hands. "*Especially not you. Especially not if I loved you.*"

"*Why*?"

"*Because you were a Warden*," said Seren. "*Because you had the Root. Because if you knew, you'd write it down.*" She looked at him. "*And then it'd be in a book. On a shelf. In a room at the top of a tower.*"

The kitchen was very quiet.

"*And someday*," said Seren Vey, "*someone would come and read it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD THEM.

All of it. Hesper and the pool. The Nine. The cupped hands. The tenth sister in the doorway with a crown in her hands, who said no and poured back. Antho had seen it. Through the little one. He'd told her. She'd

known already. Her mother had told her. And hers. And hers. All the way back.

The Ferryman's shore. The chains. The boat. *Leave a light on for me, little sister. No.*

The Harrow women. Twenty-two cottages. Thirty houses. Twenty generations. Never Kindling. Never staying. Never leaving a light on. The moth carved in the lid and crossed out.

The crown.

"*Mam took it*," said Seren. "*Before she died. I was nineteen. I was in Highcrest, selling bread. I came home and she was sick and the box was empty.*" She shook her head. "*She wouldn't tell me where. She said it was where it belonged. She said, you'll know, if you ever need to.*" She was quiet. "*I never needed to. I never knew.*"

"*Why does she want the blood*?" said Lex.

Seren looked at him.

"*Because we never drank*," she said.

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SHE'D HAVE TO EXPLAIN it badly. She always explained things badly. She was a hedge-witch, not a scholar. She knew things the way her hands knew bread. Not the way Seraphine knew them, in lines and footnotes.

She did her best.

"*The Veil learned them*," she said. "*The Nine. When it was woven. When Aurelian tied off the edge of the world. It learned what they were. What they tasted like. Everyone who drank from the pool.*" She made a shape with her hands. A ring. "*And it pushes them back. Every time. Like a door that knows your face and won't open.*"

"*But it let Maelis through*," said Kestrel.

"*Because Lex loosened the knot*." Seren looked at her son. "*When you reforged the net. You tied it again kinder. You left a little give. She said so. Just enough for a moth. If she's patient.*" She looked at her hands. "*Not enough for the others. Not enough for a king with a gold crown. Not enough for four of them.*"

"*And the blood*?"

"*The blood never drank.*" Seren held up her own hand. Square. Strong. "*Hesper didn't. Not a drop. She poured back instead. The Veil never learned her. Never learned any of us.*" She turned her hand over. "*So it doesn't push us. It doesn't know us. A Harrow can walk up to the edge of the world and put her hand on the Veil and it'll open like a curtain. Like a door that's never seen your face before and has no reason to keep you out.*"

The kitchen was very still.

"*Mam told me*," said Seren. "*When I was small. She said, if you ever have to run, really run, from something with lit eyes, go west. Go to the edge. Put your hand on the grey and walk through. They can't follow you there. Not ever. Because they can't come back.*" She swallowed. "*She said it was the last door. The one only we have the key to.*"

"*And if Maelis gets the blood*," said Seraphine slowly.

"*If she gets the blood*," said Seren, "*and puts it on the Veil, from this side—*" She stopped. "*It opens. Not just for us. For anyone. For anything on the other side of it. The way a door opens for anyone once someone's turned the key.*"

She looked round the table.

"*Four more of them*," said Seren Vey. "*Asleep. In the grey. Waiting. My sister's sister's brothers and sisters. The Gilded King, who drank first and drank most. The Glass Queen. The Iron Crown. The Thorn.*" Her voice was very quiet. "*She needs our blood to open the Veil for them. All four.*"

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NOBODY SAID ANYTHING FOR a long time.

Then Wren spoke. From beside Lex. Very quietly. With her hand flat on her stomach, under the table, where only Seren could see it.

"*And the baby*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Why does she want the baby?*"

Seren looked at her.

At her daughter-in-law. The tracker. The one with the wind. Who'd stood on a tower at the edge of the world and been looked at by the Moth Queen, and had felt, for the first time, a heart beating under her hand.

She'd known Wren would ask. She'd been waiting for it for four days.

"*Because it's never been anyone's*," said Seren.

Wren didn't move.

"*Every light in the world*," said Seren, "*is someone's. A lantern in a window is for someone. A candle is for someone. Your fire, Lex, is for everyone you love. Antho's lantern is for the lost. Even the lights inside people. The warm bits. The bit she took from Odile. From Kell. They're all* for *something. Someone. They've all been given, a little.*"

She looked at Wren's hand. Under the table.

"*A new light*," she said. "*One that's never been born. Never been given. Never been anyone's but its own.*" Her voice was very soft. "*She thinks that's the only light that would fill her. A light so new it's never been poured into anything. She thinks if she drank that, it wouldn't leak.*"

"*Would it*?" whispered Wren.

Seren looked at her daughter-in-law for a long time.

"*I don't know*," she said honestly. "*Nobody's ever let her try.*"

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SHE SAT WITH ARION that night. By the kitchen window. The small high one that looked east.

It was late. Everyone else was asleep. Or pretending. The fire was down to embers. The goat was asleep under the table with a sock. The lamp, the clay one, Wenna's, was on the windowsill. Lit.

She'd put it there. She hadn't asked anyone. She'd just picked it up, after the others had gone to bed, and carried it to the window, and set it on the sill. Facing out. Facing the dark. Facing east, toward the Vale, toward Harrow.

A light in the window.

Arion had watched her do it. From his wheeled chair. Not saying anything.

"*Mam would kill me*," said Seren. Looking at it.

"*Your mam broke the rule too*."

"*For you*." She sat down on the bench under the window. Beside his chair. "*She broke it for you. Because you weren't the dark.*" She looked at the little flame. "*I'm breaking it for—*"

She stopped.

"*For who*?" said Arion. Very gently.

She didn't answer for a long time.

"*For the little one*," she said at last. "*For Kell. Sitting with it in the dark. Telling it the one about the miller's cat.*" She swallowed. "*For everyone at Highcrest standing in the street holding up their dark lanterns. For Hollis Penn and his loaf.*" Her voice cracked. "*For me. For the girl on the steps of the Spire in the rain, who said don't ever leave a light on for me, Warden, and you said too late, I've already lit one.*"

She looked at him.

"*I don't remember her*," said Seren Vey. "*That girl. I don't remember being her. I've read about her. Forty pages. Page four's my favorite.*" She tried to smile. "*But I'd like to be her again. If I can. If there's time.*"

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HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He reached out. Slowly. With his thin shaking brown-spotted hand. And took hers. Off the bench. Into his lap.

And held it.

That was all. He didn't pull her close. He didn't kiss her. He didn't tell her anything. He held her square strong freckled hand in his old thin one, on the blanket over his knees, by the window, with the lamp on the sill.

She sat there. Looking at the lamp.

"*Tell me about the night Lex was born*," she said.

He looked at her.

"*You were there*," said Seren. "*I know you were. I can feel it. Someone held my hand all night. Long fingers. Cool.*" She looked down at their hands. "*I can't see who it was.*"

Arion Vey was quiet for a long moment.

"*It was snowing*," he said. "*The midwife from Ashbourne couldn't get through. The road was blocked. Your mother had been dead a year. Antho was five and asleep in the loft. It was just us.*" His thumb moved. Very slightly. On the back of her hand. "*You swore at me for nine hours. You said things I didn't know you knew. You said I had a neck like a bull and the sense of a turnip.*"

"*I did not*."

"*You did. It's on page twelve.*" He was smiling. "*And then, at four in the morning, he came. All at once. Huge. Purple. Furious. Screaming like a*

kettle." He looked at the lamp. *"And you held him. And looked at him. And said, oh. Oh, he's got big hands."*

She laughed. Wet.

"And then," said Arion, *"you looked up at me and said—"*

He stopped.

She waited.

He didn't go on. She looked at him. And saw his eyes were shut. And his white head had dropped a little. Toward his chest.

Not asleep. Not quite.

Tired. So tired. An old man at midnight by a window who had told the same story eleven times to himself in the dark over a year and a half and finally, finally got to tell it to her.

"Arion," she said softly.

"Mm."

"What did I say?"

He opened his eyes. Just a little. Grey. Clear. Looking at her.

"You said, he's going to be trouble," whispered Arion Vey. *"Just like his father."*

And his eyes closed again.

And his hand stayed round hers.

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SHE SAT WITH HIM until dawn.

Not moving. With her hand in his. With the lamp on the sill and the fire going out and the goat snoring under the table. Watching his face. His old furrowed walnut face, asleep. Learning it. The way you learn a face. Line by line. Like reading.

Neck like a bull, she thought. *Sense of a turnip.*

He's going to be trouble.

Just like his father.

She didn't remember saying any of it.

But she knew she had. The way she knew which way was up, at the bottom of the world. The way she knew Ember's voice. The way she knew, at the very edge of hearing, when a little silver bell with a crooked clapper rang, far off, somewhere, for someone who was sad.

At dawn, the sky outside the window went grey. Then pink. Then blue.

And Seren Vey, sitting by the window with her husband's hand in hers, put her head down on his shoulder. Very gently. On the blanket. The way you'd put your head down on someone's shoulder that you'd been doing it on for thirty years.

And fell asleep.

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WHEN SHE WOKE, THE grey book was open on his knee.

He must have reached for it. Slowly. With his free hand. Without waking her. And found the pencil. And written, very small, very neat, shaking only a little, at the bottom of the last page, under all the numbers going down like water down a slope:

She fell asleep on my shoulder.

No change.

She read it twice.

She didn't understand it. *No change*. She looked at it for a long time, with her head still on his shoulder, trying to work out what it meant.

And then she turned back. Through the grey book. Through the forty pages of columns. Through the hairs and the lines and the stairs and the grip. Back. Past the first page. To the inside of the cover.

Where he'd pasted a page. Old. Yellow. Torn out of some other, older book. And on it, in faded ink, in the same small neat hand, two hundred lines.

One a year. On his birthday. At midwinter. For two hundred years.

No change. No change. No change. No change.

No change.

Seren Vey closed the book.

And put it back on his knee. Very gently. And put her head back down on his shoulder. And didn't sleep again.

She didn't need to.

She was awake.

CHAPTER 23

The Council of Lanterns

THEY HELD IT IN the long hall of the Ashbourne Forge, because it was the only room in Caldor big enough.

Twenty hearths. Twenty anvils. A great brick chimney at each end. Lex had swept it himself that morning, with Tilda and the students, and pushed the anvils back against the walls, and carried in every bench and stool and barrel in the Forge, and set them round the great hearth at the north end in a ring.

It wasn't enough.

They came all day. From every road. On horses and dragons and carts and on foot. By noon the forge yard was full. By mid-afternoon the street outside was full. By dusk there were people sitting on the woodpile and the roof of the lean-to and the rim of the warm spring, and Quill the raven had been driven off his chimney by a Sunreach hawk and was sulking on the weathervane of the chapel, shrieking abuse.

And when the sun went down, Lex lit the great hearth.

And everyone came in.

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HE LOOKED ROUND AT them from the anvil block where he was sitting. And couldn't breathe for a moment.

The Queen of Caldor. In a borrowed brown dress from Mother Orla's niece, too short at the wrists. With her silver circlet on again. Sitting on a barrel at the front of the ring with her back very straight.

Dame Elowen Dunmore behind her. Standing. Oathkeeper point-down on the floor.

Commander Roole. Arm in a sling. Hatchet face grey and set. Fenn beside him.

Queen Ishara of the Sunreach. She'd come in at noon on a golden horse with forty riders and Zahir on her shoulder and three old women in red behind her who she said were Ashari, fire-women of the deep desert, who remembered things about fire that nobody in Caldor ever knew. They sat behind her now on a bench. Very old. Very still. Their faces brown and creased as walnuts. Watching the great hearth with black eyes that didn't blink.

Teo Brask. Seventeen now. Taller. Still dripping. Who'd come in off the coast road at three in the afternoon on foot, soaking wet in a clear blue sky, and said *the sea told me to come* and then *sorry about the floor*.

Benno, the standard-bearer of the Ashen Banners. Eighteen. With two hundred swords behind him in the street and Teodra Hale's greatsword on his back and his young face set like stone.

The twins. Kestrel. Tilda. Hedda. Brannoc. Kit, the Coldwater boy, at the very back, very white.

His father. In the wheeled chair. Wrapped in a blanket. With his grey book on his knee.

His mother. Beside his father. On a stool. With the clay lamp in her lap.

Seraphine, with her notebook. Antho, with the Lantern. Pim, under a bench, because there wasn't a table. Ivy Moss, on a stool by the hearth, with her crutch across her knees.

And Wren.

Beside him. On the anvil block. With her hand on his knee.

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"*Well*," said Brannoc. Into the silence. "*Somebody'd better start. Or we'll be here till Lantern Night.*"

A few people laughed.

Lex didn't. He looked at the faces round the ring. All of them. Looking at him. Waiting.

He'd never been good at this. Antho was good at this. Arion was good at this. The Queen was very good at this. He was a smith. He thought with his hands. When he had to talk to a room he always said the wrong thing first, and then the right thing, and then something embarrassing.

[Just say it,] said Ember. *[Like you'd say it to Brannoc. Over the anvil.]*

He stood up.

"*There's three things*," said Lex.

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HE HELD UP ONE finger.

"*The little one*," he said. "*The Well. It's coming up. Lantern Night. The end of the year. We can't stop it. Nobody can. It's what it is. It goes toward the light.*" He looked round. "*It's the size of a country. It can't come through any door. So we have to make it a place to come up into. A room. Big enough. Somewhere she can't get at it.*"

He held up a second finger.

"*Her*," he said. "*Maelis. The Moth Queen. She's taken Highcrest. She's dimmed half of it. She's got thousands of moths and hundreds of her own people and Silas Hask with wings, and she's Tier V, and she's sitting in my father's room at the top of the Spire reading two hundred years of his books.*" His voice didn't shake. He was proud of that. "*She wants our blood. Mam's. Antho's. Mine. To open the Veil and let her brothers and sisters through. And she wants the little one, when it comes up. All of it. To drink.*"

He held up a third finger.

"*And them*," said Lex. "*The Dimmed. Everyone she's touched. The Keepers at Greyfall. Half of Highcrest. Every shepherd and woodcutter in the Greyspine who had a light in the window.*" He looked at Elowen. "*Hollis Penn. Standing on the Spire steps in his apron holding up his lantern.*"

The long hall was very quiet.

"*Three things*," said Lex Vey. "*Make it a room. Stop her. Bring them back.*" He put his hand down. "*I don't know how to do any of them. That's why you're all here.*"

He sat down.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE STOOD UP.

She had a map. Of course she did. A big one. Hand-drawn. The whole of Caldor and the Sunreach and the Saltreach and the Greyspine and the Blightmarch, from the edge of the sea to the edge of the Veil. She and Antho had been up all night making it. She pinned it to the great brick chimney-breast over the hearth with four horseshoe nails that Tilda handed her one by one.

It had pins in it. Black ones and red ones. Fifty-three black. Twenty-nine red.

And one gold one.

At the far eastern edge of the map. Past the Blightmarch. Past Duskhold. In a place that was drawn in grey, with nothing in it. No villages. No roads. No rivers. Just grey, and the word *VHESSA* in Seraphine's small neat hand, and a ring drawn round it in red.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It needs room*," said Seraphine. "*Lex is right. A lot of room. More than you'd think.*"

She tapped the map.

"*It's the size of a country. A small one. I've measured it. As well as I can. By listening.*" She looked round. "*When it comes up, it'll need somewhere it can unfold. Somewhere with nothing in the way. No villages. No farms. No forests. No rivers it would drown, no towns it would swallow. Nothing alive that it would—*" She stopped. "*That it would make room* in. *By accident.*"

"*There's nowhere in Caldor like that*," said Duke Harlowe's daughter. From the back. Very young. Very frightened. "*Is there? Everywhere's got something in it.*"

"*There's one place*," said Seraphine.

She put her finger on the gold pin.

"*The Blightmarch*," she said. "*Eastern Vhessa. Past Duskhold. Where the Gloam was.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL WENT VERY still.

Everyone knew the Blightmarch. Everyone in Caldor had grown up on stories of it. The eastern march, eaten. Twenty years of Gloam. Grey grass. Silent birds. Villages gone quiet. Duskhold, the black citadel, grown out of

Gloam-stone in the middle of it like a tumor. Morvane's fortress. The Quiet, standing in rows.

The Gloam was gone now. Five years gone. Since the brothers closed the breach. But nothing had come back. Not really. Not in the deep east. The land was dead. Grey. Empty. A wasteland a hundred miles across where nothing grew and nobody went, and the wind blew grey dust off the hills, and the ruins of Duskhold stood in the middle of it, black and cracked and falling, like the bones of something enormous that had died there.

"*There's nothing there*," said Seraphine quietly. "*Nothing alive. Nothing that would be hurt. It's been dead for twenty years.*" She looked at the map. "*It's the only place in the world big enough and empty enough.*"

"*And it's got a door*," said Antho.

Everyone looked at him.

He was sitting very still. With the Lantern in his lap. Looking at the map. At the gold pin.

"*The Vhessa breach*," he said. "*Where the Gloam came through. The first breach. The oldest wound in the net.*" He looked at his father. "*It goes all the way down. To the deep. We closed it, five years ago. The three of us. With blood.*" His voice was very quiet. "*But closed isn't gone. It's still there. Like a scar. Like a door that's been shut.*"

"*A door can be opened*," said Kestrel.

"*A door can be opened*," Antho agreed. "*If someone asks it right.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I tore it*," said Arion.

The hall turned.

He was sitting in his wheeled chair beside the hearth. With his blanket and his book and his white head. Looking at the map. At the grey place. At the red ring round it.

His face was very calm.

"*Twenty years ago*," said Arion Vey. "*Twenty-one. At the Great Stone in Vhessa. With all my Authority and a Rewrite that I'd spent fifty years designing. I tried to break every Ceiling in the world at once. In one stroke.*" He looked at his hands. "*It didn't work. It tore. And the Gloam came*

through the tear, and ate the east, and took Morvane, and took twenty years of everyone's lives."

Nobody said anything.

"I know that breach," said Arion. *"Better than anyone alive. I made it. I know its edges. Every one. I know where it's thin and where it's thick and where it was stitched shut five years ago by my sons with their own blood."* He looked at Antho. *"If you're going to open it again, you'll need someone who knows where the edges are."*

"Father—" said Lex.

"I'm eighty-three," said Arion. *"I think. The book says so."* He tapped the grey book on his knee. *"I can't walk. I can barely hold a cup. I have a season left. Perhaps less."* He looked round the hall. At all of them. *"I can still remember. That's all I've got left. I'd like to use it for something."*

His mother put her hand on his arm.

Arion looked down at it. Her square strong freckled hand on his thin old arm.

"I tore it trying to free everyone at once," he said. More quietly. *"It would be nice to help open it for something that needs to come home."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"So that's the room," said Lysandra. *"The Blightmarch. Through the old breach."* She looked at Lex. *"How do you make a room the size of a country, smith?"*

"I don't know yet."

"That's not very reassuring."

"I know." He looked at the map. *"It's a mould. That's all I know. You make the empty shape first. In the ground. And then you pour."* He rubbed his face. The handprint glittered under his fingers. *"I've made moulds. I've never made one bigger than a cartwheel. Brannoc made one for a church bell once."*

"Nearly killed me," said Brannoc. From the bench. *"Three months. Lost a toe."*

"The Blightmarch is a hundred miles across."

"So it'll take longer," said Brannoc Holt. Unperturbed. *"And you'll lose more toes."* He scratched his grey beard. *"But it's just a mould, lad. A big*

one. Same as any other. You find the shape. You pack the sand. You make the empty bit just so, and you let it set." He shrugged his enormous shoulders. *"I'll help. So will every smith in this hall. So will every student. You don't make a bell mould alone."*

He looked round. At the students. At Tilda with his hammer. At the forty young faces round the walls of the long hall, lit gold by the great hearth.

"We're the Ashbourne Forge," said Brannoc. *"It's what we do."*

◆ ◆ ◆

"Fire," said a voice.

Old. Cracked. Dry as sand. In an accent Lex didn't know.

Everyone turned.

One of the three old women behind Queen Ishara had stood up. The smallest. The oldest. She was tiny. Bent nearly double. In a robe of faded red. With her face as brown and creased as a walnut and a pair of black eyes as bright as a crow's.

She was looking at Lex.

"You need fire," she said. *"To set a mould. You need to bake the sand. Hard. Hot. So it holds the shape."* Her black eyes didn't blink. *"Very hot. A long time. Over a hundred miles."*

"Yes," said Lex. Slowly. *"Yes. I do."*

"We have fire," said the old woman. *"The Sunwell. The grieving one. Under the glass."* She smiled. Toothless. Fierce. *"It burned its own people once. To kill a hungry thing."* Her black eyes glittered. *"It would very much like to help make a home for one."*

Queen Ishara, sitting in front of her, didn't turn round. But Lex saw her mouth twitch.

"This is Grandmother Asha," said Ishara. *"She is three hundred years old. Or she says she is. She was a fire-woman before the Treaty of Scald, when the Order put a Ceiling on the Sunreach."* She looked at Lex. *"She has been waiting two hundred years for someone to ask her for fire."*

"Two hundred and eleven," said Grandmother Asha. *"But who's counting."*

Antho laughed. Out loud. He couldn't help it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*And water*," said Teo.

He was standing up. Dripping. Red to the ears. With everyone looking at him.

"*For the quench*," he said. "*When the mould's set. When the—when the thing comes up.*" He swallowed. "*The Undertow says it'll help. The sea. It says it remembers the seventh. From before. When it was little. It says the seventh used to make room for the tide to come in.*" He went redder. "*It says it misses it.*"

"*The sea misses it*," said Lex.

"*The sea's very sentimental*," said Teo. "*You wouldn't think so. But it is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*That's the room*," said the Queen.

She was standing now. At the front of the ring. In her too-short borrowed dress, with her circlet on. Looking at the map.

"*The Blightmarch. A mould. Ashbourne's smiths and Sunreach fire and the Undertow's quench. The old breach for a door.*" She turned. "*Lantern Night.*"

"*Lantern Night*," said Lex.

"*That's the first thing*." Lysandra looked round the hall. "*Now the second. Her.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*She's Tier V*," said Roole. Grimly. From his bench. "*She took Highcrest in one night. She dimmed four Keepers at her door with a touch each. She's got Hask, and he's eighty-six, and he flies.*" He shook his head. "*I've got eleven hundred Keepers, Majesty. Six hundred are in the Greyspine and the west trying to keep shepherds from walking toward the moths. Three hundred were in Highcrest.*" His jaw tightened. "*Were.*"

"*Swords don't work*," said Elowen. "*On the Mothwing. They come apart into dust and pile up again. You need wind. Or fire. Or—*" She looked at Lex. "*Whatever he does. The black thing.*"

"*Black heat*," said Lex.

"*Can you teach it*?"

He looked at her.

He'd never thought of that. He'd never thought of it as a thing you could *teach*. It was just a thing he'd done. In the deep. Because Kestrel asked him *what's fire that isn't light* and Brannoc's voice came up out of his hands.

"*Yes*," said Kestrel. Before he could answer. "*He can. I learned it in one go. Anyone who can talk to fire can learn it. You just have to ask it to hide.*"

"*How many people in Caldor can talk to fire*?"

There was a pause.

"*Forty*," said Tilda Crane. From the wall. Very quietly. With Brannoc's hammer in her hands. "*In this hall. Forty of us. Students. We all hear it. Master Lex taught us.*" She swallowed. "*And there's other forges now. Fifteen. Every one with a Flame-Listener.*"

"*And the Ashari*," said Grandmother Asha. "*There are two hundred of us. Old women. In the deep desert. We've been doing black heat since before your Founders were born.*" She sniffed. "*We just call it* sand.*"*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's not enough*," said Antho.

Everyone looked at him.

He was sitting very still. With the Lantern in his lap. And his clear grey eyes on the map.

"*Black heat burns them*," he said. "*If they come close. If they come* looking. *But they won't come close to black heat. Not after the first time. They'll learn. She'll teach them.*" He looked up. "*She'll come for the light. That's what she is. She goes toward the light.*"

"*So we put the lights out*," said Roole.

"*On Lantern Night*?"

The hall went very still.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STOOD UP.

"*That's why she said Lantern Night*," said his brother. Very quietly. "*Isn't it. That's why the end of the year.*" He looked round. "*Not because that's when the little one comes up. Because that's when every window in Caldor has a lantern in it.*"

Nobody spoke.

"*Every year*," said Antho, "*on Lantern Night, everyone lights a lamp. For the lost. For someone who didn't come home. Every house. Every window. Every grave.*" His voice was very flat. "*It's the night the whole world leaves a light on.*"

He looked at his mother.

"*It's her feast*," said Antho Vey. "*Isn't it, Mam. It's the night she's been waiting nine hundred years for.*"

His mother didn't answer.

She didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LONG HALL WAS silent for a long time.

The great hearth crackled. Outside, in the street, someone's horse stamped. On the chapel weathervane, Quill shrieked something about Sunreach hawks that Lex was fairly sure wasn't repeatable.

And then Ivy Moss said, from her stool by the hearth, very small: "*Not all of them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

EVERYONE TURNED.

She went red. All the way up into her pale hair. She gripped her crutch. But she didn't stop.

"*Not all the lights*," said Ivy Moss. "*She can't drink all of them. Some of them, she can't.*" She looked at Seren. "*The lamp-lady's. The clay one. The moths couldn't drink it. In the deep. And Master Antho's six. In the drowned city. They couldn't drink those either.*"

"*Because they were given*," said Seraphine slowly. "*Not kept. Not waiting. The Harrow lamp's for someone else. And Antho's six were for a promise that was already kept.*"

"*Yes.*" Ivy Moss nodded. Hard. "*She drinks the waiting ones. The lights left on for someone who's not home. The promises.*" She swallowed. "*That's what a moth wants. A light that's* waiting.*"* She looked at the map. "*Lantern Night's all waiting. Every lantern's waiting for someone. That's why it's a feast.*"

"*So—*" said Lysandra.

"*So change them*," said Ivy Moss.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY UNDERSTOOD. NOT AT first. Lex didn't. He saw Seraphine's face change. Saw her pencil stop. Saw her look at Ivy with her eyes going very wide.

And then he saw his mother's face.

Seren Vey was looking at the small pale girl on the stool by the hearth. With the clay lamp in her lap. And her face was doing the thing it had done in the gold room at the bottom of the world, when Lex said *a mould*.

"*Oh*," said Seren. Softly. "*Oh, clever girl.*"

"*What*?" said Wren.

"*Don't leave the lights on*," said Seren Vey. "*Give them away.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOOD UP.

With the lamp. In the middle of the long hall of the Ashbourne Forge. Small. Fierce. Freckled. Holding it up. So everyone could see it. Little. Brown. Clay. With a chip in the spout.

"*My mother made this*," she said. "*For a man she didn't trust. Who was going to take her daughter away from her. Who was a Warden of the Order that hunted women like her.*" She looked at Arion. "*She'd never left a light on in forty years. And she made this, and lit it, and put it in the window. For him.*"

She turned the lamp. So the light fell across the ring of faces.

"*Not waiting for him*," said Seren. "*He was already there. Already coming up the path. She didn't light it hoping he'd come. She lit it because he* had." She looked round. "*That's not a promise. That's a gift. You can't drink a gift. It's already gone. It's already somebody else's.*"

"*On Lantern Night*," said Seraphine. Her pencil was flying. "*Everyone lights a lantern. Waiting. For the lost. For the dead. For someone who isn't home.*"

"*And this year*," said Seren Vey, "*they don't wait.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*They bring them*," said Lex.

He was on his feet. He didn't remember standing. The idea was coming up out of his hands the way they always did. Hot. Fast. Like iron coming up out of a fire.

"*To the Blightmarch*," he said. "*All of them. Every lantern. Every person who can carry one. They bring them to the room. To the mould. To the place where the little one's coming up.*" He looked at the map. "*And they don't leave them on for someone. They* give *them. To it. To the thing that's coming home.*"

"*A light given*," said Antho. Slowly. "*To the seventh. To the room.*"

"*Every lantern in Caldor*," said Lex. "*Set down. Round the edge of the mould. A ring of them. Ten thousand. A hundred thousand. Not waiting. Given. So when it comes up, it comes up into light that's already its own.*" He looked at his mother. "*Light she can't drink.*"

"*And she'll come for it anyway*," said Kestrel. "*Because she can't help it. Because it's the brightest thing in the world.*"

"*And she'll find black heat round every one*," said Grandmother Asha. Her toothless grin was very wide. "*Sand. Two hundred old women and forty young smiths. Waiting in the dark round the edge of the light.*" She cackled. "*Oh, I like that. I like that very much.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL ERUPTED.

Not in shouting. In *talking*. All at once. Everyone. Brannoc and Hedda arguing about sand. Teo and Seraphine with their heads together over the map. Roole and Elowen and Benno at the back, talking about where to put two hundred swords and eleven hundred Keepers on a dead plain a hundred miles across. Ishara saying something sharp and fast in Sunreach to her three old women, who were all cackling now. The twins already talking about illusions. *Lanterns, Ilse. Lanterns made of nothing. Ten thousand. To make her think there's light where there's sand.*

Lex stood in the middle of it and couldn't stop smiling.

[That was Ivy,] said Ember. Very quietly. In his hearth. *[That whole thing. The fourteen-year-old with the crutch. She did that.]*

I know.

[Your mother finished it. But Ivy started it.]

I know, thought Lex. *I know.* He looked at the small pale girl on her stool by the hearth, red to the ears, gripping her crutch, with half the long hall now turning to look at her. *Kindled beside an open way. Class unrecognized.*

[What do you think she is?] said Ember.

I don't know, thought Lex. *Something new*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE THIRD THING CAME last.

Late. When the fire was down and half the hall was asleep on the benches and the other half was still arguing about sand. When Lex was sitting on the anvil block with Wren's head on his shoulder and his father asleep in the wheeled chair and his mother asleep beside him with the lamp in her lap.

The Dimmed.

Nobody knew.

"*They don't wake up*," said Fenn. Quietly. Sitting on the floor by the hearth, with his narrow sandy face in the firelight. "*The ones from Greyfall. Twenty-eight of them. We've had them in the infirmary at the Keepers' house in Millbridge for two months. They eat if you put food in their mouths. They walk if you lead them.*" He looked at his hands. "*They don't wake up.*"

"*Odile woke up*," said Antho. "*At the Keep. On the first night.*"

"*Pim*," said Lex. "*Pim cupped his hands round hers. Made room.*"

"*Pim can't do ten thousand*."

"*No*."

"*And Kell*," said Seraphine. "*In the deep. You read her name. From the Ledger. And what Dorran said.*" She looked at Lex. "*She came back a little. Not all the way. But some.*"

"*Because I knew what was taken*," said Lex slowly. "*I knew what Maelis took. The warm thing. The only one she had. And I gave it back. Out loud.*" He looked at the fire. "*I don't know what she took from Hollis Penn. Or the girl with the baby. Or the Keepers at Greyfall.*"

"*Someone does*," said a voice.

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WREN LIFTED HER HEAD off his shoulder.

She'd been awake. He'd thought she was asleep. She sat up. Slowly. With her hand on her stomach and her fox-red braid over her shoulder and her green eyes very bright in the firelight.

"*Someone knows*," she said. "*For every one of them. What the warm thing was.*" She looked at Fenn. "*Someone who loves them.*"

The hearth crackled.

"*Odile*," said Wren. "*What did Maelis take from her?*"

"*The first time she came up the mountain*," said Antho. "*When she knocked on the cave door. And I said, thank goodness, I've no idea what I'm doing.*" His voice was very quiet. "*She told me after. It was the warmest thing she had.*"

"*And who knew that*?"

Antho looked at her.

"*Me*," he said.

"*You*." Wren nodded. "*And Kell. What Maelis took from Kell. Dorran carrying her. Who knew that?*"

"*Seraphine*," said Lex. "*Kell told her. At the Heart.*"

"*Someone who loved her enough to listen*," said Wren.

She stood up.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I'm going to Highcrest*," said Wren Ashdown.

Lex was on his feet.

"*No—*"

"*Yes*." She didn't look at him. She was looking at the map. At Highcrest. At the dark city on the hill with the gold light at the top. "*My mother's there. Fennel Street. The narrow house with the green door. Third from the end. With Tam and Robbie.*"

"*You don't know that she's—*"

"*I know*," said Wren. Her voice was very steady. "*I know. I felt it. In the wind. Three nights ago. When Highcrest went dark. I felt something go out.*" She swallowed. "*Something I've known my whole life. Something that used to cough in the next room.*"

The hall had gone quiet. Everyone who was awake was looking at her.

"*I know what the warm thing is*," said Wren. "*For Mam. I'm the only one who does. Tam's too little. Robbie's too little. Da's dead.*" She looked at Lex. Finally. "*I'm the only one who knows what to give back.*"

"*Wren—*"

"*I'm not asking*," said Wren Ashdown. Very gently. "*Hammer. I'm not asking. I'm telling you. Before I go. Not after. Not from the road.*" She put her hand on his face. On the handprint. "*Like Antho did. Like you taught him.*"

He couldn't say anything.

"*I'll take Pim*," said Wren. "*Nothing can dim Pim. And Elowen, because she knows the sally port. And Ilse and Ivo, because they can make me look like nothing.*" Her thumb moved on his cheek. "*I'll go in. I'll find her. I'll find out if I'm right.*"

"*And if you're not*?"

"*Then I'll come home*," said Wren. "*And we'll think of something else.*"

She looked at him. With her green eyes. For a long time.

"*And if I am*," she said, "*then we'll know how to bring them all back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LET HER GO.

He'd think about that later. Many times. In the forge. In the loft at Harrow. Lying awake. That he let her go. Into the dark city with the gold light at the top. With his child in her. With the Moth Queen sitting in his father's chair by the window, reading.

He'd think: *I should have stopped her*.

And then he'd think: *I couldn't have*.

And then he'd think, the way Brannoc had taught him to think about iron that wouldn't take the shape you wanted: *I didn't want to*.

Because she was right.

Because she always was.

Because she was Wren Ashdown, who'd been hungry once, and hated waste more than anything in the world, and wasn't going to waste her mother.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LEFT AT DAWN.

On the wind. With Pim on her back, small and solemn with his arms round her neck. With Elowen on a grey horse below, and the twins in their cart, and Oathkeeper drawn.

Lex stood in the forge yard and watched her go.

Over the roofs of Ashbourne. Over the chapel elms, where Quill was still sulking. South. Toward the downs. Toward the dark city on the hill.

She didn't look back.

But at the edge of the village, where the road went over the river, she lifted one hand. Without turning round.

And the wind that went with her, that always went with her, that had come up out of her in a Wellworld of Gale and never left—

Came back.

Just for a moment. Round him. In the forge yard. Warm. Soft. Smelling of her hair.

Like a hand on his face.

Like *stay*.

And then it was gone. South. With her.

And Lex stood beside the warm spring in the cinders of the yard where he'd learned his trade, and put his hand on his face, on the handprint, where her thumb had been.

And went inside.

And started to think about sand.

CHAPTER 24

Relighting

THE SALLY PORT SMELLED of rats and old water, and Wren was sick in it twice.

"*Sorry*," she said. The second time. Wiping her mouth on her sleeve. Crouched in the dark of the tunnel under the north wall of Highcrest, with Pim's small hand on her back and Elowen's lantern shuttered and the rock dripping somewhere ahead.

"*Don't be sorry*," said Elowen Dunmore. "*Be quiet.*"

"*I'm being quiet*."

"*You're being sick very loudly*."

"*It's a very loud baby*," said Wren.

Ilse laughed. Behind her. In the dark. Then stopped. Then laughed again, smothered, into her brother's shoulder.

Wren got up. Her knees were shaking. Her stomach was a boat in a gale. Four months, Old Mag said. Near enough. *The sickness should be passing*, Old Mag said. *Any day now. Ginger.*

Wren had eaten so much ginger she could taste it in her sleep.

"*Go on*," she said. "*I'm fine.*"

They went on.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE TUNNEL CAME OUT under a grating in a cellar under the castle kitchens. Elowen knew the way. Elowen knew every way. She'd grown up in this castle, she said, in a house with four aunts, running wild in the corridors while her father was away being a knight.

They went up through the kitchens.

Empty. Pots on the stove, cold. Bread on the table, half-kneaded, gone grey and hard. A cat asleep on a sack of flour that lifted its head as they passed and looked at them with green eyes, and then put its head down again.

Up through the servants' stair. Out through a side door into a lane.

Into the city.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN HAD BEEN IN Highcrest a hundred times. She'd lived here for three years, after her mother got sick, in the narrow house on Fennel Street. She'd guarded Arion here for a month of dawns. She'd danced in a ballroom here with no shoes on.

She'd never seen it like this.

It was noon. Summer. Hot. And dark.

Not night-dark. *Under*-dark. The way it's dark under a tree, or under a bridge. Grey. Dim. Shadowed. The glitter overhead was so thick the sun was only a pale smudge, like a coin seen through dirty water. The light that came down through it was grey-gold and flat and wrong. It made everything look like a drawing. Like the Unfinished in Lex's Delve. Lines, and no color.

And it was *quiet*.

Highcrest was never quiet. Highcrest was bells and carts and hawkers and children and dogs and the clang of the smithies on Anvil Row and the shouting from the market and the gulls that came up the river from the sea. Highcrest at noon in summer was the loudest place Wren had ever been.

It was silent.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE IN THE streets.

Everywhere. On every corner. In every doorway. Standing. Sitting on steps. Leaning on walls. People. Ordinary people. Bakers and porters and washerwomen and clerks and old men and children.

All facing the same way.

North. Uphill. Toward the top of the city. Toward the Spire. Toward the gold light that came out of every window of it, soft and warm, through the glitter, like a lamp seen through fog.

Their eyes were dim.

They weren't moving. Not really. Swaying. Very slightly. All together. Like grass in a wind that wasn't there. And on every one of them, somewhere, dust. A smudge. Grey-gold. The size of a moth's wing.

And in their hands, lanterns.

Not all of them. Many. Dark. With dust on the glass. Held up. Toward the Spire. The way you'd hold up a cup to be filled. The way you'd offer a gift.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Gods*," whispered Ivo.

He was standing at the end of the lane. Very white. Looking out into the street. At the rows and rows of them. At a woman Wren half-recognized, the woman who sold cheese in the Tuesday market, standing in the gutter with a dark lantern held up and her face slack and peaceful.

"*Don't look at them*," said Elowen. Very low. "*Look at the ground. Look at your feet. Walk.*"

"*They're not doing anything*," said Ilse. Her voice was shaking. "*They're just—standing there.*"

"*Walk*."

"*Ivo*," said Wren.

He looked at her.

"*Make us look like them*," she said. "*Dim. Grey. Swaying. With lanterns. Facing the Spire.*" She swallowed. "*Make us look like we belong.*"

Ivo stared at her for a moment.

Then he nodded. And put his hand out. And Ilse took it without looking.

And Wren felt it go over her. The illusion. Cool. Light. Like a veil. Like a cobweb on her face. She looked down at herself. Grey. Flat. Her green coat gone the color of ash. Her hands holding a lantern that wasn't there. And when she looked at Elowen, the knight was gone, and in her place was

a stooped grey woman with a dark lamp held up toward the north, swaying.

Pim didn't need it.

Pim walked out into the street in his blue coat with the brass buttons buttoned wrong, and the moths drifting overhead parted round him like water round a stone. And didn't come back. And the dimmed people in the street didn't turn. Didn't look. Didn't see him at all.

A room with the lamp out.

◆ ◆ ◆

FENNEL STREET WAS IN the Lower Town. Near the river. A narrow street of narrow houses, tall and thin and leaning toward each other overhead, so that the sky was a strip. Wren had walked down it a thousand times. Carrying water. Carrying bread. Carrying her mother's medicine from Master Fenwick's on Physic Lane.

She knew every stone.

She walked down it now under Ivo's illusion, grey and swaying, with a lantern that wasn't there, and her heart going like a drum.

Past the cobbler's. Dim. The cobbler standing in his doorway with an awl in one hand and a dark lantern in the other. Past the widow Abel's. Dim. The widow sitting on her step with a cat in her lap, both of them facing north. Past the house with the blue shutters where the Fenwicks' apprentice lived. Dim. Dim. Dim.

Third from the end.

Green door.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER MOTHER WAS ON the step.

Of course she was. She was always on the step. She'd sat on that step every afternoon for three years, in the sun, when she was too sick to do anything else. With Tam on one side and Robbie on the other. Waiting for Wren to come home.

She was sitting on it now.

In her grey shawl. With her stick across her knees. Thin. Small. Grey-threaded. Facing north. Up the hill. Toward the gold light.

With a lantern in her lap.

Wren knew that lantern. Tin. Old. Dented. With a crack in the horn pane that her father had mended with a strip of birch-bark the winter before he died. It had hung in the window of the grey-plank house in Thistledown, with the horseshoe over the door upside down so the luck wouldn't run out. It had hung in the window of this narrow house on Fennel Street since they came.

For her father, the first winter. For Wren, ever since.

Every time she went away. Every time she went up a mountain with a smith who walked like a bear. Every time she went to the Glass Desert, or the Wellworlds, or the bottom of the world.

Her mother lit it. And put it in the window. And sat on the step beside it. And waited.

It was dark.

There was dust on the birch-bark.

And her mother's eyes, open, turned up toward the Spire, were dim.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STOPPED.

In the middle of Fennel Street. Under Ivo's illusion. Grey. Swaying. With a lantern that wasn't there.

And couldn't move.

"*Wren*," said Elowen. Very low. Beside her. "*Wren. Go.*"

She couldn't.

She stood in the street and looked at her mother on the step. And all she could think of was the first time Lex had seen her mother. Five years ago. Coming up this street with a sack of tools on his shoulder and his hood up. And her mother on the step, coughing, laughing, crying, all at once. *So. You must be the Hammer.*

And the second time. The autumn after Duskhold. When her mother stood up. On her own. For the first time in three years. Off this step. And Wren had flown up the street on the wind.

Pathfinder, she'd said. *Rare. Level forty-one. No cap. Mam. No cap.*

Her mother had cried. And laughed. And coughed. All at once.

She wasn't doing anything now.

She was just sitting there. With her stick. With her dark lantern. With her face slack and peaceful and turned toward the light at the top of the hill.

As if Wren had never come home at all.

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMEONE GRABBED HER LEG.

She nearly screamed. She nearly loosed the arrow she wasn't holding. She looked down.

A boy. Nine. Ten. Thin. Filthy. With a shock of red hair and freckles and a gap in his front teeth where the new ones were coming in crooked. Holding on to her leg with both arms. Through the illusion. As if the illusion wasn't there.

Crying.

"*Wren*," said Robbie Ashdown. Into her knee. "*Wren. Wren. I knew it was you. I knew. You walk wrong. You always walk wrong. Even grey.*"

She dropped to her knees.

The illusion broke. She felt it go. Like a cobweb tearing. She didn't care. She was on her knees in Fennel Street with her little brother in her arms, holding him, and he was holding her, and he was so *thin*.

"*Robbie*." Into his hair. His filthy red hair. "*Robbie. Robbie. Are you all right? Are you hurt? Did they—*"

"*I hid*." He was shaking. "*Under the bed. When the moths came. Mam said hide. Mam said hide and put the candle out and don't come out.*" He gulped. "*And then she didn't come and get me. And I came out. And she was on the step. And Tam was on the step. And they wouldn't—*"

He couldn't finish.

Wren looked over his head.

Tam. Twelve. Sitting on the step beside their mother. On her other side. Where he always sat. With his knees up. Facing north.

Dim.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I've been feeding them*," said Robbie. Into her shoulder. "*I've been putting bread in their mouths. And water. Like you do for a baby bird. They eat it.*

But they don't look at me." His voice cracked. *"Wren, they don't look at me. Nobody looks at me. Nobody in the whole street."*

"I know."

"Four days." He was crying so hard he could barely talk. *"I've been feeding them four days. I didn't know what to do. I didn't know where you were. I thought you were dead. I thought everyone was dead except me."*

"I'm here," said Wren Ashdown. *"I'm here. I came. I'm here."*

She held him. And looked at her mother over his head.

And didn't know what to do either.

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM DID.

Or tried. He came and knelt on the step. In front of her mother. Small and solemn in his blue coat. And cupped his hands. Round her mother's hands. Round the dark lantern in her lap. Not touching. An inch away.

And was silent.

Wren felt it. The room. The space. Pim's quiet, going round her mother's hands like the walls of a cup.

Her mother blinked.

Once. Slowly.

And her eyes moved. A little. Off the Spire. Down. Toward Pim.

And then back. Up. Toward the light.

Pim kept his hands there. For a long time. Wren watched him. Watched his thin face go grey with effort. Watched his hands start to shake.

Her mother didn't come back.

She didn't get worse. The dimness didn't spread. Something in her face eased a little, the way Odile's had eased, the way Kell's had eased in the drowned city. Room. A space. Somewhere for the warm thing to come back *into*.

But it didn't come.

"It's not enough," said Pim. Very quietly. Not looking up. *"I can make the room. I can't put anything in it."*

He took his hands away.

He looked at Wren.

"*It's not mine*," said Pim. "*The warm thing. I don't know what it is. I don't know her.*" His grey-violet eyes were very steady. "*You do.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN SAT ON THE step.

Beside her mother. On the other side from Tam. Where Robbie usually sat. With Robbie in her lap, too big to be in her lap, being in her lap anyway.

She looked at her mother's face. Thin. Grey-threaded. Turned north. Peaceful.

What did she take?

She'd thought about it all the way from Ashbourne. On the wind. With Pim on her back. She'd thought, *I'll know. When I see her. I'll know.*

She didn't know.

Her mother had a thousand warm things. She'd loved her husband. She'd loved Thistledown. She'd loved the grey-plank house with the horseshoe upside down. She'd loved Tam and Robbie, every day, even when they were awful. She'd loved Wren.

Which one?

The warmest, Odile had said. *It's the warmest thing I have. And it took it.*

The only warm thing, Kell had said. *I only had the one.*

Her mother had had a thousand.

Which one was the warmest?

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT THE lantern.

In her mother's lap. Tin. Dented. With a crack in the horn pane mended with birch-bark. Dark. With dust on it.

She'd always thought it was for her father. The first winter. That her mother lit it for him, because he'd died in the autumn, of a fever he'd caught in the mines at Coldwater. Because you lit a lantern for the dead on Lantern Night. Everyone did.

But it hadn't been Lantern Night.

She thought back. Hard. The way you track an animal across bare rock, by the bent lichen.

The first winter. In the grey-plank house in Thistledown. Da dead in the autumn. Mam sick. Coughing. The cough that would last ten years. Tam a baby. Robbie not born yet. No money. No food. Snow.

And Wren, nine years old, taking Da's old bow off the wall. The one she couldn't draw. And going out into the snow.

Because if she didn't, her mother would die.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D BEEN GONE THREE days.

She'd never told anyone that. Not Lex. Not anyone. She'd been gone three days and two nights, in the snow, in the woods above Thistledown, with a bow she couldn't draw and a knife and a lump of cheese. She'd slept in a hollow under a fallen pine. She'd nearly frozen. She'd cried a lot.

And on the third day, she'd found a hare. In a snare she'd set herself, the way Da had shown her once, when she was six. A big brown winter hare. Dead. Frozen stiff.

She'd carried it home.

Through the snow. In the dark. With her feet so cold she couldn't feel them and her hands so cold she couldn't feel the hare. Down the mountain. Into Thistledown. Up the street.

And in the window of the grey-plank house, with the horseshoe over the door upside down so the luck wouldn't run out—

A light.

◆ ◆ ◆

That was the first time, thought Wren.

She was sitting on the step on Fennel Street with her brother in her lap and her mother beside her, dim, facing north. And she was nine years old, standing in the snow outside a grey-plank house in Thistledown with a frozen hare in her arms, looking at a light in the window.

That was the first time she lit it.

Not for Da. For me.

She'd lit it the first night I was gone. And sat up with it. Three nights. Coughing. With Tam in her arms. Sick. Starving. Sitting by the window with a lantern lit, waiting for her nine-year-old to come home out of the snow.

And I came.

I came up the street with a hare.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE REMEMBERED HER MOTHER'S face.

In the door. When she pushed it open. When she came in out of the snow with the hare in her arms and her feet like blocks of ice.

Her mother had been sitting by the window. With the lantern. With Tam asleep in her lap. Grey. Thin. Coughing.

And she'd looked up.

And seen Wren.

And her face—

Wren had never seen a face do that. Not before. Not since. Not even Lex's, on the roof of the Spire, when she said yes. It had *broken*. All at once. Every part of it. Like ice breaking on a river in spring. And under it, something so bright and so warm and so enormous that nine-year-old Wren Ashdown had stood in the doorway with snow on her boots and a frozen hare in her arms and been, for the first time in three days, not cold at all.

You came back, her mother had said. *Oh, Wrennie. You came back.*

◆ ◆ ◆

That's it, thought Wren.

That's the warmest thing.

Not Da. Not Thistledown. Not the house. Not Tam or Robbie.

Me. Coming back. Through the snow. To the light she left on.

She looked at the dark lantern in her mother's lap.

She's lit it every time since, thought Wren. *Every time I went away. For that. For the feeling. Waiting at the window for me to come back up the street.*

And Maelis took it.

She took the coming-back.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT to do.

She knew what the warm thing was. She knew what had been taken. She could feel it, the shape of the hole where it had been, the way you can feel the shape of a missing tooth with your tongue.

But she didn't know how to give it back.

Lex had read Kell's name out of the Ledger. And then said what Dorran said. *I've got you, High Warden. I've carried heavier.* And Kell had come back a little.

A little.

Not all the way.

She looked at her mother. At the dark lantern. At the dust on the birch-bark.

I came back, thought Wren. *I came back with a hare.*

You lit the lamp. And I came back.

It's the wrong way round.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GOT UP.

She put Robbie off her lap. Gently. Onto the step. And stood up. And turned round. And looked at her mother. Sitting on the step. Facing north. Toward the gold light at the top of the hill. With the dark lantern in her lap. Waiting.

Still waiting, thought Wren. *She's still waiting. That's what the moth left her. The waiting. Without the coming-back.*

She's been waiting for me for four days. On the step. With the lantern. Facing the wrong way.

Toward the wrong light.

She bent down.

And took the lantern out of her mother's lap.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER MOTHER'S HANDS DIDN'T fight her. They let go. Slack. Empty. They lay in her lap, palm up, the way Kell's had lain on the steps of the grey house in the drowned city. The way a pair of hands lies when it's let go of something and there's nothing left to hold.

Wren held the lantern.

Tin. Dented. Cold. Dark.

She didn't have a light. Nobody did. Not in Highcrest. Not under the glitter. The moths would come for any light that was lit.

She looked at Elowen.

"*Fire*," said Wren.

Elowen looked at her. Then at the glitter overhead. Then back. "*Wren. The moths—*"

"*I know. Give me fire.*"

Elowen didn't have fire. She had a tinderbox. In her belt-pouch. Flint and steel and a twist of char-cloth. She took it out. Slowly. With her hard grey eyes on Wren's face.

And handed it over.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN OPENED THE LANTERN.

She knelt on the step. In front of her mother. With the dented tin lantern on the stone between them. And struck the flint.

Once. Twice. Sparks. On the char-cloth. A glow. She blew on it. Gently. The way Lex said good morning to the fire. She held the glow to the wick.

The wick caught.

A little flame. Small. Gold. In the tin lantern with the cracked horn pane mended with birch-bark. On the step of a narrow house on Fennel Street, in the dark city, under the glitter.

And overhead, the glitter *turned*.

She felt it. Everyone felt it. A shift. A ripple. Through the whole great grey-gold ceiling of moths over Highcrest. Turning. Toward the little flame. The only light in the Lower Town. The only light in the city except the gold one at the top of the hill.

They started to come down.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN DIDN'T LOOK UP.

She closed the lantern. Very carefully. The little latch, the one that always stuck, that Da had bent the winter before he died. And picked it up.

And didn't set it in the window.

She put it in her mother's hands.

Into her lap. Into her slack empty upturned palms. And closed her mother's fingers round the handle, one by one, the way you'd close a child's fingers round a coin.

Not a light left on. Not waiting. Not for someone who wasn't home.

Given.

"*Mam*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

HER MOTHER DIDN'T MOVE.

Overhead, the moths were coming. A slow grey-gold slide, down out of the ceiling, like snow sliding off a roof. Toward the lantern. Toward the little flame in her mother's hands.

"*Mam*," said Wren again. Kneeling. With her hands over her mother's hands. Over the lantern. "*Maren Ashdown. Of Thistledown. And Fennel Street. It's me. It's Wren.*"

Nothing.

"*I came back*," said Wren. "*Through the snow. With a hare. I was nine. Do you remember? I was gone three days and you lit the lamp and sat by the window, and I came up the street in the dark with a frozen hare, and I opened the door.*" Her voice was shaking. "*And you looked up.*"

The moths were close. She could hear them. Like rain on a roof. Like sand on stone.

"*And your face*," said Wren. "*Mam. Your face. I've never seen anything like it. I never will again. It broke. All of it. Like ice on the river.*" She was crying. She didn't stop. "*And you said, you came back. Oh, Wrennie. You came back.*"

The first moth reached the lantern.

It settled on the horn pane. On the birch-bark. Grey-gold. Wings spread. And pressed against the little flame inside. And *drank*.

And got nothing.

Wren felt it. Felt the moth press and pull and find nothing. Felt it flutter. Confused. And try again. And find nothing.

Because it's given, she thought. *It's not waiting. It's hers. I gave it to her. It's already someone's.*

"*I came back*," said Wren Ashdown. To her mother. Kneeling on the step. With her hands round her mother's hands round the lantern. "*Mam. I came back. I'm here. I'm home. Look at me.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HER MOTHER BLINKED.

Once. Slowly. Like someone waking from a very long sleep.

Her eyes moved. Off the Spire. Off the gold light at the top of the hill. Down.

To the lantern. In her hands. Lit. Small. Gold.

And then up.

To Wren's face.

And they weren't dim.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T HAPPEN ALL at once. Not like the lanterns in the Hollowmaw, when Seren walked past. Not like a lamp being lit.

It happened the way ice breaks on a river in spring.

A crack. Somewhere deep. A sound you feel more than hear. And then another. And then the whole surface going at once, breaking, heaving, groaning, and the dark water underneath showing through, moving, *alive—*

Her mother's face broke.

All of it. Every part of it. At once.

And under it, so bright and so warm and so enormous that Wren Ashdown, twenty-five, four months gone, kneeling on a step in a dark city under a sky full of moths, was nine years old again, and not cold at all—

"*Wrennie*," said Maren Ashdown.

Her voice was a croak. Four days unused.

"*Oh, Wrennie. You came back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN COULDN'T SPEAK.

She put her face down on her mother's knees. On the lantern. On their hands. And cried. The way she'd cried on this step five years ago, when she

came home from the Greyspine with a smith. The way she never cried. The way Lex said she never cried, and was always wrong.

Her mother's hand came up. Off the lantern. Slowly. Shaking. And went into her hair. Into her fox-red braid. And held on.

"*What happened*?" said Maren. Faintly. "*Wren. What happened? I was—I was waiting. On the step. For you. And then there was a light. Up the hill. And it was so warm. And I thought it was you.*" Her hand tightened. "*I thought it was you coming home.*"

"*It wasn't me*."

"*No*." Her mother looked down at her. With her own eyes. Green. Wren's eyes. Clear. Wet. "*No. This is you. That was—*" She stopped. Frowned. "*I don't know what that was.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ELOWEN WAS BESIDE THEM.

Kneeling. With Oathkeeper across her knees. And her hard grey face doing something Wren had never seen it do.

"*Wren*," she said. Very quietly. "*Wren. Look up.*"

Wren looked up.

The moths were still coming. Down out of the glitter. Slowly. A great grey-gold slide. Toward the lantern in her mother's hands.

And every one that reached it—

Fell.

Not burned. Not crumpled. Not like Lex's black heat.

They reached the lantern. And pressed against it. And drank. And got nothing. And pressed again. And got nothing.

And then they just—*stopped*. Hung in the air. Wings still. Confused. Starving. In front of a light they could see and couldn't drink.

And fell. Slowly. Like leaves. Onto the step. Onto the street. Into the gutter.

And didn't get up.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's given*," said Wren. Hoarse. Staring at them. "*It's hers. I gave it to her. They can't drink it.*" She looked at her mother. "*And she was waiting for me. And I came. So it's not waiting anymore.*"

"*It's kept*," said Pim.

Everyone looked at him.

He was standing on the step behind them. Small. Solemn. Looking at the lantern with his grey-violet eyes.

"*The promise*," said Pim. "*She lit it for you to come back. And you came back. So it's kept.*" He looked at the moths, falling. "*Like Master Antho's six. In the drowned city. Like the lamp-lady's.*"

He looked at Wren.

"*They can only drink the waiting*," said Pim. "*When the waiting's done, there's nothing left to drink.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

TAM TOOK LONGER.

He was twelve. Wren didn't know him as well. She'd been gone so much. Five years of mountains and Wellworlds and the bottom of the world. He'd been seven when she left. He was twelve now. A stranger. Thin and gangly and freckled, with a voice that was starting to crack.

She didn't know what his warm thing was.

Robbie did.

"*The kite*," said Robbie. Kneeling on the step beside his brother. Fierce. With his gap-toothed face set. "*It's the kite. Last spring. You made it, Tam. Out of Mam's old petticoat and some willow. And it wouldn't fly. And you tried for a week. And it wouldn't. And then Wren came home.*"

Wren went still.

"*And she looked at it*," said Robbie. "*And she said, let me try. And she held it up. And the wind came. Her wind. And it went up. So high. Over the river. Over the walls. And you were holding the string.*" His voice cracked. "*And you laughed, Tam. You laughed like a donkey. You laughed so loud the widow Abel came out.*"

He took the dark lantern Wren held out to him. The second one. From the window. Another tin one. Lit it from their mother's. Closed it. Put it in his brother's slack hands.

"*Tam*," said Robbie Ashdown. Nine. Gap-toothed. Furious. "*Tam, you idiot. The kite flew. Wren made it fly. You were holding the string. Look at me.*"

And Tam blinked.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY STAYED ON THE step for a long time.

All four of them. Wren and her mother and her two brothers. Squashed together. On a step made for one. With two lit lanterns in their laps and moths falling round them like autumn leaves.

Elowen kept watch. And Ilse and Ivo, who had dropped their illusions and were sitting in the gutter holding hands and crying, both of them, and not ashamed. And Pim, who stood at the bottom of the step with his hands in his pockets, watching the moths fall.

Up and down Fennel Street, the dimmed stood in their doorways. Facing north. Swaying. With their dark lanterns held up.

The cobbler. The widow Abel and her cat. The Fenwicks' apprentice.

Not one of them turned.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It has to be someone who loves them*," said Wren.

Later. When her mother was leaning against her shoulder, drinking water from a cup Ilse had found, and Tam was sitting with his head on his knees, shaking, and Robbie was holding his hand.

"*It has to be someone who knows*," she said. "*What the warm thing is. What was taken. I couldn't do it for the widow Abel. I don't know her warm thing. Pim couldn't do it for Mam.*" She looked at the street. At the dimmed. At the hundreds of them, the thousands, all over Highcrest. "*It has to be family. Or a friend. Someone who listened.*"

"*And a lamp*," said Elowen.

"*And a lamp. Given. Not waiting. Put in their hands.*" Wren looked at the tin lantern in her mother's lap. "*And their name. And the warm thing, said out loud. Given back.*"

"*Every one of them*," said Ilse. From the gutter. Very quietly. "*Every single person in this city. Someone has to come and find them. And sit with them. And remember.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Thousands*."

"*Yes*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Thousands.*"

She looked up the hill. At the Spire. At the gold light in every window.

"*Then we'll need thousands*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN THE MOTHS stopped falling.

Wren felt it. A change. In the air. In the glitter overhead. The great slow turning of it, over the whole of Highcrest, going still. All at once. Like a flock of starlings in the moment before it turns.

She looked up.

Something was coming down out of it.

Big. Heavy. Broad-shouldered. With wings. Grey-gold. Ragged. Strong. Beating. Carrying a man the size of a bear down out of the glitter over Fennel Street as easily as a hawk.

A miner's pick in one hand.

His eyes were lit.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILAS HASK CAME DOWN in the middle of Fennel Street.

Lightly. On his toes. Like a moth on a window. His great wings folding. The dimmed in the doorways on either side of him didn't turn. Didn't look. Didn't see.

He looked at the step.

At the green door. At the four people squashed onto the step. At the two lit lanterns. At the moths lying dead in the street round them like leaves.

At Wren.

He looked at her for a long time. With his gold eyes. At her face. At her hand. Flat. On her stomach.

"*She said you'd come*," said Silas Hask.

Elowen was on her feet. Oathkeeper up. Between him and the step.

Hask didn't look at her.

"*She said*," he said, "*the tracker will come for her mother. They always come for their mothers. She said, Silas, when the tracker comes, bring her to me.*"

He looked at the lanterns. At the dead moths.

"*She didn't say anything about this*," said Hask. Slowly. "*She didn't say anything about people waking up.*"

He looked back at Wren.

"*How did you do that*?" he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN STOOD UP.

She didn't know why. Elowen was in front of her. Pim was beside her. She should have stayed sitting. She should have kept her hand on her mother's and her eyes on the ground and let the knight with the oath-sword deal with the winged man with the pick.

She stood up.

And looked at him. Past Elowen's shoulder. At his heavy weathered face. At his lit eyes. At his chest, rising and falling, deep and easy, with no rattle in it at all.

"*I gave it back*," said Wren. "*What she took. I knew what it was. I gave it back.*"

"*What was it*?"

"*Me*." She looked at her mother. "*Coming home. Through the snow. When I was nine.*"

Hask didn't say anything.

"*Everyone she's taken*," said Wren. "*Every one. Somebody knows. What was taken. Somebody who loves them.*" She looked at him. "*Somebody could give it back.*"

Silas Hask looked at her for a long time.

And Wren saw something in his face. Behind the gold. Deep. Far back. Like a man standing a long way back from a window in a dark room.

"*Who's yours*?" she said.

He went very still.

"*Your warm thing*," said Wren. "*Before. Before her. Before the wings and the sip and the breathing. Your sister. Your da. Your mam. Who knew what it was? Who'd have come for you?*"

Hask didn't answer.

He looked at the lantern in Maren Ashdown's lap. Lit. Given. With dead moths round it.

"*Nobody*," said Silas Hask. "*They're all dead.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LIFTED HIS PICK.

Not at her. At the sky. At the glitter. He held it up. Over his head. Like a man holding up a lamp.

And the glitter answered.

It came down. All of it. The whole great grey-gold ceiling over Fennel Street. Not slowly now. Not drifting. *Falling*. Like a wall. Like a wave breaking.

"*She wants you*," said Hask. Very quietly. Under the roar of wings. "*Tracker. Not your mam. Not your brothers. You.*" He looked at her hand. On her stomach. "*And what you're carrying.*"

"*Wren*!" Elowen was shouting. "*Wren, GO—*"

Wren didn't go.

She stood on her mother's step on Fennel Street, with the moths coming down like a wall and Silas Hask in front of her with his pick held up and his gold eyes on her stomach.

And opened her mouth.

And *whistled*.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWO NOTES. HIGH. SHARP. A bird call. The one she'd used in the Greyspine five years ago, on the way up to the Hollowmaw, to tell a clumsy smith *stop. Danger. Come.*

And she put the wind in it.

All of it. Everything she had. Gale, Commanding. The First Breath, the last of it, that had lived in her lungs since the eye of the storm. She put it in two notes and sent them up. Out of Fennel Street. Out of the Lower Town. Out of the glitter. Over the walls of Highcrest. North. Over the downs. Over the Vale.

To Ashbourne.

To a forge. To a long hall with twenty anvils. To a man sitting by the great hearth with a map of the Blightmarch and a cup of cold tea, thinking about sand.

Stop. Danger. Come.

Hammer. Come.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS HIT.

And Silas Hask, standing in the middle of Fennel Street with his pick held up like a lamp, looked at the tracker on the step. Whistling. With the wind pouring out of her. With her hair coming loose and her green eyes blazing and one hand flat on her stomach.

And for one moment, one breath, before the wall of moths came down between them—

He lowered the pick.

Just a little. An inch.

As if he'd heard a bird call from somewhere very far off. From a long time ago. From a grey town in a grey valley, where a little girl with grey on her lips used to whistle at the window when he came home from the pits.

Stop. Danger. Come.

And then the moths came down.

And Wren couldn't see him anymore.

CHAPTER 25

The Uncapped Man

LEX HEARD IT OVER the hammers.

He was in the long hall. At the great hearth. With Seraphine's map of the Blightmarch spread on the anvil in front of him and Brannoc on one side and Grandmother Asha on the other, arguing about sand. Twenty anvils going behind him. Forty students. The whole long hall ringing like a bell-tower at a wedding.

And through it, over it, under it, coming in through the open doors and the open windows and the great brick chimney, from very far off—

Two notes.

High. Sharp. A bird call.

Stop. Danger. Come.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS ON HIS feet before he knew it.

The map went off the anvil. Grandmother Asha's tea went over. Brannoc said something that was certainly not a hymn. The hammers stopped. One by one. Down the long hall. Twenty of them. Until the only sound was the great hearth crackling and the wind.

The wind.

It came in through the doors. Through the windows. Down the chimney. Warm. Soft. Wrong. Not from the north, where the summer wind always came from in the Vale. From the south. From Highcrest. Carrying something in it. A smell. Smoke and river-mud and old stone and dust.

Plums.

And under it, very faint, so faint he wasn't sure he heard it at all, a voice. Hers. Not words. Just the shape of her. The way she shifted her weight from foot to foot when she'd been standing still too long. The creak of her bow-string.

Frightened.

"*Wren*," said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN WAS ON THE chapel green.

She'd been sleeping there for a week. Curled round the old cracked Stone like a cat round a hearth, with the village children climbing all over her and Quill sulking on her horns. She lifted her great blue head when he came out of the forge yard at a run. Her golden eye was already on him.

She'd heard it too.

She didn't wait for a saddle. She didn't wait for Brannoc's chair. She lowered her neck and he was on it, gripping the ridge of scale behind her head with both hands, and she went up off the green in a single leap that cracked the chapel windows and sent every child on the green flat on their backs, shrieking with delight.

And turned south.

And *flew*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D FLOWN FAST BEFORE. On Ashka, on the night of the Blade. On Vharuun, coming out of the Rift. He'd flown so fast the wind tore tears out of his eyes and froze them on his face.

He'd never flown like this.

The Vale went by under them like a ribbon pulled through a fist. The river. The fields. Millbridge. The downs. Green and gold and green. The storm-mother's wings beat so hard the air round them cracked like thunder, and lightning ran along the edges of her scales in long blue threads, and she didn't climb and she didn't glide and she didn't rest.

She went straight. South. Toward the glitter on the horizon.

[Lex,] said Ember.

I know.

[Lex, she's—]

I know.

[No. Listen. The wind. It's not just Wren. There's something else in it.]

Lex listened.

And under Wren's fear, under the plums and the river-mud, something else. Small. Quick. Like a bird's heart. Like a little drum, very far off.

Beating fast.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW HIGHCREST FROM twenty miles off.

The lid of glitter. The dark city under it. The Spire, lit from every window, gold.

And in the Lower Town, near the river, something else.

A *storm*.

Small. Tight. Fierce. A whirl of wind and dust and grey-gold, spinning in one narrow street like a waterspout. He could see it from twenty miles. The glitter round it, the great slow ceiling, was being dragged down into it. Sucked in. Torn apart. Spat out. Round and round.

Wren.

Holding a street. Alone. Against a sky.

◆ ◆ ◆

VHARUUN DIDN'T SLOW DOWN.

She came over the walls of Highcrest at a height of fifty feet, with her wings half-folded and lightning crackling off every edge of her, and the glitter over the city *recoiled*. All of it. A great flinch. The way a hand flinches off a hot stove. The moths nearest her burned. Instantly. Bright. Like sparks. And the ones behind them saw the light, saw the lightning, saw a storm-mother made of sky coming down on them like the end of the world, and turned.

Toward her.

Toward the light.

"*Up*!" Lex shouted. "*Vharuun, go up! Take them up! Take them away from the street!*"

She heard him. She went up. Straight up. Out of the glitter. Into the blue above it. Blazing. Crackling. A beacon.

And the moths followed her.

Not all of them. A great many. A river of grey-gold, pouring up out of the ceiling over the Lower Town after the dragon, like smoke up a chimney. Leaving a hole. A gap in the glitter. Over Fennel Street.

And Lex let go.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELL.

Fifty feet. Through the hole. Toward the street. With the wind roaring in his ears and the glitter on every side of him and the Lower Town coming up at him, narrow roofs and narrow streets, tall thin houses leaning together overhead.

He didn't have Wren's wind. He'd never learned to Windstep properly. He always landed in a hedge.

He asked the Stone instead.

Catch me.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STREET CAUGHT HIM.

Not softly. Stone is never soft. But *kindly*. The cobbles of Fennel Street rose up under him as he came down, a hump, a wave, like a pillow being plumped, and he hit it and rolled and the stone gave a little and took the force of the fall the way a blacksmith's arm takes the shock of a hammer-blow, and then let him go.

He came up on one knee. In the middle of Fennel Street. In a ring of buckled cobbles.

In front of a green door. Third from the end.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE ON THE step.

Four of them. Squashed together. A thin grey-threaded woman with a stick. A gangly freckled boy of twelve. A gap-toothed red-haired boy of nine. Holding two lit lanterns between them. Tin. Dented. With moths lying dead round their feet like leaves.

And in front of them, in the street, with her bow in one hand and nothing in the other and her hair loose and blazing and the wind coming

out of her in a whirl that had dragged half the sky down into Fennel Street—

Wren.

She was whistling.

Still. He could hear it. Under the roar. Two notes. Over and over. Hoarse now. Cracking. *Stop. Danger. Come.* Pouring the wind out of herself. Holding the moths off the step. Off her mother. Off her brothers. Off the lanterns.

She saw him.

The whistle stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIND DROPPED.

All at once. Like a sail when the sheet's cut. The whirl round Fennel Street sagged. Slowed. The glitter overhead started to come back down. Slowly.

And Wren swayed.

He was there. He didn't know how. He was across the buckled cobbles and he had her. Before she fell. In both arms. Against his chest. She was shaking so hard her teeth were going.

"*You came*," said Wren. Into his coat. Hoarse. Her voice nearly gone.

"*You whistled*."

"*From Highcrest*." She was laughing. Or crying. He couldn't tell. "*From Highcrest to Ashbourne. A hundred miles. I didn't know if it'd work.*"

"*It worked*."

"*Good*." She sagged against him. "*Good. Because I've got nothing left. Not a breath. Not a puff. I couldn't blow out a candle.*" Her hand found his. Pulled it. Down. Flat. Onto her stomach. "*Lex. Lex. It's fast. Feel it. I can feel it. It's going so fast.*"

He couldn't feel anything. It was too early. Too small.

He felt it anyway.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*."

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED UP.

Over Wren's head. Down Fennel Street.

Elowen Dunmore was on one knee in the gutter. With Oathkeeper in both hands. Bleeding from a cut over her eye. Ilse and Ivo were behind her, in a doorway, white-faced, holding each other. Pim was standing on the step in front of Wren's mother. Small. Silent. With his arms spread.

And in the middle of the street, twenty yards off, with his wings folded and his pick on his shoulder and the glitter coming down round him like snow—

Silas Hask.

He was bleeding too. A long scratch down one cheek. Elowen's work, Lex thought. His patched leather coat was torn. One of his great grey-gold wings had a rent in it.

He was looking at Lex.

"*She whistled*," said Hask. "*And you came.*" He shook his head. Slowly. "*A hundred miles. In an hour.*"

"*Less*."

"*Less*." Hask looked at Wren. In Lex's arms. With his gold eyes. "*She held the street the whole time. Against all of it. Against me. With a baby in her and no arrows left.*" Something moved in his face. "*Never seen anything like it. Not in twenty-six years down the pits.*"

"*Then let her go*."

"*Can't*." Hask shifted the pick on his shoulder. "*She wants her. You know that. She told you herself. On the gate.*" His voice was very quiet. "*And anything of yours.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT WREN DOWN.

Gently. On the step. Beside her mother. Who took her. Who put her thin arms round her daughter and pulled her close and looked up at Lex over Wren's head with her green eyes, Wren's eyes, very hard.

"*Hammer*," said Maren Ashdown.

"*Ma'am*."

"*Don't try*," said Wren's mother. "*Do.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED ROUND.

And walked down Fennel Street.

Not fast. Not running. Walking. The way he'd walked through the Mothwing in the deep. The way Brannoc walked up to a forge in the morning, knowing what the day was going to be. With his fire coming up. Not gold. Not bright.

Dark.

Black heat. Pouring off him. Rippling the air. The dead moths in the gutter curling as he passed. The cobbles under his boots ticking, the way stone ticks when it's too hot.

Hask watched him come.

He didn't move. He didn't spread his wings. He stood in the middle of the street with his pick on his shoulder and watched Lex come, the way a miner watches a seam he's about to work.

"*You're angry*," said Hask.

"*Yes*."

"*Good*." The big man smiled. Slightly. "*Angry's easier. Angry's got faults all over it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

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SILAS HASK — Level 86 → 88
"He has been eating moths' light for
 four days. It agrees with him."
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LEX VEY — Level 93
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◆ ◆ ◆

HASK MOVED FIRST.

Lex didn't see it. He *felt* it. The way you feel a roof start to go before you hear it crack. A shift. A change in the air. And then the pick was coming at his head from the left, fast, so fast, a miner's swing, short and hard and absolutely precise—

Not at his head.

At his *face*.

At the left side. At the cheek. At the handprint.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE GOT HIS ARM up. Just. The pick took him on the forearm instead. The flat of it. Not the point. It didn't cut. It hit like a falling beam, and something in his arm *went*, and he staggered sideways into the wall of the cobbler's house.

And his fire stuttered.

The black heat. It flickered. Went thin. For a moment, a breath, gold came through it. Bright. Like a forge door opening.

And the glitter overhead saw it.

And came down.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Fault*," said Silas Hask. Mildly. Stepping back. "*There. On your face. Where she touched you.*" He tapped the side of his own cheek with one big scarred finger. "*Every seam's got one. Every wall. Every man.*" He tilted his head. "*She put yours there for me. Didn't she. Like a chalk mark on a pit-prop. Hit here.*"

Lex pushed himself off the wall.

His arm hurt. Badly. Not broken. Cracked, maybe. His fire was coming back. Dark. Slower than before. He could feel the place on his cheek. The handprint. Cool. Smooth. Like the inside of a shell.

Like a hole in a bucket, he thought. *Like a crack in a crucible.*

Where the heat gets out.

[He's right,] said Ember. Very quietly. *[Lex. He's right. I can feel it. When he hit near it. Your fire went toward it. Like water toward a drain.]*

I know.

[She marked you so you'd leak.]

I know.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS WERE COMING down. Thick. Round him. He burned them. They came anyway. Not at him. Past him. Toward the step. Toward the two lit lanterns in Maren Ashdown's lap. Toward Wren.

Pim was holding them. Lex could feel it. The room. The silence. Round the step. Round the lanterns. The moths parting round it, like water round a stone.

But Pim was tired. Lex could feel that too.

Not long, he thought. *He can't hold it long.*

He turned back to Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Why?*" said Lex.

Hask looked at him.

"*Why her?*" said Lex. "*You said it yourself. She held the street. With a baby in her. With no arrows.*" He wiped his mouth. There was blood on his hand. He didn't know where it came from. "*You said you'd never seen anything like it. And you're going to take her up that hill and give her to the Moth.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*Why?*"

Silas Hask was quiet for a long moment.

"*Because your father killed my family*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE STREET WENT VERY still.

Even the moths seemed to slow.

"*She told me*," said Hask. "*Two nights ago. In his room. At the top of the Spire. She was reading his books.*" His gold eyes didn't move off Lex's face. "*The grey ones. Two hundred years of them. She read me one page. Out loud. In his handwriting.*"

He shifted the pick.

"*Vhessa*," he said. "*Twenty-one years ago. At the Great Stone. A Rewrite, he called it. To break every Ceiling in the world. In one stroke.*" His voice didn't change. "*And it tore. And the grey came through. And it went down into the deep seams at Coldwater. Into the coal. Into the air.*"

He breathed in. Deep. All the way down. With no rattle.

"*Into my da*," said Silas Hask. "*And my mam. And my sister. Nell. She was eight. She used to whistle at the window when I came home from the pits.*" He looked at Wren. On the step. "*Like that. Two notes. Exactly like that.*"

Lex couldn't move.

"*He wrote it down*," said Hask. "*Your da. In his little grey book. In his little neat hand.* Vhessa, *he wrote.* Rewrite failed. Breach opened. Estimated losses, eastern march: eleven thousand in the first year. *And then a line. And then the price of bread in Highcrest that autumn.*"

His gold eyes were very bright.

"*Eleven thousand*," he said. "*In a column. Between a line and the price of bread.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

There wasn't anything to say.

He'd stood in a chamber at Duskhold, five years ago, and heard his father confess. *I tore it*. He'd stood beside him and his brother while the three of them closed the breach with blood. He'd heard the World Notice. *The Vhessa Breach is closed.*

He'd never once thought about Coldwater.

Not really. Not the people in it. Not the miners with grey on their lips. Not a girl of eight who whistled at a window.

He'd Unbound them. Two summers ago. In the rain. Four thousand of them. He'd stood at their Stone and put his hand on it and felt them go up like mine-damp. And flown away. On a dragon. Pleased with himself.

And never once thought: *these are the people my father's breach was killing*.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's dying*," said Lex.

Hask looked at him.

"*My father*," said Lex. "*He's dying. He's eighty-three. He has a season left. Maybe less. He can't walk. He can barely hold a cup.*" His voice was rough. "*He knows. About Vhessa. He's known for twenty-one years. He wrote it down because that's what he does. That's how he carries things. In columns.*" He swallowed. "*He's spent twenty-one years trying to make it right. Five years ago he closed it with his own blood. He sat in a crystal for fifteen years holding the breaches shut from inside the net.*"

"*Doesn't bring Nell back*."

"*No*," said Lex. "*It doesn't.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*So which of you do I owe*?" said Silas Hask.

He said it quietly. Not angry. Tired. The way a man asks a question he's been asking himself every night in the dark for a long time.

"*Your da, who killed them*?" he said. "*You, who set me free?*" He looked down at his own glowing hands. "*Her, who gave me breath?*"

Lex looked at him.

At the big man in the middle of Fennel Street with grey-gold wings folded down his back and a miner's pick on his shoulder and lit eyes in his heavy weathered face. Level eighty-eight. In two years. From a Common hewer capped at twenty-four.

Breathing. All the way down. For the first time in twenty-six years.

"*Nobody*," said Lex.

Hask's eyes narrowed.

"*You don't owe anyone*," said Lex Vey. "*Not him. Not me. Not her.*" He took a step forward. Black heat rippling. "*That's what free means, Silas. That's what I took off you at the Stone. Not the Ceiling. The* owing. *Nobody puts their hand on your shoulder and pushes down. Nobody gets to say what you owe them.*"

He took another step.

"*Not even her*," he said. "*Especially not her.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK SWUNG.

Lex was ready this time. He didn't block. He *stepped in*. Inside the swing. The way Garrick had taught him, five years ago, on the Old Founders' Road, with a stick. *Never stand where a man wants you to stand, lad. Stand where he doesn't.*

The pick went past his ear. He felt the wind of it.

And he put his hand flat on Hask's chest.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T STRIKE.

He didn't burn.

He *listened*.

The way he'd listened to the lined wolf in the Delve. The way he'd listened to the little one in the gold room. The way the Hearth had taught him, in the Wellworld of Flame. *What do you burn for*?

He listened to Silas Hask.

And found the flaw.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS IN THE middle. Of course it was. Where it always was.

Where the breath went in. Where the light went in. Where Maelis had put it, the sip, the second sip, the bigger one, out of what she'd brought up from the deep. Out of the little one.

It was going in. Through Hask's chest. Through his lungs. Holding up his wings. Burning in his eyes.

And it was going *out*.

Slowly. Steadily. Through a place in the middle of him. Like water through a sieve. Like heat through a crack in a crucible.

Leaking.

Not as fast as Maelis. Not nearly. But leaking. Out of the middle. Out of a hollow place where something had been taken out and nothing had been put back.

Lex knew what it was.

He'd felt it once before. In a cave in the Greyspine. In his brother. In the place where a seal had broken and the Murmur had come through.

A crack, thought Lex. *A crack where the dark came in. Where the grief came in. Where a girl of eight who whistled at the window used to be.*

She didn't fill it. She just poured light into a cracked cup.

And now he has to keep coming back to her for more.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULD STRIKE IT.

He knew he could. Aurelian's little hammer was in his coat. One tap. *Tink*. On the flaw. On the crack. And it would open. And everything she'd poured into him would pour out. All at once. The light. The breath. The wings.

And the grey would come back.

Into his lungs. Into his chest. Twenty-six years of coal-dust and Gloam. All of it. At once. Like a dam breaking.

He'd die. In the street. In front of everyone. Coughing grey.

Like Nell.

Lex took his hand off Hask's chest.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK STARED AT HIM.

They were standing very close. Chest to chest, nearly. In the middle of Fennel Street. With the moths coming down round them and the step behind and the dead in the doorways on either side, swaying.

"*You found it*," said Silas Hask. Very quietly. "*Didn't you. The fault. In me.*"

"*Yes*."

"*Where*?"

"*In the middle*." Lex looked at him. "*Where she poured. It's leaking. It's always going to leak. You'll have to keep going back to her for more.*" He didn't look away. "*Forever. Like she has to keep going back to the Well.*"

Hask didn't say anything.

"*I could open it*," said Lex. "*One tap. And it'd all go. Everything she gave you.*" His voice was very quiet. "*And the grey would come back. All of it. At once.*"

"*Then do it*."

"*No*."

"*Do it*." Hask's gold eyes were very bright. "*You've got the hammer. I've seen it. The little one. Do it, smith. End it. Here. In the street. I've got her in me and I've got your da's breach in me and I've got Nell in me and I can't—*"

He stopped.

"*I can't tell which is which anymore*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STEPPED BACK.

One step. Out of reach of the pick. Out of reach of the man.

"*I'm not going to do it*," he said.

"*Why not*?"

"*Because you held the pick down*," said Lex. "*Wren saw. When she whistled. Just before the moths came. You lowered it. An inch.*" He looked at Hask. "*You heard Nell.*"

The big man's face did something.

"*Somebody knows your warm thing*," said Lex. "*Wren asked you. Who'd have come for you. You said nobody. They're all dead.*" He shook his head. "*That's not true. I know it now. Two notes. At a window. When you came home from the pits.*" He swallowed. "*I know it. Wren knows it. That's two people.*"

Hask didn't move.

"*When you're ready*," said Lex Vey. "*When you've had enough of going back to her for more. When you want to stop leaking.*" He looked at him. "*Come and find us. And somebody'll light you a lamp. And put it in your hands. And whistle.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS STOPPED.

All at once. Overhead. The glitter. Going still. The way it went still when she was coming.

Lex looked up.

So did Hask.

There was nothing there. No woman with lit eyes. No wings. Only the glitter, hanging, still, over Fennel Street. And at the top of the hill, through it, the Spire. Lit. Gold. Every window.

And in the top window, the brightest, something *moved*.

Lex couldn't see it. It was too far. But he felt it. The way you feel someone look at you across a crowded room.

Watching.

Hask felt it too. Lex saw his face change. Saw the big man's shoulders go tight. Saw his wings shift, under the torn leather, the way a dog's hackles rise.

"*She's calling*," said Silas Hask. Very low.

"*Don't go*."

"*I have to*." Hask looked down at his own glowing hands. "*It's going out of me. I can feel it now. Now you've said it. I can feel it going.*" His voice was very quiet. "*I need more.*"

"*Silas—*"

"*Smith*." Hask looked at him. And for a moment, just a moment, the gold in his eyes went dim. Not dimmed. Dim. Like a man standing a long way back from a window. "*She doesn't need your wife. Not yet. Not tonight.*" He swallowed. "*She's patient. She takes what she needs first. And then she comes back for the rest.*"

"*What does she need first*?"

Hask didn't answer.

He spread his wings.

"*Look after the tracker*," said Silas Hask. "*She held a street against the sky.*"

And went up. Into the glitter. Toward the gold light at the top of the hill.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Level 93 → 94
"He found the fault. He didn't strike
 it. The net has no category for this.
 It has made one."
New title: [The One Who Didn't]
```

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY GOT OUT AT dusk.

Through the sally port. All of them. Wren carried in Lex's arms, too tired to walk, with her head on his shoulder and her eyes shut and her hand on her stomach. Maren Ashdown on Elowen's arm. Tam and Robbie between the twins. Pim at the back. Small. Silent. Grey with tiredness. Holding the two lit lanterns. One in each hand.

The moths didn't follow.

Lex kept looking back. All the way down the tunnel. All the way to the ditch at the bottom of the north wall, where Vharuun was waiting, blazing,

crackling, with half the glitter of Highcrest still circling her, burning, falling.

They didn't follow.

◆ ◆ ◆

She takes what she needs first.

He thought about it all the way home. On Vharuun's neck. In the dark. With Wren asleep against his chest and her mother asleep against Elowen and the boys asleep against each other and the twins awake, holding hands, staring at the stars.

And then she comes back for the rest.

What does she need first?

He knew. He'd known since the Hall of Lanterns. Since the gate. *Bring me the blood. All of it. Every drop of Harrow in the world. Your mother. Your brother. You.*

And anything of yours.

Not yet, Hask had said. *Not tonight. She takes what she needs first.*

The blood, thought Lex. *She needs the blood first. To open the Veil. Before Lantern Night. Before the little one comes up. So her brothers and sisters can come through in time for the feast.*

And there are three of us.

Me. Antho. Mam.

He looked north. Toward the Greyspine. Toward the Hollowmaw. Toward a cave full of lanterns at the top of a mountain, a hundred miles off.

Where his mother was.

Sitting by a window. With a clay lamp on the sill. Lit.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember. Very quietly. In his hearth.

I know.

[He told you.] *The coal was glowing.* [*Hask. He knew what she was going to do. He told you as much as he could without saying it.*]

I know.

[Lex. The Keep. Your mother—]

I know.

He leaned down. Over Vharuun's great blue neck. Over his sleeping wife. And put his mouth close to the dragon's ear, the way Antho did, the way Pim did.

"*Faster*," he said.

And the storm-mother, who had flown from Ashbourne to Highcrest in less than an hour, and fought half the sky over the Lower Town, and was so tired her lightning had gone out and her wings were shaking—

Went faster.

CHAPTER 26

Moths at the Keep

ANTHO WAS AT THE door when they came.

He was always at the door now. At midnight. Every night. Since his mother came home. He'd taken it over from his father, the way you take over a job from an old man whose hands have started to shake. He went down the long passage with the copper oil-flask and filled the three lamps in the niche. The clay one, which wasn't the clay one anymore, which was a new one Seraphine had found in the Ashbourne market, because the real one was on the kitchen windowsill now, in his mother's keeping. The iron one. The *ARDENT* one.

And he put his hand on the black glass. And listened.

[...brother...]

Evening, he thought. *How is it?*

[...the Warden told me the one about the miller's cat again...]

Again?

[...I asked...it's my favorite...the cat wears boots...]

Antho smiled. In the dark. With his hand on the door. He couldn't help it.

[...brother...]

Mm.

[...something's coming...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT A moment after.

Not through the door. Through the mountain. Through the long passage behind him, and the lanterns, and the cave mouth, and the slope. The Threshold. The place he stood. All of it, at once, the way you feel a draft from a door that's been left open three rooms away.

Something was coming in.

Not up. Not from the deep. *In*. From the world. From outside. Over the Greyspine. Down onto the slope. Toward the cave mouth.

Toward the light.

He took his hand off the glass.

And ran.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS HALFWAY UP the passage when the first lantern went dark.

He felt it before he saw it. He always did now. A thousand and thirteen lanterns, and he could feel every one, the way you can feel every tooth in your mouth. One went. Near the top. Near the cave mouth. Just *went*. Like a candle in a draft.

Then another. Then five. Then twenty.

Going dark. One after another. Coming down the passage toward him. Like a tide coming in.

"*SERAPHINE*!"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE KEEP WAS WAKING.

He heard it all round him as he ran. Doors banging. Feet on stone. Students shouting. Odile's voice, low and sharp, giving orders. The Millbridge twins. Cass. Teo's old fish-buckets going over somewhere with a crash.

And under it all, coming down the passage from the cave mouth, a sound.

Like rain on a roof.

Like sand on stone.

Like wings.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE REACHED THE KITCHEN.

It was the first room off the passage. Halfway up. Where the long passage widened and the side-caves opened out. The kitchen and the library and the cold-room and the little stone rooms where people slept.

His mother was in the kitchen doorway.

In her nightdress. Too long in the hem. Barefoot. With her grey-brown hair loose down her back and the clay lamp in her hand. Lit. Small. Gold. Held up.

His father was behind her. In the wheeled chair. With his blanket and his spectacles and his face white.

"*Antho*," said Seren. Very calmly. "*How many?*"

"*I don't know.*"

"*Lots*?"

"*Lots.*"

She nodded. Once. And her face went the way it had gone in the deep, when the moths came down the shafts. Hard. Cold. Old. The Harrow face.

"*Shut the shutters*," said Seren Vey. "*Light a lamp inside. Get a broom.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN THE passage like smoke.

Antho saw them. Standing in the kitchen doorway with his mother behind him and the Lantern in his hand. He saw them come round the last bend of the passage above. A great slow grey-gold river, pouring down between the walls, over the lanterns, filling the passage from floor to roof. Glittering. Drifting. Every lantern they passed going dark.

Nine hundred, he counted. Without meaning to. *Eight hundred and ninety. Eight hundred and seventy.*

And in the middle of it, walking, pale shapes. With ragged wings. With dim gold eyes. Long hands reaching for the lanterns as they passed.

Mothwing. Dozens.

And behind them, at the back, filling the passage so that he had to stoop under the roof, with his great grey-gold wings folded tight against his back and a miner's pick in one hand—

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO OPENED THE LANTERN.

All of it. Full. Twelve Hush-runes blazing. The deep soft gold of it pouring out down the passage like the light from a door flung open on a winter night. And with it, the hush. The quiet that kept voices out.

The moths hit it.

And stopped. The way they'd stopped on the slope, the first night. Hung there. At the edge of the light. A wall of them. Beating. Drinking.

He felt it. The pull. The Lantern thinning. Like a child sucking the juice from an orange.

"*Odile*!"

She was there. Beside him. With the students. Eight of them. Their eyes going dark. Shade, wrapping round the moths at the edge of the Lantern's light, folding them, holding them.

It didn't hurt them. It never had. It just slowed them down.

"*Master Antho*!" Cass. From the library door. "*The cold-room! They're coming in through the cold-room! Through the bats' way!*"

The bats' way. The crack at the back of the cold-room where the water dripped. Where four hundred bats went in and out every night. Too small for a person.

Not too small for a moth.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Seraphine—*"

"*I've got it*." She was coming out of the library. In her nightgown. With her spectacles crooked and her hair in a plait and an iron cup in each hand. Hush-cups. Pim's. Two of the last ones he'd filled before he went to Highcrest with Wren. "*I've got it. I can hear where they're coming in.*"

"*Seraphine, that's not what they're—*"

"*I know what they're for*." She was already past him. Running. Awkwardly. Toward the cold-room. "*They make room. Let's see what moths make of a room.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T GO AFTER her.

He couldn't go anywhere. He was standing in the kitchen doorway with the Lantern full open and his mother behind him and the moths in front of him and the Mothwing pressing in behind the moths, and if he

moved, the Lantern's light moved with him, and the hush went with it, and the wall of moths came down on the kitchen like a wave.

So he stood.

He was the Threshold Warden. He stood in doorways. That was what he did.

He held this one.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HASK CAME through the moths.

Not round them. Through them. Walking. Stooping under the roof of the passage. His wings folded tight. His pick on his shoulder. The moths parting round him like a curtain round a man stepping onto a stage.

He stopped at the edge of the Lantern's light.

And looked at Antho. With his lit gold eyes.

"*Threshold Warden*," said Silas Hask.

Antho didn't answer.

"*I've heard of you*," said Hask. "*The mad warlock of the Greyspine. Eight years in a cave. Killed your mother.*" His mouth twisted. "*That's what they said in Coldwater. When I was a boy. That's what everyone said.*"

"*They were wrong*."

"*I know*." Hask looked past him. Into the kitchen. At the small woman standing in the doorway behind Antho, in her too-long nightdress, with the clay lamp held up. "*There she is. Alive. Barefoot.*" He looked back at Antho. "*Everyone was wrong about everything, weren't they. Your da wasn't a merchant. You weren't a murderer. She wasn't dead.*"

"*What do you want*?"

"*You know what I want*," said Silas Hask.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HELD THE DOOR.

He felt the Lantern pulling at him. Thinning. The moths at the edge of it, drinking. The Mothwing behind them, pressing. And Hask, in front, with his pick, not pressing at all. Just standing there. Looking.

Fault, thought Antho. *He's looking for the fault. Lex told me. He finds the weak place. In anything.*

What's mine?

He knew. He'd always known.

Alone. I'm weakest when I'm alone. When I'm holding something by myself and there's nobody beside me.

He wasn't alone. Odile was beside him. The students. His mother behind him. His father.

Seraphine, he thought. *Seraphine's in the cold-room. With two cups. Alone.*

He felt it go. A flicker. In the Lantern. In the hush. In him.

Hask saw it.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*There*," said Silas Hask. Mildly. "*That's it.*"

And he didn't strike.

He *stepped back*.

Out of the light. Back into the moths. Into the glitter. Gone. Like a man stepping back into the dark at the edge of a firelit room.

And the moths came forward.

All of them. All at once. Not drifting now. *Pouring*. Down onto the Lantern's light like a river onto a weir. Too many. Too fast. The edge of the gold buckled. Bent. Like a sheet of glass under a weight.

"*Hold it*!" Antho was shouting. "*Odile! Hold the edge! Hold—*"

And from behind him, from the kitchen, his father's voice.

Thin. Old. Cracked.

"*Seren—*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED.

He shouldn't have. He knew it as he did it. He was in a doorway. He was the Threshold Warden. You don't turn round in a doorway.

He turned anyway.

There was a window in the kitchen. Small. High. Cut through the rock of the mountain, looking east. With a clay lamp on the sill. His mother had put it there every night since she came home. The Harrow lamp. Lit. Facing out.

The window was full of moths.

Pressed against the glass from outside. Hundreds. Thousands. So thick the glass was gone, and in its place a wall of grey-gold wings. Pressing. Pushing.

And the glass was *bending*.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT BROKE.

Not like glass breaks. It didn't shatter. It *gave*. Softly. Like ice going rotten in spring. Like a window that's had something leaning on it for a very long time. The glass went soft and grey and glittering, and then it wasn't glass, it was dust, and the dust fell inward onto the sill and the floor.

And through the hole where the window had been came pale shapes.

Three of them. Mothwing. Thin. Ragged. With long hands and dim eyes. Squeezing in through the window the way a moth squeezes through a gap in a shutter. Folded. Patient.

Onto the sill. Past the clay lamp. Down into the kitchen.

Toward his mother.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER GOT THERE first.

Antho would never know how. His father couldn't walk. He couldn't stand. He'd been in a wheeled chair for two weeks.

He got there first.

Out of the chair. Onto his feet. With his stick. Three steps across the kitchen floor, staggering, his thin legs shaking under him, his white hair flying, his face set. Between the Mothwing and his wife.

And swung the stick.

It wasn't much of a swing. He was eighty-three. He'd never been a fighter. He'd been a Warden-Architect, a scholar, a man of ledgers and council chambers. He swung the stick the way an old man swings a stick at a dog.

It hit the first Mothwing on the side of the head.

And the Mothwing came apart. Into dust. Like the others did. And drifted. And started, slowly, to gather.

And the second one put its long pale hand on Arion Vey's face.

◆ ◆ ◆

"NO—"

Antho didn't know who screamed. Him. His mother. Odile.

The Mothwing's hand was on his father's cheek. Very gently. Like a mother. And the dust came off its fingers onto his father's skin. Grey-gold. Glittering. The shape of a hand.

And his father's eyes—

Didn't dim.

Antho saw it. He'd never forget it. He saw the dust on his father's cheek, and saw his father's eyes, grey, clear, behind his spectacles, and saw them stay *exactly the same*.

His father looked at the Mothwing. With its hand on his face. Calmly. With mild interest. The way he'd looked at the Moth Queen in her dark drawing room on the Crown Terrace.

"*Nothing there*," said Arion Vey. "*I'm afraid.*"

The Mothwing went very still.

"*She took it already*," said his father. "*Thirteen years ago. On a grey river. She paid it to the Ferryman.*" He smiled. Faintly. "*Every warm thing I had was her. And she gave it all away. There's nothing left in me for you to drink.*"

He looked past the Mothwing. At his wife. Standing in the middle of the kitchen with the clay lamp in her hand.

"*Except what she's given back*," said Arion. "*This summer. A little at a time.*" His voice was very soft. "*Burnt porridge. You have a nice voice. She fell asleep on my shoulder.*"

He swayed.

"*And you can't have those*," said Arion Vey. "*Those are already mine.*"

His knees went.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELL.

Antho saw him go down. Slowly. The way a tree goes down. His thin old legs folding. His stick clattering. His white head hitting the stone floor of the kitchen with a sound Antho would hear in his sleep for the rest of his life.

And didn't move.

And the third Mothwing, the one who hadn't touched anyone yet, stepped over him.

Toward Seren.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO MOVED.

Out of the doorway. Into the kitchen. With the Lantern. With the dark. With everything he had.

And behind him, the moths came through.

He felt them. The doorway, empty. The light gone out of it. The hush gone. The moths pouring into the kitchen behind him like a river through a broken dam. Over Odile. Over the students. Over him.

He didn't care.

He had the dark round the third Mothwing before it could take another step. Shade. Commanding. Not asking. *Taking*. He wrapped it in black and squeezed, and it came apart into dust, and he squeezed the dust, and the dust went *out*, the way a candle goes out when you pinch the wick.

He'd never done that before.

He'd never let himself.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Clarity: 100 → 81]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT FOR THE second one. The one that had touched his father. It was bending over the old man on the floor. Its long pale hand reaching again. For his face. For his eyes. As if it couldn't believe there was nothing there.

Antho took it the same way. Dark. Squeeze. Out.

[Clarity: 81 → 66]

The first one, the one his father had struck, was gathering. Slowly. A heap of grey-gold dust on the floor by the window, piling up. Taking shape.

He put it out too.

[Clarity: 66 → 52]

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IT WAS THERE.

In the back of his skull. In the old place. On the left side. Where it had lived for eight years.

Not the little one. Not the small frightened voice that said *brother* and *Mal* and *it's my favorite, the cat wears boots*.

Him.

The old thing. The black-eyed thing. The mad warlock of the Greyspine, who'd lived in a cave and held a knife to his brother's throat and listened to the dark until the dark listened back.

It was awake.

And it was *glad*.

There you are, it said. In his own voice. *There you are. I knew you'd come back. I knew you'd stop asking it nicely.*

Look what we can do.

Look what we can do when we stop asking.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS WERE IN the kitchen. All round him. Thousands. Pouring in through the doorway, through the window, through the cracks. Going for the lamp in his mother's hand. Going for the Lantern in his.

He could put them all out.

He knew it. He could feel it. Shade, Commanding. Not asking. Taking. He could reach into the dark and wrap every moth in this kitchen in black and *squeeze*, and they'd go out, every one, like candles pinched, like stars swallowed. He could do it. Right now. It would be easy. It would be so easy.

[Clarity: 52 → 44]

Do it, said the old thing. *Do it. They took Father. They took Mam's window. They're going to take Mam.*

Put them all out.

[Clarity: 44 → 38]

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN, FROM VERY far down, through the floor, through the mountain, through the long passage and the bell-shaped cavern and the black glass door left on the latch—

A voice.

Small. High. Young. Frightened.

[...brother...]

He went still.

[...brother...don't...]

[...don't do that...that's how I USED to be...]

[...that's the OTHER thing...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD IN THE middle of the kitchen of the Lantern Keep with the moths pouring round him and his father on the floor and his mother behind him and his Clarity at thirty-eight and falling.

And listened.

[...brother...that's what I did...when I was the other thing...when I was hungry...]

[...I didn't ask...I just TOOK...I pulled everything in and squeezed it and it went OUT...]

[...worlds...]

[...I put out WORLDS...]

[...don't...]

[...please don't...]

[...stay...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D HEARD THAT WORD before.

Not from the little one. From his brother. On a woodpile behind a cottage at Harrow, when he was fifteen and hearing voices and Lex was ten. From his brother in a cave in the Greyspine, with a knife at his throat. From his brother at the bottom of the world, at the Heart, pulling him back from an open door.

Stay.

It was the rune on the inside of Wren's ring. It was the rune Lex had cut into the Lockward. It was the rune Lex had cut into the ring of the lantern he'd made for their father, the twenty-rune one, so his father would stay.

Stay.

Don't go out there. Don't open the door. Don't become the thing.

Stay here. With us. As yourself.

The voice that had broken him for eight years.

Telling him to stay.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Clarity: 38 → 41]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LET GO OF the dark.

He didn't squeeze. He didn't take. He opened his hands. And let the Shade go back to being Shade. Soft. Quiet. Asking.

And the old thing in the back of his skull screamed.

No. No. NO. Not again. Not after all this time. Not now that we're—

Be quiet, thought Antho Vey. *I'm listening to someone.*

And it went quiet.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Clarity: 41 → 55 → 70]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE OPENED HIS EYES.

He didn't remember shutting them.

The kitchen was full of moths. They were everywhere. On the walls. On the ceiling. On the shelves. Round the Lantern in his hand, which had gone dim, drinking. Round his students, who were on their knees in the passage outside, Odile holding a boy whose eyes had gone dim.

Round his father. On the floor. Still not moving.

And round his mother.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS STANDING BY the broken window.

With the clay lamp in her hand. Held up. Lit. Small. Gold. With moths pressed against it on every side, drinking, getting nothing, falling. A ring of dead moths round her bare feet.

And in front of her, in the window, filling it, stooping to fit, with his great grey-gold wings folded tight against his back and a miner's pick in his hand—

Silas Hask.

He'd come in through the window. While Antho was fighting. While Antho was putting out Mothwing like candles and his Clarity was going down like a stone.

He was standing on the sill.

Looking at her.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Seren Vey*," said Silas Hask.

She looked back at him. Small. Barefoot. In her too-long nightdress. With the lamp.

"*Seren Harrow*," she said.

Hask nodded. Slowly.

"*She wants you*," he said. "*Up the hill. At the top of the Spire.*" His voice was quiet. Rough. Reasonable. "*She says she won't hurt you. She says she just wants to talk. About family. About a crown.*"

"*She's lying*."

"*She doesn't lie*." Hask looked at the lamp. At the dead moths round her feet. "*I've been with her a month now. She's never once lied. Not to me. Not to anyone.*"

"*Then she's choosing where to stand*," said Seren Vey. "*It's the same thing. It's worse.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK DIDN'T ARGUE.

He looked past her. At Antho. Standing in the middle of the kitchen with the dim Lantern and his Clarity creeping back and his eyes clear.

At Arion. On the floor. White. Still.

"*He's breathing*," said Hask. "*The old man. I can hear it. Shallow. But breathing.*" He looked back at Seren. "*He took a fall. He's eighty-three. He might not get up.*"

Seren didn't move.

"*You come with me*," said Silas Hask, "*and the moths go. All of them. Out of the Keep. Out of the mountain. And your boy can see to his father. And your students. And his wife, in the cold-room, with two little iron cups, who's very brave and very tired and won't hold much longer.*"

Antho went cold.

"*You don't come*," said Hask, "*and they stay. And keep drinking. Every lantern. Every lamp. Every one of those students out there in the passage.*" He looked at the lamp in her hand. "*Everything but yours. Because yours is given. I know.*"

He held out his big scarred hand. Glowing faintly at the knuckles.

"*She only needs you*," he said. "*Not tonight. Not him. Not the smith. Not the tracker. Not the little light.*"

His gold eyes were very steady.

"*You*," said Silas Hask. "*Just you. For now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS MOTHER LOOKED AT him for a long time.

Then she looked at Antho.

And Antho knew. Before she said anything. He knew the way he'd known thirteen years ago. On the stairs at Harrow. With the dark coming in behind the hearth.

She'd decided.

"*Antho*," said Seren Vey.

"*No.*"

"*Antho, love.*"

"*No. Mam. No. I'll—*" He didn't know what he'd do. He had the Lantern and the dark and his Clarity at seventy and he didn't know what he'd do. "*I'll stand in the window. I'll hold it. I'll—*"

"*You'll look after your father*," said his mother. Very gently. "*He's on the floor. He hit his head. Somebody has to sit with him.*" Her voice didn't shake.

"*And your wife. And your students. And the little one, at the door, which is frightened.*"

She came across the kitchen.

Barefoot. Through the dead moths. With the lamp held up. And stopped in front of him. And put her square strong freckled hand on his face.

"*I held a door for thirteen years*," said Seren Vey. "*It's your turn.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE GAVE HIM THE lamp.

She put it in his hands. The clay one. Wenna's. Small. Brown. With a chip in the spout and a thumbprint in the base. Lit. Into his hands. And closed his fingers round it. One by one. The way you'd close a child's fingers round a coin.

Not left on.

Given.

"*Keep it lit*," she said.

"*Mam—*"

"*Keep it lit*." She held his hands closed round it. "*Not in the window. In your hands. Not waiting for me. Given. To you. For you.*" Her eyes were very bright. "*It's yours now. Do you understand? It's not for me to come back to. It's yours.*"

He couldn't speak.

"*If it's waiting*," said his mother, "*she can drink it. If it's yours, she can't.*"

She let go of his hands.

And turned. And walked back across the kitchen. Through the moths. To the window. To the big man on the sill with his hand held out.

She didn't take his hand.

She stopped in front of him. And looked up at him. Small. Barefoot. Fierce.

"*If you touch my husband again*," said Seren Harrow, "*or my sons, or my sons' wives, or that child in the tracker's belly, I will find your warm thing, Silas Hask. Whatever it is. Wherever she's hidden it.*" Her voice was like iron. "*And I'll give it back to you. Every bit. All at once.*"

Hask looked down at her.

"*And then you'll have to carry it*," said Seren. "*All of it. Alone. Without her.*"

The big man didn't say anything.

He reached down. And picked her up. Carefully. The way you'd pick up a bird. And folded her against his chest. Inside his wings.

And turned. And stepped off the sill.

Into the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHS WENT.

All of them. All at once. Out of the kitchen. Out of the window. Out of the passage. Like smoke going up a chimney when a door's opened. A great grey-gold rush, up and out, through the cave mouth, into the night. After him. After her.

Gone.

And the Keep was dark.

Not all of it. Not the passage. Antho could feel it. Half the lanterns were gone. Five hundred. Six. Dark. With dust on their panes.

But the kitchen was lit.

By one lamp. Small. Clay. Brown. In his hands.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE CAME OUT OF the cold-room at a run.

With an iron cup in each hand. Both empty. Her face white. Her spectacles gone. Her plait coming down. Dust on her nightgown. On her arms. On her face. Grey-gold. Glittering.

Her eyes weren't dim.

She stopped in the kitchen doorway and looked at him. At the lamp in his hands. At his father on the floor. At the broken window.

At the empty place by the window where his mother had been.

"*Antho—*"

"*She went*," said Antho Vey.

His voice didn't sound like his. It sounded far away. Like a voice from the bottom of a well.

"*She went with him*," he said. "*To save us. To make them go.*" He looked down at the lamp. "*She gave me this.*"

Seraphine came across the kitchen. And knelt beside Arion. And put her fingers on his throat.

"*He's alive*," she said. "*Antho. He's alive.*"

Antho sat down on the floor.

Beside his father. With the lamp in his lap. And put his hand on his father's chest. And felt it go up. And down. Up. And down. Shallow. Slow. Old.

But going.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CAME AT DAWN.

On Vharuun. With Wren asleep against his chest and her family and the twins and Pim. Out of the south. Over the Greyspine. Fast. So fast the storm-mother's wings were shaking.

Antho heard the dragon land. He heard the boots on the slope. He heard his brother's voice, shouting his name. He heard him coming down the passage at a run, past the dark lanterns and the lit ones, past the students in the passage, past Odile, who'd brought the boy back with a lamp and his name and the first song he'd learned at the Keep.

He didn't get up.

He was sitting on the kitchen floor. Where he'd been all night. Beside their father, who was in the wheeled chair again now, wrapped in three blankets, with a bandage round his white head and his eyes shut. Awake. Mostly. Not talking.

With the clay lamp in his lap.

Lex stopped in the kitchen doorway.

He looked at the broken window. At the dust on the floor. At the dead moths. At their father. At Antho.

At the lamp.

"*She went*," said Antho. "*Lex. I'm sorry. She went with him. She made him promise.*"

His brother didn't say anything.

"*Hask*," said Antho. "*Silas Hask. He came in through the window while I was—*" He stopped. "*While I was putting them out. Squeezing them. The old way.*" He looked at his hands. "*My Clarity was at thirty-eight.*"

Lex came across the kitchen. And sat down on the floor. Beside him. Shoulder to shoulder.

"*What brought it back*?" he said.

Antho looked at the floor. Through it. Down. Through the mountain. To the door.

"*The little one*," he said. "*It said stay. It said, don't do that, that's how I used to be.*" His voice cracked. "*It said, that's the other thing.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SAT THERE FOR a long time.

Brothers. On a kitchen floor. With their father asleep in the chair above them and their mother gone up the hill in the arms of a man with wings.

"*Hask told me*," said Lex at last. Very quietly. "*In Highcrest. Yesterday. He said she takes what she needs first. And then she comes back for the rest.*" He put his face in his hands. "*He told me. He tried to tell me. I flew as fast as I could.*"

"*I know*."

"*I was too slow*."

"*You were in Highcrest*," said Antho. "*Saving Wren's mother. And Wren. And the baby.*" He looked at his brother. "*You can't be in two places, Lex. Nobody can. That's why there's two of us.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NOTE WAS ON the windowsill.

Seraphine found it. Mid-morning. When she went to sweep up the dust where the glass had been. Lying on the sill. Where the clay lamp used to sit.

Not paper.

Dust. Grey-gold. Fine as flour. Laid out on the stone of the sill in words. In a hand Antho didn't know. Long. Slanting. Elegant. Like the hand of someone who'd learned to write nine hundred years ago, with a quill, in a hall of glass.

Make your room, smith.

Make it beautiful. Make it big. Make it ready.

On Lantern Night, I'll bring your mother to it.

And when the little one comes up toward her lamp, the way it always does, I'll be standing right beside her.

With my hands cupped.
— M.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE READ IT OUT loud. In the kitchen. To all of them.

And then she put down the broom.

And Antho watched his wife, who had stood in the cold-room all night alone with two iron cups and made a room in the dark that the moths couldn't get into, until the cups ran out, until the moths found the edge of it, until they started to come in—

He watched her look at the words on the sill.

And then reach out. With one ink-stained finger. And draw it through the dust. Through the words. From corner to corner. One long straight line.

Crossing it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She can't drink it*," said Seraphine. Very quietly. To no one. To the dust. "*The lamp. She gave it to you. In your hands. It's yours now. It's not waiting for her.*"

She looked at Antho. At the clay lamp in his lap.

"*So the little one won't come up toward it*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*Will it. Not toward Seren's lamp.*"

Antho looked down at the lamp.

Small. Brown. Clay. Lit. In his hands.

"*No*," he said slowly. "*Not toward Mam's.*"

He looked up.

At his brother. At his wife. At his father in the chair with the bandage on his head and his grey eyes, open now, watching.

"*Toward mine*," said Antho Vey.

CHAPTER 27

The Breach He Made

ARION VEY WENT BACK to Duskhold on a litter, with a bandage round his head and his wife's lamp in his son's hands.

He hadn't asked to go. He hadn't asked for anything, the first three days after. He'd lain in the narrow bed in the little stone room off the library, the one Antho had given Seren, the one that still smelled faintly of her, of lamp-oil and old wool and the deep. With his eyes open. Looking at the high small window. At the sky.

Not talking.

They thought it was the fall. Seraphine did. She came and sat with him and felt his head and looked into his eyes with a candle and asked him questions. *What's your name. What year is it. Who's the Queen.* He answered them all. Correctly. In a whisper. And then turned his face back to the window.

It wasn't the fall.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE FOURTH MORNING he said to Antho, *"Take me to the breach."*

His son was sitting by the bed. He'd been sitting there, on and off, for four days. With the clay lamp in his lap. Never putting it down. Not to eat. Not to sleep. He slept sitting up, against the wall, with the lamp in both hands, and when he woke he looked at it first, before anything, to see that it was still burning.

He looked up now. Red-eyed.

"Father. You can't travel."

"I can lie down," said Arion. *"On a litter. On a dragon. I can lie down anywhere."* He turned his head on the pillow. Slowly. It hurt. Everything hurt now. *"Lex is going to make a room in the Blightmarch. You're going to open the door. I'm the only one alive who knows where the edges are."*

"Father—"

"She took your mother," said Arion Vey. *"Up the hill. To my rooms. She's sitting in my chair reading my books with my wife beside her."* His voice was very quiet. *"And I've been lying here for three days looking at a window."*

He looked at his son.

"I'd like to do something," he said. *"Before I can't."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY TOOK HIM ON Ashka.

Lex wasn't there. Lex was already in the Blightmarch. He'd gone the day after, with Brannoc and Tilda and Grandmother Asha and forty students and two hundred Ashari fire-women in red and every smith from every forge in Caldor who could hear fire. They'd gone east. To start.

To make room.

So it was Antho who carried him. Down the long passage. Past the lanterns. Five hundred and six of them dark again, with dust on their panes. Six hundred and seven lit. Antho counted them under his breath as he walked. Arion heard him.

And at the cave mouth, Ashka was waiting. With a litter strapped to her back between two ridges of blue scale. Brannoc's work again. Leather and ash-wood and oiled canvas.

And Seraphine was waiting. With a pack and three lamps and her notebook. And Pim. Small and silent in his blue coat. Who looked at Arion on the litter. And came and stood beside it. And put his thin hand on the edge.

And didn't let go the whole way.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BLIGHTMARCH WENT ON forever.

Arion had forgotten.

He'd been here before. Many times. Twenty-one years ago, when it was green. When it was the eastern march of Vhessa, rolling hills and birch woods and little grey towns round the mouths of mines. Coldwater. Ashpit. Greyford. Kell's Hollow. Names in a ledger. He'd ridden through them on his way to the Great Stone, with Corvin beside him, talking about nothing, about the weather, about the price of bread.

He'd been here five years ago. When it was dead. Gloam-grey. Silent. With his sons. With Duskhold rising out of the middle of it like a black tooth.

He'd never seen it from the air.

Grey. That was all. From horizon to horizon. Not Gloam-grey; the Gloam was gone. Just grey. Dust-grey. Ash-grey. Hills with nothing on them. Valleys with nothing in them. Rivers that had stopped. Woods that were only stumps, black and broken, standing in rows like the teeth of a comb. Little grey towns with no roofs.

No birds. No sheep. No smoke. No sound.

A hundred miles of it.

And in the middle, far off, black and broken and falling, like the bones of something enormous that had died there—

Duskhold.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE THEM PUT him down at the edge.

Not at the ruins. Not yet. At the edge of the Blightmarch. Where the grey began. On a low hill, the last green one, looking east.

He wanted to look at it.

They set the litter down on the grass. Antho and Seraphine. And propped him up, with a folded blanket behind his back, so he could see. And sat down beside him. One on each side. And Pim sat at his feet.

And they looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Eleven thousand*," said Arion.

Nobody said anything.

"*In the first year*," said Arion. "*I wrote it down. In the grey book. That autumn. Eleven thousand, estimated.*" His voice was very steady. "*And then a line. And then the price of bread in Highcrest.*"

Antho was very still beside him.

"*Lex told me*," said Arion. "*Yesterday. Before he went east. He sat by the bed and told me what Hask said. In the street. In Highcrest.*" He looked at the grey. "*Eleven thousand. In a column. Between a line and the price of bread.*"

"*Father—*"

"*It's true*," said Arion Vey. "*That's the thing. It's true. I did write it. I do remember writing it. I remember dipping the pen.*" He looked at his hands. Thin. Shaking. Brown-spotted. "*I remember thinking, I'll come back to this. I'll find out the names. I'll write them all down. Properly. Each one.*"

He was quiet.

"*I never did*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WIND CAME OVER the grey. Thin. Cold. Smelling of nothing.

"*I was going to*," said Arion. "*I meant to. And then I went to Avaloria to hold the breaches. And then I was in the crystal for fifteen years. And then I woke up, and there was Duskhold, and you two, and the Queen, and the festival, and the Key, and—*" He stopped. "*There was always something. Something more important. Something I could fix.*"

He looked at the grey.

"*I couldn't fix them*," he said. "*So I didn't look at them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Do you know what he said*?" said Arion. "*Hask. To Lex. In the street.*"

"*Which of you do I owe*," said Antho. Quietly.

"*Which of you do I owe.*" Arion nodded. Slowly. "*Your father, who killed them. You, who set me free. Her, who gave me breath.*" He looked at his son. "*Do you know what Lex said back?*"

Antho shook his head.

"*Nobody*," said Arion. "*He said, you don't owe anyone. That's what free means. Nobody gets to say what you owe them.*" His mouth moved. Not

quite a smile. "*He's a better man than me. Your brother. He always was. Even when he hated me.*"

"*He doesn't hate you*."

"*I know. That's what makes it worse.*" Arion closed his eyes. "*I owe them, Antho. Hask's sister. Nell. Eight. Who whistled at the window. I owe every one of them. Eleven thousand. More. I owe them their names.*" He opened his eyes. "*And I've got a season. Perhaps less. And I'm lying on a hill on a litter looking at the grey I made.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS WRITING.

He heard the pencil. Quiet. Steady. Beside him. He turned his head.

She was sitting on the grass with her notebook on her knees. Not looking at him. Writing.

"*What are you doing*?"

"*Writing down Coldwater*," said Seraphine. Without looking up.

He stared at her.

"*I've got the records*," she said. "*The Keepers' records. From when Lex Unbound the Coldwater Stone. Two summers ago. Four thousand and twelve names. The living.*" Her pencil moved. "*And the Kindling registers. From before. From the Order. Every child Kindled at Coldwater for forty years. With their classes and their Ceilings.*" She turned a page. "*And the parish books. Births and deaths. Seventy years of them. The priest kept them in a box under the altar and the Gloam never got in.*"

She looked up.

"*If I cross them*," said Seraphine Ilvane, "*the living against the Kindled against the parish. The ones who were born and Kindled and aren't on the living list.*"

She didn't finish.

She didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION LOOKED AT HER for a long time.

At his son's wife. With her ink-stained fingers and her crooked spectacles and her notebook on her knees. Who had sat in the cold-room four nights ago with two iron cups and held the dark alone. Who had been

a Warden archivist once, and fled with stolen records, and been framed by his oldest friend, and nearly killed proving her innocence.

Who had always been good at gaps. At the spaces between letters. At the pages someone's torn out.

"*How long*?" he said.

"*For Coldwater*?" She bit her pencil. "*A week. If I don't sleep.*"

"*And the rest*?"

Seraphine looked at the grey. At the hundred miles of it. At the little grey towns with no roofs. Ashpit. Greyford. Kell's Hollow.

"*Longer*," she said.

"*I can help*," said Arion.

She looked at him.

"*I can still write*," said Arion Vey. He held up his shaking hand. "*Badly. Slowly. But I can write. I've been writing every day for two hundred years.*" He looked at the notebook. "*I'd like to write them. Myself. In my own hand. In the grey book. Where the line is.*"

He swallowed.

"*Between the line and the price of bread*," he said. "*I'd like to fill it in.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT TO THE ruins in the afternoon.

Ashka carried the litter. Low. Slow. Over the grey. With Antho and Seraphine walking below, and Pim riding on the dragon's neck, very straight, with his hand on the litter's edge.

Duskhold had been a citadel. Morvane's. Grown out of the Gloam-stone over fifteen years like a tumor out of the grey, black and smooth and windowless, with no doors. A great hall in the middle of it with a pit in the floor where the breach had been.

It was falling now.

Five years without the Gloam. The black stone was cracking. Crumbling. The great smooth walls had split and slumped and fallen in, and the towers were stumps, and the whole thing lay in the middle of the grey like the skeleton of a beast, ribs and spine and skull, with the wind going through it.

And all round it, as far as he could see, people.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION SAT UP ON the litter.

He didn't mean to. It hurt. He did it anyway.

The grey plain round the ruins was *covered*. Tents. Hundreds. Wagons. Fires. Forges. Real forges, with bellows and anvils and hearths, set up on the bare grey ground in rows, like a market. Smoke going up from all of them. And between them, everywhere, moving, working, shouting—

People. Thousands.

He saw the Ashen Banners, two hundred of them, digging. With spades. In a long line. Cutting a trench into the grey ground that went away east further than he could see. He saw Keepers in grey coats, carrying sacks. He saw the red robes of the Ashari, two hundred old women, sitting in a ring on the ground with their hands flat on the dust, and the dust in front of them going dark and hot and rippling.

He saw students from the Ashbourne Forge with hammers. Smiths from every forge in Caldor. Sunreach riders on golden horses, dragging sledges. Farmers from the Vale with ox-carts. Miners from Coldwater—from *Coldwater*—with picks.

And in the middle of it all, on a hill of black rubble that had been Duskhold's great gate, a big man with dark curly hair badly cut and a grey-gold handprint on his face, standing with a map in his hands, shouting at someone.

And beside him, a bigger one. Bald. Grey-bearded. Shouting back.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He's been at it four days*," said Antho. Quietly. Beside the litter. "*Lex. He hasn't slept. Brannoc says he's going to fall over.*"

"*Brannoc says that about everyone*."

"*Brannoc's usually right*."

Arion looked at the grey plain. At the trench. At the forges. At the thousands.

"*How*?" he said. "*How did he get so many? In four days?*"

Antho was quiet for a moment.

"*He asked*," he said.

Arion looked at him.

"*He went to Ashbourne*," said Antho. "*And stood in the forge yard. And said, I need to make a room for something that's coming home. It's very big. I can't do it alone.*" He looked at the plain. "*And they came. Brannoc's students. And then the other forges. And then the Banners. And then the Ashari. And then—*" He shook his head. "*And then everyone. The Vale. The Saltreach. Coldwater. People he Unbound. People he's never met.*"

"*Just because he asked*."

"*Just because he asked*," said Antho Vey. "*Nobody's ever asked them for anything before. Not like that. Not as if it mattered whether they said yes.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CARRIED HIM INTO the ruins at dusk.

Into the great hall. What was left of it. The roof was gone. The walls were fallen. The black floor was cracked and heaped with rubble and open to the sky.

And in the middle of it, where the floor dipped down, where five years ago there had been a pit, a chasm, a breach—

A line.

Thin. Dark. Long. Running across the black floor from one side of the fallen hall to the other. Like a scar. Like a seam. Like a crack in a crucible that's been mended and still shows.

The first wound.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY SET THE LITTER down beside it.

And Arion looked at it for a long time.

He remembered kneeling here. Twenty-one years ago. On this floor. Except it hadn't been this floor then. It had been grass. A hillside. With the Great Stone of Vhessa standing on top of it, tall and grey and humming with the net. He'd knelt in the grass at the foot of the Stone with Corvin beside him and put his hands flat on the ground and reached into the net.

And pulled.

Like a rotten sail in a gale. That's what he'd told his sons. Five years ago. In this hall. With eleven thousand of the Quiet watching him. *It tore. Right here. Under my hands.*

And Corvin had been standing beside him.

And it found Corvin first.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*He was my friend*," said Arion.

Nobody asked who.

"*Corvin*," he said. "*Morvane. Before. He was a Warden-Commander. He liked dogs. He was terrible at cards. He thought we were coming here to investigate a fault.*" He looked at the dark line on the floor. "*I didn't tell him. I didn't tell anyone. I was going to fix it. All of it. In one night. And then I'd tell them. Afterward. When it was done.*"

He put his hand out. Over the edge of the litter. Toward the line. He couldn't reach it.

Antho knelt. And took his father's hand. And put it on the floor. On the line. On the scar.

It was warm.

Arion hadn't expected that. He'd expected cold. The breach had been cold. The Gloam had been cold, like wet ash, like the bottom of a well.

It was warm.

"*It's not dead*," said Antho. Quietly. "*Is it. The breach. It's closed. But it's not dead.*"

"*No*," said Arion. Slowly. With his hand on the warm black line. "*No. It's—*" He stopped.

He could feel it.

Not with the Root. He'd given that away. Not with any Well; he'd never Listened properly. He'd been a Listener's husband for eleven years and learned a little, nothing like his sons.

With his hands.

With two hundred years of knowing where things were thin. Where the net was worn. Where a thing was likely to tear if you pulled on it too hard, too fast.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It goes down*," said Arion.

He shut his eyes.

"*All the way*," he said. "*To the deep. It always did. That's why I came here. The net was thinnest here. It always had been. The world was worn*

through here, like the elbow of an old coat." His fingers moved on the line. Slowly. Feeling. *"And when I tore it, I tore it all the way down. And when we closed it, we closed the top. The skin. The world's side."*

He opened his eyes.

"Not the bottom," he said. *"The bottom's still open. Under. It's a shaft, Antho. Like the ones the Uncapped made. Only older. Wider. Deeper. Going down from here to the bottom of the world."* He looked at his son. *"Straight down. To where the little one is."*

Antho went very still.

"That's why it's warm," said Arion. *"It's not the breach. It's the little one. Underneath. Close. Pressing up against the bottom of it."* His voice dropped. *"It's been pressing up against it since the Heart. Since it started to rise. It knows. It's always known. This is the way up."*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SHOWED ANTHO THE edges.

It took all night.

He couldn't move. He couldn't sit up for more than a few minutes. He lay on the litter beside the line with his hand on it, and Antho lay beside him on the black floor with the clay lamp between them and his own hand on the line, and Arion talked.

Where it was thick. Where they'd stitched it, five years ago, three of the blood, with the Root and the Stone and the Shade. Where the stitches were tightest. Where they'd pulled.

Where it was thin. Where the old tear had gone deepest. Where the edges had never quite met, even after the mend, and something had been left. A gap. A seam. A place where a door could be.

"Here," said Arion. At two in the morning. His voice a thread. His hand on a place in the line, near the middle, where the black was a little wider. *"Here. This is where I knelt. This is where my hands were."* He swallowed. *"This is where it tore first."*

"And this is where I open it," said Antho.

"This is where you open it."

Antho put his hand over his father's. On the line. On the place.

"How?" he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION WAS QUIET FOR a long time.

The stars were out. Very bright. Over the open roof of the fallen hall. The fires of the camp outside were a red glow over the broken walls. Somewhere, far off, someone was still hammering. One anvil. Slow. Steady. In the dark.

"*I tore it trying to free everyone at once*," said Arion Vey.

His voice was very quiet.

"*In one stroke. With all my Authority. Pulling. As hard as I could. As fast as I could.*" He looked at the line. "*Because I was angry. Because I'd seen the Ceilings. Every grey band round every gold thread. Millions of them. And I couldn't bear it.*" He was quiet. "*And because I thought I knew best. I thought I could do it alone. Without asking anyone. Without telling anyone. Not Corvin. Not Seren. Not the net.*"

He turned his head on the litter. And looked at his son.

"*Don't do it like that*," he said.

Antho didn't answer.

"*Don't pull*," said his father. "*Don't decide. Don't take. You know how. You did it in the deep. At the Hollowmaw door. Kestrel told you.*"

"*Ask*," said Antho.

"*Ask*." Arion's hand tightened under his son's. On the line. "*Ask it to open. Ask the little one to come up. Ask the net to let it through.*" His voice cracked. "*Ask everyone. Lex. Seraphine. Brannoc. Every smith out there. Every old woman in red. Every miner from Coldwater with a pick.*"

He looked at the stars.

"*I tore it alone*," said Arion Vey. "*You open it with everyone.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY LAY THERE UNTIL dawn.

Father and son. On the black floor of a fallen hall. With their hands on a scar. And a clay lamp between them. And a boy asleep at the foot of the litter with his blue coat for a pillow.

Antho slept, a little. Toward morning. With his hand still on the line.

Arion didn't.

He lay on the litter and looked at the stars going out, one by one, as the sky went grey. And thought about a man who liked dogs and was terrible at cards. And a girl of eight who whistled at a window. And eleven thousand names, in a column, between a line and the price of bread.

And his wife. Sitting in his chair at the top of the Spire. In his rooms. With a woman with lit eyes reading his books.

She's sitting in my chair.

She's reading my books.

She's looking at my wife.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE THOUGHT ABOUT THE offer.

He'd thought about it every night since the dark drawing room on the Crown Terrace. Every night. In the Spire. In the Keep. On the litter. *A little light. From my own hands. Twenty years. As much as you like.*

Enough to be young when she comes home.

He'd written it in the grey book. *Offered: twenty years. Price: not stated.* And under it. *I would give anything to see her face when she sees mine.* And under that, so small it was almost nothing. *Anything?*

She'd come home.

She'd seen his face. Old. White. Furrowed. In a chair. And she'd knelt down and put her hands on it and listened, and said *you have a nice voice*.

She hadn't needed him young.

He'd been wrong. He'd been so wrong. He'd sat in that dark room and wanted it, wanted it so badly, to be young for her. And she'd come home and not needed it at all. She'd fallen asleep on his shoulder. She'd eaten burnt porridge with him. She'd read his letter by a window and found the one thing in it he'd never been able to remember.

No change, he'd written.

He'd meant it.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND NOW SHE WAS up the hill.

In the Spire. In his rooms. With the woman with lit eyes. Who never lied. Who only chose where to stand.

And he was on a litter. On a black floor. In a fallen hall. Eighty-three. Eighty-four, maybe, by now. With a bandage round his head and a season left. Perhaps less.

He couldn't walk.

He couldn't hold a cup.

He couldn't climb the ninety-four steps of the Spire, or the six floors in the lift, or the last stair to the top, to the door of his own room, to the chair by the window, where his wife was sitting.

Not like this, he thought.

Not old.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED HIS HEAD.

Very slowly. On the litter. And looked at his son. Asleep. On the black floor. With his long black hair loose and his face, in sleep, younger than it ever was awake. With his hand on the scar. And the clay lamp between them. Lit.

Given, Seren had said. *Not waiting. Yours.*

He thought about the moths at the Keep. The Mothwing with its hand on his face. *Nothing there*, he'd said. *She took it already. Every warm thing I had was her.*

And she gave it all away.

There's nothing left in me for you to drink.

He'd been proud of that. Lying on the kitchen floor with his head split open. He'd been proud.

There's nothing left in me for her to drink, he thought now. Slowly. Looking at the stars going out. *Nothing she wants. Nothing she can use. I'm an old man with nothing warm in him that isn't already given away.*

So what would she want with me?

What would she want, from a man with nothing left?

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNEW THE ANSWER.

He'd known it in the dark drawing room. He'd known it in the way she looked at him. With her lit eyes. As if he were the loveliest thing she'd ever seen.

I'd like to be your friend, she'd said. *I've been very lonely.*

He'd thought she was lying. And then he'd remembered she never lied.

She means it, he thought now. Slowly. Looking at the stars going out. *She does want a friend. A Vey. Her own. One who's lived too long and is dying of it, the way she should have been dying for nine hundred years.*

She wants me in her household.

Drinking from her hands. A sip at a time. Like Orrin. Like the Mothwing. Like Hask. Young forever, and hers forever, and never able to stop going back to her for more.

A Vey on a string.

He lay very still.

And she'd let me in, he thought. *Wouldn't she. Into her house. Into my own rooms. Up the stairs I can't climb. To the chair by the window where my wife is sitting.*

She'd let me walk right in. Young. Strong. Grateful.

Her friend.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SUN CAME UP over the grey.

Red. Then gold. Then white. Over the hundred miles of dust and stumps and roofless towns. Over the camp. Over the trench. Over the forges and the fires and the thousands of people asleep on the bare ground.

Over the fallen hall. And the scar on the floor. And an old man on a litter with his hand on it, and his son asleep beside him.

Arion Vey reached for the grey book.

It was on the litter beside him. Where it always was. With the pencil tucked into the binding. He got it open. Slowly. With his shaking hands. To the page. *Offered: twenty years. Price: not stated.*

And under it. *I would give anything to see her face when she sees mine.*

And under that. *Anything?*

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he crossed out the first line. Slowly. One long straight stroke. From corner to corner. The way his wife's mother had crossed out a moth in the lid of a box.

And under it, very small, very neat, shaking only a little, he wrote:

Price: known. Her household drinks from her hands.

And under that:

So will I. Once. Long enough to climb the stairs.

And under that, smallest of all:

Then I'll give it back.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CLOSED THE BOOK.

And put it back on the litter. And put his hand back on the scar. On the warm black line. On the place where he'd knelt twenty-one years ago and pulled.

And lay there in the sunrise.

And beside him, his son stirred. And opened his eyes. And looked at the lamp first. Before anything. To see that it was still burning.

It was.

"*Morning*," said Antho. Hoarse. Sleepy.

"*Good morning*," said his father.

And smiled at him. The real smile. The wide startled one. The one he'd smiled on the slope of the Hollowmaw, a year ago, when Lex said *you look old*.

Antho blinked.

"*What*?" he said.

"*Nothing*," said Arion Vey. "*I was just thinking. You'll be very good at it. The door.*" He looked at the line under their hands. "*You've always been good at doors. Better than me. Much better.*"

He shut his eyes.

"*Wake me when your brother comes*," he said. "*I want to tell him about the edges.*"

And he didn't sleep.

He lay with his eyes shut and his hand on the scar and the grey book on the litter beside him, and the sun climbing over the grey country he'd made.

Counting.

Not hairs. Not lines. Not stairs.

Days.

CHAPTER 28

Listening to Nothing

SERAPHINE ILVANE HAD SPENT her whole life in rooms with too many books in them, and she had never once been inside a room with nothing in it at all.

She thought about that on the ninth night in the Blightmarch. Sitting in the tent. With the lamp turned low and the grey book open on the folding table and an old man asleep on the cot beside it, breathing slow and shallow and uneven. With the parish registers of Coldwater on one side of her and the Keepers' Unbinding list on the other and the Order's Kindling rolls on her knees.

Crossing them.

One name at a time. A finger on each list. *Born. Kindled. Not living. Born. Kindled. Not living. Born. Kindled.*

Not living.

And then, every hour or so, when he woke, reading them out to Arion. Slowly. One at a time. So he could write them in the grey book. In his own hand. In the place where the line was. Between the line and the price of bread.

Abel Mason. Hewer. Thirty-one.

Bette Mason. His wife. Twenty-nine.

Nell Hask. Eight.

He'd stopped at that one. For a long time. With the pencil shaking in his hand.

And then written it. Very carefully. Very small. Very neat.

Nell Hask. Eight. She whistled at the window when her brother came home.

That wasn't in any of the registers. Seraphine hadn't said it. Arion had added it himself.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWO THOUSAND ONE HUNDRED and six, so far.

Coldwater alone. Not counting Ashpit. Not counting Greyford, or Kell's Hollow, or the farms in between, or the drovers on the roads, or the travelling tinkers who never got written down anywhere.

She'd known it would be a lot. She hadn't known it would be like this.

Every one of them had a line. A name, a class, an age. Some of them had more. A note from the priest in the margin of the parish book. *Drowned in the millrace, 4th Harvestmonth. Sang in the choir. Was kind to my mother when she was dying.* The priest had been old and tired and he'd written things down that didn't need writing, the way old tired men do.

Seraphine had copied every one.

And Arion had written every one. In the grey book. In the space between.

It had taken him nine days to write two thousand one hundred and six names. His hand shook so badly that some of them were nearly illegible. He'd had to stop every twenty names to rest. He'd fallen asleep mid-word, twice, and woken, and found his place, and gone on.

He hadn't missed one.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE LOOKED AT HIM now. Asleep on the cot. White. Thin. With the bandage off his head now, and a scab there instead, and the grey book on the blanket on his chest where it had fallen when he slept.

Eighty-five, the book said. She'd checked. She checked every morning. She'd taken over the counting from him; his hand was needed for the names.

Eighty-five.

A season, she'd told them. In the library at the Keep. Perhaps two. Not past Lantern Night.

She'd done the sum again last night. With the new numbers.

She hadn't told anyone.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS SOMETHING WRONG with him.

Not the age. Not the shaking. Not the falls. Something else. Something she couldn't name. She'd noticed it on the hill, the first day, when they set the litter down at the edge of the grey and he looked at the Blightmarch for the first time. Something in his face. Something *decided*.

She'd seen that face before. On Antho, on the night before the Highcrest singing. On Lex, at the Heart, before he went down into the anvil. On Seren, on the stairs at Harrow, in a memory Antho had told her once at three in the morning.

The face of someone who has made up their mind about something and isn't going to tell anyone.

She'd asked him. Twice. *Arion. What is it?* And he'd smiled. The wide startled smile. And said *I'm just tired, my dear. I'm eighty-five. I'm allowed to be tired.*

She didn't believe him.

But she was a scholar. And a scholar knows when a page has been torn out. You don't always know what was on it. You just know there's a gap.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE PUT THE LAMP out.

Not all the way. Down to a glow. And left the tent. Quietly. Without waking him. And went out into the dark.

The camp was asleep.

Thousands of them. Under the stars. On the bare grey ground. In tents and under wagons and wrapped in blankets by the dying fires. The forges were banked. The trench, the great long trench that went away east into the dark further than she could see, was quiet. Nobody digging. Nobody hammering.

Except one.

There was always one. Somewhere. In the dark. One anvil. Slow. Steady. Far off. The sound came across the grey like a heartbeat. Seraphine had stopped hearing it after the third night. She heard it now.

She knew whose it was.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T GO TOWARD it.

She went the other way. Toward the ruins. Toward the fallen hall of Duskhold, black and broken under the stars. Through the gap in the wall where the gate had been. Across the rubble.

To the scar.

The dark line on the black floor. Warm. Running from one side of the hall to the other. The first wound. The place where Arion had knelt twenty-one years ago, and pulled, and torn the world.

Antho was there.

Of course he was. He was always there. Lying on his side on the black floor, with his hand on the line and his head on his arm and the clay lamp beside him. Asleep. Mostly. Not asleep. In the place between, where he went when he was listening to the dark.

She sat down beside him.

He didn't wake. But his free hand moved. Across the floor. And found hers. And held it.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE'D COME HERE EVERY night.

To listen. That was what she told herself. To listen to the little one, through the scar. To learn the shape of it. So she could tell Lex. So he'd know what shape to make the room.

That was true. She did listen. She did learn. She'd filled forty pages of her notebook with it. Shapes. Sizes. Folds. The way it curled and uncurled in the deep. The places where it was thick and the places where it was thin. The bite, where the Moth had drunk, still aching. The wounds where the shafts were, twenty-nine of them now, still open, still leaking.

She'd drawn it. Over and over. Trying to get it right.

She hadn't got it right yet.

It wasn't a shape. That was the problem. It kept *not* being a shape. Every time she thought she had it, every time she drew a line and thought *there, that's the edge*, it moved. Not much. A little. The way a room seems a different size depending on who's in it.

It's the room, she kept telling herself. *It's not a thing. It's the room the thing goes in. You can't draw a room. You can only draw the walls.*

And it hasn't got walls.

That's what we're making it.

◆ ◆ ◆

BUT THAT WASN'T THE only reason she came.

She came because it was the only place in the world where she could hear it properly. And because, for the first time in her life, she could hear *something*.

She'd sat by Malachi's fire in the Pale Wastes for nineteen days. Five years ago. And heard nothing. While Lex learned to talk to flame and Wren learned to walk on the wind and Antho learned to rest in the dark.

Nothing.

Some people don't, Malachi had said. Gently. *It's not a failing. Someone has to write it down.*

She'd written it down. Five years. Every word. Every lesson. She'd copied the Codex nine times.

And then, in the kitchen of the Lantern Keep, with a black pebble on the table between the porridge and the teapot, Antho had said *pebble*.

And she'd heard the space round the word.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CLOSED HER EYES now.

On the black floor of the fallen hall. With her hand in her husband's. With the scar warm under her other palm.

And listened.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT FIRST, NOTHING. THE way it always was at first. The wind over the broken walls. Antho breathing. The anvil, far off. Slow. Steady.

And then, under it—

Not under it. Between. In the spaces. In the gaps between one hammer-stroke and the next. Between one breath and the next. Between the wind and the wall.

The quiet.

Not silence. Silence was nothing. Silence was what you got when you took everything away. This was different. This was *full*. Full the way a held breath is full. Full the way a cup is full before you pour anything into it. Full of the possibility of being filled.

Room.

She could hear it. She could hear the *room*. Not the little one's voice; she'd never heard that, not the way Antho did. Not words. Not *brother* and *Mal* and *the cat wears boots*.

Just the space it made. Everywhere. In everything. In the gaps between things. The way, if you looked at a page long enough, you stopped seeing the letters and started seeing the white.

◆ ◆ ◆

Where are you? she thought.

Not to it. She'd never spoken to it. She didn't know how. She thought it the way you think a question to yourself, sitting at a desk, staring at a page of Wellscript you can't read.

Where's your edge?

How big are you, really?

What shape do you want to be?

And the quiet—

Moved.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE FELT IT.

Not heard. *Felt*. Under her palm. Through the scar. Through the black floor. A shift. A ripple. The way a pond moves when something swims underneath it.

The room changed shape.

Not much. Not far. Just—round her. Close. The quiet that was everywhere drew in. Toward her. Toward her hand on the scar. The way people in a crowded hall draw back to make a space round someone who's fallen.

And there was a space.

Right there. Round her hand. Round her. On the black floor of the fallen hall. A small round room of quiet, the size of a bed, with her in the

middle of it. With nothing in it. Not the wind. Not the anvil. Not Antho's breathing. Not even her own heart.

Nothing.

Room.

And in the room, very faintly, very far off, like someone speaking in a house three streets away—

[...you asked...]

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE'S EYES FLEW OPEN.

The room was still there. Round her. Quiet. Empty. The wind had stopped. The anvil had stopped. She couldn't hear Antho, though he was right beside her, though his hand was in hers. She couldn't hear anything.

Except that.

[...you asked me...]

[...what shape I want to be...]

[...nobody ever asked me that...]

She couldn't breathe.

She'd never heard it. Never. Five years. She'd heard the space. The quiet. The room. She'd never once heard the *voice*.

She heard it now. Not the way Antho did. Not in the back of her skull, in an old place, where something used to live. There was no old place in her. Nothing had ever lived in her.

She heard it in the *room*.

In the space it had made round her. Like a voice in an empty church. Like a word written on a blank page.

[...the one with the glass eyes...] it said. Wondering. *[...the one who hears the gaps...]*

[...you made me make a room...just by asking...]

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I didn't*—" She didn't know if she said it out loud. In the room, it didn't seem to matter. "*I didn't make you. I just asked.*"

[...that's how...]

[...that's how it works...that's what I AM...]

[...somebody asks...and I make room...]

She looked at her hand. On the scar. In the middle of the small round quiet.

"*I asked what shape you want to be*," she said.

[...yes...]

"*Do you know*?"

The room was quiet for a long time.

[...no...] it said. Very small. *[...I've been all the shapes...I was a pool...I was a hunger...I was the dark under the lid...I'm the room now...]*

[...I don't know what shape I am when nobody's using me...]

[...nobody's ever let me just BE...]

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE ILVANE SAT ON the black floor of the fallen hall of Duskhold with her hand on a warm scar and listened to a Well tell her it didn't know what it was.

And for the first time in her life, she understood something before she'd read about it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WASN'T A SHAPE.

That was the trouble. She'd been trying to draw a *shape*. A thing. An outline. Edges. Walls.

The little one wasn't a thing. It was the space *for* a thing. It didn't have edges because edges were what the *thing* had. A room didn't have edges. The walls did.

You can't draw a room, she'd been telling herself. *You can only draw the walls*.

She'd been right. And she'd been wrong.

You couldn't draw a room.

But you could *write* one.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS ON HER feet.

The small round quiet broke round her. Like a soap bubble. The wind came back. The anvil came back, far off. Antho's breathing. Her own heart, going so hard she could feel it in her ears.

Antho was sitting up. Awake. Staring at her.

"*Seraphine—*"

"*It talked to me.*"

He went very still.

"*It talked to me*," said Seraphine. "*Not you. Not through you. To me. In a room. It made a room round me and talked to me in it.*" She was shaking. "*Antho. I heard it. I heard its* voice."

His face—

She'd never forget his face. Sitting on the black floor of the fallen hall in the starlight with the clay lamp beside him and his long black hair everywhere and his eyes going wide and wet.

"*Oh*," said Antho Vey. "*Oh, love.*"

"*And I know what shape it is*," said Seraphine.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE RAN.

She'd never been good at running. She'd learned late, from a book. She ran anyway. Across the rubble. Out through the gap where the gate had been. Across the grey ground. Between the sleeping tents and the banked forges and the dying fires.

Toward the anvil.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS AT THE head of the trench.

Where it started. At the edge of the ruins. Where Duskhold's great gate had been, and the black rubble of it lay in a long slope down to the grey ground. He'd built an anvil out of a block of the fallen Gloam-stone, black and smooth, and set a hearth beside it out of more of the same, and he was standing at it in the dark, alone, in his shirtsleeves, with a hammer.

Not working iron. There was no iron on the anvil.

Working *stone*.

A lump of grey Blightmarch dust, packed hard. The same dust as the trench. As the whole hundred miles of it. He was hammering it. Slowly. Steadily. Asking it. Shaping it. Making it hold.

Testing. The way you test sand for a mould. Pack it. Strike it. See if it keeps the shape.

It didn't.

She watched it crumble under his hammer. Watched him look at it. Watched him sweep it off the anvil with the side of his hand. And scoop up more. And pack it. And lift the hammer.

His face was grey. His eyes were red. The handprint on his cheek glittered in the light of the hearth.

"*Lex*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED UP.

"*Seraphine*." His voice was hoarse. "*What's wrong? Is it Father? Is he—*"

"*He's asleep. He's fine.*" She was breathless. "*Lex. Lex, stop. Stop hammering.*"

He stopped.

"*It doesn't hold*," he said. He looked at the dust on the anvil. "*Nine days. It doesn't hold. Not the trench, not the walls, not the floor. I've tried everything. Brannoc's tried everything. The Ashari bake it and it cracks. Teo's tide wets it and it slumps.*" He rubbed his face. "*It's dead, Seraphine. The whole Blightmarch. Twenty years of Gloam. There's nothing left in it to hold a shape. It's like trying to make a mould out of ash.*"

"*That's because you're making the wrong thing*," said Seraphine.

He looked at her.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're making a hole*," said Seraphine. "*A pit. A bowl. A shape. Walls and a floor and edges.*" She was gasping. She'd run the whole way. "*That's what a mould is. I know. You're right. It needs a shape.*"

"*Then—*"

"*It doesn't have a shape*." She grabbed his arm. His big scarred forearm, grey with dust. "*Lex. It doesn't have one. I asked it. Just now. At the scar. It made a room round me and I asked it what shape it wanted to be.*"

He went very still.

"*It said it doesn't know*," said Seraphine. "*It said it's been every shape. A pool. A hunger. The dark under the lid. A room.*" Her voice cracked. "*It said nobody's ever let it just* be.*"*

"*Then what do we—*"

"*We don't make it a shape*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*We make it a* word."

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE PULLED OUT HER notebook.

Right there. At the anvil. In the light of his hearth. She flipped past forty pages of shapes, of outlines, of drawings that hadn't been right. To the back. To a page she'd drawn on the very first night, in the library at the Keep, before any of this.

A circle. With a break in it.

The glyph. From Malachi's vellum. The one scratched into the black. The one Lex had cut into every Hush-cup, on the inside, on the curve, where the palms would be.

Hollow.

"*Wellscript*," said Seraphine. "*Lex. Listen. The Founders' glyphs. You used to read them. With the Root. You know what they are.*"

"*Runes*."

"*They're not runes*." She shook her head. Hard. "*Runes are what you cut into iron. To tell it what to do. Ardent. Stay. Hush.*" She tapped the page. "*Wellscript's older. Wellscript's what the Listeners wrote before the net. Before runes. Before anything.*" She looked at him. "*Do you know what a Wellscript glyph* is?"

He shook his head.

"*It's a name*," said Seraphine. "*Not a word for a thing. The thing's own name. The name a Well would answer to. If you wrote it right. If you wrote it big enough.*" She looked at the broken circle on the page. "*That's why the Codex is written in them. That's why Malachi drew the seventh in the middle and filled it black and scratched this into it.*"

She looked up at him.

"*He wasn't labelling it*," said Seraphine. "*He was calling it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STARED AT THE page.

At the broken circle. At the gap. At the place where the ring didn't quite close.

"*A hundred miles*," he said slowly.

"*A hundred miles*." Seraphine was nodding. Fast. "*Not a bowl. Not a pit. A* glyph. *Cut into the ground. Into the Blightmarch. Round. A hundred miles across.*" She drew her finger round the circle on the page. "*The trench is the line. You've already started it. You started it nine days ago. You just didn't know what you were writing.*"

She stopped her finger. At the break. At the gap in the circle.

"*And here*," she said. "*Where it doesn't close.*"

He looked at it.

"*Where's that*?" said Lex Vey.

Seraphine looked past him. Past the anvil. Past the hearth. At the black ruins rising behind him in the starlight. At the gap in the fallen wall where the gate had been. At the hall beyond it. At the warm dark scar on the floor.

"*There*," she said. "*The breach.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

He stood at his anvil of black Gloam-stone in the middle of the grey plain at two in the morning with the hammer hanging from his hand and looked at the page in her notebook. At the broken circle. At the gap.

And she watched it happen.

She'd watched it happen before. In the gold room at the bottom of the world, when his mother said *somewhere with room*. In the long hall of the Ashbourne Forge, when Ivy Moss said *change them*. It came up out of his hands. Always. Out of the part of him that had stood at an anvil since he was eleven.

"*A mould*," he said. Very slowly. "*Is the shape the metal takes.*"

"*Yes*."

"*So if the mould's a word—*"

"*Then whatever pours into it*," said Seraphine, "*takes the shape of the word.*"

"*It takes its own name*."

"*It takes its own name*." Her eyes were stinging. "*It comes up through the breach. Into the circle. Into a hundred miles of its own name, written in the*

ground, by everyone who came here to make room for it." She swallowed. *"And it's not a pool. And it's not a hunger. And it's not the dark under a lid."*

"It's itself," said Lex.

"It's itself," said Seraphine Ilvane. *"For the first time. In nine hundred years. Since before the Nine. Since it was a little pool in a valley that nobody ever stopped at."*

She closed the notebook.

"We're not digging it a hole," she said. *"We're writing it a name. So it knows what it is when it gets here."*

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX PUT DOWN THE hammer.

On the anvil. Very carefully. The way you'd put down something you weren't going to need for a while.

Then he picked her up.

Off the ground. Notebook and all. And swung her round. Once. In the starlight. In the middle of the grey plain. The way Brannoc had picked up his mother on the slope of the Hollowmaw.

"Put me down!" Seraphine was laughing. Shrieking. *"Lex! Put me down! You'll wake the whole camp!"*

He put her down.

And kissed her on the forehead. Hard. The way his mother had, in the gold room.

"You heard it," said Lex Vey.

"I heard it."

"It talked to you."

"It talked to me." She was crying now. She couldn't stop. *"It made a room. And I was in it. And it talked."*

He looked at her. With his red eyes and his grey face and the handprint glittering.

"Malachi would be so—" He stopped. His voice cracked. *"He said someone has to write it down. He said it wasn't a failing."*

"I know."

"He was right," said Lex. *"Someone had to. Someone had to sit there for five years writing it all down. Every word. Every glyph."* He tapped the

notebook in her hands. *"So that when the time came, someone would know how to write its name."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PANEL CAME WHILE she was standing there.

In the dark. At the anvil. With Lex's hands on her shoulders and her notebook against her chest and her face wet.

Silver. Gold. And something else. The clear color. The window color. The color of the air in an empty room.

```
SERAPHINE ILVANE
Class: LATTICE SCRIBE (Rare)
  → SCRIBE OF THE SEVENTH (Epic)
Level 44 → 52
ATTUNEMENT
  ▓▓▓ (unrecognized) ... ANSWERING
"She asked. It made room. She wrote
 down what it said. That is the whole
 of the art."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE READ IT TWICE.

Scribe of the Seventh.

Then she laughed. Wetly. Into her hands.

"It doesn't know what to call it," she said. *"Look. Unrecognized. The net still doesn't have a name for it."*

"Not yet," said Lex.

She looked up at him.

"It will," said Lex Vey. *"On Lantern Night. When it comes up into a hundred miles of its own name."* He looked out at the trench. At the long dark line of it going away east under the stars. *"Then the net'll have to call it something."*

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT BACK TO the tent at dawn.

Exhausted. Dizzy. With the notebook full. With Lex already gone to wake Brannoc and Grandmother Asha and Teo and every smith in the camp, shouting, *it's a word, it's a word, we're writing a word*, so that the

whole Blightmarch woke at once to the sound of a Worldforger running between the tents like a boy on Kindling-day.

She lifted the tent-flap.

And stopped.

The cot was empty.

The blanket was folded. Neatly. At the foot. The way a Warden folds a blanket, in the Spire, in the dormitory, every morning for two hundred years.

The grey book was on the table.

Open.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WENT TO IT. Slowly. She didn't want to. She went.

It was open to the page where the names were. Two thousand one hundred and six of them. In his shaking hand. Between the line and the price of bread.

And under the last one, a space.

And under the space, three lines she'd never seen before. In a hand that shook more than all the others. As if he'd written them in the dark. By feel.

Price: known. Her household drinks from her hands.

So will I. Once. Long enough to climb the stairs.

Then I'll give it back.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE READ IT THREE times.

Then she put the book down. Very carefully. On the table. Open. The way he'd left it.

And went outside. Into the dawn. Into the grey. Into the noise of the camp waking, and Lex shouting, and Brannoc shouting back, and the Ashari cackling, and the first hammers starting up, one by one, down the long line of the trench.

She looked south.

Toward Highcrest. A hundred miles off. Beyond the edge of seeing.

Toward the Spire. And a room at the top of it. And a chair by a window.

"*Antho*," she said. Not loudly. Not to anyone.

And then louder. Running. Toward the ruins. Toward the fallen hall. Toward the scar on the floor, where her husband was asleep with his hand on it and the clay lamp beside him.

"*Antho*!"

◆ ◆ ◆

ASHKA WAS GONE FROM the camp.

So was the litter.

And in the soft grey dust at the edge of the trench, where the dragon had been sleeping, Seraphine found the marks. Ashka's great claws. The drag of the litter-poles. And between them, very faint, so faint she'd never have seen it if she hadn't spent her whole life noticing what wasn't there—

Footprints.

Small ones. Bare. A boy's.

Going to the dragon. Climbing up.

Not coming back.

CHAPTER 29

The Old Man and the Moth

ARION VEY HAD NOT stolen anything in two hundred and thirty-three years, and he was finding it very educational.

He'd stolen a dragon. That was the first thing. A full-grown storm-drake the size of a house, from the edge of a trench in the middle of the Blightmarch at four in the morning, while his son slept on a black floor with his hand on a scar and his son's wife walked across a grey plain toward an anvil to tell his other son how to write a name.

He hadn't meant to steal her. He'd meant to ask.

He'd lain on the litter at the edge of the trench and waited until the camp was quiet. And then he'd said, very softly, into the dark, "*Ashka.*"

And the dragon had lifted her great blue head off her forepaws and looked at him with one golden eye.

Please, he'd thought. Not knowing if she could hear him. He'd never had the Bloodbond. He'd never been able to talk to dragons. *Please. I need to go to Highcrest. I need to go now. Before I can't.*

Ashka had looked at him for a long time.

And then she'd got up. And come over. And lowered her neck. And slid her great head under the litter, very gently, the way a dog slides its nose under your hand. And lifted it. Onto her back. Into the place between the two ridges of scale where Brannoc's straps were.

And Arion had lain there on the litter on the dragon's back in the dark and laughed silently until he cried.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SECOND THING HE'D stolen was a boy.

He hadn't meant to steal him either. He hadn't known he was there. Ashka had gone up off the grey in a long slow climb, quiet, careful, the way she flew with Pim on her back. And somewhere over the edge of the Blightmarch, with the stars going round and the wind cold on his face, Arion had felt something move at the foot of the litter.

A small cold hand. On his ankle. Through the blanket.

He'd lifted his head. Slowly.

Pim was sitting at the foot of the litter. Cross-legged. In his blue coat with the brass buttons buttoned wrong. With his hair blowing everywhere and his grey-violet eyes very steady.

"*Pim*," said Arion.

The boy didn't say anything.

"*You can't come*."

Pim didn't say anything.

"*Pim. It's dangerous. It's the most dangerous thing I've ever done. I'm going into the Spire. To her. To the Moth. I might not—*" He stopped. "*I might not come out.*"

Pim looked at him.

And then he moved up the litter. On his knees. Carefully. Holding the straps. Until he was beside Arion's head. And lay down. On his side. Next to him. On the litter. With his thin arm across Arion's chest.

The way he'd lain at the foot of the litter all the way from the Keep. The way he'd stood by the litter at the cave mouth with his hand on the edge. The way he'd sat on the rock at the Hollowmaw a year ago, telling an old man about the bats in the cold-room, waving his hands.

"*Moths can't see me*," said Pim. Into the blanket. Very quietly.

Arion didn't say anything.

"*I've got a room*," said Pim. "*Inside. Where nothing gets in. The Ferryman said.*" A pause. "*She won't see me. Nobody will.*"

Arion looked up at the stars.

"*Your master will kill me*," he said.

"*Master Antho doesn't kill people*," said Pim. "*He reads to bats.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN OUTSIDE Highcrest an hour before dawn.

Not near. Not close. Ashka knew. She came down in a hollow in the downs ten miles north, in a stand of beech, where nobody would see. She set the litter down very gently on the leaf-mould. And lay down beside it. And curled round it. Like a cat round a hearth. With her great golden eye on the old man.

Waiting.

Arion lay on the litter and looked south. Through the beech trunks. At the glitter. The lid over the city. Faint and grey-gold in the starlight. And under it, at the top of the hill, the Spire.

Lit.

Every window.

And the top one brightest.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*I can't climb*," he said. To no one. To the boy beside him. To the dragon. "*I couldn't climb the steps of the Spire if my life depended on it. I couldn't climb out of this litter.*"

Pim didn't answer.

"*But she'll let me in*," said Arion. "*She'll send someone down. She'll carry me up. I know she will.*" He looked at the light at the top of the tower. "*She's been waiting for me. She's been reading my books and waiting for me to come.*"

He was quiet for a long time.

"*And when I get there*," said Arion Vey, "*she'll offer me a drink.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T HAVE TO go to her.

She came to him.

At dawn. In the beech hollow. With the light coming grey through the trunks. He heard nothing. Ashka heard nothing; he watched her head come up and her golden eye go wide, too late.

There was a moth on the litter.

On the blanket. On his chest. Large. Grey-gold. Wings spread. The size of his spread hand. With two rings on its upper wings, like eyes.

And through it, a voice.

Low. Soft. Hoarse. Delighted.

"*Warden-Architect*," said Maelis. "*You've thought about it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME FOR HIM at noon.

Four Mothwing. And a litter of their own. Black. Silk-hung. Like a bier. They came down out of the glitter over the beech hollow on their ragged wings, slowly, gently, the way autumn leaves come down, and landed in a ring round his litter. And bowed.

Ashka roared at them.

They didn't flinch. They didn't move. They knelt on the leaf-mould with their pale faces bowed and their dull gold eyes on the ground and waited, while the storm-drake roared and lashed her tail and lightning crackled along her horns.

"*Ashka*," said Arion. "*It's all right.*"

The dragon looked at him. With her great golden eye. And something in it, through the eye, through whatever it was that dragons had instead of words, that made his old heart turn over.

"*It's all right*," said Arion again. Very gently. "*I asked them to come.*"

He looked at the boy. Beside him. Very still.

"*Stay with her*," he said. "*Pim. Stay with Ashka. Don't come.*"

Pim looked at him.

And nodded.

Arion knew he was lying. He let him. Some things you let a boy lie about.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTHWING CARRIED HIM up the West Way.

On the black litter. Through the dim streets. Past the people. Standing in doorways. Sitting on steps. Swaying. With their dark lanterns held up toward the Spire. He looked at their faces as he passed. He couldn't help it. He'd lived in this city two hundred years. He knew some of them.

The woman who sold cheese in the Tuesday market. The old porter from the Spire gate who'd carried his trunks for forty years and never once asked why he didn't age. A boy he'd taught letters to, a long time ago, in a

charity school in the Lower Town, grown now, grey at the temples, swaying in a doorway with his children beside him.

Hollis Penn.

On the Spire steps. In the front row. In his apron. With flour on his hands. Holding up his loaf-shaped lantern, dark, with dust on it. Toward the gold window at the top.

Arion looked at him for a long time as the litter went past.

He didn't know Hollis Penn's warm thing. He didn't know what had been taken. He'd met the man twice. Once at the Highcrest singing, waking up holding a loaf. Once at the wedding, carrying bread up a mountain.

He thought: *someone does. Someone loves him. A wife. A daughter. An apprentice.*

He thought: *someone will come*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DIDN'T TAKE HIM up the stairs.

There was a lift. Lysandra had put it in for her grandfather. A cage of brass and wood on chains, in a shaft at the heart of the Spire, that went up six floors with a great deal of clanking. Arion had ridden in it every day for twenty years. He knew every creak.

They took him up in it now. In the black litter. With the Mothwing standing round him in the brass cage, silent, swaying.

Six floors.

And then the last stair. The narrow one. The one that went up from the sixth floor to the top, to the rooms under the roof, where he'd lived for two hundred years. Ninety-four steps. He'd climbed it ten thousand times. Twenty thousand.

The Mothwing carried him up it.

And at the top, the door. His door. Plain oak. With a brass handle that stuck in wet weather.

It was open.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROUND ROOM WAS lit.

Gold. Soft. Warm. From nowhere. From everywhere. From the walls and the floor and the ceiling and the shelves of grey books and the cold grate that had never once, in two hundred years, warmed the room properly. The light came out of all of it. Like the light in a lamp. Like the light in two eyes at the end of a long lane.

And she was in his chair.

By the window. The tall window looking north over the city. In his chair. With one of his grey books open on her knees. Reading.

She looked up.

"*Warden-Architect*," said Maelis. "*Welcome home.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T LOOK AT her.

Not first. He'd decided that on the litter. On the West Way. On the lift. He'd decided it a hundred times. *Don't look at her. Look at the room. Look for—*

She was on the window seat.

Small. Barefoot. In a grey dress that wasn't hers, too long in the hem. With her grey-brown hair loose. With her hands in her lap. Bound. With something fine and grey-gold and glittering. Silk. Moth-silk. Round her wrists. Like a bracelet. Like a string of pearls.

Her right palm was bandaged.

She was looking at him.

Her face—

He didn't know what her face was doing. He'd never know. It went white. And then it went still. And then something went across it, so fast he almost missed it. Something that wasn't fear. Something that wasn't relief.

Something *furious*.

"*You stupid*," said Seren Vey, "*stupid old man.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS LAUGHED.

Delighted. Low and warm. She put down the grey book. Carefully. On the little table beside the chair. Where he'd always put his books. Where the ring from his teacup had worn a pale mark in the wood over two hundred years.

"*Oh, she's been like this the whole time*," said Maelis. Fondly. "*Six days. She won't eat. She won't sleep. She won't tell me where my sister's crown is.*" She looked at Seren. "*She sits on your window seat and tells me what she'd like to do to me. In some detail. She's very inventive.*"

"*I'll show you inventive*," said Seren.

"*I'm sure you will, my dear.*" Maelis didn't take her eyes off Arion. "*But not just now. Your husband's come to visit. All this way. On a litter. To see you.*" Her lit eyes were very soft. "*Isn't that lovely.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Her hand*," said Arion.

Maelis looked at the bandage. On Seren's palm.

"*The first night*," she said. Simply. "*I'm sorry. I didn't want to. But I needed it. A little. Just a little. In a glass bottle.*" She smiled. "*It's on your desk. Would you like to see?*"

He didn't look.

He didn't need to. He could see it. Out of the corner of his eye. On his desk. Where he'd written two hundred years of grey books. A small glass bottle, the size of a thumb. Stoppered. Sealed with grey-gold wax. And inside it, dark. Red-dark. A finger's depth.

Harrow blood.

"*It's not enough*," said Maelis. Conversationally. "*Not for the Veil. Not for all four of them. I'll need more. On Lantern Night. When the little one comes up.*" She tilted her head. "*But it's enough to start. Enough to loosen the knot. Enough to wake them.*" Her lit eyes were very warm. "*They'll be stirring by now. In their cocoons. Feeling it. The give in the knot.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You came to say yes*," said Maelis.

It wasn't a question.

Arion looked at her. Finally. At her face. At her eyes. Lit. Gold. Warm. Like windows. Like lamps.

And felt it. The pull. The lane. The house at the top of the hill with every window lit and the door open and someone standing in it.

He let it pull.

He'd decided that too. On the litter. *Let it. Don't fight it. You're too old to fight it. Let her think it's working.*

"*Yes*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN MADE A SOUND.

Small. Sharp. Like something breaking.

He didn't look at her. He couldn't. If he looked at her he'd stop. He'd look at her face and see what was on it and he'd stop.

"*I'm eighty-five*," he said to Maelis. "*I think. I lose track. A year a week. More.*" He held up his hand. Thin. Shaking. "*I came up your stairs on a litter carried by your people because I couldn't climb them. I can't hold a cup. I can't stand.*" He looked at the window seat. Not at Seren. At the window behind her. "*She's here. In my room. And I can't get up out of this litter and cross the floor to her.*"

"*No*," said Maelis gently. "*You can't.*"

"*You said you'd give me time*."

"*I did*."

"*Twenty years*."

"*As much as you like*." Maelis leaned forward in his chair. Her long glowing hands on her knees. "*Enough to be young. Enough to stand. Enough to cross a floor.*"

She held out her hands.

Cupped.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS LIGHT IN them.

He'd seen it before. Through Antho's eyes, through the little one's memory, in a hall of glass nine hundred years ago. Through Lex's account, in the deep, when she knelt and drank. He'd never seen it with his own.

It was beautiful.

Dark and gold at once. Soft and deep and glowing. Like the night sky far from any town. Like the moment before a word. It moved in her cupped hands like water, like light, like something alive. Pouring a little between her long fingers. Leaking.

The little one, he thought. *A piece of it. What she drank in the deep. What she's been keeping.*

Its screaming, in a cup.

"*Drink*," said the Moth Queen.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DRANK.

She leaned down. Over the litter. Close. Her silver hair falling round them both like a curtain. And held her cupped hands to his mouth. The way she'd held them to her household, nine hundred years ago. The way she'd held them to Orrin. To Silas Hask.

And he bent his head. Slowly. His old neck creaking.

And drank.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT DIDN'T TASTE OF anything.

That was the first thing. He'd expected it to taste of something. Light. Honey. Wine. It didn't. It went into his mouth like air. Like breath. Like the first breath you take after you've been holding it a long time underwater.

And then it went *down*.

Into his throat. His chest. His heart. His old slow uneven heart, beating like a drum with a hole in it. And the hole—

Closed.

He felt it close. Like a door. Like a wound. Like a dam being mended, stone by stone, all at once, from the inside. The water that had been pouring through him for months, the two hundred years coming due, the flood—

Stopped.

Held.

Like the Root had held it. For two hundred years. Like a hand holding a door shut.

And then it went *back*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT GO.

His hands first. On the litter. He was looking at them. He couldn't look away. The brown spots. Fading. The knuckles. Shrinking. The skin. Tightening. Smoothing. The tremor—

Gone.

His hands were still. Steady. Long. Narrow. Brown. Strong. A young man's hands. A Warden-Architect's hands, at thirty-one, the year he took the Root. The hands he'd had for two hundred years. The hands he'd stood in front of the mirror and prayed would change.

He lifted them. Turned them over. They didn't shake.

He felt his face. His jaw. The furrows. Going. Like snow off a roof in spring. He felt his hair. Thick. Heavy. Dark. Falling across his forehead. He felt his back straighten on the litter. His shoulders. His chest. Deep. Full. Breathing all the way down.

He felt his heart. Slow. Strong. Even.

Thirty-one.

He sat up.

He didn't decide to. His body did it. On its own. The way a young body does. And then he swung his legs off the litter. And put his feet on the floor of his own round room. And stood.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS STANDING.

In the middle of the room. On his own feet. Without a stick. Without a hand. In his old grey coat, which was too big for him again now, which hung on his shoulders the way it had hung a year and a half ago, at the masquerade, when he was forty-five forever.

He took a step.

And another.

Across the floor. Toward the window seat. Toward the small barefoot woman with moth-silk on her wrists and a bandage on her palm, sitting very straight, staring at him.

He stopped in front of her.

And looked down at her. With his young face. His dark hair. His grey eyes.

And she looked up at him.

And he saw it. He saw her see him. A young man. Thirty-one. Dark-haired. Grey-eyed. Standing in front of her in the gold light.

The man she'd met on the steps of the Spire in the rain. The man in the forty pages. The man she'd paid away.

She didn't know him.

He saw that too. He saw her look at his young face and search it, the way she'd searched his old one, with her hands, in the cavern at the bottom of the Hollowmaw. Search it for something. Anything.

And find nothing.

She didn't know this face. She'd never known it. The Ferryman had it. All of it. The steps and the rain and the lanterns and the young man in the grey coat who had looked at her as if she were the first light he'd seen in two hundred years.

She didn't remember any of it.

She'd only ever known the old one.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Say something*," said Seren.

Her voice was a whisper.

He looked at her.

"*Say something*," she said again. Her eyes were very bright. "*Please. I don't know your face. I never did. I only knew the old one.*" Her voice cracked. "*Say something, so I'll know it's you.*"

Arion Vey knelt down.

In front of the window seat. On the floor of his own room. With his young knees, that didn't creak. And took her bound hands in his young hands, that didn't shake.

"*Good evening*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE SHUT HER EYES.

And listened.

He watched her do it. Watched her face go still. Watched her listen to his voice. Young now. Deep. Quiet. Dry. The voice from the Root. The voice from Ember. The voice she'd fallen in love with in the dark, twice, without knowing whose it was.

And he watched her open her eyes.

"*You sound wrong*," said Seren Vey.

He stared at her.

"*You sound wrong*," she said. Fiercely. Wet. "*You sound like the dark. Like the Root. Like Ember. You don't sound like* you." She was holding his hands so hard it hurt. "*You sound like a voice I fell in love with three years ago through a wall. Not like the man who ate my burnt porridge. Not like the man who said page nine.*"

He couldn't speak.

"*I liked the old one*," said his wife. "*You stupid man. I liked him. I liked his hands. I liked that they shook. I liked that he fell asleep in the middle of telling me about Lex.*" Her voice broke. "*Why did you do this? Why did you let her—*"

"*To climb the stairs*," said Arion.

She stopped.

"*To get to you*," he said. Very quietly. "*That's all. I couldn't climb the stairs.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

BEHIND HIM, MAELIS LAUGHED.

Softly. Warmly. Like someone watching children play.

"*Isn't that lovely*," she said. "*He came all this way. To be young for you. And you don't want him.*" She rose from his chair. Tall. Glowing. Unfolding. "*I did warn him, Seren. I did. I said she doesn't remember a young man. I said, let her fall in love with you a third time.*" She tilted her head. "*I didn't think she'd fall in love with the old one.*"

She came across the room. Slowly. Her gown whispering on the floor. Her wings shifting under the silk of her back.

"*No matter*," said Maelis. "*He's mine now. Aren't you, Warden-Architect?*" She stopped behind him. Close. He felt her there. The warmth. The glow. "*You drank from my hands. Like Orrin. Like Silas. You'll need to come back. Every few days. For more.*" Her voice was very soft. "*Because it leaks. Doesn't it. Your clever son told you. It always leaks.*"

He felt it.

He'd felt it from the first breath. Under the youth. Under the strength. Under the steady even heart. A thread. Thin. Fine. Like a hair. Running out of the middle of him. Leaking. Slowly. Like water through a crack in a cup.

Pulling him toward her.

A Vey on a string.

"*Stay with me*," said Maelis of the Crowned. "*Be my friend. Sit in your chair by your window and read me your books. And I'll keep you young.*" She bent down. Her silver hair brushing his shoulder. "*And on Lantern Night, when your sons bring the little one up, you'll stand beside me. And help me hold your wife's hand over it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

Slowly. On his young legs. And turned round. And looked at her.

"*No*," said Arion Vey.

Maelis smiled.

"*You don't get to say no*," she said gently. "*Not anymore. Not with my light in you.*"

"*Your light*." He looked at her. "*Is that what it is?*"

Her smile flickered.

"*It's not yours*," said Arion. "*It's the little one's. You knelt in the deep and put your hands in it and drank while it screamed. My son heard it. My wife heard it. Kell heard it.*" He touched his chest. Where the thread was. Where the light was. "*This isn't yours. You stole it. And you poured it into me. And now I'm carrying it.*"

He looked at her.

"*And what you carry*," said Arion Vey, "*you can give back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T RUN.

He'd thought about running. On the litter. In the lift. A hundred times. *Drink. Stand. Grab her. Run. Down the stairs. Out of the Spire. Into the city.*

He didn't run.

He walked. Calmly. Past the Moth Queen. Across his own round room. To the tall bookcase on the far wall, crammed with old leather spines. And put his hand on a book. Third shelf. Fourth from the left. *A History of the Treaty of Scald, Volume II.*

And pulled it down.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BOOKCASE SWUNG OPEN.

Behind it, the little round room. Windowless. Dusty. Lavender and old paper. Portraits on every wall, floor to ceiling, frame to frame. Two hundred years of one man's face. Never older. Never younger. Staring.

Maelis was behind him. He felt her come. Fast. Glowing.

"*What's this*?" she said. And for the first time since he'd known her, her voice wasn't soft. It was *interested*. "*What's this, Warden? It's not in your books.*"

"*No*," said Arion. "*It wouldn't be.*"

He went into the little room. To the far wall. To the great dark canvas there, taller than a man, cracked and blackened with age. A portrait of himself in the robes of a High Warden two hundred years out of fashion. The oldest one. The first. Painted the year he took the Root.

Thirty-one.

He looked at it. At the young man in the painting. Dark-haired. Grey-eyed. Tired already. Trapped already. Staring out of the canvas at a room he'd never leave.

"*I always hated this one*," said Arion Vey.

And put his foot through it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A STAIR behind it.

Narrow. Steep. Dark. Cut into the stone of the Spire's wall. Going down. A Warden-Architect's stair. Built by the first one, nine hundred years ago, so that the holder of the Root could leave the top of the tower without passing through any door that anyone else could see.

Arion had used it twice in two hundred years.

Once to go and meet a girl on the steps in the rain.

Once to go to Vhessa.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Seren*!"

He turned. And she was already there. In the doorway of the little room. Barefoot. With the moth-silk still on her wrists. And behind her, holding the end of the silk in both small hands, untying it, very fast, very quietly, with his tongue between his teeth—

Pim.

In his blue coat. Grey with dust. His hair everywhere. His grey-violet eyes very steady. He'd come in through the door. Through the round room. Past the Moth Queen. Past the Mothwing at the stair. Nobody had seen him. Nobody ever did.

A room with the lamp out.

The silk came off Seren's wrists. Pim dropped it. On the floor. And looked up at Arion.

"*I lied*," said Pim. "*About staying.*"

"*I know*," said Arion. "*Thank you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS WAS IN THE doorway.

Behind Seren. Behind Pim. Tall. Glowing. Her lit eyes very wide. Her long hands reaching. Not fast. Not hurried. The way you'd reach for a moth on a window.

For Seren.

And Pim turned round. In the doorway of the little room. Between the Moth Queen and the woman she was reaching for.

And was *silent*.

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION FELT IT GO out of him. The deep silence. The room in the boy. The place where nothing was. It went out of Pim and filled the doorway of the little round room like water filling a cup.

And Maelis's hands *stopped*.

In the air. An inch from Seren's back. Pressed against nothing. The way her hand had pressed against nothing in front of Antho's chest, in the deep, at the tear.

She looked down.

At the boy. Small. In a blue coat. Standing in the doorway. With his arms at his sides and his thin face set and his eyes on her.

And her face changed.

Not anger. Not surprise.

Fear.

"*What*," said Maelis of the Crowned, very softly, "*are you?*"

Pim didn't answer.

He never did.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*GO*," said Arion.

Seren went. Past him. Into the dark of the stair. Barefoot. Fast. He heard her feet on the stone. Going down.

He looked at Pim.

"*Come on*," he said. "*Pim. Come on. Now.*"

Pim didn't move.

He stood in the doorway. With the silence pouring out of him. Holding the Moth Queen back with nothing. With a room. With a place in himself where nothing was, that he'd made out of being hurt.

He was shaking.

"*I can't*," said Pim. Without turning round. Very quietly. "*If I move, it goes. If it goes, she comes through.*"

"*Pim—*"

"*Go*," said the boy. "*She needs you to go. The lamp-lady.*" His voice was very small. "*Somebody has to stand in the door.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ARION VEY STOOD IN the little round room behind the bookcase at the top of the Spire, surrounded by two hundred years of his own face, with the Moth Queen's stolen light in his young chest and the stair to freedom at his back and his wife's footsteps going down it.

And a thirteen-year-old boy in the doorway, shaking, holding back a Sovereign with nothing at all.

Somebody has to stand in the door.

He thought about Antho. In a cave. For eight years. Holding a breach shut that he didn't know was there. With his mother holding it from the other side.

He thought about Kell. In the deep. With a broken stick.

He thought about Seren. Thirteen years. With her back against a door. Singing.

He thought about himself. Two hundred years. In a crystal. In a tower. Holding the net. Alone. Because it was easier than facing what he'd done.

I tore it alone, he'd said to his son, on the black floor at Duskhold. *You open it with everyone.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME BACK ACROSS the little room.

And stood behind Pim. In the doorway. Close. With his young hands on the boy's thin shoulders.

And didn't push. And didn't pull.

He was a Warden-Architect. Two hundred and thirty-three years old. He'd stood in more doorways than anyone alive.

He knew how to stand behind someone in one.

"*I've got you*," said Arion. Very quietly. Into the boy's hair. "*I've got you. You're not holding it alone.*"

And Pim's shaking stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS LOOKED AT THEM.

Over the boy's head. At the young man behind him. With her lit eyes. With her long hands pressed flat against nothing.

"*Warden-Architect*," she said. "*You can't stand there forever. Neither of you can. He's a child. You're—*" She smiled. Thin. "*You're mine. You'll need me. In a day. Two. You'll feel it leaking and you'll need me.*"

"*I know*," said Arion.

"*Then step aside.*"

"*No.*"

"*Then what*," said Maelis, "*do you think you're going to do?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOOK HIS HANDS off Pim's shoulders.

Slowly. Still standing behind him. Still in the doorway.

And cupped them.

In front of his own chest. Over his heart. Where the light was. Where the thread was. Where the little one's stolen screaming sat in him, holding back the flood. The way she'd cupped hers, to give it to him.

He'd never done this. He'd never Listened. Not properly. He'd been a Listener's husband for eight years and learned a little, nothing like his sons. He didn't know how to give a thing back.

But he'd watched.

He'd watched his wife put a lamp in his son's hands. *Not waiting. Given. To you. For you.* He'd watched Lex claim a core and hold it warm in his palm. He'd watched the little one, through his son's eyes, in a hall of glass, nine hundred years ago, feel a cupful of something pour back into it from a girl's empty hands.

She gave me back, it had said. *Just a little. Just what she had.*

Nobody else ever did.

"*It's not mine*," said Arion Vey. To the Moth Queen. To the light in his chest. To the little one, wherever it was, at the bottom of the world, pressing up against the bottom of a scar in a fallen hall.

"*It's yours*," he said. "*I'm giving it back.*"

And he *poured*.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT OUT OF him the way breath goes out after you've held it a long time.

All at once. Through his cupped hands. Out of his chest. Out of the middle of him. Dark and gold and glowing, like the night sky far from any town. Pouring between his fingers. Not leaking. *Pouring*. On purpose. Given.

Down.

Onto the floor of the little round room. Onto the stone. Into the stone. Into the Spire. Down through six floors and the lift-shaft and the foundations and the hill and the bedrock of Highcrest. Down. Into the dark under the world. Into the room under everything.

Home.

And the flood came back.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT.

Two hundred years. Held back by the Root. Held back by the Moth's stolen light. And now nothing holding it. The dam gone. The water coming. All of it. At once.

His hands first. In front of his chest. Still cupped. Empty now. He watched them. The skin loosening. The knuckles swelling. The brown spots coming up through the young skin like stains through cloth.

He felt his back curve. His knees go. His hair—

He felt it go. White. Thin. Fine as thistledown. Falling across his forehead.

He felt his heart.

Slow. Uneven. A drum with a hole in it. Slower than before. Older than before.

Older than he'd ever been.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT DOWN.

Slowly. Onto his knees. In the doorway. Behind Pim. With his empty hands still cupped. And his white head bowed.

And the Moth Queen stood in front of them both with her hands pressed against nothing and looked at the old man on his knees.

Her face—

He'd remember it. For as long as he had left. Which wasn't long.

It was the face of someone watching a lamp go out that they'd wanted very much. That they'd lit themselves. That they'd thought was theirs.

"*Why*?" said Maelis. In a whisper. "*Why would you—you were young. You were* young. *You could have had twenty years. A hundred. Forever.*"

Arion looked up at her.

He was very tired. He was older than he'd ever been. He could feel the end of it. Close. Like a wall in the dark that you can't see but you know is there, a step ahead.

He smiled.

"*Because she liked the old one*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HANDS.

Under his arms. Small ones. Strong ones. Square. Lifting.

He was being lifted. Off his knees. Out of the doorway. Back. Into the little room. Toward the stair. Toward the broken canvas and the dark beyond it.

He turned his head.

His wife.

She'd come back up. Barefoot. Up the Warden-Architect's stair. She was lifting him. With her arms under his. Dragging him. Swearing. Under her breath. Very inventively.

"*You stupid*," said Seren Vey, through her teeth. "*Stupid, stupid, stupid old man.*"

"*Seren—*"

"*Be quiet*." She had him on his feet. Barely. His arm over her shoulders. Her arm round his waist. "*Be quiet and walk. Pim. Pim, love. Come on. Back up. Slowly. Don't turn round.*"

Pim backed up. Step by step. Into the little room. With his arms at his sides and the silence pouring out of him. Toward the stair.

And the Moth Queen stood in the doorway of the little round room, between the bookcase and two hundred years of portraits, with her hands pressed against nothing, and didn't follow.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN THE Warden-Architect's stair.

In the dark. Slowly. One step at a time. Seren holding him up. Pim behind them, backing down, silent. Down through the walls of the Spire. Down past six floors. Past the lift-shaft. Past the foundations.

It took a very long time.

He didn't remember most of it. He remembered her arm round his waist. Her shoulder under his arm. Her breath, hard, in the dark. Her voice, swearing, and then not swearing. Saying other things.

"*Page four*," she was saying. Somewhere near the bottom. In the dark. "*The librarian. That's my favorite. I told you.*"

"*I know*."

"*And page nine. The lanterns. Don't ever leave a light on for me, Warden.*"

"*Too late*."

"*Too late*." She was crying. He could feel it. On his shoulder. "*And page twelve. Neck like a bull. Sense of a turnip. Did I really say that?*"

"*You really said that*."

"*I don't remember*," said Seren Vey. Holding him up. In the dark. On the stair. "*I don't remember any of it. I don't remember you. I never knew your young face. I only ever knew the old one.*"

She stopped. On the stair. And held him.

"*But I think I'd like to*," she said. "*Remember. If I can. If there's time.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WAS A DOOR at the bottom.

Small. Iron. Rusted. Opening onto a lane behind the Spire. A lane he knew. A lane where, two hundred years ago, a young man in a grey coat had come out in the rain and walked round to the front steps, very casually, as if he'd just happened to be passing, and found a girl with flour on her cheek sheltering under the arch, laughing at the lanterns.

Seren pushed it open.

And outside, in the lane, in the dim grey-gold under-light of the glitter, waiting—

A dragon.

Blue. Enormous. Crackling. Crammed into the narrow lane so tightly her wings were folded flat against the walls on either side and her tail went round the corner and out of sight. With her great golden eye on the door.

Ashka.

And on her neck, with her hair burning gold and her Sunreach blade drawn and her amber eyes blazing—

"*Took your time*," said Kestrel Varn.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY GOT HIM ONTO the dragon's back.

He didn't remember that either. He remembered hands. Kestrel's. Seren's. Pim's small ones. Lifting. Pushing. Strapping. He remembered the

litter, Brannoc's litter, the leather and ash-wood and oiled canvas, and lying on it, and Seren lying down beside him, and Pim at their feet.

He remembered Ashka going up.

Straight up. Out of the lane. Through the glitter. The moths burning off her in sparks. Into the blue.

And he remembered looking back.

Down. At the city. At the Spire. At the top window. The brightest one.

And in it, a figure. Tall. Grey-gold. Glowing. Standing at his window. In his room. Watching them go.

Not following.

Watching.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SLEPT ON THE dragon.

When he woke, it was dark. Stars. Wind. The litter rocking under him like a boat.

His wife was asleep beside him. On her side. With her head on his shoulder and her bandaged hand on his chest.

He lay very still.

He couldn't feel his feet. He couldn't feel much of anything below the waist. His heart was slow and uneven and very, very tired. He knew. He'd known on the stair. He'd known the moment he poured the light back.

Older than before.

Older than I've ever been.

He looked at the stars.

Not long now, he thought. *Not past Lantern Night. Seraphine said. Not past Lantern Night.*

He turned his head. Slowly. On the litter. And looked at his wife's face. Asleep. Small. Freckled. Grey-brown hair across her cheek.

Long enough, he thought. *Please. Just long enough.*

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS GREY BOOK WAS in his coat.

He hadn't known he'd brought it. He must have. He always did. Two hundred years. He'd never once gone anywhere without one.

He got it out. Slowly. One-handed. Without waking her. And opened it. In the starlight. To the page.

Price: known. Her household drinks from her hands.

So will I. Once. Long enough to climb the stairs.

Then I'll give it back.

He found the pencil. In the binding. And under the last line, very small, so shaky it was almost illegible, he wrote:

Gave it back.

And then, under that:

She said she'd like to remember.

And then, under that, the old line. The one from the inside of the cover. The one he'd written two hundred times, on his birthday, at midwinter, alone.

No change.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he crossed it out. One long straight stroke. From corner to corner.

And under it, smaller than anything he'd ever written in his life, he wrote:

Everything changed.

And put the book back in his coat.

And closed his eyes.

And slept.

CHAPTER 30

The Cradle

ASHKA CAME HOME ON the fourth day, low and slow over the grey, with her wings shaking.

Lex saw her from the head of the trench. He'd been watching the south for four days. Ever since Seraphine came running across the plain at dawn shouting his brother's name, with the grey book in her hands. Ever since he'd stood in the empty tent with the folded blanket and read three lines in his father's shaking hand.

So will I. Once. Long enough to climb the stairs.

He'd wanted to go. He'd been on Vharuun's neck before Antho caught his arm.

No, his brother had said.

He's going to her. He's going to drink from her hands. He's going to—

I know what he's going to do. Antho's face had been white. *He told us. He left the book open. He didn't sneak off, Lex. He told us.* His grip had tightened. *He's never told anyone anything in two hundred years. And he told us. In writing. In the book. Where he puts everything that matters.*

So we let him go?

Kestrel's gone after him. Antho had looked south. *On Vharuun. An hour ago. She'll find Ashka. She'll wait.* He'd looked back at Lex. *And you've got a word to write. And I've got a door to learn.* His voice had cracked. *He gave us the edges. He stayed up all night giving them to me. So we could do this.*

So Lex had stayed.

He'd stood at the head of the trench for four days. Hammering. Testing. Shouting at Brannoc. Not sleeping. Looking south.

And now Ashka was coming.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE CAME DOWN BY the ruins. In the dust. Heavily. The way a dragon comes down when she's carried something a long way and her wings won't hold anymore.

There were people on her back.

Kestrel first. Sliding down off her neck. Grey with dust. Her hair dark. Her face set. She saw Lex coming across the rubble at a run and held up one hand. *Wait*.

Then a boy. Small. In a blue coat with brass buttons. Climbing down the dragon's foreleg like a squirrel. Pim. Who saw Antho coming from the other direction, from the fallen hall, and ran. Straight into him. And held on.

Then a woman. Small. Barefoot. Grey-brown hair. With a bandage on her right palm.

Kneeling on the litter.

Beside an old man.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX STOPPED.

At the foot of the dragon. In the dust. And looked up.

His father was lying on the litter. Under a blanket. With his eyes shut. And his face—

It wasn't eighty-five.

It wasn't ninety.

He didn't know what it was. He'd never seen a face like it. Not on anyone. Not on Old Mag, who was ninety-six. Not on Grandmother Asha, who said she was three hundred. It was a face like a walnut left in a drawer for a hundred years. All furrow. All bone. The skin so thin he could see the veins under it, blue, like rivers on a map. The hair on the pillow so white and so fine it was hardly hair at all. Like the down off a thistle. Like smoke.

His hands on the blanket were bones. Just bones. With skin.

"*He gave it back*," said his mother.

She was looking down at him. At his father. Not at Lex. Her square strong hand was on the old man's chest. Over his heart.

"*She gave him twenty years*," said Seren Vey. "*He was young. For an hour. He stood up and walked across the floor and knelt in front of me.*" Her voice was very steady. "*And then he gave it back. Poured it out. Through his hands. Down into the floor. Back to the little one.*"

She looked up at Lex.

"*He's older now than before he drank*," she said. "*He's older than anyone I've ever seen.*"

Lex couldn't speak.

"*He did it to climb the stairs*," said his mother. "*To get to me. And then he gave it back. So he wouldn't be hers.*" Her eyes were very bright. "*He said I liked the old one.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER OPENED HIS eyes.

Grey. Clear. Steady. Behind the furrows. Behind the hundred years in a drawer. The same grey. Always the same.

He looked up at Lex.

"*Ah*," said Arion Vey. His voice was a thread. A whisper. A sound like dry leaves. "*There you are. I wanted to tell you about the edges.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY PUT HIM IN the tent.

In the cot. With the blanket. With the grey book on his chest. And Seren sat beside him, on the stool, and didn't move.

She didn't move for three days.

She read to him. From the grey book. The names. Two thousand one hundred and six of them. One at a time. Slowly. And when she got to the end of Coldwater, Seraphine brought her Ashpit. And when she got to the end of Ashpit, Greyford.

And his father wrote them.

He couldn't hold the pencil anymore. Not properly. Seren held it for him. Her square hand round his bone hand round the pencil. Moving it. Letter by letter. Name by name. Slowly. In the space between the line and the price of bread.

Lex stood in the tent-flap the first night and watched them do it.

Hesk Corran. Hewer. Forty.

Moll Corran. His daughter. Nine. She kept a hen called Duchess.

He couldn't watch for long.

◆ ◆ ◆

[He's dying,] said Ember.

Lex was at the anvil. At the head of the trench. At two in the morning. With a lump of grey Blightmarch dust packed on the black Gloam-stone in front of him and a hammer in his hand. Not hammering.

I know.

[Not slowly. Not a season.] The coal in his hearth was very quiet. *[I can feel it. I'm a piece of him. When he poured it back, something went with it. Something that was holding.]*

How long?

Ember didn't answer for a long time.

[Lantern Night,] it said at last. Very quietly. *[He's holding on for Lantern Night. I can feel him holding. Like a man holding a door.]* A pause. *[I don't know if he'll make it.]*

Lex put down the hammer.

[Lex.]

Mm.

[Make the room,] said Ember. *[Make it in time. He wants to see it. He wants to see the little one come up. Through the breach he made.]* The coal glowed. *[He wants to see the door open the right way. Once. Before he goes.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DUST WOULDN'T HOLD.

That was the trouble. That was still the trouble. Seraphine had given him the word. The broken circle. A hundred miles across. Written into the Blightmarch with the break at the breach. He knew what to make now. He'd known since the night she ran across the plain with her notebook.

He didn't know how to make it *hold*.

The trench was cut. Fourteen miles of it, now. The Ashen Banners and the Keepers and the miners from Coldwater had been digging for two weeks, and the Sunreach riders dragging the spoil away on sledges, and the

farmers from the Vale with their ox-carts. Fourteen miles of trench. Ten feet deep. Twenty wide. Curving away east from the ruins of Duskhold in a long slow arc, like the first stroke of a pen on a very large page.

And it was falling in.

Every night. The walls slumped. The floor cracked. The dust, the dead grey dust of twenty years of Gloam, just wouldn't stand. The Ashari baked it. Two hundred old women in red, sitting in rows along the lip of the trench with their hands flat on the ground, black heat pouring out of them, baking the walls hard. And by morning the baked walls were cracked like old pottery and sliding down into the trench in heaps.

Teo's tide came. Up the old dry riverbeds from the sea, three hundred miles, a thin cold silver trickle that the Undertow sent because Teo asked it nicely. It wet the dust. And the wet dust slumped into mud. And the mud dried and cracked.

Brannoc's smiths hammered it. Forty students and every Flame-Listener from fifteen forges, standing in the trench with hammers, beating the walls, asking them. The walls held while they hammered. And fell in when they stopped.

It's dead, Lex had said. To Seraphine. Two weeks ago. *There's nothing left in it to hold a shape. It's like trying to make a mould out of ash.*

It still was.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're putting things in*," said Brannoc.

It was the fifth morning after Ashka came home. Dawn. Grey. The old smith had come and found him at the anvil, where he'd been all night, and stood beside him looking at the trench. At the walls that had fallen in overnight. At the heaps of grey dust in the bottom.

Lex looked at him.

"*Heat*," said Brannoc. "*Water. Hammers. Asking. All of it. You keep putting things in. Into the dust. To make it hold.*" He scratched his grey beard. "*Lad. That's not how you make a mould.*"

"*Then how—*"

"*What did I tell you*?" said Brannoc Holt. "*When you were twelve. In the casting-pit. With the sand and the wooden pattern for the hinge.*"

Lex stared at him.

"*Anybody can melt iron*," said Brannoc. "*Making the right kind of empty—that's the craft.*" He looked at the trench. "*You're not making the empty, lad. You're making the walls. And then you're trying to make the walls strong enough to hold an empty that isn't there yet.*" He shook his head. "*Backwards. All backwards.*"

"*Then how do I make the empty*?"

Brannoc looked at him for a long time. With his old kind fierce eyes.

"*I don't know*," he said. "*I never could. Not properly. Not the big ones. That's why I lost the toe on the church bell.*" He put his enormous hand on Lex's shoulder. "*I could never hear it. The empty. I could only make walls and hope.*"

He looked at the trench.

"*But somebody can*," said Brannoc. "*Somebody in this camp can hear it. The empty. Ask them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE ASKED SERAPHINE.

She tried. She sat with him at the anvil for a whole afternoon with her notebook on her knees and her eyes shut, listening, making little rooms of quiet round her hand the way she'd learned at the scar, and trying to explain.

It's not a thing, she said. *You keep trying to make it a thing. It's the space for a thing. You don't make it. You* leave *it.*

How?

I don't know. She opened her eyes. *I just ask. And it comes. I can't do it for you, Lex. It's like Listening to fire. You can't do it for someone. You can only sit with them while they learn.*

He asked Pim.

Pim looked at him for a long time with his grey-violet eyes. And then cupped his hands. Round nothing. Round the air. In front of Lex's face. And was silent.

And Lex felt the room. The space. The quiet in the boy's cupped hands.

And couldn't make one.

He asked his mother. On the sixth night. In the tent. With his father asleep and the grey book open and her hand round his father's hand round the pencil.

She looked up at him.

"*It's not a thing you do*," said Seren Vey. "*Love. It's a thing you* are." She looked at his father. "*You don't make room for someone. You just—are room. For them. Before they get there.*"

"*How*?"

She smiled. Tired. Wet.

"*I don't know*," she said. "*I just was. With your brother. With you. Before you were born.*" She looked down at the grey book. "*Ask Wren.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN CAME ON THE seventh day.

On the wind. From Ashbourne. Alone. Five months gone and visibly so now, round under her leathers, with her hand on her stomach all the time without seeming to notice. She came down out of the sky at the edge of the camp, lightly, the way she always did, and stood in the grey dust with her bow on her back and her fox-red braid over her shoulder.

And looked at the trench. At the fourteen miles of it, curving away east. At the thousands of people. At the forges and the fires and the two hundred old women in red sitting in a row along the lip.

And then at Lex.

He'd come running. From the anvil. Across the dust. He stopped in front of her.

"*You shouldn't be here*," he said.

"*Old Mag said I could*," said Wren. "*She said the sickness is gone. She said I'm as strong as a horse. She said if I sit at home one more day with my mother she'll strangle me herself.*" She looked at his face. At the handprint. At the grey under his eyes. "*And you look terrible.*"

"*I haven't slept*."

"*I know. I could hear it. All the way from Ashbourne. On the wind.*" She put her hand on his face. "*Hammering. All night. Every night. Like a heart.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD HER.

Sitting on the black Gloam-stone anvil at the head of the trench at dusk, with her beside him and the sun going down red over the grey. All of it. The word. The circle. The walls that wouldn't hold. Brannoc. *Making the right kind of empty.* Seraphine. *You don't make it, you leave it.* Pim, with his cupped hands. His mother. *It's a thing you are. Ask Wren.*

"*Why me*?" said Wren.

"*I don't know*," said Lex. "*She just said, ask Wren.*"

Wren was quiet for a long time.

Then she looked down. At herself. At the round of her stomach under her leathers. At her own hand resting on it.

"*Oh*," she said.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOOK HIS HAND.

She didn't say anything. She took his big scarred forge-hand, grey with Blightmarch dust, and put it flat on her stomach. Under her leathers. Through her shirt. Warm.

And held it there.

"*Wait*," said Wren. "*Just wait. Don't do anything. Don't ask anything. Just wait.*"

He waited.

He sat on the anvil with his hand on his wife's stomach in the dusk and waited. He didn't know what for. He didn't feel anything. Warm. Round. Firm. The rise and fall of her breathing. Nothing else.

He waited.

The sun went down. The camp went grey, then blue. The fires came up along the trench, red, one by one, like beads on a string. Somewhere far off, someone was singing. One of the Ashari. A thin high song in a language Lex didn't know.

He waited.

And thought about nothing.

Not the trench. Not the walls. Not the dust. Not his father in the tent with a hundred years in a drawer. Not his mother. Not the glitter over Highcrest. Not Lantern Night.

Nothing.

Just his hand. On her stomach. And the warm. And the waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

And something *moved*.

Under his palm. Small. Quick. Like a fish turning in a pond. Like a bird stirring in a nest. Like a knock on a door from the inside.

He went still.

It moved again. Harder. A push. A little fist, or a foot, or an elbow, against the inside of the world. Against his hand. As if to say *there you are*.

As if to say *I'm here*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE COULDN'T BREATHE.

He sat on the anvil in the blue dusk with his hand on his wife and felt his child kick for the first time. And didn't move. And didn't speak. And didn't think. Couldn't think.

Wren was crying. Silently. Beside him. With her hand over his.

"*There*," she whispered. "*That's the first time. I've been feeling it for a week. Little flutters. That's the first time it's been strong enough for anyone else.*" She laughed. Wetly. "*It waited for you. I think. I think it waited.*"

He looked at her.

At her face. At her hand over his. At the round of her under his palm. At the warm.

And understood.

◆ ◆ ◆

Room.

That was what she was. Right now. Under his hand. A room. Made. Not built. Not dug. Not hammered out of dead dust. *Made*. From inside. Slowly. Over months. Before anyone was in it. A space. Warm. Waiting. The right shape. Exactly the right shape.

For someone who wasn't there yet.

Who was coming.

She hadn't put anything into it. Not heat. Not water. Not hammers. She'd just—*been*. Been room. Every day. For five months. Without

thinking about it. Without asking. Her body had made a space for a new thing to come into the world, the way bodies have been making spaces since before there were people, since before there were Wells, since the first new thing came through the first room into the first morning.

The oldest mould there is, thought Lex.

A mother, carrying a light.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT.

Not through his hand. Not through the kick. Through something else. Something that had always been there and he'd never noticed, the way you never notice the space between the hammer-strokes until someone points it out.

The room. In her. Round the child. The space that wasn't anything, that was only *for* something.

He could feel its shape.

Not its walls. Not its edges. Its *shape*. The way it was made for exactly what was in it. The way it gave where the child pushed. The way it held without holding. The way it was full of nothing and the nothing was full of *waiting*.

It's not the walls, he thought. *Brannoc's right. It was never the walls.*

The walls hold because the empty's right. The empty's right because it's made for *something. Shaped to it. Waiting for it.*

You don't make the walls strong enough to hold the empty.

You make the empty want what's coming. And the walls hold themselves.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
ATTUNEMENT
  ▓▓▓ (unrecognized) ... LISTENING
"He heard the room his child is made
 in. He understood it was the same
 room as all the others."
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◆ ◆ ◆

HE READ IT.

He read it twice.

Then he took his hand off Wren's stomach. Very slowly. And looked at it. In the firelight. Big. Scarred. Grey with dust.

And stood up.

"*Lex*?" said Wren.

"*I know how*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T GO TO the trench.

He went to the scar.

Into the fallen hall. Across the rubble. To the warm dark line on the black floor, where his brother lay every night with his hand on it and the clay lamp beside him.

Antho was there. Sitting up. Awake. Watching him come.

"*Lex—*"

"*I need it to tell me*," said Lex. "*What it's waiting for. What it wants to come into.*"

Antho looked at him.

"*Not a shape*," said Lex. "*Seraphine's right. It hasn't got a shape. But it's waiting for something. It must be. Everything coming home is waiting for something.*" He knelt down. By the scar. Beside his brother. "*I need to know what it's waiting for. Then I can make the room want it.*"

Antho was quiet for a long time.

Then he reached out. And took Lex's hand. And put it on the scar. Beside his own. Warm.

"*Ask it*," said his brother.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX CLOSED HIS EYES.

And didn't ask anything.

He did what he'd done on the anvil. With his hand on Wren. He waited. He thought about nothing. He let his hand lie on the warm black line on the floor of the fallen hall, and he didn't push and he didn't pull and he didn't hammer and he didn't ask.

He was room.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...smith...]

He heard it. Far off. Through the scar. Through the floor. Through the bottom of the breach, where it went down and down to the deep. Small. Young. In the room it made round his hand.

[...smith...you're quiet...]

[...you're never quiet...you're always hammering...]

I'm listening, thought Lex. *What are you waiting for?*

The little one was quiet for a long time.

[...waiting...]

[...I'm waiting for someone to say what I am...]

[...the glass eyes asked what shape I want to be...I don't know...]

[...but I want someone to say...]

[...someone to look at me and say THAT'S what you are...]

[...and mean it...]

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX OPENED HIS EYES.

His brother was looking at him.

"*A name*," said Lex. "*It wants a name.*"

"*I know*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*It's been asking me. For months. Every night.* What am I? What's my name? *I never know what to say.*" He looked at the scar. "*Mal called it little one. Mam calls it lamb. Kell calls it* you. *Nobody's ever named it.*"

"*Seraphine says the glyph's a name*."

"*It's the Founders' name*. *For the seventh. For the Well.*" Antho shook his head. "*That's not its name. That's what it* is. *Like calling you* smith." He looked at Lex. "*It wants someone to give it its own. The way you'd name a child.*"

Lex looked at the scar.

"*Then we write the Founders' word*," he said slowly. "*In the ground. A hundred miles. So it knows what it is. So it comes up into the shape of what it is.*" He looked at Antho. "*And then someone names it. When it gets here. On Lantern Night.*"

"*Who*?"

"*I don't know.*" Lex put his hand back on the scar. "*Someone who made room for it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT BACK TO the trench at midnight.

All of them did. He woke them. Brannoc and Tilda and Hedda. Grandmother Asha and the Ashari. Teo. The students. The smiths. Roole and the Keepers. Benno and the Banners. The miners from Coldwater with their picks. The farmers from the Vale. Everyone.

He stood on the black rubble of Duskhold's gate in the firelight with thousands of faces looking up at him.

He'd never been good at this. He always said the wrong thing first, and then the right thing, and then something embarrassing.

He said the embarrassing thing first.

"*I've been doing it wrong*," said Lex Vey.

Somebody laughed. Brannoc. Loudly.

"*We've been building walls*," said Lex. "*Strong ones. Trying to make the dust hold. Putting things into it. Heat. Water. Hammers.*" He looked at the trench. "*And it falls in. Every night. Because we're building walls round nothing.*"

He held up his hand. The one that had been on Wren.

"*It's not walls*," he said. "*It's room. We're not making a hole. We're making a space for something that's coming. Something that's waiting to be told what it is.*" He swallowed. "*And the space has to* want *it. The way a mother wants a child before it's born. The way a window wants someone to come home.*"

The camp was very quiet.

"*So when you dig*," said Lex, "*don't dig a trench. Dig a place for it. When you bake the walls, don't bake them hard. Bake them* ready. *When you hammer, don't hammer them strong. Hammer them—*" He stopped. Looked for the word.

"*Welcoming*," said Grandmother Asha.

Everyone turned.

The tiny old fire-woman was standing at the front of the crowd. Bent nearly double. With her black eyes glittering.

"*Like setting a table*," she said. "*For a guest. You don't set the table strong. You set it* nice. *So they know you've been waiting.*" She cackled. "*Even the sand knows the difference, smith. Everything knows the difference between a wall and a welcome.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

IT HELD.

Not at once. Not that night. Not the first mile.

But they went back into the trench, all of them, at midnight, in the firelight, and they did it differently. Lex didn't know how to tell them. He didn't have to. They knew. Every one of them. Every person in that camp had been waited for, once. By someone. At a window. With a lamp.

The Ashari sat on the lip of the trench and poured their black heat into the walls, and they didn't pour it to make them hard. They poured it the way you'd warm a bed for someone coming in out of the cold. Slow. Even. Kind.

Teo asked the Undertow to send its tide up the riverbeds, and he didn't ask it to wet the dust. He asked it to wash it. Clean. The way you'd wash the step before a guest arrives.

The smiths stood in the trench with their hammers and they didn't beat the walls. They tapped them. Lightly. Over and over. All down the line. The way you'd knock on a door to say *I'm here, I'm home, I've been waiting*.

And Lex walked the line.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WALKED IT FOR fifty-one days.

A hundred miles across. Three hundred and fourteen round. He walked every one. With his hand on the wall of the trench. Not hammering. Not asking. Just there. Being room. Listening to the empty in the dust, the space that was being made, the shape that wasn't a shape, and *wanting*.

Wanting it to come.

Wanting it home.

And the walls held.

Behind him. Every mile. He'd walk past, and put his hand on the dust, and feel the empty in it, and want, and the dust would—*settle*. Not harden. Not set. Settle. The way a dog settles by a fire. The way a house settles in its first winter. The way a room feels different once you know someone's coming to stay.

And the next morning it would still be there. And the morning after. And the morning after that.

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN WALKED WITH HIM.

Some of it. As much as she could. As her stomach grew and her back ached and Old Mag sent furious letters by raven from Ashbourne. She walked beside him with her hand on the wall and her other hand on herself and her wind going ahead of them along the trench, clearing the dust, smoothing the floor.

Brannoc came behind. On a cart. With Hedda. With the forge on the back of it, a little portable hearth and an anvil, so that every evening, wherever they stopped, Lex could say good morning to a fire.

Pim came. Sometimes. Riding on the cart with his feet dangling. Filling Hush-cups. A hundred of them now. Lined up in baskets in the back of the cart. For Lantern Night.

Ivy Moss came. On her crutch. Very slowly. Talking to the dust. Telling it what was coming. *It's very big*, she'd say. Crouched at the bottom of the trench with her hand flat on the floor. *Bigger than anything. But it's not angry. It's just frightened. You'll like it. I promise.*

The dust listened.

Lex could feel it listen.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER WROTE NAMES.

Every day. In the tent at Duskhold. With Seren's hand round his round the pencil. Coldwater. Ashpit. Greyford. Kell's Hollow. The farms. The drovers. The tinkers.

Every evening a raven came from the tent to wherever Lex was on the line. Seraphine's raven. With a slip of paper. A number.

Three thousand and forty.

Four thousand, two hundred and eleven.

Five thousand, nine hundred and eighty.

And underneath, every evening, in Seraphine's hand, smaller:

He's still here.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE FIFTY-FIRST DAY they came round.

Back to the start. Back to the ruins. Three hundred and fourteen miles. From the black rubble of Duskhold's gate, east, round, through the whole of the grey Blightmarch, and back. The trench meeting itself. The circle closing.

Almost.

Lex stopped at the edge of the ruins.

In the trench. At the end. Where it came round from the east and ran up to the edge of the fallen wall and stopped. Where the other end of it started, a hundred yards off, on the other side of the hall, going out west.

And between them, the hall. The fallen walls. The black floor. And the scar.

The gap.

The break in the circle. Where the ring didn't quite close.

Hollow.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CLIMBED OUT OF the trench.

Slowly. Fifty-one days. He was so tired he could barely lift his feet. He climbed up onto the black rubble of the gate and stood there in the evening light and looked at it.

All of it. From the top of Duskhold's ruins. The highest point in the Blightmarch.

A circle.

Cut into the grey. A hundred miles across. A line of dark earth, twenty feet wide, ten deep, going away from his feet in both directions, curving, curving, out of sight to the east and the west and round, round, a ring so big the far side of it was below the edge of the world.

With a break in it. Right here. At his feet. Where the hall was. Where the scar was.

A word.

Written in the ground. By everyone. In fifty-one days.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE ALL THERE.

He saw them. Below him. On the grey plain round the ruins. Thousands. Standing. Looking up at him. With their spades and their hammers and their picks. With dust on their faces and blisters on their hands. The Ashen Banners. The Keepers. The Ashari in their red. The smiths and the students. The miners from Coldwater. The farmers from the Vale.

Brannoc. Tilda. Hedda. Teo. Kestrel. Roole. Benno.

Seraphine, at the edge of the hall, with her notebook. Antho beside her. With the lamp.

Wren. At the foot of the rubble. Six months gone. With her hand on her stomach. Looking up at him.

And at the door of the tent, beside the ruins, in a chair that someone had carried out—

His father.

Wrapped in blankets. White. Bone. Older than anyone. With his grey book on his knee. And his mother beside him. With her hand on his shoulder.

Looking up.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
LEX VEY
Level 94 → 95
"Three hundred and fourteen miles of
 room, made by asking, for something
 that hasn't arrived. The net has
 checked. It has never been done."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He didn't have to.

He put his hand on the black rubble under his feet. On Duskhold. On the last bones of Morvane's citadel, grown out of Gloam-stone over the

breach his father tore. And felt it. Down. Through the rubble. Through the hall. Through the scar.

Through the bottom of the breach. Where it went down and down and down. To the deep.

To something pressing up against it. Enormous. Soft. Young.

Listening.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...smith...]

It was very faint. Very far. Very small.

[...smith...what's that...]

[...up there...round the hole...I can feel it...]

[...it's like...]

It didn't have the word.

[...it's like when the lamp-lady sings...]

[...it's like the cups...]

[...it's like being WANTED...]

Lex stood on the rubble of Duskhold and closed his eyes.

It's yours, he thought. *All of it. A hundred miles. It's your name. We wrote it for you. So you'll know what you are when you get here.*

The little one was quiet for a long time.

[...my name...]

[...is that me...]

[...is that what I AM...]

Yes, thought Lex Vey. *That's what you are. Room. For everything new. For everything coming home.*

Come home.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FAR OFF, VERY far, a hundred miles south and west, under a glittering lid, at the top of a tower, in a round room with a cold grate and a window looking north—

Something stood up.

Lex felt it. Not through the little one. Not through the Stone. Through the handprint on his face. Cool. Smooth. Like the inside of a shell.

It *tightened*.

The way a mark tightens when the hand that made it closes.

He opened his eyes. And looked south. And saw, at the very edge of the sky, where the grey met the horizon—

The glitter.

Moving.

Not drifting. Not turning. *Moving*. East. Toward him. Toward the Blightmarch. Toward the circle. The whole great grey-gold lid of it, lifting off Highcrest like a cloud lifting off a lake. Spreading. Coming.

Slowly.

Patiently.

The way a moth comes to a lamp.

CHAPTER 31

The Way Up

THE LITTLE ONE COULDN'T find the way.

That was the thing nobody had thought of. Not Seraphine, with her notebooks. Not Lex, with his three hundred and fourteen miles. Not Antho, lying every night on the black floor of the fallen hall with his hand on the scar.

It was *everywhere*. Folded round the whole of the deep like a hand round a lamp. It could feel the breach under Duskhold, pressing up against the bottom of it like a child pressing its face to a window. It could feel the Hollowmaw door, three hundred miles north, where Kell sat with it and told it about the miller's cat.

It could feel the circle. The word. The hundred miles of room. Above it. Waiting.

It couldn't *get* there.

[...I don't know how...] it said. On the fifty-second night. When Lex came down off the rubble and the whole camp went to sleep under the stars, exhausted, and Antho lay down by the scar with the clay lamp. *[...I'm too big...I'm everywhere...if I go toward the circle I have to leave the door...if I leave the door I leave the Warden...]*

[...and if I go all at once I'll—]*

It stopped.

[...I'll pull things...] it said. Very small. *[...like before...when I was the other thing...if I move too fast I'll pull everything in after me...]*

Antho lay very still.

[...I need someone to show me...] said the little one. *[...the way...slowly...a little at a time...]*

[...brother...]

[...will you come down and show me...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TOLD THEM AT breakfast.

In the tent by the ruins. With porridge, which Seraphine had burned, because she'd learned it from his mother. With his father in the chair by the tent-flap, wrapped in blankets, with the grey book on his knee and his mother's hand on his shoulder. With Lex asleep across three stools, snoring. With Wren beside Lex, eating two bowls of porridge at once because the baby, she said, wanted porridge.

"*I'm going down*," said Antho.

Nobody said anything.

"*It needs someone to lead it*," he said. "*From the Hollowmaw door to here. Through the deep. Under the world. Slowly.*" He looked at the clay lamp in his lap. "*It's following the light. My light. Mam's lamp. Where I go, it goes.*" He looked up. "*It's three hundred miles, under. It'll take a month. More. I have to start now. Or it won't be here by Lantern Night.*"

Seraphine had put down her spoon.

"*Alone*?" she said.

Antho looked at her.

"*No*," he said. "*Not alone. I don't do alone anymore.*" He swallowed. "*I was going to ask you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT DOWN THE Hollowmaw door four days later.

Seraphine. Pim. And him.

Lex wanted to come. He'd stood at the cave mouth of the Lantern Keep with his face grey and his hands in fists and said *I'm coming*, and Antho had said *no*, and they'd had the argument they always had, the one about who carries what.

And then Wren had said, very quietly, from behind Lex, "*Hammer. He's right.*"

And Lex had turned round.

"*You've got to hold the top*," said Wren. With her hand on her stomach. Six and a half months gone. "*The circle. The camp. Your father.*" Her voice didn't shake. "*Someone has to be here when they come up. You said so. On the slope. The night before the deep. You said someone has to be the light we're coming home to.*"

She looked at Antho.

"*This time it's you*," she said to Lex. "*This time you're the window.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SO IT WAS THE three of them.

Down the long passage. Past the lanterns. Six hundred and seven lit, five hundred and six dark. Into the bell-shaped cavern. To the niche. To the three lamps. Burning.

To the door. On the latch. A thin gold crack down the middle of the black glass.

Antho knocked.

Kell, he thought. *It's me again.*

[...Vey...]

Faint. Far. Dry. Tired.

[...you're early...]

We're coming down. To take it home.

The Warden was quiet for a long moment.

[...about time...] said Isaura Kell. *[...I've told it the one about the miller's cat four hundred times. It knows the cat's name. It knows the cat's* boots *by name.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE DEEP WAS QUIET.

Antho noticed it the moment they stepped through. Different. From the last time. From the moths and the glitter and the tide of grey-gold rising out of the dark toward Lex's light.

There were no moths.

None. Not one. Not a glitter. Not a flicker. Just Shade's dark. Soft. Starlit. Endless. The way it had been after the Heart. Before.

"*They've gone up*," said Seraphine. Very quietly. With her hand out. Listening. "*All of them. Up the shafts. Back to her.*" She frowned. "*She's not sending them down anymore. She doesn't need to.*"

"*Why*?" said Pim.

Seraphine looked at him.

"*Because she knows where it's going*," she said. "*She'll be waiting at the top.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

KELL WAS IN THE gold room.

The little one had kept it. The fold. The warm place. Round a clay lamp, the copy, the one from the Ashbourne market that Seraphine had given Seren on the way up, that Seren had left with Kell. Lit. On the warm dark. With Kell sitting beside it.

Very straight.

She'd healed. Mostly. The wound in her side, where the Mothwing's knife had gone in, was a scar now. Pink. Puckered. Under her ruined robes. The little one had held the room round it for months, the way it held the room round everything, and the wound had closed into it.

She was thinner. Greyer. Her short hair had grown out a little, and was white. All of it. Her eyes were clear. Not dim. Not half-dim. Pale and steady and very, very tired.

She looked up as they came in.

"*Vey*," said Isaura Kell. "*Scholar.*" Her pale eyes went to Pim. And stopped. And something moved in her thin face. "*And who's this?*"

"*Pim*," said Antho. "*He's mine. One of my students. He came because he wanted to see it.*"

Kell looked at Pim for a long time.

Pim looked back.

"*The quiet one*," said Kell at last. "*It's told me about you. The boy with the room inside.*" Her mouth moved. Sideways. "*It says you're its favorite. After the lamp-lady. And the cat.*"

Pim went very red.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...brother...]

All round them. In the warm dark. Close. So close. Antho had never heard it so close. Not even in the gold room, the first time. It was pressed round them on every side, soft and enormous, the way a crowd presses round a fire on a cold night.

[...brother you came...and the glass eyes...and the QUIET one...]

Pim was smiling.

Antho had seen Pim smile three times in three years. He was smiling now. Standing in the gold room at the bottom of the world with the dark pressing round him, soft and warm and huge, and his thin face lit up like a lamp.

"*Hello*," said Pim. Out loud. To the dark.

[...hello...] said the little one. *[...you made the cups...]*

"*Me and Master Lex*."

[...the cups were like being carried...]

"*I know*," said Pim. "*That's why I made them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WENT AT ONCE.

There was no time. Lantern Night was forty days off. The little one was three hundred miles from where it needed to be, under the world, and it was the size of a country, and it didn't know the way.

So Antho showed it.

He didn't know the way either. Not properly. He'd never been under the world between the Hollowmaw and Vhessa. Nobody had. There was no map.

But he had the lamp.

He held it up. The clay one. His mother's mother's. Lit. In his hand. And he turned until he was facing south and east. The way his father had told him. The way the edges ran. The way the deep sloped, under the world, from the oldest crack to the first wound.

And he walked.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT FOLLOWED.

He felt it. Behind him. Around him. Above and below. The whole vast soft dark of it, folded round the deep, beginning, very slowly, very

carefully, to *move*. Not all at once. Not fast. A little at a time. The way a river moves when the ice starts to break. The way a sleeping animal shifts in the night.

Toward the lamp.

Toward him.

[...this way...] it said. Wondering. *[...this way...where the light goes...]*

This way, thought Antho. *Slowly. Don't pull. Don't hurry. Just follow.*

[...I'm following...]

I know.

[...I've never followed before...]

[...I've only ever been the place things come through...]

[...nobody ever led me anywhere...]

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK THIRTY-FOUR DAYS.

He'd remember them, afterward, as one long walk. Through the dark. Under Shade's stars. With his mother's lamp held up in front of him and his wife on one side and a boy on the other and a gaunt white-haired woman behind, very straight, walking.

And behind her, following, folded, soft, enormous, the little one.

They slept when they were tired. On the warm dark. In the gold room, which came with them, which the little one carried the way a snail carries its shell. They ate what Seraphine had brought, and when that ran out, what the little one gave them, which was nothing, which was room, which somehow, down there, was enough.

And they talked.

◆ ◆ ◆

KELL TALKED MOST.

That surprised him. He'd never heard Isaura Kell say more than ten words together, except at the Heart, when she'd told Seraphine about Dorran. She'd been High Warden of the Order of the Lattice. She'd given orders. She didn't *talk*.

She talked now.

Walking. In the dark. With her hands clasped behind her back. Very straight. She told them about the Spire. About the dormitory, when she

was a cadet, at nine, the youngest they'd ever taken. About the older cadets blowing out the candle and whispering *never leave a light on, or the Nine will come*.

"*I believed them*," said Kell. "*Of course I did. I was nine. I lay awake every night for a year, terrified of lanterns.*" Her mouth moved sideways. "*And then I grew up and became High Warden and sent people to burn women who weren't afraid of the dark.*"

She told them about Dorran Vask. The first time she met him. A big frightened boy of nineteen, in the Kindling hall at the Spire, with a brand on his arm that she'd put there herself. *You'll stand at the Stones*, she'd told him. *In the west. On Kindling-day. You'll put your hand on their shoulders. And push down.*

"*He cried*," said Kell. "*When I branded him. He tried not to. He was so big. He cried like a child.*"

She was quiet for a long time.

"*I didn't*," she said. "*I watched him cry and I didn't feel anything at all.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE TOLD THEM ABOUT the Rift.

Not all of it. Antho knew most of it. Lex had told him. Elric unwriting his own men in the Umbral Rift, at the edge of the world. Kell found forty-one percent gone, faded, thin, half a woman. Dorran picking her up.

"*He said*," said Kell, "*I've got you, High Warden.*" She stopped walking. In the dark. Very straight. With her hands clasped behind her back. "*He said, I've carried heavier.*"

Nobody said anything.

"*He was lying*," said Isaura Kell. "*I was the heaviest thing he ever carried. I could feel it in his back. He was shaking the whole way.*"

She started walking again.

"*Your brother got that back for me*," she said. Not looking at Antho. "*In the drowned city. After she took it. He read it to me. Out of the Ledger. And then he said the rest. The bit that wasn't written down.*" Her voice was very steady. "*I'd like to keep it, this time. I'd like—*"

She stopped again.

"*Vey*," she said.

"*Yes.*"

"*When this is done*," said Kell. "*When it's up. Whatever happens.*" She turned round. In the dark. And looked at him. With her pale eyes. "*Take my name out of the Ledger.*"

Antho stared at her.

"*It's still in there*," said Kell. "*Isn't it. Your brother carries it. Ysmir's book. With the Unnamed. Two names left. Mine and Elric's.*"

"*Yours came back. At the Heart.*"

"*It came back. It's still written there.*" She looked at her hands. "*Faded. Pale. The way they go when the person comes back. But it's there. In a book for people who've been forgotten.*" Her mouth twisted. "*I don't want to be in a book for people who've been forgotten.*"

"*Where, then?*"

Isaura Kell was quiet for a long time.

"*Somewhere people read*," she said at last. "*Somewhere ordinary. In a list. With other people. Not the Unnamed. Not the Wardens. Just—people.*" She looked at Seraphine. "*You're writing names. Your father-in-law. In his grey book. The ones from the breach.*"

Seraphine nodded. Slowly.

"*Put me in there*," said Kell. "*At the end. After the Vhessans. When you're done.*" Her voice didn't change. "*Isaura Kell. Of Highcrest. She was High Warden. She signed forty-one warrants and remembered every name.*" A pause. "*She was carried once. By a man she'd branded. And she sat with a frightened thing in the dark until it got home.*"

She looked at Antho.

"*That's all*," she said. "*That's enough.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You're not going to die*," said Seraphine.

Kell looked at her.

"*You're talking like you're going to die*," said Seraphine. Her voice was shaking. "*You're asking us to put you in a book. At the end. After the dead.*" She stopped walking. "*You're not. You're going to come up. With it. On Lantern Night. Into the circle. With all of us.*"

Isaura Kell looked at her for a long time.

"*Scholar*," she said. Very gently. "*I've been High Warden of the Order of the Lattice. I've stood in front of kings. I've sat in council with Aurelian's ghost. I've been unwritten and eaten and made into a door.*" She looked at the dark. At the little one, following. "*I know what's waiting at the top. I know what she is. I know what she'll do.*"

"*Then—*"

"*Then I know someone will have to stand in front of it*," said Kell. "*With a stick. When she comes for it. When it's halfway up and can't go back and can't go forward.*" She looked at Seraphine. "*And I've had a lot of practice.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM TALKED TO THE little one.

All the time. In his own way. Which was mostly not talking. Walking beside Antho with one hand held out to the side, palm open, toward the dark. As if he were holding a hand. As if someone were walking beside him, very big, very soft, and he were holding its hand to show it the way.

Sometimes he'd stop. And cup his hands. Round nothing. And be silent.

And the little one would make a sound. Not a word. A ripple. Like a cat purring. Like a breath let out.

"*It likes that*," said Pim. Once. When Antho asked. "*It says it's like being little again. Before the Nine. When it was a pool. When nobody stopped.*" He looked at his hands. "*It says when I make a room round it, it feels the size it's supposed to be.*"

"*What size is that*?"

Pim thought about it for a long time.

"*The size of a person*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE TWENTIETH DAY, the bell rang.

They were in the middle of the dark. Halfway. Nowhere. With nothing round them but Shade's stars and the little one following.

And Antho felt something in the warm dark beside him change. Shift. Fold. The way it had folded in the gold room, the first time, when his mother said *show them where Mal is*.

The middle came.

Close. Very close. Right beside them, in the dark, to the left of the path, where nothing had been. Two little lights. Pale. Silver-gold. Like very old candles. Curled together. Side by side. Asleep.

One small. With the shape of a straw hat.

One tall. With something in its hands.

The little one had brought them. It hadn't been asked. It just did it. Folded the middle of itself up to the path and laid it there, in the dark, beside them. The way a child brings you something it's proud of.

[...look...] it said. *[...Mal and his brother...they're coming too...]*

And very faintly, so faint Antho had to stop walking and hold his breath, from the two little lights, singing.

Little light, little light, burning low.

In tune.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T HAVE THE bell. Lex had it. Three hundred miles up. On a cord round his neck. On the black rubble of Duskhold.

But Antho heard it anyway.

Far off. Very faint. Coming down through the world. Through the circle. Through the breach. Through the dark.

Ting.

In tune. Clear. Like a struck glass.

And then, after it, so faint he almost didn't hear it at all—

Ting.

Flat.

Slightly off. A little crooked. Like a bell with a bent clapper.

The way it had rung for nine hundred years.

◆ ◆ ◆

KELL HAD STOPPED WALKING.

She was standing very still. In the dark. With her hands at her sides. Looking at the two little lights. At the small one. With the straw hat.

"*That's the Listener*," she said. Very quietly. "*Isn't it. The old one. The one who sat with it.*"

"*Malachi*," said Antho.

"*Malachi*." Kell didn't move. "*I met him. At the Heart. Before. When I was its Warden. When I had no face.*" Her voice was very strange. "*He looked at me. With those eyes. The shifting ones. And he said—*"

She stopped.

"*What did he say*?" said Seraphine.

Isaura Kell looked at the little light with the straw hat for a long time.

"*He said, oh, my dear*," she said. "*You look so tired. Would you like to sit down?*"

She was crying. Antho had never seen her cry. Not at the Heart. Not in the drowned city. Not when Lex read her name from the Ledger.

She was crying now. Standing very straight in the dark with her hands at her sides and the tears running down her thin grey face.

"*Nobody had asked me that*," said Isaura Kell. "*Not in fifty years. Would you like to sit down.*"

She sat down.

On the warm dark. Beside the two little lights. Very slowly. Like an old woman lowering herself onto a bench in a churchyard.

And sat there. For a long time. With her hands in her lap. Beside Malachi. Not saying anything.

The little one held the room round all three of them. Very gently. The way you'd hold a cup you'd been told was precious.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO AND SERAPHINE SLEPT apart from the others that night.

A little way off. In the dark. Not far. Just far enough. On the warm floor of the little one, with the clay lamp between them and their hands touching across it.

"*She's going to die*," said Seraphine. Very quietly. "*Isn't she.*"

Antho didn't answer.

"*She knows it*," said Seraphine. "*She's been knowing it since we found her. Since the gold room. Since she said, I'll stay with it.*" Her voice cracked. "*She's been getting ready. All this time. Telling us things. Telling us what to write.*"

"*I know*."

"*Can we stop it*?"

He looked at her. Across the lamp. At her face, in the gold light. Her spectacles off. Her eyes very wet.

"*I don't know*," he said honestly. "*I don't know what's going to happen. Nobody does. Not Lex. Not Mam. Not Kell.*" He swallowed. "*I know she's going to stand in front of it. When it's halfway up. With a stick. Because that's who she is now.*"

"*That's who she chose to be*."

"*That's who she chose to be*," Antho agreed. "*And you can't stop someone being who they chose. You can only stand next to them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS QUIET FOR a long time.

"*Antho*," she said.

"*Mm*."

"*Four hundred and twelve*," said his wife.

He looked at her.

"*Reasons*," said Seraphine. "*The list. From the wedding. I only read you the first one.*" She took something out of her coat. The little leather notebook. The size of her palm. Battered now. Its corners soft. "*I've been adding to it.*"

"*How many*?"

"*Five hundred and three*."

He laughed. He couldn't help it. In the dark. At the bottom of the world.

"*Read me one*," he said.

She opened the notebook. In the light of the clay lamp. And turned the pages. Past four hundred and twelve. Past the wedding. Past the moths, and the Delve in the cold-room, and the deep, and the tear, and the Keep.

To the last one.

"*Five hundred and three*," read Seraphine Ilvane. "*He held the door. With the little one screaming and his Clarity at thirty-eight and the old thing in his head telling him to squeeze. And it said, stay. And he listened.*"

She closed the notebook.

"*That's the best one*," she said. "*I think. So far.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He reached across the lamp. And took the notebook out of her hand. And opened it. To a blank page. At the back. And took the pencil from behind her ear.

And wrote. In the gold light. In his own hand, which wasn't as neat as hers, which was cramped and slanting from eight years of writing in a cave by the light of a single candle.

Number one, he wrote. *She asked how long. Not what's wrong. How long. She'd counted.*

He gave it back to her.

She read it. And put her hand over her mouth.

"*That's mine*," said Antho Vey. "*My list. Starting now.*" He lay back on the warm dark. "*I'm behind. I'll be behind for the rest of my life.*"

"*You're very good at counting*," said Seraphine. Wetly.

"*I'm very good at counting*," he agreed.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE THIRTY-FOURTH DAY, the dark changed.

Antho felt it first. Through the lamp. Through his feet. The warm dark under him, that had been flat and endless for a month, began to *slope*. Up. Gently. Like the floor of a valley rising toward a pass.

And the stars overhead—

Fewer. Closer. Shade's stars, that had been so far, were coming down. Or he was going up. The dark between them getting thinner. Less deep.

"*We're close*," said Seraphine. With her hand out. "*Antho. We're close. I can hear it. Above. A room. A big one.*" Her face was lit. "*The circle. I can hear the circle.*"

And then he saw it.

Far ahead. Up. At the top of the long slope of dark. A line. Thin. Gold.

Not a crack in a door. Not lamp-light.

Warm light. Coming *down*. Through something. Like light through a gap in a floor. Like sunlight through the cracks in a barn.

The scar.

The bottom of the breach. Under Duskhold. Where his father had knelt twenty-one years ago and pulled. Where the three of them had knelt five years ago and mended.

Where his brother had stood on the black rubble fifty-two days ago and said *come home*.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LITTLE ONE STOPPED.

All of it. All at once. The whole vast soft enormous fold of it, behind them, round them, under them. Stopped. At the bottom of the slope. Under the scar. Under the circle.

And went very still.

[...is that it...]

Very small. Very quiet. Very frightened.

[...is that the room...]

"*That's it*," said Antho.

[...it's so close...]

[...I can feel it...the circle...my name...a hundred miles of it...]

[...it's like...]

It didn't have the word. It never had the word.

[...brother...]

[...brother, what if they don't like me...]

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO SAT DOWN.

On the warm dark. At the bottom of the slope. Under the thin gold line of the scar. With the clay lamp in his lap.

Seraphine sat beside him. Pim on his other side. Kell a little way off, very straight, with her hands on her knees.

"*They made you a room*," said Antho. To the dark. To the little one. "*All of them. Thousands. With spades and hammers and their bare hands. For fifty-one days. They dug it and baked it and washed it and tapped on the walls so it would know someone was coming.*" He looked up at the gold line. "*They don't even know you. Most of them. They've never heard you. They just heard my brother say* something's coming home *and they came.*"

The little one was quiet.

"*They made a room for you*," said Antho, "*before you got there. That's what you do for someone you're going to love. Before you've met them.*" He swallowed. "*That's what my mother did for me. And my brother. And Wren's doing it now. For hers.*"

[...]

"*You don't have to worry about whether they'll like you*," said Antho Vey. "*They already do. They made you a room.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FROM FAR ABOVE, through the scar, through the breach, through three hundred miles of a word written in the ground—

A sound.

Hammering.

One anvil. Slow. Steady. In the dark.

Like a heart.

Like a knock on a door.

I'm here. I'm home. I've been waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...that's the smith...] said the little one. Wonderingly.

[...he's knocking...]

[...he's knocking for ME...]

And Antho, sitting at the bottom of the world under the first wound with his mother's lamp in his lap and his wife's hand in his, laughed. Out loud. He couldn't help it.

"*He never stops*," he said. "*He never stops hammering. Not since he was eleven.*"

[...why...]

Antho looked up at the thin gold line. At the light coming down through the scar. At the place where, in six days, on Lantern Night, he'd stand with his hands on a door his father tore, and ask.

"*Because that's how he says I love you*," said Antho Vey.

The little one was quiet for a long time.

And then, all round them, soft and enormous and young, it did the thing Antho had felt once before, in the deep, when his mother said *it's a choice*.

It laughed.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FAR ABOVE, ON the black rubble of Duskhold, at the head of a trench three hundred and fourteen miles long, a man with a grey-gold handprint on his face stopped hammering.

And put down the hammer.

And put his hand flat on the anvil of black Gloam-stone. And felt it. Through the stone. Through the rubble. Through the scar. Through the bottom of the breach.

Something enormous. Soft. Young.

Laughing.

And Lex Vey sat down very suddenly on the rubble beside his anvil. In the dark. Alone. With his face in his hands.

And on the horizon, all round him, in every direction, in a ring a hundred and fifty miles across, outside the circle, glittering grey-gold under the stars like frost on a window—

The moths were waiting.

CHAPTER 32

Lantern Night Eve

THEY CAME WITH LANTERNS.

Lex watched them come from the top of the rubble. All day. The last day of autumn. From the north and the west and the south. Along the old roads into the Blightmarch that nobody had walked in twenty years. Across the grey. In carts and wagons and on foot and on horseback.

Thousands.

More than had come to dig. More than had come to bake and wash and hammer. People who'd never held a spade. Old women. Children. Shopkeepers. Fishwives from the Saltreach. Shepherds from the Greyspine. The whole of Ashbourne, Mother Orla at the front in a cart with a barrel of bacon. Bess Rook from Fen Hollow, eighty-one, on a donkey this time, because she said she'd walked three hundred miles once and that was quite enough for one life.

And every one of them carrying a lantern.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY WERE THE LANTERN Night lanterns. The ones everyone in Caldor lit, on the last night of autumn, every year, for nine hundred years. For the lost. For the dead. For someone who hadn't come home.

Paper ones from the Saltreach, painted with fish and boats. Tin ones from the Vale, dented, mended, older than the people carrying them. Brass ones from Highcrest. Clay ones. Glass ones. A great carved stone one from the Ironbacks that took four men and a mule.

A loaf-shaped one, empty, carried by a girl of twelve with flour on her hands and her face set like stone.

They carried them across the grey and set them down. Round the rim of the circle. On the lip of the trench, all the way round, every few feet, three hundred and fourteen miles. The way Lex had asked. The way his mother had said.

Not waiting.

Given.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D WATCHED THE FIRST one.

At dawn. At the edge of the ruins. Where the trench came round from the east and stopped at the fallen wall. An old man from Coldwater, a hewer, with a pick on his shoulder and grey on his lips, who'd dug with the Banners for fifty-one days without saying a word to anyone.

He'd come to the lip of the trench with a tin lantern. Dented. Black with coal-dust. And knelt. Slowly. And set it down on the baked grey earth of the rim.

And lit it.

And then he'd put his hand on it. Flat. On the top. The way you'd put your hand on a child's head. And said, very quietly, so that Lex, standing ten yards off on the rubble, almost didn't hear:

"*For the little one. From Absalom Ware. That was my wife's.*"

And got up. And walked away.

And the next person came.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY DID IT ALL day.

All round the circle. Three hundred and fourteen miles. Kneeling. Lighting. Putting a hand on the lantern. Saying who it was for and who it was from.

For the little one. From Bess Rook. I never had one before. I bought this one in Millbridge.

For the little one. From the Tidewater fishing families. The sea says hello.

For the little one. From Mother Orla of the Crooked Kettle. There's bacon in the morning.

Lex heard some of them. Most he didn't. The circle was too big. But he heard them anyway. Through the ground. Through the trench. Through the walls of baked grey earth that he'd walked three hundred and fourteen miles with his hand on.

Every one. A small warmth. A small weight. Set down on the rim of the room. Given.

And under the ground, under the breach, under Duskhold, something enormous and soft and young, listening.

[...that one's for me...]

[...and that one...]

[...and THAT one...]

[...smith, they keep SAYING it...for the little one...for the little one...]

[...nobody ever gave me anything...]

◆ ◆ ◆

AND OUTSIDE THE CIRCLE, all round, on the horizon—

The glitter.

It had come in the night. Thirty days ago. Lifting off Highcrest like a cloud off a lake and drifting east. Slowly. Patiently. Across the downs and the Blightmarch's edge. And spreading. And settling.

Not in the circle. Outside it. A ring. A hundred and fifty miles across. A wall of grey-gold on every horizon. From the ground to the sky. Like a sandstorm that had stopped mid-blow. Like frost on the inside of a window. Like the edge of the world.

It hadn't moved for thirty days.

It just sat there. Glittering. Turning, very slowly, round and round. Watching.

Waiting for Lantern Night.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN IT, THE Dimmed.

Lex could see them. If he looked. If he stood on the highest point of the rubble and looked south, toward where the West Road came into the Blightmarch, toward where the glitter was thickest.

People.

Standing. In rows. Outside the circle. At the foot of the wall of moths. Thousands of them. Tens of thousands. Swaying. Like grass. With their faces turned toward the middle of the circle. Toward Duskhold. Toward the breach.

Holding up dark lanterns.

The Dimmed of Highcrest. Walked out of the city behind her. Thirty days ago. Across the downs and the grey. Two hundred miles. Barefoot, some of them. In their aprons and their nightclothes. Following her light.

And the Keepers from Greyfall. And the shepherds from the Greyspine. And everyone else she'd touched. All summer. All autumn.

She'd brought them all.

To stand at the edge of the circle on Lantern Night. With their dark lanterns. Facing in.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She brought them*," said Wren.

She was beside him. On the rubble. Sitting on a folded blanket on a block of black Gloam-stone, because she couldn't stand for long anymore, with her back against the remains of Duskhold's gate-tower and her hands on the great round of her stomach. Eight months. Near enough. Old Mag, who had come from Ashbourne in Mother Orla's cart and was now sitting in the tent below them telling Seren everything she was doing wrong, said it could be any day.

Not tomorrow, Lex had said.

It'll come when it comes, Old Mag had said. *Babies don't read calendars.*

"*She brought them so we'd see*," said Wren. Looking south. At the rows. "*So we'd know they're there. All of them. Every one she's touched. Standing at the edge of the room with their lights out.*"

"*Why*?"

"*Because she knows we'll come for them*." Wren's hand moved on her stomach. Slowly. "*She knows how to relight them now. I showed her. On Fennel Street. Hask was there. He saw.*" Her voice was very steady. "*She knows that tomorrow night, when the little one comes up, half the people in*

this camp will be out there at the edge. With lamps. Looking for their mothers."

Lex didn't say anything.

"*Not in here*," said Wren. "*Not guarding the circle. Not standing round the lanterns with black heat. Out there. Kneeling in the dust in front of the Dimmed. Telling them what they love about them.*" She looked at him. "*She's going to make us choose.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FAMILIES HAD COME.

That was the other thing that had happened, over the thirty days. Word had gone out. From Fennel Street. From Wren. From Maren Ashdown, who had walked out of Highcrest through the sally port with her daughter on one arm and her sons on the other and told everyone she met on the road north, for two hundred miles.

It can be done. You need a lamp. And their name. And you need to know what she took.

You need to love them.

They'd come. Wives. Husbands. Daughters. Brothers. Old friends. Apprentices. Into the Blightmarch, with the lantern-bearers. Hundreds. Thousands. Carrying two lanterns each. One for the rim. One for the edge.

They were camped now on the south side of the circle. Nearest the Dimmed. Nearest the glitter. In a long uneasy line. Looking out at the rows of swaying people with their dark lanterns. Looking for faces.

Lex had seen a woman standing at the lip of the trench at noon with her hand over her mouth, staring south. At a man in the front row of the Dimmed. In an apron. With flour on his hands.

Hollis Penn's wife.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT DOWN TO the tent at dusk.

His father was dying.

Everyone knew. Nobody said it. He was in the cot, in the tent at the foot of the rubble, where he'd been for fifty days. Under three blankets. With the grey book on his chest. With Seren on the stool beside him, where she'd been for fifty days.

He was so small now. Lex could hardly see him under the blankets. A shape. A breath. A white wisp of hair on the pillow, like smoke.

His eyes were open.

Grey. Clear. Looking at the tent roof. At nothing.

"*Lex*," said Arion Vey.

His voice was almost nothing. A breath with a word in it.

Lex knelt by the cot.

"*I'm here*."

"*The book*," said his father.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN LIFTED IT OFF his chest. And put it in Lex's hands.

It was heavier than it looked. Grey cloth. Two hundred pages. More. The first forty were the columns. Hairs. Lines. Stairs. Grip. Going down like water down a slope. And then the names.

Lex turned the pages.

Names. In his father's hand. In the space between the line and the price of bread. Shaky at first. Then shakier. Then, after the day Ashka brought him home, in a hand that wasn't quite his father's. Bigger. Rounder. Square. Where someone else's hand had been round his, holding the pencil.

Abel Mason. Hewer. Thirty-one.

Nell Hask. Eight. She whistled at the window when her brother came home.

Moll Corran. Nine. She kept a hen called Duchess.

Page after page. After page. After page.

He came to the end. The last one. Halfway down a page. In a hand so shaky it was barely letters at all.

Tam Brindle. Drover. Fifty-two. He sang on the road.

And under it, the count. In Seraphine's hand.

Eleven thousand, two hundred and six.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Not all*," said his father. "*There's more. Thousands more. The farms. The roads.*" His eyes moved. To Lex. "*I won't finish.*"

"*Father—*"

"*Finish them*," said Arion Vey. "*After. You and your brother. And Seraphine.*" His voice was a thread. "*Every one. In the book. Between the line and the price of bread.*"

Lex held the grey book in both hands.

"*And at the end*," said his father, "*after the last one—*"

He stopped. His breath going in and out. Shallow. Slow.

"*Kell*," said Seren. Very quietly. Beside him. "*He wants Kell at the end. Antho told us. Through the scar. She asked.*"

"*Kell*," said Arion. "*Isaura Kell. Of Highcrest.*" His mouth moved. "*She hated me. For forty years. Most infuriating man in the Spire. Always right. Never told anyone anything.*" Something that might have been a laugh. "*She was right.*"

He looked at Lex.

"*Put her at the end*," he said. "*After the Vhessans. And then—*"

He stopped again.

"*And then me*," said Arion Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T SPEAK.

He knelt by the cot with the grey book in his hands and looked at his father. At the tiny white shape under the blankets. At the grey eyes. Clear. Steady. Looking back at him.

"*Not with the dead*," said his father. "*Not with the names. Just—*" He swallowed. It took a long time. "*After. On a new page. One line.*"

"*What line*?"

His father didn't answer.

He looked past Lex. At Seren. On the stool. With her hand on his chest. Over his heart.

"*She'll tell you*," said Arion. "*When it's time. She knows.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex.]

Ember. In his hearth. Very quiet.

I know.

[Lex. Let me—] *The coal was glowing.* [*Let me talk to him. Please. Just once. Before.*]

Lex looked at his father.

"*Father*," he said. "*Ember wants to talk to you.*"

His father's eyes moved. To Lex's chest. Where the hearth was.

"*Can it*?" he said. "*Can I hear it?*"

"*I don't know*." Lex looked at his mother. "*Mam could. In the deep. She heard it. She's a Listener.*"

"*I'm not*," said Arion. Faintly. "*I never was. I was a Listener's husband. I learned a little.*" He closed his eyes. "*Not enough.*"

Seren reached out.

And took Arion's thin bone hand. Off the blanket. And laid it flat. On Lex's chest. Over his heart. Over the hearth. And put her own square freckled hand over it.

And held it there.

"*Listen*," said Seren Vey. "*Love. Just listen. The way you listened to me on the stairs. You don't have to hear it. Just listen.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[Hello, old man.]

Lex felt it. Felt Ember say it. In his hearth. In the old dry voice. The voice of a man of two hundred and thirteen, sealing his sons in a thunderstorm in a cottage at Harrow, pressing a piece of himself into the seal like a maker's mark.

He felt his father's hand go rigid on his chest.

His father's eyes opened. Wide.

He heard it.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T KNOW HOW. He'd never know. Maybe it was his mother's hand on top. Maybe it was the dying. Maybe it was that Ember was a piece of him, and a man can always hear himself, at the end, if he listens hard enough.

He heard it.

[You look terrible,] said Ember.

His father laughed. A breath. A crack. A sound like dry leaves.

"*You look—*" He stopped. "*I don't know what you look like. I've never seen you.*"

[I look like you,] said Ember. *[Twenty years ago. Grey at the temples. Two fingers tapping. A face that never changed.]* A pause. *[I've been your son's friend. For five years. I've been very rude to him. I told him terrible jokes about metallurgy.]*

"He told me."

[He laughed at most of them.] *The coal glowed.* [*Arion. Listen. I've got them. All of them. Everything you were, up to the seal. The steps. The rain. The night Antho was born. Walking Lex up and down the kitchen with the fever.*] *A long pause.* [*She paid you to the Ferryman. But I've got them. I've had them all along. Copies. In a hearth.*]

His father's hand trembled on Lex's chest.

[When you're gone,] said Ember, very quietly, *[I'll keep them. Every one. And if she wants them, someday, I'll give them to her. Your side. What you saw. What you felt. On the steps. In the rain.]* A pause. *[She'll never remember being there. But she'll know what it looked like to you.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS FATHER DIDN'T SAY anything for a long time.

His hand lay on Lex's chest. Under his wife's hand. Trembling. His eyes were open. Wet. Looking at nothing. At the tent roof. At Lex's chest. At a coal in a hearth that sounded like himself.

"*Thank you*," said Arion Vey. At last. In a whisper. "*Thank you for looking after him.*"

[He looked after me,] said Ember. *[Mostly by forgetting to spend his points.]*

And his father laughed.

The real laugh. The wide startled one. Cracking out of him like ice off a roof. Shaking the cot. Shaking his bone hand on Lex's chest. Shaking the tears out of his grey eyes.

And Seren laughed too. Beside him. With her hand on his. Crying.

And Lex knelt by the cot with his father's hand on his heart and his mother's hand on his father's and Ember glowing in his hearth like a forge-fire at dawn.

And didn't laugh.

But nearly.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT OUT TO find Brannoc after.

He didn't know why. He just did. The way you go to the forge when you can't sleep. The way you put your hands on iron when you can't put them on anything else.

The old smith was at the anvil. The black Gloam-stone one. At the head of the trench. In the dusk. Alone. With a hammer.

Not hammering.

Just standing there. With his enormous scarred hand on the anvil. Looking east. Along the trench. At the lanterns. Three hundred and fourteen miles of them. Lit. Going away round the circle in a ring of small gold flames, out of sight, round the edge of the world.

"*Look at that*," said Brannoc Holt. Quietly. Without turning round. "*Lad. Just look at that.*"

Lex stood beside him. And looked.

"*When I was capped*," said Brannoc, "*I used to lie awake. You know. I told you. Thinking if I could just get to twenty-five, I'd be able to make something that mattered.*" He was quiet for a long time. "*I never did. Never once. Sixty-three years. Bells and hinges and horseshoes and nails.*"

"*Brannoc—*"

"*I dug that*," said Brannoc. Pointing. At the trench. At a stretch of it, twenty miles east, where the wall was smoother than the rest. "*That bit. With Tilda and Hedda and the lads. Four days.*" His voice was rough. "*And I knocked on it. Every foot. Like you said. Like a door.*"

He looked at Lex. With his old kind fierce wet eyes.

"*Something that mattered*," said Brannoc Holt. "*At sixty-three. With my bad knees. With a spade.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING.

He put his hand on the anvil. Next to Brannoc's. The black Gloam-stone. Warm. From fifty-one days of hammering.

Brannoc looked down at their two hands. Side by side. On the anvil. His enormous scarred one. Lex's big scarred one. The same burns. The

same calluses. In the same places. Thirteen years. From the bellows to the hammer.

"*You did good, lad*," said Brannoc. Very quietly.

"*You said that at the wedding*."

"*I'll keep saying it*," said Brannoc Holt. "*Till you believe it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

KIT FOUND HIM AT midnight.

The Coldwater boy. Seventeen. Who'd walked out of the Drowned Archive behind them six months ago and never gone back. Who'd dug with the Banners for fifty-one days and said almost nothing and slept by the fire at the end of the line every night with his back to the others.

He came up the rubble in the dark. Slowly. With his hands in his pockets.

And stood there.

"*Master Lex*," he said.

"*Kit*."

The boy didn't say anything for a long time.

"*I knew her*," he said at last. "*Nell. Nell Hask.*"

Lex went very still.

"*She was my age*," said Kit. "*In Coldwater. Before the grey. We were in the same dame-school. She sat next to me.*" He looked at his hands. "*She taught me to whistle. The two-note one. Stop, danger, come. She said every pit-kid should know it. In case of firedamp. In case you get lost in the dark.*"

He put his fingers to his mouth.

And whistled. Very softly. Two notes. High. Sharp. The same two notes Wren had whistled from Fennel Street. That Lex had heard over twenty hammers and a hundred miles.

Stop. Danger. Come.

"*She used to do it at the window*," said Kit. "*When Silas came home from the pits. Every night. You could hear it all up the street. Two notes. And he'd whistle back. And everyone would laugh.*" His voice cracked. "*He was so big. And he'd stand in the street outside their house with coal all over him and whistle back at an eight-year-old.*"

He looked up at Lex. In the dark.

"*I know his warm thing*," said Kit. "*Silas Hask. I know what she took. I was there.*" He swallowed. "*I'm the only one left who was.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HIM for a long time.

At a boy of seventeen from a grey town in a grey valley. Who'd stood on a ledge at the bottom of the Drowned Archive and said *I'm staying* to the biggest man he'd ever known. And watched him walk away up the stair with the moths going with him like a cloak.

"*Tomorrow*," said Lex. "*When it comes up. When she comes. He'll be with her.*"

"*I know.*"

"*He'll be in front. Between her and everyone. With his pick.*" Lex's voice was very quiet. "*He'll be the most dangerous thing on the field. After her.*"

"*I know.*"

"*And you want to—*"

"*I want to give it back*," said Kit. Fiercely. "*Like Wren did. With her mam. I want a lamp. And his name. And the whistle.*" His thin face was set like stone. "*I want to stand in front of him and do it. Like Nell did. At the window.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

"*He'll kill me*," said Kit. "*Probably. If I get that close. If she tells him to.*" He looked out at the glitter on the horizon. "*Doesn't matter. He held the pick down. At Fennel Street. Wren said. When she whistled. Just for a second.*" His voice cracked. "*He heard Nell. Just for a second. Through all of it.*"

He looked back at Lex.

"*I want him to hear her all the way*," said Kit.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX GAVE HIM A lantern.

His own. The one from the window at Harrow. Iron and glass. *ARDENT* on the pane. *HOME* on the base. He'd brought it. He didn't know why. He'd taken it out of the window of the cottage at Harrow on the day he left for the Blightmarch and carried it three hundred and fourteen miles round the circle in Brannoc's cart and never once lit it.

He lit it now. On the rubble. In the dark. With his own fire.

And put it in Kit's hands.

Not left on. Given.

"*For Silas Hask*," said Lex. "*From the Ashbourne Forge. From the smith who Unbound him in the rain.*" He closed the boy's fingers round the handle. "*And from Nell.*"

Kit looked down at the lantern.

At the little gold flame behind the glass. At the word on the base.

HOME.

He didn't say anything.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAT ON THE rubble with Wren until the stars went round.

Neither of them slept. Neither of them tried. She sat on her blanket on the Gloam-stone block with her back against the gate-tower and her hands on her stomach, and he sat on the rubble beside her with his head against her knee, and they looked at the circle.

At the lanterns. Three hundred and fourteen miles of them. Gold. All the way round. A ring of small lights at the edge of the world.

At the glitter beyond them. On every horizon. Grey-gold. Turning. Waiting.

At the Dimmed. In their rows. At the foot of the glitter. Swaying. With their dark lanterns held up.

And at the black rubble under them. At Duskhold. At the fallen hall, a hundred yards off, where the scar was. Where his father would be carried tomorrow, on his litter, to lie beside the breach with his hand on the edges. Where his brother was. Under. At the bottom. With the lamp. With Seraphine and Pim and Kell. With the little one pressing up against the underside of the world like a child against a window.

Waiting.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's kicking*," said Wren. Very quietly. Near midnight.

He put his hand on her stomach.

It was. Hard. Fast. Over and over. Like a little drum. Like a fist on a door. Like a heart.

"*It's been doing that all night*," said Wren. "*Since the lanterns. Since they started lighting them.*" She looked out at the ring of gold. "*Like it knows. Like it can feel them.*"

"*Maybe it can*."

"*Maybe*." She was quiet for a moment. "*Seren says the Harrow women always knew. When a child was coming. They said the light in the window got brighter. All on its own. The night before.*"

Lex looked at the lantern-ring.

Was it brighter? He couldn't tell. It was three hundred and fourteen miles of small gold flames. It was the brightest thing he'd ever seen.

"*She wants it*," said Wren.

He didn't need to ask who.

"*She's out there*," said Wren. "*Somewhere in the glitter. Watching. She's been watching for thirty days.*" Her hand tightened on his. On her stomach. "*She wants the little one. And she wants this.*"

"*She won't get either*."

"*You don't know that*."

"*No*," said Lex. "*I don't.*" He looked at her. "*I know that there's three hundred and fourteen miles of people round this circle who'd stand in front of her for it. For both of them. For you.*" His voice was rough. "*I know that.*"

Wren looked at him for a long time.

Then she leaned down. Awkwardly. Round the great curve of herself. And kissed him on the forehead. On the handprint. On the grey-gold mark of a long-fingered hand.

"*Idiot*," she said softly.

◆ ◆ ◆

AT MIDNIGHT, THE BELL rang.

On the cord round his neck. Against his chest. Under his shirt. The little silver bell with the crooked clapper.

Once.

Flat.

Lex put his hand over it.

And under the ground, under the rubble, under the scar, under the breach, in the deep, very faint, very far, he felt something answer. A ripple. A breath. Like something enormous turning over in its sleep.

[...is it time...]

Not yet, thought Lex. *Tomorrow. When the sun goes down. When the lanterns are all lit.*

[...I'm frightened...]

I know.

[...are YOU frightened...]

Lex looked at the glitter on the horizon. Turning. Waiting. At the Dimmed in their rows. At his wife beside him, with her hand on their child. At the tent at the foot of the rubble, where his father was dying.

Yes, he thought. *Yes. I'm frightened.*

[...]

[...good...] said the little one. *[...then it's not just me...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ON THE HORIZON, to the south, where the West Road came into the Blightmarch and the glitter was thickest—

A light.

Not a lantern. Not a fire.

A pillar.

Grey-gold. Glowing. Rising out of the wall of moths into the night sky like a column of smoke lit from inside. Tall. Taller than the Spire. Taller than anything. Reaching up. And up. Until it touched the stars and the stars went out round it.

And at the bottom of it, so far off it was only a speck, a shape. Standing in the glitter. In front of the Dimmed. Tall. Thin. With something folded on its back.

Looking north.

Toward the circle.

Toward the rubble.

Toward a woman on a blanket with her hands on her stomach.

And on Lex's face, cool and smooth as the inside of a shell, the handprint *tightened*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SLEEP.

He sat on the rubble until dawn with his hand on his wife's stomach and his other hand on the bell. Watching the pillar. Watching the glitter. Watching the stars go round.

And as the sky went grey in the east, over the far side of the circle, over three hundred and fourteen miles of lanterns burning gold—

A sound.

From the tent. At the foot of the rubble. Small. Quiet. A sound Lex had heard once before, a long time ago, in a cottage at Harrow, when he was four and woken in the night by a thunderstorm.

His mother. Singing.

Little light, little light, burning low.

Flat. On the high note.

To an old man in a cot. Who was still breathing. Who was holding on.

For one more night.

CHAPTER 33

The Opening

THE SUN WENT DOWN on Lantern Night at the bottom of the world, and Antho Vey couldn't see it.

He felt it.

He was sitting on the warm dark under the breach. Where he'd sat for six days. With his back against the little one and the clay lamp in his lap and his face turned up toward the thin gold line of the scar overhead. The underside of the world. The first wound. Mended once, five years ago, by three of the blood.

And through it, all day, light.

Not much. A seam of it. Gold. Warm. Coming down through the scar like sunlight through a crack in a barn roof. And with it, sound. Faint. Far. Muffled through rubble and rock.

Voices. Thousands of them. Hammers. Carts. Someone singing.

For the little one. From.

For the little one. From.

All day. He'd heard it all day.

And then, a little after what must have been the middle of the afternoon, the gold seam above him had begun to change color. Gold to amber. Amber to red. Red to a deep soft violet, like the sky an hour after sunset. Like the inside of a closed eye.

And then it went dark.

And then, very slowly, it went gold again.

Different gold. Not sun. *Lamplight*. Three hundred and fourteen miles of it. Coming down through the scar from a ring of lanterns round the rim of a word written in the ground.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...brother...]

All round him. Close. The whole vast soft weight of it. Pressed against the underside of the world. Against the scar. The way you'd press your face against a window on a winter night, looking out at the lights.

[...brother, it's dark up there now...]

[...but it's not dark...it's LIGHT...it's all light...]

[...is it time...]

Antho put his hand on the warm dark beside him.

Nearly, he thought. *Nearly. Just a little longer.*

[...I'm frightened...]

I know.

[...the smith said he was frightened too...]

He was, thought Antho. *He told me. Through the Bloodbond. Last night. Sitting on the rubble with Wren.* He looked up at the gold line. *Everyone's frightened. That's all right. You can be frightened and still come up.*

[...can you...]

I did, thought Antho Vey. *For thirty years. I'm still doing it.*

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS BESIDE HIM.

With her hand out. Palm up. Eyes shut. Listening. Not to the little one. To the room. To the space above them. To the circle.

"*They're all there*," she said. Very quietly. "*All round. I can hear them. Where the room changes. Where people are standing.*" Her face was very still. "*Thousands. At the rim. With the lanterns.*"

"*And outside*?"

Seraphine was quiet for a moment.

"*Outside it's—*" She stopped. "*Outside there's nothing. No room. The glitter takes up all the room. It's like—*" She shook her head. "*It's like listening to a wall.*"

"*Is it moving*?"

"*Not yet*."

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM WAS ASLEEP.

Curled up on the warm dark on Antho's other side. In his blue coat. With his knees pulled up and his head on his arms and a hundred iron cups in two baskets beside him, wrapped in straw. He'd filled every one. Over fifty-one days. On Brannoc's cart, on the circle, on the rubble. A hundred rooms you could carry.

He'd brought them down. Antho didn't know why. Pim hadn't said. Pim never said.

Kell was standing.

A little way off. Very straight. In her ruined white robes, gone grey, gone the color of old candle-wax. With her white hair cut short again. With a stick in her hands.

Pim had found it for her. On the twenty-sixth day. Antho didn't know where. There was nothing down here. No trees. No wood. No stone. Just dark and stars and the little one.

But Pim had walked off into the dark one day, alone, for an hour. And come back with a stick. Long. Plain. Dark. Like a shepherd's crook without the crook. And held it out to Kell without a word.

She'd looked at it for a long time.

Where did you get that? she'd said.

Pim had looked at the dark. At the little one. And then back at her.

It made it, he'd said. *I asked.*

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Vey*," said Kell.

He looked up.

She was looking at the scar. At the gold line overhead. Her thin face lit by it. Very calm.

"*When it goes*," she said. "*When you open it. It'll go up. All of it. Slowly. Like water coming up a well.*" She shifted her grip on the stick. "*And there'll be a time. In the middle. When it's half through. When the front of it's up there in the circle and the back of it's still down here.*"

"*I know*."

"*It can't go back then*," said Kell. "*Not without tearing. And it can't hurry. Not without pulling.*" She looked at him. "*It'll be stuck. In the door. Like a man with one foot over the threshold.*"

Antho didn't say anything.

"*That's when she'll come*," said Isaura Kell. "*Not before. Not after. Then.*" She looked back at the scar. "*When it can't run.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

[Antho.]

Not the little one.

Lex.

Through the Bloodbond. Faint. Far. Through the rubble and the rock and the scar. His brother's voice. Not words, exactly. The shape of words. The way you hear someone talk through a wall.

[It's time. Father's here. At the scar. On the floor. Mam's with him.]

How is he?

A pause.

[Holding on,] said Lex. *[He's got his hand on the edges. He says he can feel you. Underneath. He says you're in exactly the right place.]*

And the glitter?

A longer pause.

[It's moving,] said Lex.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO STOOD UP.

He woke Pim. He didn't have to. The boy was already awake. Already sitting up. With his grey-violet eyes very wide, looking at the scar.

Seraphine stood up. With her notebook in her coat. With her hand still out.

Kell didn't move. She was already standing.

And all round them, the little one went very still.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WENT TO THE scar.

It wasn't far. A few steps. Up the last of the long slope. To where the warm dark met the underside of the world. To where the gold line was. Overhead. Close now. So close he could reach up and touch it.

He reached up.

And put his hand flat on it.

Warm. Rough. Like the underside of a stone that's been lying in the sun all day. And through it, on the other side, so close, so very close, separated by nothing but a mended wound—

A hand.

Thin. Bone. Brown-spotted. Shaking. Laid flat on the scar from above. On the black floor of the fallen hall. Exactly where Antho's was, from below. Palm to palm. Through the wound.

His father's.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Antho.]

Not through the Bloodbond. Not through the little one. Through the scar. Through the hand. Faint. A thread. A breath with words in it.

[There you are.]

"*Father*," said Antho. Out loud. To the stone.

[You're right under where I knelt,] said his father's voice. *[Exactly. Not an inch off. I can feel it.]* A pause. A breath. *[You'll be very good at this. I told you.]*

"*I don't know how.*"

[Yes, you do.]

"*I've never opened anything. I've only ever held things shut.*"

[Then do it the same way,] said Arion Vey. *[But the other direction.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO CLOSED HIS EYES.

He stood at the bottom of the world with his hand on the underside of a scar and his father's hand on top of it and the little one pressed against his back, enormous and soft and trembling.

And he thought about doors.

The cave in the Greyspine. Where he'd lived for eight years. With a crack in it he didn't know was there, and his mother holding it from the other side.

The black glass at the bottom of the Hollowmaw. Where he'd said *evening, Mam* every night for three years.

The doorway at the bottom of the Heart. Where he'd stood with his back to the hunger and shut it out with his own body.

The tear in the gold room. Where he'd stood while the little one screamed and his Clarity went to thirty-eight and something old in his skull told him to squeeze.

The kitchen doorway at the Keep. Where he'd turned round. And shouldn't have.

Kell's door. Where he'd knocked.

Every door I've ever stood in, he thought, *I've been holding something back. Keeping something out. Keeping something in.*

I've never once stood in a door to let something through.

◆ ◆ ◆

Ask, his father had said. On the black floor at Duskhold. In the dark. With both their hands on the scar. *Ask it to open. Ask the little one to come up. Ask the net to let it through.*

Ask everyone.

I tore it alone. You open it with everyone.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE ASKED.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT THE SCAR. NOT first.

The little one.

Are you ready? thought Antho.

[...no...]

Will you come anyway?

A long silence. The whole vast weight of it, pressed against his back. Trembling.

[...yes...]

[...if you're there...if you stay in the door...if you don't go...]

I'll stay in the door, thought Antho Vey. *I'll stay in it the whole time. Until you're through. Until the last of you is up. I won't move.*

[...promise...]

I promise.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN HIS FATHER.

Show me the edges.

And his father did. Through the scar. Through their two hands, palm to palm. He felt it. His father's hand moving. Very slowly. On the stone above. Tracing. The line. Where it was thick. Where it was thin. Where the old stitches were. Where the gap was, under where he'd knelt, where the edges had never quite met.

[There,] said his father. *[That's where it'll go first. It wants to. It's been wanting to for twenty-one years.]*

Thank you.

[Don't pull,] said Arion Vey. Very faintly. *[Whatever happens. However frightened you are. However slow it is. Don't pull.]*

I won't.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEN THE NET.

He didn't know how to ask the net. Nobody did. Nobody held it anymore. Lex had given the Root away. It was nobody's. It just *noticed*.

So he let it notice.

He stood in the doorway. Under the scar. With his hand up and his father's hand on the other side and the little one at his back. And he didn't hide. He didn't use the dark to make himself small. He didn't fold his thread into Shade the way he'd learned in the Greyspine, hiding from Wardens.

He stood there. And let the net see him.

Threshold Warden, it had called him. At the Heart. *One who stands in the doorway between dark and dark, and decides.*

I'm deciding, thought Antho. *I'm deciding to open it.*

Will you let it through?

The net didn't answer. It never answered. It just noticed.

But he felt it notice.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN EVERYONE.

He reached for his brother. Through the Bloodbond. Up. Through the rock. Through the rubble.

Lex.

[I'm here.]

I need everyone.

[What?]

I need them to ask, thought Antho. *Everyone. Round the circle. At the lanterns. I need them to ask it to come up. Out loud. All at once.*

A silence. Long. Through the stone.

[How?]

I don't know, thought Antho. *You're the one who makes speeches.*

And through the Bloodbond, far off, he felt his brother laugh.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T HEAR WHAT Lex said. He'd never know. He'd ask, afterward, and Lex would go red and say *I don't remember, something stupid, something about porridge*, and Wren would say *it was beautiful, actually, you idiot*, and Lex would go redder.

He heard what came after.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT STARTED AT THE rubble.

Right above him. Through the scar. A voice. Then two. Then twenty. He couldn't hear the words. Just the sound. Like a crowd at a fair, when someone says *quiet, quiet, listen*, and the noise drops, and then—

One word.

He couldn't make it out. Muffled. Through rock. A single word, said by hundreds of voices at once.

And then it *spread*.

Out from the rubble. Along the circle. He felt it go. Through the ground. Through the trench. Through the walls of baked grey earth that

his brother had walked three hundred and fourteen miles with his hand on. East and west and round. The word. Passing from lantern to lantern. From person to person. The way a song goes round a room.

Faster. And faster. All the way round.

Until the whole circle was saying it.

Three hundred and fourteen miles of people, kneeling at the rim of a word written in the ground, with their hands on lanterns they'd given away, saying one word. All at once. Over and over.

And this time, he heard it.

Not with his ears. Through the scar. Through his father's hand. Through the little one, pressed against his back, going very, very still.

Come.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...oh...]

The little one.

[...oh...they're saying...]

[...brother, they're all saying...]

[...they're saying COME...]

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SCAR OPENED.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT LIKE A TEAR. Not like a wound. Not like rock breaking.

Like a hand opening.

From the middle. From the place under where his father had knelt. Where the edges had never quite met. Antho felt it go. Under his palm. The stone going soft. Going warm. Going *away*. Not breaking. Not crumbling. Just—becoming room. The way the black glass of the Hollowmaw door had stopped being there when Kell said *come in*.

A gap. Between his hand and his father's.

He felt his father's hand slip through it.

Down. Into the dark. Thin. Bone. Shaking. Reaching.

And Antho caught it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY HELD HANDS THROUGH the opening breach.

Father and son. One above, one below. One on a black floor in a fallen hall, on a litter, a hundred years in a drawer. One at the bottom of the world with a clay lamp and something the size of a country at his back.

Holding hands. Through the door.

And the door kept opening.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT SLOWLY. LIKE his father said. Like he'd asked. Not pulled. Not torn. Asked. The gap widening. From the middle. Along the line of the old scar. A foot. A yard. Ten yards. Following the edges. Following the place where it had always been thin.

And light came down.

Gold. Warm. Lamplight. Three hundred and fourteen miles of it. Pouring down through the opening breach into the deep like water into a well. Into the dark. Onto him. Onto Seraphine, with her hand out and her face turned up and her mouth open. Onto Pim, standing, small, with a basket of cups in each hand. Onto Kell, very straight, with her stick.

Onto the little one.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...LIGHT...]

Not frightened.

[...it's LIGHT...it's all the light...it's all for ME...]

And it began to rise.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO FELT IT GO past him.

Not through him. Past. Around. The way water goes round a stone in a stream. The way a crowd goes round a man standing in a doorway. The whole vast soft dark of it, folded round the deep, beginning to move. Up. Toward the light. Toward the opening. Toward the circle.

Slowly.

So slowly. Like dough rising. Like the tide coming in. Like the first green coming up through a field in spring, when you can't tell if it's grass or wishful thinking.

He held the door.

He stood in the opening with his father's hand in his and the light pouring down on him and the little one rising round him on every side. Soft. Warm. Enormous. Brushing past him. The way a cat brushes your legs when it goes past you into a room.

[...brother...]

I'm here.

[...you're in the door...]

I'm in the door.

[...don't move...]

I won't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ANTHOREN VEY
THRESHOLD WARDEN
New skill: OPEN THE WAY (Master 1)
"He has stood in a hundred doors to
 hold them shut. This is the first he
 has stood in to hold it open."
Level 82 → 87
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◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE WAS CRYING.

He could hear it. Beside him. Below the opening. With her hand out and the light on her face and the little one rising past her, round her, brushing her hair, her sleeves, her outstretched palm.

"*I can hear it*," she was saying. Over and over. "*Antho. I can hear it go up. I can hear the room filling. The circle. I can hear it filling.*" She was laughing. "*It's like—it's like a jug being filled. At a pump. You can hear the note change. As it fills. Higher. And higher.*"

He could hear it too.

Not the note. The *voices*. Above. Through the opening. Getting louder. Not saying *come* anymore. Saying other things. Shouting. Crying. Laughing.

There. Look. There. Look at it. Look.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Antho.]

Lex. Through the Bloodbond. Close now. So close.

[Antho. It's coming up. I can see it.]

What does it look like?

His brother didn't answer for a long time.

[Like the sky,] said Lex at last. *[Like night. Coming up out of the ground. Soft. Dark. With stars in it. Shade's stars. Filling the circle. Slowly. From the breach. Spreading out.]* A pause. *[Like ink in water. Like the first dark of evening. Like—*]

He stopped.

[It's beautiful,] said Lex Vey. *[Antho. It's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN SERAPHINE STOPPED laughing.

All at once. Like a door shutting. She went rigid beside him. With her hand out. Palm up. Her face turned up toward the opening. Toward the light.

"*Antho*," she said.

He didn't look at her. He couldn't. He was holding the door. He was holding his father's hand.

"*Antho, the wall*." Her voice was very small. "*The glitter. Outside the circle. I can hear it. I couldn't before. I could only hear the wall. It took up all the room.*" She swallowed. "*It's not a wall anymore.*"

"*What is it*?"

"*It's moving*," said Seraphine. "*All of it. All the way round. From every side. At once.*" Her hand was shaking. "*It's coming in.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ABOVE, THROUGH THE OPENING, the voices changed.

Not *look*. Not *there*.

Lanterns. Lanterns. Hold the lanterns. Black heat. Black heat. Ashari. Ashari to the rim.

They're coming.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT HIT.

Not the little one. The *circle*. The rim. Three hundred and fourteen miles of lanterns, given, set down on the edge of a word written in the ground.

The moths hit it.

All at once. From every side. Like a wave. Like the tide coming in over the flats, so fast, so silent, round your ankles before you've seen it come. The great grey-gold wall that had sat on the horizon for thirty days. Coming in. Drifting. Pouring. Over the grey. Over the Dimmed in their rows. Over the families at the south edge with their second lanterns.

To the rim.

To the light.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND HE FELT THEM *fall*.

He'd never forget it. He'd feel it for the rest of his life. Through the ground. Through the walls of the trench. Through the opening breach. Through his father's hand.

Thousands of them. Tens of thousands. Hitting the ring of lanterns. Pressing against them. Drinking.

And getting nothing.

Given. Every one. *For the little one. From*. Set down. Not waiting. Not left on for someone who wasn't home. Given away. To something that was coming. That was *here*.

They couldn't drink it. Any of it. Not one lantern in three hundred and fourteen miles.

They pressed. And drank. And got nothing. And pressed harder. And got nothing.

And fell.

Like snow. Like leaves. Onto the rim. Into the trench. Grey-gold. Glittering. Heaps of them. Drifts. Walls.

And behind them, more. Pouring in. Pressing. Falling. Pressing.

And in the dark round every lantern, invisible, rippling, the Ashari and the smiths. Black heat. Burning every one that came too close.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's holding*," said Seraphine. Breathless. "*Antho. The rim. It's holding. They can't get through. They can't drink the lanterns.*" Her voice cracked. "*Ivy was right. Ivy was right.*"

He held the door.

The little one was still rising. Past him. Round him. Slowly. Up. Through the opening. Into the circle. He could feel it. Half of it now. More. The front of it up there in the light, spreading, filling the word written in the ground, going out toward the rim in every direction like the first dark of evening.

And the back of it still down here. Round him. Round Seraphine and Pim and Kell. In the deep.

Half through.

It can't go back then, Kell had said. *Not without tearing. And it can't hurry. Not without pulling.*

It'll be stuck. In the door.

That's when she'll come.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED AT KELL.

She was standing very straight. Under the opening. In the light pouring down. With her stick in both hands. Not looking at him.

Looking up.

At the opening. At the light. At the little one rising through it, soft and dark and enormous and starred, filling the hole in the world.

At something else. In the light. Coming *down*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW IT.

At the very top of the opening. Where the breach met the fallen hall. Where his father lay on the black floor with his hand through the gap.

A shape.

Not falling. Not flying. *Leaning*. Into the opening. Into the light. The way a moth leans into a gap in a shutter. Folded. Tight. Patient.

Tall. Thin. Grey-gold. Glowing. With silver hair to her knees and something on her back, folded close, like a cloak, patterned with rings and whorls and eyes.

And two lights at the front of her. Gold. Warm. Like windows.

She came down through the opening breach like a moth coming down a chimney. Into the light. Past the rising dark. Down. Toward the back of the little one. Toward the part still in the deep. Still round him. Still half through.

Toward the middle.

Toward the warmest, deepest, softest place. Where two little lights lay curled together, singing in tune.

With her hands cupped.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...brother...]

All round him. The little one. Rising. Half through. Stuck. Unable to go back. Unable to hurry.

Feeling her come.

[...brother...]

[...brother, it's HER...]

[...she's coming DOWN...she's coming down the door while I'm IN it...]

[...I can't MOVE...]

[...I can't move I can't move I can't—]

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO HELD THE DOOR.

He held it with his feet set on the warm dark and his hand in his father's through the opening and his other hand round the clay lamp, his mother's mother's, lit, given, *his*.

He didn't move.

He'd promised.

I'll stay in the door. The whole time. Until you're through. I won't move.

And the Moth Queen came down through the light toward the heart of the thing he was holding the door for. And he couldn't stop her. Because he couldn't move. Because if he moved, the door would close, and the little one would tear.

He'd never been so frightened in his life.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN KELL MOVED.

Past him. Under the opening. Into the light. In her ruined robes. With her white hair. Very straight.

With a stick.

She went up.

Antho didn't know how. There was nothing to climb. There was only the light pouring down and the dark rising up. She went up anyway. Into the opening. Along the rising dark. The way you'd walk up a hill. The little one carried her. Folded round her feet. Lifting her. The way it had carried them all up from the gold room, folded like a letter.

Up. Toward the Moth Queen. Coming down.

She stopped. Halfway. In the middle of the opening. In the middle of the light. In the place where the front of the little one was in the circle and the back of it was in the deep.

In the door.

And turned round. And faced up. Toward the shape coming down.

And lifted the stick.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Isaura*," said Maelis.

She'd stopped too. Just above. Leaning. Glowing. With her hands cupped and her lit eyes on the gaunt white-haired woman in the light below her. Blocking the way.

"*Isaura Kell*," she said. Softly. Fondly. "*High Warden. I broke your stick.*"

"*I got another one.*"

"*I see.*" The Moth Queen tilted her head. "*Where from?*"

"*It made it*," said Isaura Kell. "*For me. Because a boy asked.*"

Maelis looked at the stick. In Kell's bony hands. Long. Plain. Dark.

Something moved in her face.

"*It made you a stick*," she said. Slowly. "*To hold against me.*"

"*Yes.*"

"*The thing I drank*," said Maelis. "*Made you a stick. To stop me drinking it again.*"

"*Yes*," said Kell. "*It's very young. It doesn't know any better.*" Her pale eyes didn't waver. "*Neither do I, apparently.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

BELOW THEM, AT THE bottom of the opening, Antho stood in the door with his father's hand in his and the lamp in the other and couldn't breathe.

[...the Warden...] said the little one. Very small. *[...the Warden's in the door...]*

[...she's standing in the door in front of me...]

[...like she said...like she ALWAYS said...]

"*Yes*," whispered Antho. Out loud. To no one. To the dark. "*Yes, she is.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND MAELIS SMILED.

Not lovely. Not sad. Not fond. Not patient.

Hungry.

"*Oh, Isaura*," she said. "*You stupid, stubborn, beautiful woman. You've learned nothing. You still think the person standing in the door decides what comes through.*"

She spread her wings.

All of them. Enormous. Filling the opening. Grey-gold. Glowing. Every painted eye on every wing turned down. Toward Kell. Toward the light. Toward the soft dark rising.

"*I don't need to come through*," said the Moth Queen.

And behind her, above her, out of the circle, out of the light, out of the great grey-gold wall that had broken itself against three hundred and fourteen miles of given lanterns—

The moths came down the opening.

All of them. Every one that was left. Not to the rim. Not to the lanterns. Down. Through the breach. Past Maelis. Past Kell. Like smoke down a chimney when the wind turns. A river of grey-gold glitter, pouring down into the deep.

Toward the back of the little one. Still in the dark. Still round Antho. Still half through.

Toward the middle.

Toward the two little lights.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FROM ABOVE, THROUGH the opening, through the light, through his father's hand in his, very faint, Antho heard his father say one word.

Not to him.

To someone above. On the black floor of the fallen hall. Beside the litter.

Seren.

And then he felt his father's hand go slack.

And slip out of his.

CHAPTER 34

The Moth and the Flame, Part One

LEX SAW HIS FATHER'S hand go slack.

He was on his knees beside the litter. On the black floor of the fallen hall. With the breach open in front of him, a long gold-lit gap in the floor where the scar had been, pouring light down into the deep and dark up into the world. With his mother on the other side of the litter, holding his father's other hand. With the little one rising past them out of the opening, soft and starred and enormous, spreading out across the circle like the first dark of evening.

And his father's arm, reaching down into the gap. Down through the light. Holding his brother's hand.

It went slack.

And slid back up out of the breach. Limp. And fell onto the black floor beside the litter. Palm up. Empty.

"*Father—*"

His mother was already there. Over him. Her face an inch from his. Her ear on his chest.

She didn't say anything for a long time.

"*He's breathing*," said Seren Vey. At last. In a whisper. "*Lex. He's breathing. Just. Just.*"

She didn't lift her head.

"*He held it as long as he could*," she said. "*He held the edges. He held Antho's hand. He said my name.*" Her voice cracked. "*And then he let go.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX COULDN'T MOVE.

He knelt on the black floor with his father's empty hand in front of him and couldn't move. He'd been carrying things for so long. The hammer. The fire. The circle. Three hundred and fourteen miles of it. Fifty-one days. And now his father was a white wisp on a litter with his eyes shut and his mother's ear on his chest, listening for a heart that might stop.

And below him, in the breach—

[LEX.]

Antho. Through the Bloodbond. Not faint now. A shout. A scream.

[Lex, the MOTHS. They're coming down. All of them. Past Kell. Past HER. Down the opening. To the middle.] His brother's voice was shaking so hard it barely made words. *[To Mal. To the little lights. Lex, I can't move. I can't move. If I move the door shuts and it tears.]*

[LEX.]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED DOWN INTO the breach.

Into the light. Into the gold pouring down from three hundred and fourteen miles of lanterns. Into the dark pouring up. Soft. Starred. Rising past the edges of the opening like water coming up a well.

And in the middle of the opening, halfway down, standing on the rising dark like a woman standing on a hill—

Kell.

Very straight. In her ruined robes. With her white hair. With a stick held up in both hands. Crosswise. Like a bar across a door.

And above her, filling the opening, enormous, glowing, with her wings spread from wall to wall of the breach and every painted eye turned down—

Maelis.

And between them, and past them, and *round* them, like smoke round a chimney-pot when the wind turns—

The moths.

Pouring down. Past Kell. Past the Moth Queen. Down the opening. A river of grey-gold glitter, going *down*. Into the deep. Against the rising dark. Toward the back of the little one. Toward the middle.

Toward two little lights, curled together, singing in tune.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...MAL...]

The little one. All round him. Rising. Stuck. Half through.

[...they're going for MAL...for the MIDDLE...]

[...I can't stop them I can't MOVE I can't—]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD UP.

His mother looked at him. Over his father's chest. With her face white and her eyes very bright.

"*Go*," said Seren Vey.

"*Father—*"

"*I've got him*." Her hand was flat on the old man's heart. "*I've got him. I've had him all summer. I'll keep him.*" She looked at Lex. Fierce. Small. Freckled. "*Your brother's in the door. Kell's in the door. Somebody has to go down.*"

He looked at her.

"*Go*," said his mother.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FROM THE RUBBLE, behind him, through the broken wall, a scream.

Not a moth-scream. Not a battle-scream.

Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED.

Through the gap where Duskhold's gate had been. Up the black slope of rubble. To the top. To the block of Gloam-stone at the foot of the gate-tower, where she'd been sitting all day on her folded blanket. Where she'd sat all last night. With her hands on her stomach.

She wasn't sitting.

She was on her knees. On the blanket. Doubled over. With both hands pressed to the great round of her stomach and her face screwed up and her red hair loose and her mouth open.

And Old Mag was beside her. Ninety-six. With her one bright eye. And Maren Ashdown on her other side. Holding her shoulders.

And over the three of them, round them, a bubble.

Wind. Wren's wind. A dome of it. Clear and hard and spinning. Over the top of the rubble. Over the gate-tower. Over the blanket. Holding the moths off. A storm the size of a room, with three women in the eye of it.

And it was *flickering*.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE RAN.

Up the rubble. He didn't remember deciding to. He was running. Slipping on the black stone. Grabbing. Climbing. Over the broken blocks of Morvane's citadel. Toward the bubble of wind. Toward the women in it.

The moths were round the bubble. Thick. Pressing. Grey-gold. Like a swarm round a hive. Beating against the spinning wall of air. Getting thrown off. Coming back. Getting thrown off.

Coming back.

And every time Wren's face screwed up, every time she doubled over, the bubble *flickered*. And the moths pressed closer. And got thrown off again. Barely.

He came through the bubble.

It let him. It always did. It was her wind. It knew him.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Lex.*" Wren looked up. Her face was grey. Wet. Twisted. "*Lex. Oh, gods. It's coming.*"

"*Now*?"

"*No, next week*," said Wren Ashdown. Through her teeth. "*Yes, now. Now. It started at sunset. When the lanterns. When they all said—*" She stopped. Doubled over. Gasped. The bubble flickered. "*When they all said come.*"

He knelt in front of her.

"*Babies don't read calendars*," said Old Mag. Calmly. With her old hand on Wren's back. "*I told you. I told all of you. Nobody listens to the herbwife.*"

"*How long*?"

"*Hours*," said Old Mag. "*First one. Could be all night. Could be till dawn.*" She looked at him with her one bright eye. "*Could be faster. This one's in a hurry. This one heard everyone say come and thought they meant it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

WREN GRABBED HIS COAT.

Both fists. The way she had on the West Road. The way she had on the slope of the Hollowmaw. Pulling him close. Her face an inch from his.

"*Listen to me*," said Wren. "*Hammer. Listen.*"

"*I'm listening*."

"*Antho's screaming*." Her eyes were wild. "*I can hear him. In the wind. Through the breach. He's screaming your name.*"

"*I know*."

"*Go*."

He stared at her.

"*Go*," said Wren Ashdown. "*Go down. Go and help him. Go and help the little one. That's what you're for. That's what all of this was for.*" Her fists were shaking on his coat. "*I'm having a baby. I'm not dying. Women have been having babies since before there were Wells. Mag's got me. Mam's got me.*"

"*Wren—*"

"*She's going to come*," said Wren. "*Up here. For this.*" Her hand went to her stomach. "*You know she is. When it's born. She's going to feel it. A new light. The newest one. Never anyone's.*" Her voice cracked. "*So you go down there and you finish it. Fast. Before she can.*"

She let go of his coat.

"*And then come back*," she said. "*Because if you're not here when this baby comes out, Lex Vey, I'll never forgive you. Never. Not ever.*"

She doubled over. Gasped. The bubble flickered.

"*GO*," said Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT.

He didn't remember going. He'd ask her, after. And she'd say *you kissed me and you went, you idiot, you kissed me on the forehead like a priest and ran down the rubble like a bear in a china shop*.

He didn't remember.

He remembered the bubble letting him out. He remembered the moths round it, pressing. He remembered burning them. Black heat. Pouring off him as he ran. Not because he decided to. Because he was so frightened and so angry and so far past thinking that the fire just came, the way it had come on the night of the gloamhounds, when he was nineteen, when the seal cracked.

He remembered the hall.

He remembered his mother, on her knees beside the litter, with her ear on his father's chest. Looking up as he came running back. Her face.

He remembered the breach.

He remembered jumping in.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT HIT HIM like water.

Gold. Warm. Thick. Pouring down from above. From three hundred and fourteen miles of lanterns. He fell through it.

And the dark caught him.

Rising. Soft. Starred. The little one. Coming up through the breach like a tide coming up a beach. It caught him the way the Stone had caught him in Fennel Street. Not softly. *Kindly*. Folded round his feet and his legs. Held him.

[...SMITH...]

I'm here.

[...smith you came down...]

Where?

[...the MIDDLE...they're going for the middle...]

He looked up.

◆ ◆ ◆

KELL WAS ABOVE HIM.

In the light. In the middle of the opening. On the rising dark. Very straight. With her stick crosswise.

And above Kell, the Moth Queen.

She wasn't fighting. Lex saw that at once. She wasn't trying to get past. She hung in the opening with her wings spread wall to wall and her lit eyes on Kell, *watching*, the way you'd watch a dog you've told to sit.

And past them both, round them both, down the edges of the breach like rain down a chimney—

The moths.

Not at Kell. Not at Lex. *Past*. Down. A river of them. Grey-gold. Pouring down the inside walls of the opening, along the edges, where the light was thinnest. Into the deep. Into the dark below. Toward the back of the little one. Toward the part still down there. Still round Antho. Still in the door.

Toward the middle.

She wasn't trying to get through.

She was holding Kell's attention while her moths went round.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Smith*."

Maelis. From above. Not looking at him. Looking at Kell.

"*How nice of you to drop in*," she said. "*Your wife's in labor, isn't she? I can feel it. Up there. On the rubble. In that little wind.*" Her voice was very soft. "*A new light. Coming. Tonight.*"

Lex didn't answer.

"*You should be up there with her*," said the Moth Queen. "*Holding her hand. What are you doing down here?*"

"*Burning your moths*," said Lex.

And let go of the dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELL.

Down. Through the opening. Past the edges. Past the moths pouring down the walls. Down through the rising dark of the little one, which parted for him, which let him through the way the bubble had let him through. Down. Toward the bottom. Toward the door.

Toward the deep.

He hit the warm dark at the bottom of the breach on his feet. Beside his brother.

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WAS IN THE door.

Standing. Under the opening. Exactly where he'd been. With his feet set and his free hand held up, reaching, toward the place where their father's hand had been. Empty. And his other hand round the clay lamp. Lit.

His face was white. Grey. Wet. His eyes—

Clear. Not black. Not dim. Clear. And terrified.

"*Lex*," said his brother.

"*I know*."

"*Father—*"

"*He's breathing. Mam's got him.*"

Antho shut his eyes. For one breath. And opened them.

"*The middle*," he said. "*Lex. The middle. Go.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT.

Behind his brother. Into the dark. Into the back of the little one. The part still in the deep. Still unrisen. Still waiting its turn to go up through the door.

It was huge. Even this part. Even the back. Soft dark going away in every direction under Shade's stars. Folding. Trembling.

And full of moths.

They were everywhere. He'd come down into a blizzard. A snowstorm of grey-gold. So thick he couldn't see the stars. Pouring down out of the opening, round Antho in the door, past him, into the dark, spreading out, *searching*.

Not drinking. Not yet. *Searching*. Turning. Drifting. Like bees in a field looking for the one flower.

Looking for the middle.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...SMITH...]

Where is it?

[...I'm HIDING it...I folded it...small...like the lamp-lady...]

[...but I'm going UP...I can't fold and go up at the same time...I can't HOLD it...]

[...it's coming UNFOLDED...]

And Lex saw it.

Ahead. In the blizzard. A hundred yards off. Low down. Where the dark was softest.

A glow. Faint. Silver-gold. Like very old candles.

Two little lights. Curled together. Side by side. Asleep. Coming out of the fold. Unfolding. Slowly. As the little one rose and couldn't hold it.

Singing.

Little light, little light, burning low.

In tune.

And the moths saw it too.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY TURNED.

All of them. All at once. The whole blizzard. Like a flock of starlings in the moment before it turns. Every painted eye on every wing. Toward the glow.

And *poured*.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX RAN.

He'd never run so fast. Not on the night of the gloamhounds. Not in the Glass Desert. Not on the white mountain at the Heart. He ran through the blizzard with the black heat pouring off him so hard the moths in front of him didn't have time to curl, they just *went*, like dry leaves thrown on a forge, a flash and a puff of grey-gold ash and nothing.

It wasn't enough.

They were faster. They were lighter. They were thousands and he was one. They poured past him on every side, a river, a flood, going for the glow, going for the two little lights, the small one with the straw hat and the tall one with the hammer.

He was going to be too late.

He *knew* it. The way he knew a weld was bad before he struck it. He was going to get there and the moths would be there first, thousands of them, pressed against the little lights, drinking.

Drinking Malachi.

Drinking the song in tune.

Drinking the middle of the thing he'd promised a home.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex.]

Ember. In his hearth. Very calm. Very clear.

[Lex. Stop running.]

I can't—

[Stop. You won't get there first. You know you won't.] The coal was glowing. *[Stop running and think. Like a smith. What do you do when the fire's in the wrong place?]*

He stopped.

In the middle of the blizzard. On the warm dark. With the moths pouring past him on every side.

What do you do when the fire's in the wrong place?

You don't chase it, he thought. *You don't run round the forge after it with a bucket.*

You move the coals.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE KNELT.

On the warm dark. On the back of the little one. In the blizzard.

And put both hands flat on it.

And didn't ask it to go anywhere. Didn't ask it to fold. Didn't ask it to hide. It couldn't. It was rising. It was half through a door. It was doing the hardest thing it had ever done and it didn't have anything left for hiding.

He asked it for something else.

Make room, thought Lex.

[...what...]

Make room. Round me. Here. Now. Not round the middle. Round me.

[...why...]

Because I'm brighter, thought Lex Vey.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LET THE FIRE up.

All of it.

Not black heat. Not hidden. Not banked. *Gold*. The way it had been at the Heart, on the white mountain, at the anvil, when he struck the seam and the hunger unfolded. The way it had been at nineteen, on the green at Ashbourne, when the seal cracked and the gloamhounds came. The way it was in the forge every morning, when he blew on the coals and said good morning and the fire woke up glad to see him.

Bright.

Brighter than anything in the deep. Brighter than the two little lights. Brighter than the lanterns. Brighter than the opening.

A Worldforger. Tier IV. Level ninety-five. Flame Commanding. With everything he had pouring out of him at once. Gold and red and white. Like a forge-door flung open. Like a sunrise. Like a lamp in a window at the end of a long lane on the coldest night of the year.

And the little one made room round him.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT IT HAPPEN.

The dark drew back. From round him. In a circle. A room. Ten yards. Twenty. Fifty. A great round space in the soft dark of the little one with him in the middle of it, kneeling, *blazing*.

Empty. Except for him. Except for the light.

And the moths saw it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY TURNED.

All of them. The whole blizzard. Away from the glow. Away from the two little lights, curled together, singing. Away from the middle.

Toward *him*.

The brightest thing in the deep.

A lamp. Lit. In a window. In an empty room.

They came.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T FIGHT THEM.

He knelt in the middle of the room the little one had made and blazed, and let them come. All of them. Pouring in. Off the walls of the room. Down out of the dark. Toward him. Toward the light.

And when they were all in—

When the room was full of them, every one, a storm of grey-gold so thick he couldn't see his own hands—

He put the fire out.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT OUT.

Down.

All at once. The gold going into him. Under the skin. Hiding. The way it had hidden in the deep the first time, when Kestrel asked *what's fire that isn't light*.

Black heat.

In an instant. Everything he'd had, everything he'd been pouring out as light, turned inside out. Hidden. Dark. And *hot*.

Hotter than he'd ever been. Hotter than the Sunwell. Hotter than the Hearth in the Wellworld of Flame, where he'd nearly become fire and his brother had quenched him through the Bloodbond.

The most dangerous heat there is.

The kind with no light in it.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE ROOM WENT SILENT.

All at once. Like a held breath. The roar of wings, gone. The glitter, gone. The storm of grey-gold, gone.

Lex knelt in the middle of the room with the black heat pouring off him and his eyes shut.

And when he opened them, the floor round him was grey.

Ash. Fine. Soft. Like snow. Lying in a great circle on the warm dark of the little one, fifty yards across. A drift of it. An inch deep. Every moth that had come to the light.

Not gathering. Not piling up. Not stirring.

Gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...oh...]

The little one. All round him. The walls of the room it had made. Trembling.

[...oh, smith...]

[...you made a lamp...in a room...and they all came in...]

[...like I used to...when I was the other thing...when I was HUNGRY...the worlds came in...]

[...you made a trap that looked like me...]

Lex knelt in the ash.

I'm sorry, he thought. *I'm sorry. I didn't know how else.*

The little one was quiet for a long time.

[...don't be sorry...] it said at last. Very small. *[...they were going for Mal...]*

[...you moved the coals...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE GOT UP.

Slowly. His legs shaking. The black heat going down, back to nothing, back to the banked glow he lived with every day. He was so tired. He'd never been so tired. He looked down at his hands. Grey. With ash. With moth.

And past them, past the edge of the room, which was folding back now, softly, the little one closing it like a hand closing—

The glow.

Faint. Silver-gold. Like very old candles.

Two little lights. Curled together. Side by side. Asleep. Untouched.

Singing.

Little light, little light, burning low.

In tune.

◆ ◆ ◆

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LEX VEY
Level 95 → 96
"He moved the coals."
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◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex.]

Antho. Through the Bloodbond. Not screaming now. Something else.

[Lex. They're gone. All of them. I felt them go. Every one.] His brother's voice was shaking. *[How did you—*]

Later.

[Lex. The little one. It's moving again. It stopped. When they came. It stopped rising. It's moving again.] A pause. *[More than half through now. Most of it. It's going up.]*

And Kell?

Silence.

[Lex,] said Antho. Very quietly. *[You need to look up.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE LOOKED UP.

Through the dark. Through the deep. Toward the opening. Toward the light.

It was a long way. A hundred yards. More. He'd fallen a long way. But he could see it. The gold. The breach. The rising dark going up through it like smoke up a chimney.

And in the middle of the opening, in the light—

Kell.

Still there. Still standing on the rising dark. Still very straight.

But not with her stick crosswise.

The stick was gone. He couldn't see it. Her hands were empty. Held up. Over her head. Gripping something.

Wings.

Grey-gold. Enormous. Torn. Kell had hold of the Moth Queen's wings. Both of them. One in each bony fist. Near the roots. Where they came out of her back.

And Maelis was *pulling*.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT DOWN. NOT TOWARD the middle. Not toward the little lights.

Up.

Out of the opening. Toward the light. Toward the fallen hall. Toward the circle. Wings beating so hard the breach shook, so hard the light pouring down through it whirled and scattered, so hard the rising dark round them both rippled like a pond in a gale.

Up.

Toward the rubble. Toward the gate-tower. Toward a bubble of wind on a block of black Gloam-stone, flickering.

Toward a woman on her knees on a folded blanket with her hands on her stomach.

And Kell was holding on.

◆ ◆ ◆

[She felt it,] said Antho. Through the Bloodbond. Very low. *[Lex. When you burned the moths. She felt them go. All of them. Every one she'd sent.]*

[And then she felt something else.]

What?

His brother's voice was very quiet. Very strange.

[Up there,] said Antho. *[On the rubble. In the wind. Something new.]*

[A light coming.]

[Lex, it's coming. Wren's baby. It's coming now. And she can feel it.]

[She turned round.]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAW THE MOTH Queen's face.

Far up. In the light. Over her shoulder. As she pulled upward, with Kell's fists in her wings, with Kell's whole weight hanging from her like a stone.

Lit. Gold. Wide.

Not hungry.

Starving.

The face of a woman who has knelt at the edge of a dry pool for nine hundred years, scraping, and has just seen, at the top of a hill, in the dark, a window light up that's never been lit before.

"*Oh*," said Maelis of the Crowned.

He couldn't hear her. Not from here. He knew what she said anyway.

"*Oh. Oh, now. Now.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND KELL HELD ON.

With both hands. With everything she had. A gaunt white-haired woman of sixty-one with no class and no level and no thread in the net at all, hanging from the wings of a Sovereign in the middle of a door between the world and the bottom of it.

Being dragged up.

Toward the light.

Toward the rubble.

Toward Wren.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX RAN.

Up. Toward the opening. Through the dark. The little one lifting him. Folding round his feet. Carrying him up the way it carried the lamp-lady, the way it carried everyone. Fast. As fast as it could. While still rising. While still half through a door.

[...the Warden...] it said. Very small. As it carried him. *[...the Warden's holding on...]*

I know.

[...she's holding on to HER...]

I know.

[...she said she would...she said someone had to stand in front of me with a stick...]

[...she didn't say she'd hold on to her WINGS...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PASSED ANTHO.

In the door. At the bottom of the opening. Standing. Exactly where he'd been. With the lamp. With his free hand held up, empty. With his face turned up toward the light, toward the shape being dragged out of the breach, toward the gaunt woman hanging from it.

Not moving.

He'd promised. *I'll stay in the door. The whole time. Until you're through. I won't move.*

Lex went past him. Up. Into the light.

And Antho, standing in the door, didn't turn his head. Didn't look at him. Kept his eyes on Kell.

But through the Bloodbond, very quiet, as Lex went past—

[Go.]

[Go. I've got the door.]

[Go get her.]

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LIGHT HIT HIM again. Gold. Thick. Pouring down.

He came up through it like a man coming up out of deep water. Out of the breach. Into the fallen hall. Onto the black floor. Rolling.

His mother was there. On her knees. By the litter. With his father. Her face turned up. Toward the gap in the broken wall. Toward the rubble beyond it.

He followed her eyes.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTH QUEEN WAS on the rubble.

Halfway up. On the black slope of Duskhold's fallen gate. Standing. On the broken blocks. With her wings half-spread. Torn. Ragged. One of them bent wrong, at the root, where a bony fist had been.

And at her feet, on the black stone, a shape.

Small. Thin. Grey. In ruined robes that had been white once. Lying very still. With white hair. With empty hands.

Lex couldn't see her face.

He didn't need to.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ABOVE THE MOTH Queen, at the top of the rubble, at the foot of the gate-tower, a bubble of wind.

Flickering.

Going out.

And in it, a woman on her knees on a folded blanket, with her mother holding her shoulders and an old herbwife holding her hands. Screaming.

Not in fear.

The other kind.

The kind that comes at the very end. When the light's almost here.

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS LOOKED UP AT it.

At the bubble. At the women in it. At the one in the middle.

Her face was lit from inside. All the way through. Like a window. Like a lamp. Like a moth's wings when the candle's behind them.

She took a step. Up. Toward it.

And a voice behind her, from the bottom of the rubble, from the black floor of the fallen hall, said:

"*Maelis*."

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE STOPPED.

She turned her head. Slowly. Over her shoulder. Down.

At a small woman. Barefoot. Grey-brown hair loose. Kneeling on the black floor beside an old man on a litter. With her square strong freckled hand flat on his chest.

Looking up at her.

"*Sister's girl*," said Maelis.

"*Aunt*," said Seren Harrow.

And she stood up.

And picked up the lamp.

Not the clay one. Antho had that. Below. In the door.

The copy. The one from the Ashbourne market. The one she'd left with Kell, in the gold room, at the bottom of the world. That Kell had carried all the way up. Thirty-four days. Through the deep. In the front of her ruined robe. That had fallen out of it, a moment ago, as the Moth Queen dragged her up out of the breach past the edge of the black floor, and rolled, and come to rest against the side of the litter.

Still lit.

Seren held it up.

"*Come here*," she said. "*Come down here. To me. I've got something for you.*"

CHAPTER 35

The Moth and the Flame, Part Two

THE MOTH QUEEN LOOKED at the lamp.

Lex saw her look. From the black floor of the fallen hall, on his hands and knees, soaked in gold light and grey ash, with the breach behind him and the little one pouring up out of it like night coming up out of the ground. He saw her stop on the rubble. Halfway up. With her torn wings half-spread and her face turned down over her shoulder.

At his mother.

Small. Barefoot. Standing beside the litter with a clay lamp held up in her square strong hand. A plain lamp. Brown. From a market stall in Ashbourne. With a little gold flame in it.

"*Come down*," said Seren Harrow. "*Aunt. Come down here. I've got something for you.*"

Maelis didn't move.

Above her, at the top of the rubble, the bubble of wind flickered. Out. In. Out. And in it, Wren screamed. Not in fear. The other kind. And the Moth Queen's head jerked toward it. Up. Like a moth jerks toward a candle.

And then back. Down. To the lamp.

Torn.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*You can't give me anything*," said Maelis.

Her voice was very quiet. It carried anyway. Down the rubble. Across the fallen hall. Low and soft and hoarse.

"*You know that*," she said. "*You've always known. Your mother knew. Your mother's mother. All of you.*" Her lit eyes were on the lamp. "*Anything you give me goes straight through. Your clever boy heard it. With his little hammer. In the deep.*" She turned one long glowing hand over. Looked at it. "*Straight through. Like water through a sieve. Nothing stays.*"

"*I know*," said Seren.

"*Then why—*"

"*Take it anyway.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE RUBBLE WAS VERY quiet.

Lex was on his feet. He didn't remember standing. He was standing on the black floor at the foot of the slope with his hands at his sides and the black heat coming up in him, slow, banked, ready. And Aurelian's little hammer in his coat. Against his ribs. He could feel it there.

[Lex,] said Ember. *[Wait.]*

She's going to go for Wren—

[Wait,] said Ember. *[Look at her face.]*

He looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS LOOKING AT the lamp.

Not the way she'd looked at the lanterns of Highcrest. Not the way she'd looked at the little one in the deep. Not hungry. Not starving.

Puzzled.

The way a child looks at something it's never seen before and doesn't have a word for. The way the little one had sounded, in the gold room, when it said *nobody ever asked me that*.

"*Take it*," said Seren Harrow. "*It's for you. From me.*" She held it higher. "*Not left on for you. Not waiting. I'm not waiting for you to come home. I don't want you to come home.*" Her voice was very steady. "*I'm giving it to you. Here. Now. A light that's yours. Because nobody ever gave you one.*"

Maelis stared at her.

"*Nine hundred years*," said Seren. "*You've been drinking. Taking. Lights left on for other people. Promises. Waiting. You've never once had a light that was* yours." She swallowed. "*Your sister wouldn't. My mother wouldn't. I wouldn't. Nobody ever gave you anything. You only ever took.*"

She held out the lamp. In her square hand. Up the slope of black rubble.

"*So I'm giving you one*," said Seren Harrow. "*Take it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ABOVE THEM, AT the top of the rubble, something moved.

Not in the bubble. Beside it. Out of the dark. Out of the moth-ash drifting on the night air. Big. Heavy. Broad-shouldered. With great grey-gold wings folded tight. With a miner's pick in one hand.

Silas Hask.

He was standing at the edge of Wren's wind. At the foot of the gate-tower. Where the bubble met the rubble. With his pick up. Not swinging. *Looking*. The way a miner looks at a seam. His lit eyes moving over the spinning wall of air. Reading it.

Looking for the fault.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAW IT A moment after he did.

The flicker. Every time Wren screamed. Every time her body took her. The wind went thin. For a breath. In one place. On the side nearest the gate-tower. Where it was hardest for her to hold. Where her back was turned.

Fault, thought Lex. *She's got a fault in her wind. And he's found it.*

Hask lifted the pick.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*SILAS*!"

Lex was running. Up the rubble. He knew he wouldn't make it. It was fifty yards. Uphill. Black broken stone. Past the Moth Queen, who was standing in the middle of it.

He ran anyway.

And somebody got there first.

◆ ◆ ◆

KIT.

Seventeen. Thin. White-faced. From a grey town in a grey valley. Coming up the far side of the rubble. From the east. From the trench. Where he'd been all night, with the Banners, at the rim, burning moths.

Climbing. Fast. Over the broken blocks. With one hand on the stone.

And in the other, held up, held out in front of him like a priest carries a candle into a church—

A lantern.

Iron and glass. *ARDENT* on the pane. *HOME* on the base. Lit.

He came over the last block. Onto the flat at the foot of the gate-tower. Between Silas Hask and the bubble of wind.

And stood there.

◆ ◆ ◆

HASK STOPPED.

The pick was up. Over his head. Ready. A miner's swing. Short and hard and absolutely precise. Aimed at the fault in the wind.

Kit was in front of it.

"*Kit*," said Silas Hask.

The boy didn't move. He stood in front of the bubble with the lantern held up in front of his chest and his thin face set like stone.

"*Move, lad*."

"*No*."

"*Kit. She wants it. The tracker's baby. She's coming for it. She told me to break the wind and hold it open for her.*" Hask's voice was rough. Calm. Reasonable. And under it, something else. Something shaking. "*Move. I don't want to—*"

"*Then don't*," said Kit.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE BOY PUT two fingers in his mouth.

And whistled.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWO NOTES.

High. Sharp. Clear.

A bird call.

The one Wren had used in the Greyspine, five years ago, on the way up the mountain. The one she'd sent from Fennel Street, a hundred miles, to a forge. The one a girl of eight had taught a boy in a dame-school in Coldwater, before the grey came, in case of firedamp, in case you get lost in the dark.

Stop. Danger. Come.

The one she'd whistled at the window. Every night. When her brother came home from the pits. With coal all over him. And he'd stand in the street outside and whistle back. And everyone would laugh.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILAS HASK STOOD VERY still.

With his pick up. Over his head. And his lit eyes on the boy. And his wings folded. And his face—

Lex saw it.

He'd seen it once before. On Fennel Street. For one breath. When Wren whistled and the moths came down and Hask lowered the pick. An inch.

He saw it now.

All the way.

◆ ◆ ◆

KIT CAME FORWARD.

One step. Two. Until he was standing right in front of the big man. Close. Under the pick. With the lantern held up between them.

And he held it out.

Not left on. Not waiting.

Given.

"*Silas Hask*," said Kit. His voice was shaking. He didn't let it stop him. "*Of Coldwater. Hewer. Delvebreaker. Level whatever it is. I don't care.*"

The pick didn't move.

"*Nell whistled at the window*," said Kit. "*Every night. When you came home from the pits. Two notes. And you'd stop in the street. With coal all over you. With your lamp on your helmet. Big as a house.*" His voice cracked.

"*And you'd whistle back. Every night. And the whole street would laugh. Because you were so big and she was so little.*"

Hask's face was doing something.

"*She was my friend*," said Kit. "*She sat next to me in dame-school. She taught me the whistle. She said every pit-kid should know it.*" He was crying. "*She said, in case you get lost in the dark, Kit. In case you can't find your way home.*"

He pushed the lantern forward. Into Hask's chest.

"*She'd be so angry with you*," said Kit. "*She'd be so angry. Look at you. Wings. Lit up. Breaking things.*" His voice broke completely. "*You're lost, Silas. You're lost in the dark. And she's not at the window anymore.*"

He whistled again.

Two notes.

"*So I'm doing it*," said Kit. "*For her. Come home.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE PICK CAME DOWN.

Not on the wind. Not on the boy.

Down. Slowly. To Hask's side. The way a man lowers a pick at the end of a shift. When the coal's all cut. When there's nothing left to do but go home.

He let go of it.

It fell on the black stone with a clang.

And Silas Hask, Level eighty-eight, Mothborn Champion, the first of the Uncapped, the biggest man Lex had ever seen except Brannoc, put out both his enormous scarred hands. Glowing at the knuckles.

And took the lantern.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAW IT HAPPEN. From the middle of the rubble. Thirty yards off. With the Moth Queen between them.

He saw Hask's hands close round the lantern. Round the iron handle. Round *HOME*.

He saw the big man's face.

It broke.

Like ice breaking on a river in spring. Like Maren Ashdown's on the step on Fennel Street. All of it. At once. Every part.

And Lex saw his eyes.

The gold went *out*.

Not dim. Not dimmed. *Out*. Like a lamp being blown out. Like a candle pinched. The lit gold of the Moth Queen's light, the light she'd poured into him from her own hands, in her dark drawing room, on the Spire, all summer—

Gone.

And under it, his own eyes. Brown. Ordinary. Wet.

And from somewhere in the middle of his chest, where the flaw was, where the crack was, where Lex had put his hand on Fennel Street and felt the light leaking out like water through a sieve—

A sound.

Low. Deep. Rattling. Wet.

A cough.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILAS HASK WENT DOWN on his knees.

On the black stone. At the foot of the gate-tower. In front of the boy. With the lantern in both hands against his chest. Coughing. Deep and wet and terrible. The way his father had coughed. And his mother. And his sister.

Grey.

Lex could see it. Coming up. On his lips. On his breath. In the lantern-light.

He gave it back, thought Lex. *Like Father. The moment the warm thing came home, he didn't need her light anymore. And it went.*

And the grey came back.

Hask was coughing so hard he couldn't breathe. Bent over the lantern. Shaking. And Kit was on his knees in front of him, holding his shoulders, holding him up, crying, saying *I'm sorry, I'm sorry, Silas, I didn't know, I didn't know it would—*

And Silas Hask lifted his head.

Grey on his lips. Brown eyes streaming. Breathing like a broken bellows.

And put two fingers in his mouth.

And whistled back.

◆ ◆ ◆

TWO NOTES.

Cracked. Rattling. Barely a whistle at all. The whistle of a man with grey in his lungs and no breath to spare.

Stop. Danger. Come.

The whole street would have laughed.

Kit didn't laugh. Kit put his arms round the big man's neck and held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE MOTH QUEEN *turned*.

Away from the lamp. Away from Seren. Away from the bottom of the rubble.

Up.

Toward the gate-tower. Toward the bubble. Toward the fault in the wind, which was open now, which was flickering, which nobody was standing in front of anymore except a coughing man on his knees and a boy holding him.

Toward the light that was coming.

And she *flew*.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE WAS FAST. SHE'D always been fast. She'd struck Lex across the dark in the deep so fast he never saw her hand move.

She was faster now.

Torn wings and all. She went up the rubble in a single beat, a grey-gold streak, past the coughing man and the boy, toward the bubble, toward the flicker, toward the woman on the blanket screaming the last scream—

And something was in front of her.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX NEVER KNEW HOW Hask did it.

He'd ask him, after. Much after. When Hask could talk without coughing, which wasn't often. And Hask would shrug his enormous shoulders and say *don't know, smith. Twenty-six years down the pits. You learn to move when the roof goes.*

He was on his knees. Coughing. Grey. With a lantern in his arms and a boy round his neck.

And then he was on his feet. In front of the bubble. In the fault. In the gap in the wind.

With his pick.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SWING IT.

He didn't need to. He was a hewer. Twenty-six years. A Delvebreaker. Fault-Finder, Master. He'd found the weak place in every seam and every wall and every man he'd ever looked at.

He'd looked at her all summer.

In her dark drawing room. In his father's chair. At the top of the Spire. With her lit eyes. With her lovely voice. With her cupped hands, full of stolen light, leaking between the fingers.

He knew exactly where her fault was.

He'd known since the first sip.

He held the pick out. Point first. Straight. In front of him. At the height of a woman's heart.

And the Moth Queen flew onto it.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WENT IN.

Not deep. Not far. A hewer's pick isn't a spear. It went in a finger's width. Through the grey-gold silk of her gown. Into the place in the middle of her. Where the flaw was. Where the hollow was. Where she'd been empty since before the pool, since before the Nine, since she was twenty-nine and cold all the way through and didn't know why.

Fault.

And Lex was there.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE'D NEVER RUN SO fast. Not in the deep. Not ever. Up the rubble. Behind her. With the little hammer out. Aurelian's. Small. Plain. Worn smooth.

She was hanging in the air in front of Hask. On the point of his pick. With her wings spread and her mouth open and her lit eyes wide.

And Lex reached past Hask's shoulder.

And tapped the end of the pick.

Once. Lightly. The way you'd tap a bell to hear if it's cracked. The way you'd tap the end of a chisel to start a split in a block of stone, exactly where the grain wants to part.

Tink.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SOUND WENT DOWN the pick.

Into the point. Into the fault. Into the hollow in the middle of her.

And this time, it came back.

Not from her. From the *hollow*. From the empty place. From nine hundred years of nothing. It rang. Like a bell. Like a struck glass. Like a voice in an empty church. The note going round and round inside her, in the hollow, louder and louder, finding every edge of the emptiness, every crack, every place where the light had gone in and through and out—

And she *opened*.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT BROKE. NOT SHATTERED.

Opened. The way a door opens. The way a hand opens. The way a flower opens at dawn.

From the middle. From the point of the pick. The flaw. Widening. Spreading. Through her. Out. And everything in her—

Poured.

◆ ◆ ◆

ALL OF IT.

Every sip. Every drink. Every light. Nine hundred years of them. The pool, in the hall of glass. The lanterns of Highcrest. The warm things. Odile's *thank goodness, I've no idea what I'm doing*. Kell's *I've got you, High*

Warden. Hollis Penn's. The Keepers at Greyfall. The shepherds in the Greyspine. The little one, in the deep, screaming. Every light she'd ever taken, every warm thing, every promise left on in a window for someone who wasn't home.

It came out of her like water out of a broken dam.

Gold. Bright. Pouring. Out of her chest. Out of her hands. Out of her eyes. Down the point of the pick. Down the rubble. In a great glittering river of light. Down the black slope of Duskhold's gate. Across the floor of the fallen hall. Into the breach.

Into the little one.

Home.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND OUT IN THE circle, all round, on the south edge, at the foot of the broken wall of moths, where the Dimmed stood in their rows with their dark lanterns held up—

Lex didn't see it. He'd hear about it. From Elowen. From Roole. From Hollis Penn's wife, who was kneeling in the dust in front of her husband with a lantern in her hands and his name in her mouth and her whole heart in her voice when it happened.

Every dark lantern in the hands of every Dimmed person on the field—

Lit.

All at once. From inside. Like the lanterns in the Hollowmaw when Seren walked past. Not because someone gave them back. Because what had been taken was pouring out of the woman who'd taken it, all at once, down a breach into the earth, and the earth didn't want it, the earth was full, the earth was *home*, and the little one, rising through the door with its whole vast soft heart, took every warm thing that came pouring down into it.

And gave it back.

To whoever it belonged to.

◆ ◆ ◆

HOLLIS PENN BLINKED.

On the south edge of the circle. In the front row. In his apron. With flour on his hands.

And looked down at his wife. Kneeling in front of him. With a lantern. Crying.

"*Mags*," he said. "*What's happened? Why are you—*"

He looked at the loaf-shaped lantern in his hands. Lit. Gold. Warm.

"*Why am I holding the shop lantern*?" said Hollis Penn.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE RUBBLE, THE Moth Queen came down off the pick.

Slowly. Like a leaf. Like a feather. Like the last of the dust coming down after a door's been slammed.

Onto the black stone. Onto her knees.

And Lex saw her.

◆ ◆ ◆

She was *old*.

Not her face. Her face was the same. Long jaw. High cheekbones. Wide soft mouth. A face from a church window.

But everything else.

Her hair, which had been silver, was white. Not white like Arion's. White like ash. Like dust. Like the dust on the floor of a room nobody's lived in for a thousand years. Falling round her on the black stone.

Her skin, which had been grey-gold and glowing, was *grey*. Just grey. Thin. Dry. Like paper. Like the wings of a moth that's beaten itself against a window all night and fallen on the sill at dawn.

Her wings. Spread on the black stone behind her. Torn. Faded. The painted eyes on them gone pale. Dust coming off them. Not glittering. Just dust.

And her eyes.

Dark.

Not lit. Not windows. Not lamps. Brown. Warm brown. The color of honey. Like anyone's.

The way they'd been before the pool.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE KNELT ON THE rubble and looked at her hands.

Grey. Thin. Empty. Shaking.

"*Oh*," said Maelis. In a whisper. A dry whisper, like a page turning. "*Oh. It's all gone.*"

She looked up.

At Lex. Standing over her with the little hammer. At Hask, behind him, on his knees again, coughing, with the lantern and the boy. At the bubble of wind beyond them, flickering, holding.

"*Nine hundred years*," said the Moth Queen. "*And I'm empty. Just like before. Just like the first day.*" She laughed. It was barely a sound. "*Cold. Right in the middle.*"

She looked at her hands.

"*I always was*," she said. "*Always. Even before. I told her. Hes. In the hall. I said I've always been cold. I never knew why.*"

She shut her eyes.

"*I thought if I drank enough*," said Maelis of the Crowned. "*I thought if I could just find the right light. The newest one. The one nobody'd ever given to anyone. I thought that one would stay.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SOMEONE WAS COMING UP the rubble.

Slowly. Barefoot. On the broken black stone. Small. With grey-brown hair loose down her back.

With a lamp.

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN HARROW CLIMBED THE rubble of Duskhold with a market-stall lamp in her square strong hand. Past Lex. Past Hask and the boy. To where the Moth Queen knelt on the black stone, grey, empty, old.

And knelt down in front of her.

And held it out.

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS OPENED HER EYES.

And looked at it. At the little clay lamp. Brown. Plain. With a little gold flame. Held out in front of her face in a small square freckled hand.

"*I can't*," she said. "*It'll go through. You know it will. I'm empty. It'll go straight through.*"

"*Take it anyway*," said Seren.

"*Why*?"

Seren Harrow looked at her aunt. Her aunt many times over. Her mother's mother's mother's mother's mother's sister. Kneeling on a pile of rubble at the end of the world. Grey. Old. Empty.

"*Because I'm giving it to you*," she said. "*That's all. That's the only reason. Not so you'll go away. Not so you'll leave us alone. Not so it'll fill you.*" Her voice was very gentle. "*Just because nobody ever did.*"

She took the Moth Queen's grey hands. In hers. And put them round the lamp. One by one. The way you'd close a child's fingers round a coin.

"*It's yours*," said Seren. "*From me. Not left on. Given.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS HELD IT.

In her cupped grey hands. A little clay lamp. Lit.

And Lex watched the light go into her.

He watched it. He'd remember it for the rest of his life. He watched the little gold flame light her hands from underneath. Her fingers. Her palms. Glowing through them, through the thin grey skin, the way a candle glows through a paper lantern.

And then go in.

Up her wrists. Her arms. Into her chest. Into the middle. Into the hollow. Into the place where everything had always gone straight through.

He waited for it to go out the other side.

It didn't.

◆ ◆ ◆

It *stayed*.

Small. Gold. Warm. In the middle of her. Where the hollow was. Where she'd been cold since she was twenty-nine. Where nine hundred years of stolen light had poured in and through and out like water through a sieve.

It stayed.

Not because the hollow had closed. Not because she'd been mended. Lex could hear the flaw still, with the Flaw-Sense, with the little hammer in his hand. Wide open. Empty.

It stayed because it was *given*.

Because it wasn't a promise. Wasn't waiting. Wasn't someone else's. Wasn't stolen. Wasn't drunk. It had been put in her hands by someone who wanted nothing back.

It was *hers*.

And a thing that's yours doesn't leak.

◆ ◆ ◆

MAELIS LOOKED DOWN AT herself.

At the little gold glow in the middle of her chest. Small. Warm. Steady. Like a lamp in a window. Like a coal in a hearth.

Her face—

Lex had seen a lot of faces. He'd seen his mother's, in the cavern, when his father said *good evening*. He'd seen Maren Ashdown's, on the step on Fennel Street. He'd seen Silas Hask's, a moment ago, breaking.

He'd never seen a face like this.

It was the face of someone who has been cold their whole life, and has just, for the very first time, felt warm. And doesn't know what it is. And is frightened of it. And wants it more than anything. And knows, all at once, that this is what they were looking for. For nine hundred years. At the edge of the pool. At every window. In every light they ever took.

Not a light to drink.

A light someone *gave*.

"*Oh*," said Maelis. Very softly. Wonderingly. "*Oh. Is this what it—*"

She stopped.

She looked up at Seren. With her brown eyes. Honey-brown. Like anyone's. Wet.

"*Is this what she felt*?" said Maelis. "*Hes. When she poured it back. Into the pool. With her empty hands. Was it like this?*"

Seren looked at her for a long time.

"*I think so*," she said. "*I think it was exactly like this.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTH QUEEN SMILED.

Not lovely. Not sad. Not fond. Not patient. Not hungry.

Just a smile. Small. Tired. Surprised. The smile of a woman of twenty-nine, sitting on the edge of a dry fountain in a garden of glass, with her little sister's head on her shoulder.

"*Hes always was the strange one*," said Maelis.

And came apart.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT INTO DUST. NOT the way the Mothwing did. Not grey-gold and glittering, gathering again.

Into *light*.

Gold. Soft. Warm. Like the light of a clay lamp. Like the light in a window at the end of a long lane on a winter night. She came apart into it, gently, from the middle out, from the little warm glow in her chest, the way a dandelion comes apart when you blow on it. All of her. Her white hair. Her grey hands. Her torn wings, the painted eyes going last, one by one, like lamps being put out in a house where everyone's gone to bed.

And the light didn't go anywhere.

It hung there. Over the rubble. For a long moment. A shape. A woman's shape. Kneeling. With her hands cupped.

And then it went down. Slowly. Like the last of the dust. Like snow. Into the black stone. Into the rubble. Into the breach.

Into the little one.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LAMP WAS ON the stone.

Where her hands had been. The little clay lamp from the Ashbourne market. Upright. On the black rubble.

Still lit.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOBODY SAID ANYTHING.

Lex stood with the little hammer in his hand. His mother knelt on the black stone in front of the lamp. Hask was on his knees behind them, coughing, grey, with Kit's arms round his neck and the *HOME* lantern in his lap.

And at the top of the rubble, the bubble of wind—

Went out.

All at once. Like a candle pinched.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX TURNED.

He was running before he finished turning. Up. The last of the rubble. To the gate-tower. To the block of Gloam-stone. To the folded blanket.

Old Mag was kneeling on it. With something in her arms. Wrapped in her shawl.

Maren Ashdown was on her knees beside her. With her hands over her mouth.

And Wren—

Wren was lying back against the gate-tower. With her red hair everywhere and her face grey and wet and her eyes shut. Breathing. Hard. Fast. Alive.

Her eyes opened.

She saw him.

"*Hammer*," said Wren Ashdown. In a voice like a rope that's been pulled too long. "*You missed it.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T HEAR THE rest.

He was on his knees. On the blanket. Beside her. With his hands on her face. He didn't remember kneeling. He heard Old Mag saying something. He heard Maren crying. He heard Wren saying *I told you, I told you, I said if you weren't here I'd never forgive you*, and laughing, and crying.

And he heard something else.

From Old Mag's shawl.

A sound. Small. High. Thin. Furious.

Like a kettle.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Here*," said Old Mag.

And put it in his arms.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS VERY SMALL.

That was the first thing. He'd held iron bars that weighed more. He'd held hammers. He'd held his father, on the stairs of the Hollowmaw, weighing nothing.

This weighed less than nothing.

And more than everything.

Wrapped in Old Mag's grey shawl. Red. Creased. Wet. Furious. With its fists up by its face and its mouth open, screaming at the whole world for being so cold and so bright and so loud.

With a shock of dark hair. Curly. That nobody was ever going to be able to cut.

◆ ◆ ◆

[Lex,] said Ember. In his hearth. In a voice he'd never heard it use. Not dry. Not precise. Not rude.

Small.

[Lex. Oh, Lex. Look at her.]

Her.

He looked at Wren.

Wren was looking at him. From against the gate-tower. Grey. Wet. Laughing. Crying.

"*A girl*," said Wren. "*Hammer. It's a girl.*" She held out her hand. Shaking. Toward the bundle. Toward him. "*And she's got big hands. Look at her hands.*"

He looked.

Small. Red. Furious. Clenched by her face.

Square.

Too big for the rest of her.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE SAT DOWN ON the blanket. Beside his wife. With his daughter in his arms. And couldn't stop shaking.

And the baby stopped screaming.

All at once. Like a bell stopping. She opened her eyes. Dark. Unfocused. Newborn. And looked up. At nothing. At the sky. At the dark over Duskhold, where the stars should have been.

And weren't.

Because the little one was there.

Rising. Out of the breach. Up. Over the ruins. Over the circle. Filling it. Soft and dark and starred and enormous. Spreading out across the hundred miles of its own name like night spreading across the sky.

And at the very edge of it, where it touched the rubble, where it touched the gate-tower, where it touched the blanket—

It *leaned*.

Toward the baby. Gently. The way the clay lamp leaned toward the black door. The way a child leans toward another child, to look.

[...oh...]

Lex heard it. Everyone on the rubble heard it. Even Old Mag.

[...oh...a new one...]

[...a NEW one...]

[...she came through...]

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THE BABY, THREE minutes old, looked up at the soft dark leaning over her. With her dark unfocused newborn eyes.

And stopped crying.

And stared.

And the little one stared back.

And for one moment, on the rubble of Duskhold, on the last night of autumn, with three hundred and fourteen miles of given lanterns burning round the rim of a word written in the ground—

The two newest things in the world looked at each other.

◆ ◆ ◆

FROM THE BOTTOM OF the rubble, Lex heard his mother start to sing.

Flat.

On the high note.

And far below, at the very bottom of the breach, still standing in the door with their mother's mother's lamp in his hand, waiting for the last of the little one to go up past him—

He heard his brother start to laugh.

CHAPTER 36

The Seventh Well

THE LAST OF IT went up at dawn.

Lex felt it go. Sitting on the folded blanket at the foot of the gate-tower with his daughter asleep on his chest, inside his shirt, against his skin, where Old Mag had put her. *Warm*, Old Mag had said. *That's what they want. Warm and a heartbeat. You've got plenty of both.*

He felt it through the stone. Through the rubble. Through the Stone in him, the Well he Commanded, which had been listening to the ground all night.

The breach emptied.

The last soft fold of the little one, the very back of it, the part that had been at the bottom of the deep pressed against the underside of the world for six days and thirty-four days and a year and a half and nine hundred years—went up. Past his brother. Through the door. Out. Into the circle.

And under it, at the bottom, standing in the door with a clay lamp, alone—

[...brother...]

[...brother, that's the last of me...]

[...you can come up now...]

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HEARD HIS BROTHER come up.

Not with his ears. Through the Bloodbond. Felt him climb. Out of the deep. Up the walls of the breach. Slowly. With the lamp held up. The way you'd come up out of a cellar in the morning after a long night.

And felt him stop. At the top. At the edge of the opening. On the black floor of the fallen hall.

And look round.

[Lex,] said Antho. Through the Bloodbond. Very quietly. *[Lex. Come and see.]*

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WENT DOWN THE rubble.

Slowly. With Lark on his chest. With Wren asleep against the gate-tower, finally, with her mother beside her and Old Mag beside her mother, both of them asleep too, sitting up, heads together. With the sun coming up.

He went down through the gap where Duskhold's gate had been.

And stopped.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE HALL WAS GONE.

Not fallen. *Gone*. The broken walls. The black floor. The rubble. Morvane's citadel, grown out of Gloam-stone over fifteen years like a tumor out of the grey, falling to pieces for five.

Gone.

In its place, grass.

Short. Soft. Green. The green of a field in the first week of spring. Covering the ground where the hall had been, and the floor, and the breach. Going away down a long gentle slope. Wet with dew. With small white flowers in it. Daisies. Snowdrops. Things Lex didn't know the names of.

At the bottom of the slope, where the breach had been, where his father had knelt twenty-one years ago and torn the world, where three of the blood had knelt five years ago and mended it, where his brother had stood six days in a door—

A pool.

◆ ◆ ◆

SMALL. ROUND. NO BIGGER than a cartwheel. Ten feet across. With an edge of plain grey stone, worn smooth, much older than anything round it.

And inside the ring, dark.

Not water. Not empty. *Dark*. Still. Deep. So deep that looking into it was like looking up at the night sky. Not empty. *Full*. Full the way a held breath is full. Full the way the moment before a word is full.

Antho was kneeling beside it.

On the grass. In the dawn. With the clay lamp beside him on the grey stone rim. Lit. Looking down into the pool.

He didn't look up as Lex came.

"*It's the same*," said Antho. Very quietly. "*Lex. It's the same pool. From the hall of glass. From before the Nine.*" His voice was shaking. "*It showed me. In the gold room. That's what it looked like. Before they drank.*"

Lex knelt down beside him.

And looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT WAS THE MOST beautiful thing he'd ever seen.

He'd thought the little one rising was. He'd stood on the rubble six days ago and told his brother *it's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen*, and meant it.

This was more.

Small. Still. Dark. Full. In a ring of old grey stone in a field of new grass on the last morning of autumn.

And at the bottom of it, very far down, so far he could barely see them—

Two little lights.

Curled together. Side by side. Silver-gold. Like very old candles.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Is that all of it*?" said Lex.

He didn't understand. The little one was the size of a country. He'd felt it. Rising through the breach all night. Spreading out across the circle. A hundred miles of soft dark sky coming up out of the ground.

"*No*," said Antho. "*Look.*"

He lifted his head. And looked out. Past the pool. Past the field. Past the last of the black rubble, at the top of the slope, where the gate-tower still stood with Wren asleep at its foot.

Lex looked.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE BLIGHTMARCH WAS GONE.

He'd stood on the rubble fifty-two days ago and seen it. A hundred miles of grey. Dust. Ash. Stumps. Roofless towns. Hills with nothing on them. Valleys with nothing in them. Rivers that had stopped.

He looked now.

Green.

Not all of it. Not yet. Not like the Vale in summer. Like the Vale in the first week of spring. A faint green. A mist of it. Over the hills. In the hollows. Along the old dry riverbeds, which weren't dry. Which had *water* in them. He could hear it. A chuckle over a shallow. A gurgle round a stone.

The stumps of the burned woods had shoots on them. Green. Thin. Reaching.

And over everything, hanging in the morning air, soft, faint, enormous, stretching from one edge of the circle to the other, a hundred miles across—

A haze.

Not mist. Not cloud. *Dark*. Very faint. A soft dusk in the dawn. Like the shadow of something very large that's lying down. Like the dark between the stars, in the daytime, if you knew where to look.

It was *settling*.

He could see it. Very slowly. Coming down. Over the hills. Into the valleys. Into the ground. Into the trench round the rim, three hundred and fourteen miles of baked grey earth that had been dug and washed and knocked on like a door.

Into its name.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It's lying down*," said Antho. "*In the circle. In the word. All of it.*" He looked at the pool. "*And the middle's here. The heart. Where Mal is.*

Where the breach was." He swallowed. "*It's making itself small. The way it did for Mam, in the deep. Folding up. So it fits."*

"*Will it stay small*?"

His brother looked at him.

"*It's not small*," said Antho. "*It's everywhere in the circle. In the grass. In the water. In the ground.*" He put his hand flat on the new green grass beside the pool. "*Here. Feel."*

Lex put his hand down.

And felt it.

Under the grass. Under the soil. Under everything. Soft. Warm. Vast. *Resting*. The way a person rests at the end of a very long walk, when they've finally got home, and sat down by the fire, and taken off their boots.

And everywhere it rested, things were coming up.

Grass. Shoots. Springs. Room. Making room. For everything new.

[...smith...]

Very soft. Very sleepy. From everywhere. From the grass.

[...is this the room...]

Yes, thought Lex.

[...it's so big...it's bigger than I thought...]

[...it's MINE...]

It's yours, thought Lex Vey. *All of it. We made it for you.*

◆ ◆ ◆

THE WORLD NOTICE CAME at sunrise.

Lex felt it before it came. Everyone did. Everyone in the world. The pressure. Behind the eyes. The net reaching out, through every thread, to every person, all at once.

Not silver. Not gold. Not violet. Not grey-gold.

Clear.

The color of a window. The color of the air in an empty room. The color he'd seen once, on a panel over Seraphine's head in a kitchen at the Lantern Keep.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
▓▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓▓
THE SEVENTH WELL HAS COME HOME.
```

```
▓▓▓ WORLD NOTICE ▓▓▓
The net has learned a new word.
ATTUNEMENT
  Flame · Stone · Tide · Gale ·
  Radiance · Shade ·
  HOLLOW
"The room in the middle. Where new
 things come in."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

HE READ IT.

He read it twice.

And beside him, on the grass, his brother made a sound. Small. Low. Like a breath let out after a very long time held.

"*They wrote it down*," said Antho. "*The net. It's in the net now. Seven.*" He was laughing. Crying. "*Lex. Seven circles. Six round and one in the middle. It's not empty anymore.*"

Lex looked at his own panel.

He didn't mean to. It came up on its own. The way they did, sometimes, now, since the reforging. When the net noticed something and wanted you to see.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
LEX VEY
Class: WORLDFORGER (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 96 → 97
ATTUNEMENT
  Flame ........ COMMANDING
  Stone ........ COMMANDING
  Tide ......... ANSWERING
  Gale ......... ANSWERING
  Hollow ....... ANSWERING
  Shade ........ LISTENING
  Radiance ..... LISTENING
Title: [Maker of Room] (new)
Title: [Father] (new)
  +0 to everything. +everything to
  one thing.
```

◆ ◆ ◆

[I didn't write that one,] said Ember. Quickly. *[The second one. I want that on record.]*

You absolutely wrote that one.

[I made a suggestion,] said Ember. *[The net took it. The net's very sentimental this morning. I think it's the baby.]*

Lex laughed.

Lark stirred against his chest. Inside his shirt. And made a small cross sound. And went back to sleep.

◆ ◆ ◆

SERAPHINE CAME DOWN THE slope at a run.

Awkwardly. With her notebook in one hand and her spectacles in the other. Barefoot. In the grass. With her face lit up like a lamp.

"*It's got a name*," she said. "*The Attunement. In my panel. It says Hollow. It says Hollow, Speaking.*" She stopped in front of them. Gasping. "*It's not unrecognized anymore. It's in the net. It's* real."

Antho stood up.

And picked her up. Off the grass. Notebook and all. And swung her round. Once. In the dawn. Beside the pool. The way Lex had swung her at the anvil on the night she ran across the plain with a word.

"*Put me down*!" She was shrieking. Laughing. "*Antho! You'll drop the notebook in the Well!*"

He put her down.

And kissed her.

In front of everyone. In front of the pool and the grass and the dawn and a Worldforger with a baby in his shirt.

"*Five hundred and four*," said Seraphine Ilvane. Against his mouth. "*Reasons. That one. Right now. Number five hundred and four.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN IVY MOSS.

She came down the slope on her crutch. Slowly. Very slowly. With her pale hair everywhere. She'd been at the rim all night. At the trench. With the families. Telling the dust what was coming.

She stopped at the edge of the pool.

And looked down into it.

And a panel came up over her head. Clear. Like a window.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
IVY MOSS
Class: ▓▓▓▓▓▓▓ (unrecognized)
  → HOLLOWKEEPER (Unique)
Level 1 → 19
"Kindled beside an open way. The net
 did not know what she was. It knows
 now. She was the first to hear the
 room. She was always going to keep
 it."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE READ IT.

And then she looked up. At Lex. At Antho. At Seraphine. With her small pale face very still.

"*Keeper*," she said. In a whisper. "*It says keeper.*"

"*It does*," said Antho.

"*Of it*?" She looked down at the pool. "*Of the room?*"

"*Somebody has to*," said Antho Vey. Gently. "*Somebody has to sit with it. And tell it things. And listen. And let people come and look, and make sure*

nobody ever kneels down and drinks." He looked at her. *"Somebody who's always been on the edge of things. Watching."*

Ivy Moss looked at the pool for a long time.

"I've never done anything," she said. *"I told Master Lex. On the green. I've never done anything. I've just watched."*

"I know," said Antho. *"That's why."*

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FOUND KELL ON the rubble.

Lex had known. He'd seen her, in the night. Lying on the black stone halfway up the slope. Very still. Small. Grey. With empty hands. He'd seen her and run past, because Wren was screaming, because the Moth Queen was on the pick.

He'd known.

His mother found her first. In the dawn. When she came down from the gate-tower, where she'd been sitting with Wren and the baby. She came down the rubble barefoot, and stopped, and knelt.

And didn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT TO HER. With Lark. And Antho. And Seraphine.

Isaura Kell was lying on her back on the black stone. On the last of the rubble, where the grass hadn't reached yet. With her white hair. With her ruined robes. With her bony hands at her sides, open, palm up.

Her eyes were shut.

Her face—

It was the first time Lex had ever seen her face *still*. Not set. Not hard. Not holding anything. Just still. The way a face is when there's nothing left to hold. When the door's shut and the work's done and everyone's home.

Beside her, on the stone, a stick.

Long. Plain. Dark. Like a shepherd's crook without the crook.

◆ ◆ ◆

"She held on," said his mother. Very quietly. Kneeling. With her hand on Kell's hand. *"All the way up. Out of the breach. Up the rubble. She held on to the wings."* Her voice cracked. *"Till she fell."*

Nobody said anything.

"*She said she would*," said Antho. "*In the deep. She said, someone has to stand in front of it. With a stick. When it can't run.*" He knelt. On Kell's other side. "*She didn't say she'd hold on to the wings.*"

"*The little one said that*," said Lex.

His brother looked at him.

"*In the night*," said Lex. "*When it carried me up. It said, she said someone had to stand in front of me with a stick. She didn't say she'd hold on to her wings.*"

Antho looked down at Kell's face.

At her still face. At her white hair.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND FROM THE GRASS, from the ground, from everywhere, soft, faint, very young—

[...the Warden...]

They all heard it. Even Lex. Even his mother.

[...the Warden's asleep...]

Antho didn't answer for a long time.

"*Yes*," he said at last. Very gently. "*The Warden's asleep.*"

[...she told me the one about the miller's cat...four hundred and eleven times...]

[...she held on...]

[...she held on to HER...so she couldn't get me...]

[...brother...]

"*Yes*."

[...will she wake up...]

Antho put his hand on Kell's still face.

"*No*," he said. "*No. She won't.*"

The ground was quiet.

[...like Mal...]

"*Like Mal*."

[...]

[...can she come in the middle...with Mal...where it's warm...]

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX LOOKED AT HIS brother.

His brother looked at him.

And his mother, kneeling on the black stone with her hand on Kell's, looked up at both of them. And then down. At the dead woman. At the stick beside her. At the grass, coming up through the rubble, an inch from Kell's open palm.

"*She'd like that*," said Seren Harrow. "*I think. She said once. In the deep. That nobody had asked her to sit down in fifty years. Not until Mal.*"

She took her hand off Kell's.

"*Ask her*," she said to the ground. "*Little one. Ask her if she'd like to sit down.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GRASS CAME UP.

Not fast. Not like the springs and the shoots. Slowly. Gently. Through the black rubble. Round Kell's hands. Round her feet. Round her shoulders. Green. Soft. With small white flowers in it.

And the ground under her—

Made room.

Lex felt it. Through the Stone. Through the rubble. A space. A hollow. Opening under Isaura Kell, very gently, the way a bed gives when you lie down on it at the end of a long day. Soft. Warm. Deep.

And she went down into it.

Slowly. With her hands at her sides and her eyes shut and her face still. The grass closing over her. Like a blanket drawn up. Like the earth folding round her the way the little one had folded round his mother in the deep, to hide her from the moths.

And then there was only grass.

And a stick, lying on it. Long. Plain. Dark.

And a scattering of small white flowers, in the shape of a woman lying down.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...she's in the middle now...] said the little one. Very softly. *[...with Mal...and his brother...]*

[...three little lights...]

[...she's sitting down...]

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO PICKED UP THE stick.

He held it for a long time. In both hands. Crosswise. Like a bar across a door.

Then he walked down the slope. Through the new grass. To the pool. And laid it on the grey stone rim. Very carefully. Beside the clay lamp.

"*For whoever keeps the room*," he said. Not to anyone. "*So they know someone stood in front of it once.*"

And Ivy Moss, standing at the edge of the pool on her crutch, looked down at the stick.

And didn't say anything.

But she didn't take her eyes off it either.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEIR FATHER WOKE AT noon.

In the tent. On the cot. Under three blankets. Where they'd carried him in the night, after the breach, after his hand went slack and slid out of Antho's and fell on the black floor.

Lex was there. With Lark. Wren was there, on the other cot, propped up, grey and exhausted and refusing to sleep any more because she wanted to look at the baby. His mother was there. On the stool. Where she'd been all night. With her hand on his father's chest.

Seraphine was there. With her eyes shut. Listening.

"*It's making room*," she said. Very quietly. Before he woke. With her hand out. Palm up. Over the old man on the cot. "*In him. Lex. Antho. It's making room.*"

"*It can't heal*," said Antho. "*You said. It doesn't heal.*"

"*It doesn't*," said Seraphine. "*It can't. That's not what it does.*" She opened her eyes. They were wet. "*But it's making room. In his time. In the years. The flood. The two hundred years coming all at once.*" She looked at Arion. "*It's making room for them. So they don't have to come all at once. So they can come—*"

She stopped.

"*Slowly*," said Seren.

"*Slowly*." Seraphine nodded. "*Like an ordinary man. A year a year. Like everyone else.*" Her voice cracked. "*It's not giving him time back. It can't. He's old. He's the oldest man I've ever seen. He'll stay old.*"

"*But*," said Lex.

"*But he'll stay*," said Seraphine Ilvane. "*For a while. Not a season. Longer.*" She shook her head. "*I don't know how long. A year. Two. Ordinary years. It's made room for them.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND HIS FATHER OPENED his eyes.

Grey. Clear. Steady. In a face like a walnut left in a drawer for a hundred years.

He looked at the tent roof.

Then at his wife. On the stool. With her hand on his chest.

"*Seren*," he said.

His voice was a thread. A whisper. A breath with a word in it. But it was *his*.

"*I'm here*," said Seren.

"*I let go*."

"*I know*."

"*I couldn't hold any more*." His eyes were wet. "*I held the edges. I held his hand. And then I couldn't.*"

"*I know*," said his wife. "*It's all right. He held the rest. Your son. He held the door all night. It's through. All of it. It's home.*"

Arion closed his eyes.

"*It's home*," he whispered.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Father*," said Lex.

His father opened his eyes again. And turned his head on the pillow. Very slowly.

And saw what Lex was holding.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HAD NEVER SEEN his father's face do that.

Not when he said *you look old*, on the slope of the Hollowmaw, and his father smiled the wide startled smile. Not when Seren knelt in front of his chair in the cavern and said *you have a nice voice*. Not when Ember said *hello, old man*.

It did something Lex didn't have a word for.

All the furrows. All the bones. All the hundred years in a drawer. All of it, at once, going soft. Going open. Going *young*. Not young like the Moth Queen's light. Young like a boy who's just been handed something he never thought he'd be allowed to hold.

"*Oh*," said Arion Vey.

"*She's called Lark*," said Wren. From the other cot. Hoarse. "*Lark Vey. Born on Lantern Night. At the top of the rubble. While you were asleep.*"

His father didn't say anything.

He lifted his hand. Off the blanket. Thin. Bone. Brown-spotted. Shaking.

And Lex leaned down. And held his daughter close. Close enough.

And his father touched her.

One finger. On her cheek. Very lightly. The way you'd touch a soap bubble. The way you'd touch a flame to see if it's real.

Lark opened her eyes.

Dark. Unfocused. Newborn. And looked up. At an old man. Older than anyone.

And reached out. With one small square hand. Too big for the rest of her. And closed it round his finger.

And held on.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She's got big hands*," whispered Arion Vey.

"*She's going to be trouble*," said Seren. Very softly. Beside him. "*Just like her grandfather.*"

His father looked at her.

And for a moment, just a moment, Lex saw something go across his face. A flicker. A stone turning over in a field.

"*You said that*," said Arion. "*Didn't you. When Lex was born. You said, he's going to be trouble. Just like his father.*"

"*Page twelve*," said Seren Vey.

"*You remembered*."

"*No*," said his mother. "*I read it.*" She put her hand on his. On Lark's. On the three of them. "*I'm making new ones. Remember?*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE NAMING HAPPENED AT dusk.

At the pool. In the middle of the circle. With everyone.

Everyone who was left. Which was nearly everyone. Lex had been afraid. All night. All day. Afraid of the counting that would have to come, after. The names for the grey book.

There weren't many.

Eleven Ashari, at the east rim, where the moths came thickest, who'd held black heat round their lanterns until there was nothing left in them. Six Keepers. Four Banners. A shepherd from the Greyspine who'd walked into the moths after his Dimmed son and relit him and been dimmed himself, and his son had relit him back.

Fenn.

Keeper-Lieutenant Fenn. Narrow. Sandy. Quiet. Who'd straightened every leaning Stone in the west with his own hands. Who'd stood at the south edge all night with the families, between them and the Mothwing who came with knives, holding a Keeper's staff crosswise. Like a bar across a door.

Roole carried him in. And laid him on the grass by the pool. And stood there with his hatchet face set like stone and his arm still in its sling and didn't say anything at all.

Twenty-three.

Lex would write them all. In the grey book. After the Vhessans. Before Kell. Every one.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY CAME DOWN THE slope at dusk. From the rubble and the tents and the rim. Thousands. Into the field of new grass. Round the pool. In a great ring. Quiet. The way people are quiet in a chapel. In a churchyard. At a window, on a winter night, waiting.

The lanterns were still burning.

All of them. Round the rim. Three hundred and fourteen miles. Given. And the little one hadn't taken them. It hadn't needed to. They'd been given to it, and it was home, and they were *its* now, and it had left them exactly where they were.

Lit.

A ring of small gold lights at the edge of a hundred miles of soft new green.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*It needs a name*," said Antho.

He was standing at the pool. With the clay lamp. With Seraphine beside him and the stick on the rim and Ivy Moss on her crutch at the edge of the grey stone.

"*It's been asking*," he said. To everyone. To the ring of thousands round the field. "*For months. Every night. What am I? What's my name?*" He looked at the pool. "*The net calls it Hollow. That's what it is. Like calling my brother smith. It wants its own.*"

The field was very quiet.

"*Someone who made room for it*," said Lex. From the other side of the pool. With Lark asleep in his shirt. "*That's what we said. In the dark. Someone who made room should name it.*"

"*Everyone made room*," said Seraphine. "*Three hundred and fourteen miles of people. With spades.*"

"*Someone first*," said Antho.

And everyone looked at Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE WAS STANDING AT the very front of the ring. Small. In his blue coat with the brass buttons buttoned wrong. With his hands in his pockets and his mop of black hair and his grey-violet eyes.

He'd been there all day. At the pool. Sitting on the grey stone rim with his legs dangling over the dark. Not saying anything. Looking down.

He went red.

All the way up. Into his hair.

He didn't hide. He didn't run to tell Ashka. He stood at the front of the ring with thousands of people looking at him and his face like fire.

And then he walked forward. To the pool. And knelt down. On the grey stone rim.

And cupped his hands.

Round nothing. Over the dark. An inch above it. The way he'd cupped them round the hole in the cold-room floor. Round the Fenmoor lantern. Round Odile's dusty hand in the snow.

Making a space.

And was silent.

◆ ◆ ◆

The pool *leaned*.

Toward him. All of it. The dark in the stone ring. Rising. Very slightly. Toward his hands. The way the clay lamp leaned toward the black door. The way the little one had leaned toward Lark on the rubble.

[...the quiet one...]

[...the one with the room inside...]

Everyone heard it. Every person in the field. Soft. Young. From the grass. From the ground. From everywhere.

[...he made the cups...]

[...he made me feel the size I'm supposed to be...]

[...the size of a person...]

Pim didn't move.

[...quiet one...]

[...what's my name...]

◆ ◆ ◆

PIM LOOKED DOWN INTO the pool.

At the dark. At the full. At the moment before a word.

At the bottom of it, very far down, three little lights. Curled together. One small, with the shape of a straw hat. One tall, with something in its hands. And one thin and very straight, newer than the others, with white hair.

Sitting down.

He looked at them for a long time.

And then he said it. Not loudly. Pim never said anything loudly. Very quietly. Into his cupped hands. Into the space he'd made. The way you'd whisper a secret to someone very small.

"*Mal*," said Pim.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIELD WAS SILENT.

"*It always asked for him*," said Pim. To his hands. To the pool. "*First thing. Before brother. Before lamp-lady. It said Mal. Mal? Mal? Like a child calling in the dark.*" He swallowed. "*Because that's the name it heard most. From someone who loved it. Who sat with it. Who sang in tune.*"

He looked down at the three little lights.

"*It doesn't know names are for one person*," said Pim. "*It just knows that's the name that meant somebody stayed.*"

He took his hands away.

"*So that's its name*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ON THE CORD round Lex's neck, against his chest, under his shirt, beside his sleeping daughter—

The little silver bell with the crooked clapper—

Rang.

Once.

In tune.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
▓▓▓ THE SEVENTH WELL ▓▓▓
HOLLOW
Named: MAL
"By a boy who made room. After an old
 man who stayed."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

THE POOL DIDN'T DO anything.

It didn't flare. It didn't rise. It didn't sing.

It just lay there, in its ring of old grey stone, in the middle of a hundred miles of new green, under the first stars of winter. Small. Still. Dark. Full.

Like a pool that someone, at last, after nine hundred years, had stopped at.

And knelt beside.

And not drunk from.

And *named*.

◆ ◆ ◆

[...Mal...] it said. Very softly. Wonderingly. To itself. To everyone. To the grass and the water and the stars.

[...I'm Mal...]

[...that's me...that's what I am...]

[...I'm the one somebody stayed for...]

And Lex, standing at the edge of the pool with his daughter on his chest and his brother across the water and his mother behind him with her hand on an old man's shoulder in a chair someone had carried down the slope—

Laughed.

And couldn't stop.

And neither could anyone else.

CHAPTER 37

What the Light Costs

THEY BURIED FENN AT the rim.

At the place where the trench came round from the east and met the ruins. Where the first lantern had been set down, on the morning of Lantern Night, by an old hewer from Coldwater who'd said *for the little one, from Absalom Ware, that was my wife's*.

The lantern was still there. Still lit. They dug the grave beside it.

Roole did most of the digging. One-armed. With his other arm still in its sling. He wouldn't let anyone help. He dug for three hours in the cold winter sun with his hatchet face set like stone, and when it was deep enough he climbed out and stood at the edge of it and looked down for a long time.

Then he went and got Fenn's staff. The Keeper's staff. Plain ash. That Fenn had held crosswise at the south edge all night, between the families and the Mothwing with knives.

He laid it in the grave first. And then they laid Fenn on top of it.

"*He straightened every leaning Stone in the west*," said Roole. Standing at the head of the grave. In his Keepers' grey. To the hundreds of Keepers standing round it in rows. "*With his own hands. Every one. The summer after the Heart.*" His voice didn't change. "*He said someone should. He said it was the least we could do. After all the years we spent pushing children down.*"

He looked at the grave.

"*He didn't talk much*," said Commander Roole. "*When he did, he said exactly what he meant.*"

He was quiet for a long moment.

"*So will I*," he said. "*He was my friend. I'll miss him every day.*"

And then he picked up the spade again. And filled it in.

◆ ◆ ◆

THERE WERE TWENTY-THREE GRAVES along the rim, in the end.

The eleven Ashari weren't buried. Grandmother Asha wouldn't have it. *We're fire-women*, she said. *We go back to the fire.* And the two hundred old women in red who were left sat in a ring round the eleven who weren't, at the east rim, where the moths had come thickest. And put their hands flat on the dust. And the dust went dark and hot and rippling.

And then bright.

And then there were eleven small heaps of white ash on the grey ground, and a smell like a forge at dawn, and two hundred old women singing in a language Lex didn't know.

Grandmother Asha didn't sing. She sat at the edge of the ring with her black eyes very bright and her toothless mouth pressed shut.

Lex sat beside her.

"*Two hundred and eleven years*," she said, after a long time. "*I waited for someone to ask us for fire.*" She looked at the heaps of ash. "*My sister was one of those. Ruhaya. She was older than me. She said she'd been waiting two hundred and forty.*"

"*I'm sorry*."

"*Don't be*." Grandmother Asha looked at him. With her crow's eyes. "*She'd have waited forever. She'd have died in the deep desert of nothing, of old age, waiting.*" She turned back to the ash. "*She died making a room for something coming home. That's a fire-woman's death. That's the best kind.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE LITTLE ONE SENT flowers.

That was what people said. Afterward. In the taverns, in the Vale, in the Saltreach, in the market in Highcrest. *The little one sent flowers to the graves.*

It wasn't quite true. Lex knew. He'd felt it. Through the Stone. Through the ground. It hadn't *sent* anything. It didn't do that. It didn't make things. It made *room*.

But every grave along the rim, every one of the twenty-three, had flowers on it by the next morning. Small white ones. Snowdrops. In winter. Pushing up through the turned earth.

Because there was room for them now.

◆ ◆ ◆

KELL HAD NO GRAVE.

She had a stone.

Brannoc made it. Out of a block of the black Gloam-stone from the rubble of Duskhold, the last of it, before the grass covered it all. He cut it square. And smooth. And set it at the edge of the pool. Beside the stick.

And on it, in his big careful hand, the way he'd cut the first rune he ever struck, six years ago, the night before Thornhollow:

ISAURA KELL She held on

Lex had asked him why just that. Why not *High Warden*. Why not *Warden by gift*. Why not something about Dorran, or the deep, or the stick.

Brannoc had looked at him for a long time.

"*Because that's what she'd want*," he said. "*Lad. She was a Warden. Wardens don't want speeches.*" He brushed the black dust off the stone with his enormous hand. "*She'd want people to walk past and read it and know exactly what she did. That's all.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN THE GREY book, after the Vhessans, after the twenty-three from the rim, on a new page—

Lex wrote it. Himself. In his own big clumsy careful hand. Sitting by the pool on the first night of winter with the book on his knee and Lark asleep in his shirt.

Isaura Kell. Of Highcrest. She was High Warden. She signed forty-one warrants for unlatticed sorcery and remembered every name.

She was carried once. By a man she'd branded.

She sat with a frightened thing in the dark until it got home.

She held on.

And then, under it, he turned the page. And left it blank.

For later.

◆ ◆ ◆

HIGHCREST WOKE UP ON the second day of winter.

Lex didn't see it. He heard about it. From Elowen, who went back with the Queen. From Hollis Penn, who went back to his bakery and found the ovens cold and the dough grey and the cat asleep on the flour sack. From Maren Ashdown, who went back to Fennel Street with Tam and Robbie and sat on the step in the thin winter sun, and the widow Abel came out of her house next door with her cat in her arms and sat down beside her and said *Maren, what in the Lady's name happened*, and Maren laughed and couldn't stop.

Every one of them.

Everyone the Moth Queen had touched. Everyone who'd walked two hundred miles behind her with a dark lantern. Every Keeper at Greyfall. Every shepherd in the Greyspine. Every warm thing she'd taken in nine hundred years, pouring out of her down the point of a hewer's pick on the rubble of Duskhold, into the breach, into the little one.

And the little one, rising through the door with its whole vast soft heart, had taken every warm thing that came pouring down into it.

And given it back.

◆ ◆ ◆

ODILE CAME TO THE pool on the fourth day.

From the Keep. On foot. A hundred and fifty miles. She said she'd wanted to walk it. She said she'd wanted to see the circle from the ground, the way the people who dug it saw it.

She stood at the edge of the pool and looked down into it for a long time.

"*It gave it back*," she said. To Antho. Who was sitting on the grey stone rim with his legs dangling over the dark. "*Master Antho. The thing she took. The first night. At the Keep. In the snow.*"

"*I know*," said Antho. "*I felt it go back. All of them. All at once.*"

"*No. You don't understand.*" Odile sat down beside him. On the rim. "*I had it already. Pim gave it back. In the snow. He made room for it and it came back.*" She looked at the pool. "*And then on Lantern Night, at the Keep, at midnight, I was standing at the door with the students, and I felt it come back again.*"

Antho looked at her.

"*Twice*," said Odile Marsh. "*I've got it twice now. The first time I came up the mountain. When you opened the cave door. When you said, thank goodness, I've no idea what I'm doing.*" She was smiling. Crying. "*It's twice as warm.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SILAS HASK LIVED.

Lex hadn't been sure he would. None of them had. The grey came back into him on the rubble the moment the warm thing came home. All of it. Twenty-six years of coal-damp and Gloam. His father's cough. His mother's. His sister's.

He'd sat on the black stone at the foot of the gate-tower all night, coughing, with Kit's arms round his neck and the *HOME* lantern in his lap. Grey on his lips. Breathing like a broken bellows.

And at dawn, when the little one lay down in the circle—

It made room.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Not a cure*," said Seraphine. Kneeling beside him on the grass by the pool, with her hand out, listening. "*It can't cure. You know that. It doesn't heal.*"

"*I know*," said Hask. Hoarsely. Between coughs.

"*But it's made room*," said Seraphine. "*In your lungs. Where the grey is. It hasn't taken the grey out. It's made more room round it. So there's space to breathe.*" She looked at him. "*Can you feel it?*"

Silas Hask breathed in.

Slowly. Carefully. The way a man breathes who's been afraid to for twenty-six years.

It caught. Halfway. A rattle. A catch. The grey.

And then it went past. Further. Deeper. More than halfway.

Not all the way down.

But further than it had gone in years.

He sat on the grass by the pool and breathed. In. Out. In. With his big scarred hands flat on the ground and his eyes shut.

"*Not all the way*," he said at last. Very quietly.

"*No*."

"*Enough*," said Silas Hask. And opened his eyes. Brown. Ordinary. Wet. "*It's enough.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HIS WINGS HAD FALLEN off.

In the night. On the rubble. While he sat coughing with Kit. Lex hadn't seen it happen. Kit had. Kit said they'd just—*dropped*. Like dead leaves off a tree in autumn. Grey-gold. Dry. And crumbled into dust on the black stone, and the wind took the dust, and there was nothing left but two long scars down his back, under the torn leather, where they'd come through.

"*Doesn't matter*," said Hask. When Lex asked. "*Never liked flying. Hewers don't go up. We go down.*"

He was still Level eighty-eight. The net said so. Delvebreaker. Epic. The levels were his. He'd earned them, every one, the wrong way and the right way, and the net didn't take back what it gave.

But the line under it had changed.

◆ ◆ ◆

```
SILAS HASK
Class: DELVEBREAKER (Epic)
Level 88
Growth: unbounded
"He broke the Moth. He'll never break
 another core. The net is not sure
 which of these it is prouder of."
```

◆ ◆ ◆

THE QUEEN CAME TO see him on the sixth day.

At the pool. In her plain blue dress with her silver circlet and Elowen Dunmore behind her with Oathkeeper drawn. She stood on the grass in front of the big coughing man sitting on the grey stone rim beside Kell's stick, and looked at him for a long time.

Hask stood up.

Slowly. Coughing. And bowed. Badly. He'd clearly never bowed to anyone in his life.

"*Majesty*," he said.

"*You broke cores*," said Lysandra. "*Twenty-nine of them. And left the shafts open. And she came down them.*"

"*Yes, Majesty.*"

"*You carried Seren Vey out of a window. In the night. While her husband lay on the floor with his head split open.*"

"*Yes, Majesty.*"

"*You stood on Fennel Street and tried to take a pregnant woman to the Moth Queen. And you stood at the top of the rubble on Lantern Night and lifted your pick to break the wind round her while she was giving birth.*"

Hask didn't look away.

"*Yes, Majesty*," he said.

The Queen looked at him.

"*And then you put the pick down*," she said. "*And stood in the gap. And held it out. And the Moth Queen flew onto it.*"

"*Yes*," said Silas Hask. Very quietly. "*That too.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LYSANDRA WAS QUIET FOR a long time.

"*I sentenced Varric Sorn to ten years as schoolmaster in Fen Hollow*," she said at last. "*Teaching the children of the people Dorran Vask capped. Because he'd wanted to put them on a list.*" She looked at Hask. "*It was the cruelest thing I could think of. And the kindest.*"

Hask didn't say anything.

"*So I've been thinking*," said the Queen of Caldor, "*what would be the cruelest and the kindest thing I could do to you.*"

She looked past him. At the pool. At the stick on the rim. At the black stone with two words on it. At a small pale girl on a crutch, sitting on the other side of the pool, very still, watching.

"*Someone has to keep it*," said Lysandra. "*The room. Ivy Moss is its keeper. The net says so. But she's fourteen. And she can barely walk. And there'll be people. Uncapped. Thieves. Fools. Moths, maybe, someday, from the grey.*"

She looked back at Hask. "*People who'll want to kneel down at the edge of it. And cup their hands.*"

Hask went very still.

"*Isaura Kell stood in front of it*," said the Queen. "*With a stick. In the deep. For six months. And then she held on to the Moth Queen's wings until she fell.*" She nodded at the stick on the rim. "*That's hers. Pim says the little one made it for her.*"

She looked at him.

"*Pick it up*," said Lysandra.

◆ ◆ ◆

SILAS HASK LOOKED AT the stick for a long time.

Long. Plain. Dark. Like a shepherd's crook without the crook.

"*I'm the one who broke the cores*," he said. Hoarsely. "*Majesty. I'm the one who made the holes. I'm the one she came down.*"

"*I know.*"

"*It screamed. Every time. I felt it. I told the smith it was rock settling.*" His voice cracked. "*It screamed and I went up three levels and the cough got better and I did it again.*"

"*I know*," said the Queen. "*That's why.*"

She looked at him with her sharp dark eyes.

"*Nobody else in the world knows exactly what it sounds like when someone hurts it*," said Lysandra. "*Except Antho Vey. And he has a door to keep.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PICKED UP THE stick.

His enormous scarred miner's hand closed round it. Round the plain dark wood. And held it. For a long time. Very still.

And from the pool, from the grass, from everywhere, soft and young and very small—

[...the big one...]

Hask flinched.

[...the big one who broke my hands...]

He stood by the pool with the stick in his fist and his face grey and didn't move.

[...he's holding the Warden's stick...]

[...brother...is he going to stand in front of me...]

Antho was sitting on the rim. On the other side. With his legs dangling over the dark. He looked across the pool at Silas Hask.

"*Are you*?" he said.

Hask looked at him.

Then he looked down into the pool. At the dark. At the full. At the bottom of it, very far down, three little lights. Curled together. Sitting down.

"*I'm sorry*," said Silas Hask. To the pool. Out loud. Hoarse. "*I'm sorry. I didn't—*" He stopped. Coughed. Tried again. "*I knew. I knew it was alive. I knew it hurt. I did it anyway. Because I could breathe.*"

The pool was quiet.

"*I'll stand in front of you*," said Silas Hask. "*If you'll let me. Every day. Till I can't. With her stick.*" His voice was very quiet. "*Nobody kneels at your edge. Nobody cups their hands. Not while I'm breathing.*"

A long silence.

[...you said sorry...]

Hask didn't move.

[...brother...he said sorry...]

"*He did*," said Antho Vey.

[...nobody ever...]

[...except me...]

The grass round Hask's boots stirred. Just a little. Like a cat brushing past.

[...all right...] said Mal. *[...all right, big one...you can stand in front of me...]*

◆ ◆ ◆

KIT STAYED WITH HIM.

And Brigid, and the Tull brothers, and old Absalom, who came up from the rim with his helmet-lamp and his pick and sat down on the grass beside Hask without a word and stayed there.

The Coldwater crew.

They built a house. On the slope above the pool. Where Duskhold's gate had been. Out of the last of the black rubble, before the grass took it all. Small. Plain. With one window. Facing the pool.

And in the window, a lantern.

Iron and glass. *ARDENT* on the pane. *HOME* on the base.

Lit.

Not waiting for anyone.

They were all already there.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE SHAFTS CLOSED ON the eighth day.

All twenty-nine. The broken ones. The wounds. The holes the Uncapped had left when they shattered cores, and the moths had come down like smoke down a chimney.

Lex felt them go. Sitting by the pool at dawn. Through the Stone. One by one. All over Caldor. In tavern cellars and inn yards and village greens. A tavern-keeper in the Saltreach who'd been charging a copper a look came down to his cellar in the morning and found nothing but a floor. Grey stone. With a puddle where the drip landed.

Drawn back, Seraphine said. *It's home now. It doesn't need to reach up anymore. It's drawing its hands back. All of them. Even the cut ones.* She listened. *Like a hand coming back to rest in a lap.*

No more Delves opened after that.

Not unclassified ones. The old ones were still there. The Frostvault, and Qel'Varran, and the Delve in the Bitter Hills that was nothing but a well-shaft with iron rungs. The net's Delves. Tidy. Predictable. Ordered.

But no more round black holes in the grass, breathing warm air that smelled of the Hollowmaw, humming the Lantern Song flat.

The little one had stopped shedding.

It was home.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN CAME ON the twelfth day.

Lex didn't see him come. Nobody did. He was just there. At dawn. On the grass beside the pool. Tall. Thin. Grey-robed. Leaning on his long pole. With the lantern on top of it lit.

Eyeless.

Looking down into the pool.

Ivy Moss saw him first. She'd been sitting on the rim since before dawn, the way she did every morning now, telling Mal things. She looked up and saw a tall grey eyeless man standing on the grass beside her and didn't scream. She was a Hollowkeeper. She'd been Kindled beside an open way. She'd stopped screaming at things.

She said, very politely, "*Good morning*."

"*Good morning*," said the Ferryman.

◆ ◆ ◆

THEY FETCHED ANTHO. AND Lex. And their mother.

And their father, in the wheeled chair that Brannoc had made, pushed down the slope by Pim over the new grass very slowly and very carefully, with a blanket over his knees and the grey book on top of it.

The Ferryman turned his eyeless face toward them as they came.

"*Anthoren Vey*," he said.

"*Ferryman*."

"*You opened a door*." The eyeless face didn't change. "*I felt it. In the river. All rivers are my water, a little.*" He was quiet. "*You opened it by asking. I have not felt a door opened by asking since before the world was woven.*"

"*My father showed me the edges*."

The Ferryman turned his face. Slowly. Toward the old man in the wheeled chair.

"*Arion Vey*," he said.

"*Ferryman*," said Arion. Faintly.

"*I told your son you would come to my shore*," said the Ferryman. "*Before long. I said old men always do.*" He tilted his head. "*You have not.*"

"*Not yet*," said Arion Vey.

"*No*." The Ferryman looked at him for a long time. "*Not yet. The little one has made you room. I can see it. A little. Ordinary room. A year. Perhaps two.*" He was quiet. "*I will wait. I am very patient. I have been here since before the world was made.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN HE TURNED his face toward Seren.

She was standing behind the wheeled chair. With her hand on her husband's shoulder. Small. Barefoot, still; she'd refused shoes since the Blightmarch turned green. She said she wanted to feel the grass.

"*Seren Vey*," said the Ferryman.

"*Ferryman*."

"*You paid me*," said the Ferryman. "*Thirteen years ago. To cross. The memory you would least wish to lose.*" The eyeless face was very still. "*A man. All of him. Every day. The steps of the Spire, in the rain.*"

"*I know*."

"*And then you did not cross. You turned round. For your son.*" He was quiet. "*I told him once, I do not give refunds. The river takes what it is owed.*"

Seren didn't say anything.

"*That is still true*," said the Ferryman. "*I do not give refunds.*"

He reached into his grey robe.

"*But I may give a gift*," he said.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE HELD OUT HIS hand.

Long. Grey. Thin. Empty.

And in it, very faint, so faint Lex could barely see it in the dawn, something. Not a thing. A *glimmer*. Like light on water. Like the reflection of a lamp in a wet window. Like rain.

"*The river runs clean*," said the Ferryman. "*The Tithe is ended. The hunger is home and has a name. The one who drank it dry knelt on a hill and was given a lamp, and was warm for the first time in nine hundred years, and is gone.*" He looked at Seren with his eyeless face. "*There is one fewer of the Nine in the grey. I carried them out. I have kept that payment nine hundred years.*"

He held the glimmer out. Toward her.

"*I am lighter this morning*," said the Ferryman. "*I find I would like to give something back.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

"*One*," he said. "*Only one. Not all of him. The river would not allow it. A love for a love; that is the price, and no one has paid it.*" His eyeless face was

very gentle. "*But one memory. As a gift. Not a refund. For opening a door by asking. For giving a moth a lamp.*"

Seren stared at the glimmer in his hand.

"*Which one*?" she said. In a whisper.

"*The first*," said the Ferryman. "*The steps. The rain.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE DIDN'T TAKE IT.

Not at first. She stood behind the wheeled chair with her hand on Arion's shoulder and looked at the glimmer in the Ferryman's long grey hand for a long time.

Then she looked down. At her husband. At the white wisp of his hair. At the grey book on his knee.

"*If I take it*," she said. Slowly. "*I'll remember him. Young. On the steps.*" She swallowed. "*I'll know what he looked like. When he looked at me. The first time.*"

"*Yes*."

"*And then I'll look down*," said Seren. "*And he'll be this.*" Her hand tightened on his shoulder. "*And I'll know the difference. I'll know what I lost.*"

The Ferryman didn't answer.

His father didn't say anything. He sat in the wheeled chair with his eyes on the pool and his hands on the grey book and didn't say anything at all.

But Lex saw his hands. On the book. Shaking.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Take it*," said Arion Vey.

His wife looked down at him.

"*Take it*," said her husband. Very faintly. Not looking at her. Looking at the pool. "*Please. I've been carrying it for thirteen years. Alone. The steps. The rain. You laughing at the lanterns.*" His voice was a thread. "*I'd like someone else to have it. Just one. Just the first.*"

He looked up at her.

"*So it's not just mine*," he said. "*So when I go, it's still somewhere.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

SEREN TOOK IT.

She reached out. Past the wheeled chair. And put her square freckled hand in the Ferryman's long grey one. Over the glimmer.

And closed her fingers.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX SAW HER FACE.

He'd seen it do a lot of things. In the gold room. In the cavern. On the rubble with a lamp held out to a Sovereign.

He'd never seen it do this.

It went still. Utterly. Her eyes wide. Looking at nothing. At the pool. At the dawn. At something nobody else could see.

And then it *lit*.

From inside. Like a window. Like a lamp. Like the face of a girl of nineteen standing under the arch of a tower in the rain with flour on her cheek, laughing at the lanterns, who has just turned round and seen a young man in a grey coat coming round the corner, very casually, as if he just happened to be passing.

Looking at her.

As if she were the first light he'd seen in two hundred years.

◆ ◆ ◆

SHE KNELT.

Slowly. On the grass. Beside the wheeled chair. And took her husband's face in both her hands. His old face. His walnut face. A hundred years in a drawer. White wisp of hair. Grey eyes.

And looked at it.

For a long, long time.

"*You did*," said Seren Vey. In a whisper. Wet. Shaking. Laughing. "*You did look like a librarian telling off a choir.*"

His father's face broke.

"*I told you*," he said. "*Page four.*"

"*You had ink on your cuff*," said his wife. "*Here.*" She touched his wrist. "*And your hair was too long. And you were so tall you had to stoop under the arch. And you pretended you were just passing.*"

"*I was just passing*."

"*You were not*." She was crying. "*You came round that corner three times. I saw you. The first two times you turned back.*"

Arion Vey laughed.

The real laugh. The wide startled one. Cracking out of him like ice off a roof. Shaking the wheeled chair. Shaking the grey book off his knee onto the grass.

"*I never told anyone that*," he said. "*Not in the letter. Not in the book. I never told anyone I turned back twice.*"

"*You didn't have to*," said Seren Harrow. "*I was there.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FERRYMAN WAS GONE.

Lex didn't see him go. Nobody did. When he looked up, there was only the grass, and the pool, and the dawn. And a small pale girl on a crutch sitting on the grey stone rim, looking at the place where the tall grey man had been.

"*He said*," said Ivy Moss, very quietly, to no one in particular, "*he said thank you. To Mal. On the way out. He said, thank you for the room.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC MET LARK ON the fifteenth day.

He'd been at the pool every day. Every day since Lantern Night. Cutting Kell's stone, and then helping the Coldwater crew with their house, and then sitting on the grass by the pool with Hedda, doing nothing, which he said was the first time in sixty-three years he'd done nothing and he found he was very good at it.

He hadn't asked to hold her.

Lex had seen him looking. From across the pool. From the slope. From the doorway of the tent. The way he'd looked at Lex, the first night, at eleven, standing in the ashes at Harrow.

He hadn't asked.

So on the fifteenth day, Lex walked across the grass to where the old smith was sitting by the pool with his knees creaking and his grey beard full of crumbs from Mother Orla's bacon, and sat down beside him.

And put Lark in his arms.

◆ ◆ ◆

BRANNOC DIDN'T MOVE.

He sat on the grass by the pool with the baby in his enormous scarred arms, in the crook of his elbow, like a loaf, and didn't move at all. For a long time.

Lark looked up at him. With her dark eyes. Not unfocused anymore. Fifteen days. Looking. At a great grey bald face with a soot-stained beard and wet eyes, very close.

And reached up.

And grabbed his beard.

"*Ah*," said Brannoc Holt. Very softly. "*Ah. There you are.*"

He didn't take her hand away. He let her hold on. His beard in her square fist, too big for the rest of her.

Then he reached into his coat. With his free hand. Slowly. And took something out.

Old. Black. Square-headed. Small.

A horseshoe nail.

"*There you go, lass*," said Brannoc. And put it in her other hand. And closed her fingers round it. "*That's your first bit of iron.*"

Lex couldn't breathe.

"*Your da had one*," said Brannoc. To the baby. Not looking at Lex. "*When he was two. Sat on my woodpile with his thumb in his mouth while his mam and his brother watched the sparks. I gave him a nail.*" His voice was very rough. "*He had it in his fist the night his da sealed him. Did you know that? Arion told me. He said the boy was holding a nail.*"

He looked down at the baby with her fist round the nail.

"*Smiths*," said Brannoc Holt. "*All of you. Every one. From the first day.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

ANTHO WENT BACK TO the Keep on the twentieth day.

With Seraphine. And Pim. And Odile. On Ashka. Who'd been sleeping on the slope above the pool for twenty days, curled round the Coldwater crew's house like a cat round a hearth, with her great golden eye on Mal.

He came to say goodbye. At the pool. At dawn.

"*Someone has to keep the door*," he said. "*The Hollowmaw. There's still a door there. Still lamps. Still a thousand lanterns.*" He looked at the pool. "*And Mal's got a keeper here. And a big man with a stick.*"

"*You'll come back*."

"*Every month*," said Antho. "*To sit with it. To tell it things.*" He smiled. The real one. The one that was exactly like Lex's. "*It likes the one about the miller's cat. I'm going to learn some new ones.*"

He looked at his brother.

And opened his panel. Right there. By the pool. The way people did now, sometimes, with no Wardens watching. The way a man might pull up his sleeve to show you a scar.

◆ ◆ ◆

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ANTHOREN VEY
Class: THRESHOLD WARDEN (Unique)
  TIER IV
Level 87 → 90
Clarity: 100
ATTUNEMENT
  Shade ........ COMMANDING
  Gale ......... SPEAKING
  Tide ......... ANSWERING
  Hollow ....... LISTENING
Title: [The Door That Opened] (new)
"He has stood in every kind of door.
 He stood in this one longest."
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◆ ◆ ◆

"*Hollow*," said Lex. "*Listening.*"

"*I can hear it*," said Antho. "*Not like before. Not in the old place. Not through a crack.*" He touched his chest. "*Here. Like Seraphine does. In the spaces. In the room.*" He looked at the pool. "*It's different. It's not inside me anymore. It's next to me.*"

He put his hand on Lex's shoulder.

"*Like you*," said Antho Vey. "*It's next to me. Like you.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX WENT HOME ON the twenty-third day.

To Harrow. With Wren. And Lark. On Vharuun's neck, in Brannoc's chair, with the baby inside his shirt and Wren behind him with her arms round his waist and her chin on his shoulder.

Over the circle. Over a hundred miles of soft new green with a pool in the middle and a ring of small gold lights round the rim, still burning, given. Over the edge of it. Over the downs. Over the Vale.

Home.

The cottage was there. In the clearing. In the birch wood. By the stream. Grey Vale stone and new oak beams. With a door that stuck in wet weather because he'd hung it himself in a hurry and never planed it.

And a window on the east side. Deep and wide. With a sill broad enough to sit on.

Empty.

He'd taken the lantern. The *ARDENT* one. *HOME*. Given it to Kit, on the rubble, on Lantern Night, for Silas Hask. It was in the window of a small black house on a slope above a pool now.

The window at Harrow was dark.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE MADE A NEW one.

That night. At the little forge he'd built in the lean-to behind the cottage. Iron and glass. Small. Plain.

He thought about what to cut on it.

Not *HOME*. Not *ARDENT*. Not anything waiting. Not a light left on for someone who wasn't here.

He thought about it for a long time. Standing at the anvil in the dark with the hammer in his hand and the little lantern in the tongs and the fire saying good evening.

And then he cut one word. On the base. Where only someone who picked it up would see.

HERE.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT IT IN the window.

And lit it. With his own fire.

And Wren came and stood beside him. With Lark asleep on her shoulder. And looked at it. At the little gold flame behind the glass. Facing out. Facing the road.

"*Who's it for*?" she said.

"*Nobody*," said Lex.

She looked at him.

"*Everybody's home*," said Lex Vey. "*Mam's home. Father's home. Antho's home. Mal's home.*" He looked at the baby on her shoulder. "*She's home. You're home.*"

He looked at the lantern.

"*It's not waiting for anyone*," he said. "*It's just—here. Lit. For whoever's in the room.*"

Wren looked at the little lantern for a long time.

Then she leaned against him. With the baby between them. And said, very softly, into his shoulder, "*Idiot.*"

But she didn't move.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND ON THE CORD round his neck, under his shirt, against his chest—

The little silver bell with the crooked clapper didn't ring.

Not that night. Not the next. Not for a long time.

Because nobody was sad.

EPILOGUE

The Gilded King

THERE WAS A MOTH in the Spire that nobody had found.

It was in the round room at the top. The room with the cold grate and the long window looking north, and the shelves of grey books, and the tall bookcase that swung open if you pulled the right book down. It was on the desk. On the desk where a Warden-Architect had written two hundred years of ledgers in a small neat hand.

It was very small. Smaller than the others. Grey-gold. Its wings folded. Sitting quite still on the corner of the desk, beside the pale ring in the wood where a teacup had stood for two hundred years.

Beside a glass bottle.

Small. The size of a thumb. Stoppered. Sealed with grey-gold wax. And inside it, dark. Red-dark. A finger's depth.

It had been sitting there since the night the Moth Queen flew east.

She'd told it to.

Stay, she'd said. Very softly. Bending down over the desk with her lit eyes and her long glowing hands. *Stay with this, little one. Don't let anyone touch it. And if I don't come back—*

She'd smiled.

If I don't come back, she'd said, *take it home*.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT FELT HER GO.

On the last night of autumn. Far off. A hundred miles east. On a hill of black rubble at the edge of a word written in the ground. It felt the light go

out of her. All of it. Pouring. Down the point of a hewer's pick. Into the breach. Into the little one.

And then it felt the other thing.

The thing that came after. Small. Gold. Warm. In the middle of her. Where she'd always been cold.

A lamp. Given.

And then she came apart into it. Gently. Like a dandelion. And was gone.

The little moth sat on the corner of the desk in the dark round room at the top of the Spire and didn't move for a long time.

It didn't know what it felt. It was a moth. It didn't feel things. It went toward the light. That was all.

But the light it had always gone toward was gone.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE THIRD NIGHT of winter, when the Queen of Caldor came home to Highcrest and the lanterns came back on in every window, and the whole golden city on its hill was lit up like a heap of embers in a grate for the first time since summer—

The little moth unfolded its wings.

And took hold of the glass bottle with its legs. Six of them. Thin as hairs. Round the neck of the bottle.

And lifted.

It was too heavy. A moth can't lift a glass bottle. Everyone knows that.

It lifted it anyway.

Slowly. An inch off the desk. Two. Its wings beating so hard they shed. Grey-gold dust falling on the desk, on the ring where the teacup had stood, on the open grey book that a Warden-Architect had left there in the summer, on a line in his small neat hand about the price of bread.

Out through the window. The long one. Facing north. Which someone had left open a crack, to air the room.

Into the night.

West.

◆ ◆ ◆

IT TOOK A LONG time.

It flew by night, because by day it couldn't see. It flew low, because the wind was too strong higher up. It flew round every lantern, every lamp, every lit window in every village between Highcrest and the edge of the world, because it was a moth, and it went toward the light, and it had to make itself go *past*.

It was very hard.

It went over the downs. Over the Blightmarch's western edge, where the grey was going green. Over the old Greyfall fort, empty now, its gates open, its lanterns gone. Over the bare lands. The cracked grey ground. The black stumps. The wind that never stopped.

It nearly died a dozen times.

It didn't.

It had been told to take it home.

◆ ◆ ◆

ON THE FORTIETH NIGHT, it came to the end of the world.

The Veil.

Grey. Hanging from nowhere. Falling to nowhere. Stretching north and south as far as there was anything to stretch. Not quite still. Moving, very slightly, the way a curtain moves when there's a window open somewhere behind it.

The moth came down out of the dark onto the bare frozen ground at the foot of it.

And couldn't get up again.

Its wings were done. Shredded. Most of the dust gone off them. The painted eyes on them faded to nothing. It lay on the frozen ground at the foot of the Veil with the glass bottle beside it, too tired to move.

And the Veil pushed.

Not hard. Not angrily. Just firmly. The way it always had. *Not you. Not ever.*

The moth lay on the ground and felt it push.

◆ ◆ ◆

AND THEN IT MOVED.

One leg. Then another. Crawling. Dragging the bottle. Across the frozen ground. An inch. Two. Toward the grey.

The bottle's cork came loose.

It had been loosening for forty nights. In the cold. In the wind. In the long flight west over a hundred villages full of lamps. The wax had cracked. The cork had worked. And now, on the frozen ground at the foot of the Veil, with a moth dragging it the last inch on legs as thin as hairs—

It came out.

And the bottle tipped.

And a finger's depth of dark red-dark blood ran out across the frozen ground. And touched the bottom of the Veil.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE VEIL DIDN'T KNOW it.

That was the thing. That was the whole thing. The Veil had been woven nine hundred years ago, by a man with a little hammer, at the edge of the world, to keep nine people out. It had learned them. Every one. What they were. What they tasted like. Everyone who'd knelt at the pool and drunk.

It had never learned the blood that touched it now.

Hesper's line. The tenth. The sister who wouldn't drink. Who'd poured back instead. Whose daughters had never Kindled and never stayed and never let a moth in, for nine hundred years, so that the net never once got a proper look at them.

The Veil didn't know it.

And so the Veil did the only thing a door can do when a hand it's never seen before is laid on it, and there's no reason in the world to keep that hand out.

It *opened*.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT MUCH.

Not like a curtain. Not like a door swinging wide. A finger's depth of blood isn't enough for that. Seren Vey's whole heart wouldn't have been enough for that. It would take more blood than one bottle to open the edge of the world.

But a crack.

A thin one. Low down. At the foot of the grey. Where the blood had run. A line of something that wasn't grey. That was dark. That had a smell coming through it. Dust. Old dust. And underneath, faint, very faint—

Gold.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE MOTH CRAWLED INTO it.

On its hair-thin legs. With its shredded wings dragging. Through the crack. Out of the world.

Into the grey country.

And lay on the other side, on a broad white road that ran straight as a ruler across a plain of grey-gold dust, under a dim grey-gold light that came from nowhere, toward a palace of glass and bone and gold on the edge of the sky.

And died.

◆ ◆ ◆

IN THE TALLEST OF the glass palaces, in a hall with a ceiling like a frozen waterfall, four cocoons hung from the rafters.

There had been five. The fifth was empty. Split from top to bottom. Hanging open like a seed-pod in winter. Under it, on the glass floor, in the dust, a crown of silver wire, fine as frost, shaped like folded wings.

Nobody had picked it up.

The other four hung in a row. Grey-gold silk. Thick as a man's arm. Swaying very slightly, though there was no wind.

And under the first one, the biggest, on the floor, a crown of gold leaves.

◆ ◆ ◆

THE FIRST COCOON MOVED.

◆ ◆ ◆

NOT A TREMOR. NOT a shiver. Not the slow waking of a sleeper hearing his name in another room.

It *heaved*.

All of it. At once. The great grey-gold mass of silk bucking against its ropes like a sack with something alive in it. The dust pouring off it. The rafters creaking.

And then it split.

Not along a seam. Not like a seed-pod. *Torn*. From the inside. By hands. Big ones. Strong ones. Golden.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE CAME OUT OF it all at once.

Not crouching. Not slow. He dropped out of the torn silk onto the glass floor of the hall on his feet. Like a man jumping down off a cart. And stood there. Tall. Broad. Enormous. Taller than any man. Broader than Brannoc. With a great gold beard that came down to his chest, and gold hair to his shoulders, and skin like old ivory.

And his eyes.

Lit. Like hers had been.

But not like windows. Not like lamps at the end of a long lane on a winter night.

Like *furnaces*. Like the open mouth of a forge, white-hot, roaring. Like the sun, if the sun were angry.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE STOOD IN THE dust under his torn cocoon and breathed.

And looked down the hall.

At the empty cocoon at the end. Split. Hanging open. At the crown of silver wire on the floor beneath it, in the dust, untouched.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he walked down the hall. Past the other three cocoons. Past the crown of glass on the floor, and the crown of black iron, and the crown of thorns that had once been roses.

To the end.

And bent down. And picked up the crown of silver wire.

And held it in his enormous golden hand. Very gently. The way you'd hold a moth.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*Orrin*," said the Gilded King.

His voice was deep. Like a bell. Like a mountain. Rough with nine hundred years of not being used.

Something moved at the far end of the hall. Near the tall glass doors. A shape. Bent. Grey. Thin as a rake. With a steward's chain gone black round its neck. And two eyes barely lit at all. Dim sparks. Like the ends of cigars in a dark room.

It came forward. Slowly. On its knees. Shedding dust.

"*Majesty*," whispered Orrin. "*Majesty. You wake.*"

"*Where is my sister*?"

The old steward didn't answer.

He didn't need to. The Gilded King was holding her crown.

◆ ◆ ◆

"*She went first*," said Orrin. Very quietly. Kneeling in the dust. With his face bowed. "*As she always did. To the light. Through the Veil. When it loosened.*" His dry voice shook. "*She said she'd bring you something back.*"

"*And*?"

"*And she felt the Well grown back*," said Orrin. "*Full again. Rising. And she went to it. And drank, once, in the deep. And grew bright. Sovereign. They called her Sovereign. The net did.*"

The Gilded King said nothing.

"*And then they made a room for it*," whispered Orrin. "*The smith. And his people. A hundred miles. A word in the ground.*" He shook his head. "*And it came up into the room. And she went to drink it there. And—*"

He stopped.

"*Say it.*"

"*And a hewer broke her on his pick*," said Orrin. "*And the smith struck the flaw. And everything she'd ever drunk poured out of her. Nine hundred years of it. Back into the Well.*" His dim eyes flickered. "*And then a Harrow woman knelt down in front of her. And gave her a lamp.*"

The hall was very silent.

"*And she took it*," said Orrin. "*Majesty. She took it. And it stayed. In the middle of her. Where she was always cold.*" His voice broke. "*And she smiled. And came apart. Into light.*"

◆ ◆ ◆

THE GILDED KING LOOKED down at the crown of silver wire in his hand.

For a long, long time.

"*A Harrow woman*," he said.

"*Hesper's line*," whispered Orrin. "*The last of it. And her sons. The smith and the warden. Vey on the father's side. Harrow on the mother's.*" He swallowed. "*It was the Harrow blood that opened the crack, Majesty. In the Veil. Just now. Her own little moth brought it. The last one. She told it to.*"

The Gilded King's furnace eyes moved.

Down the hall. To the tall glass doors. To the broad white road beyond them, running straight across the grey-gold plain toward the edge of the world.

Toward a crack. Low down. At the foot of the grey. With something coming through it. A smell. Faint. Very faint.

Green.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE DIDN'T SAY ANYTHING for a long time.

Then he turned. And walked back up the hall. To the other three cocoons. And stood under them.

And put his enormous golden hand flat on the first. The one above the crown of glass.

It stirred.

On the second. Above the black iron.

It stirred.

On the third. Above the thorns.

It stirred.

All three. Trembling. The dust sliding off them. The silk heaving, very slightly, the way a sleeper twitches when someone says their name in another room.

"*Wake*," said Oszric of the Crowned. Very softly. "*Ysenne. Caddoc. Rhosyn. Wake up.*"

He looked down at the crown of silver wire in his other hand.

"*Our sister is dead*," said the Gilded King.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE TURNED BACK TO the old steward. Kneeling in the dust.

"*Who killed my sister*?"

Orrin bowed his head lower. Until his brow touched the glass floor.

"*Everyone*," he whispered. "*Majesty. Everyone killed her. A hewer. A smith. A boy who whistled. A Harrow woman with a lamp.*" His voice was barely a sound. "*Three hundred and fourteen miles of people with spades.*"

The Gilded King looked at him.

And then he smiled.

It was not a lovely smile. It was not sad. It was not fond. It was not patient.

It was the smile of a man who has been asleep for nine hundred years and has woken to find his house robbed and his sister dead and a door left open a crack.

"*Then we'll go and see everyone*," said Oszric.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE PUT THE CROWN of silver wire inside his robe. Against his chest. Over his heart. Very carefully.

And then he bent down. And picked up his own. The crown of gold leaves. From the dust under his torn cocoon.

And put it on.

"*Orrin*."

"*Majesty*."

"*The Harrows*," said the Gilded King. "*Hesper's line. The woman with the lamp. Her sons. All of them.*" His furnace eyes were very bright. "*I want them brought to me. When the crack is wider. When my sisters and brother are awake.*"

"*Majesty*."

"*And Orrin*." He looked toward the doors. Toward the white road. Toward the crack at the edge of the world, with green coming through it. "*The smith. The one with the little hammer. Who struck my sister's flaw.*"

"*Majesty*?"

"*He has a child*," said Oszric of the Crowned. "*Doesn't he. I can smell it. Through the crack. Something new. Something born on the night my sister died. Something that's never been anyone's.*"

The old steward didn't move.

"*Bring me the smith's child*," said the Gilded King.

◆ ◆ ◆

FAR AWAY. ON THE other side of the world. At the bottom of it. In a place that wasn't a place, at the very center of the net, where the first knot was tied and the last thread ran through, there was a man.

He'd been there for nearly three years.

He didn't have a body anymore. Not really. He had a shape. A thread. Grey. Thin. Wound tight round something that sat in the middle of the First Knot like a stone in a fist. A key. In three pieces. Bow, bit and blade. Barred. Locked. Held shut by a Lockward forged out of the bones of the world, and his thread wrapped round it, holding it in place.

He'd been holding it for nearly three years.

He was very tired.

He'd been tired his whole life. *Always someone's second*, he'd said once. In a cold fortress. To a man with white skin and black veins who called himself the Pale Warden. *Always second. Always behind. Always earning what others were born holding.*

He wasn't second now. He was the only one. Holding a key in the dark at the center of the world, so nobody could ever turn it again.

He'd made his peace with that.

Mostly.

◆ ◆ ◆

HE FELT THE VEIL crack.

Far off. At the edge of the net. A thread pulling. A knot loosening. The way you feel a draft from a door that's been opened in a house where you thought all the doors were locked.

And then he felt something on the other side of it. Waking. Big. Hot. Golden. *Angry*.

And then he felt it *look*.

Not at the smith. Not at the warden. Not at the Harrow woman or the child.

At the net. The whole of it. The great weaving. Reforged two years ago by a smith with gold in his eyes and given away.

Looking for a way to unwrite the edge of it.

Looking for the Key.

◆ ◆ ◆

ELRIC THORNE, WHO HAD been Arion Vey's friend for forty years and his betrayer for one night and had given back sixty stolen threads at the lid of the world and gone into the Knot to hold it shut, opened what he had left instead of eyes.

In the dark. At the center of the world. With a key in his fist and a Lockward round it and his thread wound tight.

And said, to no one. To the dark. To the net. To a smith asleep in a cottage at Harrow with a baby on his chest and a lantern in the window that said *HERE*.

"*Lex*," said Elric Thorne. Very quietly. "*Lad. Wake up.*"

"*They're coming for the Key*."

◆ ◆ ◆

AND IN A COTTAGE at Harrow, in the birch wood, by the stream, in the deep east window where a small iron lantern burned for whoever was in the room—

On a cord round the neck of a man asleep in a chair, with his daughter asleep on his chest and his wife asleep against his shoulder—

The little silver bell with the crooked clapper—

Rang.

Once.

Flat.

Ting.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX OPENED HIS EYES.

◆ ◆ ◆

Here ends The Sorcerer's Hollow, *Book Three of the Lattice Chronicles.*

The story continues in Book Four, The Sorcerer's Crown.

THE STORY CONTINUES

Book Four of The Lattice Chronicles
The Sorcerer's Crown